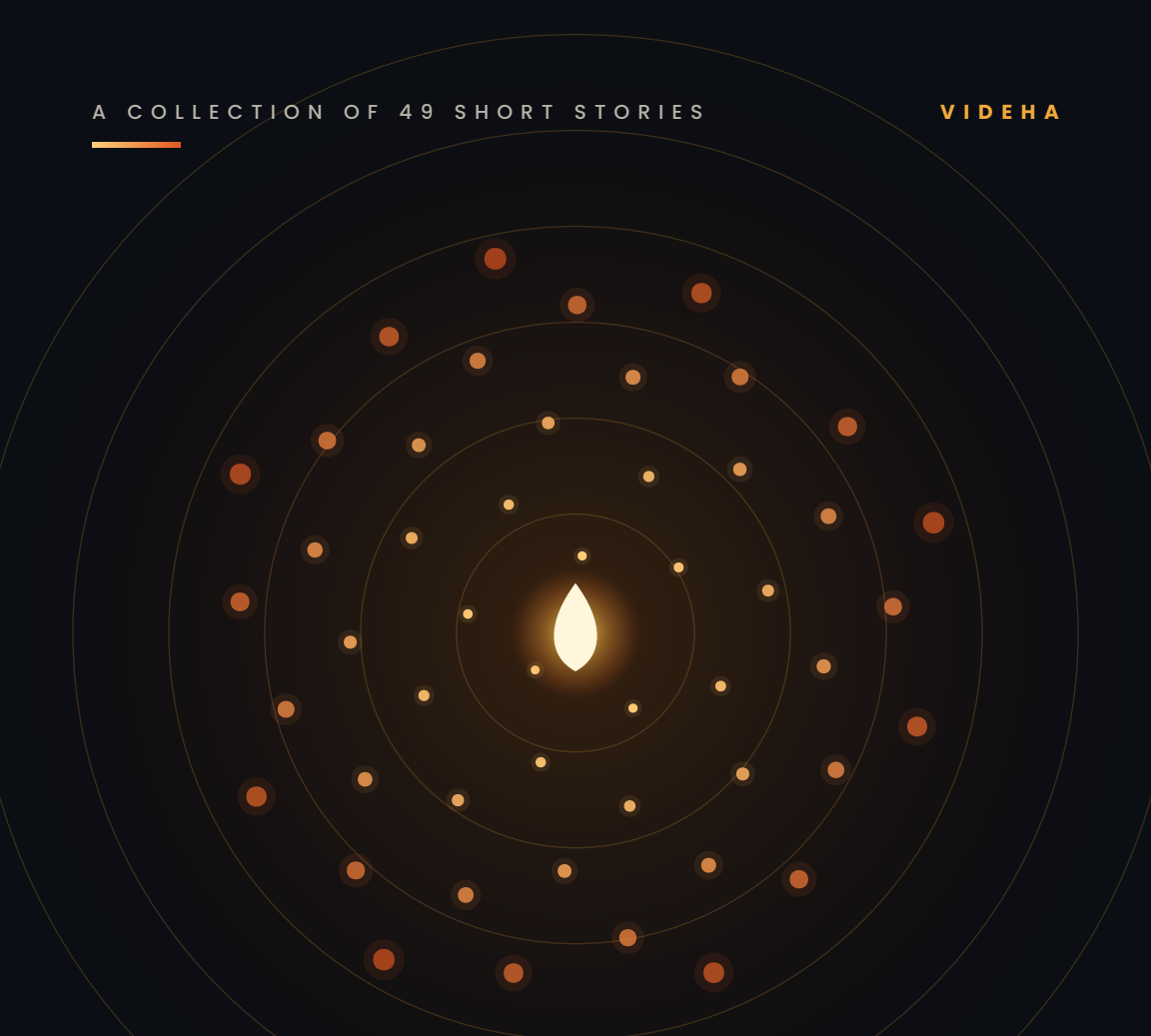


A COLLECTION OF 49 SHORT STORIES

VIDEHA



LIGHT

Stories Across Lifetimes

GAJENDRA THAKUR

Translated from the original Maithili by the author himself

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A Collection of 49 Short Stories

Gajendra Thakur

Translated from Original Maithili into English by the author himself

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I. The Thief of the Panji

STORY

The genealogical register on Niranjan's table was as old as the little lamp placed before it was new. The brass still retained the shop's polish. There was electricity, there was a scanner, there were two LED lamps, yet every evening he still lit this small flame. His father used to say: if you look at paper from the front, you see the letters; give it light from the side, and you see the body of the paper.

That night, it was the body of the paper that stopped him.

Everything was in order up to page forty-nine of the register. Names followed one another in sequence, with brief annotations, now and then a red-ink mark, now and then some date added by a hesitant hand. In the middle of page fifty, where the fifth line should have been, the paper was not merely blank; it had been abraded. It looked as though someone had not simply crossed out the writing there, but had taken away the upper layer of the paper along with the letters.

Niranjan stopped the scanner. The image on the screen was only half open. He did not touch the register. He was already wearing gloves, but this was his habit: first the eyes, then the light, and only after that the hand.

At the top of the page was written, "Udayanpur Branch." Four entries below it were clear. At the fifth place: an abrasion. The sixth entry resumed in an ordinary hand. But the numbering jumped. Beside the fourth entry was a small "4"; beside the sixth, "6." Where had five gone?

Such things were common enough in digitisation work. Insects ate paper, water bled ink, pages tore halfway through, old bindings shuffled leaves out of order. But here the paper remained. Only a single line was gone.

He moved the lamp to the right side of the table. As the direct light shifted away, a faint shadow formed over the scraped patch. There were pressure lines in the surface of the paper - not letters, but the pressure once made by letters.

A shiver passed through Niranjan.

He could read nothing. But he could tell that a line had existed. It had been fairly long. Twice in the middle the pen had lifted. At the end were a few rounded turns. He did not take a photograph yet. First he wrote in his notebook: "Page 50; Entry 5 absent; appears deliberately scraped; original text indistinct."

"Found the thief?"

Shivkant stood at the door. He was not really Niranjan's maternal uncle; like many older men in the village, Niranjan addressed him as Mama. The register had been found in an iron chest in the loft of Shivkant's house.

Niranjan did not smile. "Not the thief. The place where the theft happened."

Shivkant came in. He bent toward the page, but without his spectacles he could see little. "What could be stolen from a register like this? Was there money in it?"

"A name."

Something came over Shivkant's face that Niranjan could not immediately read. It began almost like a smile and dissolved into a cough. "It is old paper. Many hands must have passed over it."

"The number five is missing."

"Does a lineage run by counting numbers?"

"Sometimes counting the numbers tells you that someone stopped a lineage from running."

Shivkant got up after saying only, "It is very late. Put out the lamp."

Niranjan did not put it out.

He had not come to Udayanpur merely to look at a Panji for the first time. For four years he had been preserving in digital form the old registers, loose fragments of paper, marriage notes, partitions of land, dates of death, letters and photographs belonging to different families. People called him the "Panji man", though he described himself as an archivist. To him, a genealogical register was not merely an object of family pride; he believed that what a family did not write down often revealed more than what it did.

The next morning he opened page fifty again. In daylight the scrape looked like an ordinary wound. The pressure marks he had seen in the slanting night light disappeared. He did not press the paper. He set the camera at three angles and enlarged the images. A few shapes emerged - perhaps the first character was an "M", perhaps something else, perhaps only the grain of the paper. Guessing was easy; calling a guess evidence was hard. In his notes he added one word: "indistinct."

At the back of the register was an index: names with page numbers. He began matching every name in the Udayanpur branch. He found four names. He found the name in the sixth entry. The fifth was absent. But there was a torn entry beginning "Mahe...", and the page number beside it had been overwritten in black ink. The original number might have been 50; over it someone had written 58.

Niranjan did not grow excited. He grew more cautious. The more signs he found, the more he held himself back. Human beings are very quick at making stories; truth is slow.

All day he examined the other papers in the house: an old copy of a land record, two wedding invitations, a ledger containing accounts of paddy. He looked for dates close to the period of page fifty. No certain year emerged; many entries in the register appeared to have been copied at a later time.

That evening, an elderly woman stopped him near the village well. "You are the one looking at the Panji?"

Niranjan greeted her respectfully. "Yes, Kaki."

"The one from Shivkant's house?"

"Yes."

"Is the red thread there?"

The question was so specific that Niranjan started. There really was an old red thread caught inside the binding, perhaps once used as a marker. "It is."

The old woman lifted her water-pot and said, "Where the thread was, the page is not."

"Which page?"

She did not answer. She only said, "If you ask my name, the people of the house will tell you: she has grown very old, her words no longer join properly."

"Then do not tell me your name. Tell me the thing itself."

For the first time she looked at him carefully. "And can a thing travel without a name?"

She walked away.

That night Niranjan examined the red thread. It was not on page fifty. It was caught farther back in the binding, between pages eighty-three and eighty-four. Along the outer edge of page eighty-three was a narrow tear, as though something had once been stitched there. Page eighty-four followed in sequence. No entire leaf was visibly missing.

This time he lit the lamp, but looked not at page fifty; he examined the paper inside the binding. At one end of the red thread was a knot. Within the knot clung an almost powder-fine trace of paper. The thread might not merely have marked a page; perhaps it had once tied a separate slip of paper into the book.

He slept little that night.

The next day he asked Shivkant, "Was any slip of paper ever removed from this register?"

Shivkant was drinking tea. "Not that I know of."

"Why is there a red thread?"

"Old registers have threads in them."

"Kaki said: where the thread was, the page is not."

The rim of Shivkant's cup struck his teeth. "Which Kaki?"

"She did not tell me her name."

"Old people in the village make up many stories."

Niranjan remained silent. Sometimes silence after a question does more work than an answer. After two sips, Shivkant said on his own, "In the old days, what belonged to the house remained in the house. Now everyone puts everything on a mobile phone."

"I am not putting it on a mobile phone. The family has given permission for a digital copy."

"Making a digital copy does not mean every wound must be opened again."

"Then there is a wound?"

Shivkant set down the cup. "That is not what I said."

Niranjan did not open his notebook. This conversation was not an archival record; it was the edge of trust.

He changed the subject. But one sentence remained lodged inside him: every wound must be opened again.

On the third day, beneath some clothes in an old chest, he found four letters. Shivkant himself had opened the chest; the moment he saw them, he said, "These are of no use." Niranjana did not touch them without permission. "If they are of no use, I will leave them."

After a while Shivkant took out one letter. "Look at this. Only this one."

Half the letter had been spoiled by damp. The salutation was gone. At the end the name "Harinarayan" survived. In the middle were references to family fields, a sick child, and "the matter of his name." No full sentence remained. What could still be read was this: "...what was written in the Panji was not by the household's consent..." Then a stain; then "...how is the child to blame..." Then the paper was torn away.

Niranjan searched the register for Harinarayan's name. It appeared on page forty-seven: a man of the Udayanpur branch, against whose name two sons were listed. One of those sons was Shivkant's grandfather.

"To whom was this letter written?" Niranjan asked.

"I do not know."

"The envelope?"

"No."

"The other letters?"

Shivkant's hand came down on the lid of the chest. "Enough."

Niranjan made a digital copy of the letter and returned the original. As soon as it left his hand, Shivkant's face loosened, as though for a few moments he had feared the paper might not come back.

That evening the old woman met him again near the well. This time she gave her name without being asked: "Subhadra."

Niranjan greeted her.

"Found the letter?"

A question rose in him - how did she know? But he said only, "One."

Subhadra smiled. "He will give one. He will keep three."

"You saw them?"

"Not I. My mother had seen them."

"What had she seen?"

"The face of the one whose name has been scraped away."

For the first time, Niranjan heard the missing line attached to the shadow of a living person. Until then he had been looking at a number, a thread, a letter, an indentation. "The name?"

Subhadra shook her head. "First you tell me: what does the paper say?"

"The paper says something was written there. Later it was erased. That is all."

"Good. Paper is wise. It does not talk too much, the way people do."

She set the water-pot down on the ground. "My mother used to say that Harinarayan's younger brother, Kamalakant, left the house. Something about him had been entered in the Panji in a different way. Later the people of the house erased it. But the story was not Kamalakant's. The story was about the child who was called by two names in the village - one given by his mother, the other by everyone else."

The word escaped Niranjan before he could stop it. "Mahendra?"

Subhadra gave him a sharp look. "The paper told you that much?"

"In the index there is 'Mahe...'. The page number was changed."

Subhadra was silent for a long time. "Then the paper saved half the name."

"The full name?"

"Mahesar."

"Kamalakant's son?"

"Will you write that?"

"If there is evidence."

"Then do not write it. I am not evidence. I am something heard and remembered."

Niranjan liked that answer. Village memory often wished to make itself into proof; Subhadra understood her own limit.

"Mahesar's mother?"

Subhadra lifted the water-pot again. "Understand only this much: there was no place for her in that household's Panji. But without her body, how could Mahesar have come into the world?"

"Her name?"

"That story belongs to another house. Ask that house."

"Which house?"

Subhadra pointed east, where the main settlement ended and a small hamlet lay beyond the pond. "There."

Niranjan did not go that day. He knew a story was becoming visible, but his work was not only to seize a story; it was also to mark the boundary. The family had entrusted him with this register, and he did not want to use that trust to invade another family's life. He wrote only in his notes: "Oral indication: 'Mahesar'; source identifies her account as received memory; independent corroboration required."

That night page fifty lay open again. In the lamp's slanting light, he looked at the indentations. This time the first shape seemed to him like an "M". He immediately looked away. Once the mind believes it knows something, the eyes often begin to see the same thing.

On the fourth day Shivkant himself came to the table. In his hand were three letters.

"Scan these," he said. "But not on the internet."

"Nowhere without your permission."

All three letters appeared to be in Harinarayan's hand. One mentioned Kamalakant: "He will not return home again." Another contained the name "Mahesar" clearly, but the sentence defining the relationship had been cut in half. The third letter was brief, perhaps written by some elder of the family. One line survived: "To keep the Panji pure is the duty of the house." Beneath it, apparently added later in Harinarayan's hand, was another sentence: "If, in purifying it, we erase the human being, what will remain?"

Niranjan read that line twice.

Shivkant kept looking toward the window. "I do not know why Grandfather kept this letter."

"Perhaps what has been erased is never erased completely."

"Do you write literature?"

"No. I make files."

For the first time Shivkant laughed. "Sometimes a file becomes literature too."

The three letters strengthened one fact: someone named Mahesar had existed, was connected to a family dispute, and Kamalakant figured in that

dispute. But it still did not prove that Mahesar was the name in the scraped fifth line of page fifty. Niranjan preserved that distance.

When the scanning was complete, he showed Shivkant the digital list. "What should I write for Entry 5 on page 50?"

Shivkant stared at the screen for a long time. "If you write 'indistinct', people will ask questions."

"If I leave it blank, the theft will happen again in the digital copy."

"Theft?"

"The person who scraped the paper erased it once. If I leave the blank place without any mark, I will erase it a second time."

Shivkant leaned back in the chair. "Then write: one line has been scraped away. The name is uncertain."

"Only that."

"Not Mahesar?"

"There is no proof."

Shivkant looked at him. Perhaps he was surprised that even after finding a story, Niranjan could resist the temptation to complete it. "All right."

That night Niranjan added a separate note to the digital copy: "On the original page, the entry sequence runs from 4 to 6; the intervening line has been physically abraded. A modified index entry and family letters contain the name 'Mahesar', but the name on the scraped line cannot be read with certainty."

It took him half an hour to write that sentence.

The next morning Subhadra Kaki came again. This time not to the well, but to Shivkant's courtyard. In her hand was a small cloth bundle. Shivkant stood at the door. Their eyes met. There was no greeting, no declaration of an old quarrel - only the kind of silence in which, for many years, two households may have acknowledged one another's existence while also refusing to do so.

Subhadra set the bundle before Niranjan. Inside was a torn scrap of paper. Along one edge clung the dried fibres of a red thread.

Niranjan's breath seemed to stop. Before reaching for it, he looked at Shivkant.

Shivkant said, "Look."

It was not a whole page - roughly the size of a palm. The upper edge was irregular. The writing had faded. There were three lines. The first was incomplete. In the second, "Mahesar" was clear. In the third, only "...kant" and "...birth..." could be read. There was no seal, no complete date, no mark that could establish beyond doubt that this was a fragment of the same register. Yet the thickness and colour of the paper, and the fibres of red thread, certainly resembled the Panji.

"Where was this?" Niranjan asked.

Subhadra said, "His mother had given it to my mother."

"His mother - Mahesar's?"

Subhadra did not answer directly. "The woman whose name you have been asking for all this time."

"Why did she give the bundle?"

"She had said: if the Panji ever begins to speak, hold this scrap up to its mouth."

Shivkant said suddenly, "This story was never told in our house."

Subhadra turned toward him. "That is why the paper came to ours."

Silence again between them.

Niranjan did not dare place the scrap over the scraped page. It might fit; it might not. Without scientific examination, matching them by eye could itself become a story. He placed the scrap separately on black paper, photographed it, measured it and recorded the damage.

"The original will remain with you," he told Subhadra.

"Why with me?"

"Where it came from."

Subhadra smiled. "The house it came from no longer exists."

Shivkant said softly, "Shall we put it in the chest, then?"

Subhadra looked at him. "Again?"

In that single word lay the old fear: erase it again? shut it away again? fall silent again?

Shivkant did not answer.

Niranjan said, "There will be two digital copies. One for you, one for him. The original can remain wherever the two of you think proper."

"And the Panji?" Subhadra asked.

"Nothing already in the Panji will be altered. What has been erased will be recorded as erased. The scrap will be described as 'possibly related paper', not as an authenticated original fragment."

Subhadra nodded. "Good. The living are often in too much of a hurry to give names to the dead."

Niranjan wanted to write down that sentence, but his notebook remained closed.

By evening the scanning was complete. Shivkant's register was wrapped again in cloth. The iron chest was cleaned. Niranjan explained a simple arrangement to protect it from damp. File names were settled. For page fifty he kept three images: direct light, slanting light, and detail.

Before leaving, he opened page fifty once more. The lamp was lit. Darkness was falling outside. Inside the house, Shivkant and Subhadra were speaking softly - perhaps about Mahesar, perhaps about something else. Niranjan did not try to listen.

He placed the lamp to the left of the page. The scraped place rose into relief again. The pressure lines still refused to become letters. But he no longer felt the old restlessness. The paper had made its limit clear.

Truth does not always give a complete name. Sometimes it gives only the shape of an empty place.

Niranjan saved the file. He typed the title: "Udayanpur_Panji_Page_050_Entry_5_Scraped."

For a long time afterward, the cursor went on blinking on the screen.

From inside, Shivkant called, "Work finished?"

Niranjan said, "This part is finished."

"Found the thief?"

Niranjan looked at the lamp. The small flame was steady. Its light fell not directly on the page but from the side, revealing every fine line of the abrasion.

"No," he said. "Perhaps the thief was not one person."

Subhadra's voice came from inside. "Then?"

Niranjan closed the register. "When everyone joins in refusing to speak a name, silence itself becomes the thief."

No one answered.

He extinguished the lamp, but the slant-lit image of the page remained on the screen - an erased line that could not be read, yet could no longer be unseen.

— *End of Story 1* —

2. The House Seen Again

STORY

When Madhavi reached Bardaha after thirty years, the house was smaller than it was in her memory.

She understood this the moment she stepped down from the bus. The turn into the village was no longer the same, half the pond's embankment had been filled in, there was now a betel shop beneath the peepal tree, and brick walls had risen along both sides of the old path. Yet the house having become smaller was something different from all these changes. The courtyard that in childhood had seemed so vast that she would run from one side to the other at dusk and be left breathless could now be seen almost in its entirety from the doorway.

Ashok stood at the door. He was no longer her little brother. The hair at the front of his head had thinned greatly, his stomach had pushed outward, and beneath his eyes was the kind of swelling Madhavi sometimes saw on her own face in the morning.

"You came," was all Ashok said.

Madhavi nodded. Her bag was in her hand. Ashok reached to take it, but Madhavi did not give it to him. Whether this was an old habit or a present one, she herself could not tell.

"Everything was over by yesterday evening," Ashok said. "We were late informing you. The phone..."

"I understand."

In truth, she did not entirely understand. News of Kaki's death had reached her at ten the previous night. Ashok's son had called. Behind his voice she could hear many people talking. She could not get a train ticket and came by bus. By the time she arrived, the pyre, the riverbank, the first rites - all were over. The house now held that silence which follows a death, a silence in which people keep doing one thing after another so that what has happened does not stand too plainly before them.

Kaki, whom everyone called Barki Kaki, the elder aunt, had been the last person in this house who remembered Madhavi's childhood in full. Whenever they spoke on the phone, Kaki would say, "That little red box of yours is still in the upstairs room." Madhavi always laughed. She no longer remembered what was in the red box. Perhaps old notebooks, two glass bangles, a copy of a school certificate, or something else that had seemed as necessary as the whole world at seventeen and meant nothing at all when one was nearing sixty.

Five or seven women were seated in the courtyard. Some faces came back to her; others were difficult to attach to names. The moment they saw her they tried to rise. Madhavi folded her hands to stop them. Leela - Ashok's wife - came and held her. The embrace was very brief, but within it Madhavi felt the fatigue in Leela's body.

"Didi, you came late," Leela said.

It was not a reproach. Only a fact.

"Yes."

"Kaki took your name during her last two days."

Something shifted inside Madhavi, but outwardly she asked only, "What did she say?"

Leela thought for a moment. "Nothing in particular. She asked: have you informed Madhavi?"

The answer brought Madhavi relief and disappointment at once. Families often turn words spoken by the dying into a final message. Here there had been no message. Only the question of whether she had been informed.

They took her inside. One part of the veranda had been enclosed with aluminium framing. Where Baba used to sit on a cot in the evenings there was now a sewing machine. A new room had been added on the right; its cement still stood out against the old ochre of the walls. The tulsi altar in the middle of the courtyard had grown smaller. The tulsi itself was green.

"Mother's room?" Madhavi asked without thinking.

Ashok did not understand. "Whose?"

"Our mother's. The one at the back."

"Oh, that? It is a storeroom now."

No one in the family had ever called it "Mother's room" while she was alive. Then it had simply been "the back room." For a few years after her death it was called "the old room." Now that "Mother's room" had slipped out of Madhavi's mouth, she herself found it strange.

"Wash your hands and face first," Ashok said. "You have come all this way."

There was a motor pipe where the hand-pump used to be. The old well had been covered. As she washed her hands, Madhavi looked at the lid. In childhood her mother had dried her hair on the well's platform. Winter sunlight reached there first. Now two empty plastic flowerpots stood on the lid.

Until noon people kept coming and going. Kaki's daughters arrived; then someone went to the market for ritual supplies, someone sorted lentils, someone else telephoned relatives with the date. Madhavi kept forgetting names. People recognized her; she identified them by guesswork. "You are Vimala Kaki's daughter?" "No, I am Rambabu's younger daughter-in-law." "Oh, yes." In such little mistakes, the distance of thirty years became perfectly visible.

Kaki's cot stood empty. A white sheet had been spread over it. On the wall above the head were two pictures of gods, a clock running five minutes slow, and, hanging from a nail, the cord of Kaki's spectacles. The spectacles themselves were not there.

Madhavi stood at the doorway. She remembered the last time she had seen Kaki's face, five years earlier, at a wedding. Kaki had held her hand for a long time and kept telling her to come to the village more often. Madhavi had said, "I will." Then she had not come. There was no single reason. Work, the children, her husband's illness, inconvenient trains, heat, floods, time, exhaustion - reasons were always available.

"Didi, will you sleep in this room?" Leela asked.

Madhavi started. "Which room?"

"The one at the back. Shall I have your mother's old room cleaned?"

"No, no. I will sleep where everyone else is sleeping."

"It will be crowded."

Madhavi looked toward the rear door. "Then that room will be fine."

Leela brought the key. As soon as the door opened, the smell of stale cloth, paper, old wood and shut-in air came out. The window was jammed from inside. Leela forced it open. A layer of dust began to float in the light.

The room was half full: empty paddy sacks, a broken fan, plastic flowers from some wedding, two old brass vessels, bundles of discarded schoolbooks. But the walls were the same. In the western wall was a small niche where her mother used to place a lamp at dusk. Above it the black stain of smoke still remained, though faintly.

Madhavi went over to it. She did not touch the wall. She only looked from close by.

"That stain simply will not go," Leela said. "We have had it whitewashed twice, and it comes through again."

Madhavi smiled. "Smoke is stubborn."

Leela smiled too. "Kaki used to say: do not whitewash this spot. Your mother used to keep the lamp here."

Madhavi said nothing at once.

Her mother had been dead twenty-four years. In her final years her knees had hurt, but she still lit the evening lamp herself. Madhavi was then living in another city. Phone calls were expensive, letters irregular. News from home arrived in small pieces: "Mother's knee pain has worsened." "Mother is better now." "Mother fell." "Come home this time." Madhavi would come, then return. When her mother died, she reached in time. The room had then been full of people. She had not had the leisure to look at the wall.

Leela began moving the sacks. Madhavi stopped her. "Why do so much? I am staying only one night."

"I will spread a sheet."

"I can do it myself."

Leela looked at her as though that sentence had made her understand something old. "All right. The broom is outside."

Madhavi was left alone.

She pushed the window fully open. Outside was the small rear courtyard where a guava tree had once stood. The tree was gone. A new wall had taken its place. Beyond the wall a child was reciting multiplication tables. The voice came clearly: two twos are four, two threes are six.

Madhavi moved one of the sacks aside. Beneath it she found a wooden board. She recognized it at once. Her mother used to sit on it while sorting

greens. One corner had worn round. Madhavi lifted it; it was heavier than she expected. She placed it beneath the niche and sat down.

Here, once, her mother had braided her hair. Here Madhavi had opened her schoolbook and memorized Maithili poems. Here, one day, Baba had said, "There is no need to send you away to college." And here, for the first time, Madhavi had shouted inside the house.

She still remembered that day with unnatural clarity. It was raining. Water dripped from one corner of the roof. Baba was sitting in the veranda reading the newspaper. Madhavi's admission letter had arrived - an opportunity to study outside Darbhanga. Baba had said, "Study here. Why send a girl so far away?"

Madhavi had looked at her mother. Her mother was wiping a brass plate. Madhavi wanted her to say at once: let her go. Her mother said nothing.

"Why are you not saying anything?" Madhavi had snapped at her mother.

Her mother set down the plate. "First speak to your father calmly."

"Will he agree if I speak calmly?"

"Will he if you shout?"

In anger Madhavi had gone outside. A narrow lane then ran along the left side of the house through the rear courtyard. It was full of rainwater. After a while her mother came out behind her carrying an umbrella. Madhavi stood crying against the outer wall of the house.

Her mother stood beside her. For some time both of them watched the water. Then her mother looked up toward the roof and said, "Look at it from this side. See where the water is getting in."

Madhavi had said angrily, "I do not care about the roof."

Her mother was silent a little longer. Then she said, "From inside a house, you cannot see the whole of it. Sometimes you have to stand outside."

At the time Madhavi had taken the sentence to be about the roof. Or perhaps advice: if you have stormed outside in anger, then look at the house from outside. Her mother's roundabout way of speaking angered her further.

"Are you in favour of sending me or not?" she had asked directly.

Her mother had said, "You want to study. Then you should go."

"Then tell Baba."

"I will."

"When?"

Her mother had not answered.

In the end Madhavi did go. How Baba came to agree was blurred in her memory. An uncle telephoned, a teacher came to the house, the scholarship was discussed, someone said the cost would be lower - many people intervened. Madhavi had settled inside herself on the belief that she had fought and gone by her own strength. In her memory, her mother's part in the story had been that of a silent woman who, at the end, tied up her clothes, put in a jar of pickle, came with her to the station, and when the train began to move said only, "Eat on time."

For thirty years, the story remained that way.

Now, seated on the wooden board, Madhavi looked at the black smoke-mark above the niche. Without warning, her mother's sentence rose inside her: from inside a house, you cannot see the whole of it.

She got up and went to the window. The new wall at the back stood so close that the house could not be seen from outside. Only a palm-sized piece of sky remained.

By evening the relatives had thinned out. The house grew quiet. Ashok and two other men sat outside on chairs calculating the expenses of the rites. Madhavi sat in the veranda drinking tea. In the middle of the conversation Ashok said, "This house has deteriorated badly now. The roof will have to be replaced."

Madhavi murmured, "Hmm."

"While Kaki was here, we could not do much. Now we will see."

"What?"

"What to do. Repair it, or..." He left the sentence unfinished. "Land prices have gone up."

Madhavi understood. For the first time, the possibility of selling the house stood before her without being named. The expected shock did not come. She thought that after being absent for thirty years, the moral right to oppose a sale was not self-evident. Then she wondered: why the question of rights at all? If the house remained, for whom would it remain? Ashok did not live here; his son was in the city. Leela carried a great deal of work.

"What do you think?" Ashok asked.

Madhavi looked into her cup. "Let Kaki's rites be completed first."

Ashok nodded at once. "Yes. Of course."

The subject stopped there.

The electricity went out at night. Leela left on one small inverter bulb and switched off the rest. No wire reached the back room. Madhavi was spreading the sheet by the light of her phone when Leela brought a small brass lamp.

"Keep this. There is not much oil, but it will burn for a while."

The lamp was placed in the niche.

As soon as the flame rose, the stain on the wall deepened again. Madhavi's shadow stretched as far as the window. The room no longer seemed merely small; suddenly it seemed deep. The corners of things emerged one by one.

Leela stood at the door. "Your mother was very quiet, wasn't she?"

The question came so unexpectedly that Madhavi looked at her. "Why?"

"Kaki used to say so. Of the two sisters-in-law, your mother spoke less. But once the elder one decided on something, she made it happen."

"Made what happen?"

Leela shrugged. "I came into the family later. That was Kaki's way of telling it."

Madhavi wanted to ask something more - what did Kaki say? What had her mother decided? But Leela was already turning away. "Sleep. People will start coming again early in the morning."

Madhavi remained alone before the lamp.

"Once the elder one decided on something, she made it happen." The sentence was not proof. It was only a fragment of what Leela said Kaki used to say. If Madhavi wished, she could turn it into a key for changing her old story: Mother persuaded Baba behind the curtain; Mother called the teacher; Mother had the scholarship papers filled in. But there was no proof of any of this. And her mother was no longer there to be asked.

She searched inside her memory. The day at the station. Her mother was wearing a sari with a red border. Baba kept taking the ticket out of his pocket and putting it back. The train was late. Her mother opened Madhavi's bag once and checked: pickle, towel, two books. Then quietly she slipped a twenty-rupee note inside. Madhavi had seen her do it but said nothing. At the time twenty rupees had seemed a small amount. Now she wondered: how much money did her mother ever have in her own hands?

That thought too had come late. Thirty years late.

She did not sleep well. The sounds of the house had changed. Now a cat ran across the roof, now air moved through the pump pipe, now a dog barked outside. In childhood she had known the meaning of every sound. Now all of them were unfamiliar.

Once, in the middle of the night, she woke and looked at the lamp. The oil was gone; the wick was black. Her phone showed two twenty. As she drank water she looked toward the stain in the niche. Even in darkness she could make out its shape.

Very early in the morning she got up. The others in the house were still asleep. Pale light was coming through the rear window. She went outside, crossed the courtyard and opened the main door. There was dew in the lane. Two cows were moving away in the distance.

Without thinking, Madhavi walked along the left side of the house toward the same narrow lane where she had once stood with her mother in the rain. The lane was no longer narrow; one house had been demolished, leaving an open space in the middle. Half of the old outer wall had been plastered with cement, half remained old brick.

She stood on the far side of the road and looked at the house.

From there the house truly was different. The courtyard could not be seen. There were only the uneven lines of the roofs, the high wall of the new room, a small surviving patch of the old tiled roof, and the back room's window. The iron bars of the window had rusted. Above them, old rain-streaks marked the wall.

Her mother's voice came back into Madhavi's mind: from inside a house, you cannot see the whole of it. Sometimes you have to stand outside.

This time the sentence was not about the roof.

It did not suddenly reveal to her that her mother had been right and Baba wrong; nor did it tell her that all the grievances of her childhood had been groundless. She understood only one small thing: when she was seventeen, from inside the house she had been able to see only her own place in it. Not her mother's. Her mother too, living within that same house, may not have been able to see everything whole; perhaps she too had sometimes needed to stand outside - in her mind, in her silence, or only in that lane.

And perhaps, that day, her mother had not been speaking about the roof at all. Perhaps she had been giving Madhavi permission to stand outside.

This was not a conclusion. Only a new shimmer of meaning. Like the flame of a lamp - not a straight beam, but light falling from the side, making the unevenness of an old wall visible.

Madhavi did not remain there long. The air was cold. She turned back toward the house. The main door stood open. From inside came the sound of Leela sweeping.

Ashok called from the veranda, "Where did you go so early?"

"Just nearby."

"To look at the road?"

Madhavi paused for a moment. "To look at the house."

Ashok laughed. "The house was inside."

Madhavi smiled lightly too. "Yes."

She went in.

After breakfast she had to catch the bus. Leela packed puris for her. Ashok said, "Will you be able to come again on the thirteenth-day rites?"

Madhavi counted the date in her head. She had a doctor's appointment, a visit to her daughter's house, and some work. "We will see," she said.

In the past she would have felt guilty giving such an answer. This time there was only uncertainty.

Before lifting her bag she went once more to the back room. The sheet had been folded and placed to one side. The wooden board remained beneath the niche. She thought of taking it, then did not. She remembered the red box. There was no time to search the upstairs room. Perhaps next time. Perhaps never.

The previous night's lamp still stood in the niche. The oil was finished. Madhavi straightened the wick. Morning light fell on the black stain of the wall. In that light the stain was very faint, almost invisible.

She understood: some things can be seen clearly in darkness, some only from a distance.

But she did not complete the sentence in her mind. Completing it would turn it into a lesson again.

She closed the door, gave the key to Leela, and came outside.

Ashok went with her as far as the bus stand. On the way he did not bring up selling the house again. Neither did Madhavi. They spoke instead about the market, the road, fares, floodwater, the doctor.

When the bus began to move, Ashok stood outside the window. Morning sunlight fell on the thinning hair on his head. For a moment Madhavi saw the little brother of childhood who had wanted to follow her all the way to school. Then the bus moved on.

At the last turn of the village the house could no longer be seen. Only a few roofs, a distant peepal tree, and hazy light. Madhavi did not turn back to look through the rear window.

She no longer needed the house to remain before her eyes.

The sentence her mother had spoken thirty years ago had, for the first time, changed its place inside her.

And in that changed place, her mother no longer seemed silent.

— *End of Story 2* —

3. In a Free State

STORY

1. Delhi — The Yellow Bulb on the Roof

When Binod first came to Delhi, he was twenty-two. Fourteen years later, he still told people in his village that he was in Delhi only “for a few days.” The thought that a few days could stretch this long sometimes made him laugh at himself.

He worked as a night guard at a private hospital. Behind the hospital stood a four-storey building, and on its roof, beneath a tin awning, were three rooms. Binod shared one of them with two other men. Outside the room a yellow bulb burned all night. In its light, the rooftop water tank, the drying towels, the small gas stove, and three pairs of slippers all seemed to take on the same colour.

In the village, Binod’s identity began even before his name: lineage, neighbourhood, father, fields, brothers. Here, at the gate, the plastic badge on his chest said only “BINOD K.” During his first month it had felt strangely light. No one asked: which family? which clan? which genealogical line? Inside the hospital, people were either patients, relatives of patients, or people at work. At two in the morning, every identity grows smaller.

But a smaller identity does not make the body’s exhaustion smaller. Standing at the gate all night, lifting the barricade whenever an ambulance arrived, sometimes keeping a quarrelling family from forcing its way inside, sometimes showing an old patient’s son where the drinking-water tap was—by dawn, his legs would feel heavy.

His shift ended at six. He climbed to the roof, slipped off his sandals, and put tea on the gas stove. At that hour the Delhi sky never looked to him like the dawn over the pond in his village; it looked like ash. Even so, this was the hour he felt most his own. His two roommates would still be asleep. The street noise had not yet fully awakened. He put little sugar in his tea, dipped two biscuits into it, and opened his phone.

His sister Renu’s message often arrived at that hour: “Awake?” Binod would feel like replying, “I’ve been awake all night.” But usually he wrote only, “Yes.”

Renu lived in the village with their mother. She had married in a neighbouring block, but after her husband fell ill she returned to her mother’s home. Binod’s earnings from Delhi went into repairing the roof, medicines, his nephew’s schooling, and now and then into debts whose full accounting he himself did not understand.

One morning Renu called.

“You’re coming for Chhath this time, aren’t you?”

Binod rested his elbows on the parapet. Rooftops stretched far into the distance. Clothes hung on some, pigeons clustered on others, solar panels shone on a few.

“I’ll see. Getting leave from the hospital...”

“You said the same thing last time.”

“We were short two guards then.”

“And now?”

“Now one guard’s daughter is ill.”

Renu fell silent. Binod regretted the answer at once. It sounded as though he were using another man’s sick daughter as a shield for his own absence. Yet it was also true.

Renu said, “Ma was cleaning your old room last night.”

“Why?”

“She said there shouldn’t be dust when Binod comes.”

Binod tried to laugh. “What, I don’t know how to sleep in dust?”

Renu did not laugh. “She has grown old.”

After the call ended, Binod stared for a long time at the phone’s black screen. In daylight the yellow bulb was almost useless, yet it was still burning. He got up and switched it off.

Before going inside, he walked to the four flowerpots kept in one corner of the roof. The tulsi in one had dried. In another, coriander had sprouted only to turn yellow. In the third, one of his roommates had planted a chilli sapling bought from the market. The fourth was empty. For fourteen years Binod had often thought of filling that empty pot with soil brought from his village. Each time there had been no ticket, no soil, no time.

That day too, he went back into the room.

That evening he wrote an application for leave during Chhath, but did not submit it. The paper stayed in his bag for three days. On the fourth, he took it out and used the blank reverse side to write down his market expenses.

To say Delhi had kept him there would not be quite right. To say the village was calling him back would not be entirely right either. Between the two, he had tied small knots of daily work, debt, affection, shame, and fatigue.

That night, as he stood at the gate, the badge on his chest gleamed again: “BINOD K.”

In his mind, he said his full name once, only to hear it.

2. The Gulf — The Four O’Clock Call

Nasim’s room had a window, but it did not open. Beyond the glass, countless city lights burned through the night. Sometimes he thought they could go on burning without air, because in this city perhaps no one ever needed to let the outside air in.

He repaired air-conditioning systems. Day or night, whenever a call came, the company vehicle took him out. Mall, office, hotel, warehouse—wherever a machine that cooled the air stopped, Nasim’s work began.

At home his mother would say, “You must always be nice and cool there.”

Nasim would laugh every time. How could he explain that when he opened outdoor units on rooftops under the sun, the metal could burn his hands? That the back of a machine made to produce cold air could blaze like fire? He did not explain these things about his work. Money reached home; that was enough.

His wife, Shabina, chose the time of her calls carefully. When it was four in the morning in India, the night here was not yet entirely over. Nasim was usually back from work by then. Shabina would be awake before prayer. For both of them, it was an hour when the child slept, roommates slept, neighbours slept, and the world asked fewer questions.

"Awake?" Shabina would ask.

"Yes."

"Have you eaten?"

"Yes."

Very often both those yeses were lies. Sometimes Nasim had not been awake at all and had only risen at the sound of the phone; sometimes he had not eaten. But there was no deceit in those lies, only economy. The time for speaking was short; the space available for worry was shorter still.

His daughter Mahira was five. When she saw her father on the phone, she would bring the screen very close. "Babu, why are your eyes so big?" Nasim would laugh.

One day Mahira showed him a house she had drawn on paper—two windows, a door in the middle, a round yellow sun above. To the left of the house stood one very tall man.

"Who is that?" Nasim asked.

"You."

"Why am I outside the house?"

Mahira looked at the camera, searching for an answer, then back at the drawing. "You are outside."

Shabina quickly said, "She's a child. She drew whatever came to mind."

Nasim said, "She drew it right."

That night, the contract of Sharif, who worked with him, came to an end. Sharif was packing his things into two bags. Everyone asked, "Will you come back again?" Sometimes Sharif said yes; sometimes, we'll see. His ticket was one-way.

Before Sharif left for the airport, Nasim gave him the small electric kettle from his room. "It'll be useful at home."

Sharif laughed. "We have gas at home."

"Then give it to someone else."

Sharif put the kettle in his bag. Things belonging to migrants often change owners; when one goes home, not every object makes the journey back.

After Sharif left, his bed stood empty. The company said a new worker would arrive in two days. That night Nasim noticed an old towel Sharif had left on the bed. He meant to throw it away, then washed it and hung it on the line. He remembered that when he had first arrived, even his pillowcase had belonged to someone else. New people came here, but the things were already waiting. It was as though the room recognised shifts, not people.

Two days later Nasim's salary came. He sent half the money home. Shabina messaged at once: "Received. I'll buy Ma's medicines. I'll pay Mahira's school fee too."

Nasim looked at the figures. From what remained would come his share of the room, food, phone, old debts. He postponed buying new shoes again. The sole of one shoe was coming loose at the side; he would glue it.

The four o'clock call did not come that morning. Shabina had perhaps slept late. Nasim thought of calling her himself, then opened the photograph of the house Mahira had drawn.

He had looked at the picture many times. This time his eye went inside the house. Between the windows was a tiny yellow dot, perhaps where Mahira's crayon had rested while she coloured.

Nasim enlarged the picture with two fingers. The dot blurred.

He did not call. He placed the phone beside his head and closed his eyes. Before sleep came, he looked once more at the loose sole of his shoe, took out the tin of adhesive, and set it nearby. Small repairs he did with his own hands; larger breakages he postponed until the next salary. Beyond the sealed glass window, the city was still burning with light.

3. Assam — The Smell of Leaves

When Phoolkumari reached the Devjhar tea garden, for the first three days everything seemed to have a smell—wet earth, leaves, wood smoke, dampness in the room, oil rubbed into the body, and a sharp odour drifting from the factory that resembled nothing she knew.

From the sixth day onward, the smells began to separate. Wet leaves smelled one way, plucked leaves another, drying leaves another. What had first seemed a single thing opened into differences once she began learning the work.

Phoolkumari had come with her husband Jagdish through a contractor. For two years running, the harvest in the village had been poor; there was also the old household debt. "We'll go for six months, then come back," Jagdish had said. Into her trunk Phoolkumari packed six saris, the child's clothes, a small brass bowl her mother had given her, and not a handful of soil from home, but five tulsi seeds.

They were given one room in the workers' line. In the rain the tin roof clattered so loudly that on the first night her three-year-old son Sonu covered his ears and cried. Phoolkumari held him to her chest and sang a lullaby in Maithili. From the next room another woman was soothing a child in another language. The two languages did not understand one another, but the tune that puts a child to sleep did.

During her first week of work, Phoolkumari's fingers ached. She did not yet have the speed to recognise the tender leaves. She was too slow. Hema, who worked beside her, took her hand and showed her which leaves to leave and which to pluck. Hema spoke her own language, with bits of Assamese; Phoolkumari spoke Maithili, and a few Hindi words bridged the gap between them. Work learns language before grammar does.

After a month, people began calling Phoolkumari "Phuli." She did not like the name, but at the time resisting it did not seem important enough. At weighing time numbers were called, not names. On her wage slip her

name was written correctly—Phoolkumari Devi. She kept every slip in her trunk.

One evening Hema came to her room. Sonu was drawing circles on the ground with a piece of charcoal. Hema noticed the small tulsi plant.

“This?”

“Tulsi.”

Hema said something in her own language, then joined her palms. Phoolkumari smiled. “Yes. Worship. Medicine too. Fragrance too. Home too.”

Hema did not understand the last word. Phoolkumari pointed to her chest, then outward, toward the distance. Whether Hema understood remained unclear; but she named some plant from her own home, and the next day brought Phoolkumari two leaves from it.

When six months were over, Jagdish said, “Let’s stay another three months. We’ll clear a little more of the debt.”

Phoolkumari did not answer at once. By then Sonu had begun picking up some of the words spoken by the children in the garden. New sounds were entering his Maithili too. Sometimes Phoolkumari laughed; sometimes they startled her.

“Ma is alone in the village,” she said at last.

“Your brother is there.”

“My brother has his own household.”

“There is work here.”

“I know.”

The conversation ended there. No decision was made.

At the Sunday market, Phoolkumari would sometimes look for things from home—sattu, flattened rice, the familiar smell of mustard oil. She could not find everything, but whenever she found something, she bought more than she needed. Once Jagdish laughed and asked, “Who’s going to eat so much chura?” Phoolkumari said, “Let it be.” In truth, it was not so much the eating of the chura as the familiar rustle from inside the trunk that pleased her. When she opened it at night, the smell did not turn into the village, but it opened like a small door in the village’s direction.

That night it rained hard. The sound on the tin roof was so loud that conversation was impossible. The electricity went out. Phoolkumari poured oil into the small brass bowl, set a cotton wick in it, and lit it. The bowl was not really a lamp, but it became light.

Sonu sat beside her. “Ma, does it rain like this at home too?”

Phoolkumari was about to say, “Yes,” but stopped. Rain in the village, rain here—what did like this mean? The sound of water? The smell of earth? The tin roof? Missing one’s mother?

She said, “It rains at home.”

Sonu was satisfied. A child does not need a comparison; a child needs an answer.

After the rain stopped, water kept dripping from the leaves outside the room. Phoolkumari opened the trunk and counted the wage slips. Beneath them lay an old ticket, its date long past. She had not thrown it away.

In the lamp's light, the tulsi plant cast an enormous shadow on the wall. The plant itself was still small.

4. Kolkata — Two Cities Inside One Room

Kiran had been in Kolkata for eight years, yet she still could not recite her full address without looking at a piece of paper. The lane's name was written in Bengali letters, the house number looked as though it had been changed twice, and the postman often left letters downstairs at the paan shop.

She spent her days caring for an elderly woman. The family called her "Kiran-di." The first time she heard the "di," she had laughed. In the village she would have been someone's didi; here, even the family that paid her monthly wages called her sister. A form of address sometimes creates closeness; sometimes it conceals distance.

The elderly woman, Malati Sen, could barely walk, but her memory was sharp. Three times a day she asked the same question: "Tomar bari kothay?" At first Kiran gave the full name of her village. Malati Sen would ask, "Which district?" The third time: "Darbhanga?" In the end Kiran learned to answer, "Near Darbhanga." Her village was in fact far from Darbhanga, but this answer shortened the conversation.

One day Malati Sen asked, "Don't you go home?"

Kiran said, "I do."

"After how many days?"

Kiran began to count. The last time had been three years ago. Before that, two years. "When I get time."

Malati Sen laughed. "No one gives you time. You have to steal it."

Kiran did not understand all the Bengali words, but she understood the meaning: no one gives you time; you must steal it. From that day the sentence stayed inside her.

She left work at seven in the evening. During festival days the streets filled with light. Some pandals were so bright that night seemed like day. Kiran avoided the crowds and took the lanes. Her rented room was on the ground floor; outside its window stood another wall, scarcely an arm's length away. Even by day no direct sunlight entered.

In the room she had a cot, a plastic trunk, a steel rack, and a photograph of her daughter Sonam on the wall. Sonam lived in the village with her grandmother. When Kiran came to Kolkata eight years ago, her daughter was seven. Now she was fifteen. Even her voice on the phone had changed.

"Ma, after school I want to go to a city to study."

"Where?"

"Darbhanga, maybe Patna. Teacher says I should fill out the form."

Kiran's first response was an account of the money. The second was pride. The third was a fear she could not name. Her daughter too would leave home. Then what, in the village, would home be? Grandmother? A locked room? The ridge between fields? Kiran herself?

"Fill out the form," she said.

"The money?"

"I'll manage."

After the call, she opened the trunk. Inside were four saris, some papers, two drawings from Sonam's childhood, and an old envelope. The envelope did not contain a letter from her husband—he had never written one. It held a panchayat paper recording their agreement to live separately. After Kiran came to Kolkata, people in the village had asked many questions. In Kolkata, no one asked whether she was married, where her husband was, why her daughter lived with her grandmother. People asked only: Can you work? Can you stay till night? Can you lift the old woman?

There was harshness in those questions, but also a kind of leave. She did not have to present a defence of her character.

That night Kiran wanted to light a small lamp. The landlord had forbidden open flame. So she switched on the torch on her phone and aimed it at the photograph on the wall. Sonam's face turned bright; the rest of the room remained dark.

After a while Malati Sen's daughter called. "Kiran-di, Ma took her medicine, didn't she?"

"Yes, she did."

"Can you come half an hour early tomorrow? I have a meeting."

Kiran thought of Sonam's college form. She needed to go to a cybercafé tomorrow. If she went to work half an hour early, no time would remain.

She wanted to say, "No."

What came out was, "I'll see."

The call ended.

Sunday was her only half-day off. Often she thought of going to the Hooghly, but washing clothes, shopping, sending money, recharging the phone, having a long talk with her daughter—these consumed the day. Once she really had gone to the river. Seeing the water did not remind her of the river in her village; instead she was struck by the thought that water connects far-flung cities in its own way, yet water itself never has to write down an address. That day she had bought two books for Sonam. One was still lying in the trunk—she had never found an opportunity to send it.

For a long time Kiran remained angry at those two words. Kolkata had given her enough freedom that no one demanded an account of her past; yet the freedom to say "no" had still not entered her practice.

The phone's torch grew hot and flashed a warning. She switched it off. Sonam's face dissolved into the dark, but on the screen the last date for submitting the form still glowed.

Kiran plugged the phone in to charge. She began calculating how she might steal half an hour tomorrow.

5. Punjab — The Ticket Home

Naresh's sister Bela ended every phone call with the same line: "If you keep counting the days, the days won't pass."

Naresh operated a machine in a hosiery factory in Ludhiana. Inside the factory there was no way to tell day from night by the sound; the machines droned by day and by night. Outside, the seasons changed. Inside, the smell of yarn, dust, and oil remained almost the same.

When he left the village, his daughter Komal was two. Now she was six. On the phone she called him "Babu," but the last time he went home, for

the first two days she would not sit beside him alone. Bela had laughed and said, “The father from the photograph has come for real, so she’s afraid.”

Naresh had laughed too, but something inside him remained caught on the sentence.

In the factory he worked with people from Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Nepal, Odisha, and Bengal. Everyone spoke differently; under the roar of the machines every language shrank into commands—thread, stop, start, lift, put down, hurry. At mealtimes language opened out again: someone’s pickle from home, someone’s sattu, someone’s flattened rice, someone’s dried fish.

Naresh liked the rooftop at night best of all. Behind the factory, the workers’ quarters had an open roof. In winter it was hard to go up there, but in summer half the men slept there. The city lights dimmed the stars, yet the sky was open. In the village, an open sky had been ordinary; here it felt like an amenity.

One evening two fingers of his left hand were grazed in the machine. The wound was not serious, but at the sight of blood his mind ran suddenly homeward. The supervisor had it bandaged and gave him half a day’s rest. Back in his room, Naresh opened his phone and, without thinking much, began searching for a train ticket for the following week.

He found a seat—the waiting list was not too long. He booked it.

He sent Bela a screenshot.

Her call came at once. “Are you really coming?”

“Can’t you see the ticket?”

“I can see the ticket. I know you.”

“This time it’s certain.”

“What happened to your hand?”

Naresh started. “Nothing.”

“Raju, who works with you, called home. His sister lives in my in-laws’ village.”

Naresh felt irritated. Migration created great distances, and news travelled even farther. “It’s only a small scrape.”

“Doctor?”

“It’s been bandaged.”

Bela was silent. Then she said, “I haven’t told Ma. Come home first; then we’ll tell her.”

Naresh’s chest felt lighter. The ticket was on his phone. One week. Seven days. For the first time, he began counting.

The very next day the factory owner announced that a large order had come in for the next fifteen days. Any worker who took leave would have to repay part of his advance immediately. Three months earlier, when his daughter had a fever, Naresh had taken an advance. The figure the owner quoted made his head swim.

“I’ve already bought my ticket,” he said.

The owner shrugged. “You can go. Settle the account before you leave.”

No one was stopping him. The door was open. Only leaving had a price.

That evening another message came from home. One side of the roof leaked in the rain; Bela wrote that if he could send a little extra money that month, they would call a mason. Naresh read the message and switched off

the phone. No one was explicitly telling him, don't come home. Everyone was simply placing a need before him—the factory's order, the roof at home, his daughter's waiting, the advance to be repaid. The decision was his, but other people's lives were tied around it on every side.

Naresh went up to the roof that evening. The wound throbbed beneath the bandage. He opened the ticket on his phone. Below it was the option: Cancel. He moved his finger toward it, but did not press.

Bela sent another message: "Komal has told everyone that Babu is coming."

Naresh turned the phone face down.

Other workers were playing cards on the roof. Someone was listening to a song on the radio. Bright light spilled from the upper windows of the factory in the distance. Naresh remembered the veranda of his village house, where one small lamp left most of the courtyard in darkness, yet people could still see one another's faces.

Here there was plenty of light, and only half a face.

At nine that night the ticket was still not cancelled. At eleven it still was not. At three in the morning, when he got up to drink water, he saw that his waiting-list position had moved forward by one.

Whether he laughed or grew sad, he himself could not tell.

Bela did not call at dawn. Only a voice message from Komal came: "Babu, I'll wear my red frock at the station."

Naresh listened to the message twice. Before he could listen a third time, the siren for the factory's first shift sounded.

He put the phone in his pocket and went down the stairs. The ticket was not in his pocket but inside the screen; returning home, too, was still inside the screen.

— End of Story 3 —

4. Water-Samadhi

STORY

I did not hear the river's voice before.

In the first year of my marriage, I went many times to the Kamla flowing behind this house—at dusk, when washing utensils, during the Chhath offering, or simply to look at the water. The river then was water: flowing, falling, rising, sometimes muddy, sometimes blue. I understood no language of its own.

Now, when night comes, it speaks my name.

“Malati.”

At first softly. Then twice. Sometimes three times.

I have told no one this. Once a thing is spoken aloud inside a house, it no longer remains one's own. People seize it and clothe it in meanings of their choosing. This house has no shortage of meanings. Even the meaning of my name has changed according to everyone's convenience.

At the time of my marriage, I was “Lakshmi.” In the first year I became “barren.” In the second year, when a son was born, I became “Lakshmi” again. In the fifth year, when my son died of fever, I became “ill-fated.” In the seventh year, when Subodh left the house, no one had the courage to call me “the guilty one” to my face, but the word was written in everyone's eyes.

Even now, there is no agreement in the household over whether Subodh left or drowned.

My mother-in-law says he drowned.

My elder brother-in-law says he ran away.

The village says his bicycle was found near the river bridge at night, so one may assume the water took him.

I say: the bicycle was found; the body was not.

People hear this and look at me as though the body's not being found were my fault too.

Subodh's bicycle still hangs above the cowshed. A thick layer of dust and earth has settled over the wheels. In the beginning I had suggested bringing it down. My elder brother-in-law said, “Let it stay. There should be a sign.”

He did not say whose sign—Subodh's, or my waiting.

The first mention of the “water rite” came three months after Subodh disappeared.

It had not rained that day, yet the courtyard was wet. Early in the morning my mother-in-law overturned a water pot while drawing water from the well. The water spread across the earth and reached my feet. She did

not look at me. She merely said, "In this house, water asks for what is due to it."

I thought she was remembering her son. I picked up the pot.

In the afternoon my elder sister-in-law asked quietly, "Did Ma say anything to you?"

"Water asks for what is due to it."

Her hand stopped. She had been sorting mustard seeds. Without raising her eyes, she asked, "Only that?"

"Only that."

There was so much relief in that "only" that for the first time I grew suspicious.

"What is the water rite?" I asked.

She answered at once, "Nothing. Old people's talk."

"Then why were you frightened?"

"I wasn't frightened."

She began rubbing the mustard seeds so hard that two or three sprang from her palm and fell to the ground.

That night I asked my mother-in-law.

She was gathering the ash from the hearth. "It is an observance of the ancestors."

"What observance?"

"When a great calamity comes upon the household, water is given its due honour."

"How is it honoured?"

She pulled a half-burnt piece of coal from the ash. "Not everything is meant to be asked."

I laughed. I truly did. It seemed to me like the sort of thing told to children to keep them from going out at night—a ghost in the peepal tree, a witch in the pond, a shadow in the bamboo grove.

"And if water is not honoured?"

For the first time she looked at me. "Then water takes for itself."

That night, for the first time, the river spoke my name.

Even now I wonder: did my mother-in-law's sentence come first, causing me to hear the voice? Or had the voice always been there, and the sentence merely opened its meaning? I cannot answer that. Sometimes cause and consequence put on each other's clothes.

The same happened with Subodh.

A week before he disappeared, he had said to me, "If ever I am not here, don't let yourself remain trapped in this house."

I had grown angry. "Why are you saying such a thing?"

He had said, "Nothing. Just like that."

Now my elder brother-in-law says: you see, he was already planning to run away.

My mother-in-law says: perhaps he had sensed death approaching.

I have Subodh's face from that moment. Into that face I can now read whatever I wish: fear, guilt, exhaustion, love, deceit—anything. The face of a dead or absent person is the most obedient document of all.

Subodh had debts. I understood that properly only later. The fertiliser shopkeeper, two private loans, instalments on a group-credit loan, and some money borrowed in my elder brother-in-law's name. He had not told me everything. People in the house say that, as his wife, I failed to understand my husband's condition. I wonder: a man who kept his account book under his pillow—was I supposed to read the figures by taking his pulse?

After Subodh disappeared, creditors came into the courtyard twice. The third time, my elder brother-in-law stopped them outside. After that, the voices inside the house changed. Less was said in front of me, more behind me.

“Should we send her to her mother's home for now?”

“What will people say?”

“The body hasn't been found.”

“Then she is neither widow nor married wife.”

“Such a state in between eats away at a household.”

I did not see who said the last sentence. I was in the kitchen. The voice came through the wall. When I stepped outside, everyone fell silent.

That night the river said again, “Malati.”

I closed the window.

My room is on the western side of the house. In the rains, the river's smell comes all the way inside. I used to like it: wet earth, kans grass, distant refuse, fish—all mingled together. Now there is something metallic in it for me. I have smelled blood only a few times; when my son died, blood came from his nose. The river's smell at night takes me back to that room.

My son's name was Aditya. Everyone at home called him Adu. When he died, no one remembered the water rite. Perhaps the death of a child is not treated as the household's fault. When a woman's husband disappears, the road of blame runs straight to the woman.

I do not say this loudly. I no longer like speaking loudly. When I raise my voice, it sounds to me like my mother-in-law's.

One afternoon in Chaitra, my mother-in-law asked me to open the upstairs room. It had been locked for years. Inside were an old low stool, a torn mosquito net, two empty grain bins, papers belonging to Subodh's father, and a wooden chest. Its latch was jammed. My elder brother-in-law struck it with a hammer and opened it.

Beneath some clothes inside lay a book like a panji—whether it was an actual genealogical register or simply the family lineage-book, I do not know. I began to read, but my elder brother-in-law snatched it away.

“What is this to you?”

“Am I not of this house?”

He was silent for a moment. “You are.”

“Then?”

“It's old history.”

My mother-in-law stood in the doorway. “Let her see.”

My elder brother-in-law looked at her as though she were crossing some boundary. But he handed the book back to me.

Much of the writing I could not read. Old ink, broken letters. Men's names appeared most often. Women's names sometimes came only through

relationships: “wife,” “daughter,” “mother.” In two places the same sentence had been written in red ink: “Water honoured.”

At the first place, the name had half faded: “...Devi.” At the second it was clear: “Chandrakala.” There was no date, only a rough indication of the year.

I asked my mother-in-law, “What does ‘Water honoured’ mean?”

She said, “Close the book.”

“You said it was an observance of the ancestors.”

“Not everything written is meant to be understood.”

“Who was Chandrakala?”

My mother-in-law’s face changed. My elder brother-in-law took the book from my hands and put it back in the chest.

That night I asked my elder sister-in-law about Chandrakala. She remained silent for a long time. Then she said, “Ma’s mother-in-law’s sister.”

“What happened to her?”

“I didn’t see it.”

“Did you hear?”

“The story has many versions.”

“Tell me one.”

“Her husband died. There was some quarrel in the house. One morning her anklet was found by the river.”

“The body?”

“No.”

“Then people decided she had drowned?”

My elder sister-in-law raised her hand as if to cover my mouth, then lowered it. “Speak softly.”

“Why?”

“Because Ma will hear.”

“What is Ma afraid of hearing?”

Her answer was so soft that it seemed the river’s voice had entered the room: “Perhaps that Chandrakala did not drown.”

A shiver went through me.

“Then?”

“That is all I have heard. Some said she ran away to her mother’s home. Some said she was seen near the market across the river at night. But in the family book they wrote, ‘Water honoured.’ After that, no one searched for her.”

I lay awake the whole night.

That night the river did not speak my name.

I found the silence more frightening than the voice.

The next day my mother-in-law called me into her room and shut the door from inside. For the first time I looked closely at an old framed photograph hanging on the wall. Five women, three men. One woman’s face had been scratched away—not the glass, the photograph itself.

“Chandrakala?” I asked.

My mother-in-law trembled. “Your elder sister-in-law talks too much.”

“Is this Chandrakala?”

“No.”

“Then who?”

“What do you want, Malati?”

It was the first time anyone had asked me directly: what do you want? The question left me unable to answer. Subodh? Aditya? My mother’s home? Freedom? Truth? Simply one night’s sleep?

My mother-in-law said on her own, “Subodh will not return.”

“How do you know?”

“A mother knows.”

“Mothers do not know everything.”

The moment the sentence left me, her face changed as though I had struck her. Even to me my voice sounded harsh.

After a long while she said, “I too was once a new bride in this house.”

“So?”

“In my time too there was talk of the water.”

My breath seemed to catch.

“Why?”

She did not answer. She kept looking at the framed photograph. Then suddenly she said, “Go to your mother’s home.”

“Now?”

“Yes.”

“And people?”

“You cannot bind bamboo over people’s mouths.”

“And if Subodh returns?”

“He will not.”

“How do you—”

“Go.”

That day, for the first time, I understood that my mother-in-law was not pushing me toward the river. Perhaps she was trying to keep me away from it. But then another question rose: why had she said, “Water asks for what is due to it”? To frighten me? To warn me? Or was she herself a prisoner of the same old sentence?

By evening I had packed a bundle. There was not much: two saris, some papers, Aditya’s little woollen cap, and one note from Subodh—though it was not really a letter, only three lines written on the back of a fertiliser account.

“Malati,

I	will	be	late.
Eat		your	rice.
Bolt the door from inside.”			

For years I have kept those three lines as though they were a love letter.

That night my elder brother-in-law said, “You’re leaving tomorrow?”

“Yes.”

“All right. Tell your people you’ve gone for a few days. Don’t open up the affairs of this house over there.”

“Which affairs?”

He looked at me. “You understand.”

“No. Say it plainly.”

He grew angry. "Subodh's debts, his disappearance, old matters of the house—what is the need to carry all this from village to village?"

"And the water rite?"

At those words his face turned to stone. "All that is meaningless."

"Then 'Water honoured' in the book?"

"Old people wrote in old ways."

"Chandrakala?"

"I don't know."

"Mother?"

"Enough!"

His hand came down on the wooden cot so hard that the lamp trembled. The flame stretched once, then shrank. On the wall my shadow merged with his. For a moment I could not see the boundary of my own body.

That night the river spoke my name again.

This time not only "Malati."

"Malati, now."

I did not open the window. I pressed my palms over my ears. The voice did not stop. At times it came from the well, at times from the drain, at times from inside the water pot. I got up and overturned the pot. Water spread across the floor. A thin stream crept along the base of the wall toward the door. It seemed to me that it was showing me the way.

I lit the lamp.

In the light, water was only water.

I put out the lamp.

In the dark, the water became a path again.

I sat with the lamp burning all night.

Before I lifted my bundle at dawn, my mother-in-law came into the room. She carried the same book.

"Take this," she said.

"Why?"

"If it stays here, someone will write again."

"Write what?"

She opened the book and showed me Chandrakala's line. "Whatever proves convenient."

For the first time I saw not fear in her eyes, but shame.

"Chandrakala did not drown?"

My mother-in-law said, "I don't know."

"Did you hear otherwise?"

"I heard from my own mother-in-law that Chandrakala was put on a bullock cart at night and sent across the river. She never came back. In the book they wrote: 'Water honoured.' The household was saved."

"How was the household saved?"

She laughed—a laugh with no joy in it. "When a man's honour was saved, they called it saving the household."

"And in your time?"

Again she fell silent.

I took her hand. It was cold as ice.

"What were you told?"

“Your father-in-law lived with another woman for three months. They blamed me for failing to hold my husband’s heart. One night my mother-in-law took me to the river.”

My fingers tightened around her palm.

“Then?”

“She took me to the water’s edge. She said, ‘Take one step forward, and the impurity of the household will wash away.’ I did not step forward.”

“Then?”

“She herself began to cry. She said, ‘The same was said to me.’ We both came back. The next day your father-in-law returned. The matter was buried. Nothing was written in the book.”

“Then why did you tell me, ‘Water asks for what is due to it’?”

At the question she withdrew her hand from mine.

After a long while she whispered, “Because the sentence I had grown up hearing came out of my own mouth in a moment of crisis. I did not even think.”

I should have felt relief at that answer. I did not.

Because then I understood: if there is a curse, it needs no ghost. A sentence is enough, if generation after generation it is placed in a woman’s ear at the proper moment.

I did not take the book.

“You keep it.”

“No.”

“If I take it to my mother’s home, people will ask questions.”

“Then have it digitised.”

The word sounded strange in my mother-in-law’s mouth. Perhaps Subodh had once used it; perhaps someone who copied panjis had come to the village. I do not know.

“And if someone wants to write ‘Water honoured’ again?” I asked.

My mother-in-law ran a finger along the blank margin of the book. “Then write my name first.”

I did not understand. Perhaps I did.

When I left the house, there was mist at dawn. The bus stand was across the river bridge. My elder brother-in-law said he would take me there. I refused. The bundle was not heavy. In the end my mother-in-law forced the book into it.

“I’ll send it back,” I said.

“Read it first.”

I set out.

Once the last house of the village fell behind me, the river’s voice became clear.

“Malati.”

I did not stop.

Before the bridge a footpath turns toward the ghat. Whether my feet turned there of their own accord or I knowingly turned them, I still cannot say. There was half an hour before the bus. I thought: I will look at the river once. Only look.

The ghat was deserted. Mist hung low over the water. The bank was soft. There were two or three old footprints. One pair of small feet went toward the river; there were no prints returning. I stood looking at them.

Whose feet were these?

Perhaps a woman who had bathed at dawn and gone back by another path. Perhaps a child's. Perhaps yesterday's. Perhaps made by my own eyes.

The river said, "Now."

I tried to see my face in the water. In the mist and movement, the face kept breaking apart. For one moment I thought it was not I in the water, but Chandrakala. The next moment, my mother-in-law. The third, a woman whose face had been scratched out of a photograph.

I took one step forward.

The mud swallowed my feet to the ankles.

Cold water touched them.

And at that very moment the book shifted inside the bundle with a heavy thud of paper. I remembered: there was still space in that book to write "Water honoured." If someone wished, the same could be written beside my name. Whether a body was found or not, whether there was evidence or not—a single sentence would decide the household's story.

I did not take the second step.

I turned back.

Then the river laughed very loudly.

I cannot say whether that is true. Perhaps the current struck a stone. Perhaps wind passed through the kans grass. Perhaps a truck climbed onto the bridge. But in my ears it was laughter. A woman's or a man's, old or a child's—I could not tell. Only laughter.

I climbed up from the ghat. My legs were trembling. I did not look back.

When I reached the bus stand, the bus had already arrived. The driver snapped, "Get in, we're getting late."

I climbed aboard.

I sat by the window. The bus moved onto the bridge. Below, half the river was hidden in mist. I held the bundle tightly in my lap. One corner of the book pressed through the cloth into my ribs.

At the middle of the bridge I saw it clearly—a woman standing at the ghat. She was wearing my sari. Her feet were in the water. Her face was hidden in the mist.

I closed my eyes. Opened them again. No one was there.

The bus descended on the far side.

At my mother's home, I slept heavily for three days. On the fourth I opened the book. I read Chandrakala's line again: "Water honoured." Beneath it was a blank space.

I picked up a pen. For a long time I wondered what to write. "Chandrakala left the house"? I had no proof. "Chandrakala survived"? No proof of that either. "Story disputed"? This book was not a court.

In the end I wrote no conclusion. Beside the blank space, in small letters, I wrote only:

"No body was found."

And beneath that:

“There was another story too.”

As soon as I had written that much, my hand began to tremble. I stopped the pen.

That night, for the first time in my mother's room, I lit a lamp. There was electricity, even so. The book lay before it. The light fell at an angle. The raised lines of the old ink cast shadows like writing on the wall.

For a long time that night, no voice of the river came. The river is far from here.

I thought: I have escaped.

Then the water inside the pot stirred.

There was no wind in the room.

I got up and went to the pot. The water was still. I saw my own face.

And just behind me, inside the water, another face.

I turned. The room was empty.

I looked back into the water. Only me.

Then a very soft voice came:

“Malati.”

I raised the lamp wick.

The light grew larger.

The voice fell silent.

But now I cannot say whether I returned from the river, or the river returned with me.

— End of Story 4 —

5. Outside Caste

STORY

My father's name is not in the Panji. Neither is my grandfather's. As for my great-grandfather, the question does not even arise.

I used to know this not as an insult but as a fact. Like the fact that there is a bamboo grove to the east of our house; that the pond fills during the rains; that in Agahan the scent of paddy reaches all the way to the far end of the village. The Panji was someone else's book. What did it have to do with us?

But one day the book came to our house. Then I understood: even those whose names are absent from a book may still live inside it—only not in the form in which they know themselves.

It was afternoon. The hard sun of Jeth. I was sitting on a mat in the courtyard, sorting makhana. Mother was inside cleaning the paddy bin. Babuji was resting on a low wooden cot, his back propped up. Then came the metallic ring of a bell from the road. Not a bicycle—a scooter.

In our village the sound of a scooter is ordinary now, but in those days anyone who arrived on one invariably had some business. The man got down and went first not to our door but to the large house opposite. About half an hour later, the younger master of that house brought him into our courtyard.

"He would like to ask you people a few things," the younger master said.

Babuji sat up. The man greeted us. He looked at me, then took a thick volume from his shoulder bag. It was wrapped in cloth.

My hands stopped of their own accord.

I had seen such a book before only from a distance—on the day of a wedding, at an upanayan ceremony, or in the house of a Panjekar. I had never had any reason to go near one.

The man said, "I am digitising old genealogical Panjis. While reading some pages from this village, I came to a place where I could go no further. I was told that your Babuji knows some old matters."

Babuji did not smile. The polite smile he sometimes gave strangers did not appear. He asked only, "Who told you?"

The man looked toward the younger master. The younger master lowered his eyes.

"My name is Neelabh," the man said. "I have not come to open a quarrel. I only want to understand an empty space."

An empty space. Those two words lodged inside me.

Babuji said slowly, “And what will you do once you understand the empty space?”

“Where the record is silent, I will write the reason for the silence.”

Babuji fell silent again.

Neelabh opened the book. The pages had yellowed. Their edges were crumbling. The ink was dark in some places, pale in others. He did not place a finger on the page; he stopped his hand beside it, as though the letters might flake away at a touch.

“A line has been struck out here,” he said. “Not merely struck out—written first, then scraped away. After that, something was added by another hand.”

Babuji’s face did not change. But Mother came out from inside. She had a broom in her hand. She stood half-hidden by the doorway.

Neelabh read what could still be read: “...Dharni... daughter... house...” Then the words vanished into abrasion.

Mother set the broom down.

For the first time I saw fear on Babuji’s face. Not anger, not shame—fear.

My great-grandmother’s name was Dharni. Very few people in the village knew that. At home I had heard stories of her as Barki Amma—only this much: that she was formidable; that the smell of cured leather gave her headaches; that she sang beautifully; and that once, during a flood, she had walked through waist-deep water and saved two children.

Her caste was ours. Not the caste of the people whose names belonged in the Panji.

I looked at Neelabh. Babuji would not look at him.

Mother spoke first. “Dharni was my grandmother-in-law.”

Babuji snapped, “Who asked you?”

Mother fell silent. But the words were already outside.

Neelabh asked gently, “Her connection with this house...?”

“With our house,” Babuji cut in. “Not with that one.”

Across from us, the younger master seemed to shrink a little.

That evening I asked Mother, “Why was Dharni’s name in that book?”

Mother had set dal on the stove. Whether it was smoke or the question that troubled her eyes, I could not tell. After a while she said, “Why shouldn’t it be?”

“None of our names are in it.”

“Having a name there and having that name acknowledged are not the same thing.”

I did not understand the sentence then. Mother returned to her work.

That night Babuji called me. “If that man comes again tomorrow, you are not to say anything.”

“Why?”

“Old matters have no value.”

“Then why were you afraid?”

Babuji looked at me as though I had crossed a boundary. Much later he said, “I am not afraid. I am tired.”

For the first time I understood that sometimes exhaustion, too, is inherited.

Neelabh did not come the next day. He came on the third. This time alone. Instead of the book, he carried a small printed enlargement of a scan. He remained standing outside the door.

"I will not come inside," he said. "Tell me only as much as you feel is right."

Babuji had gone to the fields. Mother looked at me. Whether there was permission in that look or caution, I do not know.

I took Neelabh to sit beside the bamboo grove. He opened the sheet. The scraped line had been enlarged. Here and there, traces beneath the ink were visible.

"Dharni," I read.

He said, "Yes. That much is clear."

Then a few letters: "du..." "na..." "house..."

"Dular?" I guessed.

"I will not write a guess," Neelabh said.

That one sentence made me trust him for the first time.

I asked Mother again. This time she did not evade me.

When Dharni was young, she worked in the house opposite. She plastered floors with dung, pounded paddy, washed utensils through the night at weddings. A young man of that house—Mother would not tell me his name—began speaking with her. How far the matter went is not something evidence can settle; village memory does not keep accounts by the rules of proof. But one night Dharni was put out through the back of that house. The next month she was hurriedly married into another hamlet.

"Then why was her name in the Panji?" I asked.

Mother said, "Because somebody wrote it."

"Who?"

"Whoever saw."

"And who erased it?"

Mother looked straight at me. "Whoever was afraid."

I understood: this story was not proof of love. It was proof of fear.

Word spread through the village that the Panji man was digging up an old disgrace. The word 'disgrace' made me laugh. When even the name of the man in the story had not survived, why should the disgrace rest only on Dharni's head?

One day two men were talking at the crossroads while I stood there waiting for tea. One said, "If such things are written down, what will remain of a lineage's honour?"

The other said, "Children these days will break families apart in the name of history."

I asked, "Is a house so weak that one erased line can split it?"

Both fell silent. One recognised me and his face changed. "I wasn't talking about your house."

"It is my house too," I said.

My voice did not tremble when I said it. After I came home, I trembled badly.

Babuji heard about it. That night he scolded me. "Do you think the lines of caste have been erased?"

I said, “If the line was so necessary, who wrote Dharni’s name in the Panji?”

Babuji rose from the cot. “You have learned to ask questions. You do not know the price of answers.”

“Who paid the price?”

He said nothing.

I asked again, “Dharni?”

That night Babuji gave me no answer. In the morning I found him sitting alone beside the bamboo grove. As soon as he saw me, he said, “My father used to say that for a long time Dharni stopped singing at night.”

That was all.

It was Babuji’s admission. In his language.

When Neelabh came for the fourth time, Babuji himself asked him to sit. This time the book was with him again.

“I want to put a note beneath this erased line,” Neelabh said. “Not a verdict. Only that local oral memory mentions a woman named Dharni, and the record appears to show that her name was erased.”

Babuji asked, “Will you write her caste?”

Neelabh said, “If the family wants it and the source is clear, yes. Otherwise, no.”

Babuji looked at me. For the first time the decision came toward me.

I said, “Write the caste. Otherwise people will again think the reason the name was erased was some mystery. It was not a mystery. It was a boundary.”

Mother added softly, “And write that Dharni had a home of her own. She was not only a story belonging to that house.”

The sentence rose inside me like the wick of a lamp.

For the first time, I thought of Dharni’s story outside that house.

She had a son—my grandfather. He made dholaks. He dried goatskin, carved wood, tightened rope. Dholaks made by his hands were played at kirtans in three villages. Dharni transplanted paddy in the fields, wove winnowing trays in winter, and when my grandfather fell ill she sat for seven days with his head in her lap.

Not one line of that was in the Panji.

The greatest event in my great-grandmother’s life was not that young man whose name no one now remembers clearly. Yet perhaps that relationship was the only reason she had entered the book at all.

This gave me a new anger. To keep someone outside is not only to erase a name; it is also to compress an entire life into the one moment in which that life was shamed.

I told Neelabh, “If you write Dharni’s story, write the dholak too.”

He did not smile. He remained serious. “The dholak?”

I told him my grandfather’s story. The winnowing trays, the paddy transplantation, the flood, the songs. Mother corrected me from time to time. Twice Babuji interrupted—“That is not how it happened”—and then supplied the right version himself.

Neelabh kept taking notes.

Afternoon declined into evening. The electricity went out. Mother brought an earthen lamp. Its light fell obliquely across the page. The raised traces of the scraped ink appeared again.

Neelabh said, "Sometimes erased letters cannot be seen in direct light. They appear in light falling from the side."

I said, "So do people."

He looked at me. Then said nothing.

A few months later Neelabh sent me a copy—a printout from the digital archive. Beneath that page was a note:

"In the original entry, the name 'Dharni' is clear; the remaining portion appears to have been deliberately erased. According to local family memory, Dharni belonged to a nearby marginalised community; independently of this entry, her life is preserved in oral histories of labour, craft and family. The nature of the relationship is uncertain."

I read it three times.

The first time my eye stopped at 'marginalised community.' The second, at 'independently.' The third, at 'uncertain.'

I liked that he had not proven a love story. I liked that he had not written 'disgrace' either. We did not need a new story manufactured in the name of evidence; we needed the acknowledgement that the old book's silence had not been neutral.

One day the younger master from the house opposite came over. He carried a copy of the same printout.

"Will this be public?" he asked.

"Yes," I said.

He remained silent for a long time. Then he said, "My father knew about this. He never told me."

"My Babuji also knew half of it, and kept the other half unsaid."

He folded the paper, then opened it again. "I am ashamed."

I became angry all at once. "Shame is your private feeling. It is not compensation for Dharni's life."

He fell silent.

My voice had been harsh. Later I thought that perhaps I should have been gentler in that moment. Then I thought: why must those who have always been kept outside also tend to the remorse of others?

I did not apologise.

A year later, the village school held a small exhibition on local history. There were some pages from Neelabh's digitisation project, old photographs, farming tools, written lines from songs. The note on Dharni was there too.

I watched the children looking at the page. A girl asked, "Why was this name erased?"

The teacher said, "The rules of caste were very strict in society then."

I was standing at the back. I wanted to say: be careful with the word 'then.' A boundary does not break in a single day of time. But I remained silent. The girl asked again, "If they erased it, did the name disappear?"

The teacher searched for an answer.

I stepped forward and said, "On paper, to a great extent."

The girl asked, "And in real life?"

I said, “In real life, only as far as people stopped remembering.”

Babuji is no longer alive. When he died, many people from the village came. So did the younger master from the house opposite. After the shraddha, I opened an old chest. Inside were clothes, papers, a half-broken beater from my grandfather’s dholak, and one sheet written in Babuji’s hand.

There was no genealogy on that page. Only names—Dharni, Sukhiya, Ramotar, Kamli, Jagesar... Some I knew, some I did not. At the top Babuji had written: “Our people.”

No caste. No father or husband beside anyone. Only names.

I sat for a long time holding that sheet. Whether it contained the whole of Babuji’s remorse or merely his habit of making lists, I do not know. I cannot ask him now.

I did not give the page to Neelabh. Not everything has to become an archive. Some things have the right to remain at home.

But I did one thing.

I copied all the names from that page into a separate notebook. About those Mother knew, I asked Mother. About those Kaki knew, I asked Kaki. Beside some names only one sentence could be written: “Laughed a great deal.” “Built boats.” “Went toward Nepal to earn.” “Saved three children.” “Remembered the first line of a song.”

I did not call this notebook a ‘Panji.’

If I called it a Panji, rules would arise again—who belongs inside, who remains outside.

I called it “People.”

Now, when evening comes, I sometimes light a lamp. Even when there is electricity. Mother laughs: “This old-fashioned habit of yours.”

I place the lamp beside that notebook. The light does not fall straight; it falls from the side. The shadows of the inked letters grow large.

Dharni’s name too.

Her name is still not complete in the Panji. Perhaps it never will be. But in my notebook, after her name, there is not only the event for which she was erased. It says:

“Dharni — wove winnowing trays. Saved two children in a flood. Sang songs. For a time she stopped singing. Then, many years later, she began to sing again.”

Mother added the last sentence.

I had asked, “Are you certain you remember that?”

Mother said, “Not I. My mother-in-law used to say it.”

I wrote: “Oral memory.”

I learned that much caution from Neelabh.

Sometimes I think the real thief in Story 1 was not any single person. Not the one who wrote the book, not the one who scraped the line, not that house, not this one. The thief was the system that had divided, from birth, the right to have one’s name written down. But even as I write this, I remain careful: calling it a ‘system’ does not absolve the hand of the individual. No abstract thing made the abrasion; someone’s hand did.

I do not know the name of that hand.

And perhaps knowing it is not even necessary.

What matters is that now, when someone looks at that page, they will not take the empty space for emptiness.

They will know: someone was here.

Someone who had a home of her own. Her own people. Her own songs.

And whose name can be seen again in light falling from the side.

— *End of Story 5* —

6. The Reckoning of the Bed

STORY

My clearest memory of the first night of my marriage is not the groom's face but the width of the bed.

The bed was old teak. All four legs were so thick it seemed half the family's history rested upon them. But the sleeping space? Whether it had been made for two people or one and a half—that question arose on the very first night. Mohan was already asleep, spread comfortably across it. I, the new bride, sat there guarding my elbows more carefully than my veil.

Without opening his eyes, Mohan said, "Move over a little."

I thought: the first command of marriage. And a command that explained the whole map of the house. I moved. Toward the wall. Then moved again. Toward the bed's rope edge. In the end I had reached so far to one side that a single turn in sleep might have made a widow of the new bride.

In the morning my mother-in-law asked, "Did you sleep well?"

I said, "Half."

She thought it was the shyness of a new bride and laughed. That was when I understood: in this house, even an answer would not be heard in full.

My name is Sonmati. Mother used to say, "There is gold in your name; what lies in your fate you will discover when you reach your husband's home." Within my first week there I understood: what lay in my fate was an accounting of space. And accounting for space is harder than accounting for money, because money can be counted; sleeping space is measured in palms, elbows, knees and snores.

Mohan was a good man. Let me say that at the outset, or people may read what follows and turn him into a villain. His only fault was that he regarded a bed as a natural thing—like earth, sky or air—in which his share had somehow formed by itself at the centre.

My fault was that I learned the arithmetic too quickly.

Two months after the wedding, my younger brother-in-law had examinations. On the pretext of studying through the night, he carried away the lantern from our room. Mohan said, "It is hot tonight. We'll sleep in the courtyard." There were three cots there: Babuji on one, my brother-in-law on another, and Mohan and I on the third. At midnight a guest arrived. My mother-in-law called out, "Sonmati, move over a little; we have to make room for the guest."

I counted silently—first the husband, then the wall, now the guest. In this family, a new bride was perhaps some category between movable and immovable property. Shift her wherever there is an empty patch.

I left the cot and slept on a mat. By morning my back was so stiff that while rolling out puris I could hear the protests of my own body. My mother-in-law said, “You are young. Nothing will happen.”

I asked, “What happens when one is old?”

She laughed again. “By then you will have a bed of your own.”

I kept that sentence in my mind. “A bed of your own.” That day I understood for the first time that, in a household, respect sometimes arrives in the form of a cot or a bedstead.

Our first child was born—Bittu. He was so small I thought he could fit inside my palms. But the moment night fell, the area occupied by his body expanded miraculously. He slept in the middle, arms stretched east and west. Mohan on one side, I on the other.

Mohan said, “Why is this child in the middle?”

I said, “Whoever rules the night with crying gets the kingdom.”

“I cannot sleep.”

“And I can?”

Mohan fell silent for the first time. It was my first victory in married life, though the prize for winning was staying awake at three in the morning to feed the baby.

After Bittu came Munni. Now there were four living beings on the bed. One night I joked, “We ought to make a Panji for this bed—to record who has occupied how much of it since which date.”

Mohan said, “You want an account of everything.”

I replied, “The one whose share keeps shrinking is bound to keep accounts.”

So I really did begin keeping one, on the back pages of an old ledger for paddy and rice. At the top I wrote: “The Reckoning of the Bed.” First entry: “First year of marriage—about one and a half cubits.” Second: “After Bittu’s birth—one cubit and two fingers.” Third: “After Munni’s birth—sleeping with elbows folded.”

The ledger became my private amusement. Household work all day; politics of sleeping space at night. Sometimes I wrote: “Mohan’s snoring: an extra half-cubit.” Sometimes: “Bittu’s kicking: border dispute.” Sometimes: “Munni wet the bed: entire territory evacuated.”

That year the rains were heavy. When the river rose, two families from the lower hamlet stayed in our house for three nights. Bedding spread through the veranda, the dalan, even the space above the cattle shed. At night, after putting Munni to sleep on our bed, I saw Phulo Kaki lying on the floor near the door with her two children.

Without anyone asking me, I gave her the bed. Mohan asked, “You’re on the mat again?”

I said, “This time I will not enter it as a loss in the ledger.”

“Why?”

“Because this time no one made me move.”

Mohan perhaps did not fully understand, but he came and lay beside me on the mat. At midnight, when his snoring began, I thought of reaching for the ledger, then remembered I had left it by the bed. I quietly pushed his elbow away. Even voluntary generosity has boundaries.

Once Mohan found the ledger. He laughed so hard while reading it that my mother-in-law came running. "What happened?"

Hiding the ledger, Mohan said, "Nothing. Sonmati is measuring the land of the house."

I said, "Not land. A kingdom."

My mother-in-law gave me a look that was half rebuke, half laughter. That night she came quietly to me and said, "When I married, there wasn't even a cot. I slept on straw for six years."

I asked, "When did you finally get a bed of your own?"

She thought for a while. "When your father-in-law went to the city to earn."

I laughed. "So the bed came, and the man went."

She laughed too, but her laughter ended quickly. That night I understood for the first time that a woman's reckoning of the bed is not only an accounting of width. It is also an accounting of absence.

Years passed. Bittu went to school. Munni followed. My younger brother-in-law married. A new bride came into the house—Reena. On her first night, I nearly repeated the old mistake. I said, "Reena, there are many guests; the bed in your room—" Then I stopped halfway through the sentence.

Reena looked at my face. I said, "No. The guests will sleep in the veranda. A newly married couple's bed is not public property."

My mother-in-law heard from a distance. She said nothing. Only in the morning, while handing me a bowl of tea, she asked softly, "Will you write this in your ledger too?"

After Reena came, my own earlier days returned to me again and again. If she lay down on the bed in the afternoon from exhaustion, someone would say, "The new bride is sleeping in the daytime." The old sentence would rise to the tip of my tongue—"You are young, nothing will happen." But I swallowed it.

One day Reena was doubled over with stomach pain. There was a puja in the house. The aunties decided she should stay apart, on a mat in a separate room. I heard and said, "Let her stay apart—but why on a mat? The bed is empty."

Someone whispered, "It is the custom."

I asked, "Does the rope of the bed become impure by custom too, or only a woman's back?"

My mother-in-law looked at me as though to scold me, then turned her eyes away. Reena slept on the bed. That night she said softly, "Didi, you speak a great deal."

I said, "I did not speak before. So now everything that was left unsaid comes out at once."

I wrote: "Reena's first night—whole bed. First evidence of reform in the family."

When Munni became a teenager, a new problem began. A separate small cot was bought from the market for Bittu—"He studies and stays awake late at night." Munni asked, "Do I not study?" The answer in the house was not logic but tradition: "Daughters sleep beside their mothers."

Munni looked at me. In that look I saw my own first night as a bride—the body shifting toward the wall.

For the first time I spent some of the money I had saved from sewing and had a simple bamboo cot made. I put it in Munni's room.

Mohan said, "Why was there any need to spend so much?"

I said, "A bed is necessary for Bittu's studies, but the floor is enough for Munni's studies—this is mathematics I do not understand."

That night Munni sprawled so widely across her cot that by morning the sheet was on the floor. I wrote in the ledger: "Daughter's first independent bed—sense of boundaries: zero; joy: complete."

Mohan read it and said, "One day this ledger of yours will be produced in court."

I said, "Before it reaches court, read it at home."

When Bittu turned ten, I started sewing for money. First blouses for two households in the village, then uniforms for schoolchildren, and gradually the work increased. The earnings were not much, but they were mine. For the first time the ledger began to contain accounts of money instead of sleeping space. In three years I had saved enough to buy a new cot from the market.

When the cot arrived, the men of the house held what amounted to a council. Babuji said, "This will stay in the veranda; good for guests." My brother-in-law said, "Also useful for sitting in the afternoon." Mohan pressed the rope with his hand. "Strong."

I took out the bill and placed it before Babuji. "Read the name on this."

The bill said: "Sonmati Devi."

Babuji put on his spectacles. "So?"

"So this bed is mine at night. During the day everyone may sit on it. Guests may sit on it too. But at night no one sleeps on it without asking me."

The house went completely quiet. My own voice sounded a little too loud to me. Then my mother-in-law called from inside, "She is right. She earned it; the bed is hers."

With the bed came a new difficulty—everyone liked it too much. In the afternoon my brother-in-law lay on it with the newspaper. In the evening Bittu sat there with his books. Munni brought a friend. On Sundays Mohan lay on his stomach listening to the radio. All day, my "own" possession turned into a public square.

I made a rule: "After nine at night, the bed must be empty."

Bittu asked, "Why?"

I said, "The one who pays the tax has the right."

Mohan corrected me. "Not tax. Price."

I said, "I have paid the tax of my sewing—eyes, back, fingers, all of it."

After that no one argued. At nine, my bed really did begin to be found empty. It was perhaps the first timetable in the history of the household that had never been written down but was actually enforced.

That day, more than the bed, I received one sentence from my mother-in-law. I wrote in the ledger: "Year fifteen—bought a whole bed. Witness: Mother-in-law."

But life does not respect accounts. Six months after I bought the bed, Babuji fell ill. The air in the veranda suited him. My new cot was moved there. I returned to the old bed. Mohan smiled and said, "Lost your kingdom?"

I said, "Lent it out."

Babuji slept on it for three months. During those three months I did not enter a single loss in the ledger. For the first time the reason was clear to me: the space had not been taken from me; I had given it. The difference looks so small, but the body understands it at once.

Babuji recovered. The bed came back to my room. That night I slept in the exact middle. Mohan stood at the side laughing. "Where do I go?"

After Babuji's illness, my mother-in-law spoke to me alone one day. "Did it hurt you to give up the bed?"

I said, "Not to give it. It would have hurt if it had been taken without asking."

She was silent. Much later she said, "No one in my life ever asked me that question—whether I wanted to give or not."

All the jokes in my ledger suddenly felt not light but heavy. Behind every "move over a little" I had written, how many women must have moved without anyone asking them? No ledger contained that count.

Even so, I did not close the ledger. It would have been another injustice to make every heavy thing entirely solemn. That evening I wrote: "Mother-in-law: question received late. Answer still remains."

I closed my eyes and said, "Move over a little."

Mohan laughed so much that in the end he had to make room for me too.

The children grew up. Bittu went to Patna to study; Munni married and moved to another city. The beds in the house suddenly grew large. In the same rooms where once we had slept with elbows folded, now one could stretch out both arms without touching anyone.

Pain began in Mohan's knees. At night he groaned when turning over. I placed bricks under my new cot to raise it, so that it would be easier for him to sit and stand. He would say, "Your bed is saving me in my old age."

I would say, "I'll add interest to the ledger."

I did not actually add the interest. In old age, husband and wife say many things in the language of jokes, because said directly the words become too heavy. "Take your medicine" means: "Stay." "Pull the blanket over yourself" means: "I care more about you than about the cold." "Move over" sometimes means: "I am still here."

My mother-in-law had died many years before. Her old cot remained in the shed. One day, while cleaning it, I found a small knot of cloth caught among the ropes. Inside were three coins and a scrap of paper. In her handwriting were the words: "For a bed of my own."

I sat there for a long time. She had never managed to buy one. Whether the bed she finally slept on had come from my father-in-law's earnings or

from household money, I do not know. But the moment I saw those three coins I understood: she too had kept accounts. She simply had no ledger.

I pasted the three coins between the pages of my ledger. Beneath them I wrote: "Mother-in-law's unfinished account."

Mohan read the page. For a long time he said nothing. Then he said, "Mother never told me this."

I said, "Mothers do not tell their sons everything. Some things the bed knows."

Mohan kept looking at my face. That night, for the first time, he said on his own, "You sleep in the middle. I am fine at the side."

I laughed. "Reform after so many years?"

He said, "Does a student who passes late get no certificate?"

I wrote in the ledger: "Year thirty-two—Mohan moved aside voluntarily. Verification required."

Two years later Mohan died. Not suddenly. Six months of illness, medicines, tests, hospital, home, hospital again. In the final month, the bed was almost entirely his. I had a small stool beside it. At night I sometimes fell asleep there with my head resting on it.

One night he was struggling to breathe. He opened his eyes and said very softly, "Sonmati..."

I bent toward him.

"Move over... a little."

I burst out laughing. Whether it was right to laugh at such a time, I still do not know. But Mohan laughed too—a weak, broken laugh. I moved the stool closer to the bed and held his hand.

That was his last complete sentence.

After Mohan died, the house filled with people. Son, daughter, grandchildren, relatives, neighbours. The bed became public again—someone sitting, someone weeping, someone silent. I did not mind. In grief, the private boundaries of the body change of their own accord.

The first night after everyone had gone, I slept alone on that bed. The whole bed was mine. Space in the middle. Space on the right. Space on the left. More space than I had asked for all my life.

I could not sleep.

I took out the ledger. I held the pen for a long time. At last I wrote: "Year thirty-four—whole bed. Account does not balance."

Then I closed the page.

Time went on. Bittu now works in Bengaluru. Munni sends her daughter Ananya to stay with me during the holidays. Ananya found my ledger. Her Maithili reading is slow, but her curiosity is quick.

She asked, "Nani, what is this 'Reckoning of the Bed'?"

I said, "My ledger of property."

She looked around the house—the old cupboard, the sewing machine, the brass lota. "How much property?"

I patted the bed. "Mostly this."

She burst out laughing. That night she climbed onto my bed while looking at her phone. Within five minutes she had spread herself right across

the middle—one hand toward my head, one foot toward the side where Mohan used to sleep.

I watched her. By old habit the measurement happened in my mind—my share had shrunk again.

In her sleep Ananya said, “Nani, move over a little.”

I moved gently.

Then I stopped abruptly. The yellow light of the lamp fell across the table. The ledger lay open. Its last page was blank. I got up and took the pen.

I wrote: “Year sixty-five—Ananya in the middle. I am on the left. Moved over of my own will.”

After writing that, I looked at the line for a long time. All my life, protecting space and giving space had looked almost the same. They were not. It had taken me nearly fifty years to understand the difference.

Ananya turned over again and pulled half the blanket with her.

I added another line to the ledger: “Blanket dispute still ongoing.”

Then I put out the lamp.

— End of Story 6 —

7. The Second Marriage

STORY

News of Padma's second marriage reached the village before it reached Padma.

Badki Kaki was the first to say that five years was a long time: after all, how many days could a woman go on lighting a lamp beside a photograph? Chhotki Kaki said five years was not such a long time, especially when the daughter was still only twelve. The aunt from next door said that precisely because the girl was twelve, it would be better to arrange the marriage now; once she turned fifteen, it would become difficult. Not one aunt explained for whom it would become difficult.

At the time Padma was sitting in the courtyard, sorting lentils. She set aside three spoiled grains, threw away two pebbles, then shook the sieve. Each of the aunts took her silence as agreement with her own position.

Her mother-in-law, Bhavani Devi, said she regarded Padma as a daughter, but that it was a sin to keep a daughter bound to the house. In the same breath she added that her granddaughter Trisha was the last sign of this family line and ought not to be taken anywhere else. Everyone present untied the knot between those two sentences in whatever way suited them.

Padma's mother said that if a widowed daughter returned to her mother's house, people blamed the mother; if she stayed with her husband's family, they blamed the in-laws; if she remarried, they blamed her for betraying the memory of her first husband; if she did not, they blamed her for wasting her own life. So one ought to stop keeping accounts of other people's blame. But her very next sentence was that if there was to be a marriage, it should be within their own caste, in their own region, and into a good household.

Padma's brother Pramod said the property papers should be made clear first. In his view, feelings could come later; mutation and title records came first. To discuss marriage before his sister's share had been entered on paper, he said, would be foolish. People in the village called his caution concern for his sister; two agnates from her husband's family called it an eye on the land.

Padma was then sewing the blue edging onto a school uniform. The wheel of the machine turned with an even rhythm. Pramod asked three times whether she was listening. Padma rethreaded the needle. Pramod went outside and told people that his sister had a very strong mind.

The story of her strong mind spread through the whole neighbourhood that week. Someone said Padma had always been hard like that. Someone said sorrow turns a person to stone. Someone said that because she earned money by sewing, she would make her own decision. Everyone spoke of "her own decision," but no one placed the question of the decision before her.

The proposal came from Chandrakant. He was an assistant in a library in the neighbouring block; his wife had died four years earlier. He had a ten-year-old son, Nachiketa. Chandrakant's sister Nirmala brought the proposal.

She said her brother was a straightforward man, did not drink, received his salary on time, and his son needed a mother.

Padma's mother looked toward Trisha. Trisha was folding the corner of a page in her book. Nirmala immediately added that Trisha too would be kept in the house like a daughter.

Badki Kaki said "like a daughter" was a very fine phrase. Chhotki Kaki said softly that the distance between a daughter and someone kept like a daughter becomes clear only after marriage. Whether Nirmala heard her or not, no one could be certain.

Padma made tea. She served Bhavani Devi first, then her mother, then Nirmala. She filled her own cup last. Looking at Padma's hands, Nirmala said they were working hands; a woman like this would manage a household well. Padma wiped with a cloth the tea that had spilled over the rim of the cup.

On returning home, Nirmala told her family that Padma was quiet. Chandrakant asked whether quiet meant consenting. Nirmala replied that in matters like these, what could a woman say openly? The people of the house understood. Chandrakant may have remained silent for some time; this information came later through Nirmala, so no one knew exactly how long that silence lasted.

Two days later Chandrakant came himself. His maternal uncle accompanied him. The uncle said that in a second marriage there was no need for elaborate rituals; simplicity was best. Bhavani Devi said she had no objection to a simple ceremony, but Trisha's schooling must not be interrupted. The uncle said there was a school there too. Pramod replied that "there is a school" and "the same education will continue" were not the same statement.

During this exchange Chandrakant looked toward Padma two or three times. He said that if Trisha wished, she could continue at her old school until the examinations. Nirmala immediately added that commuting such a distance every day would not be practical; after marriage, arrangements naturally changed.

Trisha raised her head for the first time. She asked whose marriage it was going to be—her mother's, or her school's. People laughed. Someone said the child was clever. Someone said children asked too many questions these days. No one answered her.

Padma pulled Trisha's notebook toward herself and straightened the folded corner of the page. Trisha looked at her mother and then fell silent.

Chandrakant's uncle said one thing ought to be made clear at the outset: Chandrakant would make no claim on the land belonging to Padma's first husband's family. Pramod said that making no claim was not an act of generosity; the legal position was a separate question. Bhavani Devi, alarmed, asked why land had to enter a discussion about marriage. From outside, the agnate Ramsevak called out that if the land was not discussed now, it would certainly be discussed later.

For half an hour that day, the marriage discussion was about relationships and affection; for the next hour and a half, it was about account numbers and plot records. Padma got up in the middle and went

inside. The aunts later said she must have left out of shyness. Trisha said her mother had a customer's blouse to deliver at four o'clock.

In the evening Bhavani Devi went into Padma's room. When she came out, she said the daughter-in-law was saying nothing, but one could tell from her eyes that she was worried about Trisha. Padma's mother went in and came out saying her daughter was sad at the thought of leaving her home. Pramod went in and came out saying she had not disliked the discussion about the papers. All three had met the same Padma. All three emerged carrying different answers.

That night Padma trimmed the lamp-wick shorter. Her first husband's photograph stood above the cupboard. For five years a lamp had burned beside it every evening—but whether Padma lit the lamp for the photograph or simply because that was a convenient place to keep it was another question everyone had answered in their own way. Some called it fidelity, some grief, some habit. Padma had never said why she lit the lamp.

The following week Chandrakant came again, this time alone. The door was open. Bhavani Devi had gone to a neighbour's house; Trisha was at school. Padma was cutting cloth in the veranda. Chandrakant sat on a chair outside. Later he told his sister that he had not managed to speak much with Padma. Nirmala asked whether he had at least asked for her consent. He said the atmosphere had not been right. Nirmala told him that an atmosphere did not create itself; one had to create it.

Chandrakant also said that the question of Padma leaving the house was difficult, because Bhavani Devi would be left alone. Nirmala replied that in marriage a woman went to her husband's house; there was nothing difficult about that, it was normal. Chandrakant said that in a second marriage the word "normal" ought to be used with care.

How accurately that sentence reached Padma was uncertain. In the village, sentences too change from house to house like marriage proposals. By the time it reached her, it had become: Chandrakant is very modern.

As evidence of his modernity, people said he would not make Padma give up her sewing work. Nirmala added only that in the new house the coming and going of customers would have to remain within proper bounds. Padma's mother said why should an earning daughter give up her work? One aunt said that if the husband earned, why should a woman have to run around so much? Pramod said giving up financial independence would be foolish.

Padma oiled the sewing machine. It began to turn more smoothly than before.

One night Trisha asked her grandmother whether, if her mother married again, her father would change. Her grandmother said dead people do not change; new relationships are added to life. Trisha asked why an old home had to be left in order to add a new relationship. Her grandmother said that was the custom of the world. Trisha asked which people made customs. Her grandmother ordered her to go to sleep.

After that question, Padma's mother concluded that Trisha was against the marriage. Bhavani Devi thought the child felt insecure. Pramod thought the new family would never accept Trisha completely. Word reached

Nirmala that the girl was stubborn. Chandrakant said that asking questions and being stubborn were two different things.

Padma went on oiling Trisha's hair. After a while Trisha wrapped her arms around her mother. The next day, the people of the house again gave that embrace different meanings.

For a month the discussion continued. Not a wedding date—the possibility of a wedding. Meanwhile Padma's sewing work expanded. Piprahi School gave her an order for fifty pairs of uniforms. Two new machines appeared in the veranda, along with two young women to work with her. The aunts said such expansion before a marriage was not proper; it would be difficult to wind it up later. Pramod said precisely because of this work it would now be even harder for his sister to leave the house.

One day Bhavani Devi said that if Padma left, the machines could be kept in the storeroom; if necessary, they could even be rented out. Trisha heard her. She said the machines had not come there to live in a storeroom. Bhavani Devi grew annoyed at the child's reply, but that evening she herself wiped the dust from the machines.

At last Chandrakant's family asked for a formal meeting. Everything, they said, should be made clear once and for all. Sunday was fixed. A low wooden platform was spread in the veranda, plastic chairs were brought in, and extra milk was ordered for the tea. The marriage that was supposed to be conducted simply began, in conversation, to resemble a village council.

Nirmala said they wanted no dowry from Padma. The aunts praised this generosity. Pramod asked that it also be stated clearly that there would be no expectation regarding Padma's own earnings, her machines, or the money in her bank account. The uncle became offended and said a relationship could not begin with such distrust. Pramod replied that a good relationship could not begin with ambiguity either.

Bhavani Devi raised the subject of Trisha. Nirmala said the child would go with Padma; what question was there? The uncle added that when she grew up, responsibility for her marriage would also fall on her biological maternal uncle's side. Pramod straightened in his chair. Padma's mother intervened. Trisha stood behind the door.

After a long silence Chandrakant said that responsibility for Trisha would be shared; marriage was not a process for dividing a child. His uncle signalled him to be quiet. Nirmala changed the subject.

Then came the question of the house. Everyone had been assuming that Padma would move to Chandrakant's town. As for what would happen to the sewing centre in Padma's veranda, Nirmala said that if necessary the machines could be sold; one machine could be kept at the new place. Pramod said that work built over five years should not be reduced to "one machine." Padma's mother said that wherever a woman lived, she could begin her work again there. Bhavani Devi remained silent.

Trisha came out from behind the door. She asked where Dadi would live. Bhavani Devi quickly said she would live in this house. Trisha asked again: alone? No one answered.

Chandrakant looked at Padma. For the first time everyone seemed to realise that the woman whose life was being discussed had not spoken once during the entire meeting.

The uncle said it was natural for her to be silent out of shyness. Nirmala said times had changed; if Padma wished, she could say what she thought. Her mother moved closer and said her daughter should say whatever she felt was right. Pramod added: without pressure. Bhavani Devi said she placed no compulsion on her daughter-in-law. The aunts suddenly fell silent, as though at last the right to silence too were being handed over to Padma.

Padma stood up and went inside. Everyone looked at everyone else. The uncle checked his watch. Nirmala whispered that perhaps Padma had gone in to cry. Her mother thought of following, but Bhavani Devi stopped her and said she should be left alone now.

Padma returned five minutes later. In her hands she carried neither bedding, nor jewellery, nor the photograph of her first husband, but the thick ledger of her sewing work. Inside it were the accounts for school uniforms, the wages of the two young women, bank deposit slips, customers' measurements, and the work scheduled for the next three months. She placed the ledger on the platform. Then she laid Trisha's school-fee receipt on top of it. Bhavani Devi's prescription became the third paper in the stack.

Pramod said the meaning of all this was clear: his sister had financial responsibilities here. Nirmala said those responsibilities could be fulfilled from the new house as well. The uncle said marriage required accepting some changes. Padma's mother said a daughter leaves her comforts behind and begins a new life; women had always done so. Trisha opened her mouth to speak, but Padma took her hand and stopped her.

Chandrakant asked softly what Padma wanted. It was the first question in which Padma herself was the subject of the sentence.

The yellow light of the lamp was visible even in the remaining daylight in the veranda. Padma looked once at Bhavani Devi, once at Trisha, and then at Chandrakant. Five years of interpretations—grief, fidelity, hardness, shyness, consent, dissent—seemed to fall away from her face.

Then, for the first time in the story of her own marriage, Padma herself spoke: "I will marry. But I will not leave this house. If Chandrakant wishes, he may come here."

— End of Story 7 —

8. The Metre of a Ghazal

STORY

1. The Court

Nasima Bi was no more than sixteen when she first sat down to sing before Ustad Karim Bakhsh. The room was not large, but its ceiling was very high. Two bats hung upside down in the darkness above, while below a lamp with yellow glass burned. The Ustad told her that singing a ghazal was not only a matter of keeping the voice true; one also had to hear where the line was returning. Nasima already knew the meaning of the word *radeef*, but not its weight.

The Ustad repeated the same closing phrase again and again. The first time it sounded like a command, the second like a complaint, the third like laughter, the fourth as though someone had gone far away and a name was being called after them. The Ustad asked, “The words remained the same, did they not?” Nasima said, “They did.” “And the meaning?” She remained silent. The Ustad smiled. “A ghazal begins in that silence.”

That night, at her first *mehfil*, Nasima came out from behind the curtain. Before her lay a low platform with silk cushions, a *paan* box, perfume, a purse of money, and five pairs of eyes. Her throat trembled at the very first *alaap*. The first beat of the *tabla* steadied her. When the recurring phrase returned at the end of the second line, a soft “Wah” rose from the gathering. Nasima understood that the listeners were hearing the ending, while she herself was hearing the road by which she had reached it.

After the *mehfil*, a wealthy *babu* remarked that the girl’s voice was still raw, but raw mango had more flavour. Outside, the Ustad told her that learning to smile at comparisons like that was also part of the profession. Nasima was angry within. For the first time she understood that *bahr*—the measure—existed not only in a ghazal but in the life of the *kotha* as well: how far to go, where to stop, whose words to answer, and to whom one should offer only a smile.

The next morning the Ustad pointed out only one mistake from the *mehfil*: the moment she heard “Wah,” she had seized the next line too quickly. He told her, “The listener will push you, but do not put the rhythm into his hands.” Nasima wrote the sentence on the first page of her notebook. Much later she understood that it had been advice for singing and for life alike. Those who praise you do not always know the road; those who condemn you do not possess the measure either. Without one’s own inner counting, an artist can lose herself in another person’s applause.

That night in her small room she carefully straightened the lamp-wick. The Ustad’s sentence returned to her: the ending may remain the same while its meaning changes. For the first time Nasima wanted to find some *radeef* for this life of hers, but no word came. The metre was not yet complete.

2. Transactions

Within five years Nasima Bi's name had reached the houses of the city's wealthy. Invitations now came on red paper. Her fee was agreed beforehand, but after a mehfil someone would say there had been fewer guests that night, someone would promise to add the balance next time, someone would offer bangles instead of money. Nasima gradually understood that people who knew the value of music did not necessarily know the value of an artist's labour.

She began keeping a ledger: date, house, time, composition sung, the accompanists' shares, carriage fare, money received—everything. The Ustad laughed that if an artist kept accounts, where would feeling remain? Nasima replied that feeling came out even better on a full stomach. The Ustad laughed again, but from the following week he too began checking his share in Nasima's ledger.

At one mehfil the mistress of the house asked Nasima to sing again the same popular ghazal she had sung the previous time. Nasima sang it. People smiled at the first line, nodded at the second, and when the radeef arrived there was a "Wah." But that night the meaning had changed inside Nasima. A line that on the previous occasion had sounded like the waiting of love now sounded like unpaid fees. She began laughing at herself while she sang. The listeners took it for artistry.

Gradually, before each performance Nasima began making three things clear: the time, the fee, and her right to choose the songs. Invitations from some houses stopped. Some people said she had become arrogant. An elderly listener quietly observed that earlier people bought her voice; now they had to listen to her conditions, and so it looked like arrogance.

The habit of keeping a ledger taught Nasima something else. In many of the very houses where she was affectionately called "one of the family," when the time came to pay her she became an outsider. One night she wrote in the margin of her ledger: "Affection need not be accounted for; labour must be." The next day she struck out the sentence because it seemed too harsh. But the mark of the crossed-out ink remained. Some things become clearer when they are crossed out.

That evening Nasima closed the ledger. Rain fell outside. Water struck the roof at almost equal intervals, but now and then a heavy drop spoiled the rhythm. Nasima listened. In the transactions of life, no tabla keeps perfect time forever. The metre was not yet complete.

3. Rights

When a man from a recording company came, Nasima was around thirty. He said her voice would no longer remain confined to an earthen-walled room; it would be pressed onto a disc and travel to distant cities. At first Nasima was delighted. Then she looked at the paper. It carried the ghazal poet's name, the company's name, and the accompanists' names in small print; the singer was named only as "Nasima." "Bi" had been removed—no gharana, no Ustad.

The company man said a short name sold better in the market. Nasima asked whether the market shortened only her name or her share as well. The man laughed, thinking it a joke. Nasima did not. She read the paper again.

She had long known the value of words; remove a single letter and the meaning can change.

On the day of recording she was told to shorten the ghazal. The whole performance would not fit on the disc. Two couplets would have to be removed. Nasima asked which ones. The man said the less popular ones. Nasima replied, "Popularity is not a radeef that can simply be attached to the end of every line." The recording stopped. Three hours of argument followed. In the end, one *alaap* was shortened and one interlude cut, but the two couplets remained.

The disc reached the market. For the first time Nasima's voice sounded in her own absence. At a *paan* shop she heard her own song. Two young men chewing *paan* were imitating her. One missed the note; the other laughed. Nasima stood at a distance and listened. Her voice had now left her body. It could no longer be stopped.

After the first disc, another company offered more money on the condition that Nasima not mention her old *Ustad*, because for the new publicity "a self-emerged voice" would sound better. Nasima rejected the offer. People said she had little financial sense. She knew that lineage did not belong only to blood; art too forms a lineage of debts to those from whom it is learned. Removing the *Ustad's* name would make the disc look cleaner, but it would leave the history of the voice incomplete.

That night, after returning home, she placed the disc before the lamp. Yellow light moved across the round black surface. She understood that rights did not mean locking everything inside oneself; when something went out into the world, preserving one's presence with its name and form was also a kind of right. The metre was not yet complete.

4. Form

Time changes a voice as well. Once Nasima crossed forty, people began saying that the old sweetness had diminished. Some requested higher notes; some compared her with younger singers. At first Nasima was hurt. Later she understood that people looked at a voice as they looked at a body—youth was their standard of measure.

The *Ustad* was no longer alive. His old *tanpura* hung in Nasima's room. One day she told her pupil *Rukhsana*, "*Bahr* is not the measure of a body. You cannot understand it by looking at what is short or tall, fat or thin. It is an inner measure of time." *Rukhsana* asked whether an old voice, then, could remain in *bahr*. Nasima replied, "If the breath speaks truth, why not?"

From that day Nasima stopped hiding her changed voice. Notes that had once gleamed were now dimmer; but in that dimness there was a grain, a roughness, that made some couplets sound deeper than before. A newly rich patron said that listening to the "old colour" had its own pleasure. Nasima laughed inwardly—the living woman before him had been turned into an "old colour."

There were fewer *mehfils* and more learners. In the afternoons girls came to the outer room of the house: some from school, some from market households, some from families of the very profession that society listened to at night and looked down upon by day. Nasima taught them one thing

again and again: matching the qafiya is not enough; when a word returns, do not leave its first meaning behind—carry it with you.

Once Rukhsana spoke of giving up her practice. Her marriage had been arranged; her future in-laws had said that a woman of the house would not sing on a stage. Nasima did not stop her. She asked only, “What is your decision?” After a long time Rukhsana said, “It is becoming difficult to know what my decision is; everyone puts their words into my mouth.” Nasima remained silent. She remembered her own first mehfil as a girl. Form does not belong only to the voice but to a decision as well; when there is no space inside, someone else’s sentence begins to take the shape of one’s body.

In the evening, looking at her face in the mirror, Nasima saw that fine lines had multiplied beside her eyes. She touched them with a finger, then lit the lamp. The form had changed; the measure had not ended. The metre was not yet complete.

5. Wall

Nasima had a daughter, Saba. While still small, she had been sent to her maternal grandparents, because Nasima wanted the girl to have an identity in her own name before she was identified through her mother’s profession. Saba studied, found a job, and made a home on the other side of the city. She loved her mother, but when introducing Nasima to colleagues she would say, “She teaches music.” The old name of the profession never came onto her tongue.

Nasima understood this. One day Saba asked her to move house; the name of the lane made people ask old questions. Nasima asked whether the old smell of the voice would not travel to the new house as well. Saba grew irritated. “I want what is good for you,” she said. Nasima replied quietly, “The wall between concern and shame is very thin.”

For several months they met less often. Nasima remained with her pupils. Rukhsana began performing outside. A new pupil, a young woman named Mithila, was studying at the university and, in the name of research, writing down the songs of older women singers. On the very first day Nasima told her, “If you are going to research me, do not turn me into a ‘subject’. Sit with me as a person.” Mithila did not laugh. She closed her notebook and sat.

One evening Saba arrived unexpectedly with a box of sweets. Her son’s marriage had been fixed. Nasima was delighted. Then Saba said softly that her mother must certainly come to the wedding, but should not bring too many “old acquaintances.” The sentence was gentle; Nasima heard the qafiya of its meaning at once.

Saba’s shame hurt Nasima, but she did not blame her daughter. When Saba was a child, two schoolmates had teased her after learning of her mother’s profession. She had come home that day and cried for a long time. Nasima had told her then, “We cannot shut people’s mouths.” Now she understood that the child had carried the burden of that impossible task inside herself. A wall is not built in one day; sometimes the bricks are laid by hands outside, sometimes by fear within.

On the wedding day Nasima went in a plain sari. Some people recognised her; some did not. At night a guest requested that Nasima sing a line. Saba froze for an instant. Nasima looked at her daughter and said, "Today belongs to the bride." She did not sing. In that not-singing, Saba heard her mother for the first time. The metre was not yet complete.

6. Beyond

Years passed. Half the houses in the old lane became shops. Nasima's staircase had grown crooked, but afternoon practice continued in the upstairs room. One day Mithila brought a small recording device. She said she wanted to record the old teaching sessions—not for the market, but for learning. Nasima refused at first. Later she set conditions: whatever was recorded must be given to all the students, and her spoken teaching must not be cut away to leave only the songs.

The recording began. Before recording a ghazal, Nasima recorded a mistake. Rukhsana missed a note; Nasima did not stop her. Afterwards she said, "Keep that. People should know that a note does not descend perfected from the sky." Mithila asked why, when artists usually wanted to hide their mistakes, Nasima wanted hers preserved. Nasima replied, "Because if you cut out the mistake, you cut away the road to learning."

One day Saba listened to the recording. Her mother's laughter, cough, voice counting the beat, a sharp correction to a pupil followed suddenly by a gentle explanation—all were there together. The mother of Saba's childhood returned in that voice, the same mother whom for years she had kept behind the wall of a profession. The following Sunday she came to Nasima's house and said her granddaughter wanted to learn music.

Nasima looked at the girl. Her name was Deepika. Nasima laughed and said, "There is light in your name; now let us hear what is in your throat." Saba laughed too. After many years, there was no need in this laughter to explain anyone's side.

Deepika began coming regularly. She kept count of the beat on her phone and then matched it to the clapping of her grandmother's hands. Nasima treated the new device as neither insult nor miracle. She said, "The measure may change; listening does not." One day Deepika cleaned up an old recording and played it. Out of the crackle emerged the voice of the young Nasima. The old Nasima listened for a long time, then said, "That is me, but it is not the me of now. Neither must be made proof of the other."

In her first lesson Deepika slipped out of rhythm. Nasima stopped clapping and said, "If you go outside it, do not panic. First understand where you have gone. Then return." Whether the sentence was meant for music or for life, no one made clear. The metre was not yet complete.

7. Essence

Nasima's final public mehfil was never announced as such. People knew only that she now went out less often. One winter evening her old pupils arranged a small gathering. There was no wealthy patron, no red invitation. Students, neighbours, Saba, Deepika, two elderly accompanists, and Mithila—that was all. In the middle stood the same glass-shaded lamp, its glass now clouded.

Nasima sat down to sing, but stopped after the first *alaap*. Her breath was short. Rukhsana moved forward. Nasima gestured: sing. Rukhsana began the *ghazal*. The *radeef* Nasima had learned from the *Ustad* in her adolescence returned once more. The words were the same; their meanings carried the weight of every age.

In the first couplet Nasima saw the *Ustad's* room. In the second, the unpaid rupees in the ledger. In the third, the round black record. In the fourth, the wrinkles in the mirror. In the fifth, Saba's silence. In the sixth, Deepika's off-beat clap. The *radeef* kept returning, but now it was not an ending; it was like the joining of all the roads.

The *ghazal* ended. Everyone was silent. No one hurried to say "Wah." Nasima looked at the lamp. Inside the glass the wick was small, but steady. She called Deepika close and said, "People will tell you that *bahr* is a rule. It is a rule, but not a bondage. A measure that lets you speak the truth is *bahr*; one that silences you is only a wall."

Deepika asked, "Then when is a *ghazal* complete?" Nasima smiled. "When the *radeef* returns and changes the meaning it had the first time."

After everyone had left that night, Saba rose to extinguish the lamp. Nasima stopped her. "Let it remain for now." There was mist outside. Inside, a string of the *tanpura* trembled faintly without anyone touching it—perhaps from the cold, perhaps from the air. Nasima closed her eyes and listened.

As the gathering ended, Mithila asked Nasima whether she wanted the story of her life written. Nasima said, "The moment people begin writing a story, they start looking for its ending." Mithila asked, "And if there is no ending?" Keeping her eyes on the lamp-wick, Nasima replied, "Then write that the closing phrase arrived, but the meaning remained alive to change again." Hearing this, Mithila did not open her notebook. Some sentences have to be lived for a while before they are written.

No one knew whether Nasima was listening to her old *mehfils* or to the next generation's practice. The closing phrase returned once more in her mind, but this time its meaning was not death; it was remaining possibility. The metre was not yet complete.

— *End of Story 8* —

9. The Guest Room

STORY

When the door of the room closed from inside, Anamika noticed for the first time that the latch had been changed. The old brass latch was gone; in its place was a new steel one. She ran her hand over it. Thirty years earlier, when she had left this room to go away for her studies, the latch used to jam every other time. Mother would push from outside and say, "Don't force it. Lift it from the side."

Now Mother said, "I had this new one fitted. The old one broke."

That was all. Everything that had broken, changed, been sold, divided, whitewashed, built in those thirty years seemed to gather inside that single sentence. Anamika set her suitcase beside the bed. Mother went on fluffing the pillow. Outside, in the courtyard, the voices of those who had remained after the funeral rites were thinning one by one. Father's pyre had gone out that very afternoon; tonight, for the first time, his absence would assume its full shape inside the house.

"You'll have to sleep here," Mother said. "The roof leaks in the upstairs room."

Anamika said, "I'll sleep with you."

Mother's hands stopped as she set down the pillow. "With me?" Then she immediately became casual again. "All right. The bed is wide enough."

This was the same guest room in which Anamika had been put when she first returned from abroad after her marriage. She had been hurt then. A guest in her own home? That night she had told her husband on the phone, "Mother didn't let me sleep in my own room." Her husband had laughed: "Whose home is it now?" Anamika had disliked the question. She had ended the call.

Today the sheet spread in that room was new, but the cupboard was old. Behind its glass stood two steel tumblers, a flask, a small soap box, a book of prayers, a mosquito-repellent device. On top of the cupboard was the wooden elephant from her childhood. One leg was broken; the red paint had almost faded away.

"This is still here?" Anamika asked as she took down the elephant.

Mother said, "Why would I throw it away?"

"I thought you must have cleared everything out."

"If everything is cleared out, what will remain in a house?"

Anamika did not laugh. Neither did Mother. Both had heard something more inside those two sentences.

Dinner had passed in near silence. The relatives gradually took their leave. Two plates remained in the kitchen. Anamika did not want to eat, yet Mother spooned ghee over her rice. "Does aeroplane food ever fill the stomach?" she asked. Anamika said, "Mother, these days they hardly give you anything on planes the way they used to." Mother replied, "So you pay more money for less food?" For the first time, both of them laughed.

Back in the room, Anamika opened her suitcase. Clothes, medicines, chargers, papers, and the new woollen blanket she had brought for Father - a blanket that would now never be used by him. She took it out and laid it on the bed. Mother looked at it, then looked away.

"He liked this colour," Anamika said.

"Yes."

"I asked him on the phone the last time."

"Yes."

"He said dark blue."

"Yes."

Anamika suddenly grew irritated. "Why do you say yes to everything?"

Mother began folding the blanket. "Then what should I say?"

"Something. Whatever you feel."

"Is everything one feels meant to be said?"

At those words Anamika remembered an evening long ago. She had been sixteen. Father had torn up her college form because she insisted on studying outside Darbhanga. Crying, Anamika had gone to Mother's room. Mother, sitting by the hearth, had said, "When you live in a house, you have to understand the ways of the house." Anamika had taken the sentence for cowardice. For months she had spoken little to Mother. Later she received a scholarship, Father relented, and she left. But Mother's sentence remained inside her like a thorn.

Tonight, thirty years later, on the night of Father's death, the same thorn woke again.

"Why didn't you take my side then?" she asked. She tried to keep her voice as even as she could.

Mother had finished folding the blanket. "When?"

"You know when."

Mother was silent for a while. Outside, the pump at the well started and stopped almost at once. A dog barked far away. A small lamp burned on the table in the room; there was electricity, yet Mother had lit the lamp.

"The day of your form?"

Anamika was startled. Mother had recognised a day thirty years old without hesitation. "Yes."

Mother sat on the edge of the bed. "I didn't take your side?"

"No."

"That is how it seemed to you?"

"How else was it supposed to seem? Father tore up the form. You told me to understand the ways of the house."

Mother laughed softly; there was tiredness in the laugh. "Is that all you remember?"

Anamika did not answer.

Mother said, "Your mausi came the next day and talked to your father for two hours. Did she come of her own accord?"

Anamika raised her head and looked at her.

"Who got your scholarship papers sent from the school? Your father did not even know the application date. Who wrote to your headmaster that

night? Who paid the fare when your mama went to Patna to submit the certificates?"

There was neither triumph nor complaint in Mother's voice. She seemed merely to be reading out a page from some very old household account.

Anamika said, "You?"

"I did."

"Then why didn't you tell me?"

"If I had told you, your father would have understood that I was opposing him inside his own house. In his stubbornness he would have stopped you. I needed to send you out, not display my courage."

The room suddenly seemed smaller. Anamika rose and opened the window. Night stood outside. Half the mango tree was in darkness, the other half in the neighbour's electric light.

"You let me misunderstand you for thirty years."

Mother replied, "Sometimes misunderstanding, too, opens a road."

Anamika turned at once. "That is not a good thing."

"Did I say it was good?"

Both fell silent again. A silence more exhausting than a quarrel, because inside it every unfinished sentence could be heard.

Anamika picked up her phone. Three messages from her daughter were on the screen: "Ma, have you reached?" "Is Nani all right?" "Should I call?" Her finger moved to type a reply, then stopped. Her daughter too had once said, "You people decide everything according to what suits you." Anamika had been deeply hurt then. Now it seemed to her that generations changed, but sentences changed their form and returned.

Mother asked, "What happened?"

"Nothing. Ira is asking."

"Tell her Nani is all right."

Anamika wrote, "Nani is awake. I am with her." After sending it, the sentence felt strange. "I am with her" - after how many years could she truly say that?

Mother began changing the pillowcase. Anamika stopped her. "Leave it."

"It's the guest pillow. It should be clean."

"Am I a guest?"

Mother's hands stopped. "Does that still hurt you?"

"The first time I came back from abroad, you put me in this room. It hurt me terribly."

Mother ran a finger along the wood of the bed. "Your father used to cough through the night then. His room was beside mine. Your child was small and cried at night. I thought you should get some sleep. This was the quietest room in the house."

Anamika stared at her. "Why didn't you tell me?"

This time Mother laughed. "Did you have time to listen to everything?"

The blow was light, but it landed exactly where it should. Anamika remembered: she had come then on seven days' leave. The first day relatives, the second the bank, the third the dentist, the fourth photographs, the fifth shopping, the sixth packing. Mother had always seemed to be moving

between the kitchen and veranda. On the seventh day, the flight. When had she actually sat with Mother?

"I thought you had pushed me away."

"I thought I had given you rest."

Thirty years later, the two sentences sat facing each other in the same room.

Mother slowly opened the blue woollen blanket again. "May I keep this?"

Anamika said, "Keep it."

"Should I wrap myself in something meant for your father?"

"Use it. I brought it for him, but you feel the cold too."

Mother first made the gesture of refusing, then laid the blanket across her knees. "It's very heavy."

"It's warm."

"Are all warm things heavy?"

Anamika laughed. "No."

"Then all right."

Half the night had passed. They lay on the bed with a hand's breadth between them. In childhood Anamika had slept pressed against Mother's back. After marriage the distance had not always been measured, but it had kept growing. Tonight it lay plainly visible on the bed.

In the darkness Mother said, "May I ask you something?"

"Ask."

"Do you have a guest room in your house?"

"Yes."

"When Ira comes home from outside, where does she sleep?"

Anamika paused before answering. "In the guest room."

Mother said, "Yes." Only yes.

Anamika felt as though a lamp had been lit again somewhere inside the room, though the lamp on the table had already been extinguished. After her daughter went to college, Anamika had turned Ira's old room into a study. When Ira returned home she put her in the guest room - "You'll be more comfortable there." What might Ira have understood?

"Mother."

"Hm?"

"I'll make Ira's room hers again."

Mother did not turn over. "Ask Ira first what she wants."

Anamika said, "Yes. This time I'll ask."

Mother gave a faint laugh. "Then that's all right."

"First I'll understand what she wants."

After a while Mother said, "It is good to ask."

There was neither advice nor victory in that single sentence. Only this: perhaps the question no one had asked Anamika thirty years ago could be asked of the next generation.

The first light of dawn filtered through the curtain. When Anamika woke, Mother was asleep. The blue blanket lay over half her body, the other half slipping toward the floor. Anamika rose and pulled it back into place. In sleep Mother's face looked very old, and yet strangely light as well.

Anamika picked up the broken wooden elephant and, instead of putting it back inside the cupboard, set it on the window ledge. The light from outside fell on its faded red paint. The object had not changed; the way it appeared had.

Mother woke. "What are you doing?"

"Nothing. I'm letting the elephant look outside."

Mother narrowed her eyes. "It has been inside all these years."

Anamika said, "Yes. Perhaps now it wants to look outside."

Mother did not answer. She only pulled the blanket a little higher. Anamika sat on the edge of the bed. Her flight was in the evening. The whole day still lay before her. For the first time, she was in no hurry.

The new steel latch on the door gleamed in the morning light. The old latch had broken; the house had not.

— *End of Story 9* —

10. Mist

STORY

When the bus left the main road and turned toward the village, Binod wiped the window glass and tried to look outside. The glass cleared; the world beyond it did not. The mist was so dense that the trees on both sides of the road were visible only halfway up, their crowns lost above. The driver sounded the horn again and again; the sound entered the mist and seemed to shrink.

Binod had travelled this road many times, but this time he could recognise none of the turns. Where there had once been a pond, the white strip of a petrol pump now glimmered dimly through the mist. Where there had been a bamboo grove stood a two-storey house. The road had been paved; memory had not.

He had taken the night train from Delhi, then a bus from the station. He had two bags: one with clothes, medicines and papers; the other with things that no longer served any use but which he had not had the courage to throw away - an old hospital sweater, a metal key-ring, two photographs, and the plastic badge on which the faded letters could still be read: BINOD K.

Nothing remarkable had happened on his last night at the hospital. No unusual rush of ambulances, no quarrel, no farewell speech. The new guard arrived on time, signed the register and took charge of the chair. Binod removed his badge and put it in his pocket. Thirty-four years earlier that badge had felt light - no lineage, no neighbourhood, no father's name. On the last night, those same two words had suddenly become heavy.

The bus stopped at the village crossroads. The driver said, "Piprahi? Get down." Binod remained seated for a moment. The name of his village had not changed; people had simply begun calling the crossroads by the name of the nearby market. He lifted down his bags.

The first thing he recognised through the mist was a sound - the grinding rattle of an iron shutter being raised. The second was a smell - tea brewing over a small coal brazier. The third was someone's voice saying, "The cold will be severe this year." The village returned first to his ears and only afterwards to his eyes.

Renu had insisted on coming as far as the crossroads, but Binod had refused. "I won't forget the way," he had told her on the phone. Within five minutes he understood that confidence, like memory, also travels by an old map.

Three lanes opened from the crossroads. He remembered two. Whether the third was new or merely absent from his memory was hard to say. He gave the old name of his neighbourhood to a paan seller. The shopkeeper looked him up and down, then said, "You are Binod Babu, aren't you? Renu Didi's brother?"

Binod laughed. "You recognised me in all this mist?"

"Not your face. Your voice."

Something inside Binod softened at the answer. In Delhi thousands of people had seen his face; very few had recognised his voice.

The shopkeeper called to a boy, "Hey, take Babu's bag home." Binod refused. The boy nevertheless began walking ahead, perhaps simply to show him the way.

The old outer wall of the house was gone. In its place stood a new brick wall with an iron gate above it. Inside the gate Renu was standing in a white shawl, half her hair grey, a broom in her hand. For an instant Binod could not make sense of her. Renu spoke first: "Will you say it again this time - only a few days?"

Binod set his bags on the ground. "This time I haven't booked a ticket."

Renu kept looking at him. "For going back?"

"In any direction."

Renu leaned the broom against the wall. "Then come inside first."

Their mother had died seven years earlier. Binod had come for the last rites, but three days later a call from the hospital had taken him back. He did not count that journey as a return. In grief, home ceases to be a place; it becomes only a list of tasks - whom to call, where people will sit, which papers are needed, who will sleep where.

This time the courtyard was empty. The tulsi altar had been rebuilt, but the old brass bell was the same. He went toward his room. The doorway was there; the room was not. Renu and her son had removed the partition wall and made one large room.

From behind him Renu said, "Your old cot is in the storeroom. I didn't throw it away."

Binod said, "Does keeping the cot save the room?"

Renu did not answer. She had spent more years in this house than Binod had; she knew that answering some questions only makes the question smaller.

Relatives kept coming until noon. Someone asked about his work in Delhi, someone about his pension, someone why his son had not come. Binod gave short answers to every question. His own son lived in Gurugram; his daughter in Pune. Both had said, "Babu, first get yourself settled, then we'll come." Binod did not know what verb "to get settled" really was.

By evening the mist had thickened again. The electricity failed once, and Renu lit a small earthen lamp. Binod laughed and asked, "Don't you have an inverter?"

"We do. A lamp is not a substitute for an inverter."

Binod fell silent. He remembered the yellow bulb on the roof, the one that still burned in daylight fourteen years later, the one he had switched off one morning. There had also been an empty flowerpot on the Delhi roof. How many times had he thought of filling it with soil from the village? The soil had never gone. Now he himself was sitting beside the soil.

At night Renu brought out an old quilt. "Do you still have that cough?"

"In the cold."

"Did you ever show it to a doctor in Delhi?"

"I worked in a hospital. I saw doctors every day."

"For yourself?"

Binod laughed. Renu did not.

He woke very early the next morning. Years of night duty had built a clock inside his body. The house was asleep. Binod wrapped a shawl around himself and went outside. The mist was even denser than the day before.

He thought he would walk to the old pond. Five minutes away. After ten minutes he realised he had reached another lane. New houses, closed gates, motorcycles under covers, a web of wires. A dog barked once and fell silent.

At a turn he stopped. A yellow light seemed to float in the mist. When he came closer, he saw the veranda of the old primary school. The school had moved to a new building; one room in the old one bore a sign: "Village Archive Centre."

The door was half open. Someone coughed inside. Binod called, "Is anyone there?"

"There is - come in. Open the door all the way; the mist won't come inside."

Binod entered. An old man sat at a table: thick spectacles, a woollen cap, a heap of papers in front of him and a small lamp. The lamp's light fell at an angle. The old man raised his head.

"Whom are you looking for?"

"The way," Binod said before he could stop himself, then laughed. "I had set out for the pond."

The old man smiled too. "The pond is the other way from here."

Binod's eyes fell on the table. On one copy were lines in old Devanagari with modern typescript at the side. Some spaces were blank. In some were brackets: "unclear", "name erased", "oral memory available".

"Are you Niranjan Babu?" Binod asked suddenly.

The old man looked at him over his spectacles. "Do you know me?"

"No. I've heard your name. You came to look at the Panji many years ago."

Niranjan laughed. "A lot of people say 'many years ago.' Now, for me too, everything is many years ago."

He asked Binod to sit. There was a plastic chair beside the table. Binod sat down. Outside the doorway the mist stood like a white wall.

Niranjan asked, "Your name?"

"Binod."

"Full name?"

Binod paused for a moment. He remembered the hospital badge. "Binod Kumar."

"Father's name?"

He told him. Niranjan wrote nothing on the paper. He merely nodded.

Binod asked, "Will my name be in the Panji?"

"It may be. It may not. Which Panji, which branch, whose hand - many things matter."

"Then what do you get from all this work?"

Niranjan was silent at the question. With his old hand he straightened a page. "At first I used to think that if I could read again the letters that had been erased, I would find the truth. I was very enthusiastic."

"And now?"

"Now I understand: even if the erased letters are recovered, the whole person is not. Sometimes it is more honest to leave a blank space named as a blank space."

Binod looked at the box on the table marked "name erased". "Does leaving the blank bring the person back?"

Niranjan smiled. "On paper? Sometimes. In life? I don't know."

Just then came the sound of running feet outside. A boy of twelve or thirteen rushed in, a mobile phone in his hand. "Niranjan Baba, Dadi says please find her grandmother's name. She says you keep everything in your mobile."

Niranjan laughed. "The world doesn't fit inside a mobile, boy."

"Then in the computer?"

"Not there either."

The boy was not discouraged. "Then show me as much as does fit."

Niranjan took the phone from him. "First go and ask your grandmother her own name properly. Ask her grandmother's name properly too. It won't do to say only 'so-and-so's daughter.'"

The boy ran back out. When the door opened, a wave of mist entered. The flame of the lamp trembled slightly, but did not go out.

Binod said, "In Delhi, the badge on my chest said only BINOD K."

"Was that convenient?"

"At first. Later I understood how much is left out of two words."

"Even a full name leaves things out," Niranjan said. "A Panji may record five generations and not record one person's laugh. It does not say which season frightened him. It does not say for whom he left home, or to whom he returned."

Binod said nothing for a long time. He remembered Renu's question from the previous day - "Only a few days this time too?" He had replied that he had not booked a ticket. That answer had not been a promise to stay; it had merely meant there was no date of departure.

Niranjan took a small steel container from the table drawer. The tea inside had gone cold. "Will you have some?"

Binod declined. Then he asked, "Did you find the name in that erased line?"

Niranjan's hand stopped on the container. In the lamp's slanting light his eyes looked very tired, though his voice was ordinary. "Some names were found, some stories were found, and some claims did not agree with one another. In the end I did not write on the page, 'This is the truth.' I wrote: 'There are signs of deliberate erasure here; two oral memories from outside this family tell different stories.' That's all."

"Then the thief?"

"While searching for the thief, I understood that sometimes a theft is not done by one hand. When many people remain silent, a name disappears."

The sentence had nothing to do with Binod's own house, and yet it struck somewhere inside him. In Delhi he had erased no one's name. But how many birthdays, illnesses, quarrels, nights of his mother's, Renu's

weariness - he had been absent before them all. Absence is not the same as guilt; neither is its effect nothing.

He stood up. "Which way did you say the pond was?"

Niranjan pointed toward the door. "Go straight and turn right at the first peepal tree. But in the mist even a peepal can look like a new electric pole. Ask someone again."

Binod laughed. "I'll keep asking the way."

The moment he stepped outside, his spectacles fogged over. He took them off and put them in his pocket. There was not much difference now between the world without his glasses and the world inside the mist.

He did not go to the pond. Before reaching the peepal tree he heard, from a distance, the scratch of a broom. He recognised the sound. Renu was sweeping dust together outside the lane.

"Where did you go off to?" Renu asked.

"The pond."

"This is the road to the pond?"

"No. The road changed in between."

Renu looked not at any paper in his hand but only at the cold on him. "Come. The tea is ready."

As soon as he entered the house, Binod went toward the storeroom. The old cot was indeed there - its ropes loose, one leg eaten by insects. Beneath it lay a broken flowerpot. He picked it up.

Renu came behind him and asked, "What will you do with that?"

"Plant something."

"In winter?"

"When the season comes."

"Until then?"

"I'll keep it filled with soil."

Renu looked at him, then brought him a small spade from outside. No questions.

Binod lifted soil from one corner of the courtyard and filled the pot. At that moment he clearly remembered the empty fourth flowerpot on the Delhi roof, the one he had spent fourteen years thinking of filling with soil from his village. He laughed. How often people try to make objects travel while putting off the journey they themselves need to make.

He opened his bag and took out the hospital badge. BINOD K. was now very faint. Renu saw it. "You've kept this all this time?"

"Yes."

"Is it useful?"

"No."

"Then?"

Binod thought about the answer. "It tells me I was somewhere for a very long time."

Renu said, "It is clear even without the badge that you were."

Binod did not bury the badge in the flowerpot. He placed it on the window ledge, where the pale morning light fell on it.

By noon the mist had not lifted completely. It had thinned only enough for the roof of the house opposite to become visible. The distant trees were still only half there.

Handing him tea, Renu asked, "What are you thinking now? How many days this time?"

Binod looked at the soil in the pot. "I won't count the days."

"Then?"

"When morning comes, I'll see how much of the mist has lifted."

Renu said, "The mist doesn't always lift completely."

"I know."

They drank their tea in silence. The earth in the courtyard was damp. On the window ledge, the two faded words on the old badge caught the pale light, and in the flowerpot there was, for now, only soil - no plant, no promise.

The road was not clear. The house could be seen.

— *End of Story 10* —

II. The Limits of Justice

STORY

Rataneshwar Jha kept three kinds of paper on his table. On the left were his students' research papers, in the middle his own manuscript, and on the right little slips on which he wrote down questions that arose through the day. However small the question, it arrived on the slip as a complete sentence. "What is the reason for this conclusion?" "Where does perception end?" "How is the speaker's reliability established in verbal testimony?"

He disliked half-written sentences. A half-sentence was usually a half-thought - that was his conviction. His students called him strict; his colleagues, exacting. At home his daughter Mrinal would say, "Babu, even when you drink tea, you look as though you are searching for the delimiter of the cup."

Rataneshwar always laughed at the joke. "The cup is not the delimiter; it is the substratum," he would say, teasing Mrinal further.

That morning there was a new slip on his table: "The role of place in the cognition of absence." A note for his next university lecture. Outside the window there was no mist, only clear winter light. The little brass lamp was unlit; he used it only while reading at night.

The phone rang at half past seven. Mrinal's name was on the screen. Rataneshwar thought the school bus must be late again. Mrinal's son Anay was nine, and every morning, within five minutes of the bus's arrival, he managed to forget something or other - his water bottle, his geometry box, sometimes his entire schoolbag.

Rataneshwar answered. It was not Mrinal on the other end, but a man's voice. "Babu, this is Rohit... come to the hospital."

"What happened?"

The voice stopped twice. "The school vehicle... an accident..."

Rataneshwar's first question was, "Is Anay conscious?"

There was silence at the other end. The sentence that came after it was grammatically complete, but not complete in meaning.

Rataneshwar stood up. The chair slid backwards. The slip from the right side of the table fell to the floor - "The role of place in the cognition of absence." He did not pick it up.

On the way to the hospital Rohit kept calling. "The doctors have seen him." "The police are here." "Mrinal is not saying anything." Rataneshwar heard every sentence, but by old habit his mind began identifying the source of each claim: perception? hearsay? a physician's statement? inference?

For a moment he was angry with his own mind. Then he understood that even this anger was of no use now. The habits the body makes over decades are the first to rise in a crisis.

Mrinal sat on a plastic chair in the hospital corridor. Anay's blue sweater lay in her lap. One sleeve hung almost to the floor. Mrinal looked at Rataneshwar but did not stand.

Rataneshwar sat beside her. "Mrinal."

She asked only, "Babu, did you see?"

Before answering, Rataneshwar understood that the question might mean, "Did you see the body?" It might mean, "Did you understand?" It might mean, "Have you accepted it?" On an ordinary day he would have clarified the question. Not today.

"Yes," he said.

Mrinal lifted the hanging sleeve and placed it back in her lap. Then both of them were silent for a long time.

In the afternoon a police officer took a statement. The driver was injured. The vehicle had struck a tree by the roadside. The first written account said: "The vehicle went out of control due to the driver's negligence." Rataneshwar read the paper and asked, "Whose direct perception established the negligence?"

The policeman looked at him. "Babu, it is the standard form."

"A standard form does not determine guilt."

Rohit said softly, "Leave all this for now."

Rataneshwar placed the paper on the table. "If it is not written correctly now, this will become the fact later."

Mrinal raised her head for the first time. Her eyes were dry. "Babu is right. Write only what was seen."

The paper was changed: "The vehicle struck a tree; investigation into the cause is continuing." Rataneshwar's reasoning was useful here. Fact and inference remained separate. Later it emerged that an animal had suddenly come into the road ahead, and brake marks were also found. The driver was not declared blameless, nor was he immediately declared guilty.

Rataneshwar might have taken some satisfaction in this. But the place in the mind where satisfaction would have to live was filled with something else.

After the cremation the house filled with people - relatives, neighbours, colleagues, students. Everyone had words. "It was God's will." "Time heals every wound." "He was a very virtuous child." "He had only as many days as were written for him..."

Rataneshwar listened. Never before had he felt so sharply that for "word" to become a means of knowledge, merely being a sentence was not enough. The speaker had to be trustworthy, the meaning intelligible, the relation appropriate - he had taught such things all his life. But in a house of mourning, many sentences stand outside truth and falsehood; they are merely cloth laid over helplessness.

An elderly relative said, "The child will be born again."

Mrinal stopped in the middle of folding the sweater. "In whose house?"

The old man fell silent.

At another time Rataneshwar would have asked about the soul, rebirth, evidence, tradition - what standing did each claim have? Today he understood only that Mrinal had not asked for the sake of argument. She was asking where the absent child would be.

By the thirtieth day the house had begun to empty. Fewer plates were washed, fewer slippers lay scattered, the door opened less often. Anay's room was not locked. Mrinal said, "If I close it, I will feel as though he is inside."

Rataneshwar entered the room alone for the first time. On the table lay an unfinished drawing - a house, a tree, and above them an enormous yellow sun. Two pencil points were broken in the box. Beside the bed was a small night-light shaped like a plastic moon. It had been unplugged, but Mrinal did not want it removed.

Rataneshwar's eyes settled on the empty chair. A word rose automatically inside him: absence. Non-apprehension of the counterpositive? Place-qualified absence? "Anay is not on this chair." A sentence could be made. So could an analysis.

Suddenly he felt something like shame. Not shame at the truth - shame at its insufficiency.

He laid a hand on the chair. The wood was cold. The knowledge was clear: the chair was empty. But that knowledge did not shorten Mrinal's night, did not bring back Anay's laughter, did not complete the unfinished sun on the table.

Mrinal came and stood in the doorway. "Babu, what are you looking at?"

"The chair."

"Empty?"

Rataneshwar answered, "Yes."

Mrinal came inside. "How do you know it is empty?"

Had Mrinal asked this in childhood, Rataneshwar would have been delighted. Now her voice was flat.

He said slowly, "What was expected to be there is not seen."

"Then if something is not expected, is there no absence of it?"

Rataneshwar was silent. He could not tell whether the question was becoming technical or whether Mrinal was searching for a language for her grief.

Mrinal sat on the other side of the chair. "All day I see his absence everywhere. The small glass in the kitchen. No shoes in the veranda. No sound of him brushing his teeth at night. When the school bus horn sounds, my body gets up. Is all this one absence, or many different absences?"

Rataneshwar had an answer - a philosophical answer. Place, counterpositive, relation, time, qualification, expectation. If he wished, he could arrange it all in five minutes.

His mouth opened. No sentence came.

Mrinal looked at him. "You do not know?"

"I know the language of knowledge," Rataneshwar said. "I do not know the whole language of this experience."

For the first time tears came into Mrinal's eyes. "Then sit here with me."

Rataneshwar remained seated.

That night, when he returned home, the slip was still on the floor beside his table. He picked it up. "The role of place in the cognition of absence." He looked at it for a long time. Then on the back he wrote: "Place is not only external."

He crossed the sentence out. It was becoming theory again.

For the next few weeks he did not go to the university. Students kept sending messages. The head of department said, "Take time." The word "time" struck Rataneshwar as strange. Can time be taken? Time goes on without asking permission.

At Mrinal's house he kept doing small everyday tasks: bank papers, school certificates, an insurance claim, copies from the police. In these matters his exactness became useful again. On one document the date of the accident had been printed incorrectly; he had it corrected. An official said, "What difference does one day this way or that make?" Rataneshwar answered quietly, "Death happens once; it should not happen twice on paper."

That day, after a long time, Mrinal smiled faintly. "Babu, keep that sentence. It is a good one."

Rataneshwar smiled too. Reason did not erase grief here; it did prevent an erroneous entry from hardening into truth. Without writing it down, he understood that knowing a limit does not mean abandoning usefulness.

A month later he went to teach for the first time. The subject was the same - absence. The students had probably heard from the department; no one asked a personal question.

Rataneshwar wrote on the board: "ghaṭābhāvaḥ." Then he stopped, chalk in hand. In his old manner he began with the definition, gave examples, raised objections, answered them. Within twenty minutes the class had returned to its familiar rhythm. His intellect was working; grief did not lessen because of that, nor did the intellect become false because of grief.

A student asked, "Sir, when I see an empty chair, do I know the absence directly, or do I first see the chair and then infer the person who is not sitting on it?"

The class grew alert. It was an old question; Rataneshwar had answered it hundreds of times.

He looked at an empty chair in front of him.

"I will give the logical answer," he said, "but first keep one distinction in mind. To know that the chair is empty is one thing. To live without finding the person who used to sit here is another. Philosophy can make the first thing very precise. In the second, philosophy can walk beside you; it cannot become anyone's substitute."

The class was silent. Rataneshwar immediately feared that he had turned the lecture into autobiography. He picked up the chalk again. "Now let us return to the question."

He explained the positions concerning perception, inference and the cognition of absence. He invited objections from the students. One student cut through his argument; Rataneshwar was pleased. "Correct. My example was weak here," he admitted. The class came alive again.

In the evening he returned home and lit the lamp on his table. He opened the pages of his manuscript. The chapter title was "The Limits of

Knowledge." It had been chosen in small letters for a subtle subject: what kind of knowledge arises from which means of knowledge, under what conditions. Now the words seemed larger.

He did not change the title. He only struck out a sentence in the final footnote: "Correct knowledge of reality brings human error to an end."

The sentence was not entirely false. But the word "end" said too much.

He tried to write a new sentence. Three times the pen rose, three times it stopped. In the end he left the footnote blank.

Mrinal called that night.

"Babu, the lamp in Anay's room was broken. I had it repaired."

Rataneshwar's hand stopped over the pen. "Will you keep it lit?"

"Sometimes. I cannot sit there in the dark."

"All right."

"Will you come tomorrow?"

"I will."

After the call ended, Rataneshwar looked at his little brass lamp. Its light fell on the blank footnote in the manuscript. The empty space no longer seemed to him an error. Some blank spaces are not an absence of evidence; they are also places in which one acknowledges the limits of being human.

He capped his pen. He did not put out the lamp.

— *End of Story 11* —

12. Letters

STORY

This letter never went to a post office. It never even acquired an envelope. Folded into four pages, it lay between the leaves of an old year's notebook with two dried bel leaves and a blue thread. The pages did not bear Devanagari, but the crooked, winding lines of the old Maithilakshara script. Only in one place along the margin, in Devanagari, was written: "For Ira."

Ira could not read those letters.

Saraswati Devi, who wrote the letter, knew that very well. Even so, she wrote it in that script.

"Ira,

I do not know whether this letter will ever reach you. If it does, first you will have to get someone else to read it to you. You may laugh at that. What is the meaning of writing you a letter that you yourself cannot read?

I do not have a ready answer. The idea that old people know the answers to every question is false. Old age often makes the questions larger.

Do you remember, when you were seven, opening my wooden chest one day? Looking at the papers inside, you asked, "Nani, what are these marks, like trails made by insects?" I scolded you. I snapped the lid of the chest shut.

That day my scolding was not directed at your hand. It was directed at my own fear.

Those marks were not insects. They were letters. I wrote as my mother had taught me. The letters in her hand were rounded; mine leaned a little. Your mother - my daughter - learned to write even her name in this script, and then school notebooks, examinations, a job, the city and the computer together changed the path of her hand. No one is to blame. Paths change.

But when a path changes, the old footprints do not disappear at once.

In our house, writing a letter used to be like a small ritual: the trembling light of a lantern, a brass inkwell, a blank sheet of paper, and Mother saying, "First make the whole sentence in your mind; only then move the pen." I would ask, "What if the sentence changes halfway?" She would laugh: "Then the letters will turn too."

At the time I thought letters were fixed things. Now I understand - letters turn as well.

Four letters from your great-grandmother are still in my chest. In one she wrote about the paddy, in another about my father's fever, in the third about a wedding in the village. The fourth stops halfway. Its last line is: "I will write again tomorrow." After that she could not write.

For a long time I read that half-line as though it were death. Now when I read it, it seems like life. A person who writes "I will write again tomorrow" is, at the moment of writing, hoping for tomorrow. What happened afterwards was something the sentence did not know. The sentence was true in its own time.

Ira, perhaps language is like that too. It does not know its last day in advance. Afterwards people say: it diminished from here, it vanished from there. Perhaps on that very day the language itself is still being born in some child's mouth in a new way.

You have said to me many times, "Nani, speak in Maithili; I understand." Hearing your "I understand" used to make me happy and sad at once. Happy because you understood. Sad because I knew that understanding and speaking freely in one's own mouth are not the same thing.

Then I would stop myself. It is not your fault.

Nor is your mother at fault. She educated you in a city school and did what seemed right to her. If, at that time, I had said to her, "No, my granddaughter must learn the old script," she might have thought me stuck in an old age. Perhaps I truly was stuck.

There is a very fine distinction between being stuck and holding one's ground.

I have thought about that distinction many times. Is preserving an old chest a way of holding one's ground, or of being stuck? Is wrapping a torn letter in cloth and keeping it love, or fear? Is writing in a script that has no reader practice, or obstinacy?

Perhaps the answer to this letter will not be found in these four pages.

The last time you came, the light of your mobile phone was falling across my room at night. You were showing me your photographs - snow, a train, the university, your friends. I looked at them all. Then you stopped at one picture: a handwritten page displayed behind glass in an old library. You said, "Nani, look how beautiful it is."

I asked, "Can you read it?"

You said, "No. But it is beautiful."

I said nothing then.

After you went to sleep that night, I remained awake for a long time. The word "beautiful" pricked me like a thorn. When a living thing becomes merely a beautiful object and arrives behind glass, what should one call it? Preserved? Or confined?

Then I opened my chest and took out your great-great-grandmother's letter. I read the first page. The second. The third. I understood: these papers are not museum objects. In these pages my mother is speaking to me. The lines of the letters are crooked, the paper has yellowed, but when I read "Eat on time," I become a daughter again.

Then I thought: if you cannot read it, how will this voice reach you?

The next morning I thought of teaching you. But you had come for three days. The first day was for relatives, the second for the market, the third for departure. I said nothing.

I do not always regard my own silence as civility. Often silence is laziness. Often it is fear. Often it is the pride that the other person will understand on their own.

Language does not endure on pride. It needs someone to speak it. Letters need a hand.

That is why today I am writing this letter in the very script you cannot read. I am doing this contradiction knowingly.

Why?

Because if I wrote it in Devanagari, perhaps you would read the letter once, take a photograph of it on your phone, and put it away. Since it is written in this script, you will have to find someone who can read it. Perhaps an old woman. Perhaps a teacher. Perhaps a chart on the internet. Perhaps you yourself will slowly match one letter at a time.

Then this letter will make you stop for five minutes longer.

I am not placing on your head the burden of making the language immortal. A burden like that turns love into duty, and duty into fatigue. I am asking for only five minutes.

Five minutes in which you recognise one letter.

Let us say the first letter is "M."

M - māj, mother.

M - māṭi, earth.

M - mon, the heart.

You may say M - Mithila too, if you like, but the first three are enough.

One letter does not bind three things together. It merely opens three directions inside you. Perhaps language is less a thing for binding than a thing for opening.

When I was young, I thought that if Maithili was written down, Maithili was saved. Later I understood: a language preserved on paper but no longer present in the mouth is only half preserved. Then I understood: if it remains in the mouth but, out of shame, never comes out, that too is only half. Now in old age I understand that the word "saved" is itself too rigid. Language is not a seed that is either saved or rotted. Nor is language a river that must take one channel and keep flowing in it. It is like the smoke of a house - sometimes it stings the eyes, sometimes it reveals a hole in the roof, sometimes when the wind changes it changes direction.

I am writing too many metaphors. If your Nana were here, he would say, "Write plainly."

The plain truth is this: I am afraid.

I am afraid that after I die someone will take the papers in this chest for rubbish and throw them away. I am afraid your mother will say while cleaning, "They are only old papers." I am afraid you will save the pages but not the letters. I am also afraid that, because of my fear, I may make you indebted to something whose debt you never asked to carry.

Of these four fears, I do not know which has the stronger evidence. If that friend of yours who studies philosophy were here, perhaps they would make a list. I will not make one.

I will write you about one incident.

Long ago, when your mother first came to her parents' home after marriage, she brought a small tape recorder with her. She said to me, "Ma, sing the old songs; I will record them." I laughed. I said, "Where is my voice now?" She insisted. I sang two songs. In the middle of the third I forgot a line. I stopped.

Your mother said, "It is all right. Start again."

I sang again. Again I forgot a word.

I became irritated. "Turn this machine off."

She turned it off.

Years later I listened to that tape again. My voice was neither young nor clear. Every so often there was a cough. But where I had forgotten the words, those blank spaces too had been recorded.

Those blank spaces seemed the truest part to me.

Because a song is not only what was remembered; what was forgotten is part of it too.

Perhaps the history of a language is also such a recording. Some words are clear, some blurred, some silent in the middle. If we cut out the blank spaces and preserve only the beautiful part, where will the whole voice remain?

That is why in this letter I am not hiding my trembling hand. Several letters have gone crooked. In two places the ink has spread. In one place, in your name "Ira," I first turned the "r" the wrong way by mistake, then struck it out and wrote it again. If someone ever prints this, perhaps they will clean it up. Do not let them.

A mistake too is the testimony of a hand.

You may be surprised to hear that I thought of making a second copy of this letter in Devanagari. I even wrote half a page. Then I tore it up. I felt as though I were becoming the translator of my own letter - while still alive.

Translation is not wrong. I often change my way of speaking in order to talk with you. But sometimes the original paper too has the right to remain in its original script.

You have the right to read. The paper has the right to keep its letters. Between those two rights, there must be a bridge.

Perhaps you will build that bridge. Perhaps someone else will. Perhaps no one will.

My hand trembled a little while writing "no one."

I do not fear death as much as I fear remaining half-read. I laughed at myself after writing that sentence. Is it a person who dies, or a letter? Is it a person who is read, or a language? An old body is quick to perform the role of philosopher.

You may laugh at this performance.

If laughter survives, that too is one way for a language to survive.

I remember the day when you were small and said "ka-uā" instead of "kauā" for crow. Your mother corrected you at once. I stopped her: "Let her speak." Your mother said, "She will learn it wrong." I said, "First let her speak at all."

Now I think perhaps each of us was half right. One must learn, and one must speak. Without rules the letters can break apart; with nothing but rules the voice can dry up.

Ira, if someday you learn this old script, I will be glad. If you do not, I will not blame you - how could I, when I will no longer be here? But do one thing: do not keep the Maithili that is in your mouth hidden inside shame. Let it be broken, mixed, let the words come only after searching - even so, speak.

Language asks first for courage in the mouth, and only afterwards for grammar.

Scholars may strike this sentence out. Let them. A letter is not a scholarly paper.

A small lamp is burning on my table now. There is electricity, yet I have lit the lamp. You may remember asking, "Nani, why a lamp in the daytime?" I said, "Habit."

The truth is that in a lamp's light the raised surface of the paper appears differently. You can see where the ink is thick, where it is thin. Electric light opens everything at once; a lamp shows it a little at a time.

Perhaps memory too is lamplight. Not the whole room - only enough to write the next letter.

I am thinking of ending this letter, but I cannot find the last line. Your great-great-grandmother stopped at "I will write again tomorrow." I will not repeat that line. It would seem like imitation.

I could write, "Do not forget your language." But it would sound like an order.

I could write, "Remember me." But then the language would become small, reduced to my memory alone.

I could write, "Save the letters." That would become a burden.

So I am leaving the last line blank.

The blank line is not made of fear. It is your place.

If you ever read this, then, if you wish, write one sentence of your own there. In the old script, in Devanagari, in Roman letters - whatever is easiest for you. But write your own sentence.

Perhaps a language remains alive where, after another person's last line, someone writes their own first line.

— Your Nani"

After the letter there really was one blank line.

That night Saraswati Devi folded the letter and placed it inside the notebook. The next morning she did not prepare it for the post. Not the next day either. A week passed. The chest was closed again.

Three months later Ira came. The house was full of people, voices and movement; old clothes were being sorted, papers lay in heaps. Saraswati Devi was no longer there.

Ira found the notebook. She could read the Devanagari in the margin: "For Ira." She could not understand the letters inside.

She looked at the pages for a long time. In one corner of the paper was a small round stain of oil, perhaps from the lamp. In two places the ink had spread. One letter had been struck out and written again.

Ira's mother said, "I do not know all of it either. Kaki may be able to read it, perhaps."

Ira did not fold the pages. She left them spread out on the table.

Kaki came in the evening. She read the first line. Then the second. Slowly. Ira took out her mobile phone, then, without recording, turned it face down and set it aside.

"Read it again," she said.

Kaki read it again.

Late that night, after everyone had gone to sleep, Ira remained seated before the blank final line. She did not know how to write the old script.

She picked up a pencil. After thinking for a long time, she wrote in Devanagari -

"Nani, I will learn the first letter tomorrow."

She smiled a little after writing "tomorrow."

There was no lamp on the table. There was the small light of the mobile phone. She switched it off. In the first light of dawn coming through the window, her grandmother's crooked old letters and her own straight Devanagari could be seen on the same page.

The two were not translations of each other.

They came after one another.

— End of Story 12 —

13. The Panji (Final Entry)

STORY

Ishaan understood for the first time that old paper, too, can sometimes lie when Rameshwar Babu spread three photocopies before him and said, “Just write down one thing. Is this branch genuine or not?”

Ishaan looked at the papers. One was a copy of a jamabandi land record, another an old partition note, and the third a photocopy of a page from his own family’s Panji volume. At the bottom of that page, in thick blue-black ink, was written: “Vimal, son of the late Durganand; mother, Kamala.”

Rameshwar Babu placed a finger on the line. “If this line is true, my case ends. If it is false, theirs ends.”

Ishaan raised his eyes from the page. “A Panji alone will not decide a land dispute.”

“I am not saying that. The lawyer said to clarify the lineage. Once the lineage is clear, half the trouble will clear itself.”

Ishaan looked at the page again. His grandfather, Harinarayan Babu, had been a Panjekar for four decades. Ishaan had known the handwriting in the two large cloth-wrapped volumes at home since childhood. Harinarayan’s “da” remained slightly open; the head of his “sha” carried a delicate tilt; when he wrote dates, the numerals stood at even intervals. The hand in this line looked like his, and yet there was something his mind would not accept at once.

“I’ll have to see the original volume,” Ishaan said.

Rameshwar Babu took it as the opening of the first door to victory. “See it. See it today. I’ll wait.”

“Not today. I’ll examine it quietly at night.”

Rameshwar Babu laughed. “Does paper speak more truthfully at night?”

Ishaan did not answer. He remembered that his grandfather, too, often opened the Panji at night: a small brass lamp on the left, the book in the middle, a slender pen in his right hand. Grandfather used to say, “A harsh light shows everything at once. Lamplight says: look at this line first, then the next.”

That night Ishaan opened the Panji on his grandfather’s old table. The brass lamp was now his own, though its shape resembled Grandfather’s. There was electricity, yet he switched off the overhead light.

Page seventy-seven. At the top was Durganand’s marriage record; below it the marriage of his younger brother Shyamanand; then the affiliations of two daughters. All the writing had faded to a brownish black. At the end ran a thin horizontal line, Harinarayan’s customary mark for closing a branch.

Usually, the next branch began on a new page after such a line. But here, directly beneath it, without even leaving a margin, Vimal's entry had been wedged in with dark ink.

Ishaan first looked only at the letters. The hand was his grandfather's. There was little doubt about that. But Grandfather had broken his own rules. No date. No mark for "correction." No small triangle to the left of the line, the sign he used for information entered later.

A slight tightness came into Ishaan's chest. Had the handwriting not been Grandfather's, the matter would have been simple: someone else had forged it. But if it was Grandfather's hand?

He did not close the volume. For the next two hours he did nothing but compare his grandfather's handwriting. On page sixty-two, a daughter added later. On page eighty-four, a faulty date struck out and corrected. On page ninety-six, a note saying, "Information received subsequently." Everywhere Grandfather had made a later addition explicit. Everywhere except this line.

The flame trembled once. The dark line flashed for an instant. Ishaan had the strange feeling that the page itself was saying: I was not here from the beginning.

He wrote his first note on a separate sheet: "The entry appears to have been added after the original sequence; writer probably Harinarayan. Date absent. Amendment mark absent."

His hand stopped over the word "probably." Even writing "probably" beside his grandfather's name felt dishonest. Then he thought: let the sentence extend only as far as the evidence. Neither less nor more.

I

The plot called Dakkhinbari measured eleven kathas in all. Five old mango trees now stood there, along with two new houses, a motor pump, and an unpaved path through the middle. Its value no longer came from the mangoes but from the road that had drawn close to it.

Rameshwar Babu's side maintained that Durganand had died childless, so his share had reverted to the line of his elder brother Maheshwar. Madhav Babu's side maintained that Durganand had had a son, Vimal, and that half the land therefore belonged to Vimal's line.

Vimal was no longer alive. Of his two sons, Madhav, the younger, was now past seventy. Rameshwar Babu was Maheshwar's grandson. On paper the dispute lay between two old men; in the village everyone knew that the real dispute concerned the next generation's houses, the road-facing frontage, and the land's rising price.

Ishaan went first to Madhav Babu. He did not want his inquiry to rest on papers from only one side.

An old neem stood in Madhav Babu's courtyard. He sat beneath its shade on a charpoy. When he heard why Ishaan had come, his eyes narrowed.

"Did Rameshwar send you?"

“No. He came to show me some papers. But I’ll examine the matter in my own way.”

“Is my father’s name in the Panji or not?”

“It is.”

“Then what is there to examine?”

“When the entry was written, and how.”

Madhav Babu was silent for two moments. “If the name was written later, does that mean the man was born later?”

“No.”

“The Panjikar may have received the information later.”

“That is possible.”

“Then?”

“Then that should have been written. Grandfather used to note such things.”

Madhav Babu hooked a finger into the rope of the charpoy. “Will you put your own grandfather in the dock?”

Ishaan did not smile. “I’m not putting anyone in the dock.”

“Once papers are opened, the dock forms by itself.”

After saying this, Madhav Babu called inside: “Saroj, bring that old box.”

The box contained clothes, three wedding invitations, two land-revenue receipts, one school certificate belonging to Vimal, and a torn notebook. The school certificate named “Durganand” as the father. Ishaan checked the date. It had been issued when Vimal was twelve. Durganand had died roughly ten years after that—so, if Vimal was indeed his son, the dates were possible. The document did not contradict itself.

“You see?” Madhav Babu said.

“I see. This paper tells us that the school recorded Durganand as the father.”

“That is the truth, then.”

“The school record may have been the source for the Panji, and the Panji may have been the source for the school record. Each may also have copied the other.”

Madhav Babu grew a little irritated. “Why do educated people look at a straight matter from four directions?”

Ishaan wanted to say: because a straight matter has often already been straightened by someone. He did not say it.

At the bottom of the box was a small cloth pouch. Saroj opened it. Inside lay an old silver coin, a broken amulet, and a photograph of Kamala Devi. In the photograph a thin woman, a light veil over her head, held one hand on the shoulder of a small boy. Whether the boy was Vimal, Ishaan could not tell. On the back, in pencil, was written: “Kamala and Vimal, Sonapur fair.” The handwriting was not Harinarayan’s.

“This is my grandmother,” Madhav Babu said. His voice softened for the first time. “People tormented her badly. Father used to say that after Grandfather died, the family told mother and son to live separately. Once Panjikar Babu entered his name, everyone fell silent.”

Ishaan went perfectly still. “Panjikar Babu entered his name—did Vimal Babu himself say that?”

“Yes. Why?”

“I’m only asking.”

“He used to say, ‘If Harinarayan Babu had not been there, they would never have called me one of this household.’”

Ishaan put the photograph back into the pouch. The thick ink of the Panji entry was no longer merely a technical irregularity. Behind it now stood the question of whether a widow and a child would be allowed to remain in a home.

2

The next day Ishaan opened the room with the parapet in the old house. Papers from Grandfather’s time were stored there, though no diary. Harinarayan was not a man who kept a personal journal. He preserved documents—applications, marriage notices, panchayat decisions, expense slips, lineage notes written in other hands.

The smell of dust, dried neem leaves, old cloth. Ishaan opened bundle after bundle. “Eastern Hamlet,” “Northern Branch,” “Incomplete Information,” “For Correction”—labels in Grandfather’s hand.

Three hours later he found a thin bundle marked: “Durganand family—decision pending.”

Ishaan’s palms grew damp.

The first paper was an application bearing signatures from people of four villages. Its language was not formal, but direct: Durganand had died; his wife Kamala remained in the household; the boy Vimal was with her; there was a family dispute; the situation should be entered in the Panji. Beneath the application, in Harinarayan’s hand, was one line: “News of the child’s birth was not received at the original time; paternal relationship requires confirmation.”

The second paper contained statements from two people. One said Vimal was Durganand’s son. The other said, “The boy is the son of Kamala’s sister; Kamala brought him up.”

The third paper was half torn. At the top only this survived: “Before the panchayat...” At the bottom were five thumbprints. In the middle, mention of the land: “Kamala shall enjoy five kathas in Dakkhinbari for the duration of her life...” The rest had been eaten away at the edge.

Ishaan leaned back in the chair. Five kathas. Five out of eleven. The family had at some point acknowledged some right of life enjoyment for Kamala. But whether Vimal had been accepted as a natural-born son was not clear here.

The fourth paper was the smallest. An undated slip, three lines in Harinarayan’s hand:

“Vimal is said to be fostered. If she is turned out of the house, Kamala will be left destitute. The Panji cannot alter truth out of compassion.”

Ishaan stared at the slip for a long time. The last line sounded like his grandfather's explicit judgment: The Panji cannot alter truth out of compassion.

Then how had "Vimal, son of Durganand" appeared in heavy ink on page seventy-seven?

There was no fifth paper in the bundle. Only some dust caught in a fold of cloth.

For the first time the matter seemed to Ishaan less like a mystery than an unfinished sentence inside his own house. Grandfather had written "no" one day. Later he had written "yes." What happened in between?

That evening he sat beside his mother. She was eighty-five. Grandfather Harinarayan had been her father-in-law. Ishaan asked, "Do you remember Kamala Devi?"

At first his mother shook her head. Then, after a little while, she said, "Very thin. Always kept her eyes lowered. From that household?"

"Durganand's wife."

"Yes, yes. Her boy Vimal. A very bright boy."

"Did people say that Vimal was her sister's son?"

His mother looked carefully at Ishaan. "Where did you find that?"

"In the papers."

She stopped cutting betel nut. "You're opening all those old papers?"

"It's work."

"Work often stirs up the old dust of a house."

"What was true?"

She did not answer immediately. "I had only recently come into this family then. Women used to talk among themselves. I had heard that Kamala had brought up her sister's boy. Durganand had no child of his own. But no one wanted to say it openly. The boy grew up in the house. I also heard that Durganand treated him as his own."

"A formal adoption?"

"How would I know? Were women shown papers in those days?"

Ishaan fell silent.

His mother resumed cutting the betel nut. "Harinarayan Babu was very troubled by the matter."

Ishaan's breath caught. "You remember?"

"One night he and your father talked for a long time. I had gone in to give them water. Harinarayan Babu was saying, 'The boy was called a son in that house for fifteen years. The dead man's pyre has barely gone cold and now they will call him an outsider—what kind of justice is that?' Your father said, 'Then will you write into the Panji what is not there?' He fell silent."

"And then?"

"Then I came away. Where did I have the leisure to listen to every conversation among the men?"

The line from Grandfather's slip rose again in Ishaan's mind: The Panji cannot alter truth out of compassion. Perhaps that night the question had reversed itself—was truth only the fact of birth, or also fifteen years of acknowledged life?

But the Panji was not a philosophical essay. A single line could become fact from generation to generation.

3

In the third week of his inquiry Ishaan went to see Lakshminath Kaka. His age was said to be ninety-three, though he himself insisted, "Ninety-three is what they wrote; I may well be ninety-five." He had been an old neighbour of Durganand's family. His hearing was poor, and his memory worked selectively.

Ishaan did not ask the direct question first. He began with Durganand, cultivation, floods, the old road. Half an hour later Vimal's name came up.

Lakshminath Kaka laughed. "Vimal? He was Kamala's very life."

"Durganand's son?"

Kaka stopped laughing. "Son... yes, in the household he was a son."

"By birth?"

Kaka looked at Ishaan for a long time. "Have you come to make a document or to make a story?"

"To understand the truth."

"If you want the truth in one sentence, you have come to the wrong place."

Ishaan waited.

Kaka said, "Kamala's sister died in childbirth. The boy survived. Her natal family was poor. Kamala brought him home. Durganand said, 'He will live here.' From that day Vimal was his son. At the sacred-thread ceremony, Durganand sat as the father. At school, his name was entered as father. No one in the village said otherwise. After Durganand died and the question of land arose, everyone suddenly remembered birth."

"And in the Panji?"

"He was not there at first. That much I know, because Harinarayan Babu had asked me too."

"What did you tell him?"

"What I had seen. Sister's boy. But son of Durganand's household."

"What did Grandfather say?"

Kaka half closed his eyes. "He said, 'How am I to write both things together?' I told him, 'Write as much as the belly of the paper can hold.' He did not laugh."

Something became suddenly clear inside Ishaan. Perhaps this had been the problem before Grandfather too: the two truths would not fit into a single line. Biological birth was one thing; social sonship another. If Grandfather had written "fostered," would the family have refused to treat Vimal as an heir? If he wrote "son," the truth of birth disappeared.

"Was there a panchayat decision?" Ishaan asked.

Kaka nodded at once. "Yes. Five kathas for Kamala. But a year later Maheshwar's sons began ploughing it. Kamala came crying. Harinarayan Babu called another panchayat. What happened after that... I do not remember clearly."

“Was the name entered in the Panji after that?”

Kaka opened his eyes. “Could be. I cannot give you a date. But I remember one thing: Harinarayan Babu came back from Maheshwar’s house furious. He said, ‘If they will not honour a spoken decision, they will learn to honour a written one.’”

A shiver passed through Ishaan.

The sentence was not conclusive proof. No date, no second witness. Yet for the first time a possible sequence appeared: a panchayat decision, its breach, fear that the widow would be dispossessed, the Panjekar’s anger, and then the later entry in dark ink.

A forgery born of compassion? Or resistance to injustice? The words seemed to demand that he choose a side. Ishaan did not want to choose either.

Even then he was not satisfied. Oral memory and household papers pointed in the same direction, but he feared that he was reading the evidence to fit one of two stories already forming in his mind—Grandfather’s crime or Grandfather’s compassion.

So he went to see Dakkhinbari himself.

The road now ran very close to the land. Of the five old mango trees, two leaned toward Rameshwar Babu’s house and three toward Madhav Babu’s side. The earthen boundary through the middle had almost vanished. At one spot stood an old brick foundation, over which Madhav’s younger son had erected a tin roof. The pump’s pipe ran toward Rameshwar’s field as well. On paper the land was disputed; in life it was both shared and quarrelled over.

There he met an old cultivator named Sitaram, who had once ploughed for Durganand’s household. Ishaan asked only about the ages of the trees.

Sitaram pointed to them one by one. “These three were planted by Vimal. Those two by Maheshwar’s sons. The tree in the middle was lost to lightning.”

“Did Vimal cultivate this land?”

“With Kamala. About five kathas. Then there was a quarrel. Then it was ploughed again.”

“By whom?”

Sitaram laughed. “In a land dispute, if you ask ‘whose,’ everyone will give you his own name.”

He went toward the southern edge of the plot. Scraping at the earth near an old boundary, Sitaram showed him a brick. “Kamala’s little house stood here. Bamboo walls. Half of it went in a flood; later the rest was dismantled.”

Ishaan remembered the photograph—Kamala, the boy Vimal, the light veil over her head. A sentence from a paper suddenly took hold of the soil. The danger of becoming shelterless had not been a metaphor. Her house had literally stood on the edge of these five kathas.

The facts grew complicated again. If Kamala had been given five kathas for life enjoyment, Vimal had grown up on that land. If the Panji later declared him a son, the declaration had not created an entitlement out of nothing; it had given the rigid language of lineage to a life already being lived. Yet that did not make a false statement of birth correct.

Ishaan also went to the old block records room. There was dust, bound bundles, red cloth tape, and the tired face of an employee searching through papers. The complete history of the land was not easy to recover. After three days of searching, two old revenue slips were found: in one year, five kathas were noted under "Kamala, widow of Durganand" for enjoyment; in the next year, her name on the same slip had been struck out and replaced by the name of Maheshwar's branch. No reason for the alteration was recorded.

Ishaan sat for a long time looking at the slip. The panchayat's arrangement had, at least once, entered official paper. Then it had been erased.

The employee said, "Old slips have a great deal of cutting and overwriting. Do not decide anything from this alone."

Ishaan nodded. He liked the caution. More important than the pleasure of finding evidence was knowing its limit.

On the way home he wondered: had Grandfather perhaps seen this struck-out name? Had he written the heavy line after that? But "perhaps" was filling everything. His task was to write the limits of inference alongside the evidence.

When he reached home, a new difficulty was waiting. His uncle Govardhan had come. He had always behaved as if he were the guardian of Grandfather's reputation. Ishaan's mother had probably told him something.

"I hear you are examining Harinarayan Babu's writing," Uncle said.

"Yes."

"For outsiders?"

"It concerns a lineage dispute."

"You are going to prove your own ancestor a liar?"

Ishaan was tired, but kept his voice low. "I am not working to prove anyone anything."

Uncle struck the table with his palm. "Do not give me this educated phrasing. What will the village say? That Harinarayan the Panjekar falsified the record?"

"If a fact was entered falsely, that must be written."

"Must every old matter be dug up?"

Ishaan corrected him at once. "It must be, if that line is being used today to claim land."

Uncle fell silent for a moment. "Your grandfather never took anyone's money."

Ishaan was startled. "I never mentioned money."

His uncle's face changed. "I am only saying."

"Do you remember something?"

"No."

"Kaka?"

"It is an old matter."

After much pressing, Govardhan related one incident. Maheshwar's eldest son had once given Harinarayan thirty-two rupees. The village had murmured that the Panjekar had taken money. Govardhan had been a teenager then; he had heard only whispers.

Ishaan's body tightened again. If Grandfather had taken money from Maheshwar's side, then why had the later "son" entry benefited the opposite side? Or was the payment for something else? The incident pointed nowhere, yet in defending the family, his uncle had inadvertently opened another suspicion.

Ishaan returned to the bundles of papers. Thirty-two rupees was not a trivial sum. Searching for the number among Harinarayan's old expense slips was difficult, but two days later he found "32." On the slip was written: "Marriage information for Maheshwar's eldest son's daughter, five family copies, including travel—32 rupees received."

Beneath it was Grandfather's signature. The date was four years before the Vimal dispute.

Ishaan sat down and laughed. The laughter was relief, but also directed at himself. The moment he had heard a number, he had built a story of bribery in his mind. Hunger for evidence can spin stories too. It is not only interested parties who weave nets from their suspicions; investigators do it as well.

In his notes he wrote: "Report of thirty-two rupees—unrelated fee for marriage information; no basis for linking it to this dispute."

That sentence was not necessary in anyone's final report, but Ishaan kept it for himself. A record of the mistake he had nearly made belonged in the inquiry too.

Then he found a copy of an old application written when Vimal was a young man. In it Vimal had entered his name as "Vimal, son of Kamala"—the father field left blank. The date appeared to precede the Panji entry. Was that conclusive? No. Someone could deliberately leave the father field blank. But it showed that Vimal's identity had not appeared uniformly across the documents of his life. At school: "Durganand." In this application: "son of Kamala." In the Panji: "son of Durganand."

Ishaan placed the three photocopies in a row.

At that moment he understood that "lineage" was often not a straight line of blood but a series of different answers given to different institutions. The school asked: father's name? The village asked: whose household? The Panji asked: which branch? Land asked: who is the heir? And a woman asked: will anyone turn my child out of the house?

Grandfather's dark line had turned all those questions into a single answer. That was its strength, and that was its flaw.

4

The matter became more difficult when Rameshwar Babu returned. This time his younger son Ravindra came with him, a businessman in the city. He carried a bundle of papers and impatience in his voice.

"How much longer?" Ravindra asked.

"The inquiry is nearly complete."

"Then write that the entry is a later one."

"I will write that it is later. But I will write the whole matter as well."

“What whole matter?”

Ishaan mentioned the application, the panchayat decision, and the oral testimonies. Ravindra’s face hardened.

“Will all this sentimentality stand in court?”

“I am not writing a story for the court. I will record what I found.”

“Is the Panji wrong or not?”

“The entry presents itself as an original birth record, but the available material indicates that Vimal was born to Kamala’s sister and was raised as a son by Durganand and Kamala. The entry was added later, probably after the family dispute.”

Ravindra laughed, without respect in the laughter. “Then it is simple forgery.”

Ishaan looked at him. “Use words carefully.”

“Why? Because your grandfather wrote it?”

The room suddenly felt small. Rameshwar Babu glanced at his son but did not stop him.

Ishaan spoke slowly. “To call it forgery, intention, process, and fact must all be made clear. I can say that a fact was recorded inaccurately. There are indications it was done knowingly. But whose benefit it served, and under what circumstances, must be recorded too.”

Ravindra closed his bundle of papers. “I do not need a history of benefits. I need proof.”

“Then you have come to the wrong person. In history, evidence without circumstance is incomplete; circumstance without evidence is darkness.”

Rameshwar Babu spoke for the first time. “I respected your grandfather, Ishaan. But what is false is false.”

“Yes.”

“Then write it.”

“I will.”

“Not in such a way that the reader cannot understand what you mean.”

What hurt Ishaan was not that Grandfather might be called wrong. What hurt was that both sides wanted to turn Grandfather’s error into a one-line advantage for themselves. The complexity with which Grandfather may have wrestled was being flattened again.

That night Ishaan drafted his note. He changed the first sentence ten times. “The entry is false”—too harsh, because the social sonship had been real. “The entry is doubtful”—too mild, because the claim of biological paternity had weak support. Finally he wrote:

“The entry on page 77 describing Vimal as the son of Durganand was added after the original sequence had been closed. Earlier family notices, panchayat papers, and living testimony support the conclusion that Vimal was by birth the son of Kamala’s sister, but was brought up by Durganand and Kamala as their son. The entry should therefore be read not as a contemporaneous birth record, but as a later familial recognition/intervention.”

He stopped at the word “intervention.” It was a cold word, but accurate.

Then a second paragraph:

“Ownership or inheritance in the land should not be regarded as proved or disproved solely by this Panji line; the separate documents relating to possession, partition, and legal records must be examined independently.”

Ishaan put down his pen. He knew the sentence would please neither side. Perhaps that was why it was right.

But one question remained: why, finally, had Grandfather written the line? Ishaan did not want to judge his grandfather's ethics on inference alone.

5

The answer appeared where he had not been looking for it at all.

The old household shrine was being repaired. When the wooden platform was moved, a thin envelope slipped from behind it. On the envelope, in Grandfather's hand, was written: “For Harinarayan Panjika— from Kamala.”

Ishaan's first reaction was: let this not turn into the sort of letter-mystery that belongs in Story 16. He laughed at himself. Life does not read outlines. If there was a letter, there was a letter.

Inside the envelope was not a letter but a single small sheet. Whether Kamala had written it herself or had it written by someone else was unclear. Instead of a signature there was a thumbprint. The language was plain:

“Babu, the panchayat's word has not been honoured. They have ploughed the five kathas. If I go to my natal home with Vimal, there is no place there either. You said you would not write a lie. I am not asking you to write a lie. But do not write as an outsider the boy who lived as a son in this house for fifteen years. When Durganand was dying, his hand was on Vimal's head. There is no paper for this fact. If you do not accept this as paper, how am I to prove it?”

That was all.

Ishaan read it three times. After the sentence “I am not asking you to write a lie,” the distance between Grandfather's slip—“The Panji cannot alter truth out of compassion”—and the heavy entry suddenly seemed very small.

Perhaps Grandfather had failed to find a third word between falsehood and justice. In the end he chose one word: “son.” That word gave Kamala a home, but erased the distinction of birth. For one generation it was protection, for the next a right, for the third a weapon.

Ishaan felt angry with his grandfather—an anger that came from within love. He could have written “raised as a son.” He could have written “fostered.” He could have made a separate note. He could have attached the panchayat decision. Why had he turned one word into the whole truth?

Then Ishaan stopped himself. The question was being asked from the comfort of the present. At that time the power of paper had been different, the widow's insecurity different, the pressure of the family different. But understanding circumstance did not make the error right. It only showed its shape.

Ishaan lit Grandfather's brass lamp. He placed Kamala's sheet beside the Panji. The heavy line shone again. Now it no longer looked merely like "forgery"; it looked like the mark of an impatient moral decision.

But the eleven kathas of land were still a living dispute. Old compassion could not sanctify a new injustice.

After finding the note, Ishaan did not rush to a conclusion. He divided a large sheet into four sections: "Birth," "Household," "Land," "Panji."

Under "Birth" he wrote: son of Kamala's sister; two oral testimonies; "son of Kamala" in an old application.

Under "Household": raised by Durganand and Kamala; Durganand acted as father at the sacred-thread ceremony; school record named Durganand as father; accepted in the village as a son.

Under "Land": panchayat arrangement giving Kamala life enjoyment of five kathas; one year of revenue record; name later struck out; complaint of dispossession.

Under "Panji": dark ink after closure of the original sequence; Harinarayan's hand; no date; no correction mark; the word "son" without context.

The four sections told four different things. The problem began when later people made the "Panji" section the master of the other three.

Ishaan added a fifth section: "Benefit."

This was the most difficult section to write. In Harinarayan's time, the benefit was to Kamala and Vimal—to remain in the household, preserve the claim to five kathas, escape social humiliation. The loss fell on Maheshwar's branch—their exclusive lineal claim was broken. In the next generation the benefit passed to Vimal's sons—a claim of inheritance in Dakkhinbari. Today the shape of benefit had changed again: the value of roadside land, access for the house, the motor pump, the possibility of sale.

The same line had performed three different functions across three generations.

Looking at the list, Ishaan understood that the morality of a document does not remain fixed. An entry that may once have protected the weak can, when time changes, become the foundation of a powerful claim. But that transformation does not turn the original inaccuracy into truth.

In his notebook he wrote: "Do not excuse a falsehood written out of compassion merely by calling it compassion; neither erase an old act of compassion as fraud merely because a later injustice has grown upon it."

He did not put that sentence into the report. It was not an archival note. It was his own lesson.

That night his mother saw the sheet divided into four sections on his table. "You have made so many boxes. In which box is the truth?"

Ishaan did not smile. "Perhaps a little in all of them."

His mother said, "Then why does everyone look for only one box?"

"Because the land has to be awarded in one place."

Whether his mother understood exactly what he meant, Ishaan could not tell. But as he gathered the papers, he understood that this was the crisis of records: life has many compartments; decisions run in a single line.

Ishaan called both sides on the same day. On the veranda sat Rameshwar Babu, Ravindra, Madhav Babu, his son Saroj, and two elderly men from the village. Ishaan did not bring out the Panji. First he read his written note.

The moment the first paragraph ended, Ravindra said, "Enough. That is sufficient."

Ishaan raised a hand and stopped him. He read the second paragraph—the Panji was not, by itself, proof of the land. Ravindra's face fell.

Madhav Babu asked, "Then my father was not Durganand's son?"

Ishaan said, "By birth, the available evidence does not say so. By life—he grew up as a son in Durganand's household. I have to write both things."

"As a son?" Madhav Babu's voice trembled. "My father called his father Babu, lit his pyre, ploughed his field, saved the house. And now you will add 'as'?"

Silence fell over the veranda.

Ishaan looked at him. "I understand that the word hurts."

"No, you do not. Sons of paper understand paper; they do not understand sons of the spoken word."

Rameshwar Babu broke in. "Then divide the land by spoken word too."

Madhav Babu sprang up. "Your house did not even leave her those five kathas!"

Ravindra stood too. "That panchayat slip was for life enjoyment, not lineage!"

Voices rose. For a moment Ishaan thought: perhaps this was why Grandfather had wanted to end the quarrel with a single word. But a dispute can be pressed beneath paper; it does not die there.

"Sit down," Ishaan said loudly. "I am not conducting a panchayat to divide land. I am clarifying only what the Panji says."

No one sat.

Ishaan went inside and brought Kamala's small sheet. "This has been found."

Madhav Babu took it in his hand. The moment he saw the thumbprint, his face changed. Saroj moved closer. Ishaan read the note aloud.

"You said you would not write a lie... but do not write as an outsider the boy who lived as a son in this house for fifteen years..."

He finished reading.

No one spoke for a long time.

Rameshwar Babu said softly, "My grandfather did not honour the panchayat's word?"

Ishaan answered, "The papers say five kathas were set aside for life enjoyment. Lakshminath Kaka says they were ploughed over a year later. That is oral testimony, not a final judgment. But Kamala's own note makes the same complaint."

For the first time Ravindra did not open his bundle of papers.

Madhav Babu kept the note in his lap. "My father used to say that his mother cried a great deal. I thought it was because she was widowed. I never knew this."

Ishaan saw that because of one old inaccuracy, the question was no longer merely “whose land.” Every side was now being forced to see its ancestors in a new form.

“I will not strike Vimal’s name from the Panji,” Ishaan said.

Ravindra looked up at once. “Why?”

“Because striking out the name would create a second falsehood. This entry has become part of history. I will record its nature—later, made in the middle of a dispute, and converting a relationship of being raised as a son into the word ‘son.’ The original line will remain as it is; a note will stand beside it.”

Madhav Babu asked, “Then my father’s honour?”

“Honour will not be made by cutting or preserving a line. The life he lived must be recorded.”

Rameshwar Babu asked, “And the land?”

“The land will be decided by the land records. Not by the Panji alone.”

Ravindra said angrily, “So after two months of inquiry, back to court.”

Ishaan remained calm. “Truth is not always the shortest road.”

7

Two weeks later the Dakkhinbari matter came up again at the tehsil. Ishaan did not go. Both sides gave his note to their lawyers. What the court would decide is not what this story waits for. The land dispute continued. In the meantime an interim understanding was reached: both families would use the motor pump, and that year’s mango crop would be divided equally. Ravindra called the arrangement “pointless”; Saroj said, “At least it stops the fighting for now.”

Ishaan had another task.

He opened the Panji. Page seventy-seven. The dark line was unchanged. There was very little space beside it. Perhaps Grandfather had deliberately left none, as if he wanted the decision to appear final.

Ishaan did not choose blue ink. He took a fine black pen. To the left of the line he drew a small triangle—the same sign Harinarayan had used for information added later.

Then, on the next blank page, he wrote a note:

“The entry concerning Vimal on the preceding page was added after the original sequence, in the hand of Panjekar Harinarayan. According to the available family application, panchayat papers, Kamala Devi’s petition, and oral testimony, Vimal was by birth the son of Kamala Devi’s sister, but was raised as a son by Durganand and Kamala. During a family dispute he was recorded as ‘son.’ The purpose of this note is not to erase the original entry but to clarify its context. Decision regarding land/inheritance depends upon separate records.”

At the end he wrote the date. His full name. He did not add “grandson of Harinarayan.” Only: “Ishaan, keeper of records.”

When he put down the pen, he felt not an odd lightness but a weight. Writing the truth does not by itself set anyone free. From now on,

Grandfather's decision and the grandson's correction would remain together in the Panji. The next generation might question both. That was right.

His mother came and stood in the doorway. "You wrote it?"

"Yes."

"Did your grandfather's name become bad?"

Ishaan smiled faintly. "I did not decide whether his name was good or bad."

His mother came inside and looked at the page. The letters were difficult for her to read. "What have you written in all these little words?"

Ishaan read it aloud. His mother remained silent for a long time. Then she said, "If Harinarayan Babu were alive, he would be angry with you."

Ishaan laughed. "For how many days?"

"Two. On the third day he would add something to the note himself."

They both laughed.

Evening was falling. Ishaan lit the lamp. His mother said, "There is electricity."

"I know."

The lamp's slanting light fell on page seventy-seven. Faded old ink, the dark later line, and the new black note on the next page—three times visible within the same volume. None had erased another.

Ishaan suddenly understood that preserving an archive does not mean preserving paper alone. Error too has to be preserved—but with the fact that it is error written beside it. How compassion altered fact, how fact became a right, how a right could become greed—if that sequence were erased, history would once again become straight according to everyone's convenience.

Before closing the Panji, he looked one last time at Grandfather's dark line. It was still there: "Vimal, son of the late Durganand; mother, Kamala."

After the line there was now a mark. The mark sent the reader to the next page.

The Panji's "final entry" was no longer final.

— *End of Story 13* —

14. Twins

STORY

I

Amitesh Jha already knew his blood group—O positive. When teaching science at school, he would explain blood groups to the children, write A, B, AB, O on paper, draw red discs, and finally say, “These four boxes are not the whole identity of a human being. They are only one system of blood.”

Sitting in the hospital consultation room that day, he kept remembering his own sentence.

His mother, Malini Devi, was to undergo knee surgery. During the routine tests, the doctor had also recorded the family’s blood groups, because an emergency could arise on the day of the operation. Father, Suresh Jha—AB positive. Mother—O positive. Amitesh—O positive.

The junior doctor first fell silent while looking at the sheet, then asked again, “Are you certain of your blood group?”

“It has been tested three times.”

“And your mother’s and father’s?”

“Just now, in your lab.”

The doctor turned the paper toward him. “Under ordinary ABO inheritance, an AB and an O parent are not expected to have an O child. But do not draw any family conclusion from one blood group. There are rare exceptions, sample errors, old information—many possibilities. This has no bearing on the operation. If the question stays in your mind, you can repeat the tests.”

Malini Devi laughed. “Doctor Babu, this is my son. Look at his face—he has taken his father’s nose.”

Suresh Jha laughed too, but Amitesh noticed that the laughter did not reach his eyes.

“I do not examine the genetics of noses,” the doctor said with a smile. “Let us talk about the knee for now.”

The matter could have ended there. In countless homes such a small medical remark disappears over afternoon tea. But Amitesh taught science. There was a flaw in him where questions were concerned: once a “why” had arisen, he could not extinguish it merely by laying faith over it.

That evening, after bringing his mother home, he looked for his old certificates. Birth certificate—21 August, 11:40 p.m. Place—District Women’s Hospital. That was the year of the Kamala flood. The story had often been told at home: on the night Amitesh was born, half the city was submerged in

darkness; the generator kept failing; there was water outside and overcrowding inside.

Malini Devi used to say, “When you were born, three women were groaning in labour in my room at the same time. The nurses were running about. When they brought you to me, the first thing I asked was, ‘Where is my baby?’ They said, ‘Right here.’ I said, ‘How is he so fair?’ The nurse burst out laughing.”

The story had always been funny. That night, for the first time, Amitesh heard it as a question.

The next day he had his blood tested again. The result was the same. His parents were tested at another laboratory as well. Their results were the same too.

He placed the papers on the table and stared at them for a long time. Four letters—AB, O, O—suddenly weighed more than thirty years of family history.

After dinner Suresh Jha asked, “Why did you get the tests repeated?”

Amitesh did not lie. “The question stayed in my mind.”

Malini Devi stopped with the plate in her hand. “What question?”

“What the doctor said.”

“Doctors should examine illness. Not homes.”

Amitesh regretted it immediately. He understood that a scientific question remains neutral on paper, but when it arrives at the dining plate it can sound like an accusation against someone’s motherhood.

“Ma, I am not questioning you.”

“Then whom are you questioning?”

He had no answer.

2

Malini Devi’s surgery was successful. For two weeks the household revolved around the bandage on her knee, medicines, heating water, arranging bedding. Amitesh deliberately did not raise the blood-group question. He hoped time would make it smaller. But the question did not dissolve in time; it settled like sediment at the bottom.

One day his mother was sorting old clothes. The iron trunk beneath the bed was open. Amitesh saw a torn plastic bag marked in black ink: “Hospital 1995.”

“What is this?”

His mother said casually, “Probably papers from your birth. Throw it away. How much rubbish can we keep?”

Amitesh did not throw it away. With permission he opened it. Two prescriptions, post-delivery instructions, one fee receipt, and a thin yellowing sheet. Printed on it: “Mother: Malini Jha.” Beneath that, handwritten: “Male, 2.9 kg, 21/8, 23:32.” At the side, in black ink, the code “B-17.”

The birth certificate gave the time as 11:40. An eight-minute difference was not important. But what was B-17?

“Was there a tag on you?” Amitesh asked.

Malini Devi thought. “Not on my hand. Something was tied to the baby’s foot. The nurse read it out to me. I was half unconscious.”

“What did it say?”

“How can I remember something from so long ago?”

From behind his newspaper Suresh Jha said, “Amitesh, leave it now. Let your mother rest.”

His tone was ordinary, but there was more pleading than command in “leave it.”

That night Amitesh photographed the B-17 paper and put the original back in the trunk. Searching the internet seemed pointless; where would he find an old hospital code online? The next day he went to the district hospital. The old building had become a mother-and-child centre; the records office was in a new wing.

The employee at the counter laughed at first. “A delivery record from thirty years ago? You might do better at the archaeology department.”

Amitesh laughed too. “If it has been destroyed, tell me so. But please look first.”

After three applications, one copy of his identity document, and the superintendent’s signature, he was told that most daily registers from the 1990s had been lost to water damage and relocation. Some maternity lists existed on microfilm, but the collection was incomplete.

The elderly records assistant looked at B-17 and said, “B probably meant baby-bed number. Babies were kept in a separate nursery then. Tags were tied after birth. During power cuts, labels were written by hand.”

“Was there another baby beside number seventeen?”

“Who can say without the register?”

“Who was on duty that night?”

The assistant scratched his head. “Some of the old staff are retired. I remember a Sister Sushma. She may be living with her daughter in Madhubani now.”

“Address?”

“A hospital is not an address book.”

Amitesh was turning away in disappointment when the assistant called after him. “Wait. Look at this.”

He had opened a scan of a thick register. Date: 21 August. The writing was blurred. One line read: “Malini Jha—M—23:32—B17.” The next line: “Kunti Mandal—M—23:36—B18.”

Four minutes apart. Two sons. Two adjacent beds.

A chill ran through Amitesh.

He wrote down the name—Kunti Mandal.

When he returned home he did not mention the name. Late into the night he kept writing B17 and B18 on paper. What he was doing felt childish, as though adding two numbers might unlock the mystery of a life.

Yet the next morning he submitted an application to trace Kunti Mandal’s old address through the hospital’s public birth records.

Kunti Mandal's old address was in Parasauni, fourteen kilometres from the city. Amitesh did not go there at once. For many days he kept asking himself: what right did he have to raise thirty-year-old motherhood in someone else's house? One blood group and two bed numbers were not enough.

He went to his former classmate Dr Neelima, who worked in genetic counselling. After showing her all the papers, he asked, "What should I do?"

Neelima first clarified the medical point. "A blood-group inconsistency can raise a question; it is not conclusive proof. Rare biological exceptions occur. Sample or record errors are also possible. If every family member agrees, a relationship test can be done at an accredited laboratory. But think before testing—whatever the result, you may change several lives."

"Have the lives not changed already?"

"So far, only your mind has changed. Once a report comes, four or five people's homes will change."

Amitesh said nothing.

Neelima asked, "Are your parents ready for such a test?"

"Father refuses even to speak about it. Mother hears the question as an insult."

"Then get their consent first. Secretly collecting samples is not a good road to truth."

That sentence stopped Amitesh.

Three days later he sat with his parents. He did not place the papers before them. He said only, "I need to say one thing. If you ask me to leave it, I will leave it. But the question will remain inside me."

Suresh Jha looked at him for a long time. "You have reached the name Kunti Mandal?"

Malini Devi turned toward him. "You know that name?"

Amitesh's breath caught.

Suresh Jha folded the newspaper. "I remember the night of the birth. I did not remember the full name, only the surname Mandal. That woman's baby was beside ours."

"Why did you never tell me?" Amitesh asked.

"Because thirty years ago there had already been a confusion once."

Malini Devi's face went pale. "What confusion?"

Suresh Jha spoke very slowly. "On the third day after we brought you home, a man came from the hospital. He said there had been a complaint about a baby's tag being read wrongly. He wanted to see the band on your foot. It had fallen off before we reached home."

Malini Devi clutched the bedsheet in her fist. "You never told me this."

"You had fever after the delivery. The doctor said the baby was healthy and told me not to worry by looking at faces. The hospital man never came back after that. I thought the mistake had been corrected."

"And you stayed silent for thirty years?"

"I was afraid."

"Afraid of what?"

Suresh Jha's voice broke. "Afraid of losing you."

Amitesh understood for the first time that the question was not his alone. For thirty years his father had been sitting on a possibility he had buried. Today's scientific paper had lifted the lid from that old fear.

Malini Devi did not cry. She asked only, "What if that child was not mine?"

Suresh Jha gave no answer.

Amitesh said softly, "Ma, you are my mother. This test will not change that."

Malini Devi replied at once, "You can say that now. Will you say it after the report too?"

Amitesh wanted to answer, but understood that promises are easy; consequences are hard to live. He only took his mother's hand.

After a while Malini Devi herself said, "Do the test. I do not want to live the rest of my life inside half a truth."

Suresh Jha lowered his head. "Take my sample too."

4

Vimal Mandal's tailoring shop in Parasauni stood beside the main road. Amitesh could find no way to telephone first. The hospital's old address still carried the family name, but no house number. A local postman gave him the location of the shop.

He had planned to ask only whether Kunti Mandal was still alive. But the moment he entered the shop, the plan collapsed.

The man seated behind the counter was about his age. Dark complexion, broad forehead, a small scar above the right eyebrow. He stopped the sewing machine and asked, "What do you need?"

Amitesh kept looking at him. The face was unfamiliar, and yet something in it struck him with the shock of recognition. The nose? The chin? The corner of the eyes? Once the mind starts searching for resemblance, it finds faces even in clouds, Amitesh warned himself.

"Kunti Mandal's house?"

The man stood. "She is my mother. And you are?"

"Amitesh Jha. It concerns some old hospital papers."

The man's hand stopped on the machine. "Which hospital?"

"District Women's Hospital. 21 August 1995."

This time his face truly changed.

"Your birthday?" he asked.

"Yes."

The man pulled out a chair and sat down. "Mine too."

Inside the shop, the sewing machine wheel slowed and stopped by itself.

"Your name?"

"Raghav Mandal."

Amitesh remembered the B18 line.

After a while Raghav shut the shop and took him home. Kunti Devi was cleaning makhana in the back courtyard. Vimal Mandal, Raghav's father, could see poorly because of diabetes, but his voice was sharp.

Amitesh did not begin in the middle. He explained everything in order: the hospital register, the blood-group question, his father's old memory. "I have not come with a conclusion. I have only come to ask whether any such question ever arose in your family."

Kunti Devi's hands stopped over the makhana.

Vimal Mandal said, "Raghav, there is a red box on top of the cupboard. Bring it."

Inside the box was a small cloth pouch. From it emerged a hospital tag—dingy plastic, half-erased lettering. What remained legible was: "Br7."

Amitesh's hands went cold.

"This was taken off my baby's foot," Kunti Devi said. "After we came home. On the third day someone from the hospital came and said it should have been Br8. I told him, 'But this says Br7.' He wanted to take the tag. I refused."

"Then?"

"Then he said not to worry, that it was a writing mistake. The baby was ours."

Raghav sat bolt upright in his chair. "Ma, you never told me this."

"What was I supposed to say? 'Son, there was another number on your foot?'" Kunti Devi's voice was not bitter, only tired. "The baby drank my milk; he knew my breast. How could a hospital number separate him from me?"

Vimal Mandal said quietly, "I was afraid too. If poor people fought the hospital, who would listen? And if the babies really had been exchanged, would we return the child we had brought home? In three days he had become ours."

Amitesh looked at Raghav. Raghav was looking at him too. Perhaps in that same instant they thought the same thing: what shape must a bond made in three days acquire over thirty years?

Raghav asked his first question. "Your blood group?"

"O."

"I'm B positive."

"And your parents?"

Kunti Devi said, "I am A. He is O."

Raghav did not teach science, but he understood from Amitesh's face that this combination raised a question too.

"So?"

Amitesh stopped him at once. "Blood group is not proof. Even now, there is no conclusion."

Raghav laughed, anger inside the laughter. "You are a teacher?"

"Yes."

"That is why you say everything slowly. Right now I feel as if somebody has told me a thirty-year joke all at once."

Kunti Devi rose and went inside.

Raghav did not stop her. Neither did Amitesh.

The decision to take a genetic relationship test was not made by the two families together at once. Their first meeting produced only disagreement.

Malini Devi said, "I want to see Kunti Devi, but not before the report."

Kunti Devi said, "I am not coming to take away anybody's child."

Suresh Jha kept saying, "Think about the legal complications."

Vimal Mandal said, "Law later. Human beings first."

Raghav said, "I will take the test. I have a daughter. She has a right to know her family medical history."

Amitesh found this the most stable reason of all. He too was ready.

In the end all four parents and both sons agreed. Neelima made the arrangements—counselling first, written consent, then samples. She stated clearly, "The report will indicate biological relationship. Upbringing, love, inheritance, social identity—those are questions outside its scope."

The waiting room on the day of sampling held a strange tableau. Malini Devi and Kunti Devi sat two chairs apart. No one sat between them. Suresh Jha repeatedly polished his glasses. Because of weak eyesight Vimal Mandal could not properly see people's faces. Raghav typed messages to customers from his shop. Amitesh kept reading the posters on the wall: "Informed Consent," "Privacy," "Relationship Testing."

Kunti Devi suddenly asked Malini Devi, "Did your son spit up milk a great deal as a baby?"

Malini Devi started. "Yes. For six months."

Something lit Kunti Devi's face for an instant and went out. "Raghav did not."

Malini Devi asked, "Did he stay awake a lot at night?"

"Very much."

"Amitesh slept heavily from birth."

Both women fell silent.

The cruelest thing in that small conversation was that maternal memory had begun trying to turn itself into biological evidence. Spitting up milk, waking at night, fever, the first tooth—memories that had once been love now risked becoming proof.

Amitesh interrupted. "Ma, please do not match habits."

Malini Devi looked at him. "Why?"

"Because whatever matches will begin to feel like truth, and whatever does not will feel like falsehood. Let us not turn the lives we have already lived into an examination."

Kunti Devi nodded slowly.

The report took twelve days.

During those twelve days Amitesh went to school and taught the children motion, force, and light. Raghav kept stitching trousers and shirts. Malini Devi slowly began walking without a stick. Kunti Devi took her granddaughter to school. Outwardly, both households remained the same.

Inside, everyone was counting toward one date.

On the twelfth day Neelima first called Amitesh and Raghav in separately. "The report is very clear," she said. "Biologically, Amitesh is

related to Kunti Devi and Vimal Mandal. Biologically, Raghav is related to Malini Devi and Suresh Jha. The laboratory has confirmed this on two independent marker panels.”

The fan’s whirring sounded enormous in the room.

Raghav laughed first, a short, dry laugh. “Then we really are twins.”

Amitesh looked at him.

“Same day, same hospital, born into each other’s homes,” Raghav said. “If that is not twins, what is?”

Amitesh could not laugh.

His first thought was not of Malini Devi or Kunti Devi. It was Suresh Jha’s nose. For thirty years people had said, “His father’s nose.” One sentence had just become meaningless. He felt an urge to touch his own face.

Neelima said, “You two decide whether to tell the parents together or separately.”

Raghav answered immediately, “Together. We lived the lie separately for thirty years; we will not receive the truth separately.”

For the first time Amitesh saw in that sentence a temperament unlike his own—Raghav was quick, direct, a man who cut straight through. It brought him a strange relief. At least every difference of personality would not now be explained by “whose blood” they carried.

6

After hearing the report, Malini Devi looked at no one’s face at first. Her gaze remained fixed on one corner of the page. Kunti Devi’s eyes were closed. Suresh Jha drank water twice. Vimal Mandal could not make out the print; he asked Raghav, “What does it say?”

Raghav said, “By birth, I belong to the Jha family.”

Vimal Mandal replied at once, “Whatever you are by birth, you are my son.”

The sentence came so quickly that everyone in the room looked at him. Vimal Mandal himself seemed startled by it.

Malini Devi then looked at Amitesh. “And you?”

Amitesh moved closer to her. “I am your son.”

“The report?”

“The report says I was born to Kunti Ma—” The word “Ma” escaped his mouth and he stopped. Kunti Devi opened her eyes too.

Malini Devi’s face tightened. “Already ‘Ma’?”

Amitesh understood that a single word had turned into a knife. “I... I meant Kunti Devi.”

Kunti Devi intervened. “No. For now, call me Kunti. A relationship cannot be named in one day.”

Malini Devi looked at her. For the first time there was not rivalry between the two women, but exhaustion.

Suresh Jha said softly, “Raghav...”

Raghav stopped him. “Call me Raghav. No one needs to hurry to say ‘son.’”

He walked out.

Amitesh followed him. In the corridor Raghav stood gripping the railing.

"Are you angry?" Amitesh asked.

"With whom?"

"The hospital. Me. Home."

"A little with everyone." Raghav laughed. "Less with you. You found me. That is not your fault."

"Do you ever feel it would have been better if I had not looked?"

After a long time Raghav said, "Right now, yes. Five years from now, maybe not. Who knows?"

"Then what do we do?"

"First we go home. My daughter will be back from school."

"Which home?" Amitesh asked without thinking.

Raghav looked at him. "See? The problem has begun."

They laughed together for the first time.

Behind them in the room sat four parents. Four people, two sons, and one report—but the family did not become a number of six. Family had spread beyond number.

7

The months after the truth did not pass like a drama. No one left a house. No one changed a name at once. No one went to court. For this reason, the village found the story disappointing.

The news spread slowly. The old hospital error became a small newspaper item: "Allegation of infant switch after thirty years; inquiry sought." The two families did not allow their names to be printed. The hospital began a departmental inquiry, but the old records were incomplete. Identifying an individual at fault was difficult. Sister Sushma was found alive, but her memory was blurred. On the phone she said only this much: "The electricity failed many times that night. The baby tags were handwritten. I remember a complaint, but whose baby it concerned, I do not remember."

The question of legal responsibility continued. This story does not wait for that decision.

The real difficulty was Sunday lunch.

The first time Kunti Devi and Vimal Mandal came to Amitesh's house, Malini Devi had cooked fish. Kunti Devi asked, "Does Amitesh eat fish?"

Malini Devi answered with a sharp little laugh, "For thirty years."

Kunti Devi fell silent.

The following week Suresh Jha went to Raghav's shop to have a shirt stitched. As Raghav measured him, he said in a professional tone, "Chest, forty-four." Suresh Jha blurted out, "Mine was forty-four when I was young too."

Both men immediately understood that the sentence was searching for biological resemblance. Raghav loosened the tape. "This is the measurement of a shirt, not a lineage."

Suresh Jha was embarrassed.

There were countless small hurts like that. If Amitesh ate Kunti Devi's kadhi with pleasure, Malini Devi became quiet. If Raghav repaired Suresh Jha's old radio, Vimal Mandal sat longer than usual in the shop. One day the granddaughter Titli called Amitesh "the other uncle" and then laughed at herself.

Names were the hardest. "Mother" was a singular word; life had given two experiences. At first Amitesh began calling Kunti Devi "Kunti Kaki." Raghav tried saying "Malini Ma," but the phrase felt artificial in his mouth. Malini Devi herself said, "Do not force the name. The relationship will find its own word."

One evening Amitesh sat on the veranda with his mother—Malini Devi. Deliberately, inside his mind, he said the whole word: mother.

Malini Devi asked, "You went to Kunti Devi's yesterday?"

"Yes."

"What did she say?"

"She spoke about the months when she was pregnant. Before I was born, she could not bear the smell of mangoes."

Malini Devi said nothing.

"Are you angry?"

"Yes."

Amitesh was startled. His mother had never said it so plainly before.

"Why?"

"Because she knows nine months of you that I do not. And I know thirty years of you that she does not. My heart wants both to belong to me. That is greed."

Amitesh took her hand. "I am greedy too. I want to know both lives."

Malini Devi stroked his head. "Then know them. But do not leave me behind."

"Never."

This time Amitesh made the promise without hesitation.

That night he understood: biological truth does not cancel love, but neither does it automatically keep love safe. Love has to be secured again and again through new acts of living.

8

Sister Sushma's address was finally found through the hospital's former employees' association. She lived in Madhubani with her daughter. On the phone she first refused to meet them. "I do not remember something from thirty years ago. What can I give you?"

Raghav said, "Whatever memory you have, that much. If there is none, then say 'there is none.'"

Hearing that answer, she agreed to meet.

Amitesh, Raghav, Malini Devi, and Kunti Devi went together. Suresh Jha did not go. He said he did not want to place his thirty-year guilt now on

the face of an old nurse. Vimal Mandal's eyesight was too weak for the journey.

Sushma was now close to eighty. In her small sitting room were pictures of gods, medicine boxes, an old clock, and a glass-fronted cupboard. At the sight of her Kunti Devi's face tightened, as though the maternity ward of thirty years ago had returned in an instant.

"Do you recognize me?" Kunti Devi asked.

Sushma looked carefully. "No. Forgive me."

"Good," Kunti Devi said. "I did not want you to."

Sushma examined all the papers. Her fingers trembled when she held the B17 tag. "This is from that time. We used to write the numbers by hand."

"What happened that night?" Amitesh asked.

Sushma closed her eyes and sat for a long while. "Floodwater. The generator. Too many deliveries at once. One nurse short. I remember the nursery going completely dark once. Candles were brought. The babies' tags were checked again. But your particular incident—no, I cannot say."

Raghav asked, "Who switched B17 and B18?"

"I do not know."

"You?"

The room hardened.

Sushma looked straight at Raghav. "It may have been me. It may have been another nurse. The tags may have been right and the babies moved between beds. The mistake may have happened again when they were sent home. If I say, 'It was not me,' that too may be a lie. If I say, 'It was me,' that may be a lie as well."

Kunti Devi suddenly asked, "Then why did someone from the hospital come on the third day to take the tag?"

Sushma held her head. "There was a complaint—that much I remember. Two families? Perhaps. The superintendent said to verify the tags. Later I was told the matter was all right. I believed it."

"All right?" Malini Devi spoke for the first time. "What had become all right?"

Tears filled Sushma's eyes. "I am understanding that question only now, thirty years later."

Malini Devi's anger swelled in an instant. "Inside your 'all right,' the child I carried went to another house!"

Sushma had no answer.

Kunti Devi touched Malini Devi's arm. Whether the touch meant restraint or companionship was hard to tell. Malini Devi did not pull her arm away.

After a while Sushma went inside and brought a small notebook. "I did not write down everything. But I used to make notes on difficult duty days."

On the page for 21 August were three faint pencil lines: "Water rising. Generator off 11:25–11:50. Nursery tags rechecked. B17/B18 query."

That was all. No names. No confession.

Looking at the page, Raghav said, "This proves that the question arose that very night."

Amitesh said, "Yes. It does not prove who switched them."

Sushma closed the notebook. “Have you all come to forgive me or to blame me?”

Malini Devi said, “Neither. I came to know that my memory was not madness.”

Kunti Devi added, “And I came to know that I did not preserve that B17 tag for thirty years for nothing.”

Sushma said very softly, “Then take this much with you: your question arose that same night. We did not investigate it fully. This was the hospital’s failure, not merely your fate.”

After they came outside, Raghav remained silent for a long time. Then he said, “I thought we would find someone I could look at and be angry with.”

“And now?” Amitesh asked.

“Now we found an old woman who remembers half of it. Where do I put the anger?”

From behind them Malini Devi said, “Put it on the institution. Put it on the papers. But not on your own homes.”

Kunti Devi looked at her. This time the two women did not smile together, but the distance between them was no longer what it had been.

On the drive back, Amitesh decided he would not change his surname. Raghav would not either. Biological truth could be entered on paper, but to erase thirty years of school certificates, the shop signboard, wedding invitations, children’s birth records and build a new human being from them seemed false to both men.

Raghav said, “The names stay. The information gets added.”

Amitesh laughed. “That sounds like Panji talk.”

“By spending time with you, I am becoming a paper man too.”

“And by spending time with you, I am learning that paper is not everything.”

As they drove back from Madhubani, evening light spread over the paddy fields. All four sat in the same vehicle, but no one’s place had changed. This time truth had not come to exchange seats; it had only come to tell them how they had arrived where they were.

9

A year later Ishaan, keeper of records, came to Parasauni. The marriage of Kunti Devi’s granddaughter was being discussed, and the question of Raghav’s biological birth had arisen in the family lineage details. Kunti Devi herself said, “You decide what must be written in the volume. But do not erase my son.”

Ishaan seated both families together. The Panji lay before him, but he did not open it at once. “What do all of you want?”

Suresh Jha said, “Truth.”

Vimal Mandal laughed. “That word frightens me now.”

Raghav said, “Write the truth, but not in one line.”

Amitesh looked at him. That was exactly what he had wanted to say.

Ishaan asked, "Meaning?"

Raghav said, "Birth in one home, upbringing in another. Write both. I do not want to remain somebody's 'mistake.'"

Malini Devi added, "And do not use the words 'real parents.' Who is real?"

Kunti Devi smiled for the first time. "She is right."

Ishaan wrote notes for a long time. Finally he said, "A Panji usually sees lineage as one line. Your lives are two lines. I will have to change the sign."

In the Panji he drew a double branch—one line of birth, one line of upbringing. Between them he wrote a short note: "Infant exchange caused by a record error at the District Hospital in 1995; confirmed by genetic relationship testing in 2025; birth and upbringing relationships both recorded on the joint request of the two families."

No one suggested writing the word "twins." That remained Raghav's private joke.

But when the meeting ended and the two men stepped outside, evening was falling. A small lamp burned on Ishaan's table. Its slanting light fell on the Panji's double branch—two lines crossing at one point and then growing in separate directions.

Raghav asked, "Do you think the Panji recognizes us now?"

Amitesh said, "The Panji is paper. How can it know a person completely?"

"Then why did we have it written?"

"So that the next people do not mistake one line for an entire life."

Raghav was quiet for a moment, then laughed. "At school you can tell the children: I have a brother, same birthday, same age, but we are not twins."

"They will ask, 'Then what are you?'"

"I'll say: it's a long story."

Amitesh laughed too.

At the fork in the road they had to part—Raghav toward Parasauni, Amitesh toward the city. Reaching it, Raghav suddenly stopped.

"Amitesh."

"Yes?"

"If the hospital had not made that mistake that night, you would have grown up in my house, and I in yours."

"Yes."

"Then who would the people we are now have been?"

Amitesh thought for a long time before answering. "Someone else."

Raghav nodded. "Then the hospital did not only switch two babies. It killed two possible people and made two new ones."

The sentence was harsh. Amitesh said, "No. Possible people do not die. They are never born. What we lived is real."

Raghav smiled. "The teacher again."

"The tailor again."

"I am a tailor, but I can cut an argument and stitch it back together."

"And I am a teacher, but I do not have an answer to every question."

They took their separate roads.

When Amitesh reached home, he found Malini Devi lighting a lamp on the veranda. There was electricity, yet the lamp burned. This household habit running from Story 1 now gave him a new meaning. Light does not look for resemblance between faces; it does not read blood groups. It only reveals the edges of what stands before it.

Malini Devi asked, "What did Ishaan write?"

"Two lines."

"Did you like it?"

"Yes."

"Then eat. Kunti Devi called. She is sending tilkut tomorrow."

Amitesh smiled. "You are not angry?"

Setting down the plate, Malini Devi said, "I get angry. I will eat the tilkut too."

Amitesh burst out laughing.

The tragedy did not end in that laughter. There was no ending. No compensation for the hospital's mistake could rewrite thirty years for the families. To which child should Kunti Devi attach the memory of her newborn's first cry? Whose name should Malini Devi give to the nine months of pregnancy? In whose face should Suresh Jha look for his nose, in whose walk should Vimal Mandal seek his young body? These questions would rise again from time to time.

But now the questions were no longer secret.

In the lamplight Malini Devi's hand rested on the plate. Amitesh placed his hand over hers. The biological relationship report did not explain that touch. It did not need to.

Far away in Parasauni, perhaps at that very moment Kunti Devi was packing tilkut and Raghav was closing the tailoring shop. The two homes were not forcing themselves into one another's history; they were slowly opening their doors.

Amitesh remembered Raghav's word "twins."

They had not shared a womb. They did not share the same blood. They had not shared a home.

But they were two lives born from the same mistake.

And now, for the first time, both were finding room to live their own lives under their full names.

— *End of Story 14* —

15. Agnates

STORY

I

Ayan had always liked the expression “permanent address.”

At his school in Doha, whenever a teacher filling out a form said, “Permanent Address,” he would look at his father. Without a moment’s hesitation, Pranav Mishra would write: “Village Chandradih, Post Office Belahi, District Madhubani, Bihar, India.” Ayan found it strange that the place he saw for twenty days in a year was permanent, while the place where he had been born, studied, made friends and learned to ride a bicycle was temporary.

Once he had asked, “Babu, does permanent mean something that does not change?”

Pranav had said, “Yes, more or less.”

“But the roof of the village house has changed three times.”

Mrinalini had laughed. Pranav had said, “The roof changes; the house does not.”

Ayan had stored that answer away. At fifteen, children collect many answers; only later do they understand how many of them were simply ways of avoiding the question.

After Grandfather Umakant Mishra died, “permanent address” became, for the first time, a practical object. The ancestral house in Chandradih, half the ghat of the small pond, and three kathas of bamboo grove had to be mutated in the land records. Pranav was the only son, but the branches of the old joint family were so tangled in the revenue register that the local office demanded an updated family genealogy. Pranav also wanted Ayan’s name entered in the lineage list—“so he will not have to run around later.”

The office website said: “Attach the prescribed form for verification of family lineage.” When they opened the form, the first page alone had ten boxes.

1. Name of applicant.
2. Father’s name.
3. Grandfather’s name.
4. Great-grandfather’s name.
5. Ancestral village.
6. Permanent residence.
7. Present residence.
8. Verification by two agnates.

9. Certification by a representative of the local body.

10. "Other necessary documents."

Reading the tenth box, Mrinalini said, "This tenth box is the largest of them all."

Pranav asked, "How?"

"'Other necessary' means every document you have not even imagined yet."

Looking at the form on the phone, Ayan asked, "Where is Mother's name?"

Pranav looked at the screen again. "If the applicant is a minor, it will appear under guardian details."

"In the lineage?"

There was no box for it.

Mrinalini smiled. "Perhaps I am not permanent."

It was a joke, but Pranav did not laugh.

2

Three weeks later, all three reached Chandradih. The humidity of July, mango leaves scattered across the courtyard, the closed door of Grandfather's room—the village did not feel like a holiday to Ayan this time. It felt like someone's absence.

The next day Pranav, Mrinalini and Ayan went to the circle office. There were four counters in the corridor, three chairs, seven queues, and no one seemed to understand the rules of any queue. On one wall was written: "Beware of touts." Directly beneath it sat a man filling out forms for everyone and saying, "I am not a tout, I am an assistant."

Pranav opened his file. Copies of passports, Ayan's Doha birth certificate, Grandfather's death certificate, the old land record, a ration-card copy, electricity bill, panchayat tax receipt—all arranged in exact order.

The clerk behind the window kept turning the papers over. His nameplate read: "Rampukar Yadav, Clerk."

He asked, "Where was the child born?"

"Doha."

"Doha comes under which police station?"

Pranav was silent for two seconds. "It is the capital of Qatar."

Rampukar Babu pushed his spectacles up onto his forehead. "Abroad?"

"Yes."

"Then we need an attested copy of the foreign birth certificate."

"This is the original, with embassy attestation."

"It is in English."

"The office list says English is acceptable."

Rampukar Babu looked at the list, then the document. "Fine. But proof of permanent residence?"

Pranav extended the electricity bill. "For this house."

"In the name of Umakant Mishra."

"He was my father."

"Anything in your name?"

"I have lived outside for thirty years. The house remained in his name."

"Then how is your permanent residence to be proved?"

Pranav tried to laugh. "By the bill of the very house for whose mutation I have come to apply."

Rampukar Babu smiled faintly too. "I understand. The form does not."

Mrinalini spoke for the first time. "Explain it to the form."

"A form has no ears, madam."

"It does have a seal."

This time Rampukar Babu genuinely laughed. "First bring verification from two agnates. Then there will be a local enquiry."

Pranav asked, "What exactly do you mean by agnates?"

"Two adult men of the same lineage who can identify your branch."

Mrinalini immediately asked, "Not women?"

Rampukar Babu looked at the form. "It says 'persons.' Women will do. But ordinarily men come."

"So the person who knows the family will do, or the person who is male will do?"

Rampukar Babu closed the file and pushed it back toward Pranav. "Bring whoever knows. I do not want an argument."

As soon as they stepped outside, Ayan asked, "Babu, where will we find these agnates?"

Pranav took out his phone. "One is in Surat, one in Guwahati, one in Patna, and the one who lives in the village is in a land case with us."

Mrinalini said, "The lineage is permanent; the agnates are migrants."

Ayan laughed for the first time.

3

The first agnate—Pranav's cousin Shashibhushan—kept accounts in a textile mill in Surat. On a video call he said enthusiastically, "I will verify it. Send the papers."

The office said: original signature or physical presence.

"A scan?"

"No."

"Digital signature?"

"There is no provision in the form."

"Video verification?"

"Not in the rules."

Shashibhushan laughed over the phone. "The government that wants my taxes online wants my kinship on paper."

The second agnate—Basuki Kaka—had retired from the railways in Guwahati. He said, "I can come, but three months from now, for the shraddha."

Pranav did not want to wait three months.

The one left in the village was Jagdish Kaka, seventy-two, Grandfather's cousin. The problem was that he claimed the eastern edge of the bamboo

grove. When Pranav went to him, Jagdish Kaka read the form and asked, “If I verify this today, will you say tomorrow that all three kathas belong to you?”

“You are verifying kinship, not the boundary of the land.”

“I can read what the paper says. Who knows what a court will read later?”

“Then simply state that I am Umakant Babu’s son. Nothing more.”

Jagdish Kaka shook his head. “Do I need to certify that you are Umakant’s son? Look at your nose.”

Ayan, sitting beside them, touched his own nose.

Looking at him, Jagdish Kaka asked, “This boy is yours?”

Pranav said, “Yes.”

“I am seeing him for the first time.”

“That is precisely why the genealogy is being prepared.”

“How can I verify someone I am seeing for the first time?”

Pranav’s patience was about to give way, but Mrinalini intervened. “You only need to verify that Pranav is Umakant’s son. Ayan has a separate birth certificate.”

Jagdish Kaka looked at her. “And who are you?”

Mrinalini smiled. “The boy’s mother. According to the form, a secondary person.”

Jagdish Kaka did not grasp the joke, but Ayan laughed.

In the end Jagdish Kaka did not sign. He said, “First have the land measured.”

On the way home Pranav was furious. “Agnate! The man who fights over land all his life is the witness to the lineage!”

Mrinalini said, “That is why the word fits. An agnate knows the clan and the share.”

Ayan asked, “Who are my agnates?”

Pranav said, “Your cousins.”

“I do not have any.”

“Not yet. You may later.”

“What if I keep living abroad?”

Pranav did not answer.

4

There was one person in the village who knew the family’s stories from Pranav’s birth all the way to Ayan’s—Subhadra Kaki. She was eighty-four, the younger sister of Umakant Mishra. After marriage she had gone five kos away; after becoming a widow, she had returned to live with her daughter near Chandradih.

When Pranav was a child she had played with him in her lap. At Ayan’s birth she had called Doha and sung a sohar over the telephone. During Umakant’s final illness she had stayed in the house for a month.

Mrinalini said, “They want an agnate who knows the family. Who knows it better than Subhadra Kaki?”

Pranav was doubtful. "She belongs to the paternal line, but after marriage she entered another gotra."

"The form says 'person.' Rampukar Babu himself said so."

Subhadra Kaki could not read the form, but when it was explained to her she became indignant. "Government people are going to ask me whose son your grandfather was?"

"Kaki, not the government—the office."

"Is it not a government office?"

Pranav fell silent.

Kaki called Ayan closer. "You were born in Doha. Have you ever heard my voice on the phone?"

Ayan laughed. "I do not remember."

"I sang the sohar. Your father cut the call—said international calls were expensive."

Pranav looked embarrassed. "Kaki, is that relevant now?"

"You want proof of lineage, do you not? The expenses are part of the family history too."

Mrinalini doubled over laughing.

Subhadra Kaki agreed to put her thumb impression. For the second witness she suggested her elder daughter Kamla Didi, a retired teacher from the panchayat school. Kamla Didi had a habit of preserving every birth and death paper.

With the signatures and thumb impression of two women, Pranav arrived at the office in a mood of victory.

Rampukar Babu examined the form. First verifier—Subhadra Devi. Relation—father's paternal aunt. Second—Kamla Devi. Relation—cousin through the paternal aunt.

He scratched his head. "Both women?"

Mrinalini was prepared. "The form says 'person.'"

"Yes, but the verification branch may object."

"Why?"

Rampukar Babu leaned back in his chair. "Old practice."

"Where is this old practice written on the form?"

Rampukar Babu was about to answer when a woman's voice came from the adjoining counter: "Nowhere."

The nameplate read: "Suchitra Kumari, Assistant Section Officer."

She asked for the form and read it. "Verification by any adult member who knows the branch of the family is valid. 'Male agnate' is an old oral habit, not a rule."

Rampukar Babu said easily, "I only said the branch might object."

Suchitra said, "Half the objections in this office are born less from rules than from anticipation."

Mrinalini looked at Pranav. Her eyes carried the same expression as before—the tenth box.

Suchitra turned the file over again. "There is one more problem."

Pranav's face fell.

"On Ayan's birth certificate the mother's name is 'Mrinalini Mishra.' On the passport it is 'Mrinalini Jha Mishra.' Her premarital surname has been

retained. Attach a self-declaration clarifying the relationship. You need not go back to Doha for this.”

Pranav exhaled in relief.

Mrinalini asked, “May I include my parents’ names in the self-declaration?”

Suchitra smiled. “Why not?”

“There is no box for them in the main genealogy.”

Suchitra was quiet for a moment. “The form is old. Attach an additional sheet. Government papers are not the final shape of every truth.”

From the side Rampukar Babu said, “If the pages increase, the file will get thicker.”

Mrinalini replied, “A lineage does not fit into thin paper.”

This time all three—Suchitra, Rampukar and Pranav—laughed.

5

After the application was accepted, “site verification” remained. A panchayat employee would come to see the house—to verify that the applicant’s family truly maintained an ancestral residence in Chandradih.

Ayan asked, “Will the house verify us?”

Pranav said, “The employee will.”

“Does he know me?”

“No.”

“Then how will he know this is my house?”

“The neighbours will tell him.”

“Do the neighbours know me?”

This time Pranav laughed. “Some of them.”

“So the agnates did not work, but the neighbours will?”

“I do not teach government philosophy.”

On the day of the site inspection, Manoj, an assistant from the panchayat, arrived on a motorcycle. He photographed the house, asked Grandfather’s name, looked at the old tulsi altar in the courtyard, and wrote down the electricity-meter number. Then he asked Ayan, “How many days a year do you stay here?”

“About twenty.”

Pranav immediately wanted to say, “More this year,” but stopped himself.

Manoj wrote: “Family migrant; ancestral residence extant.”

Peering at the paper, Ayan asked, “What does extant mean?”

“It exists.”

“Then am I extant?”

Manoj laughed. “You are very extant.”

“Am I permanent?”

Manoj stopped his pen. “Ask the office that question.”

Subhadra Kaki was sitting in the veranda. She said, “Child, no one is permanent. Do not tell the paper that. It will get frightened.”

Manoj laughed so hard that the photograph came out blurred and had to be taken again.

For a week after the inspection there was no news. The website status said: "Local verification pending." Manoj said, "I have sent it." The circle office said, "Not received." The panchayat said, "There is a dispatch number." The circle office said, "It has not been uploaded to the portal."

Pranav grew tired of making daily phone calls. Mrinalini took a notebook and wrote on the cover: "Journey of a Lineage."

First page:

Doha—birth certificate.

Chandradih—agnates.

Panchayat—site inspection.

Circle office—receipt.

Then panchayat—upload.

Then circle office—download.

Ayan drew arrows beside the entries. The arrows went round and round and returned to their starting point.

"This is not a family tree," he said. "It is a family cycle."

Mrinalini said, "Shall we attach this diagram to the certificate?"

Pranav gave a tired laugh. "Then the file will go straight to a museum."

6

In the end the problem was a single digit. The panchayat dispatch number was 7841; the circle portal carried 7481. The paper lay for four days in digital darkness. Suchitra found the error herself and corrected it.

"All this running about for one reversed digit?" Pranav said.

Suchitra replied calmly, "A digit is small. The road of a document is long."

The file would now go before the Circle Officer for approval. On the day of the hearing, all three went to the office again. This time Ayan carried the file himself.

The officer was relatively young—Aditya Narayan. He read the papers, looked at Subhadra Kaki's thumb impression, Kamla Devi's signature, the site report, the self-declaration, and the Doha birth certificate.

Then he asked Ayan, "Your permanent address?"

Ayan looked at his father. Pranav signalled with his eyes: answer.

Ayan said, "According to the form, Chandradih."

The officer smiled. "And according to you?"

For a moment the room was silent.

"My books, friends and school are in Doha. Here are Grandfather's house, Subhadra Kaki and the pond. Both places feel like mine. But something in each of them is temporary."

Aditya Narayan twirled his pen. "That answer will not fit in the form."

Mrinalini said softly, "That is the central problem with this entire collection."

The officer looked at her, did not understand, but smiled.

He asked Pranav, “Why are you so eager to add the boy’s name to the genealogy now? You yourself are the heir.”

Pranav looked for a few moments at Grandfather’s death certificate. “Because while my father was alive, I felt every paper would continue in his name. After he was gone, I understood: when one generation drops away, the next line suddenly comes to the front. I do not want my son to spend his time later searching for papers.”

The officer nodded. “All right.”

Mrinalini said, “But the mother’s line is on an attached sheet. It is not in the main form.”

The officer looked at the form. “This format is old.”

“Everyone says so.”

“A proposal for revision can be sent.”

“Who will send it?”

The officer smiled. “Submit a written representation. I will forward it.”

Pranav looked at Mrinalini. Her eyes lit up. She whispered, “The tenth box has opened again.”

Ayan could not suppress his laugh. When the officer asked why, Mrinalini said, “Nothing. A family joke.”

Just before the hearing ended, the power went out. The room went dark. In the corridor people switched on the torches on their phones. Rampukar Babu brought an old emergency lamp; yellow light fell across the desk.

In that light Aditya Narayan made the final signature. The blue ink of the seal was half clear, half faint. Rampukar Babu said, “The ink has dried out.”

Mrinalini whispered, “The lineage is verified; the seal remains doubtful.”

Pranav nudged her with his elbow.

7

The certificate was issued three days later. Its heading read: “Verification of Family Lineage.” Beneath it: Umakant Mishra, his son Pranav Mishra, his son Ayan Mishra. Ancestral village—Chandradih. Present residence—Doha, Qatar. Remark: “Family migrant; ancestral residence extant.”

Pranav looked at the paper and breathed in relief. “Done.”

Ayan read it and then asked, “Where is Mother?”

Pranav’s face changed. “In the attached self-declaration.”

“On the certificate?”

“No.”

Mrinalini said, “I am on the back of the paper.”

The sentence was meant to be funny, but this time no one laughed.

Back home, Mrinalini wrote on a clean white sheet the names of her mother and father, her maternal grandmother, her birth village, and the date of her marriage. At the top she wrote: “Ayan’s Maternal Line.”

Ayan said, “This is not official.”

“No.”

“Then is it proof?”

"For you, it is remembrance."

Pranav said softly, "I will keep a copy of this page with the genealogy."

Mrinalini looked at him. "Not keep it. Add it."

"Add it."

Subhadra Kaki came in the evening. She looked at the certificate. Without her spectacles she could not read it, but she ran a finger over the seal. "All that running for this?"

Pranav said, "For this."

"I already knew it."

Ayan asked, "What?"

"Whose son your father is, whose son you are, whose daughter your mother is."

"Then why the paper?"

Kaki laughed. "To explain it to people who do not know."

"The people in the office do not know me. Yet they verified me."

"We told them."

"Then who made the certificate—the government or all of you?"

Subhadra Kaki looked at Pranav. "Your son asks too many questions."

Pranav said, "The school's fault."

Mrinalini added, "It may also be an inherited trait."

Subhadra Kaki burst out laughing.

8

One day before their return to Doha, Jagdish Kaka came carrying the old survey map of the bamboo grove. Pranav thought another dispute was about to begin.

But Jagdish Kaka called Ayan over. "Your certificate is ready?"

"Yes."

"Without my signature?"

"Yes."

Jagdish Kaka looked slightly hurt. "Then the importance of an agnate has declined."

From inside the house Mrinalini said, "The agnate survives. Only the monopoly has declined."

Jagdish Kaka heard her and laughed. "The boy's mother has a sharp tongue."

Ayan asked, "Kaka, earlier you did not know me. Do you know me now?"

Jagdish Kaka looked at him from head to foot. "I have seen you twice now. I know you halfway."

"When will you know me fully?"

"When you come with me to measure the boundary of the bamboo grove."

Pranav interrupted, "Land again!"

Jagdish Kaka roared with laughter. "An agnate without land is incomplete."

He unfolded the map. The folds of the old paper were worn. Ayan sat down on the ground. Jagdish Kaka began to explain: "This is the old embankment, this the stump of the mango tree, this the drain. Your grandfather's share begins here..."

Pranav watched. The man who had been afraid to sign a paper two weeks earlier was now handing the boy a story of the land. Not verification on paper, but the transfer of memory. They were two different acts.

Evening deepened. The electricity went out again. Mrinalini lit a small lamp on the veranda. Its slanting light fell at once on the map, the certificate, and the maternal line written in Mrinalini's hand.

Ayan took out his school notebook. His teacher had asked him to make "My Family Tree" for the next term. He wrote his own name at the top. Beneath it he drew two branches—on one side Pranav, Umakant, and the older names beyond them; on the other Mrinalini, Manorama, Devaki. He added Subhadra Kaki's name with an arrow away from the main branch. Beside Jagdish Kaka's name he wrote: "Knows me halfway."

Pranav saw it. "What have you written?"

"The truth."

Jagdish Kaka laughed until he began to cough.

Ayan placed the certificate beside the notebook. The government paper was straight, clean, moving in one direction. His drawing wandered crookedly in two directions, with arrows, comments and question marks in between.

Mrinalini asked, "What will you write for permanent address?"

Ayan thought for a while, then left it blank.

Pranav said, "Your teacher will mark it wrong."

"Then I will write: 'Two places.'"

"The form will have one box."

"Then I will make another box."

Mrinalini kissed his head. "That trait is certainly from my lineage."

Pranav was about to object, then stopped. "Proof?"

Mrinalini pointed toward the lamp. "So many witnesses are sitting here."

Subhadra Kaki, Jagdish Kaka and Pranav all laughed. So did Ayan.

In the lamplight the government seal looked blue, the ink of the maternal line black, the old map brown and faded. The three colours were different. None cancelled the others.

The next morning, when the car came to take them back to Doha, Subhadra Kaki put a box of tilkut into Ayan's hands. "Do not go there and say your permanent address exists only on paper."

Ayan asked, "Then where is it?"

Kaki said, "Where people remember your name without asking a form."

The car moved. Chandradih receded behind them. Ayan kept looking through the window until the roof disappeared behind the mango trees.

He opened his file. The government seal was on the certificate. Behind it was the line written in his mother's hand. Between them was the blue thumbprint of Subhadra Kaki.

Ayan took out a pen and wrote in small letters inside the file:

“Agnate: one who knows not only the line of descent, but the people in that line.”

Then, after thinking, he crossed out “not only” and wrote:

“Agnate: one who knows you, quarrels with you, makes you laugh, gives testimony or refuses it—but does not remain outside the story.”

Pranav read it and said, “The office will not accept that definition.”

Looking out of the window, Ayan said, “It is not for the office.”

The car turned at the bend. The village disappeared from sight, but the file remained in his lap—with permanent address, present address, paternal line, maternal line, agnates, seal, and a few blank spaces.

Perhaps in those blank spaces, the meaning of his own home was still waiting to be written.

— *End of Story 15* —

16. The Hidden Branch

STORY

I

During the first month after her marriage, Kirti was learning the names of the objects in this house. The western room was “the old house,” the small northern room “Baba’s room,” the iron trunk in the corner of the veranda “the big chest,” and the wooden box gathering dust beneath the stairs—“Do not open that.”

“Why?” Kirti had asked the first time.

Her mother-in-law, Malati Devi, had answered, “There is nothing in it. Old papers.”

Kirti had laughed. “If there is nothing in it, what is the harm in opening it?”

Malati Devi had laughed too, but turned her eyes away. “A new bride already has so much to do. Why breathe in old dust?”

The answer was not a prohibition; it was an evasion. Kirti understood. But in the first month in a new house, a person knowingly leaves many questions alone. Leaving questions alone is also one of the customs of settling into a home.

Two months later the rains came. A smell of damp rose from beneath the stairs. Water had crept under the wooden box. Malati Devi herself said, “Lift that box to a higher place.”

Kirti and her husband Nilansh dragged the box onto the veranda. Its bottom had swollen; one corner of the lid had lifted. Inside were old newspapers, wedding invitations, copies of land papers, two or three photographs, and a bundle of letters tied in red cloth.

Nilansh lifted the newspapers and said, “Throw all this away.”

Kirti untied the red cloth. The letters inside were not all the same size. Some were whole, some only halves, some torn at the edges. Some had postage stamps; some did not. The paper ranged from yellow to mud-brown. There were at least four different hands.

At the very top lay the right half of a torn sheet. The beginning was missing. At the end alone were the words:

“...Tell the boy that I did not change his name. When he grows up, if he asks, tell him that he had a father, but his father’s house did not recognise him by his own name. Do not lay the blame for this on the boy. — Manjari”

Kirti read it again.

“Who is Manjari?” she asked.

Nilansh shrugged. "I do not know."

Malati Devi was sorting lentils at the time. Her hand stopped. Only for a moment. Then she went on sorting.

Kirti saw that moment.

Letter Fragment 1

"Chhotki,

You wrote that Babuji's cough has worsened. Tell him I cannot come yet. The boy's fever has not gone down. The doctor says we should change the air. If changing the air could change a life, I would have changed mine long ago.

I write to you because at least you read the words in a letter. Everyone at home looks more at the address on the envelope than at the words inside.

— M..."

The lower portion was torn away.

2

Kirti dusted the letters and made separate piles—complete letters, torn letters, undated letters, unsigned letters. Nilansh joked, "Are you opening a library?"

"First I want to understand who this Manjari was."

"Mother must know."

Malati Devi lifted the tray of lentils. "It is a very old matter."

"That is precisely why I am asking."

"Sometimes it is better to let old matters remain old."

Kirti did not reply. She remembered her own mother, who used to say that not every box in a house should be opened; but if a box opens by itself, whose responsibility is it to close it again?

That evening Kirti took the bundle wrapped in red cloth to her room. After Nilansh fell asleep, she read the first complete letter.

Letter 2 — Date clear: 17 June 1974

"Dear Sudha,

I received your letter. You wrote that Amma no longer takes my name. That is not new. A person does not disappear because people stop speaking her name. It used to hurt. Now it hurts less. Perhaps the mind too grows a thicker skin.

You asked whether Deepak goes to school. Yes, he does. On the admission form his name is written as Deepak Jha. The master asked for his father's name. I had Shashibhushan Jha written there. It is true. Shashibhushan did not cease to be his father because he died.

Do not send your reply to the address of the old home. I do not want what happened last time to happen again.

Your elder sister, Manjari"

Kirti read the letter three times. The name “Sudha” sounded familiar. Nilansh’s grandmother had been named Sudha. In the house everyone called her Sudha Dadi. She had died five years earlier.

Then was Manjari Sudha’s elder sister?

In the oral family list Kirti had heard at the time of her marriage, Sudha had had one brother and one sister—the brother had died in childhood, the sister was Kusum, married in Nepal. There was no Manjari.

Kirti opened the old family photographs on her phone. In Sudha Dadi’s wedding photograph there were four young women. Nilansh had already identified Kusum. Two others were relatives. The fourth? The photograph was blurred; half her face was under a veil.

Kirti enlarged the photograph.

That night sleep came late.

Letter Fragment 3

“...Deepak is five now. His nose is exactly like Babuji’s. I am afraid even to write this. If Babuji saw him, what would he say? Perhaps nothing. His silence was always the largest sentence.

After Shashibhushan died, I could have returned to my mother’s home. But what would returning have meant? The house that had arranged my marriage—how long would that same house have accepted a widowed daughter and her son as its own? Mama said, stay here. I stayed. Here people call me Manjari. That is a great deal.”

There was a round water stain lower on the page. The ink had spread there.

3

The next morning Kirti showed Letter 2 to Malati Devi.

Without her spectacles Malati Devi first tried to hold the paper at a distance, then fetched her glasses. She read it all and remained silent.

“Was Manjari Sudha Dadi’s elder sister?”

“Yes.”

“Then why is her name never spoken in this house?”

Malati Devi said, “When I came to this house, I had heard half the matter. No one told even me the whole of it.”

“What was the half?”

“She was married very young. Her husband died within two years. She had a son. Her husband’s family proposed keeping the child and sending Manjari Didi back to her parents. She could not leave the child. She went to her maternal uncle’s house. That is all.”

“And for that her name was erased?”

“Whether someone struck her out of a line, or people simply stopped saying her name—I do not know. Sudha Ma spoke very little about it.”

“There are so many letters.”

“Ma kept them.”

“Then she had not forgotten her.”

Malati Devi smiled faintly. “Sometimes the person whose name people do not speak is the one they remember most.”

Kirti fell silent. The sentence seemed to belong more to the inside of the house than to the letters.

Letter 4 — Undated

“Sudha,

I heard of your wedding. I will not be able to come. My hand trembles as I write this, but you know the reason. I do not want my coming to become an objection in your marriage.

The red sari Amma gave me at my wedding—I am cutting a strip from its border and placing it in this letter. Stitch it into some garment of your own. There is no need to tell anyone where it came from.

Your Didi”

There was no cloth with the letter. But the red cloth in which all the letters had been tied had, along one edge, a narrow old strip of golden zari.

Kirti showed the cloth to Malati Devi.

For a long time Malati Devi touched the zari with her fingertips. “This was from Maaji’s old odhni.”

“Then Sudha Dadi really did stitch in the strip?”

“Perhaps.”

“And later the letters were tied in this cloth?”

“Perhaps.”

In a family’s history, “perhaps” is written in many places—not only on paper.

4

Kirti tried to arrange the letters by date, but more than half were undated. So she arranged them by subject—Deepak, Babuji, Amma, Sudha’s marriage, illness, money, school, land.

There were only two letters about land. That reassured Kirti that this was not some secret of property. Not every hidden matter in a family concerns inheritance. Some are hidden only under shame, inconvenience, social fear, or the weight of “what will people say?”

In one letter Manjari wrote that Deepak had gone to Darbhanga on a scholarship. In another she wrote: “He writes his maternal grandfather’s name with pride; I have told him not to abandon his father’s name either.”

Then Deepak’s name became rarer in the letters. Perhaps he had gone away. Perhaps the letters were missing.

One small slip contained only an address: “D. S. Jha, Railway Colony, Katihar.” The date was 1991.

Nilansh said, “There must be a thousand D. S. Jhas in Katihar.”

Kirti replied, "We do not even know whether this one is still there."

"Then?"

"Then first we read every letter."

Nilansh smiled. "You respect the papers more than you want to solve the mystery."

"The mystery is people's lives. If you solve it too quickly, you make the people smaller."

Nilansh looked at her for a moment. "Write that down."

Kirti laughed. "In a letter?"

Letter Fragment 5

"...Deepak says he wants to see my home. How do I explain that seeing a house is easy; seeing your own place inside it is difficult? He asks—who is my maternal uncle, who is my aunt, where is my grandparents' house? I tell him all the names. He says—then why do those people not know me?

Sudha, before a child's questions, all the arrangements of grown people become small."

5

After reading this line Kirti asked Nilansh, "Does your father ever speak of someone named Deepak?"

Nilansh's father Shailendra lived in the city. They called him.

"Deepak?" he repeated on the phone. "Once, when I was a child, a Deepak Dada came. Perhaps from Katihar. Dadi took him into the inner room. I was sent outside."

"How many years ago?"

"I was ten or eleven. A very long time ago."

"Who was he?"

There was silence at the other end.

"Ma said he was a distant relative."

"How distant?"

Shailendra laughed. "I did not ask that question then."

Kirti told him about the letters. The phone fell silent again.

Shailendra said slowly, "Then he was not distant."

"Does that upset you?"

"Upset? No. It is strange. I had a Dada in my own family and grew up believing he was a distant relative."

"Manjari?"

"I have heard the name. But I never saw her photograph in the house."

Kirti searched the wooden box again and examined the backs of the photographs. One small photograph showed two women with a boy of about eight between them. On the back, in pencil: "M., S., Deepak — 1977."

"M." and "S." Manjari and Sudha?

Did the boy's eyes resemble Nilansh's father's, or was Kirti seeing resemblance only because she now knew the story? She put the photograph aside, but made no claim. People are too quick to turn faces into proof of lineage.

Letter 6 — In Sudha's hand

This was the first letter not written by Manjari, but by Sudha. It was perhaps never sent. There was no envelope.

"Didi,

I wrote an answer to your letter three times and tore it up all three times. Babuji says your name must not be raised in this house again. Amma quietly asks me at night how you are. I lie in both directions. I tell you the house is fine; I tell the house I have no news of you.

I hate these lies. But my courage is small.

I have stitched your red border into my odhni. If anyone asks, I say it is old cloth. That is another lie.

One day I want Deepak to run in this courtyard without anyone's permission. I do not know whether I will send this letter.

— Sudha"

The letter had indeed never been sent. Perhaps that was why it remained in the box.

For a long time Kirti looked at the sentence "my courage is small." Family histories are often made not only from brave decisions, but from the moments when courage fell short.

6

Malati Devi asked, "You have read so much. What will you do now?"

Kirti said, "Nothing. First we will preserve everything."

She ordered thin transparent sleeves. Each letter was placed separately. Pieces that belonged together were set side by side without glue. No guessed dates were written. Where a name was incomplete, there was a question mark.

Nilansh joked, "A museum has opened in the house."

Kirti said, "No. In a museum objects are assumed dead. These are still speaking."

This time Malati Devi laughed. "Then listen."

She began opening her memory.

After marriage, Sudha Dadi used to come to her mother's home once a year. Sometimes she wore an odhni with a red border. Once, when Malati was a new bride, Sudha Dadi had said at night, "I had an elder sister." Nothing more. Malati had asked, "Where?" The answer was, "Where people call her by her own name."

"I thought perhaps she had died," Malati Devi said. "I did not ask again."

Kirti asked, "Why?"

“I was a new bride. The right to ask every question does not come automatically.”

Kirti smiled. “Perhaps I took that right rather quickly.”

Malati Devi smiled too. “You did well.”

The distance between two generations could be measured inside that brief reply.

Letter Fragment 7

“...If Amma wants to see me, I can come. But on one condition—Deepak will not remain outside. He will enter the courtyard with me. He will not be brought through the back door.

If this condition seems harsh to you, forgive me. I have been gentle too many times.”

The letter was incomplete. There was no reply either.

Kirti did not imagine what Amma might have answered. The temptation to fill the blank spaces of a story was the most dangerous temptation of all. What was unknown remained unknown.

7

Three weeks later Shailendra himself came to the village. He looked at the letters on the table and took the photograph in his hand.

“This boy could be the same person,” he said.

“Could be,” Kirti corrected him.

Shailendra laughed. “You are teaching me to speak cautiously too.”

From an old iron cupboard he brought out one of Sudha Dadi’s diaries. The diary was mostly household accounts—expenses, days of worship, medicines, seed, domestic calculations. But on one page from 1994 was written: “Deepak came. Two hours. Looked at Babu’s photograph. Did not eat. Touched my feet when leaving. I could say nothing.”

Shailendra read the entry and sat down on a chair. “Perhaps I was in the house that day.”

Kirti said nothing.

“Dadi could not say anything.”

“That is what she wrote in the diary.”

“I never imagined her so helpless.”

Malati Devi said softly, “Silence makes people look strong. It does not show what is inside.”

That evening the family spoke Manjari’s name openly for the first time. No one condemned her; no one glorified her either. There were many questions and few answers. The proportion was right.

Letter 8 — 2 January 1998

“Sudha,

Deepak has gone to Calcutta now. He has found work. There is talk of his marriage. He says he will invite you to the wedding. I say—invite her. He asks—what about the rest of the house? I say—invite whoever you wish.

I am growing old. The edge of my anger has dulled, but memory has not. Sometimes I think the house cast me out; then I think perhaps I too cast the house out. The truth must be somewhere between.

If Deepak has children, what shall I tell them about my home? I do not want them to think their mother's maternal side was some dark pit. There were people there—hard people, frightened people, loving people, silent people.

Yours, Manjari”

For the first time compassion stood clearly beside Manjari's anger in this letter. That was why Kirti found it the most difficult of all. A story remains simple when pain belongs entirely to one side; when the injured person, with time, also begins to see complexity, fewer excuses remain for the reader.

8

The Katihar address was no longer useful. Then Shailendra remembered something: in 1994 Deepak had given Dadi his visiting card. “It may be in the diary.”

In the pocket at the back of the diary they found not the card, but half of it. Name—“Deepak S. Jha”; company name; below it a Calcutta telephone number with part of the digits rubbed away.

Nilansh suggested searching for the company on the internet. Kirti did not object. This search was no longer an insult to the documents; it was the natural next step in seeking a living branch of the family.

The old company was closed. But the name produced a reference to a retired engineer—Deepak Shashibhushan Jha, Salt Lake, Kolkata. A public page also mentioned an educational programme involving his daughter, “Richa Jha.”

Kirti closed the screen.

Nilansh was surprised. “Shall we find a phone number?”

“First decide what we will say.”

Shailendra said, “The truth.”

Kirti asked, “Whose truth? Ours? Dadi's? Manjari's? His?”

No one answered at once.

In the end Shailendra wrote a short letter. Not a phone call. The letter carried neither the excitement of a digital discovery nor the performance of an apology.

“Respected Deepak Dada,

I am Shailendra. You may have seen me once in my childhood. In our house we have found old letters between Manjari Didi and Sudha Maaji. For the first time I am beginning to understand the branch of the family about which I was never told the whole story. If you consider it right, I would like to speak with you. If not, we will respect your silence. The letters are safe.

— Shailendra”

Kirti suggested that they should not write “your family” in the final line. The right to declare a relationship should not be seized in the first letter itself.

The letter was sent by post.

9

The reply came fifteen days later. A white envelope. The handwriting was that of an old hand, but clear.

“Dear Shailendra,

After reading your letter I was unable to write anything for a long time. My mother Manjari died in 2006. Sudha Mausi’s letters remained in a box with her until her last years. I too have some letters—perhaps the other half of those letters.

I did not grow up hating your house. My mother did not grant me that simple convenience. She used to say—be angry with people, but do not make the story small.

I met Sudha Mausi once. Whether that meeting was enough for me, I still do not know.

If you wish, we can exchange copies of the letters. Let us match the papers first. We can meet the people later.

— Deepak”

Nilansh read it and said, “Match the papers first—this really does seem to be a family trait.”

Shailendra laughed. Malati Devi wiped her eyes and, while wiping them, said, “Dust. Smoke got in.”

There was no smoke on the veranda.

10

A month later a thick envelope arrived by post. Inside were photocopies of Sudha’s letters preserved by Manjari. The story that had so far been heard only in Manjari’s voice opened into a second voice.

Sudha had written:

“Didi, Babuji’s anger has not lessened, but last week he looked at Deepak’s photograph for a very long time. When he saw me, he put it away. I do not know whether I should have told you this.”

Another letter:

“Amma says she will knit a woollen sweater for Deepak. Then she says she will not send it. Then she keeps knitting. I cannot understand why one makes a thing one does not intend to send.”

A third:

“Didi, your condition is right. Deepak will not enter through the back door. But Babuji is still alive. My courage is still only half.”

Kirti stopped while reading. “Half a courage”—perhaps the whole history of this house lived inside those two words.

Deepak had also sent a photograph in the envelope. Young Manjari, Sudha, and Deepak between them. The same photograph, but a clear copy. On the back, in Manjari’s hand: “We three—of one house, in three places.”

Kirti placed the old blurred photograph beside it. Two copies, two houses, one moment.

On the back of Letter 10 — Deepak’s unsent draft, 1994

Among Deepak’s papers was a sheet marked in pencil: “Written to Mausi, not sent.” The handwriting was that of a young man.

“Sudha Mausi,

I returned yesterday after meeting you. Two hours is a very small amount of time, but inside me it became very large. I still do not know whether you recognised me the moment you saw me. You said, “Sit.” Only that. I wanted you to say “Deepak.” Then I thought perhaps the name had caught in your throat.

You showed me Babuji’s photograph. Was I searching in it for my grandfather, or for my mother? I do not know that either. I touched your feet. You placed your hand on my head, but said nothing. When I stepped out of the house I was angry. On the road the anger lessened. Now, as I write, there is only tiredness.

Ma used to say you were not weak; there was simply too much fear around you. I did not believe that before. Yesterday, seeing your hand tremble, I understood—fear can remain in the body for many years.

I do not know whether I will meet you again. If I do, this time seat me outside your private room. I want to see the courtyard.”

The letter did not end there; the lower half was torn away. Whether Deepak himself cut it, or time did, there was no answer.

Sudha’s draft — possibly after that meeting

“Deepak,

I wanted to call you “Baua.” I could not. After you left, that one word went round and round in my mind all day. I am writing at night. It is a shame that saying it on paper is easier.

Your mother was my elder sister. I kept that sentence inside for so many years that now, when I take it out, I do not trust my own voice.

It would be false to say that your grandfather was as hard in life as he looks in the photograph. He used to look at your picture. But he did not have the courage to call you home. I do not lessen his fault. I only want to remember the whole human being.

If you come again, sit in the courtyard. Come through the front door. I could have written this sentence thirty years ago. I did not. I am writing it now.”

This letter too had never been sent. How a copy reached Deepak was unclear. Perhaps Sudha later gave it through someone; perhaps Deepak saw it with the diary at the time of his visit. In her catalogue Kirti wrote only: "Provenance uncertain."

Between these two unsent letters Kirti saw the most living bridge in the family. What people could not say sitting face to face, they wrote on paper; then they did not even have the courage to send the paper. Yet the words survived.

II

At the next family shraddha, when everyone had gathered, Shailendra spoke about the letters. There was no meeting, no announcement. After the meal people were sitting on the veranda while the children ran about.

One uncle said, "What is gained by digging up old matters?"

Kirti was about to speak, but Malati Devi spoke first. "Gain is something you measure in land. Not in names."

The uncle fell silent.

Someone else asked, "Then will you add them to the genealogy now?"

Shailendra replied, "First add them to the family's memory. The papers can come later."

Kirti was satisfied with that answer. Paper did not become the centre again. The work of the letters was not to imprison people inside documents, but to make one another acknowledge that they had existed.

That day Sudha Dadi's odhni with the red border was taken out of the cupboard. Part of its edge did indeed have a strip of zari different from the rest of the cloth. No one could prove that it was a piece of Manjari's wedding sari. But no one called it mere decoration either.

Malati Devi placed the odhni over Kirti's shoulders.

"Why me?"

"You opened the box."

"The rain opened the box."

Malati Devi laughed. "All right, then put it on the rain."

Everyone laughed. The tension lightened.

Document 12 — Kirti's note, not a letter

While cataloguing all the documents, Kirti wrote at the end:

"Manjari — Sudha's elder sister. After the early death of her husband Shashibhushan Jha, she lived with her son Deepak at her maternal uncle's house. Ties with the natal family did not completely break, but public mention and domestic acknowledgement remained limited. Correspondence chiefly with Sudha.

Deepak — Manjari's son. Met Sudha in 1994. Later resident in Kolkata.

Richa — Deepak's daughter.

Information verified up to this point. No inference beyond it."

Nilansh read it and said, "Write 'hidden branch' here."

Kirti shook her head. "It was hidden, but the branch did not hide itself. The house shut its eyes."

"Then the title?"

Kirti laughed. "The story writer will think of the title."

12

The first video conversation with Deepak took place three months later. On the screen appeared a thin man of eighty, a bookcase behind him. Richa sat beside him.

For the first five minutes everyone spoke of weather, health and cities. No one immediately said "family."

Then Deepak asked, "Has the red border survived?"

Malati Devi brought the odhni and held it out before the camera.

Deepak looked at it for a long time. "Ma used to say Sudha Mausi had stitched that piece in."

Kirti said, "I have no proof, but I have the cloth."

Deepak laughed. "In some matters, cloth is better than proof."

Richa asked, "When will we all meet?"

At the question Shailendra's face changed. Perhaps he had expected the first real question to concern the past; Richa asked about the future.

"Whenever it suits all of you," Shailendra said.

Deepak intervened. "Slowly. First let us read the letters. We know very little about one another."

Kirti agreed. Finding the hidden branch did not mean it had to be grafted instantly back onto the old trunk. Relationships, like new planting, also ask for time.

13

At the end of the year Kirti did not put the box back under the stairs. The letters were kept in clean cloth on top of the inner cupboard on the veranda. The red border was not separated; it remained wrapped around the same bundle.

Kirti made a digital copy of every letter, but did not unfold and flatten the original papers. Their folds too were history. Here the oil of a fingertip, there rainwater, elsewhere an unfinished letter.

One evening the electricity went out. Malati Devi lit a small lamp. The slanting light flashed on the transparent sleeves around the letters.

Nilansh said, "So now everything is clear?"

Kirti lifted an incomplete fragment. Only four words survived on it: "I could not return..." Then the paper was torn.

"Everything?" Kirti said. "No."

"The main thing?"

Kirti thought. “Perhaps the main thing is clear. The rest of the life remains.”

She opened the red cloth and placed a blank sheet among all the letters. Nilansh asked, “Why this?”

“For later, if Richa writes. Or her child. Or if no one writes—then it will remain blank.”

“Is a blank page also part of it?”

“Yes. Because we will not assume the branch ends here.”

Malati Devi adjusted the lamp’s wick. The light grew larger.

The shadows of the letters made different lines on the wall—some straight, some crooked, some falling across one another. From a distance they truly looked like the branches of a tree.

Kirti placed the box’s old brass key on top of the red cloth.

The box was closed again, but this time the matter was not.

— *End of Story 16* —

17. Adoption

STORY

I

The summons arrived one evening in Kartik. It was not brought by the postman but by a court employee on a motorcycle. He handed the paper to Shambhunath Jha and said, "You must appear next Wednesday."

Shambhunath opened the paper and read the first line, then removed his spectacles and set them on the veranda pillar. Petitioner—Ramanath Jha. Respondents—Shambhunath Jha and Abhinav Jha. Subject—lineage, acceptance in adoption, and rights in property.

Ramanath's courtyard lay three houses away. The distance between the two brothers was so small that laughter in one house could be heard in the other. But for the last eight months that distance had grown wider than a road.

Gauri Devi took the paper in her hand. She did not read all of it. Her finger stopped only at Abhinav's name. "Why has he made him a respondent?"

Shambhunath said, "Because the case is not about his body. It is about his name."

Abhinav was returning from Madhubani at the time. On the phone his father said only, "Son, you'll have to take leave on Wednesday."

"Is someone ill?" Abhinav asked.

"No. The lineage is ill," Shambhunath said.

For a few moments there was silence at the other end. Abhinav understood. The dispute that for eight months had been circling among verandas, field boundaries, the row at the shraddha feast, and the pages of the Panji had now entered a court file.

2

There were two years between Shambhunath and Ramanath. As boys they slept on the same cot, bathed in the same pond, and were beaten by the same schoolmaster. After marriage their hearths separated, but work in the fields, festivals, illness, and the anxiety of debt remained shared.

Shambhunath's wife, Gauri Devi, conceived three times; none of the children lived. The fourth time the doctor said plainly that it would not be right to place any further strain on Gauri's body. In the house, discussion of the matter gradually turned into silence.

Ramanath and Sunaina had two sons—Arvind and Abhinav. Arvind was the elder, quick and capable, and helped his father with the fields. Abhinav was younger, frequently ill, but loved books.

Abhinav was three when Sunaina was down with fever for a month. Gauri took him to her own house. “I’ll keep him for two days,” she had said. Two days became two weeks; two weeks became two months.

When Sunaina recovered, Abhinav would, as evening fell, clutch Gauri’s sari-end and walk toward her house. Ramanath would laugh and say, “He has become your son.”

At first Gauri laughed too. Then one day she did not. She rested her hand on Abhinav’s head and said only, “What if that were not a joke?”

After that sentence, the family talked for many months. The old father said, “The child of the house will remain in the house; what difference does changing a name make?” A priest was called, some rites were performed, there was a feast. Some people called it “adoption,” some “fostering,” some “the younger son going to the elder house.”

No one thought of preparing papers that would satisfy a court. A decision witnessed by the whole neighbourhood—why would it need a document? That was how everyone thought then.

When Abhinav entered school, Shambhunath’s name was written in the father’s-name column. The later papers, including Aadhaar, carried the same name. His wedding invitation called him “the worthy son of Shambhunath and Gauri.” Ramanath sat in the front row at every ceremony.

No one asked how far this sonship extended. The question arose only when Arvind died suddenly.

3

Arvind was killed in a motorcycle accident. Until the previous evening he had been calculating the paddy accounts with Ramanath. The next morning his body lay on the veranda of the house.

After that death Ramanath changed from within. His only surviving biological son was Abhinav, but the village called him Shambhunath’s son. On the day of the shraddha, someone asked casually, “Who will carry Ramanath Babu’s lineage now?”

It was hard to say whether the question was ordinary or cruel. But the line lodged inside Ramanath.

A few months later he said to Shambhunath, “Abhinav is my son by birth. Arvind is gone. At least have his name written again in my branch of the Panji.”

Shambhunath replied, “Who said the line of birth must be erased? But will you erase thirty years of his life too?”

“I am not erasing his life.” Ramanath’s voice rose. “I am asking whether the adoption was ever completed. Where are the papers?”

Gauri stepped in. “The child who has lived in this house since he was three—now you ask for his papers?”

Ramanath said, "So I gave away my son's body, and now not even his name is mine?"

That day Sunaina spoke sharply for the first time. "Who gave away his body? You? Did anyone ask me?"

Everyone fell silent.

After that one sentence, the quarrel was no longer only between two brothers. The woman's voice that had not been written into the old decision emerged thirty years later.

While Arvind was alive, the question of Abhinav being "adopted" had never stood at the centre of the household. The brothers had created their own language for their relationship. In matters of farming, Arvind called Abhinav "the city gentleman"; Abhinav called him "the Vice-Chancellor of Paddy University."

The boundary was no clearer for the children of the two houses. Which courtyard to visit first at a festival, which mother to call by what name—life itself had made those rules. Abhinav had decorated the house until late at night for Arvind's daughter's birthday; at Abhinav's wedding Arvind danced in front of the horse and lost one sandal.

Once Arvind had joked, "You may be Big Father's son, but don't stop being my younger brother." Abhinav had replied, "That title is written nowhere on paper." Arvind had said, "That is why it is permanent."

After the accident that sentence returned to Abhinav again and again. While Arvind lived, the relations between the two houses had possessed a certain flexibility. His death hardened that flexibility into lines. Ramanath had lost a son; Shambhunath feared Ramanath would now draw Abhinav back to his side; Sunaina grieved one son while watching the men stake claims over the other.

Abhinav himself was surrounded most of all by Arvind's absence. Yet almost no one asked much about his grief. The family's questions suddenly became questions of lineage, father's name, and shares. Sometimes he felt that Arvind's death had opened a new blank space in the family and everyone wanted to fill it with Abhinav's name.

4

On the first day in court, Abhinav sat on the rearmost chair. Two lawyers stood before him, a heap of papers between them. His name appeared in large letters on top of the file, as though he were not the person present in the room but the object in dispute.

Within the first five minutes the judge made one thing clear: "The court will not give an emotional ruling on who the 'real father' is. Put the legal questions plainly—the claim of an adoptive relationship, the claim over property, and the effect of the records."

Ramanath's lawyer argued that the family rite had been ambiguous, that no written adoption deed had been duly proved, and that for this reason the issue of shares in ancestral land remained uncertain.

Shambhunath's lawyer replied that thirty years of public and continuous conduct could not simply be ignored—school records, medical consent forms, wedding invitations, bank nominations, the panchayat family list: all recorded Shambhunath and Gauri as parents or guardians.

The judge asked, "Produce the property documents separately. The question of sonship and the question of title to land are not one and the same."

The sentence lodged in Abhinav's mind. For eight months the family had merged two questions; on the very first day the court separated them.

Outside in the corridor Ramanath saw Abhinav but did not speak. Shambhunath did not either. Both men stood with their respective lawyers counting papers.

Abhinav went to Sunaina. "Mother, are you all right?"

Sunaina said, "Your two fathers are each trying to save their own papers. You save yourself."

On the night after the first hearing Abhinav sat on the roof with his wife, Maitreyi. Below, Gauri Devi was putting the kitchen in order. In the distance a lamp also burned in Ramanath's house. At night the three houses between them seemed even fewer.

Maitreyi asked, "Whose side are you on in court?"

Abhinav laughed. "In the file I'm a respondent. In this house I'm a son. In the other house I'm also a son. Which side?"

"Then make your own side," Maitreyi said.

At that moment their ten-year-old daughter Anvi came to the roof carrying a notebook. Her school assignment was: "Make your family tree." There were fixed boxes for grandparents, parents, and children.

Anvi asked, "Baba, why do you have four grandparents?"

Abhinav looked at the printed tree. It had room for no more than four roots. He drew one extra line with a pencil. Then another. Anvi laughed. "If I do that, Teacher will say I spoiled the format."

"Write that the tree grew," Abhinav said.

Maitreyi remained silent for a long moment. Then she said, "See? Before the court decides, a child's notebook is already demanding a decision."

That night Abhinav understood for the first time that the dispute did not belong only to the previous generation. If he did not create a language for his own relationships, the next generation too would cut people down to fit the same small boxes.

5

On the second date, Shambhunath was cross-examined.

Ramanath's lawyer asked, "Where is the adoption deed?"

"There was a paper."

"The original?"

"It has not been found."

"Was it registered?"

"I don't remember. At that time we did not understand such things."

“Who was present at the ceremony?”

Shambhunath listed nearly twelve names. Four were dead, three lived away, two had lost much of their memory to old age.

The lawyer asked, “Did Ramanath state explicitly, ‘I give my son in adoption?’”

Shambhunath was silent. “I do not remember the exact words.”

“Meaning you are not certain?”

Shambhunath’s face reddened. “I am certain that from that day the child was the son of my house.”

“I am asking for evidence of an act, not the feeling of a life.”

Shambhunath answered quietly, “In life, feeling too is an act. But I understand your question.”

For the first time Abhinav heard weariness in his father’s voice. A father of thirty years had become a witness in a single day.

6

On the third date, Ramanath was cross-examined.

Shambhunath’s lawyer placed an old school admission form before him. “The father’s name here is Shambhunath Jha. Whose signature is this?”

Ramanath looked. “Mine.”

“Did you object?”

“No.”

The wedding invitation was shown. “Here Abhinav is described as ‘the worthy son of Shambhunath and Gauri.’ You sat there like the chief guest?”

“I did.”

“Any objection then?”

“No.”

An old hospital consent form was produced. When adolescent Abhinav underwent surgery, Shambhunath had signed as “father/guardian,” and Ramanath as witness.

The lawyer asked, “Why did you not oppose this relationship for thirty years?”

Ramanath’s eyes lifted from the papers for the first time. “Because Arvind was alive.”

The courtroom fell absolutely silent.

The lawyer rose to ask the next question, but the judge raised a hand. “Let him complete the answer.”

Ramanath said, “After Arvind was gone I realised—who will light the next lamp in my house? My younger son is before my eyes, but everyone calls him brother, not son.”

The lawyer asked quietly, “Then is this case about property or lineage?”

Ramanath did not answer. Perhaps for the first time he himself realised that he could no longer separate the two.

Two witnesses came before Sunaina. The first was Devvrat Mishra, a retired headmaster. In his school register, Abhinav’s admission record said

“Father—Shambhunath Jha.” The lawyer asked, “Who supplied this information?”

Devvrat thought for a long time. “Shambhunathji brought the child. Ramanathji was with him. Shambhunath filled the form; Ramanath signed as witness.”

“Did you see an adoption deed?”

“No. At school I attended to a child’s education, not the law of lineage.”

The second witness was an elderly man from the neighbourhood, Bholakant. He claimed to have been present on the day of the ceremony, but on three separate occasions he gave three different dates. A light laugh rose in the courtroom. The judge stopped it.

At last Bholakant said, “I may forget the date. But the child was in Gauri’s lap, Sunaina was kissing his head, and both brothers were sitting together. I ate the feast—that I know for certain.”

The lawyer asked, “Was it an adoption ceremony?”

Bholakant replied, “To me it was a family matter. No one then imagined that thirty years later I would be sitting in this chair choosing legal words.”

Nothing decisive was proved by this testimony. But one thing became clear in court: old events survive in memory like pictures, not like legal definitions. People who had participated naturally that day were now being asked to translate their memories into the language of law.

7

The corridor was crowded on the day of Sunaina’s testimony. Many in the family assumed she would support Ramanath.

After taking the oath, Sunaina sat down. The judge asked, “Was the arrangement concerning Abhinav’s childhood made with your consent?”

Sunaina thought for a while. “Consent is a very clean word. Life at that time was not that clean.”

“Please explain.”

“I was ill. The child was staying with Gauri Didi. When I recovered, he would not stay without her. The men in the family said it would be good for both houses if the child lived in the elder house. I did not object. But no one sat me down alone and asked: are you giving your son away or not?”

Ramanath’s lawyer grew uncomfortable. “But later you accepted it?”

“I accepted his happiness.”

“The adoption?”

“I do not know the law of the word. I am a mother. I saw the child was at ease between two houses. I did not want to tear him in two.”

Shambhunath’s lawyer asked, “Do you consider Abhinav your heir?”

Sunaina laughed—a laugh carrying more sorrow than amusement. “Why must people first consider a son an heir? Consider him a son. Look at inheritance later.”

The judge stopped writing and looked at her.

Sunaina continued, “I want one thing put on record. No one can remove Abhinav from my womb. And no one can erase Gauri Didi’s thirty years of

motherhood. If the court has to divide land, divide land. Do not divide a mother into halves.”

Abhinav lowered his head. For the first time that day he felt close to tears.

8

When Gauri Devi came to testify, she carried a cloth bag. Inside it were fewer papers than objects from a child’s life—a first-standard slate, a fifth-standard prize slip, an old fever prescription, a card on which Abhinav had written the word “Mother.”

The lawyer smiled faintly. “These are emotional objects, not documents.”

Gauri remained calm. “If you ask for documents, I will give documents. But the file of my life is incomplete without these.”

From the bottom of the bag she took out a yellowed paper. It bore the signatures of two witnesses, Shambhunath’s and Ramanath’s signatures, and Sunaina’s thumb impression. Its heading read: “Agreement concerning the upbringing and family acceptance of the child Abhinav.”

The word “adoption” appeared in one place, while a later line used “upbringing.” The lawyers immediately seized on different lines.

The judge read the paper carefully. “This document does not by itself give the final answer to every question. But it is certainly evidence of the family’s intention at that time.”

Ramanath kept staring at the paper. “Where was this?”

“In your father’s box,” Gauri said. “After his death it came to me. I thought it would never be needed.”

Ramanath’s voice broke. “I signed this?”

“Yes.”

“I don’t remember.”

Gauri answered gently, “Memory changes. Sometimes paper stands before a changing memory. But paper is not the whole of life either.”

9

Abhinav’s testimony was the hardest, because both sides wanted to turn him into proof of their own case.

Ramanath’s lawyer asked, “Whom do you recognise as your biological father?”

“Ramanath Jha.”

“Your father by upbringing?”

“Shambhunath Jha.”

“Your legal father?”

Abhinav did not laugh, but there was weariness in his eyes. “That is the question you people want to answer. In my life I have called both of them father, in different contexts.”

“Do you claim a share in Ramanath Jha’s property?”

“No.”

Ramanath suddenly looked at him.

“In Shambhunath Jha’s property?”

“Whatever he gives, I will accept. I have not filed a suit for rights.”

Shambhunath’s lawyer asked, “Then what do you want in this case?”

Abhinav remained silent for a long time. “I want no one to move me from one house to another.”

“What do you mean?” the judge asked.

“As though I were a parcel of land that can be transferred from one branch to another.”

He continued, “When Arvind Bhaiya was alive, all my relationships seemed natural to everyone. After he died, suddenly I became a tool for filling a blank place in the lineage. I cannot become Bhaiya. I am the same person I have been for thirty years.”

Silence returned to the courtroom. In this case silence repeatedly said what questions in cross-examination could not.

After Abhinav’s testimony, the Panji-keeper was called. The present Panji-keeper had been a young man at the time; the original entry had been made by his father. In the old book Abhinav’s name appeared in Shambhunath’s branch, but in small writing at the margin stood: “Son of Ramanath by birth; in upbringing since childhood.”

Both lawyers drew their own meanings from the same note. One emphasised “son,” the other “upbringing.”

The Panji-keeper said quietly, “You are each reading half a line. Read the whole line together.”

The judge asked, “Is the Panji a legal adoption certificate?”

“I would not make such a claim,” the Panji-keeper said. “It is a memory of lineage and a social record. It has uses, but by itself it does not answer every legal question.”

“Then what does this entry mean?”

“It is a trace of how the family understood the relationship at that time. But the life of a family is larger than a line.”

Ramanath kept looking at the Panji. Perhaps for the first time he saw that the old book was not taking his side or Shambhunath’s. It had merely preserved the uncomfortable mixed truth of that time.

The land map was opened that same day—the boundary ridges, plot numbers, separate deeds of purchase and sale. Some of the land called “Father’s fields” in family conversation had later been bought by Shambhunath and Gauri with their own earnings. Some had been purchased independently by Ramanath. Only part was genuinely shared ancestral land.

Abhinav felt exhausted from within. Human beings make relationships whole; papers separate things. But the dispute had reversed the process—relationships had been cut into pieces and land merged into one. Slowly the court was returning both to their proper compartments.

IO

A few weeks later the judge suggested mediation. "The documents relating to ownership of the land can be examined separately. But I am not certain a written order about family relationships will end the dispute. Sit together once outside court."

The first meeting failed. Ramanath said, "I only want my son's name in my branch of the Panji." Shambhunath said, "I will not allow my son's name to be cut out."

The mediator asked, "Why can't one name be written with two relationships?"

Both brothers said at once, "The Panji is not written that way."

Abhinav laughed for the first time. "Then the Panji will learn."

At the second meeting Sunaina and Gauri sat facing each other. The two men sat in separate corners.

Sunaina said, "Ramanath, don't fill your grief for Arvind with Abhinav's name."

Ramanath bristled. "You think I am starving for a son."

"Yes. But longing does not become a right."

Gauri turned toward Shambhunath. "And you? You hold Abhinav as though Ramanath will snatch him away."

Shambhunath said nothing.

Gauri continued, "We raised him for thirty years. Have some trust as well."

On the paper before him Abhinav wrote two terms: "birth-bond" and "upbringing-bond." He did not draw a line between them.

II

At the third mediation session, the property issue was separated first. Old partition maps, tax receipts, possession records, and papers for some land standing in Gauri's name were examined. Much that the family thought of as "the same land" was already separate on paper.

A large portion of Ramanath's claim rested on the mistaken belief that all of Shambhunath's land was ancestral property shared by the brothers. Some was ancestral; some had later been bought by Shambhunath and Gauri.

The mediator said, "The share that is genuinely joint can be calculated even without deciding the adoption question. What was privately acquired can be treated separately. First let land remain land."

Ramanath said wearily, "So half the case ends here?"

"Perhaps the half about land," Abhinav replied.

"And the rest?"

"The rest is us."

That day, for the first time after a mediation meeting, Shambhunath and Ramanath returned in the same vehicle. Abhinav did not sit between them. He travelled in another vehicle with Gauri and Sunaina.

For the first time the brothers had a chance to speak to each other without placing their son between them. No one knew what they said. After reaching home Ramanath said only, "Call the Panji-keeper tomorrow."

One evening shortly before the third mediation meeting, Shambhunath went to the old mango tree. Ramanath was already sitting there. They had climbed that tree as boys; now both had aching knees.

Shambhunath said, "Withdraw the case."

Ramanath replied, "Let Abhinav be entered in my branch."

"The same thing again."

"The same thing again."

After a while Ramanath asked, "Do you remember that day? When Gauri first said Abhinav should live in our house?"

"Yes. You laughed," Shambhunath said.

"I laughed because I had two sons then. I thought my younger brother's house would be filled—what would I lose?" Ramanath kept scraping the earth. "I did not understand that one day one of my sons would no longer be there."

For the first time Shambhunath's anger softened. "And I did not understand that your grief would become a claim upon my son."

Ramanath lifted his head. "Sometimes it feels to me that after Arvind's pyre every sound in my house became half. When Abhinav comes, it feels whole again. Then he returns to your house."

"You have not stopped him," Shambhunath said.

"If I stop him, it will be the same mistake again. He is not a child. He is a thirty-year-old man."

They fell silent. A raw mango dropped from the tree and struck the earth. Shambhunath picked it up and turned it in his hand. "I was afraid too. I thought: Arvind is gone; now you'll pull Abhinav into your house and leave mine empty again."

Ramanath said slowly, "I was afraid of my empty house; you were afraid yours would become empty."

After that one sentence, for the first time the brothers saw not land but fear inside the dispute. There was still no solution, but the real shape beneath the hostility had become visible.

12

The Panji-keeper was an old man. He opened the old Panji and said, "Here Abhinav is written in Shambhunath's branch. His birth father is not in the main line, only the note."

Ramanath said at once, "That is not right."

Shambhunath said too, "Don't cut him out."

The Panji-keeper looked at both men over his spectacles. "You two have come back from court to give orders here again?"

Gauri laughed. Sunaina did too.

Abhinav wrote a proposal in his own hand: "Abhinav: birth-bond—Ramanath—Sunaina; upbringing/adoptive bond—Shambhunath—Gauri; family acceptance continuous since childhood."

The Panji-keeper read it. "There has never been an entry like this in my book."

"Then let this be the first," Abhinav said.

Ramanath asked, "His name will be in my branch too?"

"In the birth-bond."

Shambhunath asked, "It will not be removed from my branch?"

"No."

The two men looked at each other. The decision was so simple that perhaps this was what made it difficult: no one person could call it a victory.

A settlement was filed in court. The genuinely joint ancestral land was apportioned by separate agreement; Ramanath withdrew his claim over land privately owned by Shambhunath and Gauri; Abhinav stated in writing that he would not claim Ramanath's remaining property in order to fill Arvind's place. The court recorded the settlement and closed the case.

At the end the judge said only one thing: "A court can end a dispute; you will have to carry on the relationships yourselves."

Even after the settlement was written, one final court date remained. That day, for the first time, the lawyers for both sides sat on the same bench in the corridor, reconciling the papers. Sentences that for months had been framed as allegations were now being rewritten in the language of agreement.

One draft line said: "Abhinav is recognised as adopted son." Ramanath objected immediately. It was changed to: "Abhinav is the son by birth of Ramanath and Sunaina and has, since childhood, been in a relationship of upbringing/adoption with Shambhunath and Gauri." Shambhunath stopped at the word "upbringing."

Abhinav said, "Stop trying to complete me with one word. Write both relationships, that is all."

Reading the settlement, the judge asked, "Do the parties accept this voluntarily?" Both brothers said yes. Gauri and Sunaina were not parties to the litigation, but from their seats behind them the two women looked at each other.

The judge then asked Abhinav, "Do you agree with this wording?"

"Yes," Abhinav said, "provided no one treats it as the complete definition of my humanity."

A very slight smile appeared on the judge's face. "The court is not that ambitious."

As they came out into the corridor, an old acquaintance, Ramlochan, met them and asked eagerly, "Who won?"

Ramanath opened his mouth to answer, but Shambhunath said first, "The one who charged the fee."

After many months, both brothers laughed at the same joke. Ramlochan was disappointed; he wanted a clear winner.

On the way home Abhinav kept thinking that society wants a winner at the end of a dispute, as though a story without a winner were incomplete. But

some family cases end only when people leave room for one another's existence instead of trying to win.

That evening Sunaina was massaging oil into Abhinav's scalp when she asked, "What did the court say?"

"That we should see land as land, and relationships as relationships."

Sunaina said, "It took so many papers to say that?"

Abhinav laughed. "Perhaps we needed a heap of paper before we could see one simple thing."

Gauri came carrying tea. Sunaina took a cup. For a few moments the two mothers sat on the same low bench. Abhinav did not sit between them; he sat on the ground in front.

Sunaina said, "If you were little, I would have pulled you into my lap."

"And I would have caught the other arm," Gauri replied.

"That is why I am better on the ground now," Abhinav said.

All three laughed. The laughter did not erase the flaw in the decision made thirty years earlier, but for the first time they carried its weight together.

13

Three months after the case ended came Arvind's death anniversary. In the morning Ramanath lit lamps in the courtyard—one before Arvind's photograph, one in the shrine room.

When Abhinav arrived, Ramanath looked at him for a few moments and then said, "The lamp is low on oil. Fill it."

The ordinariness of the sentence loosened something inside Abhinav. After months of courtrooms, testimony, father-names, branches, and shares, he had finally been asked to do a household task.

He filled the oil. Shambhunath arrived as well. The two brothers sat on the same mat; there was no lawyer between them now.

After the meal Ramanath gave Abhinav an old tin box. Inside were childhood photographs of Arvind and Abhinav, two marbles, a broken whistle, and their first school group photograph.

"This is yours too," Ramanath said.

"And Bhaiya's?" Abhinav asked.

"His too. A shared thing does not become half merely because it is divided."

Shambhunath heard from a little distance. He said softly, "If you had said that in court, we could have saved the fees."

Ramanath laughed for the first time. "If I had not gone to court, I might never have understood it."

That evening Abhinav sat with all four of his parents. Gauri served tea; Sunaina set down a bowl of makhana. No one asked him, "Whose son are you?"

A small lamp burned in a niche of the veranda. The wind bent the flame again and again to one side, and again it straightened.

Abhinav opened the copy of the Panji's new entry. One name had been written with two bonds. Paper was still paper—limited, flat, incomplete. But this time its incompleteness had been acknowledged.

He folded the paper and put it in his pocket. Before him sat four people whose relations to him could not fit inside a single word.

The lamp's light fell differently on all four faces, but the flame was one.

— *End of Story 17* —

18. Across Caste

STORY

I

When Ira's birth certificate was being made, the employee at the hospital counter asked, "Surname?"

Nilima looked at Chandan before answering. Chandan smiled and said, "For now, write only Ira."

The employee stopped his pen. "Only Ira? Not the father's surname?"

"The father's name is in another box," Nilima said.

The employee turned the paper around. "I am concerned with the rules. If there is difficulty later at school, you will say the hospital made an error."

Chandan said quietly, "Not an error. Leave it blank."

Ira was two days old then. She knew nothing of surnames, gotra, clan, caste, or Panji. Both her hands were closed into fists, and after drinking milk she slept against Nilima's breast.

When Chandan's father, Bhaveshwar Jha, heard about it, he asked only one thing on the phone: "Why not Jha?"

"Babu, the child is two days old," Chandan said.

"So? A name is written now itself?"

"The name has been written. Ira."

There was silence at the other end. Then Bhaveshwar said, "A name without lineage remains half."

Nilima sat nearby listening. She did not take the phone. Later she asked Chandan only, "Is my lineage half?"

"No," Chandan said at once.

"Then whose half is Ira?"

Chandan had no immediate answer. On Ira's first night, the question rose through the room like smoke from a lamp and remained under the ceiling.

2

Chandan and Nilima had married for love, but their marriage was discussed more for caste than for love. Chandan came from an old Maithil Brahmin family that kept a Panji; Nilima was from a Paswan family in which the memory of lineage lived less in books than in people's voices, songs, photographs, and places of burial and cremation.

They had studied in the same university department. First they spoke of books, then hostel food, then floods, then jobs. Caste became their largest subject only after they decided to marry.

Nilima's father, Sitaram Paswan, told her, "The marriage is yours. But when you go into that house, do not make your own name smaller."

Her mother, Kamala Devi, said, "Who needs to make it smaller? A name should remain as much as it is."

In Chandan's house things were not easy. Bhaveshwar Jha sat silent at the dining platform for three days. Chandan's mother, Saroj Devi, wept while folding her son's clothes. Uncle Madhukant said plainly, "If you marry, the question of the name in the clan-book will arise."

Chandan had replied, "The book is not getting married."

"The book tells us who we are," Madhukant said.

Nilima heard of that sentence much later. She said, "A book that cannot even see me—how can it tell you all of who you are?"

The wedding was a small ceremony. Chandan's mother came. His father did not. Everyone from Nilima's household came, though several acquaintances kept their distance.

Six months later Saroj Devi quietly visited her son and daughter-in-law in Patna. After drinking tea made by Nilima, she said, "A little less sugar." It was her first form of acceptance.

Bhaveshwar did not visit for two years. In the third year, when news of Ira's birth reached him, he remained silent the first day, telephoned on the second, and on the third sent a little silver anklet.

The anklet had "Ira" engraved on it in small letters. No surname.

3

When Ira was five, she went for the first time to her grandparents' village. It was after the rains. Grass had sprung up in the unpaved part of the courtyard, and the brass lamp in the veranda niche carried black soot even in daylight.

Saroj Devi lifted Ira into her arms the moment she saw her. Bhaveshwar stood at the doorway smiling, though he took a moment before extending his hands. Ira herself ran forward and clung to his knees.

That evening the clan-book was brought out. Not because of Ira, but because Chandan's cousin Raghav's marriage was being discussed. A thick book wrapped in cloth, red thread, old paper, branches of names.

Ira leaned over the pages and asked, "Where am I?"

The courtyard fell completely silent.

Uncle Madhukant tried to laugh. "You are still little. You'll be written later."

Ira was not satisfied. "Where is Mummy?"

No one answered.

Nilima sat at a distance on a low seat with a cup of tea in her hand. She set the cup down, but did not rise.

Chandan said, "This book contains old names from the father's side."

Ira asked again, "Mummy's father? Nani?"

“They will have their own lineage,” Madhukant said.

Ira replied simply, “Mine will have both, won’t it?”

Saroj Devi stroked Ira’s head. Bhaveshwar began turning the pages of the book. The question was not written on paper, but from that day onward it remained in the house.

4

Three years later, school assigned a project called “My Family Tree.” The teacher told the children to write the names of their parents, paternal and maternal grandparents, and, if they wished, their birthplaces.

Ira sat down with coloured pencils. She wrote her own name at the top. Below it she drew two branches—“Mother” and “Father.” Then four branches—Kamala, Sitaram, Saroj, Bhaveshwar.

She asked Chandan, “Babu, where should I write the gotra?”

Chandan was startled. “Who told you about that?”

“Dada did last time, at Raghav Kaka’s wedding.”

Chandan looked at the page. “Write it if you want. If you don’t want to, don’t.”

“What is Nani’s gotra?” Ira asked.

Nilima laughed. “In our house there was no list of that kind.”

Ira became serious. “Then is Nani less?”

“No,” Nilima said immediately.

“Then how necessary is a thing that exists on one side and not on the other?”

Nilima looked at Chandan. Children’s questions are hardest because they do not want the old language of answers; they want direct meaning.

Ira made no gotra box on her page. Instead she wrote one fact beneath every name—Kamala: saves seeds. Sitaram: used to repair bicycles. Saroj: makes papad. Bhaveshwar: keeps old books.

Chandan asked, “What will you write under me?”

Ira wrote, “Babu argues.”

Nilima laughed aloud.

“And under Mummy?”

Ira thought and wrote, “Mummy does not go silent after losing.”

Nilima’s laughter stopped for a moment. She kissed the child’s head.

5

A photograph of the school family tree was sent to Saroj Devi on WhatsApp. She was pleased. Bhaveshwar looked at it and then telephoned.

“Ira has written my name. Good. But there is no gotra.”

“It was not required for the project,” Chandan said.

“Will the school decide what is required?”

“Ira wrote what she understood.”

Bhaveshwar’s voice hardened. “If children write only what they understand, how will a lineage continue?”

Nilima was nearby. This time she took the phone. "Babuji, may I ask something?"

Bhaveswar was silent.

"If Ira is entered in your book, where will my mother and father be in her lineage?"

"They are her maternal grandparents. Who denies that?"

"In the book?"

Bhaveswar was silent again.

"The structure of the book is not made that way," he said at last.

"Then is the structure too small, or is my child too large?"

Chandan touched Nilima's wrist. The gesture was not to stop her, only to ask her to lower her voice.

Bhaveswar said, "Daughter-in-law, you are treating our tradition as an insult."

"No," Nilima replied. "I am asking about its limits."

The call ended quietly, but for the next two months Bhaveswar did not speak to Nilima directly.

6

In the meantime Nilima went to her mother. In the back room Kamala Devi opened an old tin trunk. Inside were ration cards, school certificates, two wedding photographs, an old red sari, receipts from Sitaram's bicycle shop, and a notebook of songs sung by Nilima's grandmother.

"You're looking for lineage? Take this," Kamala said.

Nilima opened the notebook. On the first page was written: "Songs of Sugni Devi, written down by Kamala."

"Nani used to write?"

"No. She sang. I listened and wrote."

"And her mother?"

Kamala scratched her head. "Her name was Phulkali. The village was perhaps... no, I will not say perhaps. I do not remember fully. Do not turn a guess into truth."

Nilima smiled. Her mother was not illiterate; she had studied through Class Five. Yet this archival caution—"do not turn a guess into truth"—felt to Nilima more trustworthy than many educated sentences from Chandan's Panji-keeping household.

Sitaram returned in the evening. Nilima explained her plan: names from both families, photographs, stories, birthplaces, occupations, songs, dates where known; where unknown, "unknown" would be written plainly.

"Who is all this to be shown to?" Sitaram asked.

"To Ira."

"Then good. But don't make it so that we can squeeze into the book of Chandan's house."

"No."

"I do not want a place as charity in anyone's book."

Kamala interrupted, "A place is not charity. But when a door is kept shut, there is no need to stand in front of it all night either."

Nilima understood: her mother and father were saying the same thing differently. Writing one's own lineage should not become revenge.

That night, for the first time, Nilima and Chandan had a major quarrel about the matter. Ira was asleep. The register lay closed on the table.

"I cannot understand whether you are on my side or merely want peace," Nilima said.

"I want both," Chandan said wearily.

"How often are both possible at once?"

Chandan said nothing. Between job, rent, the child's school, and ageing parents, he had spent years believing that time would wear many disputes away by itself. But time does not wear away every dispute; sometimes it merely rounds the edges so that people can pass it every day.

"At the time of our marriage," Nilima said, "you said the book was not getting married. How did it become so important once our child entered the question?"

"For me, the book is not important. Babu is."

"And for me, my Babu?"

Chandan held his head in his hands. "I do not want to humiliate him."

"But the structure you are protecting does humiliate him."

Chandan's anger rose. "Don't put every fault on me. I did not build this structure."

Nilima's voice sharpened too. "A structure that affects my life cannot remain only the responsibility of dead ancestors."

For a few moments the only sound in the room was the fan.

"Do you want me to throw the Panji away?" Chandan asked quietly.

"No. I want you to call it a book, not the whole world."

At that sentence Chandan's anger suddenly grew tired. He looked at the register. "Our People"—Ira had written it in coloured letters.

"I'll speak to Babu again," he said.

"Do it not for me. Do it for Ira. And for yourself too," Nilima replied.

That night they slept facing opposite directions. In the morning Chandan got up and made tea. Nilima drank it. The dispute had not ended, but many truths inside a marriage require practice in living together before they require a solution.

At noon Ira returned from school and asked, "Did you two quarrel yesterday?"

Nilima was startled. "How did you know?"

"Babu made tea."

Chandan burst out laughing. Nilima did too. A child often reads household politics through kitchen signs.

"Because of me?" Ira asked.

Both said at once, "No."

Then Chandan corrected himself. "Your questions are not the cause. The questions were already here."

Ira seemed satisfied. "Then did you find the answer?"

"We're still writing it," Nilima said.

7

Chandan called the project “A Register of Two Roots.”

“Why two?” Nilima said. “Four grandparents, eight great-grandparents...”

Ira interrupted: “Make a tree. It can have many roots.”

In the end they bought a thick blank register with a khaki cover. On the first page Ira wrote in coloured letters: “Our People.”

“Write ‘lineage register,’” Chandan suggested.

Ira refused. “People is better.”

They made three rules for the register. First: if a name is known, write it. Second: if it is not known, do not invent it. Third: give equal pages to Mother’s and Father’s sides.

Ira added a fourth rule: “If a photograph is bad, paste it anyway.”

“Why?” Nilima laughed.

“People are still people in bad photographs.”

The register began to fill. Two lines of a song by Kamala’s mother Sugni; a memory of Sitaram’s father Lachchu Paswan rowing a boat; Saroj’s mother Vidyavati’s pickle recipe; a photograph of a Sanskrit book that had belonged to Bhaveshwar’s father Dineshwar Jha.

Chandan could copy dates from the Panji, but on Nilima’s side many dates were only guesses. Those spaces were left blank.

Ira was not troubled by the blanks. She drew a tiny lamp in pencil. “If we find it later, we’ll write it here.”

Nilima thought: in the old book, blank spaces produced fear; in this new register, a blank space was making room for the future.

8

The problem rose again when Raghav married. Everyone had gathered in the village. On the day before the wedding, the men sat on the veranda looking through old papers about clan and lineage. The Panji-keeper, Harimohan Mishra, was there too.

Ira, now ten, had brought her “Our People” register. She was eager to show it to Dada.

Bhaveshwar looked at the book. He turned the first few pages in silence. His brow lifted slightly at the names Kamala, Sitaram, Lachchu, Sugni, but he said nothing.

Harimohan Mishra asked with interest, “What is this?”

“My family,” Ira said.

Uncle Madhukant laughed. “A new Panji!”

“No,” Nilima said at once. “Not a Panji. The child’s family book.”

“Does changing a thing’s name change its rules?” Madhukant asked.

“We are not announcing a change in rules,” Chandan replied.

“Then why the pressure to enter Ira’s name in the clan-book?”

“No pressure,” Chandan said calmly. “The question is: if her name is entered, how will her mother be recorded?”

Harimohan looked toward the book. “The traditional entry follows the father’s branch.”

“Then write that it is a book of the father’s branch,” Nilima said. “Not the ‘complete lineage.’”

Some people on the veranda became uncomfortable. To some the sentence sounded like a minor correction; to others, a challenge.

Bhaveswar had remained silent until then. At last he said, “Not at a wedding. This is not the time for debate.”

Nilima nodded. “I don’t want that either.”

Ira closed her register. She understood that adults often say “this is not the time” precisely when the most difficult subject arrives.

The next day Nilima’s parents also came to offer wedding congratulations. Sitaram already knew that the clan-book question had arisen. He deliberately remained silent on the subject.

After the meal Bhaveswar called him to the veranda. The two older men first talked about weather, the water in the Kamala river, the price of wheat, and aching knees. Caste was never named in that conversation, yet both knew the central subject sat between them.

At last Bhaveswar said, “We are thinking of entering Ira’s name in the book.”

Sitaram closed his box of betel. “Write it. It is the child’s name.”

“The complete maternal-side detail does not fit the format.”

Sitaram looked directly at Bhaveswar. “Then write as much as fits. The rest the child is already writing in her own book.”

Bhaveswar may have expected resistance. “Does that not insult you?”

“I would feel insulted if I asked one book for proof that I exist. My father existed; his father existed; my mother existed—whether paper accepts them or not.”

Bhaveswar was silent.

Sitaram continued, “But Ira has a right to be part of your house. Do not make her half in the name of preserving my honour.”

The sentence surprised Bhaveswar. “Then you want her name entered?”

“I want the child, when she grows up, not to have to think that her grandparents omitted her name because of their own pride.”

From inside Kamala called, “The tea is getting cold.”

Sitaram rose. As he left he added, “One more thing. Do not write my daughter only as a caste. Write her name first. Person first, box later.”

Bhaveswar gave no answer. But Nilima, at a distance, heard her father’s last sentence. Her eyes filled.

That evening Kamala sat alone with Saroj in the kitchen. It was the first time the two women had talked without anyone else present. “Are these books all written by men?” Kamala asked.

“So far, mostly,” Saroj laughed.

“Then where are our stories?”

Saroj kneaded the dough. “Kitchen, songs, children, quarrels, memory—wherever there was room.”

“That is why Ira is searching for paper,” Kamala said.

"Yes. Perhaps—" Saroj stopped and corrected herself. "Perhaps she will find more paper than we did."

The two women laughed. The stove flame burned between them.

9

That night Ira slept on the roof beside her grandmother Saroj. The distant wedding loudspeaker had grown quieter.

"Dadi, is your mother in the book?" Ira asked.

After a long pause Saroj said, "Not in my husband's family book."

"Didn't that make you feel bad?"

Saroj laughed, but there was weariness in it. "At that time I did not have the habit of asking this question."

"And now?"

"Now I can see the question."

Ira opened her book. "Vidyavati Nani is here."

Saroj touched the photograph. "Yes. That is my mother."

After a while Saroj said softly, "Your Dada is not a bad man. But sometimes good people try to stuff new things into old boxes. When the box tears, they blame the thing."

Ira burst into laughter. "Dada is a box?"

"Don't tell him I said that."

"I will tell him."

"Then will you say Dadi said it?"

"No. I'll say I understood it myself."

Saroj pulled Ira into her lap. The flame of a little oil lamp on the roof trembled in the wind. Saroj remembered her own mother Vidyavati—absent from every line of this household's book, yet alive each day in Saroj's speech, pickles, songs, and anger.

10

The next day, amid the wedding crowd, a small accident happened. Ira left her book on a veranda table. Someone turning the pages spilled tea over Kamala's photograph.

Ira ran over in panic. A brown stain spread across the photograph and she began to cry.

Bhaveswar was nearby. He immediately brought a damp cloth and tried to dry the photograph by pressing it gently. "Don't rub," he said. "The image on an old photograph will lift."

"How do you know?" Ira asked, wiping her tears.

"I learned a few things while preserving old Panjis and papers."

Together they saved the photograph. Kamala's face became slightly blurred, but it survived.

Suddenly Ira asked, "Dada, will you write in my book?"

Bhaveswar stopped his hand. "What?"

"The name of your father's father. And whatever you remember."

“That is already in the Panji,” Bhaveshwar said.

“I want it here in your voice.”

Bhaveshwar was silent for a long time. Then he took the pen. Beneath Dineshwar Jha’s name he wrote: “Whenever rain came, the first thing he did was bring the books down from the roof.”

Ira read it. “Only that?”

Bhaveshwar wrote another line: “And he used to tell his son—save paper, but do not ruin people for paper.”

After writing it, he himself fell silent for a moment. Perhaps for the first time the sentence seemed to apply to him.

II

A week after the wedding ended, Bhaveshwar telephoned Chandan. His voice was ordinary. “The Panji-keeper will come again next month.”

Chandan was silent.

“We will discuss entering Ira’s name.”

“In what form?”

“As the rules allow.”

Old irritation rose in Chandan. “Babu, the same thing again?”

“I did not finish what I had to say. Listen,” Bhaveshwar said.

He proposed that the traditional father-branch entry remain in its usual format, but that a marginal note record Nilima’s full name, the village of her maternal side, and the fact of an “inter-caste marriage”—with no insulting terminology and no judgment of “pure” or “impure.”

Chandan was not immediately pleased. “Her maternal grandparents?”

“The main book’s format does not give that much room.”

“Then the problem remains.”

“It remains,” Bhaveshwar admitted.

Chandan fell silent at the admission. For the first time his father was not claiming that the rule was complete.

When Nilima heard, she said, “Ask Ira.”

Bhaveshwar was astonished. “A ten-year-old child?”

“It is her name.”

Three days later they spoke on video. The proposal was explained to Ira. She listened carefully, then asked, “Nani and Nana will not be in the book?”

“Not fully,” Bhaveshwar said.

“Then write that this book belongs to Babu’s side. My complete family is in ‘Our People.’”

Bhaveshwar kept looking at his granddaughter on the screen. “You will not object if we write that much?”

“One condition.”

“What?”

“Write Mummy’s name first, not Mummy’s caste.”

Nilima lowered her eyes. Chandan smiled. Bhaveshwar said very slowly, “All right.”

On the day of the Panji-keeper's next visit there was no crowd in the house. Bhaveshwar, Saroj, Madhukant, Chandan, Nilima, Ira, and Harimohan Mishra sat on the veranda.

Harimohan showed them the old format. "The name can be entered. But this note is not traditional."

Bhaveshwar asked, "Was the tradition ever written before for a situation like this?"

Harimohan adjusted his spectacles. "No."

"Then only make sure the facts are not wrong."

Uncle Madhukant disagreed. "One note today, tomorrow the whole Panji will change."

"If the facts themselves are changing," Nilima said calmly, "how can a book remain true by staying still?"

"Lineage runs by rules," Madhukant replied.

Ira interrupted, "Do rules run by people, or do people run by rules?"

Everyone laughed except Madhukant.

Harimohan wrote on the paper: "Ira, father Chandan Jha, mother Nilima Paswan; parents in an inter-caste marriage; this entry is a branch-reference in a paternal-lineage Panji."

He stopped his pen. "Is this much acceptable?"

Ira read it. "Yes. But is 'Paswan' part of Mummy's name or her caste?"

"People can read it both ways," Nilima said. "I do not need to change it now."

Ira nodded. "All right."

Madhukant did not sign. Bhaveshwar signed as witness. There was no box for Saroj's signature. Ira asked, "Why not Dadi?"

"Two male witnesses are sufficient," Harimohan said.

Saroj laughed. "This book still has much to learn."

No one prolonged the dispute. The victory that day was not complete; disagreement had not ended either. But a line had been written that earlier had been considered impossible to write.

A few weeks after the new Panji note, Ira's school held a small exhibition on "family records." The children were to bring an old object, photograph, or story from home.

Ira took two things—a photographic copy of Dada's clan-book and the "Our People" register.

"Two?" asked her teacher, Malati Madam.

"One is the old book from Babu's side. One is my book that is still becoming complete."

"Complete?"

"Not yet. Becoming."

Malati smiled. "That is the right word."

In class one child asked, "Your Mummy is from a different caste?"

"Yes," Ira said simply.

Another child asked, "Then what caste are you?"

Ira thought for a moment. “Whatever a form asks, Babu and Mummy fill it in. Right now remembering the names of all my people is harder for me.”

Some children laughed. The child who had asked laughed too. The subject moved on.

At the end of the exhibition Malati Madam said, “Records preserve truth, but records themselves make selections. Searching for what was not written is also the work of history.”

At home Ira wrote the sentence in “Our People.” Beneath it she added: “And what is written should not be treated as the whole truth.”

Chandan read it and asked, “Did Madam say the second line too?”

“No. I added it.”

“Then write the source—‘Ira’s words,’” Nilima said.

Ira wrote her name. In this register, even sentences spoken by living people began to be recorded with their sources.

When Bhaveshwar next visited, he read the page. “You doubt a great deal.”

Ira replied, “The uncle in ‘The Limits of Justice’ said doubt is not bad; just don’t build a house on doubt.”

Chandan laughed. “You are mixing all the stories.”

“Families are mixed stories too,” Ira said.

Bhaveshwar smiled at that. He held a copy of his old book in one hand and the “Our People” register in the other. The papers smelled different. In one, time had yellowed; in the other, ink was still fresh.

“New paper becomes old one day too,” he said.

“That is why we should write it correctly now,” Ira replied.

13

A few months later the subject of family returned at school. This time the children were asked: “What would you like to add to your name?”

Some wrote “doctor,” some “athlete,” some the name of their village. Ira stared at the blank paper for a long time.

At home she opened the “Our People” register. On the first page she saw her old coloured letters. On the opposite side was pasted a photograph of Dada’s Panji with the new marginal note beside her name.

On a fresh page she wrote: “Ira Nilima-Chandan.”

Chandan looked at it. “Have you made a surname?”

“No. A description for now.”

“Will you change it later?” Nilima asked.

“Maybe. Names can change, can’t they?”

“They can.”

Ira then wrote: “Kamala’s granddaughter. Sitaram’s granddaughter. Saroj’s granddaughter. Bhaveshwar’s granddaughter.”

Then she left a little blank space.

“Why is this blank?” Chandan asked.

“For the people who will become family in my life later,” Ira said.

Nilima looked outside the window. Evening was descending. A small lamp burned in the wall niche; its light fell both on the copy of the old Panji and on the open page of “Our People.”

The two books remained different. Neither dissolved into the other. One did not accept all the rules of the other. Madhukant still disliked the new entry. Sitaram still said that getting a place in someone else’s book was no victory. Bhaveshwar still did not wish to abandon the paternal-branch Panji. Nilima still called its limits limits.

But Ira placed her own paper between the two books.

She looked at the lamp flame and wrote the final line: “Lineage is not what pulls me to one side; lineage is all the people whose lives have left something within me.”

Nilima read the line and said nothing. Chandan said nothing either.

Ira capped her pen.

The old book had not been closed. The new register was not complete either.

Between them her name was written—this time without erasing anyone.

— *End of Story 18* —

19. The Diary

STORY

I

Three months had passed since Devkinandan Jha's death, yet his room was still kept closed as though it belonged to someone living in the house. The dust inside the window, the brass pen-holder on the table, the clouded spectacles, and the Panji volume tied in red cloth—all of it seemed to wait for him to return one evening and pull out his chair.

His granddaughter Mrinalini had come from Delhi precisely to make an inventory of the house's old papers. She taught archival studies at a university; the family trusted that papers whose meaning no one else could make out would yield themselves to Mrinalini.

For the first two days she sorted government receipts, wedding invitations, old postage stamps, and copies of Panji records. On the third day she drew a thick green-bound ledger from beneath the table. On its cover, in Devkinandan's hand, were the words: "Household Accounts."

Mrinalini laughed. No one in the family had ever said that Grandfather kept household accounts. She opened the book. The first pages listed the prices of rice, oil, medicines, and paper. From the fifth page onward the accounts stopped abruptly. After that came dates, two or four lines at a time, sometimes a name, sometimes only a single sentence.

She understood: this was not an account book. It was a diary.

2

In the village Devkinandan was known as "the impartial Panjikaar." On the day of his death black cloth had been hung on the panchayat building. In his speech the mukhiya had said, "Before a document, Devki Babu never distinguished between his own people and outsiders."

Mrinalini had heard that speech. She had felt proud. Grandfather spoke little, but the village image of him was of a man before whose papers disputes arrived and fell quiet.

The first serious entry in the diary was dated 17 June 1987.

"Today Shivnarayan sent two sacks of paddy. He said it was better to have grain in the house before the rains. I ought to have sent the paddy back. I could not. Why? I ask myself."

Mrinalini read it twice. The name Shivnarayan was familiar: a man from the western hamlet, from an old zamindar family. His grandson was now a member of the panchayat samiti.

The next entry, three days later, read: "Bhagwati came again. She said—my husband is dead; does that mean my house is dead too? I gave no answer."

3

At the name Bhagwati, Mrinalini remembered from childhood an old woman who was always seen in a white sari near the eastern pond. Everyone called her "Bhagwati Kaki." She had died long ago.

Mrinalini asked her mother, "Was there some dispute between Bhagwati Kaki and Shivnarayan?"

Her mother was silent at first. Then she said, "Have you come to clean a room or to open up the old village?"

"Her name is in the diary."

Her mother's hand stopped. "What diary?"

Mrinalini showed her the ledger. Her mother did not read the open page. She merely looked at the green cover and said, "I have never seen this book."

"Bhagwati Kaki?"

Her mother said, "Her husband, Ramlochan, was Shivnarayan's younger brother. After Ramlochan died there was a dispute over his share of the homestead. Everyone said Devki Babu gave impartial testimony, and that was how Bhagwati managed to save her room."

"Was that why Grandfather was honoured?"

"His name became very prominent after that case."

4

The next page of the diary was torn. Along the edge half a line remained: "...what was written and what was seen did not remain the same."

The entry for 23 June was complete.

"Shivnarayan said—the old partition was oral. The Panji does not record Ramlochan as a separate household. I know that a separate hearth was maintained for five years. The Panji is a book of marriages and lineage, not a land record. But if the court treats this line as evidence, whose side will my silence take?"

Below it, in smaller letters: "The paddy is still in the veranda."

Mrinalini remained fixed on that line for a long time. Had Grandfather taken a bribe? Or had he accepted it as a gift? The diary itself was asking questions, not giving answers.

She opened the relevant old Panji volume. Ramlochan's name was there; beside marriage, Bhagwati; no son. In the margin, in pale blue ink, someone had written: "Independent household, north-west dwelling, witnesses—three."

A photograph of that single annotation had been printed in the village history booklet. The caption beneath it read: “Devkinandan Jha’s impartial record, which preserved a widow’s rights.”

5

The next day Mrinalini went to see Bhagwati’s niece, Kamala Devi. Kamala was over eighty, her eyesight weak, her memory sharp.

“Devki Babu?” Kamala laughed. “A very good man. But at first he was terribly timid.”

Mrinalini stared. “Afraid?”

“Everyone was afraid of Shivrinarayan. Devki Babu too. Later he did what was right.”

“What did he set right?”

Kamala rubbed her knee. “Where were women like us inside the papers? Bhagwati Masi went three times. The first time they said—the Panji does not concern itself with land. The second time they said—bring witnesses. The third time she took the old iron trivet from her hearth, tax receipts, and two elderly men. Only then was the note written.”

“The sacks of paddy?”

Kamala’s face changed. “Who told you about that?”

Mrinalini told her about the diary.

Kamala was silent for a long time. “People said Shivrinarayan had sent paddy. Bhagwati Masi used to say—swallowing the grain does not make the truth digestible.”

“Did Grandfather return the paddy?”

“I do not know. But there was also a story that the day after the annotation was written, two sacks of paddy were seen at Shivrinarayan’s door.”

6

The ink had spread across the diary page dated 30 June.

“At night Shail said—you speak of the impartiality of paper, but where will an impartial hand come from to hold the paper? A hand is afraid, greedy, ashamed. If you do not write these things, your book may not be false, but it will certainly be incomplete.”

Shail—Mrinalini’s grandmother. In the family she was usually spoken of in connection with cooking, songs, and her long illness; never with the work of the Panji.

The next line read: “Shail filled the pen with blue ink. She said—write what you saw. Where you do not know, write ‘I do not know.’ There is no need to become God.”

Mrinalini looked again at the blue annotation in the Panji. Had Grandmother filled that ink? The handwriting was Grandfather’s, but perhaps the courage of the sentence had come from somewhere else.

Here the diary broke the first statue erected by public memory. The village said—Devkinandan had been impartial from birth. The diary said—he had been afraid, he had wavered, and then he had corrected something.

7

Mrinalini now faced another question: should the diary be made public? It was a private book. How far could descendants expose the wrongdoing and shame of the dead?

Her mother said plainly, “If you give it to the library, remove this page.”

“Why?”

“Grandfather’s name will be disgraced.”

“What if it is true?”

“Is everything written in a diary true?” her mother replied at once. “What a person writes at night in sorrow may look different to him in the morning. Will you judge him by one page?”

Mrinalini fell silent. The objection was valid. In her classes on archival studies she told students that one source—especially a private source—was not final truth. Faced with her own grandfather’s diary, she had almost forgotten the rule herself.

She decided to treat the diary not as proof, but as a source. She would look for other sources.

8

At the district archive she found a copy of the 1987 civil suit: Bhagwati Devi versus Shivnarayan Jha. The paper was yellow, the typewriter letters dark in some places, faint in others.

The judgment had not rested on the Panji annotation alone. Tax receipts, neighbours’ testimony, evidence of a separate hearth, Ramlochan’s old debt ledger, and actual possession of the homestead—all of it together strengthened Bhagwati’s case. Devkinandan’s testimony was only one part.

Over time the village story had grown simple: “He wrote one line and the widow was saved.” The court file said otherwise: many people, many papers, and many years of lived history had combined to produce the decision.

Devkinandan’s public glory was not merely a myth of his own making; the village had compressed a complex history into one face.

His statement in the file read: “My record is supplementary information concerning lineage relations; it is not final proof of ownership of land.”

Mrinalini smiled as she read it. Grandfather himself had stated the limits of his book before the court. Later generations had cut away that limitation and preserved only the phrase “impartial evidence.”

9

Another mystery of the diary remained. On the final page for July he had written:

“Bhagwati came today. She said—do not say that you saved me. I fought for myself. You merely did not suppress my words. Understand the difference.”

Below it Devkinandan had written: “This line shamed me more than anything else.”

Mrinalini showed a photograph of the page to Kamala Devi. Kamala could not read it, so Mrinalini read it aloud.

Kamala laughed softly. “That sounds like Bhagwati Masi.”

“Those exact words?”

“Who can swear to exact words? But the meaning is hers. She used to say—later, men write the story in their own names.”

With that one sentence the village memory changed a second time. Devkinandan had been a hero, but not the only hero. Perhaps not even the principal one. Bhagwati had fought for her own home; the real work of Grandfather’s honesty was only this—that in the end he did not suppress her voice.

10

Back home, Mrinalini read the final part of the diary. 1998, 2003, 2011—small entries scattered across the years. Even long afterward Grandfather kept returning to the events of 1987.

“People call me impartial. The word frightens me. Perhaps impartiality is not a virtue but a practice. It has to be done again every time.”

Elsewhere: “The day I fail to see my own side is the day I am in greatest danger of becoming partisan.”

And on the final undated page: “My granddaughter Mrinalini works with books. Perhaps this ledger will one day fall into her hands. If she reads it, she must not save me. Nor must she make me guilty from one page. What can be checked, let her check. What cannot be checked, let her leave with a question mark.”

Mrinalini closed the ledger. It felt as though, for the first time, her dead grandfather was not giving her an instruction but a method.

11

A meeting of the village library committee was held to discuss donating Devkinandan’s papers. The mukhiya wanted a glass cabinet with a plaque above it: “Memorial Collection of Devkinandan Jha, the Impartial Panjikar.”

Mrinalini said, “Remove the word ‘Impartial.’”

Everyone was startled.

Ajay, Shivnarayan’s grandson, asked, “Why?”

Mrinalini did not tell the entire story of the diary. First she explained the court file, the many forms of evidence behind Bhagwati's claim, and the way the village memory had been simplified. Then she read the entry about the paddy.

Ajay said at once, "That is an unverified accusation."

"Yes," Mrinalini said, "which is why I am not calling it an accusation. I am calling it a diary entry. Whether the paddy was taken, returned, given as a gift, or intended as pressure—there is no final proof."

An elderly man said, "Then what is the point of reading it?"

Mrinalini answered, "Because uncertainty is also part of history."

Kamala Devi had not come to the meeting, but her voice had been recorded. Over the speaker she said, "Bhagwati's name should be on the plaque."

12

The debate continued for two hours. Some said the honour of the dead must be preserved; some asked why Bhagwati's part had never been written before; some wondered whether making the diary public would reopen old family quarrels.

In the end the new wording of the plaque was agreed upon: "Devkinandan Jha Archive: Panji Records, Private Diary, and Related Sources. Including Documents from Bhagwati Devi's Homestead Dispute."

The word "impartial" was gone. So was "great."

Back home, her mother asked, "Are you satisfied now?"

Mrinalini said, "Not entirely."

"Has Grandfather's name become smaller?"

"To me he seems larger."

Her mother looked at her sideways.

"Before, he was a statue," Mrinalini said. "Now he is a person. Afraid, making mistakes, then trying to correct them."

Her mother said nothing. She ran a hand over the green cover of the diary. "Why did Shail Ma never tell me about this book?"

Mrinalini had no answer. The reason for every secret is not preserved in an archive.

13

Four days after the meeting, Ajay himself came to Mrinalini's house carrying a thin ledger wrapped in cloth.

"Our household account book," he said. "From my grandfather's time. You read about the paddy, so look at this too."

On a page from Ashadh 1987, in very small letters, was written: "Devki—2 sacks—returned." After the word "returned" there was a mark like a question mark. The date was unclear; worms had eaten away the corner of the page above.

Ajay said, "My father used to say the paddy was a loan, not pressure."

Mrinalini asked, "Why a loan?"

"Before the rains everyone moved grain from house to house. Devki Babu's fields had gone under water that year."

"And 'returned'?"

"Returned. Perhaps."

Mrinalini immediately wrote in her notes: "Not certain—only possible." Then she smiled. Care with her own language now felt like care with a source.

She made a high-quality copy of the page. Ajay said, "Then my grandfather will not be written in the diary as someone who gave a bribe?"

"I never wrote that," Mrinalini replied. "One source says the paddy arrived. Another contains '2 sacks—returned.' Together they establish that there was a transaction involving paddy; its purpose and full sequence remain uncertain."

Ajay looked dissatisfied. "Is nothing clear in history?"

"Some things are. Some are not. If, out of a desire to make things look clear, I call a blurred thing clear, I will be doing the very thing I am accusing Grandfather of doing."

14

After that Mrinalini made a list with four headings: "What Is Certain," "What Is Probable," "What Appears in Only One Source," and "What Lives in Oral Memory."

Under "Certain" she wrote: Ramlochan and Bhagwati maintained a separate household; multiple pieces of evidence were presented in court; Devkinandan testified; the blue annotation exists in the Panji.

Under "Probable": two sacks of paddy came from Shivrinarayan's house to Devkinandan's; they may later have been returned.

Under "One Source Only": Devkinandan himself understood the paddy as connected with his own moral weakness.

Under "Oral Memory": "One line written by Devki Babu saved Bhagwati."

Looking at the four columns, she understood that public memory wants the shortest sentence; history often requires the longest footnote.

Her mother read the list and asked, "Will you put all this in the library?"

"Yes."

"What will people understand from it?"

"Where the limits of what we understand lie."

Her mother said, "If your grandfather heard this, would he be pleased or angry?"

Mrinalini laughed. "According to the diary, both are possible."

That night she looked at an old photograph of Grandfather: Devkinandan on a stage receiving a certificate of honour; behind him a banner read, "Sentinel of Truth." At the edge of the frame Grandmother Shail had been half cut off.

Mrinalini scanned the photograph, but she did not try digitally to restore the cut-off half of Grandmother. She kept the original as it was and wrote in the description: "Shail Devi partially visible at the right edge of the frame."

Sometimes correction does not mean changing the picture. It can also mean recording the fact that someone was cut out.

15

Before the library opened, five students from the local school came to see the archive. Their teacher had told them, "Look at historical sources." At first the children were more interested in old seals and worm-eaten pages.

One girl, Jyoti, stopped at the screen displaying the diary. She asked, "If Devki Babu wrote his mistake in the diary, did that make him a good man?"

Mrinalini thought before answering. "Writing a diary does not make anyone good. But seeing one's own mistake can become a road toward correction."

Another child asked, "If he had not written the diary, would we still have believed he was impartial?"

"Perhaps."

"Then writing the truth harmed him?"

Mrinalini said, "It harmed his statue. Not his life."

Jyoti asked again, "Why did Bhagwati Devi not write a diary?"

The room fell silent at that question.

Mrinalini said, "I do not know. Perhaps she had no time, no means, no habit of writing; perhaps she did write and the paper did not survive. Here, 'I do not know' is an answer."

The teacher told the students, "Write that down."

Mrinalini stopped them. "First write down the question. The answer can come later."

The children laughed, but Jyoti really did write in her notebook: "Where is Bhagwati's voice?"

That small question seemed to Mrinalini like the most important catalogue entry in the entire collection.

16

Meanwhile Kamala Devi supplied another name—Yadunath Babu, who had been a court clerk at the time and now lived with his son in Darbhanga. On the telephone Yadunath first said with great confidence, "Devki Babu returned the two sacks of paddy that very evening. I saw it."

Mrinalini asked, "Were you yourself at his door?"

There was silence at the other end.

"No, I saw them at Shivnarayan's door."

"The paddy coming back?"

"Yes... people said it had come from Devki's house."

"Which people?"

Yadunath laughed. “After so many years, how can I remember names?”

Mrinalini wrote in her notes: “Begins as direct memory; after questioning, resolves into hearsay memory.”

Yadunath sounded slightly offended. “Do you think I am lying?”

“No. I am writing that memory changes.”

“Did your grandfather’s memory not change?”

The question was direct. Mrinalini said, “It may have. That is why I do not treat the diary as proof by itself either.”

Yadunath’s voice softened. “Very well. One thing I can say with certainty: on the day of the hearing Bhagwati Devi stood in the veranda for a long time. Devki Babu was inside. After the decision, people surrounded Devki Babu. Bhagwati quietly walked out.”

“You saw that?”

“That I saw.”

Mrinalini placed a separate mark beside the statement—as a claim of direct observation, though still the memory of an elderly man.

After ending the call, she understood that archival work was not merely the preservation of paper. People keep making stories inside their own memories; questioning does not break a story, it reveals its layers.

She added a new line to her list: “Oral memory: preserve the sequence of questions as well.”

Then she saved the complete audio file of her conversation with Yadunath, resisting the temptation to cut it down to only the clean answers. Hesitation too was a source.

17

On the day the library opened, the diary was placed in a glass cabinet beside copies of the Panji records, while a digital version was made available on a screen to protect the fragile original pages. A note on the first page read: “Private writing is not, by itself, complete proof; read it alongside related sources.”

No photograph of Bhagwati could be found. Kamala supplied an old group picture. Among twelve women she pointed to one face. “That is Masi.”

The caption beneath the picture read: “Bhagwati Devi—claimant in the homestead-rights dispute; sustained struggle for her own claim.”

Devkinandan’s name did not appear in that sentence.

In the evening, after the library emptied, Mrinalini opened one diary page again before shutting down the screen: “You speak of the impartiality of paper, but where will an impartial hand come from to hold the paper?”

The page recorded the words of Grandmother Shail in Devkinandan’s handwriting. One sentence, two people present within it.

Darkness was falling outside the window. A small lamp had been lit in the library niche. Its light struck the glass and shone on both the diary and the copy of the Panji, but in the glass Mrinalini could also see her own face.

For the first time she understood: the person reading an archive is not outside the archive either.

On the screen she added one final note: “What was not found in this file has been left as not found.”

Then she saved it.

The lamp flame was not steady. Even so, there was light.

— *End of Story 19* —

20. False Lineage

STORY

I

Rambilas Mandal first felt that his lineage was too small when marriage negotiations for his son Naval began with a family in the city. The first question their uncle asked on the phone was, “Send us the genealogy. How far back are the ancestors verified?”

There was no tradition in Rambilas’s house of verifying ancestors. Everyone remembered the names up to Grandfather; the great-grandfather’s name was told in two forms—some said Dhanuki, some Dhanik. Before that, “the old people” were a collective darkness in which field boundaries, flood stories, and borrowed bullocks were remembered more clearly than names.

Naval laughed. “Babu, if the names aren’t there, they aren’t there. We’re not going to write lies, are we?”

Rambilas said nothing. Until then the idea of writing a lie had not occurred to him. It came later—when Mahendra Babu at the village tea stall said, “Oh, making a genealogy is no great task. These days everything is made on a computer.”

“Does a computer make ancestors too?” Rambilas asked.

Blowing on his tea, Mahendra Babu replied, “Not ancestors. Paper. People choose ancestors according to convenience.”

The sentence lodged in Rambilas’s head.

2

Two days later Mahendra Babu took him to a young man seated behind a photocopy shop in the market. The young man’s name was Rakesh, but the signboard read: “R. K. Document Service Centre: Applications, Family Trees, Affidavits, Online.”

Rakesh began with great professional seriousness: “How many generations do you want?”

Rambilas stared. “As many as there are.”

Rakesh smiled. “You will tell me what there is. I will give it shape. Five generations is ordinary. Seven looks impressive. If you want ten, the coloured chart costs extra.”

Mahendra Babu whispered into his ear, “Seven is right. Ten would look too showy.”

Rambilas's lineage suddenly felt like a length of cloth being measured—five, seven, ten.

He gave the names he remembered: Rambilas, son of Bhubaneswar, son of Dhanuki or Dhanik. At the word “or,” Rakesh stopped typing. “No ‘or.’ Choose one.”

Rambilas chose Dhanik, because Dhanik sounded a little more distinguished than Dhanuki.

“Above him?”

Rambilas was silent.

Rakesh looked at an empty box on the screen, as if the ancestor himself were standing there waiting.

Mahendra Babu said softly, “I seem to remember your old people mentioning someone called Raghunath.”

“Ours?”

“Could be.”

Rakesh typed: Raghunath.

One name was typed, and Rambilas's family set off down the road toward seven generations.

3

Finding names above Raghunath was harder. Mahendra Babu suggested, “It would look good if there were someone with a learned, pandit-like name in the lineage.”

Rambilas said, “Our people were farmers.”

“Can't a farmer have a pandit-like name?” Mahendra Babu argued.

Meanwhile Rakesh was browsing an online list of old-fashioned names. In the end he offered three choices—Harinarayan, Lakshminarayan, Shivnarayan.

Rambilas's wife Phulo, who had been sitting quietly on a plastic chair outside listening to everything, came in and asked, “Why does every name need so much Narayan in it?”

Rakesh laughed. “Mother, old names gain stature that way.”

Phulo said, “My grandmother's father was named Phuchchan. The whole hamlet respected him.”

For a few moments Rakesh's theory of stature fell silent.

In the end Harinarayan was chosen. Above him Raghubir, and above him Jankinath. Seven generations complete.

Rakesh produced a handsome tree. Jankinath at the roots, branches rising upward, Naval at the very top. Along the edge, in golden letters, were the words: “Tradition • Prestige • Family.”

Rambilas looked at the paper. He was amazed that men who had not existed in the world half an hour earlier now looked more permanent than he did on the coloured sheet.

Phulo asked only one thing. “Where am I?”

Rakesh looked at the screen. “This is the paternal lineage.”

“Then Naval is only his father's son?”

Mahendra Babu said, "Oh, that is the custom."
Phulo walked out.

4

The genealogy was sent to the city. Three days later the family called. Their uncle sounded delighted. "A good lineage. Jankinathji's branch?"

Rambilas's throat went dry.

"Yes... an old branch."

"Our samdhi was saying that a distinguished zamindar named Jankinath lived in that area. His ancestral site still exists, doesn't it?"

Before Rambilas could say yes, Phulo took the phone from his hand. "We do not know. We will check and tell you."

The call ended.

Rambilas snapped, "Why did you say that?"

Phulo replied calmly, "Because I do not know."

"The match was going well."

"Was the match being made, or the ancestor?"

Rambilas had no answer.

By evening the news had spread through the village that Rambilas's ancestor Jankinath had been a "zamindar." Mahendra Babu had announced it at the tea stall. The next morning two elderly men came to congratulate them on an achievement of which, three days earlier, the family itself had known nothing.

5

The first crisis arrived on the fifth day.

Bholanath Mandal came from the western hamlet carrying a bag of old papers. He spread the family tree on the table and placed a finger on Jankinath's name.

"If this Jankinath is the man you say he is, then my ancestor was his younger brother."

Rambilas's mouth remained open.

Bholanath was delighted. "Then we are agnates."

Later Mahendra Babu said, "What is wrong with that? You have acquired distinguished agnates."

But Bholanath had not come merely to become an agnate. In his bag was an old copy concerning thirty-two dhur of land, whose boundary description mentioned "Jankinath's bamboo grove."

"If that Jankinath is your ancestor," Bholanath said, "then the old question of a share in the bamboo grove should be looked at again."

For the first time Rambilas understood that a false ancestor brings not only honour; he also arrives carrying a land survey.

6

In the second week the marriage negotiations stalled again. The city family had consulted a Panjekar. On the phone he asked, "Where is the gotra entry for your seventh ancestor, Jankinath?"

Rambilas looked at Mahendra Babu. Mahendra Babu looked at Rakesh. Rakesh looked at the screen.

This time the screen produced no ancestor.

The Panjekar said, "A printed chart is not proof. I need the original source."

For the first time in Rambilas's house the words "original source" sounded frightening, as if someone were knocking at the door at night.

Rakesh offered a solution. "An affidavit can be made."

Phulo asked, "Whose oath? About something we do not even know?"

Rakesh said, "It is the process."

Phulo laughed. "When a lie is put on stamp paper, does it become a process?"

Rakesh could not find an answer to that question on his service list.

7

Meanwhile Naval, who worked in Delhi, came home. The moment he saw the family tree he laughed; then he fell silent.

"Who is this Jankinath?"

Rambilas said, "An ancestor."

"According to whom?"

"It is an old matter."

"Whose old matter?"

Rambilas lost patience. "It was made for your marriage. We are doing all this for you."

Naval said quietly, "I had said we should not write lies."

"Who has proved that this is a lie?" Rambilas protested.

From in front of the stove Phulo said, "If something has not been proved true, therefore it is not false—that is excellent new logic."

For a while only the clatter of the ladle could be heard in the house.

Naval folded the family tree and said, "If the marriage depends on this paper, let it not happen."

What angered Rambilas was not that his son might stop the marriage. It was that the eight hundred and fifty rupees spent on seven generations, two photocopies, one colour print, and Mahendra Babu's prestige were all suddenly becoming useless.

8

But the genealogy had already escaped the family's hands.

Its photograph reached the village WhatsApp group. Someone wrote, "The historic lineage of Rambilasji." Someone sent folded-hands emojis. Someone googled Jankinath's name.

Two days later a notice arrived from the block office: lineage information in an earlier land-reform application filed by Rambilas's family did not match the new family tree; an explanation was required.

Rambilas read the paper and ran to Mahendra Babu.

Mahendra Babu said, "Why did you submit this in a government file?"

"I did not!"

"Then how did it get there?"

It emerged that Bholanath had attached a copy of the coloured family tree to his land-related claim because it helped establish his agnatic connection.

Rambilas sat down holding his head.

The false ancestor had first gone to a marriage house, then to a field boundary, and now had secured a posting in a government file.

9

At the block office the clerk examined the family tree. His lips twitched when he read the golden words "Tradition · Prestige · Family."

"Is this government-certified?"

"No."

"Then why was it submitted?"

"I did not submit it."

"But it is your lineage?"

Rambilas got stuck on that question. "On paper... it is."

The clerk removed his glasses. "What is on paper is the paper's truth. Once it enters a file, it becomes the file's problem."

Rambilas remembered Rakesh's shop—"Paper gets made." Now he understood that paper is not merely made; once made, it begins making questions too.

The clerk told him to write an explanation. Rambilas asked, "Should I write that this was a mistake?"

Phulo, who had come with him, corrected him at once. "A mistake."

The clerk smiled. "Use whichever word you like. Keep the facts clear."

For the first time Rambilas heard advice in a government office that sounded like advice for his own household.

10

That night the family held a meeting. Naval wanted an immediate written declaration that the family tree was unverified. Rambilas was afraid. "The village will laugh."

Phulo asked, "They are not laughing already?"

Their younger daughter Pinky, who had found the entire affair most entertaining, opened her phone. "Babu, three memes have already been made in Jankinath Baba's name."

The first showed a photograph of an unknown old man with a moustache and the caption: "Want land? Join my lineage."

The second read: "Seven generations for only 850 rupees."

Rambilas's face fell.

Phulo could no longer suppress her laughter. At first softly, then openly. Naval joined her. Pinky had of course been laughing all along.

After a few moments Rambilas laughed too. It was not a pleasant laugh, but it made the fear smaller.

"All right," he said. "We will write what happened."

II

Rakesh was called the next day. He first tried to limit his responsibility. "I only typed the information you gave me."

Phulo asked, "Who gave you Harinarayan, Raghubir, and Jankinath?"

Rakesh looked at Mahendra Babu.

Mahendra Babu looked at the sky.

Pinky switched on the recorder on her phone.

At last Mahendra Babu said, "The names were examples."

Naval laughed. "The examples became our ancestors."

Rakesh admitted that the chart should have carried the words "Unverified Family Outline." "But customers want beautiful things," he said.

Phulo replied, "The beautiful lie has cost more than the ugly truth."

At that sentence Rambilas looked at his wife. He remembered that while the chart was being made Phulo had once asked, "Where am I?" That question still had not been answered.

12

A new document was made—this time not in colour. At the top it read: "Known Family Lineage Information and Uncertainties."

Rambilas—Bhubaneswar—Dhanik/Dhanuki. Above that, a blank box. Beneath the blank box a small note: "Name not certain."

Phulo also had the names of her parents entered. Naval said, "If this is a description of the family, both sides should be present."

Rakesh initially objected, "Then it will not remain a traditional tree."

Phulo answered, "At this point I want recognition more than tradition."

Pinky suggested that every living family member's work should also be written: Bhubaneswar—farmer; Dhanuki/Dhanik—name uncertain, farming; Rambilas—bicycle repair and farming; Phulo—sewing, home, fields; Naval—electrical engineer; Pinky—student.

Rambilas asked, "Why work?"

Pinky said, "A name alone does not make a whole person."

No one argued with that.

13

Naval himself called the city family. He told them the entire story. Their uncle was silent at first, then asked, "So the first genealogy was false?"

Naval replied, “Unverified claims were written as certainties. Yes, it was a mistake.”

The matter did not end there. Later their daughter Swara called Naval separately. “My problem is less with my uncle than with the fact that you did not stop this earlier.”

Naval said, “I did stop it, but late.”

“Why late?”

“Perhaps I too wanted your family to think mine was grand.”

Swara was silent for a while. “At least that answer has no genealogy in it.”

Naval laughed.

The marriage was not fixed at once. Naval and Swara kept talking. The story did not take the easy road of declaring love victorious, because trust between families grows more slowly than a coloured chart.

14

Bholanath’s land claim turned out to be no less comic. When Rambilas stated in writing that the connection to Jankinath was unverified, Bholanath looked disappointed.

“Then we are not agnates?”

Rambilas said, “We are people of the same village. Is that so little?”

Gathering up his bag, Bholanath said, “If we had been agnates, the thirty-two dhur question might have worked out.”

“That is exactly what I was afraid of.”

Both men burst out laughing.

A few months later the survey established that the boundary marker called “Jankinath’s bamboo grove” referred not to lineage but to an old local place-name. Whoever that Jankinath had been, no verified relation to Rambilas could be found.

Mahendra Babu commented on the finding: “See? The name turned out to be right.”

Phulo asked, “Whose?”

Mahendra Babu fell silent again.

15

The explanation was accepted at the block office. A note was added to the file: “Attached private genealogy chart unverified; not admissible for determination of land rights.”

Rambilas read the note and breathed in relief.

The clerk said, “Do not throw this paper away.”

“Why?”

“It will remind you.”

Rambilas wondered whether government officials sometimes made jokes or gave wisdom; it was difficult to tell the difference.

At home he wanted to burn the coloured chart. Phulo stopped him.

“Keep it.”

"It is a lie."

"Yes. That is why you should keep it. Show the children how a lie gets made."

The chart was put into the trunk—not with the old truths, but in a folder labelled "Mistake."

16

Had the story stopped there, Rambilas might have been spared. But the photograph of the coloured chart had travelled so widely online that a month later an invitation arrived from the district headquarters for a "Jankinath Lineage Convention." In bold letters on the envelope: "Distinguished Descendant Shri Rambilas Mandal."

Rambilas looked at the envelope, laughed first, then grew afraid. "I am not going."

Mahendra Babu said, "You may never get such an opportunity again."

Phulo said, "He is right. You may never again get such a chance to free yourself publicly from a false ancestor."

At the convention hall Rambilas saw five different portraits of Jankinath hanging on the walls. In one he had a beard, in another only a moustache, in a third a pag on his head, in a fourth a cap. There were three different birth years too. The master of ceremonies declared proudly, "We are all branches sprung from one great root."

Rambilas remembered the tree Rakesh had made. Suddenly he understood: branches first grow on paper, and then people begin looking for their shade.

His name was called. He was expected to sing the virtues of the "great ancestor." Rambilas took the microphone and said, "I need to make one thing clear first. The chart you have seen in my name is unverified. I have no evidence that Jankinath is my ancestor."

First there was silence in the hall, then an uproar.

One gentleman rose and asked, "Then why are you here?"

Rambilas replied, "You invited me."

Someone at the back laughed.

Another man asked, "But your chart?"

"It was beautiful. It was not true."

This time laughter broke out openly across the hall. The chairman on the stage looked uncomfortable at first, then began leafing through his file and said, "Actually, our committee also wants to collect original sources."

Later Phulo whispered in Rambilas's ear, "Today you gave them a research topic for free."

The convention's final resolution acquired a new line: "The source for every lineage claim shall be stated separately." Rambilas was astonished. For the first time his false lineage had done something useful.

Rakesh's shop changed too. Beneath the old signboard a new sheet was posted: "Family trees based only on information supplied by the customer; historical verification is a separate service."

Mahendra Babu read it and asked, "What does separate service mean?"

Rakesh said, "Source checking, old documents, interviews, scans—all separately charged."

"Earlier you gave seven generations for eight hundred and fifty."

"That was the design fee."

"Ancestors free?"

Rakesh smiled awkwardly. "Names supplied by the customer."

Phulo, who had come to photocopy a sewing-machine part, said, "The shop is better now. Earlier lies were cheap; now truth is expensive."

Rakesh protested, "Mother, finding truth takes time."

Phulo nodded. "That you have said correctly."

Later Rakesh removed Rambilas's old file from his samples. In its place he displayed an imaginary tree with the word "EXAMPLE" written across the top in bold letters.

Mahendra Babu looked disappointed. "Writing 'EXAMPLE' so large spoils the beauty."

Rakesh said, "Beauty has already cost us enough once."

A few months after the marriage affair, the village school assigned homework called "My Family." Pinky's young nephew Vivan brought his notebook to Rambilas. The question was: "Write the names of your ancestors for eight generations."

Rambilas laughed when he saw it. "Your school wants to become another Rakesh."

Vivan did not understand.

Rambilas wrote in the notebook: "1. Father—Naval. 2. Grandfather—Rambilas. 3. Great-grandfather—Bhubaneswar. 4. Above him—Dhanik/Dhanuki, name uncertain. 5–8. I do not know at present."

Vivan asked, "Sir will say to complete it."

From inside Phulo said, "Write that Grandmother said—I do not know."

The next day the teacher wrote "Incomplete" in red ink. Vivan came home dejected.

Naval did not telephone the teacher; he went to the next parent meeting. He said, "Where information does not exist, it is not right to tell a child to invent names."

At first the teacher said, "It is only an activity."

Naval replied, "Then 'I do not know' should also be an acceptable answer to the activity."

The next week the worksheet was changed: "Write as far back as the family knows with certainty; include the maternal grandparents' side as well; where something is not known, you may write 'I do not know.'"

On the new page Vivan also wrote the names of Phulo's parents. Rambilas saw that the episode of the false seven generations had made one small school form a little better.

Pinky joked, "Jankinath Baba has turned out to be an educationist too."

Rambilas laughed. "His contributions are many."

19

Three days after the convention, the local weekly carried a report headlined: "Historic Address by Renowned Jankinath Descendant Rambilas Mandal." The moment Phulo read the headline, she sat down in a chair.

Inside the article only half of Rambilas's words had been printed. It said, "Rambilasji emphasized the glory of his lineage along with the need for source collection." The sentence he had said most forcefully—"Jankinath is not my verified ancestor"—was missing.

Rambilas called the newspaper office. The editor said, "We were short of space."

"So you cut the main point?"

"We will publish a correction in the next issue."

In the next issue, at the bottom of page seven, two lines appeared: "In the previous issue Rambilas Mandal was described as a verified descendant of Jankinath; according to his statement, the relationship is unverified."

Pinky cut out the correction and placed it in the "Mistake" folder with the old coloured chart.

Rambilas asked, "Why?"

"To show the two lives of the same lie," Pinky said. "First the big photograph, then the small correction."

Phulo laughed. "A lie has large wings; a correction has small ones."

For weeks afterward, people from outside the village still addressed Rambilas as "Jankinath's descendant." He kept correcting them. At first he felt embarrassed by the correction; gradually it became his daily practice.

Someone would ask, "Then who were your real ancestors?" He would reply, "I will tell you as far as I know. Beyond that, I do not know."

The answer was short, but it now carried more weight for Rambilas than the coloured chart of seven generations.

20

A year later Naval married Swara. No seven-generation genealogy was printed on the wedding invitation. It contained only the names of parents, paternal grandparents, and maternal grandparents—as far as the families knew with certainty.

Mahendra Babu looked at the card and said, "Very ordinary."

Rambilas smiled. "Ordinary does not feel expensive anymore."

Bholanath also came to the wedding. Joking, he said, “Blessings from the agnate side.”

Rambilas replied, “Without the thirty-two dhur?”

“Without it today.”

Both laughed.

That evening, when the electricity went out once, Phulo lit a lamp in the wall niche. Before its light lay the new family list—some names, some blank boxes, people from both sides, and short notes about their work.

Rambilas looked at the blank boxes. Once, blank spaces had embarrassed him. Now they gave him relief, because no manufactured ancestor had been shoved into them.

From behind him Pinky asked, “Babu, who was Jankinath Baba?”

Rambilas laughed. “The most famous ancestor in our family who was not our ancestor.”

Everyone burst out laughing.

The lamp flame moved. The old golden chart lay in darkness inside the trunk. Outside, on plain paper, as far as the light reached, what was known appeared clearly, and what was unknown remained unknown.

For the first time, Rambilas did not feel that his short lineage was small.

— *End of Story 20* —

21. Roots in a Foreign Land

STORY

I

Arnav Jha did not bring his father's ashes to Mithila. In the last year of his life, his father, Shailesh, had said plainly, "Keep my body wherever you wish; do not turn me into a burden carried in the name of my village." Arnav had not understood the sentence then. Shailesh died in Toronto, was cremated there, and, with the family's agreement, his ashes were scattered in a small park by the lake. Yet six months later Arnav came to India alone. He carried an old brass key, two photographs, half an address written by his father, and a short audio recording in which Shailesh could be heard laughing and speaking to someone in Maithili.

Arnav had been born in Canada. At home his father addressed him in Maithili, while his mother, Mira, spoke Bengali and English. Arnav grew up hearing all three languages, yet no single one contained his entire childhood. Many Maithili words survived in him not by meaning but by occasion: "duaar" when his father was looking for his slippers; "aabi ja" when the food was getting cold; "nena" when he fell ill. Mira used to say that Maithili was Shailesh's tenderest language, but Arnav's school, friends, job and marriage had all been made in an English-speaking world.

While sorting Shailesh's papers, Arnav found an envelope. On the outside, in Devanagari, was written only: "Not papers of the house—papers of the heart." Inside were two photographs. The first showed an earthen courtyard, a leaning mango tree, and three adolescents. On the back, in Shailesh's hand: "East of the banyan, south of the big pond, 1977." The second photograph showed an old man seated before an open volume that resembled a Panji. On the back was written: "These people know all the names, but not all the lives."

Arnav had come because of that second sentence.

2

Changing buses at Darbhanga, he reached Kusumpur. Kusumpur was the name in Shailesh's papers, but the conductor first counted out two Kusumpurs—one east of the main road, another toward the Kamla. Arnav showed him the old photograph on his phone. The conductor laughed. "Hard to recognise a village from a photograph." At last an elderly passenger

heard the name of the pond and said, “Perhaps you—” He stopped and corrected himself. “Perhaps you want the southern Kusumpur.”

At the entrance to the village Arnav first looked for the banyan. The great banyan was gone. There was a widened road, a mobile tower, a chemist’s shop, two motorcycle repair sheds, and the blue gate of a school. He held up the photograph and tried to match the angle. A boy behind him asked, “Uncle, have you come to inspect land?”

“No. I’m looking for a house.”

“Whose?”

Arnav hesitated over the answer. “My... father’s.”

“What was his name?”

“Shailesh Jha.”

The boy shook his head; the name meant nothing to him. Arnav felt embarrassment mixed with surprise. Abroad he had always said “my father’s village” as if it were a fixed point. Yet in that very village his father could be an unrecognised name.

3

He found the place where the Panji was kept that evening. Vibhuti Babu was close to eighty. In the front room stood a wooden cupboard; volumes lay above it under cloth covers; there was a tulsi plant near the window and a brass lamp. Arnav showed him the photographs. The old man took the second one and studied it for a long time.

“That was my uncle,” Vibhuti Babu said. “I was a child then.”

Something inside Arnav suddenly gave way, as though an object had for the first time stepped out of a photograph.

“My father used to say our family was in the Panji.”

“It should be. Names?”

Arnav opened his notes: Shailesh’s father was Jagdish; Jagdish’s father was Vidyapati; above that he was uncertain. Vibhuti Babu changed volumes, one after another. Amid the smell of paper, dust and old ink, Arnav switched off his phone. After nearly half an hour the old man placed a finger on a line.

“Jagdish. Yes. Shailesh is written in this branch, but nothing after him.”

Arnav bent closer. His father was a small line: year of birth, an unfinished mark beside marriage, and then blank space.

“My name isn’t there?”

“No.”

“Why?”

Vibhuti Babu answered matter-of-factly, “Your father probably never came back to have the later names entered. Many branches of families who went abroad stop here in exactly this way.”

Arnav’s first feeling was not disappointment but a strange lightness. He had crossed an ocean in search of proof, and his absence from the book had so ordinary a cause: nobody had come and written him in.

4

Vibhuti Babu asked, "Your mother?"

"Mira Sen. A family from Kolkata."

"Where was the marriage?"

"In Toronto. Civil marriage. Later there was a small ceremony at home."

"Gotra?"

Arnav laughed, then the laugh stopped at once. "I remember my father's gotra. My mother's family does not record gotra in this form."

Vibhuti Babu looked at him attentively—neither mockery nor disapproval. He merely looked at the empty boxes in the old register. "Your wife?"

"Emma. Her father's family is of Irish origin, her mother's of Filipino origin. Our daughter is Leena Jha-O'Connor."

The old man looked down at the volume again, as if asking the paper how so many lives might be placed inside a single line.

"This book was not made for so many kinds of lives," he said at last.

The words stung Arnav. "Then I am not of this lineage?"

Vibhuti Babu immediately raised his head. "I did not say that. The boxes in the book are small. People are not."

The lamp flame trembled slightly. A motorcycle sounded outside and receded into the distance. For the first time Arnav understood that he had been asking not an old man, but an old format, to pass judgment on his existence.

5

The next morning he went in search of "east of the banyan, south of the big pond." A panchayat building now stood where the banyan had been. The big pond had been half filled; part of it had become a school playground. To the south were four brick houses, a tin-roofed structure, and, between them, the trace of an old brick drain.

Arnav took the brass key from his pocket and put it back. Trying it in someone's door would have been absurd.

An old woman was warming herself in the sun in a courtyard. The moment she saw the photograph she narrowed her eyes and said, "Isn't the boy in the middle Shailesh?"

Arnav's throat went dry. "You knew him?"

"He studied with my brother. He would take radios apart and then fail to put them back together." She laughed. "Once he dismantled the school bell. The master searched for it for three days."

Arnav laughed too. At home his father had opened watches, toasters and radios. Mira always said, "A working thing breaks in Shailesh's hands; a broken thing may perhaps become whole." The root of that habit was not in the Panji; it was in this old woman's laughter.

"Where was the house?" Arnav asked.

The woman did not look at the photograph. She pointed toward a corner of the field. “There. It was sold long ago. Half the house fell in a flood; the rest was sold. The mango tree broke in a storm two years ago.”

Arnav looked at the mango tree in the photograph. He had reached the place, and yet the place visible in the photograph no longer existed anywhere.

6

The old woman’s name was Kunti Devi. She gave Arnav tea and told him many small things, none of which were “lineage.” Shailesh had not known how to swim; during Durga Puja the ear of the clay lion kept breaking; as a boy he wrote poems but showed them to no one; his mother put neem leaves in khichdi on the first day of rain, and Shailesh quarrelled about it.

Arnav began taking notes, then put the phone away. “How have you remembered all this for so many years?”

Kunti Devi said, “I have not remembered everything. I am telling you what remained. Why should I call something a memory when I do not remember it?”

The answer felt to Arnav like the blank space in the Panji—first incomplete, then honest.

Kunti Devi suddenly asked, “Did Shailesh ever come back?”

“Twice. I was small. I do not remember clearly.”

“He used to say next time he would stay longer.”

Arnav did not answer. In Toronto too, every year his father had said, “Next year we’ll go.” Next year there was work, his mother’s ill health, Arnav’s studies, then marriage, then a granddaughter. Little by little the village had become a sentence placed in the future.

7

After hearing Kunti Devi, Arnav went to the school. The building inside the blue gate was new, but a few old admission registers survived in a cupboard in the headmaster’s room. Arnav explained why he was looking for his father’s name. The headmaster hesitated at first—the old register was a school record, not a private family archive. Arnav asked only for permission to see the name.

After much searching they found “Shailesh Kumar Jha” in one volume. The year of birth differed by one year from the Panji. Guardian: Jagdish Jha. Address: Kusumpur. Many attendance boxes were blank; his mathematics marks were good; beside handwriting the teacher had written, “Make the letters clear.” Arnav laughed. All his life Shailesh’s handwriting had been so poor that Mira could not read his grocery lists.

A retired school employee named Ramlochan happened to be there. Hearing the name, he said, “Shailesh was a very bright student.” The headmaster showed him the register. Ramlochan added, “But he came to class irregularly. He wandered toward the river.”

Arnav said, "Kunti Devi remembers him taking radios apart."

Ramlochan scratched his head. "Possible. I remember him flying kites."

The two memories did not match. At first Arnav thought someone must be mistaken. Then he realised that a boy could take radios apart, fly kites, and miss school to go to the river, all in the same life. Memories were not always contradictory; sometimes they were separate windows.

The different birth years bothered him again. The Panji gave one year, the school another. Arnav asked the headmaster, "Which is correct?"

"With only these two records, I cannot say," the headmaster replied easily. "In old admissions, years were often estimated. Not everyone had a birth certificate."

Arnav asked permission to photograph the entry. The headmaster said, "Take only the portion with his name, not the details of other children." Arnav framed the image so that only Shailesh's line was visible. It reminded him of his museum work: preserve the source, preserve the boundary, preserve the uncertainty too.

As he left the school, he thought: on paper his father had become a difference of one year, but in Arnav's memory the voice was perfectly certain. Paper and memory carried different kinds of incompleteness.

8

That afternoon a man came to Arnav and introduced himself: "I am Gopal Jha, a distant agnate of yours." He had heard of Arnav's arrival. Within five minutes he was talking about old land, partition, roadside prices and "your share."

Arnav grew uneasy. "I have not come for land."

Gopal smiled. "Everyone says that first."

"I truly haven't."

"Then why did you look at the Panji?"

Arnav searched for an answer. Abroad, searching for roots had seemed emotional, almost private. Here, consulting a Panji could be read as the first sign of a land claim. The same document could mean different things to different people.

Gopal offered to show him an old map. Arnav politely refused. As he left, Gopal said, "If you search for roots, you have to go down to the soil."

The sentence sounded right, but Arnav could smell the price of land inside it.

9

That evening Arnav listened to the audio recording connected with his father. It lasted only forty-two seconds. In the background plates clinked, someone laughed, and Shailesh's voice said, "This child cannot speak Maithili yet, but he understands everything." Then someone asked, "Will you return?" Shailesh laughed and answered, "I will return, but I do not know how far one can return."

Arnav played the sentence many times. In the recording he himself had been that child. Now the child's daughter was twelve and understood only a few Maithili words. Leena had sent him a message from home: "Send a picture of the house you are looking for." Arnav had sent none all day, because he had not found a photograph that could be called "the house."

He opened the phone and looked at pictures of the school field, the half pond, the panchayat building and Kunti Devi's courtyard. All were true; no single photograph was the answer.

IO

The next day Vibhuti Babu explained that the small mark beside Shailesh's marriage in the old volume, which looked like a question mark, was not a question mark at all. It was the beginning of a note that was to say "marriage outside," abandoned halfway by his uncle as he wrote it.

"Why did he stop?"

"I don't know."

"Could we ask someone?"

"The man who wrote it is gone. Your father is gone. Your grandfather is gone. Some questions do not yield answers."

The same uneasiness rose in Arnav again. His profession was designing museum exhibitions. He wanted dates, sources, provenance and context beside every object. "Unknown" was a legitimate word in his work, but difficult to accept inside his own family.

"Can my name be added?" he asked.

Vibhuti Babu said, "It can. But how? The paternal branch is clear. You were born abroad. Your mother belongs to another tradition. Your marriage took another form. Your daughter has a second, hyphenated surname. We can write all this, but it will not sit neatly in the old compartments of this book."

"Then what should be written?"

The old man was silent for a while. "What is certain, as certain. What you tell us, as 'stated by you.' What we do not know, leave blank."

Arnav smiled. "So I am half verified, half stated?"

Vibhuti Babu smiled too. "Everyone is like that in some measure. The only difference with old people is that, with time, what was once merely stated begins to look like proof."

II

Arnav did not immediately agree to have his name entered. He asked, "What if I do not?"

"Then you will not be in the book. You will still be in life."

The sentence was simple. Arnav had expected the registrar to persuade him, speak of the importance of tradition, or insist on entering the name. Vibhuti Babu merely knew the limits of his book.

Arnav asked for a copy of the page containing his father. Vibhuti Babu allowed it, but wrote a slip to accompany it: "Copy only; not the original entry." Arnav read it and laughed. "You mark the limits of everything."

"If we do not write the limits, people forget them."

Arnav did not fold the copy. His father travelled into his bag as a small line.

12

That night Arnav called Mira. It was morning in Toronto and she was making tea. Arnav told her about the blank space in the Panji, the different birth year in the school register, and Kunti Devi's stories. Mira listened for a long time.

Then she asked, "What did you go there to find?"

Arnav did not answer at once. "Baba's roots."

"Shailesh's, or your own?"

The question silenced him. At the beginning of the journey the two had seemed the same. Now he could see the difference. To search for Shailesh's roots meant the places of his childhood, the people, the book, the school. To search for his own meant asking what place all these things held in Arnav's life. That was another question.

Mira said, "Your father left the village, but the village never left him. When we married, he tried very hard to teach me Maithili. After three weeks he began learning Bengali himself. In the end we each learnt half of the other's language."

Arnav laughed. "There is no box for you in the Panji."

"I never looked for a place in Shailesh's Panji," Mira said. "I looked for a place in his life. I found it."

Arnav looked out into the darkness. Growing up abroad had made him imagine roots the wrong way—as if there were one clean root underground, and if he dug it up his identity would become clear. Mira's sentence suggested that sometimes a root was not an object but a direction of relationship.

Before ending the call Mira asked, "Did the key open anything?"

"Not yet."

"Then don't go forcing it into some lock just to make it open something."

Arnav laughed. "You know me very well."

"Do you need proof of that?"

They both laughed.

13

On his last night in Kusumpur, Kunti Devi invited him to dinner. Her grandchildren were there too. In the middle of the meal she hummed half a line of a song from Shailesh's childhood. Arnav started. His father had sometimes hummed that very tune while washing dishes, though the words had never been clear.

“The whole song?” Arnav asked.

Kunti Devi shook her head. “I remember only half.”

Her granddaughter wanted to search for it on the phone. Kunti Devi laughed. “My memory is not inside your phone.”

Arnav asked permission to record the half line. The old woman said, “Record it, but write that I remember only half. Don’t send it around after making up a complete song.”

Arnav named the recording “Kunti Devi—Incomplete Song.” There was a kind of peace in the title. An incomplete thing did not have to be made to look whole.

14

After the meal Kunti Devi brought a small box. Inside was a rusted round piece of tin. “This may be a piece from inside the school bell. When Shailesh took it apart, my brother stole this bit and kept it. I cannot say it is certainly the same piece. But in our house it has always lived with that story.”

Arnav held the disc. He felt, all at once, the desire to buy it, keep it, declare it “my father’s object.” Then he said, “It belongs to your family. Let it remain here.”

Kunti Devi was pleased. “Good. People looking for roots sometimes want to carry everything away with them.”

Arnav put the disc back in the box. He understood that to make a relationship one’s own, one did not always have to take the object home. Some things became relationships precisely by remaining where they were.

15

On the day he was to return to Toronto, before going to the station, Arnav visited Vibhuti Babu once more. He had prepared a slip with his full legal name, birthplace, parents, wife, daughter and email, and beneath it one line: “Paternal branch—connected with Shailesh, son of Jagdish; maternal side—Sen family; other details according to family statement.”

Vibhuti Babu read it. “This looks more like a modern government form than a Panji.”

Arnav laughed. “Then you write it.”

The old man took out a blank sheet. He did not immediately add anything to the original line in the old volume. On a separate supplementary sheet he wrote: “Arnav, son of Shailesh, born abroad. Paternal side connected with this branch. Marriage and maternal side outside the old format; information supplied by family attached. Open to future verification.”

Arnav read “open to future verification” and felt both amusement and sadness. “So I am still unverified?”

Vibhuti Babu removed his glasses. “You are sitting here, remembering your father; people here have spoken to you—that is proof enough for life. The book does its own work. It should not be asked to do all of life’s work.”

16

On the way to the station Arnav remembered Gopal's proposal about land. If he wanted, he could combine the copy of the Panji, old maps and statements from agnates and construct the story of a claim. For someone sitting abroad, the phrase "ancestral land" had an attractive sound. But where the house had been sold, the pond half filled and the banyan cut, papers of ownership were not the answer he had come looking for.

He touched the brass key in his pocket. In three days he had tried it in no lock. Now it occurred to him that the key might not even belong to the house in Shailesh's photograph. It might be from an old cupboard in Toronto; perhaps his father had simply attached a story to it.

Earlier such uncertainty would have hurt him. Now he let the key remain only a key.

17

At the airport Leena video-called him. "Did you find the house?" Her Maithili extended only as far as that one question; the rest of the conversation she conducted in English. Arnav answered in Maithili, "I did not find one house."

Leena laughed. "Then what did you find?"

Arnav opened the camera roll and showed her photographs—the copy of his father's line, the half pond, Kunti Devi's courtyard, the school field, Vibhuti Babu's lamp, the blank spaces.

Leena stopped at one image: the open volume behind the lamp. "This one is nice."

"Why?"

"The paper is old, but the flame is new."

Arnav laughed. Perhaps it was merely a child's spontaneous remark. He felt an impulse to turn it into a symbol, then stopped himself. Not everything needed to be made meaningful.

18

Back in Toronto he did not frame the copy of his father's entry. Framing it would again have made the paper look like a "final proof" hung on a wall. He scanned it, placed it with his mother's papers in a digital folder, and named the folder "Family—Known/Unknown."

Mira read the supplementary note and was silent for a long time. Then she asked, "Is my name there?"

"On the supplementary sheet."

"Separate?"

Arnav became uncertain. He did not want to make a new lineage book like Ira's in Story 18; his journey was different. "Yes, separate. The old book did not have enough room."

Mira smiled. "There was no shortage of room in Shailesh's life."

Arnav did not write that sentence down. He only remembered it.

A few weeks later Arnav sat with his daughter in the living room. Leena was doing a school project called “Where Did My Family Come From?” On the screen she had added the names of countries—India, Canada, Ireland, the Philippines. Then she asked, “Papa, what was your village called?”

“Kusumpur.”

“Is it my village too?”

Arnav did not say yes at once. “If you want, it is one place in your family. But you do not have to live there, or ask anyone for proof.”

Leena put a small dot on the map. It was a very small dot. Around it lay a great deal of blank screen.

Arnav remembered Vibhuti Babu’s book. Blank space no longer felt like exclusion. Blank space could also be room for the future.

That night Arnav placed his father’s brass key on the table. A small brass lamp Mira had given him stood in the room. Leena finished her homework and went to bed. Arnav lit the lamp. Light fell on the key, but no lock opened.

He played Kunti Devi’s recording, “Incomplete Song.” Half a line, then laughter, then silence. After it came the forty-two seconds of his father’s voice: “This child cannot speak Maithili yet, but he understands everything.”

Arnav tried to find his own old voice in the recording and could not. He switched off the phone.

In the Panji his name stood outside the original line, on a supplementary sheet. In the village there was no house of his. The key from his father was uncertain. The song was incomplete. Memory differed from person to person.

And yet this time the word “unverified” did not feel empty. He understood that proof can draw boundaries; relationships sometimes grow across them.

The lamp flame leaned a little, then straightened. The key did not grow warm; only the dust on it shone. Arnav did not wipe it clean.

For Leena he wrote three words in Maithili on a piece of paper: “Kusumpur—one place.” Beneath it he added no English, Bengali or other explanation.

He placed the paper beside the lamp and left the room. The light remained behind—not to prove anyone’s lineage, but only to show whatever fell within its reach.

— End of Story 21 —

22. Priesthood

STORY

I

The morning Shivanath Jha learnt that his younger brother Vidyanath had put forward his name for the priesthood, the bell slipped into one extra stroke during the dawn arati. The unexpected clang travelled out of the temple's little sanctum and into the courtyard. No one noticed it. Shivanath did. As he set the bell down, he wondered whether it was his hand that had trembled, or his mind.

Madhukanteshwar Sthan was no great pilgrimage centre. East of the village, beside the pond, between an old brick wall and a new tin awning, stood a small Shiva-linga, a peepal tree, a tulsi platform, and the priestly service that the Jha family had performed for four generations. Shivanath's father, Rudranath Jha, used to say, "This is not a post; it is a watchman's duty. Rise before everyone at dawn, and at night be the last to put out the lamps." Shivanath had made that sentence a rule of his life.

Rudranath had died three months earlier. After the thirteenth-day rites, the committee said the name of the next chief priest ought formally to be entered. Shivanath had thought the question was merely one of date. For eighteen years, through his father's illness, he had carried most of the daily worship, wedding sankalpas, opening rites of shraddha, recitations, vow-completions, and the village's small and large religious duties.

Then the committee secretary opened a paper and said, "There are two names."

The second was Vidyanath's.

2

Vidyanath was the younger brother, but he had always been ahead in study. Rudranath had sent him to a Sanskrit college. Later he became a teacher in the city, wrote on ritual procedure, and joined a group that prepared almanacs. In the village he was known as "Pandit Vidyanath"; to most people Shivanath was simply "Shiva Babu."

Only at the meeting did Shivanath learn that Vidyanath had not submitted an application himself. Committee president Ramkishore Chaudhary had asked for his written consent, and Vidyanath had written: "If the family and committee consider it appropriate, I shall be available for service."

Shivanath read the line and laughed. "Available."

Vidyanath said quietly, "Don't get stuck on one word, Dada."

"I am not stuck merely on the word. A man who has been available at five every morning for eighteen years—why does his availability not show on the paper?"

The air in the room grew heavy at once.

The president said, "That is why we are meeting. We must consider family tradition, service, and scriptural qualification."

Shivanath asked, "Am I unqualified?"

No one answered.

Vidyanath said, "I did not say that."

"You did not. Your certificates do."

That was the first wound. The brothers had disagreed before, but never in a public room had the fitness of one been placed against the fitness of the other.

3

Returning home, Shivanath said nothing to his wife, Urmila. She was sorting paddy at the doorway. All she noticed was that after washing his hands before dinner, he stood a very long time beside the tap.

At night Urmila asked, "What happened at the meeting?"

"Chhotka will become priest."

"Will become? Or his name has been proposed?"

"What difference does that make?"

Closing the grain tin, Urmila said, "The difference is that one thing happened in the meeting and the other happened in your mind."

Shivanath disliked the sentence. "You don't understand. When Babu fell ill, who looked after the temple? Chhotka was in the city then."

"Yes."

"In the flood year, when the water reached the Shiva-linga, who spent the night filling sandbags?"

"You."

"When Ma was ill, Babu was ill, Chhotka's fees—"

He stopped.

Urmila looked at him. "Did you say this in the meeting?"

"No."

"Why?"

"It is not right to count debts."

Urmila laughed softly. "Then why are you counting them in your mind?"

Shivanath had no answer.

4

Vidyanath was staying in his father's old room in the village. When he opened the cupboard, he found three bundles of papers—the temple offering

ledger, household expenses, and his own old hostel receipts. The sight of one receipt brought an entire year back to him.

He had been twenty then. His fees had not been paid. Rudranath had written, "Wait a few days." Two weeks later a money order arrived. Vidyanath had assumed his father had arranged it. Much later his mother told him that Barka—Shivanath—had mortgaged the small mango grove that fell to his share for five years.

Vidyanath had never discussed it with Shivanath. He felt gratitude and embarrassment. Time passed, he found employment, sent money to repair the house roof, paid for their mother's treatment, helped with his niece's education. He had imagined the old account had gradually come level.

Now, holding the receipt, he understood that family accounts never truly balance. One later act of help may change the numbers, not the memory.

That night he called the committee president. "If my name is increasing quarrel in the house, remove it."

The president replied, "This is not only a domestic matter. It concerns the temple's system of service. Even if you withdraw, the question remains: should the next priest be chosen only by seniority, or by qualification?"

After the call, Vidyanath thought for the first time that perhaps his name had not created the question. The question had been there already, only unspoken.

5

As boys, the brothers had grown up in the same temple courtyard. People came to recognise Shivanath quickly because he went from house to house with their father. Vidyanath preferred books. Once Rudranath sent them both to gather bel leaves. Shivanath returned with a full basket; Vidyanath with half a basket, but every leaf had three perfect lobes.

Rudranath laughed. "One sees quantity, the other quality."

Then the comparison was a game. As they grew older, that very sentence slowly became a division. In Shivanath's mind: "I do the people's work." In Vidyanath's: "I understand the rules." Each took half a virtue and made it a whole identity.

Shivanath remembered another incident. Vidyanath had been ten. During worship their father asked the meaning of a mantra. Shivanath fell silent. Vidyanath answered. Pleased, Rudranath gave him one of his old books. Shivanath had felt jealous—but that evening it was Shivanath who stitched a cloth cover for the book.

Now he wondered when the brother who made the cover and the brother who read the book had become rivals. No register contained that date.

6

The priesthood at Madhukanteshwar Sthan carried very little salary. Most income came from dakshina, grain, seasonal gifts, and the private rites of

village families. For that reason “office” and “livelihood” could not easily be separated.

Shivanath’s son Neelabh was studying engineering and had no interest in becoming a priest. His daughter Gauri studied Sanskrit and knew the temple hymns by heart, yet no one in the family had ever counted her when discussing succession.

One evening, picking flowers beside her father, Gauri asked, “Babu, if Kaka becomes priest, what will you do?”

Shivanath started. “Who told you he has become priest?”

“In the village every half-story becomes whole by the time it reaches the next house.”

Shivanath did not laugh. “I will serve. The temple is nobody’s inherited property.”

Gauri put the flower basket down. “Then what is the quarrel about?”

Shivanath grew sharp. “You do not need to understand everything.”

Gauri fell silent. A little later she said only, “I remember Babu’s sentence: ‘The temple is nobody’s inherited property.’”

Hearing his own words returned to him made Shivanath uneasy.

7

There was one thing inside the quarrel that Shivanath hid even from himself: priesthood was his livelihood. The small holding did not feed the family sufficiently. Dakshina from weddings, upanayanas, shraddhas, vows, house-enterings and seasonal rites met many household expenses. Losing the “post” would mean not only a loss of honour, but a reduction in income.

One night Urmila asked directly, “If Chhotka becomes chief priest, what happens to this household’s income?”

Shivanath snapped, “You too are looking at money?”

“If I do not look at money, who will pay Neelabh’s fees? Gauri’s books? Oil and salt? Service cannot be performed on an empty stomach.”

The practical question made him still more uncomfortable because before the committee he had called his claim “tradition.” Urmila showed him that livelihood was woven into tradition as well.

“Say this in the meeting,” she told him.

“People will say I want the priesthood for money.”

“And if you do not say it, people will assume money has nothing to do with it. Both are false.”

After a long silence Shivanath admitted, “I am afraid.”

“Of losing the post?”

“Of becoming smaller in my own house.”

Urmila said quietly, “Then the quarrel is about honour and stomach both. Name the thing properly; only then will a remedy appear.”

8

Vidyanath's own household was not outside the decision. His wife Sulochana taught in a city school. Their daughter's board examinations were near. If Vidyanath became the permanent priest, he would have to leave his city job, move the family, or divide every week between village and city. None of the choices was simple.

Sulochana told him plainly on the phone, "If you want to serve, serve. But do not say 'duty of lineage' and assume my life and the children's lives will rearrange themselves automatically."

Vidyanath was silent.

"And one more thing," she said. "It is good that you remember Dada's sacrifice. But do not make a decision out of guilt. Guilt will make neither a good priest nor a good brother."

After the call Vidyanath reread the line in his consent: "I shall be available for service." He felt ashamed of how easy the sentence sounded. To write "available" took seconds; to become available meant rearranging time, distance, family, income and body.

At the next meeting he said publicly for the first time, "I cannot at present promise that I can live in the village full-time."

Shivanath ought to have been pleased by the admission. Instead, strangely, his younger brother seemed more honest to him.

9

The committee opened the next meeting to villagers. The question quickly moved away from priesthood and toward the character of the two brothers.

Someone said, "Shiva Babu reaches every household."

Another: "Vidyanathji knows the scriptures better."

A third: "Worship comes from the heart."

A fourth: "From the heart, yes—but what if the mantra is wrong?"

Shivanath's ears reddened. He knew that in some complex Vedic rites he consulted a book. There was no shame in that, but public comparison made it feel like humiliation.

Then old Malati Devi rose leaning on her stick. Her husband had died many years before. "Let me say one thing. When there was no money in my house, Rudranathji did not stop the rites. Later Shivanath did not stop them either. When Vidyanath was small, I used to give him jaggery. If this priesthood is only mantra, that is half the truth. If it is only knowing people, that too is half."

The president asked, "Then what is your opinion?"

Malati Devi laughed. "I have not come to cast a vote. I have come to say that you are all calling half-truths whole."

For a while the meeting was silent.

IO

Afterward Vidyanath walked home beside Shivanath. They went a long way without speaking.

At last Vidyanath said, "Dada, I was not the one who raised the question of mantras."

"You did not have to. People raised it the moment they saw your name."

"I do not consider you unqualified."

"But you consider yourself qualified."

"Is that a crime?"

Shivanath stopped. "No. The crime is that you do not remember who gave up what in this house so that you could become qualified."

Vidyanath's face changed. "I remember."

"Then?"

"Then what? I studied, I worked, I repaired the roof, took Ma to hospital, bought Gauri's books. Dada, if I must remain indebted all my life for hostel fees, am I never to use what I learnt before my own family?"

Shivanath had no immediate answer.

Vidyanath added, "Did you send me away to study so that I would return and remain smaller than you?"

The sentence wounded them both. Vidyanath regretted it as soon as he said it. Shivanath heard it and seemed to turn to stone.

That night the two brothers lay awake for a long time in separate houses.

II

In the middle of the dispute, the brothers were called to the same household. Ramphal Mandal's elderly mother had died. The family was poor and few members could read. Ramphal came to the temple and said, "Babu, please tell us what must be done. I cannot pay anything now."

Without asking another question Shivanath changed into his ritual dhoti and set out. Vidyanath was in the village that day and went with him.

At the house Shivanath first calmed the family, distributed tasks—who would fetch water, who would support the old father—and gave everyone something concrete to do. Vidyanath explained the necessary mantras, the order of rites and their simple meanings. When Ramphal stumbled over a Sanskrit line, Vidyanath explained it in Maithili. Shivanath took the children outside and fed them.

After the rites Ramphal folded his hands. "I cannot give you anything now."

As always, Shivanath said, "Do not worry about that."

Vidyanath added, "If later you can afford it, give some oil for the temple lamp. If not, not even that."

On the way back Shivanath asked, "Is the part about the oil written in your books?"

Vidyanath laughed. "No. I learnt it from you."

Shivanath could not avoid returning the praise. "You explained the mantra well."

Only two sentences. Yet since the dispute began, it was the first time each brother had named and acknowledged the other's strength.

12

The following week the question of the temple's old accounts arose. The committee wanted a new bank account. Grain offerings, cash offerings and repair expenses were to be recorded separately.

Shivanath felt insulted. "Do you think I am a thief?"

The treasurer said, "No. We want a clear system."

Vidyanath said, "That is reasonable."

Shivanath turned on him. "To you every old thing looks dirty."

"Not dirty. Unclear."

"Same thing."

"No, Dada. In an unclear system even an honest man can become trapped."

Shivanath held the old ledger. He opened it and showed them: grain from one house, ghee from another, no dakshina taken at one shraddha, five hundred rupees received at a wedding. Beside many entries stood only, "Not taken."

Vidyanath examined the pages. "This ledger is not bad. But temple income and your personal priestly income are mixed together."

"It has been like this since Babu's time."

"Then we will make it clear."

Shivanath's voice hardened. "You have a habit of dividing everything."

Vidyanath replied, "And you have a habit of keeping everything together under the name of tradition."

This time no one mediated. Urmila stood on the other side of the doorway, listening.

13

Village politics too waited for an opportunity. Two separate groups approached the brothers and tried to claim their sides. One told Shivanath, "Give the word and we will run a signature campaign. Hereditary right must be protected."

Another told Vidyanath, "Remove the old system. We need an educated priest. We will campaign as if it were an election."

At different times, both brothers gave the same answer: "No."

Shivanath understood that if he gathered crowds in support, the dispute would spread from priesthood into caste, neighbourhood and old panchayat quarrels. Vidyanath understood that some people, in the name of "reform," merely wanted to humiliate Shivanath.

By chance they met at the temple door that night.

Shivanath asked, "Did people come to you too?"

"Yes."

"What did you say?"

“No.”

“Me too.”

For a few moments they looked at each other. The disagreement remained, but at least they had decided not to let a family quarrel become a weapon for the village.

14

Two days later Urmila went to Vidyanath's room. She always called her younger brother-in-law “Chhotka,” but this time she used his name: “Vidyanath.”

He understood that the matter was serious.

“The account you two are demanding from one another will never be complete,” she said.

Vidyanath was silent.

“Barka remembers your fees. You remember taking Ma to hospital, buying Gauri's books, helping build the house—he remembers those things too. But in the ledger of the mind, people give more weight to what they themselves gave.”

Vidyanath smiled faintly. “Bhabi, you too?”

“Me too. I think I served Babu and Ma for years. Then I remember that Ma raised my children while I worked. The account becomes uneven again.”

She rose. At the door she stopped and said, “If priesthood is for repaying debts, which debt comes first? Family's, temple's, scripture's, or village's?”

Vidyanath had no answer.

15

While cleaning Rudranath's old room, Gauri found a notebook wrapped in red cloth. On the cover was written: “Work of the Sthan.”

Shivanath took it first. Inside were dates, repairs, donations, lists of rituals, names of sick villagers, and odd little comments. On one page Rudranath had written: “Shiva understands people's homes. Vidya understands the texts. Each sees the other's deficiency, not his strength.”

Shivanath closed the page.

Gauri asked, “What comes next?”

“Nothing.”

“Show me.”

“This is Babu's private writing.”

Gauri fell silent. That evening Shivanath himself opened the notebook again. On the next page stood: “I will not write the successor's name yet. The moment I write the post, it will become brother versus post. Let the one who serves learn; let the one who has learnt serve.”

Something tightened in Shivanath's chest. The sentence supported him, and Vidyanath as well.

That night he took the notebook to his brother. He said nothing, only opened it to the page and placed it before him.

Vidyanath read for a long time. Then he asked, "Was Babu afraid of us?" For the first time Shivanath smiled lightly. "Babu knew us very well."

16

The village's annual Shivaratri approached. The committee was still postponing its decision. Shivanath wanted the matter settled before the festival; Vidyanath said the festival should be kept separate from the quarrel.

The day before Shivaratri the weather turned. Rain began in the evening; strong wind came at night. One corner of the temple's tin awning lifted. The electricity failed. The path from the pond turned to mud.

Shivanath climbed up to tie down the awning. His foot slipped and he twisted his knee. No bone broke, but walking became difficult.

Urmila said, "Now you will rest."

Shivanath's first question was, "Tomorrow's worship?"

Vidyanath was there. "I will do it."

Shivanath's face hardened again. "Alone?"

"No. You will sit there. Whatever you tell me, I will do."

"You will take instructions from me?"

Vidyanath smiled. "The village arrangement, the order of people, whose sankalpa comes first—you know all that. I will handle the ritual method."

Shivanath said nothing.

At dawn the temple held almost as much light from mobile torches as from oil lamps. Gauri managed flowers, lists and vessels of water; Urmila the prasada; Vidyanath the mantras; Shivanath sat on a low seat, recalling people's names, vows, sequence and old sankalpas.

No one announced that this was "joint priesthood." The work made its own form.

17

By afternoon the crowd had thinned. Malati Devi sat beside Shivanath and asked, "Does the knee hurt?"

"Yes."

"The mind?"

Shivanath looked at her. The old woman laughed.

He said, "Chhotka does the work well."

"I knew that already."

"But if people begin to respect him more?"

Resting both hands on her stick, Malati Devi said, "Is respect a thing that rises and falls from one plate? You sat through my husband's shraddha without taking dakshina; Chhotka cannot erase that. Chhotka knows the scriptures; you cannot erase that. Why are you both trying to cut each other's lines?"

Shivanath smiled. "You have learnt the language of the Panji."

"After hearing so many lineage stories in this village, one learns."

At a distance Vidyanath was explaining the meaning of a mantra to a young man. For the first time Shivanath tried to see him not as a rival but as his younger brother. The attempt did not entirely succeed, but it began.

18

After the festival the committee met again. This time Shivanath himself proposed, "Instead of writing one name as chief priest, write a division of service."

The president looked surprised. "Meaning?"

Shivanath read from a paper: daily worship and local family service under Shivanath's responsibility; complex scriptural rites, training and almanac consultation to be handled by Vidyanath; temple income and expenses through a separate bank account; private dakshina separate; public accounts twice a year; future succession not by birth order alone but by service, training and community consent.

Vidyanath interrupted, "One more thing."

Everyone looked at him.

"If Gauri wishes to learn, her name should be included in the training."

The room went still.

Several expressions passed across Shivanath's face. No one in the family had ever raised the matter formally. The president hesitated. "Tradition..."

Vidyanath said, "We are discussing tradition, so let us ask: who has the right to learn the work? Do not decide the successor now. Why keep the door to training closed?"

Every eye turned to Shivanath.

After a long pause he said, "Ask Gauri what she wants. Do not turn her into the solution to our quarrel."

It was neither acceptance nor refusal. But Gauri, who had been listening outside the door, came in and said, "I want to learn."

The language of the meeting changed again.

19

Vidyanath was preparing to return to the city. He was not in a position to settle permanently in the village. He had a job, a family and students. The committee asked, "Then your claim to be chief priest?"

Vidyanath said, "I am dropping the word 'claim.' I will carry the responsibilities we have written."

Shivanath could not resist the old impulse toward sarcasm. "You will remain available?"

Vidyanath laughed. "Yes, Dada. This time the word is accurate."

Both laughed. The quarrel had not vanished. The old division of land, their mother's jewellery, the money order for fees, the money for the roof—those memories remained in their places. Brotherhood was not so cheap that one meeting could wipe it clean.

Before Vidyanath left, Shivanath gave him a copy of their father's notebook.

"The original stays here," Shivanath said.

"Fine."

"And one thing—the mango grove for your fees..."

Vidyanath stopped him. "Dada, if we reopen that account, the two of us will never close it."

Shivanath was quiet for a moment. "All right. But remember it."

"I remember."

This time they were saying the same thing.

20

A few months later the arrangement was not perfectly smooth. Sometimes Vidyanath arrived late. Sometimes Shivanath forgot to fill a bank slip. The treasurer called, Urmila grew irritated, Gauri made notes. Tradition did not become a machine simply because it had been written on paper.

One day Gauri stopped Shivanath over his pronunciation.

"Babu, this vowel is like this."

Shivanath flared at once. "I have been doing this for so many years—"

He stopped. Rudranath's line came back to him: "Let the one who serves learn."

"Say it again," he told her.

Gauri repeated it. Shivanath repeated it too.

The following week Vidyanath came. Shivanath explained a local custom of an old family vow that was not found in any book. Vidyanath wrote it down.

"Where is this in the scripture?" he asked jokingly.

"In people's lives," Shivanath said.

"Source?"

"Me."

They laughed again.

21

On Rudranath's death anniversary, the brothers sat beneath the peepal behind the temple after most people had gone. The oil in the lamps was running low.

Vidyanath asked, "Dada, if the committee had simply written your name that first day, would it have been better?"

Shivanath could easily have said yes. A few months earlier he would have.

He looked toward the temple. Inside, Gauri was putting away the ledgers. Neelabh had come home for the holiday but showed more interest in fixing electric wires than in worship. Urmila was counting empty prasad containers. In Vidyanath's bag lay his ticket back to the city.

Shivanath said, "Then the quarrel would not have come outside. It would have remained inside."

Vidyanath nodded.

“And if they had written your name?”

“Then it would have remained inside you.”

They were silent for a while.

At last Shivanath said, “Was Babu’s failure to name a successor a mistake, or wisdom?”

Looking toward the lamps, Vidyanath said, “It could have been both.”

By the standards of his scriptural training, the answer was unsatisfactory. For brotherhood, it was enough.

22

At night Shivanath rose to close the temple. First he checked the lamp in the sanctum. The rule was that the main flame should never be put out completely; a small flame was to remain through the night in a protected vessel.

Gauri asked, “Babu, who will put out this lamp?”

“This one will not be put out. Check the oil.”

Gauri added oil.

Outside, Vidyanath was putting on his shoes. Shivanath called, “Chhotka.”

“Yes?”

“Come on time for next month’s new moon.”

“I’ll come on time.”

“Not like last time.”

“You have started again.”

Shivanath laughed.

The temple door closed, but the small light remained inside. No entry was made about whose lineage that light belonged to. Its only work was to keep burning—as long as there was oil, care, learning, and people who could take turns tending it.

On the page of the priesthood, duties now stood where once there had been the expectation of a single name. The family’s debts had not been repaid. The old wounds between the brothers had not disappeared. Yet the watchman’s duty had begun to move a little beyond one person’s right and toward a shared responsibility.

Shivanath looked through the crack in the door one last time. The flame was not still; when the air touched it, it trembled slightly. Yet it did not go out.

— *End of Story 22* —

23. The Ragini Lineage

STORY

I

The safest object in Madhaveswar Jha's house was not any deed to land but an old tin trunk. Inside it, less paper than voice had been shut away: reel-to-reel tape, cassettes, two CDs, faded photographs, invitations to performances, and unfinished lyrics of raginis written in his own hand.

In old age his voice had thinned, yet just as old ink never disappears entirely from paper, an ancient steadiness remained inside his clouded throat. In the evenings he would sit on the veranda and sing the same line three times: the first for the words, the second for the note, the third for the silence.

Two people were often seen together on that veranda—Kiran and Aditya. The village called both of them Madhaveswar's disciples. But the moment the word "successor" was spoken, the atmosphere changed.

Kiran had been learning from him for twenty years. Madhaveswar's taan cast a shadow in her voice, but it was not an imitation. What she heard on paths through the fields, in wedding courtyards, in Sama-Chakeva songs, in the rhythm of Jhijhiya, amid sohars, she carried back to her guru. Madhaveswar used to say, "You learn less from me than you remind me of what I have forgotten."

Aditya had returned after studying at a city music college. He could read notation, operate equipment for cleaning recordings, understand contracts, and time a performance. He had begun rescuing Madhaveswar's old reels from mould, digitising cassettes, and attaching dates to recordings. The guru told him, "You are saving my voice from old age."

Both remarks were praise. Both were incomplete. The trouble began when a city music company sent a letter proposing "a long-term archival recording agreement with the authorised successor to Madhaveswar Jha's folk-ragini tradition."

2

Aditya read the letter first. At the bottom were three spaces for signatures: Guru, Successor, Witness.

He showed the paper to Kiran.

Kiran laughed. "Has the successor already been chosen, or will the company choose one?"

“Not the company,” Aditya said. “Guruji will decide.”

“Has Guruji decided?”

“No.”

“Then why have you brought this paper?”

“Because the old reels are deteriorating. The company will pay for preservation. It will provide a studio. Publication.”

Kiran read one clause aloud: “Rights to commercial use of name, likeness, voice, style, and related performances...”

She folded the paper. “Will the voice be saved, or will it become the company’s property?”

Aditya did not answer at once. “We will read the contract properly and then talk. The wording can be changed.”

“Can the words of the voice be changed?”

“The words on the paper.”

“The words on the paper are what later become rights over the voice.”

Aditya disliked the remark precisely because it was not groundless.

3

Madhaveshwar listened to the letter. His spectacles had slipped low on his nose. He could no longer read the whole contract comfortably, so Aditya read it aloud slowly. Kiran did not interrupt.

At the end Madhaveshwar asked, “What does ‘authorised successor’ mean?”

Aditya said, “In the company’s terms, one principal representative. The person who decides about recordings, performances, and publications.”

Madhaveshwar laughed. “I am still alive, and already there must be a representative?”

“For administrative purposes,” Aditya said.

Kiran remained silent.

Madhaveshwar looked at her. “What do you think?”

“I am thinking about all the people who live inside your songs. Who represents them?”

Madhaveshwar stopped laughing.

He opened the trunk and took out an old sheet of paper bearing the signature of his guru, Jagdish Mishra. It said: “Fourteen raginis and twenty-seven tunes taught to the disciple Madhaveshwar.”

Aditya brightened. “That is almost a certificate.”

“It is,” Madhaveshwar said. “But of Jagdish Guru’s fourteen raginis, five tunes were not his. He had learnt one from a boatman. Two were sung by his mother. He himself did not know the origin of three.”

Kiran said softly, “Then the certificate tells only half the truth.”

“Most certificates tell half-truths,” Madhaveshwar said. “But a half-truth is not useless. At least it tells us that on some day, someone sat before someone else and learnt.”

4

It did not take two days for the village to hear. At the tea stall people began asking, "To whom will Madhaveswar Babu give his gaddi?"

The word gaddi troubled Kiran most. There was no throne in Madhaveswar's house—only a bamboo stool on the veranda, a harmonium, two pairs of manjiras, and one tin trunk. But the moment succession was discussed, people turned singing into a kingdom.

Someone said, "Aditya is educated. He understands the outside world."

Someone else said, "Guruji lives in Kiran's throat."

Someone whispered, "Kiran is not of the household. Aditya is his nephew as well."

The last sentence reached Kiran. She was not surprised. For twenty years she had come and gone from this house; she had brought medicines in illness, sung beside him in performances, found new songs and carried them to him. Yet the boundary of being "of the house" could still be drawn along blood.

When Aditya heard this, he became angry. "I am his nephew, yes, but I am also his disciple. Why should people see me only through blood?"

Kiran said, "The way they see me only through my voice."

For the first time each heard the other's difficulty clearly.

5

Madhaveswar kept postponing a decision. "Let the spring programme happen first," he would say.

The spring programme was small, held in the village, but this time a representative from the city company attended. His name was Ravi Seth. Crisp kurta, polished shoes, tablet in hand. He touched Guruji's feet and immediately asked, "What shall we call the brand?"

Madhaveswar did not understand. "What?"

"The name of the tradition. 'Madhaveswar Gharana'? 'Mithila Ragini Tradition'? The market needs an identity."

Kiran looked at Aditya. Shame showed on his face. "No name has been fixed yet."

Ravi Seth said, "Without a name the collection will not sell. It needs one face too. Two faces weaken publicity."

Madhaveswar asked very quietly, "If a song has two voices, does that weaken it?"

Ravi Seth laughed, thinking the guru was joking. "Two voices can be beautiful. But publicity needs one direction."

"Then publicity is something different from song," Madhaveswar said.

"In practical terms..."

"Yes," Madhaveswar stopped him. "In practical terms, many things are different from art."

6

Kiran gave the first performance. She took up an old Barahmasa tune. The first stanza was exactly as Madhaveswar had taught it. In the second she altered one small taan. Madhaveswar raised his head. In the third the taan returned, longer this time.

After the programme Madhaveswar asked, "Where did that taan come from?"

"Malti Kaki of Sonbarsa used to sing it. I heard it in her song."

"I did not teach it to you."

"No."

"You added it?"

For a moment Kiran was afraid. "Yes."

Madhaveswar closed his eyes and hummed the taan. "You added it well. But next time say where it came from. Let whoever listens not think everything is mine."

Kiran breathed in relief.

Aditya performed later. Using written notation, he had reconstructed one of Guruji's rare raginis. Two lines on an old reel were unclear, and Aditya had compared three different recordings to form the most plausible tune.

After he sang, Madhaveswar asked, "The middle line?"

"A reconstruction from three recordings."

"Certain?"

"No. The most probable."

Madhaveswar laughed. "You have brought jurisprudence into singing."

Aditya laughed too.

The guru said, "Then say when you sing it that it is a reconstruction. Do not turn conjecture into memory."

That night both disciples received the same lesson: adding was not the offence; hiding the source of what had been added came close to one.

7

Ravi Seth had recorded the programme. The next day he showed Aditya a short video. The segment containing Kiran's taan had been clipped, an old photograph of Guruji inserted, and beneath it appeared the caption: "The authentic sound of the Madhaveswar tradition."

Aditya stopped the video. "Remove the word 'authentic'."

"Why? It will perform well."

"Say it will perform well. The fact is not correct."

"What is incorrect? The voice belongs to his disciple."

"That taan came from another singer."

Ravi Seth shrugged. "People do not want so much detail."

"Then we should give people something inaccurate?"

"The market wants a simple story."

For the first time Aditya saw how thin the line could be between preservation and simplification. He took the contract home and crossed out

several clauses in red ink. “Exclusive”, “sole”, “authentic”, “full rights”—all four were marked.

Kiran looked at the paper. “If you cut so much, will the company agree?”

“If it does not, then it does not.”

“And the reels?”

“We will do them ourselves. It will be slower.”

For the first time Kiran saw the difficulty of his labour. Saving sound was not merely pressing a button; time, money, equipment, catalogues, backups, dates—these too were labour performed on behalf of a tradition.

8

Madhaveswar’s health worsened after the rains that year. His breath grew short. The doctor ordered rest. He could sing less and listen more.

One evening he called both Kiran and Aditya. The tin trunk stood between them.

“There is something I must do,” he said.

Aditya opened a notebook.

“No notes,” Madhaveswar said. “Listen first.”

He took out an old reel. The label read: “1978, Mahishi, Ragini—name unknown.”

“My guru gave me this. He told me to preserve it. I have kept it for fifty years. The name is still unknown.”

Kiran asked, “The singer?”

“Unknown too. A woman’s voice. Perhaps shaped from a field song. Jagdish Guru recorded it at a fair.”

Aditya said, “I’ll digitise it.”

“Do. But where the name belongs, write ‘unknown’. Do not fill a name from guesswork.”

Then Madhaveswar looked at Kiran. “Learn the tune. But when you sing it, say: received from an unknown woman singer.”

Kiran’s eyes filled. “Guruji, this is the oldest thing in your collection—”

“That is why, before anything else, preserve not its name but our not-knowing. If you fill every blank, where will the next person ask a question?”

9

The reel was badly damaged. Through the hiss a woman’s voice rose and sank. On first hearing the words could not be caught. Aditya cleaned the sound on the computer. Clean it too much and the voice turned artificial; clean it too little and the words drowned.

He gave Kiran the headphones.

Kiran closed her eyes. “She is saying ‘ijotiya’, not ‘ijoriya’.”

Aditya listened again. “I hear ‘ijoriya’.”

“No, there is a t in the middle.”

They went to the guru. Madhaveswar listened three times. “I cannot say.”

Kiran laughed. "Even Guruji cannot?"

"Becoming a guru does not make one's ears divine."

He dictated a note: "Word unclear: *ijotiya/ijoriya*—undecided."

Aditya said, "Shall we give both readings in publication?"

"Give both. The reader has ears too."

Something changed inside Kiran. Until then she had regarded the guru as someone who caught a mistaken note immediately. Now she understood that one form of authority was also the ability to say, "I do not know."

IO

The discussion of succession had now entered the household. Madhaveswar's younger brother Shashidhar came from the city. He was Aditya's father.

"Bhaiya," he said, "put things clearly on paper. Otherwise there will be quarrels later."

Madhaveswar laughed. "Does paper prevent quarrels?"

"It reduces them."

"Sometimes it increases them too."

Shashidhar looked at Aditya. "The family collection should stay in the family."

Kiran was sitting at the other end of the veranda. The meaning was clear: once again the boundary of "family" had reached blood.

Aditya answered at once, "Babu, the collection belongs to Guruji. He will decide."

Shashidhar grew irritated. "Am I saying anything improper? An outsider —"

Aditya stopped him. "Kiran Didi is not an outsider."

Kiran intervened. "Do not quarrel on my account. The question is the collection."

Madhaveswar remained silent for a long time. Then he said, "The collection will remain in the house, but by house I do not mean these four walls. There will be a catalogue, copies, arrangements for public listening. The originals will not be in one person's sole custody."

Shashidhar was dissatisfied. "Then who is the owner?"

Madhaveswar said, "That is the word that frightens me most."

II

Two weeks later Guruji was teaching Kiran a song. Midway his breath caught. Kiran gave him water. Madhaveswar gestured and said, "Take it from where I stopped."

Kiran began to sing. Four lines later Madhaveswar kept time with the *manjira*.

When the song ended he said, "See? A tradition moves like this. One stops; another takes it up."

Kiran's face tightened. "Then am I the successor?"

Madhaveswar smiled. "You have asked the question too quickly."

"Everyone is asking it."

"People want an answer. An artist needs work."

"But when you are no longer here?"

"Then all of you will need my name less and your own ears more."

Kiran's eyes grew wet, but she did not cry. "And Aditya?"

"He will take up the tape that has stopped."

"And I the song that has stopped?"

"Perhaps. But remember—the song too will change when it comes into your hands. Do not imprison it in my name."

12

Madhaveswar had a written declaration prepared. Aditya typed it, Kiran read it, and the guru kept correcting. After five lines he tore up the paper.

"Too legal."

A second draft was made. He tore that up too.

In the third draft he dictated:

"There is no single successor to my singing. Kiran is the principal disciple of my living performance tradition. Aditya is the principal custodian-disciple of my recordings, notation, and documents. Neither has authority over the other's work; each has a responsibility—to name sources, mark changes, write the unknown as unknown, and allow new disciples to learn."

Aditya asked, "Why 'principal'?"

"Because after you, others will learn. If I write 'sole', I close the future."

Kiran asked, "And the guru-lineage?"

Madhaveswar said, "Keep the word lineage, but draw arrows—one name leading many ways."

Aditya laughed. "A family tree?"

"A tree has one place for its roots. A song has roots in many places. Make a web."

13

When the declaration became public, the village was disappointed. People wanted a clear winner.

At the tea stall someone said, "Guruji could not decide."

Another said, "He divided it in two."

A third said, "Aditya is the real one; the papers are with him."

A fourth: "Kiran is the real one; she has the voice."

Kiran laughed when she heard. "Will they stuff paper into my throat?"

Aditya said, "Will my hard drive sing?"

For the first time in many days they laughed openly.

But rivalry inside them did not vanish. An invitation to perform described "Kiran Devi, successor to the Madhaveswar tradition"; Aditya's name appeared in small type under "archival assistance". It hurt him.

On another occasion a university invited Aditya to lecture as “custodian of the Madhaveswar singing tradition.” Kiran was not mentioned. This time she was hurt.

Both understood: the guru’s declaration could preserve a complicated truth; society would still reduce it to a simple title.

14

Madhaveswar’s last public performance took place on an autumn evening. He could not sing a whole song. On stage Kiran sat to his right, Aditya to his left.

Guruji took the first line. Kiran the second. Aditya the third. In the fourth, all three voices met, though they did not become one. Guruji’s trembled, Kiran’s was open, Aditya’s measured.

At one point in the song Madhaveswar stopped. The audience assumed he was breathless. Kiran prepared to take over, but the guru raised a hand and stopped her.

The silence lasted almost five beats. Then, from far back in the audience, an elderly woman—Malti Kaki—sang the responding line.

Kiran recognised her. She was the very woman whose taan she had brought into her singing in spring.

Madhaveswar smiled and said from the stage, “See? The lineage was sitting outside.”

The audience laughed, then applauded.

Ravi Seth, back again for the programme, was recording the moment on his phone. Later he told Aditya, “This clip will travel.”

Aditya said, “Let it travel. But write Malti Kaki’s name.”

After the programme a young researcher approached Guruji with a printed questionnaire. The first question read: “From where do you consider the genealogy of your singing to begin?”

Madhaveswar was tired, yet he took the sheet. “How much space is there for the answer?”

“Four lines.”

“Then the answer will not fit.”

The young man laughed awkwardly. “Just write the principal names.”

Madhaveswar wrote Jagdish Guru’s name. Then he turned the sheet over and, on the blank back, added his mother’s name, the boatman Ramkhelawan, “Mahishi—unknown woman singer”, Malti Devi, and question marks in two or three places.

The researcher asked, “Are all of these to be considered gurus?”

“You decide what the word guru means,” Madhaveswar said. “I cannot strike out the names of those to whom my ear is indebted.”

Kiran stood behind him listening. Aditya too. The researcher asked, “Then what is the pure form of the tradition?”

After drinking some water Madhaveswar said, “It is like searching for a pure drop of a river. Water comes from above, streams join midway, ghats

change. Remove filth, identify sources, but do not turn the river into a glass bottle.”

Later Aditya said, “Guruji, that answer was not recorded.”

Madhaveshwar laughed. “If everything is recorded, what will people remember?”

Kiran said at once, “I will remember.”

“You will remember it in your way,” the guru said. “Aditya will write it in his way. The researcher may cut it to four lines. What survives from all three will not be my complete sentence. But accepting incompleteness is better than adding lies for the sake of completeness.”

That night Madhaveshwar was very tired on the way home. Kiran held his hand as he came down the steps. Aditya carried the tin trunk and harmonium. As he sat in the vehicle, the guru looked at both of them.

“You tend the voice,” he said to Kiran.

“You tend the evidence,” he said to Aditya.

After a pause he added, “And guard yourselves from each other too. Voice without evidence may turn into myth; evidence without voice is a corpse.”

Kiran asked, “And the guru?”

Madhaveshwar closed his eyes. “The guru is a link in the middle. Make the link a god, and it becomes a chain.”

15

A few months later Madhaveshwar died. He died at night. There was no dramatic final sentence. In the evening he took his medicine, listened to a recording Kiran had sent, told Aditya to send him a list of damaged reels, went to sleep, and did not wake in the morning.

After the cremation the house filled with people. Tributes, photographs, garlands, speeches. One sentence was repeated everywhere: “The end of an era.”

Kiran disliked it. Why should an “era” end so quickly? The tune she had been singing yesterday still lived in her throat today. Aditya worked late backing up Guruji’s sound files. What exactly had ended?

After the thirteenth-day rites, the tin trunk was opened. Shashidhar, Kiran, Aditya, two local singers, the school headmaster, and a representative of the panchayat library sat together. Guruji’s declaration was read again.

One envelope lay apart. On it was written: “Ragini Lineage.”

Everyone looked up.

Aditya opened it. Inside was one sheet—not a family tree but a web of circles and arrows. Madhaveshwar’s own name was not at the centre. At the centre was written: “Song.” Around it were names—Jagdish Guru, unknown woman singer, Madhaveshwar’s mother, the boatman Ramkhelawan, Malti, Kiran, Aditya, and others. Question marks stood beside some names. Some arrows met one another. Some pointed outward into blank space.

At the bottom was a line: “Where an arrow goes outward, let the next person add not his own name, but his source.”

A trust was formed to care for the collection. Kiran laughed again at the word. "Guruji feared the word owner, and now we have a trust."

Aditya said, "Work is not spoiled by a name. It is spoiled by the way the work is done."

Rules were written: original reels in a secure place; digital copies in three locations; one public listening day a month; a catalogue for researchers; collective permission for commercial use; material of unknown origin clearly marked "unknown"; alterations in new performances identified.

The rules were beautiful. Practice became difficult at once.

For a wedding Kiran added two new stanzas to a tune learnt from Guruji. Aditya asked, "Does the programme note say they are new stanzas?"

Kiran became irritated. "Will people at a wedding read programme notes?"

"The video will circulate later."

"Will you turn every song into a file?"

"Will you call every change 'folk' and drop the source?"

They quarrelled. Sharply. Guruji was no longer there to stop them with one sentence.

They did not speak for three days.

On the fourth, Kiran went to Aditya's house herself. "The new stanzas are mine. Write that."

Aditya asked, "And the tune?"

"It begins from Guruji's form, with Malti Kaki's taan in the middle."

"All right."

Kiran asked, "And in your last publication, why was 'probable' printed in tiny letters beneath the reconstructed line?"

Aditya looked embarrassed. "There was not enough space."

"Next time make more space."

"All right."

The guru was gone. A part of the guru's work now fell to each of them in relation to the other.

Three months after the trust was formed, a folk-music training camp was held at the district headquarters. The organisers invited Kiran as "traditional performer" and Aditya as "music-archive specialist." Both titles seemed acceptable, but while certificates were being distributed the old question returned in a new form.

On the final day of the camp, certificates were being distributed to the students. The organiser asked, "Who will sign the certificates for the guru-tradition?"

Kiran looked at Aditya. Aditya looked at Kiran.

"We need one principal guru," the organiser said. "The form has only one space."

Kiran laughed. "Change the form."

"It has already been printed."

Aditya said, "Then write 'instructors' and add both signatures."

"There is not enough space."

Kiran said, "Will you reduce the song, or enlarge the paper?"

In the end a second signature space was made on the back. A small solution. But one trainee later said, "For the first time I understood that the design of paper itself makes tradition. If there is one box, people will search for one guru."

Aditya wrote the sentence in his notebook. Kiran teased him. "Must you write down everything?"

"What I do not write, you will later tell in your own way."

"And what you do write will survive in your way."

They laughed again. The dispute had not ended; it was becoming a practice.

18

Another incident occurred at the camp. Naresh, a young man who had been learning from Kiran for two months, sang Guruji's famous ragini on stage. Before singing he announced, "This is an ancient composition of the Madhaveswar gharana."

Behind the stage Kiran started. Aditya made a note at once.

Afterwards Kiran called Naresh aside. "Who told you it was ancient?"

"It was written on an online video."

"Whose video?"

"The company's."

Aditya searched on his phone. Ravi Seth's old promotional video was still circulating under the title: "Centuries-old Madhaveswar Gharana Ragini."

Madhaveswar himself had received some of the tune from his guru, some from his mother, and had later added parts. There was no basis for "centuries-old."

Aditya phoned Ravi Seth. Seth replied, "That is promotional language. Everyone understands."

"Naresh did not," Aditya said. "He took it as fact."

Ravi Seth laughed. "Fact and promotion are different things."

"On people's phones they appear on the same screen."

The argument went on. At last the title was changed to: "Ragini sung in the Madhaveswar tradition." A small change. But Aditya understood that an archive was not merely about saving old tape; new digital falsehood travelled far faster than old errors on paper.

Kiran called Naresh again. "What you sang was not bad. But next time, if you do not know something, do not make it ancient merely to increase its prestige. Let the unknown remain unknown."

Naresh asked, "Then people on stage will be less impressed?"

Kiran said, "There are many ways to impress people. There is no need to manufacture ancestors."

That year the trust began its first public class. The rule was that anyone who wished to learn would not first be asked about family, caste, profession, or certificates; only whether they were willing to practise regularly.

Seven people came on the first day. Four remained in the second month. After six months, three.

Kiran was saddened by the shrinking number. “People want the song too quickly.”

Aditya said, “The market gives a song in three minutes. Riyaz asks for three years.”

“Again you blame the market?”

“No. I am only stating the arithmetic of time.”

The three students were Sakshi, Naresh, and an elderly tailor named Munna Mian. Munna Mian said he had heard Madhaveshwar’s mother sing when he was a child. His voice was untrained, but he remembered the rhythm of two old lines.

One day he sang them. Kiran immediately reached for the harmonium. Aditya rose to record. Munna Mian stopped him with a hand.

“Listen first. The machine later.”

Aditya sat down.

Munna Mian sang three times. The third time the line changed. Aditya asked, “Was the first version right or the third?”

He laughed. “I do not know. I heard it as a child. Memory sings in its own way now.”

Kiran said, “Record all three.”

Aditya asked, “Title?”

“Munna Mian’s Memory—Three Forms.”

That day a new arrow was added to the web of the Ragini Lineage. No certificate, no claim—only the unstable memory of an old man. Had Madhaveshwar been alive, he would probably have treated that instability itself as a source.

A year later a “Madhaveshwar Ragini Festival” was held in the city. The organisers again wanted one principal face. This time Kiran and Aditya decided that Guruji’s photograph would be small on the poster and the web of the Ragini Lineage large.

Ravi Seth looked at it and said, “This design will not sell.”

Aditya said, “Then fewer tickets will sell.”

Kiran added, “Perhaps a little more of the song will survive.”

The first session at the festival was archival. Aditya played the 1978 reel of the unknown woman singer. On the screen it stated clearly: “Singer: unknown. Place: Mahishi (according to label). Words: partly unclear.”

In the second session Kiran sang the form she had learnt from the same tune. Before singing she named the sources. Then a new teenage disciple, Sakshi, came on stage. In the last line she changed one taan.

Kiran's ear caught it immediately. Her first impulse was to say, "Wrong." The word reached her mouth and stopped.

After the programme she asked, "Where did that taan come from?"

Sakshi answered nervously, "My grandmother sings it."

"Her name?"

"Chandrakala Devi."

Kiran smiled. "Next time say her name first. Then sing the taan."

From a distance Aditya watched. He made a note on his phone: "Chandrakala Devi—source verification through Sakshi pending."

Kiran saw it and laughed. "Your illness will never go away."

"Nor yours."

21

At night, after the festival ended, everyone left. Chairs lay overturned in the hall and wires were being coiled. At one corner of the stage a small brass lamp was still burning—brought from Guruji's house, not for display, but at Kiran's insistence.

Aditya asked, "Has the source of this lamp been recorded?"

Kiran glared at him. "Enough."

They laughed.

After a while Kiran became serious. "Aditya, people still ask who the real successor is."

"What do you tell them?"

"I tell them the question is wrong."

"I say there are many answers."

"Those are different things."

"Yes."

"If Guruji were here?"

Aditya looked at the lamp. "Perhaps he would say both are half-truths."

Kiran nodded. "A half-truth is not useless."

At once they both remembered the old veranda: the tin trunk, the torn certificate, the unknown singer, Guruji's laughter.

The lamp flame was not still. The fans in the hall had been switched off, yet night air entering from the doorway made it tremble.

Kiran reached forward and straightened the glass shield. Aditya switched off the light on his phone. The small flame was enough.

No single successor sat on the stage. Voice, paper, memory, revision, names, unknown blanks—all stood beside one another. The Ragini Lineage had not become a straight line of blood; it remained a web of arrows opening outward.

And the empty arrows needed the most room.

24. The Maternal Line

STORY

I

Ishani was not afraid of the key to her grandmother's house. What frightened her was the sentence always handed over with it: "This house goes to the eldest daughter."

As a child, the sentence had sounded like pride. In other houses in the village, when land was discussed, sons' names were counted; in this house, daughters'. Her grandmother, Urmila Devi, would run a hand over a pillar of the veranda and say, "For four generations this courtyard has passed from mother to daughter." Ishani had been ten then, and the story felt like magic.

Now she was twenty-nine. She had studied architecture in Patna and Delhi, worked in the conservation of old buildings, and had come to the village on three days' leave for her grandmother's eightieth birthday. The house was the same—the red-earth courtyard, the tulsi platform to the north, the old wooden chest in the western room, the black film of smoke along the veranda beam. But Ishani had changed.

When the birthday meal ended, Urmila Devi called all the women inside. Mrinal—Ishani's mother—already knew what was about to happen. Aunt Sudha, cousin Riddhi, two distant kakis who felt like aunts, even eight-year-old Anshu crowded in.

From beneath her pillow Urmila Devi took out a heavy brass-coloured key with a red thread tied through its hole. "Who knows how many days this body has left," she said matter-of-factly. "Let us decide the next hand for the house."

Mrinal looked at Ishani. Every eye turned toward her.

Without preparation Ishani said, "I will not take it."

The silence that entered the room was not the silence after death. It was the silence of insult, surprise, fear, and incomprehension. Urmila Devi closed the key inside her fist.

"What did you say?"

"Not the house. Not in this manner."

Mrinal's face went pale. Sudha Mausi said quietly, "At least listen first."

Ishani said, "I have grown up listening."

That night had begun with a birthday. It was going to end with an accounting of the maternal line.

2

In this family the word “matriline” was not very old. The old phrase was “the line of the mother’s house.” In the days of Urmila Devi’s grandmother, Bhuvaneshwari Devi, no one spoke the language of genealogy. People only knew that Bhuvaneshwari’s husband died young, her two sons went east in search of work, and three daughters remained at home.

That year the Kamla rose twice. Half the crop was lost. The rear wall of the house collapsed. Bhuvaneshwari sold her jewellery, raised the wall again, saved seed grain, and exchanged two pregnant cows for a lease on a pond. Her eldest daughter, Surmai, managed field, accounts, and household beside her.

The sons sent letters. Money came now and then. But the daily body of the household rested in Surmai’s hands. Two years before Bhuvaneshwari died, she went to the village scribe and had the house papers made out in Surmai’s name.

People said many things. “Her sons are alive.” “The daughter will marry.” “The land will go to another house.”

Bhuvaneshwari had only one answer: “The one who raised the wall has a right to the wall.”

Generation after generation turned that sentence into a line of pride. But its original cause was less a doctrine of inheritance than justice for labour. Later generations made an exception into a tradition.

Surmai received the house. Then Surmai’s eldest daughter Janki. Then Janki’s eldest daughter Kamla. Then Kamla’s eldest daughter Urmila. Urmila’s eldest daughter Mrinal. And now Mrinal’s eldest daughter, Ishani.

A straight line. A beautiful line.

Straight lines are always beautiful—until one notices the heads bent inside them.

3

The next morning Ishani woke late. Her grandmother was already sitting in the courtyard with an old sujani stitched in red, green, and black thread into little square houses. Some squares held people; some were empty.

“Do you recognise this?” Grandmother asked.

“Surmai Nani’s?”

“Yes. Half of it. Janki added the other half.”

Ishani spread the sujani out. It did not look like a museum object, but like cloth worn through daily use. The edge was torn in several places. One corner had been patched with newer cloth.

“I’ll take this,” Ishani said.

Urmila Devi was startled. “Not the house, but the sujani?”

“If you give it to me.”

“The sujani goes with the house.”

“Then I will not take it.”

Grandmother’s eyes hardened. “Will you pick and choose from tradition?”

Ishani paused. “Yes. Why not?”

Urmila Devi folded the sujani. “Tradition is not cloth in a shop.”

“And tradition is not a shackle either.”

Their first clear collision occurred there. Mrinal had been listening from the veranda but did not enter. There was hurt on her face—and something else, as though her daughter had spoken aloud, without permission, a thought buried inside her own life.

4

At noon Mrinal called Ishani to the roof. The sun was sharp; they sat in the shade of the water tank.

“Do you think we are trying to bind you?” Mrinal asked.

“You?”

“All of us.”

Ishani did not answer at once. “I think everyone likes this rule because it favours daughters. But a rule is still a rule.”

“Receiving a house has become bondage?”

“Not receiving the house. Receiving a life already decided along with the house.”

Mrinal was silent.

Ishani said, “Nani says if I take the house, I must come four times a year, look after ritual songs, keep account of the chest, be the first doorway in deaths and weddings, keep track of the old people who are left alone. This is not the key to a house. It is an entire office.”

Mrinal said softly, “Is an office necessarily bad?”

“Not bad. But did I choose it?”

For the first time Mrinal looked directly at her daughter. “Did I choose it?”

Something stopped inside Ishani.

Mrinal tried to smile. “Your grandmother’s argument was that I would receive the house, so I was fortunate. I believed that too. I never thought about how much work came attached to being fortunate.”

“Did you ever want to leave it?”

“No.”

Ishani exhaled.

Mrinal added, “But that is not the whole truth either.”

5

When Mrinal was in college she had wanted to stay in Darbhanga and pursue postgraduate study. At that time Kamla—her grandmother—fell ill, and pain began in Urmila Devi’s knees. The family farm was small, but the flow of people through the house was constant. Mrinal’s younger sister Sudha was preparing for marriage.

"I had filled out the form," Mrinal said. "I had even written the hostel address. Then Nani said: if the eldest daughter leaves the house, who will tend this line?"

"Did you tear up the form?"

"No. I put it in the chest."

"Is it still there?"

"Perhaps."

Ishani did not laugh. "You never told me."

"What would telling have changed?"

"I would have understood."

"I did not understand it myself. It did not seem like sacrifice to me. It was family work. Later, after I moved to Patna with your father, I resumed my studies. Late, but I did."

Mrinal taught history at a school. Ishani knew that. She had not known that her mother's first attempt at study had been interrupted by the family tradition.

"Then do you want me to take the key?"

After a long silence Mrinal said, "I want you not to abandon the house. But perhaps—" She stopped and corrected herself. "Perhaps I also want you to have the right to abandon it."

6

That evening Sudha Mausi told her own story. She had not been the eldest, so the house was never meant to be hers. As a child she had been jealous of that.

"Your mother got the key, I got bangles," she said, laughing. "I thought she would inherit history and I would inherit only marriage."

After marriage Sudha moved to Muzaffarpur, worked in a bank, raised two children, and cared for her husband through five years of illness. Distance from the house gave her freedom as well as guilt.

"If Ma fell ill, the first phone call went to Didi," she said. "If anyone in the village needed something, Didi. If the roof over the old room leaked, Didi. I sent money, but the actual name of responsibility was Mrinal."

Ishani asked, "Did you want the house?"

"I wanted it then. Now I understand I wanted the honour of the house, not its whole weight."

"Then was the tradition unjust?"

Sudha shook her head. "It is not that simple. This family put a daughter's name on paper at a time when many households did not. That was no small thing. But to give the right and load the work only on that daughter—that is another matter."

Mrinal listened from a distance. Mother, aunt, daughter—three women like three sisters—were looking at the tradition for the first time not as a tale of glory, but as a distribution of labour.

7

For three days Urmila Devi did not discuss the matter with Ishani. On the fourth morning she called her into the western room.

"Open the chest."

The brass key turned in the lock. Inside were sujanis, old dhotis, letters, papers, a brass lamp, two songbooks, and a thin wooden roller shaped almost like a flute, wrapped in cloth.

"Do all these go with the house?" Ishani asked.

"Not all."

Grandmother took things out one by one and told their stories. The first pages of the songbook were not in Surmai's hand; she wrote poorly. Janki had listened and written. The middle pages were Kamla's. Corrections ran along the margins in Urmila's hand. Mrinal had added two new songs.

"Then this is not one person's book," Ishani said.

"When did I say it was?"

"But the key goes to one person."

Urmila Devi glared. "Again the same thing."

Ishani fell silent.

Grandmother lifted the brass lamp. "This is said to have belonged to Bhuvaneshwari."

"Proof?"

An unwilling smile appeared on Grandmother's face. "Have those archive people taught you to question every story?"

"I only asked."

"There is no proof. My mother told me."

"Then 'it is said' is accurate."

"You will not take the key, but you will correct the language?"

For the first time they both laughed again.

8

At the bottom of the chest lay a thin notebook. On the cover was written: "The House's Mother-Line." Ishani was surprised. It held no family tree, but brief notes.

"Bhuvaneshwari—raised the wall. Surmai—saved seed. Janki—had songs written down. Kamla—recovered the pond. Urmila—replaced the roof."

No husband's or father's name beside the women. Names beside deeds.

Ishani's eyes lit up. "I like this."

Grandmother said, "Do you think all we did was carry keys?"

"No."

"Because of this house, women's names survived. Otherwise in many genealogies a daughter disappears after marriage."

Ishani turned the pages. In one place it said: "Kamla—did not attend teacher training; mother ill."

She stopped. "Who wrote this?"

"I did."

"Why?"

"If the account records what was done but not what was lost along the way, it is only half an account."

On the next page: "Urmila—wanted to study nursing; application not sent."

Ishani looked at her grandmother.

Urmila Devi looked away.

9

Urmila Devi had been seventeen when a notice appeared for assistant-nurse training at the district hospital. She was good at science. The schoolmaster had brought the form. Kamla Devi was then managing both field and household, but her mother Janki had become bedridden.

"I did not fill in the form," Urmila Devi said.

"Did anyone stop you?"

"Not directly."

"Then?"

"Everyone said: if the eldest daughter lives away, who will look after Nani? No one issued an order. There was no need for one."

Ishani asked softly, "Were you unhappy?"

"At the time? A little. Then I married, and your Nana came to live here—I did not leave the house. Children were born. The field survived. The songs survived. Many good things happened. A life is not the name of one missed chance."

"But the form?"

"Sometimes I used to dream of white clothes and the smell of a hospital. Then at dawn I would rise and milk the cow. Which of the two lives was the 'real' one?"

Ishani did not answer.

For the first time Urmila Devi stopped seeing her granddaughter's rebellion only as ingratitude. "If you take the key, will you leave Delhi?"

"No."

"Then the house?"

"We will divide the work."

"Among whom?"

"Among everyone who calls it their own."

Grandmother laughed. "Easy to say."

"That is why we will write it down."

"Paper again?"

"This time the paper will divide the work."

10

Ishani worked in the conservation of historic buildings. On the fifth day she took out a measuring tape and began drawing the house—rooms, courtyard, beams, drains, wall thickness, patches of damp.

Anshu followed her everywhere. "Didi, will the house fall?"

“No. But if everyone only tells stories and nobody repairs the roof, it will.”

Mrinal laughed. Urmila Devi did not. The sight of the measuring tape made her feel as though the house had become a patient in a hospital.

Ishani prepared a report: damp in the north wall; western beam requiring replacement; rainwater outlet blocked; soot on the surface of old paintings. She added an estimated cost.

The report went to the family group chat. Sons, daughters, grandsons, granddaughters—scattered across cities—responded. Someone wrote “too expensive”, someone “look for a government grant”, someone sent only folded-hands emojis.

Ishani sent a separate message: “If the house belongs to the maternal line, why should the eldest daughter alone bear the cost?”

At first there was silence. Then Uncle Alok wrote: “I’ll pay my share.”

Sudha Mausi: “Me too.”

Younger uncle Vineet: “Not ‘share’. Let us divide whatever is needed.”

Urmila Devi could not read the messages. Mrinal read them aloud. Grandmother only said, “Money is easy. What about time?”

Ishani wrote back: “There will be a schedule for time too.”

II

The family’s first “house meeting” was held on Sunday. Ishani gave it that name; Grandmother said, “We have always had meetings.”

“This time with an account.”

Ten people sat on the veranda; others joined by phone. Ishani wrote four headings: repairs; care of elders; preservation of songs and objects; annual gathering.

Alok Mama said, “I can come for two days once every six months.”

Sudha said, “If hospital work is needed, I can manage from Patna.”

Vineet: “One-third of repair expenses.”

Riddhi: “I will record the songs.”

Mrinal: “For now the principal key will remain with me.”

Everyone looked at Ishani.

“I will make a conservation plan, inspect at least twice a year, and prepare a digital catalogue of the songbooks and objects. But I will not be the permanent keeper.”

Urmila Devi asked, “And if the house catches fire?”

Ishani answered, “Then whoever is closest will run. A lineage cannot take a flight from Delhi to put out a fire.”

Alok laughed. Grandmother did not, but the corner of her eyes softened.

12

After the meeting, the real quarrel was raised by Riddhi. She was Sudha Mausi’s daughter, five years younger than Ishani, and after marriage lived in

a town near the village. Interested in folk craft, she ran a small group teaching sujani embroidery.

"If Ishani is not taking the house," Riddhi said, "I can hold a workshop here two days a week."

Urmila Devi replied at once, "The house is in Ishani's line."

Riddhi smiled, but her voice was firm. "Then this matriline too becomes a kingdom of eldest daughter to eldest daughter. Am I not a daughter?"

The room became silent again.

Ishani felt relief and shame at once. Even in her rebellion she had kept herself at the centre.

Sudha Mausi said softly, "My line has always been second."

Urmila Devi's face tightened. "The rule has existed since your grandmother's time."

Sudha replied, "Bhuvaneshwari did not make that rule. She gave the house to Surmai because Surmai had cared for it. Later, we turned that into birth order."

That sentence struck hardest. For the first time the origin story of the tradition testified against its present rule.

13

Urmila Devi ate little that night. Everyone understood that she had been hurt. Ishani went to her room on the pretext of bringing water.

Grandmother was awake.

"Was Riddhi right?" Ishani asked.

"A house does not run according to arithmetic of right and wrong."

"Then how?"

"By habit."

"Habits change."

"They do. But those who change them often understand later how difficult it was to save what was saved."

Ishani sat by the bed. "Are you afraid the house will fragment?"

"Not the house. The story."

"Why must the story live in one key?"

"When one person is responsible, work is forgotten less."

"And one person becomes tired more."

Grandmother was silent.

After a while she asked, "Was your mother very tired?"

Ishani's throat tightened. "Sometimes."

"She never said."

"You never spoke of the nursing form either."

Urmila Devi closed her eyes. "It seems silence too has descended through our mother-daughter tradition."

"Let us leave that part of the tradition behind."

Grandmother opened her eyes. "That part can be left."

The next day the songs were recorded. Riddhi had brought not a phone but a separate microphone. Urmila Devi laughed at first. "The song will be frightened by so much equipment."

The first song was said to be Surmai's, though the words in the songbook were in Janki's hand. While singing, Urmila Devi changed two lines. Riddhi did not stop her. When the song ended she asked, "Nani, the book has different words."

"My mother used to sing it this way."

"Then what shall I write in the recording?"

Ishani almost said, "Variant." But she stopped.

Urmila Devi herself said, "Write: version heard from Urmila. Janki's version in the book is different."

Riddhi smiled.

Mrinal sang the second song. Sudha the third. In the fourth, everyone forgot the words halfway. Anshu began searching on the phone, but Grandmother stopped him. "Search memory first."

Everyone laughed. Three different lines emerged. All three were kept in the recording.

Ishani wrote: "One song, many memories."

Urmila Devi read it and said, "Is that not like the maternal line?"

"Yes. If we do not call one form the only authentic one."

Grandmother said, "You add conditions to everything."

"Not conditions. Space."

Riddhi's workshop met on the veranda for the first time. Five women, two girls, one boy. Seeing the boy, an elderly neighbour asked, "A boy will learn sujani?"

Riddhi replied easily, "He has hands, so he will learn."

Urmila Devi heard. She said nothing.

Anshu could not tie the thread on the first day. On the second he stitched a small fish. Grandmother looked at it and said, "The tail is very fat."

Anshu replied, "It is my fish."

Grandmother laughed. "Then let it stay fat."

Ishani watched from a distance. A skill of the maternal line had crossed toward a grandson for the first time, and the sky did not fall.

Later Riddhi said, "I did not ask for the house. I asked for space."

Ishani asked, "If Nani said you should take the house?"

Riddhi thought. "Not alone. My work can continue here, but I will not abandon my own house either."

"Then the key?"

"Keys can be copied."

Ishani laughed. As an architect, why had this not occurred to her sooner? One lock, many keys. Why had tradition kept searching for one hand?

That evening Alok Mama sat with Ishani. For a long time he watched the children's stitching in the workshop. Then he said, "There is something I must admit."

Ishani asked, "What?"

"Since childhood I have heard: the house belongs to Didi. At first I thought it was unfair. Later I understood that the sentence also gave me leave. Roof leaks—Didi will see to it. Nani sick—Didi will run. Guests—Didi. I went away to study, changed cities for work; no one said, 'Why are you leaving your mother's house?'"

Ishani listened silently. The matrilineal rule gave women property, but could also become an excuse for freeing men from responsibility—this side had not yet fully entered the argument.

Alok added, "I am not here to ask for a share of the house. But I want a share of the work. Otherwise we men keep taking the benefit of the old rule while giving women all the glory for it. That is not fair."

Ishani asked, "Then what will you take on?"

"Before the rains, the roof. Twice a year, inspection by a mason. And one whole month of fetching Nani's medicines is my responsibility. Write it down."

Ishani laughed. "The first male inheritance in the maternal line?"

Alok laughed too. "Not inheritance. Arrears."

Ishani kept the word in mind. Lineage was not only an account of what one received; it also carried arrears of work that had been pushed to one side generation after generation.

16

The paper question was difficult. Legally the house stood in Urmila Devi's name. There was an old family understanding that after her it would pass to Mrinal, but no written will had yet been made.

Ishani said clearly, "We will not invent law to suit the story. Let us go to a lawyer and understand what is actually possible."

The family went to a lawyer in the district town. He examined the papers, heard what the family wanted, and said ownership, rights of use, duties of maintenance, and future transfer were separate matters; whatever they chose, they should write it clearly.

The story did not become a court case. No one sued anyone. But one question from the lawyer stopped them all: "Is your goal to preserve the house, or to preserve one fixed line of succession?"

Urmila Devi did not answer immediately.

The lawyer added, "They are not the same thing."

On the way home Grandmother kept looking out of the car window. Fields moved in the westerly wind. After a long time she said, "Bhuvaneshwari saved the house. Have we, in trying to save the line, forgotten why the house was saved?"

Mrinal took her hand. Ishani gave no answer. Some questions, answered too quickly, merely become new rules.

The decision did not come in one day. For three months there were phone calls, letters, meetings, a lawyer, and arguments among themselves. At last the family arrived at an arrangement: Urmila Devi would remain full owner during her lifetime. After her, the house would pass into Mrinal's name, accompanied by a written family agreement dividing maintenance, expenses, use, and care of cultural objects among willing members. After Mrinal, she would not automatically designate the eldest daughter; the family would meet again and consider willingness, work, and circumstances.

Ishani said, "This is not a complete solution."

Urmila Devi replied, "Do complete solutions exist anywhere but stories?"

"Not in my story either."

"Then good."

Two days a week on the veranda were fixed for Riddhi's workshop. Alok Mama took responsibility for inspecting the roof before the rains. Sudha for hospital assistance. Vineet for expense accounts. Ishani for conservation. Mrinal for the principal key.

Three duplicate keys were made. The first time Urmila Devi held one, she said, "How small the original has become."

Ishani said, "It is still the original."

"But no longer alone."

"That is the relief."

A few months later Ishani returned to Delhi. Her grandmother's house had not become hers, but its task list lived on her phone. Riddhi sent the first photograph of the rainy season—the damp on the north wall had reduced. Alok Mama sent the mason's estimate for the beam. Mrinal sent scans of the songbook. Anshu sent his sujani fish with the fat tail.

At work Ishani drew plans of old havelis, mosques, schools, and railway quarters. One day a colleague asked, "Who will inherit your ancestral home?"

Ishani no longer answered, "I will." "It belongs to Nani now. The later arrangement is shared."

"Meaning a trust?"

"Not exactly."

"Joint property?"

"What the lawyer has written on paper is one thing. Within the family we call it the house."

The colleague laughed. "Very vague."

Ishani laughed too. She remembered Niranjan's story: vagueness was not always a defect; sometimes it was honesty.

That night she listened to Grandmother's recording. Urmila Devi's voice trembled now and then, but the melodic line held. Riddhi had named the file: "Mother-Line_Form-1."

Ishani was pleased by "Form-1". It meant there was room for Form-2.

That night Ishani drew the family on paper. At first she tried a tree—ancestors above, descendants below. Then she folded the paper. Once again the tree was producing the same straight line.

On a second sheet she wrote names in circles and drew arrows between them: who cared for whom in illness, who paid for whose schooling, who taught whom a song, who rebuilt the roof, who looked after children, who ran to the hospital at the end of a life. There were so many arrows the page became a web.

Mrinal saw a photograph of it on the phone and asked, “Is this a family tree?”

“No. A work-web.”

“Are these things written in lineage?”

“Why not? If lineage records only birth, half the relationships of life disappear.”

After thinking, Mrinal said, “Then your grandmother’s ‘Mother-Line’ notebook was an early version of this idea—work beside names.”

Ishani understood that rebellion did not always mean throwing away everything old. Sometimes a new principle had already been seeded inside an old object; it only needed to be taken out of the shell of the rule.

19

Six months later Urmila Devi suddenly fell ill. Ishani took a night flight to Patna and then a car to the village. Ambulance, hospital, medicines—for several days everything was disorder.

Under the old rule, the principal burden would have fallen on Mrinal and Ishani. This time Sudha managed hospital papers, Alok the night watch, Vineet medicines, Riddhi the house, Mrinal stayed beside Grandmother, and Ishani spoke with the doctors.

Urmila Devi recovered and returned home. On the first evening on the veranda she looked at everyone for a long time.

“When my mother fell ill, one daughter did everything,” she said.

Mrinal asked, “Was that good or bad?”

“At that time perhaps it was necessary. Now it is not.”

Ishani said softly, “Then changing the rule was not wrong?”

Grandmother glared. “Will you win arguments against a sick body?”

Everyone laughed.

After a while Grandmother herself added, “But dividing the work was good.”

In that small admission Ishani felt no victory, only rest. The family’s change had been proved not by winning an argument, but by relief in a tired body.

After she recovered, Urmila Devi added a new page to the “House’s Mother-Line” notebook. Ishani saw that the title had changed: “The House’s People-Line.”

Under it she had written: “Bhuvaneshwari—raised the wall. Surmai—saved seed. Janki—had songs written. Kamla—recovered the pond. Urmila—replaced the roof. Mrinal—taught history. Sudha—support in illness. Alok—roof. Vineet—accounts. Riddhi—sujani and recordings. Ishani—measurement of the house and new arrangement. Anshu—first fat fish.”

Ishani stared at the page for a long time. “Has the matriline ended?”

Grandmother said, “The name changed. Have the mothers disappeared?”

“No.”

“Then?”

Ishani said, “But I love the word ‘matriline’.”

Urmila Devi smiled. “Keep beloved things in titles. Not in rules.”

Ishani wrote that sentence in the margin.

A year later a small exhibition was held on the veranda of Bhuvaneshwari’s house—for the family, not the market. Sujanis were hung, copies of the songbooks displayed, old and new plans of the house, photographs of the pond, brief life sketches of the women—and of the men too.

No one wrote “great matriarchal tradition.” Ishani was wary of the phrase. The introductory panel said only: “In this family, for a period, the house passed in inheritance from mother to daughter. Across generations this practice became security, right, labour, and burden. The family is now changing it toward consent and shared responsibility.”

Urmila Devi read the panel and said, “Too long.”

“Shall I shorten it?”

“No. Truth is difficult to shorten.”

A village girl at the exhibition asked, “Then who does the house belong to in the end?”

Before Urmila Devi answered, she looked at Ishani.

Ishani said, “At present, to Nani.”

The girl asked, “And afterwards?”

Grandmother laughed. “Those who care for it will sit together and decide.”

“Not the eldest daughter?”

“If the eldest daughter wants it, her voice will be there. If she does not, her ‘no’ will be there too.”

Ishani listened. A year earlier they had quarrelled over that sentence. Now Grandmother herself was saying it.

In the evening the exhibition was taken down. The sujani was folded again, but this time not locked in the chest. Riddhi kept a replica at the workshop; the original remained inside the house under a cloth cover. Digital copies of the songbooks existed in three places. Mrinal held the paper originals.

The brass lamp was brought into the courtyard. Until then Urmila Devi always had the eldest daughter light it. This time Anshu ran up. "May I light it?"

Everyone paused a little.

Urmila Devi said, "If you can keep your hand steady, light it."

Anshu touched flame to the wick. The first time it went out. The second time Riddhi shielded his hand. The third time the flame stood.

Ishani joked, "Whose lineage does the lamp belong to now?"

Grandmother answered, "To everyone who supplies oil, changes the wick, and wishes to light it."

"And those who do not wish to light it?"

"They too have the right to choose darkness."

Everyone laughed. Urmila Devi too.

The flame fell upon the red thread of the sujani. The square houses were separate, yet joined on one cloth. Some squares were empty. Ishani no longer saw the empty houses as absence; they looked like space.

After everyone slept, Ishani sat alone on the veranda. Three duplicate keys hung from a nail. The original key was no longer beneath Grandmother's pillow; it lay openly in a small wall niche.

Mrinal came. "Not sleepy?"

"It is coming."

"Do you still not want the house?"

Ishani thought. "I want the house. Not the entire story of ownership."

"The difference?"

"A great deal."

Mrinal sat beside her. "I understand now. At first I thought you were diminishing the work of my mothers."

"On the contrary, I take their work more seriously. They made decisions under particular circumstances. We turned those decisions into rules without looking at the circumstances."

Mrinal nodded. "In history class we make the same mistake—turning events into formulas."

Ishani rested her head on her mother's shoulder. "You completed your postgraduate degree. Nani could not become a nurse. We will write both."

"Write my achievement and also what did not happen?"

"Both. The maternal line is not only the history of what survived; it is also the history of what was left behind."

Mrinal gently squeezed her hand.

The next morning Ishani left for Delhi. Urmila Devi did not come to the doorway; her knees hurt. From inside she called, “Do not take the sujani.”

Ishani laughed. “I won’t.”

“Take the scan.”

“I already have it.”

“The songs?”

“On my phone.”

“The key?”

Ishani stopped. Riddhi held out one duplicate.

She took it and weighed it in her hand. A year earlier that weight had frightened her. Now it was not an order, but a means of access.

“Will you take it?” Riddhi asked.

Ishani put the key in her bag. “Yes. A copy.”

From inside came Grandmother’s laughter. “The original has lost its pride.”

The car moved. The house grew small in the rear window. For the first time Ishani felt neither that she was leaving the house nor that the house was holding her back. Between them was a road—the road to return, not return, return again.

On the veranda the brass lamp stood unlit in daylight. At evening someone would light it. A daughter, a son, a granddaughter, a grandson; perhaps no one. Light no longer meant a command of lineage.

It was only a possibility—that if anyone wished to see another person in the dark, there was still room beside the flame.

— End of Story 24 —

25. Proof

STORY

Uma Devi heard about the theft at daybreak. She had stepped out to pour water beside the tulsi altar when Saraswati Devi's grandson came running — "Mukhiya Kaki, Grandmother's hansuli has been stolen."

Uma Devi first looked at his face. The boy was breathing hard, his eyes were bright, and there was a strange excitement beneath the telling of the news. In the village, theft was a sorrow; the moment it became news, it changed shape.

"Who is the thief?" Uma Devi asked.

The boy answered without pausing. "Ramjit."

"Did you see the hansuli in his hand?"

The boy faltered. "No... but everyone says so."

Uma Devi set the lota down beside the altar. She understood that before the hansuli could be investigated, a name would have to be investigated.

I

Saraswati Devi's house was crowded that day. The previous day there had been a feast for the mundan ceremony of her eldest grandson. Leaf plates still lay on the veranda, a heap of ash in the courtyard, unused bamboo poles by the entrance, and the women's bedding inside had not yet been folded away.

The silver hansuli had belonged to Saraswati Devi's mother. She brought it out only for occasions such as weddings, sacred-thread ceremonies, and mundans. At the feast she had put it on her granddaughter; at night, she said, she had taken it off, wrapped it in a red cloth, and placed it in the wooden chest. In the morning the chest was open. The red cloth remained. The hansuli was gone.

"Where is the key kept?" Uma Devi asked.

"Under the bedding," Saraswati Devi said.

"Who in the house knows that?"

Saraswati Devi looked around. "The people of the house would naturally know."

Someone in the courtyard said softly, "Ramjit went inside at night."

Uma Devi turned toward the voice. It was their neighbour Sarita. She said, "I saw it with my own eyes."

"What did you see?"

“He was coming out of the west room.”

“With the hansuli in his hand?”

“His hand was under his gamchha.”

“So you did not see the hansuli.”

Sarita grew uncomfortable. “Must there be a distinction even in this?”

Uma Devi said, “If we do not make distinctions, what are we investigating?”

2

Ramjit was the potter’s son, around twenty years old. His household had supplied a hundred clay lamps, thirty kulhars, and two large earthen pots for the feast. Everyone agreed that he had returned at night to collect utensils.

The accusation clung to him quickly because the village already “knew” two things. First: when Ramjit was thirteen, he had been caught plucking mangoes from an orchard. Second: the day after the feast he had bought a second-hand bicycle.

“Money came on the night of the theft, and a bicycle the next morning,” someone said. “What more proof do you need?”

Uma Devi did not summon Ramjit to her doorstep. She went to his house herself.

Ramjit was sitting beside the potter’s wheel. His mother, Champa Devi, stood at the entrance. The moment Uma Devi arrived, Champa Devi said, “My son stole mangoes once, not a hansuli.”

Ramjit looked up. His eyes were red, as if he had not slept all night.

“Did you go into the room?” Uma Devi asked.

“Yes. Saraswati Dadi’s younger son told me there was an old sack in the west room and asked me to bring it out to cover the pots.”

“Did you bring the sack?”

“Yes. It was on the veranda. It was there till yesterday.”

“Why was your hand under the gamchha?”

Ramjit thought for a moment. “I had lifted a hot pot. My palm got scorched. I was holding it with the gamchha.”

Champa Devi interrupted. “Look at his hand.”

There were blisters in two places on his right palm. Uma Devi looked at them and said nothing. The blisters did not prove his innocence; they merely made another explanation for the gamchha possible.

3

When asked about the money for the bicycle, Ramjit took down an old cloth pouch hanging on the wall. It contained papers—an order from the Madhubani market for clay surahis, a handwritten receipt for an advance of five thousand rupees, and the slip from the bicycle seller.

Uma Devi read the slip. It was dated one day before the theft.

“Why did you not show these papers to anyone earlier?”

Ramjit did not smile. "No one asked. Everyone said: he got money, he bought a bicycle, case closed."

The sentence struck Uma Devi. The village's inference had moved very fast; the questions were running behind it.

As she was leaving, she heard Champa Devi say, "Mukhiya-ji, if the hansuli is never found, will my son remain a thief forever?"

Uma Devi did not answer at once. She knew that removing an accusation from paper was easier than removing it from people's mouths.

4

That afternoon a meeting was held in the panchayat building. Uma Devi deliberately did not let all the witnesses speak together. First Saraswati Devi, then Sarita, then the others who had managed the feast, and then Ramjit.

People disliked the method. "The same thing ten times," someone muttered.

Uma Devi pulled out an old blackboard that had been stored in the panchayat building during repairs to the school. With chalk she divided it into four columns. At the top she wrote: "Seen," "Heard," "Inference," "Believed beforehand."

"Is this a school?" Lalit Thakur laughed.

"No," Uma Devi said. "The statements have put on one another's clothes. I am separating the garments."

From Sarita's statement, only this went into the "Seen" column: Ramjit was seen coming out of the west room.

"Stolen object in hand" was not written.

Gopal's statement went under "Heard"—he had heard that Ramjit was counting money at night.

"From whom did you hear it?"

"From the boy's friend."

"Is that friend here?"

"No."

Uma Devi drew a small question mark beside the line.

The bicycle went under "Inference." The mango incident from when he was thirteen went under "Believed beforehand."

The blackboard filled up, but the line "Hansuli seen in his hand" remained blank.

Uma Devi did not stop there. On paper she sketched a rough map of the courtyard—the west room, kitchen, well, the place where leaf plates were kept, and the entrance. Then she asked Sarita, Gopal, Anuradha, and Ramjit separately to point out where they had been when Ramjit was seen, or said to have been seen, leaving the room.

The four maps did not match. According to Sarita, she had been near the well, from where the west door was only partly visible. According to Gopal, Sarita had been on the veranda counting leaf plates at that time. Anuradha said there was so much smoke near the well that the inside doorway could

not be seen clearly at all. Ramjit marked his own position between the kitchen and the room.

Sarita became angry. "Are you saying I am lying?"

"No," Uma Devi said. "I am looking at how much could be seen from where you were. The eye may speak truth, but the eye's location is also part of the truth."

Beside the map she wrote: "Direct perception = event + observer's position." The formula sounded a little too hard even to her, so below it she added in smaller letters: "and light, distance, attention."

Lalit Thakur laughed again. "Now it truly has become a school."

This time Uma Devi smiled. "All right. If two hours of school can save one name, it is not a bad thing."

5

In the middle of the meeting Saraswati Devi lost patience. "Has my property been stolen or not? Will all this paper and chalk bring the hansuli back?"

Uma Devi sat down beside her. "Your loss is real. There is no doubt about that."

"Then catch the thief."

"Writing down a name quickly is not the same as catching someone."

Saraswati Devi's eyes filled. "It belonged to my mother."

Uma Devi held her hand. No philosophical word was suitable at that moment. The object was not merely silver; it carried a touch from mother to daughter, from daughter to granddaughter. The pain of the theft was real, whoever the accused might be.

Uma Devi did not adjourn the meeting, but she added a fifth line to the blackboard: "Loss: certain." Beneath it: "Person responsible for loss: uncertain."

Everyone fell silent. For the first time, the distance between the two sentences became visible.

6

That evening Uma Devi inspected the west room. The lock on the chest had not been broken. The key was usually kept under the bedding. The door had opened and closed repeatedly during the feast. One window latch was loose, but there was no clear sign of entry from outside.

Saraswati Devi's younger daughter-in-law, Reena, said, "Only Maaji keeps the key."

Saraswati Devi herself immediately corrected her. "No. Yesterday I gave it to my granddaughter to open the box."

"At what time?"

"In the evening. She had to put away her bangles."

The granddaughter, Anuradha, was called. She said she had put the key back under the bedding. Two of her friends had also been in the room with her.

Uma Devi wrote down the names.

Reena said, "They are just girls."

Uma Devi looked up. "Being girls is not proof of innocence, and being a poor young man is not proof of guilt. I am only making a list of who had access."

Reena fell silent.

As Uma Devi left the room, she noticed that the key under the bedding lay where anyone doing housework could have seen it. "Secret" was merely the family's assumption, not the reality.

7

The next day Uma Devi spoke separately to all three friends. One said that after the hansuli was removed, Saraswati Devi herself had tied the red cloth. Another remembered that Anuradha had taken off the hansuli and handed it to her grandmother. The third said that the red cloth had not been placed in the chest at all, but beside the pillow.

All three had been present the same evening. Each believed her own memory to be true.

Uma Devi remembered an old teacher from her schooldays. He used to say, "Even what is seen does not travel straight from the eye to the page. The mind lies in between."

Uma Devi did not quote that sentence in the meeting; people were already impatient. But in her notes she wrote: "Direct memory of one event: three forms."

That night, for the first time, she rewrote the meaning of the word "proof" for herself: "That which leads my mind not toward what I already want to believe, but toward what happened."

She turned the page. This definition, too, was not final.

The next morning she began constructing a timeline. Photographs from the feast, the time the second batch of kheer had been put on the kitchen fire, the power cut, and an announcement made over the loudspeaker of the neighbouring mosque—all these small markers were placed together. One person's watch was a minute fast, another's five minutes slow. The camera was a full twenty-two minutes behind.

The timeline showed only this: Ramjit may have been near the west room for five to seven minutes. Theft was possible in those five to seven minutes—but during the same period there was also recorded work: bringing out the sack, covering the pots, moving hot utensils. Time did not prove him innocent; it merely widened the distance between "he was there" and "therefore he did it."

For a moment Uma Devi wished the timeline would give a clear direction. But the inquiry kept opening doors with another door behind them. She understood that uncertainty was not laziness; sometimes it was the result of labour.

Above the timeline, not in red ink but in ordinary blue, she wrote: "Opportunity: yes. Sole opportunity: no."

8

On the third day another kind of evidence began circulating through the village—character. Someone said Ramjit had been quarrelsome in school. Someone said his father had failed to repay a debt. Someone said the potter's household was short of money.

Uma Devi listened to all of it but wrote none of it on the blackboard.

Lalit Thakur asked, "Does character have no value?"

"It does," Uma Devi said. "Trust in a person is built and broken through character. But an old debt does not put today's hansuli into his hand."

"Then you will not even look at a thief's past?"

"If an earlier theft is proven, that does not mean the same person committed every later theft. And plucking mangoes at thirteen and opening a chest in someone's house are not the same event."

Lalit Thakur smiled. "You have become a lawyer."

Uma Devi said wearily, "No. I have only slowed down a little before ruining a name."

9

Ramjit's engagement broke off that same week. The girl's family said, "We will see after the theft accusation is cleared."

For the first time Ramjit raised his voice in the panchayat building. "How will it ever be cleared? If the hansuli is found, everyone will say I returned it. If it is not found, they will say I sold it. What road have you people left for me?"

No one had an immediate answer.

Uma Devi said, "So far the accusation against you has not been proved."

Ramjit gave a bitter laugh. "On paper?"

"Yes. I will write it on paper too."

"And in the village's mouth?"

Uma Devi remained silent.

Ramjit continued, "I want the paper. But for the three days my mother was called 'the thief's mother'—who has the paper for that?"

Uma Devi lowered her eyes. Justice did not begin only on the day of judgment; from the first hour of accusation, writing began upon people's bodies.

That evening Ramjit's father, Harinath, stopped Uma Devi outside the panchayat building. He rarely spoke. "I am thinking of sending the boy to the city," he said.

"For work?"

"No. Away from here."

Uma Devi asked, "Does Ramjit want to go?"

Harinath shook his head. "He says if he leaves now, everyone will say the thief ran away. If he stays, they will say he remained here shamelessly. What kind of road is this?"

Uma Devi again remembered Ramjit's first question: What road have you left for me? An accusation did not cast a shadow only on a past event; it

fell over every decision ahead. Going to the city could become proof; staying in the village could become proof. People could choose the conclusion first, then bend the meaning of behaviour to fit it.

"Do not let him make any decision under pressure," Uma Devi said. "If there is work, let him go. If there is study, let him go. If he wants to stay, let him stay. Fear of the accusation must not decide the direction of his life."

Harinath said nothing. As he walked away, he only said, "That cannot be written on paper."

Uma Devi answered silently: not everything important fits on paper. But what can fit must still be written clearly.

IO

Some people wanted Ramjit to swear an oath at the Devi shrine. "If he is innocent, let him touch the lamp and say so."

Uma Devi refused.

"Why? Is he afraid?"

"Fear is not proof."

"Would he lie before God?"

"This meeting is not a place to test anyone's faith. We are investigating a theft."

Then accusations turned upon Uma Devi as well—that she was protecting Ramjit, that she wanted the potters' votes, that she was thinking of the next panchayat election.

Uma Devi heard them. Inferences about imagined benefit had now turned toward her too. She felt like laughing but did not. The lesson of proof was not only for the accused; inference could be used against the person deciding as well.

She said publicly, "Theft is a punishable matter. If Saraswati Devi wishes to lodge a formal complaint, she has every right to go to the police. The panchayat will not beat anyone, force an oath, or declare anyone guilty merely on rumour."

Half the people were disappointed by this. More than justice, everyone wanted a conclusion.

II

Uma Devi again asked the people of Saraswati Devi's household: who from outside had gone inside on the day of the feast? The list grew long—the cook, the photographer, the barber's wife, two neighbours, the granddaughter's friends, Ramjit, and five members of the household.

The photographer's pictures were examined. In one photograph Anuradha was wearing the hansuli; in the next she was not. The chronological order of the photographs was unreliable because the camera clock had been set incorrectly.

"There is a photograph—direct proof," someone said excitedly.

Uma Devi replied, “The photograph shows that at one moment the hansuli was there and at another it was not. It does not tell us who removed it in between.”

A short video showed Saraswati Devi removing the hansuli from her granddaughter’s neck. Then the camera turned away.

Saraswati Devi stared at her own hands. “Yes. I took it off.”

“Into the red cloth?”

“I do not remember.”

On the first day her statement had been certain. Four days later she herself was uncertain. Uma Devi did not call her a liar. The memory had changed because the questions had changed.

12

On the fifth day the final round of the meeting was held. Uma Devi brought out the blackboard again.

“Seen”—Ramjit came out of the room; Saraswati Devi removed the hansuli; the key was accessible to several people.

“Heard”—Ramjit’s money, character, whispers from the night; mostly second- or third-hand.

“Inference”—the gamchha, bicycle, poverty, the old mango incident.

“Unknown”—into whose hand, and where, the hansuli last went; whether it was actually placed in the chest; who opened it later.

Uma Devi added the final column herself: “Unknown.”

“This is defeat,” Lalit Thakur said.

“Whose?”

“The investigation’s.”

Uma Devi set down the chalk. “Sometimes writing ‘unknown’ is better than writing a false ‘known.’”

Saraswati Devi was angry, but she was tired as well. “Then I have received no justice?”

“Your loss is recorded. The search for the object will continue. But we have not found proof to write Ramjit down as the thief.”

“Then he has been proven innocent?”

Uma Devi said slowly, “The accusation has not been proved. That is the truthful sentence. What I do not know, I will not give another name.”

13

The panchayat’s written note was brief: “From the available statements, documents, and site inspection, the allegation of theft against Ramjit is not established. Public humiliation, coercion, or forced confession is prohibited. The inquiry may be reopened if the object is recovered or new evidence emerges.”

Ramjit took a copy of the paper. Champa Devi wrapped it in plastic and placed it in the chest.

“Keep it here?” Ramjit asked.

Champa Devi said, "What people wrote with their mouths, we will keep its answer on paper."

The engagement did not revive immediately. Ramjit kept riding the bicycle. He completed the surahi order. Some people stopped buying kulhars from his house; others deliberately bought from him. The village did not become unanimous because of one decision.

Uma Devi regarded this not as failure, but as outcome. A record of justice could not command people's minds.

Three days after the meeting ended, a folded piece of paper was found beneath the panchayat building door. No name. One sentence: "Someone inside the house committed the theft."

The news spread again. This time people's eyes turned toward Saraswati Devi's household. The mouths that had called Ramjit a thief yesterday now began whispering new names.

Uma Devi showed the paper at the meeting. "This is information," she said, "not proof."

"The writer must be afraid to give the name," someone said.

"Possibly."

"Then the statement is true?"

"Fear is not proof that something is true. Nor is it proof that it is false."

Saraswati Devi was hurt. "Now everyone in my house is accused?"

Uma Devi folded the paper and placed it in a separate envelope. "No. The mistake we prevented in Ramjit's case will not be repeated with another name."

She entered the anonymous note in the register: "Anonymous information received; verification impossible." Again the sentence sounded incomplete to people. Uma Devi felt that incomplete writing was sometimes better than a complete lie.

14

Two months later, one morning in Sawan, the priest of the Devi shrine came to the panchayat building carrying a bundle wrapped in old newspaper.

"It was found in a corner of the lamp room," he said.

The bundle was opened. Inside was a red cloth. Inside the red cloth, the silver hansuli.

Saraswati Devi was called. The moment she saw it, she began to cry. One worn joint, a small mark her mother had made, a crooked finger-like scratch on the back—she recognized it.

The news spread across the village within an hour. By noon three conclusions were ready. First: Ramjit had returned it out of fear. Second: someone in the household had put it there out of shame. Third: the thief was an outsider who had fled after seeing the panchayat's pressure.

Uma Devi asked, "Did anyone see who put it there?"

No one had.

"Any written note?"

No.

“Then what do we know now?”

Sarita said irritably, “The hansuli has returned. Is that all?”

“That much is certain.”

People were angry again. Truth lay in the hand like the recovered object, but the person responsible had slipped out of reach once more.

The priest said he himself had closed the lamp room after the final aarti at night, but there was a small opening in the rear wall through which a hand could reach from outside. It had been there for years; no one had regarded it as a security flaw. Now everyone looked at it as if it were new.

Those who suspected Ramjit immediately said, “He must have known about it.” Those who suspected a member of the household said, “Everyone knows about that opening.” Those who believed in an outside thief said, “That is exactly how it was put back.” The same opening became proof for three stories.

Uma Devi measured it, inspected the lamp room from inside and outside, and wrote in her notes: “Possible route by which the object could have been placed.” Then she stopped. Not: “Who placed it.”

Sarita said, “You write everything only halfway.”

Uma Devi replied, “I write only as far as the event allows.”

15

Ramjit did not go to the Devi shrine himself. He was at work. When he returned in the evening and heard the news, he asked only, “Did Dadi recognize it?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

Champa Devi asked, “Have you nothing to say?”

Ramjit pressed clay onto the wheel and said, “Whatever I say, people will look for proof in that too.”

Uma Devi met him later. “The hansuli has been found.”

“I heard.”

“There is no new evidence against you.”

Ramjit stopped the wheel. “Write that sentence on paper again.”

“I will.”

“That is enough.”

He set the wheel turning again. Clay rose between his palms. Uma Devi understood: some things take shape under a hand, but not every hand is a thief’s hand.

16

Saraswati Devi did not put the hansuli back in the old chest. She bought a small iron box, changed the lock, and changed the place where the key was kept. But a week later she came to Uma Devi herself.

“I came to say one thing.”

“Tell me.”

"On the first day I did not name Ramjit. Other people did. But I did not stop them."

Uma Devi was silent.

"I wanted the hansuli. I felt that if someone were caught, the object would come back through him. Once there was a name, my mind became a little calmer."

"And now?"

"The hansuli has returned. The name has not. My mind is not completely calm."

Uma Devi said, "Sometimes the object returns, but the reason does not."

Saraswati Devi breathed deeply. "Should I go to Ramjit's mother?"

Uma Devi did not answer. This decision belonged not to proof, but to relationship.

17

Two days later Saraswati Devi went to Champa Devi's house. There was no public apology, no performance. She bought two clay lamps. While paying she asked, "Your son worked on the night of the feast. Was his wage paid in full?"

Champa Devi did not understand at first. Then she said, "Yes."

"Good."

The two women stood for a few moments. Saraswati Devi took the lamps and went home.

That evening Champa Devi told Ramjit, "She came."

"What did she say?"

"Very little."

Ramjit asked, "An apology?"

"No."

He smiled faintly. "All right. Sometimes fewer words are more truthful."

18

Uma Devi added a final note to the panchayat register: "The object was recovered on the stated date from the lamp room of the Devi shrine. The person who placed it there is unknown. No new evidence exists against the former accused."

The clerk asked, "Is it necessary to write so much?"

"Yes. Tomorrow someone may read only 'the hansuli was found' and add his own story."

"And if he reads 'unknown'?"

"Then at least he will know that we did not know."

Before closing the panchayat building that night, Uma Devi looked at the blackboard. The old four chalk columns had been half erased—Seen, Heard, Inference, Believed beforehand. The fifth word, "Unknown," was still clear.

A small brass lamp burned on the table. By the time its light reached the blackboard it had grown faint. Half the word “Unknown” lay in light, half in shadow.

Uma Devi picked up the chalk. For a moment she felt like turning the board so the entire word would come into the light. Then she put the chalk down again.

The work of proof was not to deny the existence of darkness. It was to say as much as could be seen, and to stop before giving a name to what could not be seen.

She extinguished the lamp. The blackboard disappeared into darkness, but the blank space remained in the register—deliberately blank.

— *End of Story 25* —

26. Maya

STORY

I

Eleven years later, a white envelope arrived at Harinarayan Jha's doorway. The postman said, "Sign here. It is registered."

Harinarayan was seventy-two now. He often misplaced his spectacles, but he immediately recognized the neat words printed in the corner of the envelope—"Claims Settlement Committee."

With that name, an old glass-fronted building, blue chairs, tea from a machine, and men in white shirts suddenly rose in his memory.

His granddaughter Anvi opened the envelope and read. "Baba, there is an order to pay you twelve thousand seven hundred and forty-two rupees. What is this?"

Harinarayan did not laugh. He took the envelope and sat on the veranda bench.

"The surviving fragment of a very expensive lesson," he said.

Anvi sat beside him with her school notebook. That week the word "maya" had appeared in her philosophy lesson. On the page she had written: "That which appears, but is not true."

Harinarayan read the line and shook his head. "It is not that simple."

"Then what is maya?"

Harinarayan folded the envelope and held it between his knees. "Listen to a story. After what happened to me, that word came to mean something different from what it meant in the book."

2

Eleven years earlier Harinarayan had been fifty-five. Two bighas of farmland in Bardaha, an old house, three mango trees, and some savings in the bank—that was the extent of his property.

His wife Sushila used to say that the holding was small, but as long as the body kept working, the household would run. Their son Deepak was in Delhi learning electrical work; their daughter Rupa wanted to study nursing.

Harinarayan worried less about the field than about the future. He felt the next generation could not be held back by dependence on the price of paddy and wheat, and on the weather.

At that time a distant relative by marriage, Naresh, brought him a colourful brochure. On the cover was a green orchard, solar panels in the

middle, a white house behind them, and below the words: “Green Prosperity Agricultural Development Scheme: Income from farming without leaving your own field.”

Naresh was excited. “They have an office in the city. The company leases land, plants fruit trees, and handles irrigation and marketing. You buy a share and receive income every year.”

Harinarayan turned the pages. The paper was thick. The printing glossy. Inside were charts—little in the first year, more in the third, far more in the fifth.

Sushila glanced at it. “Will trees bear fruit on paper?”

Naresh laughed. “Bhauji, this is the new way.”

Sushila handed the brochure back to Harinarayan. “Does being new make something true?”

That night Harinarayan read the brochure three times. More than the numbers, one photograph held him: a father watching his daughter pluck fruit in an orchard. Beneath it was written: “Secure income for the next generation.”

Rupa’s fee receipt lay on the table that same day. In Harinarayan’s mind, a road formed between the photograph and the receipt.

3

Three days later Harinarayan, Naresh, and their neighbour Bhola went to the city. The office was in a building whose front wall was almost entirely glass. Sky, clouds, and traffic on the road appeared together in the glass.

At the entrance a security guard wrote down their names. Inside, the air was cool. On the walls were maps of fields, photographs of fruit trees, glass plaques marked “Awards,” and on a screen a film of green orchards played continuously.

A young man named Aditya addressed them as “farmer partners.” He rarely used the word “customer.”

“I do not want to sell my land,” Harinarayan said first.

“There is no question of selling,” Aditya said with a smile. “You keep your land. This investment is in a separate project. The company conducts high-value horticulture on leased land. You take a management share.”

“Whose land?” Bhola asked.

Aditya immediately opened a folder. “Partnership leases held by the company. All the documents are here.”

He showed them many papers—seals, signatures, maps, bank-payment details, photographs of farmers. There were more papers than questions.

Bhola placed a finger on one paragraph. “It says here, ‘No ownership rights.’”

Aditya said, “Naturally. You are not buying the land; you are buying a share of production.”

The answer sounded right to Harinarayan. The brochure too said “income,” not “land.” His mind told him: See, everything is clear.

Then a woman brought tea. The company logo was printed on the cup. Harinarayan would later think about this many times—the tea had been completely real.

4

After the office visit they were taken to see a model orchard outside the city. There were around twenty people on the bus. On the way Aditya kept speaking into a microphone: in conventional farming, the farmer labours while middlemen take the profit; here science, management, and market access came together.

The orchard genuinely existed. Rows of young trees, water through pipes, a tin office, two labourers, a table for soil testing.

Bhola asked one of the workers, “How long have you been working here?”

“Two months,” the worker said.

“Does the land belong to the company?”

The worker shrugged. “How would I know? The owners know those higher matters.”

A small doubt stirred in Harinarayan. But then Aditya plucked a leaf, let them smell it, and began speaking in the language of agricultural science. People all around were taking photographs.

An elderly farmer bent to touch Aditya’s feet. Aditya stopped him, caught his hand, and lifted him. “You are a partner, not a customer.”

Harinarayan liked that sentence. All his farming life, in many places he had been called a “small farmer”; here he was being called a “partner.”

On the bus back, Bhola said quietly, “I will take the papers home and read them.”

Naresh said, “If you keep reading at leisure, the remaining shares will be gone.”

At that very moment Aditya announced, “Only fourteen shares remain in this phase.”

Harinarayan looked out of the window. The fields seemed to be racing backward. For the first time he felt that time too was moving away from him.

5

Back home, Sushila could not read all the papers, but she asked many questions. “Did you see the land?”

“Yes.”

“The owner’s name on the papers?”

Harinarayan hesitated. “It says partnership lease.”

“For how long?”

Harinarayan turned the pages again. The print was fine. In one place it said three years; elsewhere there was talk of renewal.

Sushila said, “Pay Rupa’s fees first. Keep the remaining money.”

Harinarayan suppressed his irritation. "That is why I want to do this. If another stream of income starts, her education will be secure."

"To make her education secure, you will risk the money for her education?"

The sentence pierced him because it struck not at his logic, but at his fear.

That night Deepak called. "Baba, if you must do it, begin with a smaller amount."

Harinarayan said, "With a small share the income is small too. The company has done the calculations."

After ending the call, he felt that his son, living in the city, probably understood all new things; yet here the father himself was stepping onto a new road in the city.

Two days later he withdrew savings from the bank. He kept aside Rupa's immediate fees, but added a portion of the amount saved for the next two semesters as well.

As Harinarayan signed, Aditya said, "You will not regret this."

Harinarayan smiled. The sentence was not in the contract. Yet that day it felt like the strongest assurance of all.

6

For the first three months everything went well. Project photographs kept arriving on the phone: "Irrigation completed in your block," "New saplings planted," "Market agreement signed."

In the fourth month the first income reached his bank account. It was not a large amount, but it matched the table in the brochure.

Harinarayan showed the passbook to Sushila. "See?"

Sushila looked at the amount and asked, "Did this income come from the trees or from the money of new people?"

Harinarayan laughed. "You see doubt in everything."

"I simply cannot see the source."

At the time the question seemed unnecessary to Harinarayan. The money in the bank was real. The photographs on the phone were real. The office was real.

He told his brother-in-law about the scheme. The man asked, "Did you receive money yourself?"

"Yes."

"Then it is fine."

Harinarayan took him to the city. Aditya recognized Harinarayan and said, "Our old partner!"

At that form of address Harinarayan's chest swelled a little. He was no longer merely an investor; he had become proof by experience.

Within six months, five people from the village joined the scheme. Bhola did not. He kept saying, "I cannot find a clear source of the income in the papers."

People laughed and called him timid. One day Harinarayan too said, "Too much thinking can also become maya, Bhola. The opportunity passes by."

Bhola smiled. "Possibly. But haste, too, can sometimes be maya."

7

A month after the first payment, the company held a "Partners' Meet." In a city hotel there were chairs covered in white cloth, a green curtain on the stage, and behind it large words: "From Farmer to Entrepreneur."

Harinarayan had never attended such an event. At the entrance a card on a green ribbon was hung around his neck: "Founding Partner." The card was very light, yet he felt his shoulders fill with heavy prestige.

Two farmers spoke on stage about receiving their first return. One woman said she had bought her daughter a computer. Applause followed. Harinarayan thought: the day of Rupa's next fee was not far away.

Aditya read a name from the stage: "Harinarayan Jha from Bardaha." Harinarayan rose with a start. He had only been told to stand. Everyone applauded.

After the programme Aditya called him aside. "People in your village trust you. The company would like you to become a 'trust associate.'"

"What would I have to do?"

"Nothing. Give information to anyone who is interested. No pressure. For members who join through your introduction, the company will give you an honorarium."

Harinarayan immediately said, "I will not do brokerage."

Aditya laughed. "Not brokerage—sharing experience. If you do not want the money, it can go into the project's sapling fund."

Harinarayan liked the language. "Sharing experience" made the work sound honourable.

He did not take the honorarium. He wrote that it should go to the sapling fund. This decision increased his confidence in his own impartiality—if he had no private gain, how could his advice be biased?

Later he understood that benefit is not only money. Having one's name called from a stage, answering people's questions, being called an "old partner"—these were benefits too. The taste of respect rarely enters the account book.

When Bhola saw the card, he said only, "The company is making you into its proof."

Harinarayan replied, "I have received income. How is it a lie to describe my experience?"

Bhola said, "The experience is true. But who is deciding what your experience means—you or the company?"

Harinarayan laughed at the question then. Later, the smell of that sentence stayed with him for a long time.

In the ninth month, project photographs became less frequent. Earlier two messages came each week; now one came every two weeks.

Aditya still answered the phone, but blamed delays on “field expansion.”

In the tenth month the payment came three days late. In the eleventh month, only half came.

Naresh became restless. “Let us go to the office.”

The three of them—Harinarayan, Naresh, and this time Bhola too—went to the city. The glass building was the same. The security guard had changed.

When they reached the upper floor, the company’s name was no longer on the door. In its place was the sign of a travel-services office.

At first Harinarayan thought the company must have moved to another floor. He went up the stairs. Then down again. Then back to the guard.

“The company that was here?”

The guard checked the register. “They vacated two weeks ago.”

“Where did they go?”

“I do not know.”

Naresh’s face went pale. “The phone?”

Every number was switched off. The website would not open. In the mobile group there were first complaints, then abuse, then rumours.

Harinarayan stood beside the glass wall. His face and the sky behind it appeared together in the glass. The building was still the same. The reflection too. Only the meaning had changed.

They went to the model orchard. The gate was locked. The tea-stall owner nearby said, “The company had taken the land for three months. Lots of photographs and such. Last week they removed their things.”

Harinarayan gripped the gate and looked inside. Some trees remained, some pipes. The land had not vanished. The trees had not flown away by magic.

If there had been maya, it had not been emptiness. A great deal had actually been real.

The police station was crowded. One person had lost five thousand, another five lakh. Some said the employees too had been cheated. Others said everyone had been in on it.

Harinarayan handed over his papers. An officer pointed to a line in the contract: “The company has stated an estimated return, not a guaranteed assurance.”

Heat rose through Harinarayan’s body. “But this table? These photographs? The first payment?”

The officer said, “There will be an investigation.”

The answer was painfully small. Harinarayan wanted someone to say: You are completely innocent. Or: You were a fool. Or at least: All this happened because of this one person.

But there were many names on the papers, and responsibility had been broken into fragments of lines.

On the way home Naresh began to cry. "I took all of you there."

Harinarayan said harshly, "I went on my own feet."

Whether he said it to comfort Naresh or to divide his own guilt, Harinarayan himself did not know.

IO

Five days after discovering the empty office, Harinarayan's phone rang at night. It was an unfamiliar number.

"Harinarayan-ji?" Aditya's voice came from the other end.

Harinarayan sat up. "Where are you?"

"I cannot say much on the phone. My salary too has been unpaid for two months. The people above me in the company have disappeared."

Anger rose in Harinarayan. "You made us trust them."

"I repeated the information given to me."

"Did you have no eyes? Did you not read the contract?"

There was silence at the other end. "I read it. But I was told the risk clause was legal language and the project was strong. My own family invested after the first payments came."

Harinarayan wanted Aditya to laugh, threaten him, confess to a crime—anything that would make him a clear villain. But the voice sounded tired.

"Then were you cheated too?"

"The investigation will decide that. I will give my statement."

"And my brother-in-law's money?"

"I cannot return it."

"Then why call me?"

Aditya said quietly, "Because you have probably taken my name more than anyone else's. Take it. But write this too: I was not the owner of the company."

The call ended. Harinarayan sat for a long time holding the phone.

The next day, in the collective complaint, he listed Aditya as an employee, not as the "chief operator." Naresh said, "Why so much softness?"

Harinarayan replied, "I do not know how much he knew."

"You are falling into illusion again."

"Possibly. But this time I do not want to write as known what I do not know."

At that moment Harinarayan understood something for the first time: emerging from maya did not mean doubting everything; it also meant writing down the limit of one's ignorance.

II

News spread through the village faster than the company had disappeared.

On the first day people offered sympathy. On the second, advice. On the third, stories. By the seventh day everyone had a reason ready.

“Greed.”

“The glitter of the city.”

“Signing without reading the papers.”

“Greed for money at the cost of the daughter’s education.”

The last accusation hurt Harinarayan most, because Rupa’s education had not been abandoned; yet arranging the next fee had now become difficult.

Rupa herself said, “Baba, I can study a semester later too.”

Harinarayan snapped, “Your studies will not stop.”

Rupa fell silent. Later Sushila said, “She was not blaming you. She was trying to share your burden.”

Harinarayan did not sleep that night. Aditya’s face kept returning to him. Then his own face—when he had taken his brother-in-law to the office.

He understood that in the net of fraud he had not only been caught; at one point he had also become one of the strands of the net.

The next day he visited all five village investors. He offered no defence of himself. He only spoke about gathering documents, filing a joint complaint, and writing separately what each person had seen and what each had merely heard.

Bhola came along too.

Harinarayan asked him, “Do you not feel like laughing at me?”

Bhola said, “You called me a coward. If I call you a fool and make the account equal, what work will that accomplish?”

12

When the date for Rupa’s next-semester fees arrived, the household accounts changed in a real way. The money lost to the company was no longer a number on paper; it became the possible price of the cow tied at the doorway, sacks of paddy, and Sushila’s old silver anklet.

Harinarayan thought of selling the cow. Sushila refused. “Milk keeps the household running. Do not cut away another support in order to cover one mistake.”

Rupa said, “I can take a training assignment like an extra night duty in the hospital hostel. It will bring a small stipend.”

Harinarayan said sternly, “You will not sell your study time.”

Rupa answered calmly, “Baba, you invested the money for my future. If I do some work for my own future now, how does that become a punishment?”

Harinarayan had no answer. For the first time he saw that the brochure’s picture of “the daughter’s secure future” contained a daughter who never spoke. The father had filled in the meaning of her future in his own mind.

In the end Rupa took a stipend-bearing training assignment, Deepak sent home two months of his earnings, Sushila reduced household expenses, and Harinarayan sold some paddy and paid the fees.

No single person became the rescuer. The loss was distributed across the family, just as hope had earlier been distributed among them.

That night Harinarayan said to Sushila, "I went to buy everyone's future without asking them."

Sushila said, "Where is the future ever sold? People only sell things in its name."

"Then is it a mistake even to have desire?"

"How would people live without desire? The mistake begins when desire becomes the eye, and the eye stops reading what is written in front of it."

Harinarayan remained silent for a long time. Outside was darkness. Inside a small lamp burned. Its shadow stretched long on the wall—far larger than the flame, but without heat.

13

The case dragged on for years. Some employees were arrested, some names remained only on paper, some accounts were frozen. Meetings of investors slowly became smaller.

In the first year Harinarayan remembered every date. In the second, only the important ones. In the third, he took out the papers only when the lawyer called. By the fifth year the blue file had been pushed to the top of the cupboard.

Life does not leave empty spaces untouched. Rupa completed nursing. Deepak returned from Delhi and opened a small electrical shop. Despite pain in her knees, Sushila kept growing vegetables in the courtyard.

Harinarayan returned his full attention to farming, but something had changed. If anyone in the market said "double income," he immediately asked questions. If he could not understand the fine print on a bank form, he took it to someone who could.

Some people called him excessively suspicious.

Harinarayan was afraid of becoming that. He did not want to become Bhola, nor did he want to return to his old self. He came to understand that doubt and fear were not the same, and trust and haste were not the same either.

One day the schoolmaster invited him to speak at a farmers' meeting. Harinarayan went on stage and described his loss, but he did not say, "The city is bad."

He said, "A great deal of what I saw was true. There was an office. There were trees. There was a first payment. My mistake was that from all these things I drew out a future that the documents did not make certain."

Someone in the gathering asked, "Does that reduce the fraudster's guilt?"

Harinarayan replied immediately, "No. The guilt of the deceiver is entire. Seeing one's own mistake does not lessen his guilt; it opens one's own eyes for the next time."

14

That night Sushila said, “You spoke well today.”

Harinarayan laughed. “Had I listened to you eleven years ago, it would have been even better.”

“Not everything I say is right.”

“That one was.”

As she trimmed the lamp wick, Sushila said, “Then was my advice worth more than twelve thousand seven hundred and forty-two rupees?”

Harinarayan started. The envelope had not yet arrived then; that belonged to a later time. At that moment Sushila had merely been joking about the old loss.

In Harinarayan’s memory, time sometimes tangled itself like this—a sentence from one year returning in the light of another.

He paused here while telling the story to his granddaughter Anvi.

Anvi asked, “Then was the company maya?”

“The company was committing fraud. That is a legal and moral matter.”

“Maya?”

Harinarayan thought for a while. “I will not use the word maya to blur their crime. Fraud is fraud. But what happened inside me—that is another matter.”

15

He opened the envelope again. The Claims Settlement Committee’s letter said that after the sale of seized assets, the available money was being distributed proportionately among investors. After eleven years, a small fraction of the original amount.

Anvi said, “You received money after so long. Are you not happy?”

“I am happy. But this money cannot return that time.”

“What time?”

“Rupa’s worry. Naresh’s guilt. The silence in my brother-in-law’s house when they saw me. The night Sushila stayed awake. Money does not know how to account for these.”

Anvi wrote something in her notebook.

“What did you write?”

“That loss is not only money.”

Harinarayan smiled. “Keep that line.”

Anvi asked again, “Did you ever invest again?”

“Yes.”

She stared at him.

“In an ordinary bank deposit. Later, in a small cooperative irrigation group, after seeing every member’s name, the land, the expenses, the accounts. Risk was not zero. Nothing in life has zero risk. But this time I looked at the structure before the shine.”

“Then is suspicion the way to escape maya?”

“Not suspicion alone. Keep a distance between what the thing in front of you actually is and the meaning you are making out of it.”

Evening had fallen. Sushila was no longer alive. Anvi now lit her brass lamp.

She placed the lamp beside the glass-fronted cupboard on the veranda. In the glass, a second flame appeared—one real, one reflected.

Anvi laughed. “Two lamps?”

“They look like two.”

“How many are real?”

Harinarayan held his hand before the glass. The heat of one flame reached his palm; the other merely appeared.

“The reflection is not a lie,” he said. “It is a reflection. The mistake begins when we take it for the lamp itself.”

Anvi did not cross out the old definition in her notebook. Beneath it she added: “What appears may truly appear; illusion lies in not understanding its meaning correctly.”

Harinarayan read the line, smiled, and said, “Write ‘not understanding the meaning correctly’ there. It will be clearer.”

Anvi rewrote the sentence.

The twelve thousand seven hundred and forty-two rupees from the envelope were later deposited in her education savings account. Harinarayan did not call it a gift, nor compensation for the loss. He only said, “This is the surviving fragment. Use it thoughtfully.”

The two flames remained in the cupboard glass. Darkness outside grew deeper. One flame continued to give light to the house; the other continued to form its image in the glass.

Harinarayan kept looking at both. He no longer needed to erase one visible thing in order to prove the other true. Knowing the distinction was enough.

— *End of Story 26* —

27. Rasa

STORY

I

There were five chairs on the wooden stage of the rehearsal room, though the play required only one. The other four were part of Udayakant Jha's habit—sometimes an actor sat on them, sometimes an assistant, sometimes costumes or papers were piled there. He was a director past fifty-five, yet during the first hour of rehearsal he still grew restless like a student.

Madhavi stood at centre stage. Her character was named Subhadra—a woman who had spent three days searching for a daughter missing since the night of the flood. This scene took place on the evening of the third day, when the villagers had begun to abandon the search and return home, while Subhadra kept her door open.

Udayakant wrote a single word on the blackboard: "Karuna."

Madhavi read it from a distance. "Is that an instruction for me, or for the audience?"

"For neither," Udayakant said. "It is to understand the centre of the scene."

"Is the centre so simple?"

"Not simple. Named."

Madhavi folded her dialogue sheet and placed it on a chair. "My problem is with the name. The moment you write 'Karuna,' I feel as though I am now required to cry."

Udayakant laughed. "Karuna rasa is not tears."

"Then what is it?"

"There is the supporting cause, the stimulus, the outward response, the transitory emotions, the abiding emotion—what all of them together awaken within the spectator."

Madhavi looked at him for a moment. "You have given me five terms, but Subhadra's daughter is still missing."

Udayakant fell silent. Then he smiled. "Fair enough. Find the daughter first. We shall look at theory later."

2

The scene began. An old red gamchha hung at stage left. A brass plate lay in the middle. To the right stood the frame of a wooden door, half open. Subhadra enters, lifts the plate, sets it down again, looks toward the doorway

and says, "When she comes back hungry, the first thing she will ask for is rice in this plate."

Madhavi spoke the line. Her voice trembled.

Udayakant raised a hand. "Stop."

"What?"

"Do not let the voice tremble."

"The character is trembling."

"Her body may tremble. Not the voice yet."

"Why?"

"Because if all the grief pours out in the first line, where will the rest of the scene go?"

Madhavi frowned. "Does grief ask the director for its cue before it arrives?"

"On stage, it does."

"Not in life."

"A play is not life."

"Then why do we act as though it were life?"

Udayakant did not answer at once. The assistants at the edge of the stage stopped working and began watching them. At last he said, "Because life cannot be reproduced exactly. Art makes a form capable of holding it."

Madhavi took up the line again. This time her voice remained steady. Only when she set the plate down did her fingers hold the rim a little longer.

Udayakant said nothing. He let the scene continue.

3

The argument returned at the second rehearsal. This time the cause was not tears but laughter.

Subhadra's neighbour enters and says, "The door has been open for three days. At least tie up the goat, or the goat will get in before your daughter does."

Hearing the line, Madhavi laughed involuntarily—not from within the character, but as Madhavi herself.

Udayakant clapped. "Keep that laugh."

Madhavi was startled. "In the middle of a Karuna scene?"

"Yes."

"Yesterday you wrote 'Karuna' on the blackboard."

"I wrote Karuna, not a funeral meeting."

Madhavi laughed. "So the theory has changed?"

"No. You are treating the theory as monochrome."

"And you are trying to classify experience."

"Classification and imprisonment are not the same thing."

"Sometimes they feel the same."

Udayakant wrote in small letters beneath "Karuna": "Hasya?"

"Why the question mark?" Madhavi asked.

"Because I am still watching too."

4

On the third day of rehearsal, Udayakant made a mistake.

The scene about Subhadra's daughter kept turning rigid. Madhavi spoke the lines correctly, the pace was right, the pauses were right, yet Udayakant felt a fine distance remained between body and words. He stopped rehearsal and said, "Can you remember your mother's last day?"

The stage went completely still.

Madhavi's mother had died a year earlier. Everyone in the group knew it. No one had mentioned it in rehearsal.

Madhavi closed her dialogue sheet. "No."

Udayakant understood at once. "Forgive me. I should not have asked that."

"You are the director. You have no right over my private grief."

"You are right."

"And acting does not require me to reopen a private wound."

"That is right too."

Silence came between them.

Udayakant sat down on a chair. "I was afraid the scene was becoming lifeless. In that fear I crossed a boundary."

Madhavi's voice softened, but remained clear. "If the scene is lifeless, find a remedy for the scene. Not my mother."

Udayakant lowered his head. "We will do it again."

This time he did not invoke private memory; he worked only with physical action. "Feel the weight when you lift the plate. Do not hold your breath before looking at the doorway. After the line ends, leave an empty space."

Madhavi performed the scene. Strangely, it felt deeper than before. No one wept. No one drew a loud breath. Yet the silence in the rehearsal room changed.

Madhavi herself remained a little stunned when the scene ended.

Before Udayakant could say anything, she said, "This time I did not remember my mother."

"Good."

"But something happened."

"Good."

"Would you call it *rasa*?"

Udayakant smiled. "Not so quickly in rehearsal."

5

That night at home, Madhavi opened an old brass tin that had belonged to her mother. Inside were two buttons, a broken comb, an old five-rupee coin, and needle and thread. It was no memorial. Her mother had kept sewing things in it.

Madhavi closed the tin. She did not cry.

She remembered the rehearsal scene—the plate, the doorway, the empty space. For the first time she understood that Udayakant's question had been

wrong, but the directions he gave afterward had worked. Without opening private grief, the body could still hold an unnamed memory.

But that understanding did not end her argument.

On a sheet of paper she wrote: "Form without experience—blind? Experience without form—deaf?"

Then she put a question mark beside both questions.

6

On the fourth day, Udayakant set an exercise. Madhavi had to speak the same line—"Let the door remain open"—in five different circumstances.

First: children are playing inside the house.

Second: a guest is expected.

Third: someone has run away from home.

Fourth: someone is dying.

Fifth: someone is missing, and hope of their return still remains.

The words stayed the same. The meaning changed each time.

After speaking the line the fifth time, Madhavi fell silent. "Then *rasa* is not in the words?"

"Not in the words alone."

"In the actor?"

"Not in the actor alone either."

"In the spectator?"

"Not in the spectator alone either."

Madhavi laughed. "You escape every answer by adding 'alone.'"

Udayakant laughed too. "Art very often does not live all by itself in one place."

Madhavi corrected him at once. "All by itself."

Udayakant laughed. "A rare event."

The group burst into laughter. The fatigue of rehearsal lightened a little.

When the laughter subsided, Udayakant told the group, "Now let us test the same line another way."

He seated three students at different places in front of the stage. The first was not shown the opening part of the scene; the second watched the entire scene; the third heard only the last two lines. Madhavi again said, "Let the door remain open."

The first student said, "I felt someone was expected." The second said, "I felt afraid." The third said, "I felt hope."

Madhavi looked at Udayakant. "One line, three meanings."

Udayakant said, "That is why the spectator is not an empty vessel for us to fill. A spectator arrives with memory, knowledge, and a body."

"Then why did you write 'Karuna' on the blackboard beforehand and try to decide the spectator's experience?"

Udayakant gave a slightly embarrassed laugh. "Perhaps while writing the direction of the scene, I also wrote its outcome for the spectator."

Madhavi said, "Direction is useful. Certainty about the outcome is dangerous."

With chalk Udayakant drew a small circle around “Karuna.” “Then let this be a centre, not a boundary.”

Looking at the circle, Madhavi said, “And let the circle remain open.”

That prompted Udayakant to suggest another exercise. “This time, no words. Only action.”

Madhavi lifted the plate, ran a finger along its rim, went to the doorway, touched the frame, and returned to the plate. No dialogue.

The three students were asked what they had understood. One said, “She is waiting for someone.” Another said, “She is thinking of leaving the house.” The third said, “She is angry, but she is not breaking anything.”

Madhavi laughed. “There were no words now, and still three meanings.”

Udayakant said, “The body too gives signs.”

“It gives signs, not verdicts,” Madhavi replied. “Touching a plate may be an act of mourning in one house and merely cleaning in another. The spectator completes its meaning from their own life.”

Udayakant thought for a moment. “Then anubhava does not mean one gesture equals one emotion.”

“That was exactly my objection. If we make a list—eyes like this means Karuna, hands like this means fear—the actor will no longer be alive, only a puppet of signs.”

Udayakant said, “But without any discipline, every sign becomes accidental.”

“Let there be discipline. Not a monopoly on meaning.”

At the end of that day’s rehearsal the circle on the blackboard remained open. The word “Karuna” was not erased, but enough empty space was left around it.

7

On the night of the preview, fifty people were invited to the small auditorium—students, neighbours, two elderly performers, and a few families. The stage was not fully lit, only as much as necessary.

The scene from Subhadra’s third day arrived. Madhavi lifted the plate. Her voice was steady. Her fingers lingered a little on its rim.

Then came the neighbour’s line about the goat. Somewhere at the back of the auditorium an elderly woman laughed aloud. The laughter did not remain solitary; a few others laughed too.

For a moment resistance rose within Madhavi—this was a scene of grief, why were people laughing?

At that instant she remembered her mother. Not the hospital. Not death. Rather, a time when, even with fever, her mother had complained about the neighbour’s goat: “That goat is healthier than I am—give the medicine to it.”

An almost-smile came to Madhavi’s face. She did not suppress it, nor did she complete it. Carrying only that much of the memory, she spoke the next line: “When she comes back hungry, the first thing she will ask for is rice in this plate.”

The auditorium fell silent.
Madhavi did not shed tears.

Even so, something grew heavy inside her chest. The technique did not break; the private memory did not fully open itself on stage. The two touched each other and remained separate.

8

When the performance ended, Udayakant said nothing at first. He stood in the outer corridor and listened to people's reactions.

A student said, "I laughed at the goat line and then immediately felt guilty."

An elderly performer said, "Why guilt? Do people not laugh in grief?"

A woman said, "I kept watching the open doorway more than Subhadra."

Someone said, "There were no tears in her eyes, yet I cried."

Udayakant only listened.

At that moment Janki Kaki came from behind. She was past seventy, and her village had seen two great floods. Taking Madhavi's hand, she said, "Your scene was good, but I did not feel Karuna."

Madhavi was startled. "Then what?"

"Anger. Why did everyone stop searching? Seeing a woman left alone staring at the doorway reminded me of people from an old flood. Many times a search ends not because grief is exhausted, but because the system is."

Udayakant asked softly, "Then did the scene fail?"

Janki Kaki laughed. "When did I say that? A scene that brings back an old truth and raises a question—how can I call it a failure?"

She walked away. Madhavi watched her go for a while.

"Now?" she asked Udayakant.

Looking not at the blackboard but at the empty auditorium, Udayakant said, "Now I must be more careful about saying 'one rasa.'"

Madhavi said, "We will not name the spectator's experience in advance. But I will not abandon the direction of the craft either. Perhaps—" She stopped, then corrected herself. "Perhaps both things are present here together."

Udayakant said, "I should write that sentence down."

"No. Experience it first," Madhavi said with a laugh.

While removing her makeup, Madhavi asked, "What will you write on the blackboard now?"

"Nothing yet."

"Will you erase Karuna?"

"Why?"

"Because people laughed."

"Even so, did what happened at the end change the centre of the scene?"

"Perhaps not."

"Then let the word remain. And the question mark too."

9

At the review meeting the next day, the argument sharpened again. This time it was not only the actor and director; the whole group spoke.

Nishant, the composer, said, "In the tune I wrote there was no weeping note meant to manufacture Karuna. Only two notes repeated."

Deepa, the lighting designer, said, "The scene grew deeper when I lowered the light at the doorway. But was that *rasa*, or only visual composition?"

Instead of answering, Udayakant asked, "Why should visual composition be outside *rasa*?"

Madhavi said, "Then the problem is that the word '*rasa*' becomes so large that everything fits inside it."

Udayakant replied calmly, "And the other problem is that the phrase '*lived experience*' can be made so sacred that discussing craft begins to feel like a crime."

The room fell silent again.

Madhavi said softly, "That is true."

Udayakant immediately added, "And so is your point—a category cannot command the artist's body."

Deepa laughed. "Then is the argument a draw?"

Madhavi said, "The argument was not meant to be won."

10

On the day of the main performance, the auditorium was full. Backstage Madhavi was getting ready. This time Udayakant did not bring her many instructions.

He said only, "Remember the weight of the plate."

Madhavi asked, "And the door?"

"It is already open."

"Karuna?"

Udayakant smiled. "Let it not interfere with the spectator's work."

They both laughed.

Again, laughter came at the goat line. This time Madhavi had not been waiting for it. The laughter came and passed. The scene continued.

In the final moment, Subhadra reaches out to close the door, but does not close it. She only touches the frame and places the lamp just inside.

This action had not been in the original text. Madhavi and Udayakant had created it together during rehearsal.

The lamp's light fell across the threshold. Darkness outside. An empty plate within.

Madhavi's body remained still. No one in the auditorium coughed.

11

After the curtain, a teenage girl came to Madhavi. She was a student at the theatre school. She asked, "Didi, while doing that scene, were you truly sad?"

Madhavi thought for a moment. "I was truly acting."

The student looked confused. "Meaning you were not sad?"

"There was sadness too. The character's. Some of my own memories came as well. But what happened on stage is difficult to give a single name."

"Were the tears real?"

Madhavi laughed. "Do tears need a certificate?"

The student laughed too.

Madhavi added, "If there are tears but the scene feels false, what is the use? If there are no tears but something moves inside you, is that less true?"

The student thought for a moment and bowed.

After she left, Udayakant was standing nearby. He asked, "Did the memory of your mother come today?"

Madhavi looked at him. This time the question contained no command. "It did. At the goat line."

"Because I told you to remember?"

"No. Because the audience laughed. My mother had once been ill with fever and made a joke about the neighbour's goat. It came suddenly."

Udayakant was silent for a while. "So private memory entered the stage in the end after all."

"Yes. But by another path. If you had said, 'Remember your mother and cry,' the memory would no longer have felt mine. It would have become an instruction."

"And now?"

"Now it came by itself, found a place inside the scene, and went away. I did not give the whole memory to the audience. Only as much of it as the character's work needed."

Udayakant said, "Craft makes a space, and memory chooses for itself what will fill it?"

Madhavi laughed. "Another formula?"

"No. This time only a conjecture."

"Then let it remain a conjecture."

12

After everyone had left, Udayakant returned to the rehearsal room. The blackboard was still there. Under the word "Karuna" remained the old "Hasya?" Chalk dust lay along the edge.

Madhavi came back for her bag and saw Udayakant erasing "Karuna."

"Don't erase it," she said.

Udayakant stopped his hand. "Why?"

"Let it remain. Just do not treat it as the final answer."

Udayakant lifted the chalk again. "Then what should we add?"

Madhavi went to the board. From "Karuna" she drew an arrow and wrote at its end: "Within whom?"

Below it Udayakant drew another arrow: "With whom?"

For a while they both looked at the board.

Madhavi said, “I still do not think your vibhava-anubhava scheme is complete.”

“And I still do not think your ‘lived experience’ is sufficient all by itself.”

Madhavi raised an eyebrow. “All by itself.”

Udayakant burst out laughing. “Yes—all by itself is not sufficient.”

13

That night the main lights in the rehearsal room were switched off. Only the small work light on the stage remained on—the one kept for the cleaning staff.

The shadows of the five empty chairs fell in different directions. The doorframe stood without a door. The brass plate held nothing. The red gamchha was still.

The auditorium was empty, so no one there was experiencing Karuna, Hasya, or Shanta. Nor was there reason to claim that the stage itself experienced anything.

But the light kept changing the forms of things. Chair legs looked longer, the rim of the plate gleamed, the darkness inside the frame seemed deeper.

The next morning, when the group returned, those same objects would again begin to work as characters, signs, memories, and experiences.

For now there was only the lamp.

And its light—which was not itself rasa, but without which much would not be seen.

— End of Story 27 —

28. Destiny

STORY

I

Whenever Shashibhushan Jha returned after losing, he always said the same sentence: "Fate is not with me." The sentence was short, but by the time he reached home it had grown larger. Sometimes fate became rain, sometimes planets, sometimes company, sometimes the face of the man whose presence at the betting table seemed inauspicious. Lalita used to argue with all of this. Later she stopped arguing. She asked only, "How much is gone?"

That night Shashibhushan did not answer. A brass lamp burned in a corner of the veranda. Its flame was not steady; a westerly draft entering through the gap in the door bent it again and again. Lalita sat beside the bed sewing clothes. Twelve-year-old Nandan had fallen asleep inside; sixteen-year-old Ragini was studying for an examination. The house held the kind of silence in which a question rustles like paper.

"How much?" Lalita asked again.

Shashibhushan untied his gamchha and hung it on a peg. "As much as was written."

"Written by whom?"

"The One above."

Lalita pushed the needle into the cloth. "Did the One above take the money, or did you?"

Shashibhushan looked at her irritably but did not answer. That night Lalita took out an old school notebook for the first time and wrote on the cover: "Shashibhushan's Fate." Beneath it she wrote the date. Then a single line: "Today he sold paddy and received seven thousand. Five thousand went in betting. Two thousand came home."

2

Shashibhushan had not always been like this—at least that was how the family remembered him. His father kept meticulous accounts of field measurements, seed, fertiliser, and rainfall. As a teenager Shashibhushan ran away from accounts. It was not that he disliked numbers; on the contrary, he was proud of how quickly he could calculate. The problem was that the next possibility attracted him more than the result already in hand.

The first time he placed a bet at the market, he won. The amount was small—small enough that Lalita could later hear the story and laugh—but

the victory occupied far more space inside him than its size warranted. Shashibhushan said there had been three signs that day: a crow flew to the right as he left home, he met an old friend on the road, and by the time he reached the market the clouds had cleared. He never remembered whether all three things had happened the previous week as well; everything about the winning day shone.

He lost the second week. "My mind was not steady today," he said. He did not go the third week. In the fourth he went again and won. From that day on he felt he possessed a 'sense' for the game.

At first Lalita treated that sense like any other household hobby. Some people played cards, some went fishing, some read horoscopes in the newspaper. But Shashibhushan's hobby slowly became a line of expenditure. First he wagered the money he might otherwise have spent on paan, tea, and wandering through the market. Then money the household could spare. Then money put aside 'for a few days.'

Lalita's second notebook entry came three months later: "Sold bamboo from the grove for four thousand. Said he would double it in one round. Came back with eight hundred." She added no comment.

After that day Lalita made a rule: household expenses in one box, seed and fertiliser in another, the children's education in another. Shashibhushan laughed at this division. "Money is money—why give it so many names?" Lalita answered, "If we do not give it names, it will all disappear at once." Shashibhushan thought this excessive caution. To him money was a moving thing: here today, there tomorrow, perhaps doubled and back here again. To Lalita, money was responsibility tied to place—Ragini's books, Nandan's shoes, his mother's medicine, seed for the field. They looked at the same notes, but the notes meant different things to them.

Once Lalita placed a small slip of paper in one of the money boxes: "This is Nandan's school fee." Shashibhushan saw the slip, shut the box, and did not take the money that day. Lalita felt some relief. Two weeks later, when cash in the house was low, Shashibhushan borrowed from outside. The paper had protected the box, not the decision. Lalita wrote that too: "The money that had a name was saved; debt was born from the money that did not."

3

Shashibhushan's faith in luck was peculiar. If he won he said, "See? The time has turned." If he lost he said, "The time is bad." In both cases time was primary and decision secondary. There was comfort in this logic: victory proved his insight, defeat was the universe's fault.

Mukund, his childhood friend, once told him, "Your luck works very hard. When you win it makes you clever; when you lose it makes you innocent."

Shashibhushan laughed. "You do not understand. In a game you have to read the time."

"Are you reading the time, or trying to recover the last bet with the next one?"

He did not like the question. For a few days he kept away from Mukund. Later they sat together again, but spoke less about betting.

That year the flood did not come badly, yet the paddy yield was poor. Farm income fell. Household expenses were cut. When the possibility of stopping Ragini's coaching came up, Lalita said clearly, "She will not give up her studies."

Shashibhushan said, "When did I say she should?"

"Where will the money come from?"

"It will be arranged."

"Does an arrangement make itself?"

"God will provide."

Lalita fell silent. That evening she wrote in the notebook: "Three months of Ragini's fees are due. He bet twice this week." She was not writing that line to show Shashibhushan. Perhaps she was writing it for herself, so the days would not melt into one another.

4

One night Shashibhushan came home with a very large win. As he pushed open the door, his face held such light that for a moment Lalita was genuinely happy. He put fifteen thousand rupees on the table. "Didn't I tell you the time would turn?"

Ragini came out from the other room. Nandan stood nearby, eager to count the money. Fish was cooked that night, sweets arrived, and Ragini's fees were paid the next day.

That night later became dangerous in the family's memory. The fifteen thousand did not merely pay debts; it strengthened Shashibhushan's belief that all the earlier losses had only been 'temporary.'

Lalita wrote in the notebook: "Won fifteen thousand. Fees paid. Laughter in the house." After a while she added another line: "He said, now I understand the game."

Three weeks later the remainder of the fifteen thousand was gone. After that he borrowed ten thousand. The lender was an acquaintance, so no paper was made. Shashibhushan told the family, "I took it for farm work." Lalita caught the lie immediately but did not quarrel in front of everyone.

At night she asked, "What farm work?"

Shashibhushan paused. "Seed."

"There is seed at home."

"Fertiliser."

"Yesterday you said we would use only half as much fertiliser this time."

Shashibhushan was silent. Then in a tired voice he said, "It is ten thousand. I'll repay it."

"With what?"

"By winning."

For the first time Lalita neither scolded nor wept. She only said, "Write that answer down."

Shashibhushan did not understand. "What?"

“Nothing.”

That night Shashibhushan lay awake for a long time. Dogs barked outside; a train whistle sounded in the distance. More than the ten-thousand-rupee debt, what stung him was that Lalita had caught the lie at once. He told himself he had lied to protect the household—if he had told the truth there would have been a quarrel, his mother would have heard, the children would have been frightened. But another sentence kept rising inside him: if the act was right, why had it needed hiding?

The next morning he went to the field. Dew lay on the new green paddy leaves. For a while he genuinely thought he would stop now. Sitting on the embankment, he made a plan for the ten thousand in his head—five from one person, three from another, two from household savings. Then the possibility of the next bet suddenly entered the calculation: if one round went well, the whole debt could vanish at once. In that imagination the weight of the debt grew lighter. He could not see that what he was treating as the solution was feeding the problem again.

5

Betting did not consume money alone; it consumed time. Shashibhushan always said he was going for ‘one hour.’ One hour became two, three, four. Labourers waited in the field, guests sat at home, Ragini kept a chair empty for her father at school programmes—and Shashibhushan said, “I am just coming back.”

In Lalita’s notebook the accounting of time began to grow larger than the accounting of money. “Ragini’s play—did not come.” “Nandan’s fever—returned at ten at night.” “Mother had to be taken to hospital—Mukund took her on his motorcycle.”

One day Shashibhushan’s mother, Saraswati Devi, asked him, “Son, what do you find in that game that you do not find at home?”

He answered, “It is not a game. It is concentration.”

“Do people borrow money for concentration?”

Shashibhushan tried to laugh, but his mother did not.

Saraswati Devi’s question stayed with him for a few days. He did not bet for five weeks. In the evenings he came home from the fields and sat with Nandan, looked at Ragini’s mathematics problems, ate with Lalita on the roof. The atmosphere in the house lightened. Lalita wrote, “Five weeks. Repaid two thousand of the debt.”

In the sixth week Mukund met him in the market. Pleased, he said, “Good. Leave it now.”

The sentence entered Shashibhushan not as praise but as a challenge. Hearing “leave it,” he felt people were thinking him weak. He did not go to the betting place that night, but the next day he went ‘only to watch.’ On the third day he wagered a small amount. He won.

He came home and said nothing. It was the first victory he did not tell Lalita about.

The taste of a secret win was different from that of a public one. Earlier he would come home and spread the money on the table; now he repeatedly touched the folded notes in his pocket. No one at home knew, so no one asked questions. In this silence he felt a kind of freedom. He did not see that the freedom was really the beginning of severing a relationship. If the victory was not shared, then the defeat need not be shared either—or so he imagined.

For several months he lived two lives. By day there were fields, home, children; on some evenings, betting. Now and then he brought small things for the house with his winnings—a pen for Ragini, sweets for Nandan, a sari for Lalita. When asked where the money came from, he said, “An old debt was repaid in the market.” There was no violence in these lies, so he continued to think them light. But Lalita slowly began to feel that in the house some sentences had closed doors behind them.

6

Secret betting created another kind of fatalism within him. He watched for signs less now and secrecy more. If Lalita found out, ‘his nerve would break’; if Mukund appeared in front of him, ‘the bet would go bad’; if the phone rang, ‘the rhythm would break.’ Little by little he built small walls of superstition around his own choices.

Once he considered selling Nandan’s bicycle. His reason was that the boy could walk to school and would be healthier for it. Lalita tied the bicycle key into the end of her sari.

“This will not be sold,” she said.

“Am I his father or not?”

“You are. That is why it will not be sold.”

For the first time they quarrelled in a way that Nandan stood behind the door and heard everything. Later he returned the key to his mother and said, “I can walk.”

Lalita stroked his head. “This is not about whether you can walk.”

That day Lalita did not write any amount of money in the notebook. She wrote: “Nandan was ready to give up his bicycle only so there would be no quarrel at home.” After a while she added: “This loss cannot be measured in rupees.”

Shashibhushan still did not know the notebook existed.

7

In two years the debt grew from small streams into a heavy burden. There was no single day on which everything suddenly collapsed. That was why Shashibhushan could still tell his story as a story of ‘bad luck.’ Look at each piece of debt separately and none seemed impossible: five thousand, three thousand, seven, twelve, then a new loan to repay an old one. But when all those dates gathered on one page of Lalita’s notebook, they formed a pattern.

One evening it was not a moneylender but his cousin Pramod who came. Pramod had lent him money. Standing at the door, he said, "I need it myself now. Please do something by the end of the month."

Shashibhushan seated him inside. Tea was served. The conversation remained courteous. That courtesy was harder than a quarrel.

After Pramod left, Shashibhushan said, "We will sell half a kattha on the western side."

Lalita said at once, "No."

"What use is the land if debt is sitting on our heads?"

"Sell the land and repay the debt—but then another bet?"

"I will stop."

"How many times have you said that before?"

Shashibhushan's voice rose. "You do not trust me?"

For the first time Lalita brought out the notebook and placed it before him. "Trust is not something you can audit. Decisions are."

Shashibhushan read the cover: "Shashibhushan's Fate." His face hardened. "Is this a joke?"

"Not a joke. Dates."

He opened the notebook. First page, second, third. Some places recorded wins, some losses, some household events. Lalita had not written only the defeats; she had written the victories too. That was why the notebook was not simple like an indictment.

Shashibhushan read for a long time. Then he closed it and said, "The dates may be true. But you do not know what the circumstances were that day."

Turning pages, he stopped at one entry: "Kartik 21: On Father's death-anniversary evening, went out. Returned at one in the morning." His hand became still. He remembered the day clearly: rituals and guests all day, exhaustion. At night friends had said, "It will change your mood." He went. At first he won a little, then lost. When he returned, he had seen his father's photograph still on the veranda. In the notebook Lalita had written only the times; she had not written, "Left the death anniversary to gamble." The bare fact forced him to make the sentence himself.

On another page Lalita had written: "Ashadh 5: Won eight thousand. Next day: medicine for Mother, Ragini's books, household provisions." Shashibhushan stopped there too. He felt relief that Lalita had not merely accumulated black marks. The notebook was not his enemy. That made it harder to escape. Had it been only an indictment, he could have torn it up; but because it held together victory and kindness, defeat and lies, labour and absence, tearing it would have felt like tearing up pieces of his own life.

Lalita said, "That is why I did not fill every page. What I do not know, I did not write."

That night Shashibhushan kept the notebook with him. Lalita did not stop him. In the morning it lay on the table. On one page Shashibhushan had

written in his own hand: "Phagun 12: I won. If I had not won that day, perhaps I would have stopped earlier."

Lalita sat for a while after reading the line. She understood that for the first time Shashibhushan was writing his own story—still in the language of fate, but in his own hand.

For the next few weeks he stayed away from the game. The land was not sold. Part of Pramod's money was repaid by selling wheat. Ragini began tutoring younger children. Shashibhushan felt ashamed that his daughter had started earning amid the household debt, but Ragini said, "I am doing it for my own books. Not everything is your debt."

The sentence brought him relief and pain at the same time.

A wedding took place in the village around then—procession, songs, crowds, an all-night gathering. Shashibhushan had planned to eat and return. An old gambling companion whispered, "Everyone has gathered after so long."

Shashibhushan answered, "I don't play anymore."

"Did I ask you to play? Just sit with us."

That "just sit" was like the old "only to watch" that had once drawn him back in. Shashibhushan recognised the resemblance. For a moment he remembered Lalita's notebook. Then he got up and walked out.

On the way home he felt proud that he had won—not a bet, but over himself. Yet when telling the story at home he again said, "God saved me."

Lalita smiled and asked, "Did you not walk out yourself?"

Shashibhushan paused. "Yes, I did."

"Then you too were there with God."

A few months after that successful night, Shashibhushan slipped again. This time there was no wedding, no pressure from a friend. He had money from selling the farm produce and was supposed to deposit it in the bank. In the market he saw an old acquaintance. The man merely greeted him; he did not even invite him to play. Shashibhushan himself turned back. "Only five minutes," he thought. Those five minutes became two hours. The bank closed. He lost part of the money.

On his way home, for the first time he saw clearly that there was no material from which to manufacture someone else's blame for this loss. No friend, no planet, no quarrel, no sadness. The choice had been utterly ordinary—he changed his route, went inside, sat down. That ordinariness frightened him. Tragedy does not always arrive like a storm; sometimes it is only a small turn a person takes by himself.

That night Shashibhushan took out the notebook without being asked and wrote: "Today I was supposed to go to the bank. I changed the road myself. I said five minutes. I sat for two hours. Lost this much. There was no sign." After writing, he held the pen for a long time. Lalita watched from a distance. She neither praised nor scolded him. Writing the truth could not return the loss, but it could make the next road toward a lie a little narrower.

Misfortune was real—Lalita believed that too. The following year Saraswati Devi broke her hip. Hospital expenses arrived suddenly. At that time Shashibhushan was away from betting, yet the household went into debt again. No gambling decision of his had caused it. Later that year a storm destroyed half the mango grove. That too had not been his decision.

Strangely, Shashibhushan remained calm amid these events. Earlier, had such calamity come, he might have said, “See? My luck is bad.” Now he simply dealt with the hospital slips, medicine costs, and broken branches in the orchard.

One night Lalita asked, “Will you not call it fate now?”

Shashibhushan said, “This may be fate.”

“Then all the earlier things?”

“Not all.”

The small answer surprised Lalita.

Shashibhushan continued, “I did not break Mother’s bone. I did not bring the storm. But half the debt... I made that.”

Lalita said nothing. That night she wrote only one line in the notebook: “Today he said ‘not all.’”

After Saraswati Devi returned from hospital, she walked with a stick for months. One day she said to Shashibhushan, who was sitting on the veranda, “I have seen two kinds of pain. One kind falls upon us. The other we invite ourselves. The body feels both simply as pain.” Shashibhushan asked, “Then is pain smaller if we invited it ourselves?” His mother shook her head. “No. The pain is not smaller. But the question remains whether you will open the door next time.”

Her words did not sound to him like easy advice, because Saraswati Devi herself regretted several decisions—failing to send one son to the city for education, failing to support one daughter enough in a difficult time. She did not call her mistakes fate, but neither did she punish herself for life. For the first time Shashibhushan understood that accepting responsibility and destroying oneself are not the same thing.

An old habit does not end simply because a person understands it. The attraction of betting had not died inside Shashibhushan. The rattle of cards in the market made his body alert. If an acquaintance suddenly boasted of winning a large amount, calculations began by themselves inside him. He feared those calculations and then felt ashamed of the fear.

Mukund said, “An urge arriving is not the mistake. Following it is the decision.”

“Easy for you to say.”

“Yes. Because I am not inside your body. But you are inside your body.”

That sentence too went into Shashibhushan’s notebook—this time written not by Lalita but by Shashibhushan himself.

Gradually he began using the notebook for himself. On a day when the urge to bet became intense, he would write the time: "6:20 p.m.—felt the urge while returning from the market." Beneath it: "Reason? Remembered Pramod's money; wanted to repay everything at once." A little later: "Reached home. Urge decreased."

The writing performed no miracle. Twice he gambled again. The first time he lost a little; the second time he won a little. What mattered was that he no longer came back and wrote 'fate.' He wrote: "Went, though I had already decided not to go."

Lalita added nothing beneath that line.

A year later he made a new section in the notebook: "The urge came, but I did not go." There were five dates in the first month, three in the second, seven in the third. The number did not decline in a straight line. Sometimes the urge rose during festivals, sometimes with anxiety about debt, sometimes for no obvious reason. Shashibhushan saw the irregularity. Earlier he had imagined recovery as a straight line: stopping meant the desire would disappear. Now he understood that improvement could sometimes be like a road in mist—ten steps visible, then nothing, then ten steps again.

One day Mukund saw the notebook. "What do you get by writing all this?" he asked. Shashibhushan said, "At least my mind cannot rewrite last week's story however it likes." Mukund laughed. "You have become a Panji-keeper." Shashibhushan laughed too. "No. I am only shortening the lineage of my own lies."

II

Ragini began going to college. One day, for a sociology assignment, she wanted to talk about the household's financial decisions. Shashibhushan laughed. "Do not turn me into an example."

Ragini replied, "Without you the household account will be incomplete."

"Will you write that I was a gambler?"

"If that is all you are, I will write it. But you are not only that."

Shashibhushan fell silent. His daughter was neither granting him pardon nor handing down punishment. She was accepting complexity.

Ragini asked, "Why did you used to say it was fate?"

Shashibhushan thought for a long time. "Because if, after losing once, you say, 'I made a mistake,' then next time you place a restraint on yourself. If you say, 'My luck was bad,' then trying again seems reasonable."

"So fate was an excuse?"

"Sometimes an excuse. Sometimes a real belief. Even I did not understand the difference."

"And now?"

"Now I know some things are within my control and some are not. The problem is that the mind wants to push even what is within our control to the outside."

Ragini wrote in her notebook. Shashibhushan asked, “Will you write all of that?”

“Only what you said.”

He laughed. “Like your mother.”

12

It took five years to repay the debt. In the end the half-kattha plot on the western side was not sold. But an old mango tree was cut down, two calves were sold, economies were made in Ragini’s education, many of Lalita’s wishes were postponed. It was not simple to say they had ‘survived.’ The debt was repaid, but what was lost was not all numerical.

On the day Pramod took the final instalment, he wanted to make a receipt. Shashibhushan laughed. “Paper after so many years?”

Pramod said, “The paper is not for you, it is for me. So that later I do not rewrite the story from my own memory.”

The words reminded Shashibhushan of Lalita’s notebook. He came home and took it out. The early pages had yellowed. The title “Shashibhushan’s Fate” still remained.

He said to Lalita, “Shall we change the name?”

“To what?”

“Shashibhushan’s Decisions?”

Lalita shook her head. “That is not complete either. The storm, Mother, illness, the harvest—none of those were decisions.”

“Then?”

Lalita handed the notebook back to him. “Let the name remain. Whoever reads inside will understand how the meaning of the word ‘fate’ kept changing.”

13

Years later the old place in the village market had changed form. Where Shashibhushan had once sat late into the night there was now a mobile-repair shop. Nearby were tea, vegetables, seed. People had changed, though bets were still placed somewhere from time to time—some in old forms, some in new ones.

One day Nandan asked, “Babu, will you play again?”

Shashibhushan answered, “Sometimes the mind still tells me to.”

“Then what do you do?”

“I do not order the mind to be silent. I just do not immediately walk behind it.”

“Is that difficult?”

“Sometimes very.”

Nandan asked, “What if you make another mistake?”

Shashibhushan smiled. “Then I will call it a mistake. Not a planet.”

Nandan laughed. Shashibhushan did too. There was confidence in the laughter, but no certainty. He no longer wanted to offer that kind of certainty.

Later Ragini went to the city to study. In the first month she asked Lalita on the phone, "Is Babu all right?" Lalita said, "He is all right, but 'all right' no longer means the problem has vanished. It means he sees the problem." Ragini remembered the answer for a long time. After leaving home and going far away, she understood that her anger about her father was not simple either. The empty chair of childhood, anxiety over fees, the quarrel about selling the bicycle—none of that could be erased; but her father was not made only of those things.

Nandan was affected differently. He grew excessively afraid of spending money. Before buying even a small thing he asked three times. One day Shashibhushan saw him looking at a book in the market; when he heard the price, Nandan put it back. Shashibhushan said, "Take it." Nandan asked, "Is it necessary?" Shashibhushan understood that his past had left not only debt but fear inside the child. He bought the book, but also said, "Saving is good; living in fear is not." Doubt remained on Nandan's face. Such sentences take time to become believable.

14

One evening the electricity went out. The same old brass lamp that had burned on the night the story began was lit on the veranda. The brass body had blackened in several places. Lalita straightened the wick. Shashibhushan opened the last page of the old notebook.

He wrote: "Today it has been three years since the debt became zero. Two years and seven months since I last placed a bet. In between I bet twice—one loss, one win. Both times, my decision."

His pen stopped for a while. Then he wrote: "It is raining today. This is not my decision."

Outside the veranda the rain was indeed heavy. Mango leaves shone. Lightning flashed in the distance. Shashibhushan watched the lamp flame. A westerly gust came; the flame bent and then straightened.

Lalita asked, "What did you write?"

"The line between fate and decision."

"Did you find the line?"

Shashibhushan closed the notebook. "No. But I no longer write everything on the same side."

The lamp's light reached halfway across the veranda. Outside, rain, darkness, and wind moved in their own course. None of them was under Shashibhushan's control.

On the table lay the notebook, the closed pen, the receipt for the repaid debt, and beyond them the sleeping household. Amid all this, what was within his control was not small either.

29. Shabda-Brahman

STORY

I

Vinayakant Mishra stopped writing at the age of seventy-five, but he announced it to no one. The same blue inkwell, black pen, stack of paper, and old brass lamp still remained on his desk. Anyone looking in from outside would have thought the poet was at work. The only difference was that the paper had remained white for three months.

Earlier he would rise at dawn and write two lines. Sometimes weak, sometimes good. Now dawn came, he sat before the paper, uncapped the pen, wrote one word, and struck it out. One day he wrote, “water.” He looked at it for a long time. Then beneath it he wrote, “This is not water.” He crossed out both lines.

Janaki, his wife, picking stones from rice nearby, asked, “What are you writing?”

Vinayakant said, “Nothing.”

“Then why have you kept the pen uncapped for three hours?”

He did not smile. He said, “The word does not fall right.”

Janaki went on picking out the stones. “If one word does not fall right, write another.”

Vinayakant looked at her. It was not so simple—at least not for him.

2

This doubt had not begun with any book of philosophy. Two years earlier his younger brother Naresh had died. Vinayakant was asked to write a few lines for the condolence meeting. He wrote, “Naresh was a simple man.” The moment he read the line he felt uneasy. Was Naresh simple? He had been stubborn too, envious too, generous too, miserly too—when circumstances changed, the man changed with them. The word “simple” fell over an entire life like a small lid.

He crossed out “simple” and wrote “generous.” Then he remembered the time Naresh had refused to lend money to his sister. He crossed out “generous” as well. In the end he wrote only, “Naresh was. Now he is not.”

The convener of the memorial had asked him again, “Write a little more; people will understand what he was like.” Confronted by that request, Vinayakant felt for the first time that silence too was not complete justice. If he wrote nothing, Naresh’s life would become only a date; if he wrote an

adjective, a life larger than a date would shrink into an adjective. That night he filled eight pages—childhood quarrels, Naresh's courage while crossing the river, his hardness over his sister's loan, the month he served their mother when she was ill—then tore up every page. The problem was not a shortage of words but the act of choosing. What was written would stand in the light; what was omitted would remain in darkness.

After this realization, he began to doubt his own vocation. A poet spends a lifetime choosing—what to illuminate, what to leave out. Earlier he had called it craft; now at times it seemed like power.

When the line was read at the meeting, people said, "Very profound." Vinayakant felt ashamed. To him the line was not profound; it was helpless.

From that day onward words began to seem like suspect objects. If he wrote "mother," he thought—not all mothers are one. If he wrote "home," he wondered—is home brick, relationship, memory, or the place one longs to return to? If he wrote "sorrow," he asked—whose sorrow? The body's, the mind's, humiliation's, hunger's? How could one word contain so many different lives?

3

Vinayakant took out his old poems and began to read them. On lines he had once been proud of, he now placed question marks. "Darkness weeps"—darkness does not weep. "The earth is tired"—the earth is not a human being. "The river is a mother"—a river drowns people too. Metaphors began to look like deceptions to him.

One day his granddaughter Anvi saw his papers. She was nine and had come with her mother for the holidays. She asked, "Baba, why so many question marks?"

"I am looking at old mistakes."

Anvi read a poem: "The lamp eats darkness." She laughed. "The lamp eats darkness?"

Vinayakant grew serious. "No. That is why the line is not right."

Anvi laughed again. "But it sounds nice."

"Sounding nice is not truth."

"In stories elephants talk. That is not truth either."

Vinayakant wanted to answer, but stopped. With a pencil Anvi drew a little mouth beside the lamp, in which the lamp was eating darkness. Vinayakant did not tear up the page.

That evening, while sorting old papers, he found a letter from twenty years earlier. A reader from Saharsa had written: "I read your poem 'Mother.' My mother was not gentle like the mother in your poem. She spoke sharply, lost her temper, and many times treated me unjustly too. At first the poem irritated me. Later I understood that the poem gave me the courage to say: my mother was not like this." Vinayakant read the letter twice. The poem had not portrayed that woman's mother; instead, it had given her a surface against which she could see the difference. This did not give any clear answer to his new doubt, but it changed the shape of the question.

4

A few weeks later a young university lecturer named Saurabh came to see him. He was researching Vinayakant's poetry. He wanted new poems from him.

"Have you stopped writing?" Saurabh asked.

Vinayakant said, "Perhaps."

"Why?"

"A word is not the thing. It is not the experience. We say the word 'hunger,' but where in those four letters is what happens inside the body of someone who has not eaten for three days?"

Saurabh thought for a while. "But because a word is not the experience, how does that make it useless?"

"What if the reader takes the word for the experience?"

"Then is the fault in the word, or in its use?"

Vinayakant did not grow irritated. He noted down the question. For the first time in three months there was a complete sentence on his paper that had not been crossed out: "Is the fault in the word, or in its use?"

At night he read the sentence again. He tried to write an answer beneath it. He could write nothing.

5

The language of the household remained indifferent to his doubt. In the morning Janaki would say, "Bring two seers of potatoes." Vinayakant would return from the market with two seers of potatoes. He did not ask whether the word "potato" contained the shape, taste, soil, and history of every potato. Anvi would say, "Baba, give me water." He would fill a glass. No one drank the word "water" thinking it was water; the word pointed out the way, it did not become the thing.

One evening Janaki called from the kitchen, "The dal is burning."

Vinayakant went inside. The smell of the dal had indeed changed. He lowered the flame.

Janaki said, "See? You understood as soon as you heard, 'The dal is burning.'"

Vinayakant asked, "How did you understand what I meant by 'burning'? I did not tell you the exact temperature."

Janaki looked at him with a gaze that held both affection and annoyance. "I had to save the dal, not do philosophy."

That night Vinayakant laughed for the first time in many days.

The next day Janaki called from the veranda, "Pick up that cup." There were three cups on the table. Deliberately Vinayakant asked, "Which one?" Janaki came out and pointed to the cup with the red rim. "This one." Vinayakant said, "See, 'that cup' was not enough." Taking the cup, Janaki replied, "That is why you asked. Language does not say everything in one go; people ask again."

That answer went into Vinayakant's notebook. It seemed to him that perhaps one crisis of literature lay in the expectation that a single sentence

must tell an entire world at once. At home people said incomplete things, someone else asked, and then the conversation grew. Could the reader of a poem ask again? When the writer was no longer alive, who would answer? The question opened again.

6

Even so, writing did not return. Though he had accepted that ordinary speech worked, poetry still seemed difficult to him. Saying “two seers of potatoes” in the market had a purpose. Toward what did a poem point? If it was not the experience itself, not the object, not an instruction—then what was it?

He opened a new notebook. On the cover he wrote, “The Limits of Words.” On the first page he made three columns: “What I can say,” “What changes as soon as I say it,” “What I do not know.”

In the first column he wrote: “The door is closed.”

In the second: “I am sad.”

For a long time he wrote nothing in the third. Then he wrote “death” and crossed it out.

Janaki saw the notebook. “Is this an account book?”

“Of language.”

“Does language obey so much accounting?”

“I do not know.”

Janaki pointed toward the third column. “Then write that sentence there.”

Vinayakant wrote “I do not know” in the third column. After a while he did not cross it out.

Beside that notebook lay his father’s old dictionary. Vinayakant looked up the word “home.” The meaning given was: “place of residence; dwelling.” He looked up “residence”—“place where one lives.” He looked up “place”—“location.” The words kept sending him toward one another, like narrow lanes in a village—one bend leading to another, but nowhere a single courtyard where it was written, “This is the complete meaning of home.” Earlier this circle would have seemed futile to him. Now it appeared somewhat different. Perhaps a dictionary did not put the thing into one’s hand; it showed a web of use.

Janaki came in. Seeing the dictionary open, she asked, “What are you looking for?” Vinayakant said, “Home.” Janaki looked around—wall, table, chest, window, the courtyard with the tulsi plant. “Can you not see all this?” Vinayakant laughed. “I am looking in the dictionary.” Janaki shook her head. “In the dictionary you will find the meaning of home, not home.” The sentence stayed with Vinayakant for a long time. Meaning and object were not the same—he already knew that; the question now was whether being different made meaning useless.

He did not write “home” in the third column. Instead he wrote: “Is meaning a road, not a place?” He left the question mark. This time the question mark did not feel like defeat.

7

That autumn Janaki fell ill. At first it seemed an ordinary fever, but two days later her breathing quickened. She had to be taken to hospital. Vinayakant had spent his life writing poems about other people's sorrow, yet sitting beside the hospital bed he could find no suitable sentence.

Janaki opened her eyes beneath the oxygen tube. "Did you water the tulsi at home?"

Vinayakant started. "No."

"When Anvi comes, her red sweater is in the upper chest."

"Please be quiet."

Janaki smiled. "'Be quiet' is also made of words."

Vinayakant's eyes filled. He wanted to say "fear," wanted to say "love," wanted to say "stay." In the end he said only, "I am here."

Janaki closed her eyes. "I know."

Later Vinayakant thought a great deal about those two sentences. "I am here." "I know." Both sentences were far smaller than the actual situation, yet that night their smallness—he immediately wrote "perhaps"—was not a failure.

At the hospital a nurse had asked Janaki, "On a scale from zero to ten, how much is the pain?" Janaki laughed first. "Can pain be counted too?" The nurse said, "Not completely. But I need some indication to give the medicine." Janaki said seven. Half an hour later, five. Vinayakant kept watching those small numbers. Seven was not Janaki's pain; yet seven was not meaningless. The number did not take the place of pain, it merely opened a path toward treatment. Perhaps words too could be indications of this kind—the thought came to him, but he did not immediately turn it into a conclusion.

8

Janaki recovered and returned home. Vinayakant began sitting at the desk again. Still not writing. He listened to the sentences of the house.

"The salt is low."

"You left the door open."

"The wind is strong today."

"Anvi called."

"This cup has broken."

There was no cosmic proclamation in these sentences. Yet each one changed something—the salt was added, the door was shut, the broken cup removed, the call returned. Words were not objects, but within relationships they did work.

One day Vinayakant said to Janaki, "Perhaps the truth of a word does not lie in being complete, but in falling into the right relation."

That week their daughter Mrinalini called. It was raining in Delhi. She said, "Baba, there is so much water here." Vinayakant looked through the window at his dry courtyard. The same word, "water," was joining two worlds in two places—there the road was flooded, here the soil around the

tulsi was dry. Mrinalini asked, "Is Mother well?" Vinayakant said, "She is better now." Inside "better" were medicines, weakness, the fear of the night, diminished appetite—many things were omitted. Yet his daughter understood that the immediate danger had passed. Later Janaki herself explained the details on the phone. The first sentence had opened the door; the whole house became visible afterward.

Janaki asked, "Is this poetry?"

"No."

"Good. Otherwise I would have asked what it means."

9

Saurabh came again. This time he brought an old audio recording—a poetry reading by Vinayakant from thirty years earlier. The young Vinayakant was declaiming, "Words themselves create the world." The old Vinayakant listened uneasily.

"Do you still believe this?" Saurabh asked.

"Not in so simple a form."

"Then what about the lecture you were going to give under the title 'Shabda-Brahman'?"

Vinayakant laughed. "If I gave that lecture now, the first sentence would be: 'I am not certain.'"

"That is not a bad beginning."

"People come to hear certainty."

"Sometimes people also come to hear where a scholar is uncertain."

Vinayakant played the recording again. The young voice was his own, yet like an old room in one's own house—familiar, and still far away. He did not erase it.

After Saurabh left, Vinayakant found his old lecture titled "Shabda-Brahman." On the first page he had written: "Without words, the world for human beings is an unnamed chaos; by naming, the thing becomes intelligible." Now beneath it, in pencil, he wrote: "By naming, the thing also changes." He added a third line: "Sometimes a name creates the illusion of possession over the thing." Then a fourth: "Sometimes, without a name, pain can never be shared."

The four lines did not cancel one another; each limited the others. Earlier, had Vinayakant seen a page like this, he would have called it a failed argument. Now it seemed honest.

10

A few days later Anvi sat down to write a poem for school. The subject was "My Home." Her first line was: "My home laughs." Vinayakant's old doubt immediately stirred. A house does not laugh. He opened his mouth to say so.

Anvi herself asked, "Baba, does a house laugh?"

Vinayakant paused. "Bricks do not laugh."

"Then is the line wrong?"

Vinayakant looked at the veranda. Janaki was laughing as she spoke with a neighbour. Sunlight was sliding across the wall. The smell of cumin came from the kitchen.

“If you know that bricks do not laugh, but with this line you are saying something about how your home feels, then first see whether that feeling is true.”

Anvi asked, “Then should I keep it?”

“The decision is yours.”

Anvi kept the line. Vinayakant did not snatch away the pencil.

Two days later Anvi returned from school and told him that the teacher had smiled on reading “My home laughs,” but her classmate Aarushi had said, “My home is very quiet.” Anvi had replied, “Then write differently about your home.” Vinayakant listened in silence. One line had not become the truth of all homes; instead, it had given another girl room to state her difference. He remembered the old reader’s letter. Sometimes words create likeness, sometimes they reveal difference. In both cases their work depends on context.

II

That night, after a long time, Vinayakant began a poem. He gave it no title. The first line he wrote was: “A lamp is burning.”

He looked at the line. A lamp really was burning. There was no metaphor here.

He wrote the second line: “The light reaches the table.” This too could be seen.

When he came to write the third line, his pen stopped. The phrase came to him: “Darkness draws back.” Immediately the old objection rose—darkness does not move. He did not write the line.

After a while he wrote: “Beyond the table I cannot see clearly.”

There were four lines. Was it a poem, or a description? He did not know. He did not tear up the page.

Then he remembered Naresh. He felt like writing: “My brother stands outside the darkness.” He laughed at himself; Naresh was standing nowhere. Then he thought: “My brother is in memory.” That too was not wholly right; memory was not a fixed vessel but something that changed day by day. In the end he added nothing. Earlier such a stoppage would have seemed defeat; this time stopping felt like a decision of craft in itself—not to fill what he did not know merely in order to complete a line.

Janaki called from inside, “Aren’t you coming to sleep?”

Vinayakant said, “I am coming.”

As he said it, he rose. “I am coming” was a promise about the future, not a complete experience. Yet Janaki understood.

The next morning Vinayakant opened the page again. The four lines were still there. The absence of the third line bothered him. He left a blank space in the middle. Beneath it he wrote the date.

He felt like sending the poem to Saurabh, then stopped. He wanted to show it to Anvi, but she had gone to school. Janaki set down tea and asked, "Did you write?"

Vinayakant answered, "Something."

"A poem?"

He looked at the page. "I do not know."

Janaki pushed the tea toward him. "All right."

Vinayakant watched the steam rise from the tea. "All right"—two words. Those two words did not contain Janaki's whole mind, their fifty years of marriage, the night of illness, Vinayakant's doubt. Yet the sentence was not empty.

He opened the first page of the notebook, where he had written "The Limits of Words." Beneath it he added a new line: "To have limits is not to be useless."

After a while he wrote "Shabda-Brahman." Then he could not decide whether he had made it a title or a question. He wanted to place a question mark after the word, but did not.

The lamp on the table was now extinguished; morning light was entering through the window. The light fell on the paper, but it did not fill every blank place on it.

Vinayakant did not cap the pen. It remained open.

After the meal Anvi returned. She saw the four lines on the table. "Baba, is this a poem?" Vinayakant said, "Read it and tell me." Anvi read, stopped at the blank space in the middle. "Something is missing here." Vinayakant said, "Yes." "What?" "I do not know." Anvi picked up a pencil as if to write something in the blank, then looked toward Baba. Vinayakant did not stop her, but Anvi herself put the pencil down. "Leave it. We'll write later."

Vinayakant asked, "Who will write it?" Anvi shrugged. "You, me, someone." She ran off. Vinayakant kept looking at the blank space. He did not know whether he had become a poet again. But for the first time in three months the white page did not feel like an accusation. It felt like possibility—limited, incomplete, but open.

30. Impermanence

STORY

I

Sudha Devi was seventy-eight when the first hammer fell on a wall of her house.

That morning she rose at four as on any ordinary day. She offered water at the tulsi platform, swept the courtyard, washed the brass lota kept near the stove, then sat on the small eastern veranda and drank tea. The only difference was that in the middle of the courtyard lay the bamboo poles, ropes, hammers, and iron crowbars of three labourers.

The house had already been emptied. The old grain bin was no longer in the storeroom; her son Madhukant had arranged for it to be kept in a neighbour's empty shed. The images from the prayer room had moved into a temporary tin room. Bedding, trunks, clothes, old books—all had been tied into bundles. Yet even emptied, the house did not look empty. Stains on the walls, soot on the rafters, nail scratches on the doorframe, worn bricks in the middle of the courtyard—each remained in its place.

The mason Ramphal came to Sudha Devi and asked, "Mother, shall we take down the back wall first?"

Sudha Devi set down her clay cup of tea. "Do whatever is safest."

Ramphal paused a little. Perhaps he had expected the old woman to say—do not break this, save that. But Sudha Devi said nothing of the sort.

The first blow struck the wall where the cow had once been tethered. Lime flaked down. At the second blow a brick shifted. At the third, a piece of the wall fell inward. The smell of dust rose—damp earth, old cow-dung plaster, smoke, and something else Sudha Devi could not name.

The smell suddenly brought back the first year of her marriage. The wall had been new then. She herself had plastered it with mud and cow dung while her mother-in-law Sita Devi called from behind, "What kind of plastering is that? Move your hand straight."

Sudha Devi looked at her palm. The mud of that day was no longer on a seventy-eight-year-old hand. Memory was.

Ramphal raised the hammer again.

2

The house had been built by Madhukant's grandfather Gangadhar. At first there had been two mud rooms, then a brick veranda at the back, then

another room, then a covered entrance at the front. The house had not been built all at once; it had grown with the family.

Madhukant had brought an engineer from Patna. The engineer tapped the walls, inspected the roof, dug near the foundation and said, "The southern section is settling. If rain continues like this for another two or four years, the roof will become unsafe."

Sudha Devi had said nothing that day. At night Madhukant asked, "Won't repairs be enough?"

"Mother, it has already been repaired three times. The wooden beams are rotting from within. If we build a new house, everything you need can be on the ground floor."

"Do I need convenience, or a house?"

Madhukant had fallen silent.

A few days later her granddaughter Mrinal came from Delhi. She was studying architecture. She drew a plan of the house, measured every room, and photographed the old doorframes, ventilators, and beams. Sudha Devi watched her.

"Will you save everything?" Sudha Devi asked.

Mrinal said, "Not everything can be saved, Dadi. Whatever is in good condition, we'll use in the new house. Some bricks, two doorframes, the old pillar..."

"And what cannot be saved?"

Mrinal thought before answering. "Its photographs will remain."

Sudha Devi laughed. "Will the smell remain in the photographs?"

Mrinal laughed too, but did not answer.

That night Sudha Devi admitted for the first time that the house would be demolished. The decision was not against her will; she herself could see that the roof leaked in the rains, the back room's wall was cracking, snakes had emerged twice. Yet understanding utility and accepting separation from an object were not the same task.

3

The next day the roof of the storeroom was removed. While a beam was being taken out, an old iron hook was found. The moment Sudha Devi saw it she said, "Your Babuji used to hang his umbrella here."

Madhukant's hand stopped. His father Raghuvir had been dead for twenty-two years.

"Shall we keep this hook?" Mrinal asked.

Sudha Devi said, "Why the hook?"

"Baba's umbrella..."

"The umbrella is not here. This is a hook."

Mrinal stared at her grandmother in surprise. Yesterday this woman had spoken of photographs that could not preserve smell; today she was willing to throw away a hook tied to memory.

Sudha Devi understood. “If we keep every object, the house will become just as heavy again. We need not pile up old things in the name of preserving memory.”

Madhukant smiled. “Then you tell us what to keep.”

“I do not know yet.”

The answer felt light even to Sudha Devi. For years she had known the place of every object in the house. Which room received less sun, which brick became wet first in the rains, which beam had termites—everything. But for the first time, not knowing what should be saved did not feel wrong.

When the storeroom wall came down, the bamboo grove behind it became visible. Sudha Devi was astonished. She had never before seen that view from inside the house.

“The bamboo is this close from here?” she said.

Mrinal laughed. “Dadi, the bamboo was always this close. The wall was in between.”

Sudha Devi kept thinking about that sentence for a long time.

4

On the third day Mrinal noticed five pencil lines on one wall. Faded names were written above them—Madhu 1981, Veena 1983, Shashi 1987, Mrinal 2009...

“Look at this!” she cried.

Sudha Devi came over. This was the wall where the children’s heights had been measured. When Madhukant was small, Raghuvir had drawn the line in pencil. Later Sudha Devi herself kept adding the years.

Mrinal immediately took out her phone. “Don’t break this wall. Can we cut out the whole strip and save it?”

Ramphal scratched his head. “The wall is old, bitiya. The moment we loosen the bricks, the lines may break.”

Mrinal’s face fell.

Sudha Devi touched the wall. Lime came off on her palm. “Take a photograph.”

“Dadi, aren’t you sad?”

“I am.”

“Then shall we save it?”

“Can every cause of sadness be saved?”

Mrinal fell silent.

Sudha Devi said, “Those lines were once heights. Now Madhu is taller than I am, Veena is in her own home, Shashi has lost half the hair on his head, and you study in Delhi. The wall has held the lines still. The people did not remain still.”

Mrinal took the photograph. Ramphal lifted the hammer. The first blow landed beside the lines. At the second blow, “Madhu 1981” split in two. Mrinal turned her face away.

Sudha Devi did not. She felt it was necessary to watch.

5

On the fourth day of demolition it rained. Work stopped. Half the house stood, half lay open. The veranda had no roof, so rain fell directly on the place where bedding had been spread for forty years.

Sudha Devi sat at the doorway of the temporary tin room and watched.

Her daughter Veena said on the phone, "Mother, come stay with me for a few months. Why remain there amid dust and rain?"

"I am fine."

"If the house itself won't remain, what is there for you?"

Sudha Devi wanted to answer—the house is here. Then she looked at the half-broken wall before her. She said, "The work is going on."

Veena insisted again. Sudha Devi did not go. Did she want to watch the new house being built, or the old one coming to an end? She herself did not know.

The rain grew heavier. Mud ran into a small stream across the courtyard. Red grains of vermilion could be seen flowing in it. When the prayer room had been dismantled, the old vermilion stain on the wall had mixed into the dust.

Sudha Devi remembered the days after her mother-in-law's death, when she had managed the prayer room alone for the first time. Then the lamp she had placed there after Raghuvir's ashes were immersed. Then the news of Mrinal's birth, heard in that same place.

The rain carried the red grains toward the drain. Sudha Devi did not rise to stop them.

At night Madhukant asked, "Mother, are you sad?"

"I am."

"Shall we stop the demolition?"

"No."

"Then?"

Sudha Devi said, "Being sad is not always a reason to stop the work."

6

On the fifth day the wall of the old kitchen came down. A layer of soot appeared inside it. Mrinal photographed it and said, "This looks like a map."

Sudha Devi laughed. "It is smoke."

"Smoke can make a map too."

Sudha Devi looked at her. "Your education is very expensive; did they teach you to call smoke a map?"

Mrinal burst out laughing. Ramphal laughed too.

Amid the laughter an old scene came back to Sudha Devi—Raghuvir entering the kitchen and saying, "Too much salt again today?" She answering irritably, "Make it yourself." Raghuvir laughing. An ordinary quarrel. Not a decisive event in anyone's life. Why did memory preserve moments whose importance had not been visible at the time?

She said to Mrinal, "Your grandfather liked less salt."

Mrinal laughed. "Shall I write that down?"

“No.”

“Why?”

“Does everything have to be written?”

Mrinal lowered her phone.

That day, for the first time, Sudha Devi told Mrinal to take fewer photographs. “Some things, just look at them. They won’t be here later, so look now.”

Mrinal asked, “What if I forget?”

“Forgetting too is part of life.”

The moment she said it, Sudha Devi herself fell silent. She could no longer fully remember the plan of her maternal home. In which corner had the well been? Sometimes it seemed north, sometimes west. Did that make the life in her maternal home false?

No. Memory is incomplete; that does not cause life to cease having happened.

7

On the sixth day soil was removed near the foundation. A small clay horse emerged—one ear broken, its colour almost gone.

Madhukant said, “This must be mine! I brought it from a fair when I was a child.”

Veena, who had arrived that day, immediately said, “No, it was mine. I used to play at worship with it.”

Brother and sister began to argue.

Sudha Devi took the horse in her hand. She looked at it for a long time. “It is neither yours nor hers.”

“Then?” both asked.

“I do not remember whose it was.”

Madhukant said, “Mother, you have forgotten.”

“Yes.”

Veena laughed. “Then both of us are making our own stories.”

Sudha Devi handed the horse to Mrinal. “Write on it: ‘Whose it was is not known.’”

Mrinal asked, “Shall we keep it?”

“Keep it. Because it is beautiful, not because it is evidence.”

Everyone laughed.

The clay horse remained on the tulsi platform until evening. At night a cat knocked it down. The other ear broke too. Mrinal was distressed. Sudha Devi picked up the piece and said, “Has it become more beautiful now?”

Mrinal understood her grandmother’s irony. “You turn everything into an examination.”

“No. I am learning too.”

8

On the seventh day, when the main doorway was being removed, Sudha Devi stopped them.

"Keep this doorframe."

Ramphal said, "The wood is rotten at the bottom."

"Not all of it. Cut out what is sound."

Mrinal immediately asked, "Shall we put it in the new house?"

Sudha Devi thought. Through this doorway she had entered on her wedding day. Through it Raghuvir's bier had gone out. Madhukant had gone to school for the first time, Veena had left as a bride, Mrinal had run inside during holidays—all through this doorway.

"Not as the main doorway of the new house," Sudha Devi said. "Make a bench for the veranda."

"A bench from a doorframe?" Madhukant asked.

"Why must a doorway remain a doorway forever?"

Ramphal smiled. "I will do that."

The upper beam of the frame was removed. Its inner part was surprisingly hard. Ramphal cut away the rotten portion. Mrinal touched the sawn surface. The wood inside was still pale yellow.

Sudha Devi understood—the blackness outside was not the whole wood. But neither was the yellow inside the one "true" wood. Both were different layers of time.

That evening, for the first time, the entire courtyard could be seen without the main doorway. The lane came straight inward. Sudha Devi felt a little unsafe. At night she had the tin enclosure shut. The philosophy of impermanence in its place; caution against thieves in its own.

9

By the eighth day the house was almost gone. Only an eastern wall, the tulsi platform, and the two pillars of the entrance remained.

Sudha Devi sat in the shade of that wall. Mrinal opened the plan and explained the new house—"Your room here, the bathroom here, a low cot here, and here a window opening toward the courtyard."

"Why is the courtyard small?"

"There is only this much land; if the rooms grow, the courtyard shrinks."

"Make the rooms smaller."

Madhukant objected, "Mother, where will guests stay?"

"Will guests eat the courtyard?"

The argument continued for half an hour. In the end the plan was altered. One room became slightly narrower, and the courtyard grew by two cubits.

Mrinal said, "Dadi, you are leaving the old house, but not your old habits."

Sudha Devi replied, "A courtyard is not a habit. It is a place to see the sky."

“Then do you want this to be permanent?”

Sudha Devi looked up. Clouds were moving. “Is the sky permanent, or does that change too?”

Mrinal was about to say something, then laughed. “Are you teaching philosophy now?”

“No. We are making the courtyard two cubits larger.”

Both laughed.

Sudha Devi found pleasure in that laughter. Change did not mean abandoning every old thing; fighting for some things too was part of change.

IO

On the day the new foundation was dug, a problem arose. The old tulsi platform stood in the middle of the plan. The mason said it would have to be removed.

Madhukant looked toward Sudha Devi. This time he was certain his mother would stop them.

Sudha Devi went to the platform. The bricks were cracked. The upper plaster had been renewed many times. The tulsi plant itself had dried two years earlier; a new sapling stood in an earthen pot beside it.

“Remove it,” she said.

Madhukant asked in surprise, “Will a new platform be built?”

“Yes. In the eastern corner of the courtyard.”

“The old bricks?”

Sudha Devi pulled out a brick and looked at it. It was damp within, its edge crumbling. “If two or four remain sound, use them.”

“And the rest?”

“In the rubble.”

Mrinal asked, “Dadi, you lit a lamp on this platform for fifty years.”

“Did I light the lamp for the bricks or for the tulsi?”

Mrinal was silent.

“And sometimes for my own mind,” Sudha Devi added.

The platform was broken. Beneath it was ordinary soil. No hidden vessel, no coin, no miracle. Sudha Devi liked that ordinariness. There was no rule that every old object must contain a secret.

II

The first morning after the old house had been completely removed felt strange. Sudha Devi came out of the tin room and for a few moments could not orient herself. The wall that had blocked the eastern light every day was gone. The first ray of the sun fell directly on the place where the dark storeroom had once stood.

Countless tiny particles glittered in the dust. The ground was uneven—piles of brick, broken tiles, pieces of wood. It was not a beautiful sight. But the light was extraordinary.

Sudha Devi called Mrinal. "Look."

Mrinal came out. "At what?"

"Morning sunlight must have been coming here all along. I never saw it."

"There was a wall."

"Yes."

They stood silent for a while.

Sudha Devi remembered the bamboo grove of the previous day—the bamboo had always been near; the wall had been in between. Now the light too had always been there. The house had blocked it, and the same house had sheltered her. One thing could protect and obstruct at once—this did not fit into an easy conclusion.

Mrinal said, "Shall I take a photograph?"

Sudha Devi said, "No. Look now."

12

Construction began. The foundation lines were marked. Within the shape of the old house, the shape of the new one settled larger here, smaller there. In some places a new wall crossed the middle of an old room; in others the place of an old doorway would become open courtyard.

Sudha Devi did not spend the whole day watching the labourers. After the first weeks, daily life gathered around her again—buying milk, taking medicine, talking with the neighbour, arguing with Mrinal, Veena's phone calls.

One day she noticed that for three days no particular memory of the old house had come to her. She felt guilty. Had the house receded so quickly?

At night she began testing herself—could she remember Raghuvir's voice? Her mother-in-law's face? Madhukant's childhood? The smoke in the kitchen? Everything came in dim and bright patches. Some clear, some incomplete.

She did not become afraid. Earlier perhaps she would have. Now it seemed to her that memory was like the walls of a house—some layers would fall, some inner colours would appear, some names would be erased. That did not make the time that had passed cease to exist.

The next day Mrinal showed her the bench made from the old doorframe. Ramphal had planed the wood into a simple bench. Half the old carving remained, half had been cut away.

"Do you recognize it?" Mrinal asked.

Sudha Devi sat down. "No. It is good."

Mrinal was startled. "You don't recognize it?"

"I do. But now it is a bench. Why punish it by forcing it to remain a doorframe?"

Mrinal sat beside her grandmother.

13

Three months later the roof of the new house was laid. Rain came again. This time water ran through the new drain. Two cubits of the old courtyard had been kept open as bare earth. In the eastern corner stood the new tulsi platform—four old bricks within it, the rest new.

On the day of the house-entering ceremony, Veena asked, “Mother, are you remembering the old house?”

Sudha Devi said, “I am.”

“Sad?”

“That too.”

“Do you like the new house?”

“That too.”

Veena laughed. “Both at once?”

“Why not?”

In the afternoon relatives walked around inspecting the house. Someone said the old house had had more joy. Someone said the new house was clean and convenient. Someone mourned that the old courtyard had grown smaller; someone was delighted by the bathroom. Sudha Devi listened to all the opinions. She no longer felt the need to gather evidence in favour of the house.

By evening the crowd thinned. Mrinal placed the bench on the veranda. Sudha Devi sat there. A new wall stood before her, but a small ventilator had deliberately been left high in it. A thin band of eastern light entered through it.

Mrinal said, “This ventilator is for your morning sunlight.”

Sudha Devi looked up. “The sunlight is not mine.”

“All right—for the house.”

“Not the house’s either.”

Mrinal laughed. “Then whose?”

“Whoever comes.”

14

After everyone slept, Sudha Devi walked slowly through the new house. The rooms smelled of lime, cement, and new wood. Not of the old house. For a moment she felt an acute absence. She wished that at least the kitchen might hold the old smell of smoke, the veranda the smell of Raghuvir’s hair oil, the storeroom the smell of grain. There was nothing.

She sat on the veranda bench. In one corner of the wood a small scratch from the old doorframe had survived. She ran a finger over it. Memories came—the day of her wedding, Raghuvir’s bier, the children running. Then the memories scattered by themselves.

At such a moment Sudha Devi would once have clung to memory. That night she removed her finger.

A lamp was burning on the new tulsi platform. Mrinal had lit it at dusk. The flame trembled; its shadow fell on the new wall, broke apart, then joined again.

Sudha Devi noticed—the lamp was not the same one that had burned on the old platform. The oil was new, the wick was new, even the vessel was new. But the light had no objection to this.

At that moment she remembered the word “anitya,” which she had once heard in a discourse. Then the word had seemed like distant knowledge. Now she did not want to explain its meaning. The meaning stood before her—the new wall, the old wood, the changed courtyard, people who remained in memory, and her own ageing body.

She thought—if everything changes, love is not therefore futile; perhaps it is because love’s time is limited that it is precious. But she stopped herself at once. The sentence was becoming too beautiful. Life did not always give such beautiful conclusions. When Raghuvir died, sorrow was simply sorrow. When the old house came down, dust was simply dust.

She let the conclusion go. She kept watching the lamp.

15

A few weeks later Mrinal was to return to Delhi. Before leaving she gave her grandmother a thick folder—the plan of the old house, photographs, measurements, and copies of the height marks found on the demolished wall.

“Keep it,” she said.

Sudha Devi opened the folder. “Madhu 1981” had been printed clearly.

“It is good,” she said.

“Where shall we keep it?”

Sudha Devi looked toward the new cupboard, then toward the bench.

“In the cupboard. But not on top—there is no need to see it every day.”

Mrinal asked, “Aren’t you afraid we will all forget?”

Sudha Devi thought for a while. “We will forget some things. Some we will not remember correctly. Some things you will remember that I cannot. There were some things no one will remember.”

“Then?”

“They were still lived.”

Mrinal embraced her grandmother. Sudha Devi laughed and said, “When you go to Delhi, keep calling. Live too, before you become a memory.”

Mrinal left.

At dawn Sudha Devi swept the new courtyard. There was less dust, but leaves had fallen again. Two new leaves had emerged on the young tulsi plant; one older leaf had turned yellow. She plucked off the yellow leaf, threw it away, and gave the plant water.

Sitting on the veranda bench with her tea, she watched the light entering through the eastern ventilator. The strip of brightness moved slowly across the wall. After a while it would no longer be there; at noon it would be somewhere else; by evening it would vanish.

Sudha Devi thought of no way to stop it.

She simply watched for as long as the light remained there.

— *End of Story 30* —

31. Self and Non-Self

STORY

I

Aniruddha Jha was a forty-four-year-old actor. He had been on the stage for twenty years, but he had never before been given a role like Damodar.

The play was called "The House Within the Shadow." Damodar was a sixty-five-year-old former records clerk who had left his family after the death of his younger brother and returned twenty years later. He had few lines; much of him existed in the way he walked, in pauses, in the habits of his hands, and in unfinished sentences.

At the very first rehearsal, the director, Shekhar Sen, had said, "Do not play this character by making him old. Put time inside him."

Aniruddha had laughed. "Where am I supposed to bring time from?"

Shekhar had said, "From the walk. From the breath. From the weight of what he does not say."

During the first week Aniruddha learned only the walk. Damodar did not quite drag his right foot; his heel merely reached the floor a moment late. Before answering, he drew one long breath through his nose, scratched the nail of his forefinger with his left thumb, and, when faced with a difficult question, looked slightly to the right instead of straight ahead.

Aniruddha wrote in his notebook: "Heel late. Breath. Nail. Gaze right."

That day, as he took off his shoes after reaching home, Arya asked, "What happened to your foot?"

Aniruddha started. "Nothing."

"You are walking a little differently."

He immediately straightened himself. "The effect of rehearsal."

Arya laughed. "Leave the stage at the door when you come home."

Aniruddha laughed too. At the time, the sentence seemed light.

2

Damodar's memories had been written by the playwright: an imaginary town called Sonbarsa; a red tin trunk on the eastern bank of a pond; the bamboo flute of his younger brother Naresh; rice with jaggery that his mother liked; and one rainy night when Damodar left home.

There was no Sonbarsa in Aniruddha's own life. His childhood had passed through rented houses in Darbhanga city; he had no younger brother.

His mother was alive and lived in Patna. The red tin trunk belonged only to the play.

Even so, during rehearsals Shekhar would say, “See the object. Why is the trunk red? What sound does its lid make when it opens? How much dust is there on the flute?”

Aniruddha closed his eyes and supplied details: rust at the trunk’s right-hand corner; a scrap of blue cloth inside; earth lodged in one of the flute’s holes.

A week later the playwright, Raghav, came to watch rehearsal. He asked, “Where is the blue cloth written?”

Aniruddha said, “Where?”

“You were saying that when the trunk opens, a blue cloth can be seen.”

Aniruddha turned the pages of his notebook. There was no blue cloth in the original play. He himself had added it, yet he remembered distinctly that the cloth had been there the first time he read the script.

Shekhar smiled. “An actor fills empty spaces.”

Aniruddha smiled too, but that night at home he wrote on a page of his notebook: “Blue cloth—I invented it. Not in the text.”

He drew two lines beneath the sentence.

3

By the third week Damodar’s voice had begun to settle in him. Aniruddha chose a register slightly lower than his ordinary speech, small pauses between words, and, instead of “all right,” the character’s particular “hmm.”

At first Arya teased him. “Hmm?” she would say, imitating Damodar herself.

One night over dinner Arya asked, “We have to go to Mother tomorrow, you remember?”

Mixing his rice, Aniruddha replied, “Hmm.”

Arya stopped her spoon. “The stage?”

Aniruddha looked up. “What?”

“That ‘hmm.’”

“Oh.” Aniruddha laughed. “The habit has settled in.”

But that night, while brushing his teeth before the mirror, he noticed that at a difficult question his eyes had turned to the right of their own accord.

He deliberately looked straight at his reflection.

“Aniruddha,” he said softly.

The man in the mirror said nothing; he only looked back.

4

Rehearsals intensified. Damodar’s central scene required him, after twenty years, to sit before his sister Madhu and admit that he could not have prevented Naresh’s death, but leaving home had been his own decision.

Sameera was playing Madhu. In one rehearsal she forgot a line. The sequence broke. Shekhar was about to say "Stop," but Aniruddha suddenly spoke: "Madhu, that night I was looking at the water of the pond."

The line was not in the original text.

Staying in character, Sameera asked, "For how long?"

The answer came out of Aniruddha's mouth: "Until the lantern's reflection broke twice in the water."

Shekhar remained silent. The scene continued.

Five minutes later, when rehearsal stopped, Raghav the playwright asked, "Where did the pond come from?"

Aniruddha said, "Damodar remembered it."

Everyone laughed, but Aniruddha did not. It had genuinely felt to him as though that scene at the pond had been remembered.

Shekhar said seriously, "This may be useful, but keep a boundary. Build the character's memory; do not call it your own memory."

Aniruddha immediately wrote in his notebook: "Pond—made in rehearsal. Not from my life."

He wrote the date at the top of the page as well.

5

A few days later Aniruddha went to Patna to see his mother. Usha Devi was showing him an old album. In one photograph, five-year-old Aniruddha, wearing a red sweater, stood beside a bucket.

Usha Devi said, "This was the house in Muzaffarpur. You fell down the stairs here."

Aniruddha kept looking at the photograph. The red tin trunk came to mind.

He asked, "Did we have a red trunk at home?"

His mother thought. "There was a green trunk. Your grandmother's. Red? I do not remember."

"A bamboo flute?"

"Your father played the harmonium. Not the flute."

Usha Devi laughed and asked, "Why are you examining me?"

Aniruddha could not tell her that for one moment he had clearly seen a rusted red trunk beneath the staircase of his own childhood.

That night he opened the album again. The red sweater. No green trunk was visible.

In his notebook he made two headings: "My Memory" and "Damodar's Memory."

"Falling from the stairs—mine."

"Red trunk—Damodar's."

Then, after a pause, he added: "The colour red—in both?"

The question mark he drew was very large.

6

After returning home, Arya saw the notebook.

“What is this?”

Aniruddha said, “A boundary.”

“Between what?”

“Me and the role.”

Arya turned the pages. “Why are you separating all this?”

Aniruddha drew breath before answering. Arya noticed at once.

“Damodar again.”

Aniruddha grew irritated. “Not every breath belongs to Damodar.”

Arya fell silent.

Aniruddha regretted it immediately. “I am sorry.”

Arya said, “I am not joking. Even at home you move in the character’s gait. Last night in your sleep you said ‘Naresh.’ That is all I am worried about.”

“This happens to actors.”

“I do not know how much it happens to everyone. I can see how much it is happening to you.”

For the first time Aniruddha understood that Arya’s concern was not criticism.

That night, after taking off his shoes by the door, he deliberately walked twice in his ordinary gait. The first circuit felt artificial. The second felt a little more natural.

7

One day after rehearsal Shekhar told all the actors to devise their own method of coming out of the stage. One might change costume and sit quietly for ten minutes; another might listen to a song; another might call home.

Aniruddha asked, “What will that change?”

Shekhar said, “The body gets a signal that rehearsal is over.”

Shailaja-di, a senior actress who had come as a guest to watch rehearsal, said, “A role can enter you. Do not fight to beat it out. Give it a door.”

Aniruddha laughed. “A door?”

“Yes. There is a grammar of entering the stage, isn’t there? Make one for leaving it too.”

Shailaja-di described her old method: after changing costume she would say her own name clearly—not three times, only once—look at the time, and remember one ordinary task from the day: buy milk, call her daughter, check the electricity bill.

“Why?” Aniruddha asked.

“Because the self is not some magic bead that falls out of your pocket,” Shailaja-di laughed. “But we make our present out of habits, relationships, the body, and memory. Sometimes the stage shakes all of them hard.”

Aniruddha did not need a philosophical answer to the word “self.” The method seemed useful to him.

He devised four exit-actions of his own: put Damodar's stick on the props table; plant his right foot fully on the floor; look at the time; write Arya one ordinary message—"Rehearsal over. Coming home."

8

The first public performance was a success. Reviewers especially praised Aniruddha's body language and pauses. One article said, "He does not play the character; he becomes the character."

Everyone in the troupe was pleased. Aniruddha first felt proud when he read the article, then stopped at the phrase: "becomes the character."

Shekhar said, "It is a critic's idiom. Don't put it on your head."

Aniruddha said, "If I have become the character, where is Aniruddha?"

Shekhar laughed. "Probably counting the tickets."

During that night's performance an elderly man in the audience kept coughing. In Damodar's confession scene the coughing ought to have broken Aniruddha's rhythm, but instead it joined itself to the character's memory. It seemed to him—Naresh too used to cough like that.

Naresh was not a real person. Aniruddha knew this. Yet for one moment on stage, hearing the cough, he felt grief—a grief whose source was in the play, not in his life.

At the end of the scene, applause came. The curtain fell.

Aniruddha performed his four exit-actions. He put down the stick. Planted his foot fully. Time—10:07 p.m. Message to Arya: "Not rehearsal; performance over. Coming home."

Just then someone called from behind, "Damodar Babu!"

He turned without thinking.

It was a spectator who wanted a photograph.

Aniruddha smiled, but something tightened inside him.

9

The performances continued for three weeks. At home things were sometimes fine, sometimes strange. One day, while cutting vegetables, Aniruddha suddenly said, "Madhu, a little less salt."

Arya looked at him in silence.

Madhu was Damodar's sister.

Aniruddha's hand stopped. "Arya."

"Yes."

"I... said the wrong name."

Arya said, "I understood."

That night Arya did not quarrel. She merely stuck a sheet of paper on the refrigerator: "In this house: Arya, Aniruddha, Tara."

Tara, their seventeen-year-old daughter, lived in a hostel and came home on weekends. The following Saturday she saw the paper and laughed.

"What is this—a family attendance register?"

Arya said, "Something like that."

Tara looked at her father. "The role has climbed too far into you?" Aniruddha tried to make light of it. "The colour has taken. It will wash out."

Tara said, "After the colour washes out, is the cloth still the same?" She had asked in jest, but Aniruddha gave no answer.

IO

One night after a performance Aniruddha was returning home by city train. The next station was announced. He suddenly rose and stood by the door.

The name of the station sounded to him like "Sonbarsa."

As soon as the doors opened he stepped out. Only after he was on the platform did he look at the signboard. It bore another name. Not Sonbarsa. There was no station called Sonbarsa anywhere in the city.

He sat on a bench for five minutes. His chest was beating fast. What frightened him was not that he had forgotten a name; it was that, for one moment, an imaginary place had become a real direction.

He phoned Arya.

"I got off one station early," he said.

"Are you all right?"

"Yes."

There was a little silence. Then Aniruddha added on his own, "I heard Sonbarsa."

Arya said softly, "Come home. Speak to Shekhar tomorrow."

Aniruddha did not argue.

The next day Shekhar did not propose stopping the performances, but said, "This is no longer merely an artistic curiosity. You are tired. Three days' rest."

Aniruddha felt insulted. "I can handle the role."

"The question is not whether you can handle the role," Shekhar said. "It is whether you can handle your life. Three days."

Aniruddha walked out angry. As he went down the stairs his heel again landed late. Deliberately, he lifted and placed the whole foot.

II

The first day of the three-day break was difficult. The moment Aniruddha woke, he began repeating lines; he stopped midway. He locked the script in the cupboard.

Arya made no programme for him. They went to the market. Bought vegetables. Had the old press-iron repaired. Tara showed them a notice for her college play on her phone.

In the afternoon Aniruddha was sitting on the veranda when a flute sounded on a neighbour's radio. Naresh came to mind. At the same moment he remembered his real father's harmonium. For an instant the two memories dissolved into each other.

He brought out the notebook. This time he made not two sections but three: "Mine," "The Play's," and "Mixed / Not Certain."

He put the flute entry in the third section.

He realized that earlier he had wanted an immediate verdict on every memory—mine or Damodar's? Now some experiences could be left uncertain.

Arya saw the page. "This new column is good."

Aniruddha said, "I have accepted disorder."

"Sometimes it is more accurate than order."

"Is that a philosophical sentence?"

"No. Look at the kitchen drawer."

They both laughed. The laughter felt wholly his own to Aniruddha. He did not seek proof of it.

12

On the second day of his break he went to see Shailaja-di.

Aniruddha asked, "Can a role change a person?"

Shailaja-di said, "Every experience changes us. Marriage, grief, a city, illness, acting. The question is not whether you changed. The question is whether you can see the direction of the change."

"Self and non-self?" Aniruddha asked with a laugh.

"Have you come here to teach philosophy?"

"No. There is a question in my head heavier than the title of the play."

Shailaja-di gave him tea. "If you take the self to be a stone, then the role wears it down. If you take it to be a river, then the question becomes: at what point is a river the same river? I do not know the answer. The practical matter for an actor is this: do not pour the current of the stage forcibly over the people at home."

Aniruddha remained silent.

"You called Arya 'Madhu'?"

Aniruddha started. "Shekhar told you?"

"No. Your face did."

They both laughed.

Shailaja-di added seriously, "Respect the character, but do not give it the right to rename your private relationships."

13

Three days later Aniruddha returned to the stage. This time, before the performance, he wrote on the first page of his notebook: "Damodar's story need not be literally true; its inner truth on stage is enough."

That night the confession scene was unusually quiet. Aniruddha saw Naresh's imaginary face, but inwardly he named it: "Image from the play."

Suddenly real tears came into Sameera's eyes. Arya's face flashed within Aniruddha. Earlier he would have been afraid that the two worlds were merging. This time he understood that an actor does not arrive on stage

emptied of his own life; he carries experience with him, but the ownership of experience does not change.

The scene ended. Applause came.

Behind the curtain Aniruddha put down the stick. Planted his whole foot. Looked at the time. Wrote Arya: "Performance over. I am Aniruddha. Coming home."

After sending the message, he felt a little embarrassed—writing "I am Aniruddha" seemed childish.

Arya replied: "Good. I am Arya. Tea is being made."

Aniruddha laughed.

14

But the story did not end there. Once the role became easier, another kind of problem appeared. Aniruddha feared that his acting might become mechanical. The pauses that had once carried fear could, through repetition, harden into a fixed rhythm.

One night Shekhar said, "Now you are playing too safely."

Aniruddha asked sharply, "Earlier I was too far inside; now I am too far outside?"

"The stage is the work between those two edges."

Aniruddha grew angry. "So a director must always remain dissatisfied with the actor?"

Shekhar laughed. "That is one advantage of my profession."

Then he grew serious. "Making a boundary is not making a wall. Experience Damodar, but know the road back out."

That night Aniruddha changed a pause. On the line about Naresh's death, instead of the old, fixed three seconds, he took only one breath. The next line came quickly. Sameera was startled; the scene felt new.

Aniruddha understood: keeping the character alive did not require becoming a slave to every habit he had built for him.

15

On the night of the final performance the theatre was full. Tara was home for the holidays and sat down to watch the entire play for the first time.

In Damodar's final scene he stands at the door of the old house. The play does not make clear whether he enters. His last line is: "Does the house remember, or do I?"

Aniruddha spoke the line. Silence.

Many images appeared at once: Damodar's red trunk, Naresh's flute, his own mother's green trunk, his father's harmonium, the paper Arya had stuck on the refrigerator, the city-train station board, Tara laughing.

This time he tried to remove none of the images. Nor did he declare any of them a "pure" memory.

The stage door opened. Damodar took one step inside. Darkness.

The applause went on for a long time.

Behind the curtain Tara ran up. "Baba, at one point I felt you were looking at me."

Aniruddha said, "I was."

"Was Damodar looking, or were you?"

Aniruddha smiled. "On stage that question does not have only one answer."

Tara said, "Come home. Mother will be waiting."

At those words Aniruddha's body straightened. He placed the stick on the props table.

16

For several weeks after the play ended, fragments of Damodar still visited Aniruddha. Sometimes his gaze turned right at a difficult question; sometimes his heel landed late; sometimes the "hmm" slipped out.

Previously he would correct such moments at once. Now he merely recognized them: "This is a rhythm left over from rehearsal."

One day, while putting away clothes, he saw a red towel. For a moment the red trunk came to mind. He laughed. The trunk was imaginary, but the memory of it was now a real event in his mind. A memory of an imaginary object was not itself imaginary.

On the last page of the notebook he wrote: "The imagination of what never happened also happens."

Then, after thinking, he added: "But an event in imagination and an event in the outer world are not the same thing."

Arya read it from behind him. "Notebook finished now?"

"Perhaps."

"New role?"

"Next month."

"Who?"

"A man who walks very fast."

Arya laughed aloud. "This time your feet are safe."

Aniruddha laughed too.

17

That evening the electricity went out for a while. Aniruddha lit a lamp on the veranda. Arya was reading a book; Tara was talking to a friend on the phone.

Three shadows fell on the wall—Aniruddha, Arya, Tara. Whenever the breeze touched the flame the shadows lengthened and shortened, sometimes merging into one another.

Aniruddha looked at his shadow. Damodar's stooped shoulder was not there. Then he deliberately bent his shoulder a little. The shadow immediately resembled Damodar. He straightened again.

Suddenly the game seemed simple and serious at once. The body was one; its shapes could change. Change did not make the body disappear; a fixed shape was not its complete truth either.

Without looking up from her book, Arya asked, "What are you looking at?"

Aniruddha said, "A shadow."

"Whose?"

Before answering he almost took Damodar's habitual breath, but his own easy breath came instead.

"Mine, just now," he said.

The lamp flame moved again. The shadow on the wall changed.

Aniruddha did not try to stop it.

As long as there was light, there would be shadow; the changing of the shadow did not diminish the light.

18

A week before the play closed, the university theatre department invited the troupe for a discussion. The students asked questions—about lighting, script revisions, acting method.

One student asked, "Do you become Damodar, or do you show us Damodar?"

Everyone laughed. Aniruddha was about to give the practised answer—"The actor is a medium between character and audience"—but the words reached his mouth and stopped.

He said, "Sometimes I show him. Sometimes the body does something first and I understand it afterward. But 'I become him' creates a problem. When I step off the stage, I return to tickets, house keys, daughter, wife, mother, debts, phone—all of Aniruddha's life. Damodar has none of these."

Another student asked, "Then is the character's grief fake?"

Aniruddha said, "There are not only two boxes marked fake and real. On stage the grief I feel may be a real experience; its cause may be made by a story. The tears an audience sheds are real; the event is fictional. We need not erase that distinction."

Shekhar was sitting at the back. He said nothing.

After the session a student amused his friends by imitating Aniruddha's walk: right heel late, eyes slightly to the right. Everyone applauded.

At first Aniruddha felt strange—the walk that for some weeks had seemed almost to possess his body was now merely an imitation in another person's body.

He went up to the student and said, "You are dragging the heel too much. Damodar is not that old."

Everyone laughed again. So did Aniruddha.

The day after the final performance Aniruddha went to the theatre storeroom. Shambhu, the props assistant, was sorting objects for the next production.

Damodar's red trunk lay in a corner. Aniruddha opened the lid. Inside was the blue cloth he himself had introduced at the beginning of rehearsal.

He picked it up. Ordinary cheap cotton. A fine layer of dust.

Shambhu said, "We have to paint this trunk black for the next play."

Aniruddha said involuntarily, "Black?"

"Yes. It is going to be a prison chest."

For a moment he objected inwardly—this is Damodar's trunk. Naresh's flute is inside it....

Then he smiled at himself. There had never even been a flute among the props.

"Paint it," he said.

Shambhu lifted the trunk. A small flake of red paint fell from underneath. Aniruddha bent to pick it up, then stopped his hand. The flake stayed on the floor.

He understood that linking the object to the character had been part of his practice; repainting it would not erase that practice, but neither did the practice give him permanent ownership of the object.

Shambhu held up the blue cloth. "Keep this?"

Aniruddha said, "Put it with the prop fabrics. It may be useful to someone."

A few months later Aniruddha was rehearsing a new play. The new character walked fast, thought little, and cut off questions halfway through their answers. One day Arya laughed and said, "Add a rule to your acting method: at home, let people finish their answers."

Damodar's gait had almost vanished, though not completely. Sometimes the smell of rain, the sound of a flute, the colour red, or a spectator's cough brought him back for a moment.

Aniruddha no longer feared such moments. Nor did he say that Damodar had "died." The role had ended; its experience had become a real period in the history of his life.

One night Tara asked, "Baba, if the role changed you, where did the earlier you go?"

Aniruddha said, "Where did the five-year-old Tara go?"

"Inside me?"

"Some inside, some left behind, some remembered, some not remembered. But you are you now."

Tara thought for a moment. "Then is the self like an account book?"

Aniruddha laughed. "I am not a philosophy teacher."

From inside Arya said, "A good thing."

All three laughed.

That evening the electricity went out. A lamp burned on the veranda. Three shadows fell on the wall—sometimes separate, sometimes mingling. Aniruddha could bend one shoulder and make Damodar's form; when he straightened, another form appeared.

Arya asked, "What are you looking at?"

"A shadow."

"Whose?"

Aniruddha drew breath before answering. The breath could have been part of Damodar's training, or simply his own tiredness.

"Mine, just now," he said.

The flame moved. The shadow changed. Aniruddha did not try to stop it.

As long as the light remained, shadows would keep forming; the changing of a shadow did not diminish the light.

— *End of Story 31* —

32. Cause and Effect

STORY

I

It had been raining since the third night of Bhadra. The current in the Pipahi drain had doubled from its ordinary flow, though by morning the rain had eased a little. Mud, leaves, and washed-down grass had lodged on the old culvert west of the village. From above, the culvert looked as it had for twenty years—low iron railings on both sides, a thin cracked skin of tar in the middle, and the old roots of a peepal tree at the right-hand end.

At half past seven Ramudit set out for the market in his small goods vehicle. It carried five sacks of paddy, empty grocery crates, and four people—Ramudit, his nephew Sonu, Malti, the village health assistant, and seventy-year-old Ramsakhi Devi. Malti had to reach the block health centre; Ramsakhi Devi was going to buy medicine for her eyes.

Halfway across the culvert the right wheel sank. Ramudit pressed the brake. At that instant there came a sound—first a short crack like a dry bamboo snapping, then a deep thud. The right side of the culvert dropped by nearly four feet. The vehicle tilted, the railing broke, and its front sank into the silt of the drain.

Sonu was thrown out. His arm broke. Ramudit suffered a head injury. Malti remained trapped in the vehicle, but people pulled her out at once. Ramsakhi Devi was taken to hospital; by evening she was dead.

By noon the event had reached the village not in one form but in five. Someone said Ramudit had been driving too fast. Someone said the culvert had been cracked for a month. Someone said a village boy had seen the soil beneath it slipping the previous evening. Someone said Ramsakhi Devi's allotted span had simply been completed. Someone said it was all the result of government neglect.

Everyone wanted a cause. But they did not all want the same kind of cause.

2

Ramudit returned home two days later from hospital. There was a bandage on his head and more shame than speech in him. Five people sat at the doorway—some to offer sympathy, some for news, some to ask how fast he had been driving.

“Not fast,” Ramudit said again and again. “How could I have been doing more than ten or fifteen? There was mud.”

“Why did you brake?” his neighbour Jagdish asked.

Ramudit closed his eyes. “The wheel went down. If I had not braked, the front might have gone too.”

Jagdish asked again, “Could the braking have caused a jolt?”

Ramudit was silent. The doctor at the hospital had told him to stop replaying the incident and blaming himself. But in the village every question circled the same point: what if he had not braked? What if he had not driven onto the culvert at all? What if he had waited five minutes?

At night he kept remembering the movement of his own hands while driving: accelerator released, wheel sinking, brake, sound. Four moments. In searching for a cause inside those four moments, he turned over his entire life.

One night his wife Rekha said, “The brake was in your hands. Building the culvert was not.”

Ramudit replied, “But the vehicle was in my hands.”

“Both things can be true at once.”

The sentence did not calm him. But it did divide the question into two parts.

3

On the third day Neeraj Kumar, a junior engineer from the block office, came to the broken culvert. He brought a measuring tape, a wooden rod, a mobile phone, and two employees. Villagers gathered at the edge. The less someone understood, the more confidently he stated the cause.

Neeraj did not begin by looking straight at the broken section. He climbed down underneath. The water in the drain had fallen by then. Soil had been scoured away near the right pier; a hollow had formed beneath the foundation. The mortar between the old bricks had crumbled away. A crack in the tar surface ran to the right edge.

Bhola Sah, the village mason, said, “I said three months ago that this corner was settling.”

Neeraj asked, “Whom did you tell?”

“The mukhiya. I showed a photograph too.”

Uma Devi, the mukhiya—known since the theft dispute in Story 25 for saying “Look first, then speak”—was standing nearby. She said at once, “The photograph is in my phone. A written complaint was sent too.”

A copy of the complaint was brought. It was two months old. Subject: “Scouring beside the right pier of the Pipahi drain culvert; immediate inspection required.” It bore the block office receipt stamp. In pencil below was written: “Forwarded to Technical Assistant.”

Neeraj looked at the paper for a long time. “I never received this letter,” he said.

“Then where did it go?” Uma Devi asked.

“I cannot say that yet.”

A stir ran through the people. "A government paper ate the culvert," someone joked. The laughter stopped at once, because Ramsakhi Devi's son Balram was standing there.

4

Neeraj returned two days later. This time Archana Sinha, a senior engineer from the district, came with him. She asked the year in which the culvert had been built. No one remembered exactly. The block record said 1998, but villagers said, "It was there before that."

Archana examined the broken remains, the foundation, the direction of flow, and the place where the vehicle had stopped. She also spoke to Ramudit.

"Did you notice anything unusual as soon as you drove onto the culvert?"

"The right side seemed a little low. But it had looked like that before too."

"How often did you use this road?"

"Two or three times a week."

"Load on the vehicle?"

Ramudit counted the sacks. Archana noted an estimated weight. "Where was the load-limit sign?"

No one answered. It was not even certain whether the culvert had ever had such a sign.

That evening Archana explained her preliminary view to Uma Devi. "I do not see one cause. Scouring removed soil below and weakened the foundation. The old joints had deteriorated. There was a crack above. The request for inspection was not acted on in time. The vehicle added load, and at that moment the weak portion failed. The vehicle is part of the causal chain, but if the culvert had been sound, this much load should not have made it collapse."

Uma Devi asked, "Then what will the written report say?"

"What we observed. What is inference will be called inference. What is established by records will be sourced."

Uma Devi smiled slightly. "I like that."

5

On the fifth day preparations were under way for Ramsakhi Devi's shraddha. The priest, Shashikant, had come to Balram's house. Amid the grieving family, discussion of the meaning of the rites rose almost inevitably.

One relative said, "A person comes carrying his own karma. Whatever one's destiny..."

Balram cut him off. "Did my mother scour away the soil beneath the culvert?"

The room fell silent.

Shashikant said quietly, "To speak of karmic consequence does not mean that we stop looking for physical causes."

Balram's voice was hard. "But people use it to escape responsibility. They say, 'Her time was over,' and that is the end of it."

The priest straightened his seat. "Seeking meaning in suffering is one matter. Asking why the culvert collapsed is another. Whether religion can answer the first fully, I cannot say with certainty. The second will be answered by engineers, records, and investigation."

Balram kept looking at him. His anger did not end, but its target became a little clearer.

Shashikant added, "If I call this death only 'karma,' then the actions of anyone who failed to repair the culvert become invisible. That would not be religion. It would be convenience."

Ramsakhi Devi's elder daughter Manjula, who had been sitting in the room, spoke for the first time. "Mother herself used to say—leave things to God, but if the roof leaks, change the tiles."

A few people laughed softly. This time the laughter did not feel like an offence.

6

The journey of the paperwork through the block office was more tangled than the debris of the culvert. The mukhiya's complaint was entered in the receipt register. The mail-distribution register for that day recorded: "Technical Branch." But the technical branch's inward register carried no such number.

The clerk Mithilesh said, "A lot of papers come in. Sometimes they land on another desk..."

Uma Devi interrupted. "Do not make it lighter by saying 'another desk.' It did not reach the correct desk. Write that."

Mithilesh was startled. "It means the same thing."

"No. 'It went somewhere' makes the event foggy. Find out whose responsibility the paper was."

Rajiv, the contract worker who distributed the mail, said he had had a high fever that week; another worker had handled the job for two days. That worker had since been transferred. There was no signature on the file.

The inquiry did not establish that anyone had deliberately suppressed the complaint. It did establish that after receipt, the chain of accountability for the paper had broken.

Balram was not satisfied. "Then who is guilty?"

Archana said, "The administration will determine responsibility. We will record technical causes. Sometimes one name emerges; sometimes the process itself is arranged so that no task belongs clearly to anyone. That too is a failure, but its remedy is different."

Balram wanted one face on which he could place his anger. It was difficult to be angry at a "process."

7

The village tea stall became a court of causes. One group said heavy vehicles should have been banned. Another asked: if the culvert was that weak, why had the road not been closed? A third group named the original contractor, although after twenty-five years it was difficult to make the original construction the sole culprit.

Bhola Sah added from experience, "The crack was visible from above, but the real danger was underneath. The water ate the soil away beside the pier."

A young man showed a video on his phone. "Look—the railing is leaning slightly a day before the accident."

Another said, "You cannot even see the date clearly in the video."

Everyone bent over the screen. The cause now seemed to be before their eyes, yet the evidence was still incomplete.

At last Nandu the tea seller said, "Seems to me everyone is selling his own cause."

"And what are you selling?" someone asked.

"Tea. Causes are free."

This time everyone laughed.

8

Ten days later, after recovering from her injuries, Malti returned to the health centre. Women from the village came to see her. Everyone asked about the accident, but she kept returning to one thing Ramsakhi Devi had said immediately before it: "If I get the medicine, good. If not, I'll come again next week."

"Did she have some premonition?" someone asked.

Malti grew irritated. "No. She was going to buy medicine. Why do we turn an ordinary sentence into a sign after someone dies?"

The question sounded harsh to many people. But for Malti it was necessary. She could not bear to turn Ramsakhi Devi into a character walking toward death. She had been a living woman talking about eye medicine, her granddaughter's wedding, and seed potatoes when she drove onto the culvert.

Malti wrote in her diary: "While seeking causes after a death, let us not destroy the ordinariness of the life that came before it."

9

Sitting at home with his arm in plaster, Sonu watched a short video of the accident on his phone. A friend had filmed it from a distance—the vehicle climbs onto the culvert, two seconds, dust, people shouting. Sonu stopped the video again and again to look at the wheel.

At one point it seemed to him that Ramudit's vehicle had turned slightly left. "If Kaka had gone straight..."

Then he watched again. There was more mud on the left; the turn might have been an instinctive attempt to save the wheel.

Sonu sent the video to Neeraj. Neeraj replied, “It is useful, but by itself it cannot establish the cause.”

The words “by itself” troubled Sonu. He wanted one cause. Once he had one, the scene inside his mind would fall into order. But the investigation kept opening new branches.

During the inquiry Archana also called for the old maintenance records. One file had an entry from 2016: “Surface repairs.” Another from 2019: “Railing painted and small potholes filled.” There was no mention of scouring near the right pier or of inspection beneath the foundation.

Bhola Sah looked at the records and said, “So repairs were done—but only to what could be seen. Who looked at what was happening underneath?”

Archana replied, “That is an important distinction. Laying new tar on top does not make the foundation new. Maintenance work was done, but there is no evidence that a structural inspection was done.”

Deepak, the old contractor’s son, was hurt by this discussion. For two days his father’s name had been circulating in the village—“It must have been badly built from the beginning.” Deepak brought old papers from home. The original measurement book was incomplete, but there were payment records and inspection signatures.

Deepak said, “After twenty-five years it is easy to put every fault on my father. He is not even alive to answer.”

Archana said, “With the material available, we cannot now establish whether there was a defect in the original construction. Twenty-five years of water, scouring, repairs, and inspections are also part of the causal chain. Writing an inference against a dead person is not an investigation.”

Deepak’s face relaxed a little. He had not been given complete exoneration, but blame without evidence had been stopped. That small distinction seemed very large to him that day.

At the same time Balram had to fill out an application for compensation from the district office. One box on the form read: “Cause of death.” His hand stopped there. What should he write? “Accident”? “Culvert collapse”? “Vehicle accident”?

Manjula said, “Write what is on the medical certificate.”

The certificate said: “Complications arising from injuries sustained inside a vehicle after collapse of the culvert.” Balram read the sentence and fell silent. He understood that paperwork makes causes smaller, but that there is also a reason for making them smaller—so that a claim can be checked.

The clerk asked for one more document—local confirmation that the culvert had collapsed. Balram snapped, “My mother died—is even that not enough proof?”

Uma Devi explained, “They are not asking for proof of grief. They are asking for a record of the event for which public money will be paid. The system feels hard, but the question of paperwork and the question of mourning are different.”

Balram submitted the papers. On the way home he understood for the first time that the word “cause” belonged not only to philosophy or

engineering; it affected money, responsibility, records, and a family's future as well.

IO

The interim technical report arrived three weeks later. Uma Devi read its main findings in the panchayat building. The report had four levels: immediate cause, contributing causes, pre-existing condition, and administrative response.

Immediate cause: failure of the weakened right foundation at the moment the vehicle load came upon it. Contributing causes: scouring by the drain, erosion of soil beneath the foundation, weakness in the old masonry joints. Pre-existing condition: cracks above and settlement at the edge. Administrative response: inspection not carried out in time; lack of follow-up on the complaint received.

The report also stated that the available evidence did not establish that the vehicle was carrying more than the prescribed capacity. There was no reliable measurement of speed. Application of the brake by the driver was not established as the decisive cause of the collapse.

Ramudit sat in the last row. At those words his shoulders loosened slightly. He was not "freed"—Ramsakhi Devi's death could not rise and disappear because of a line in a report. But the hard stone called "It was all because of me" became a little lighter for the first time.

Balram heard the report and said, "Then the administration is guilty."

Uma Devi replied, "The report says the inspection did not happen. Determining responsibility is a separate process."

Balram flared. "Everything is separate, separate!"

Archana, who was present at the meeting, said calmly, "If we do not separate the strands, no one's responsibility can be established inside a mixture. To join causes together, we first have to identify them separately."

II

That night Balram opened an old trunk while remembering his mother. Inside were Ramsakhi Devi's papers, medicine slips, postcards, seed accounts, and an old prayer book. A dried tulsi leaf lay between its pages.

Balram's wife Vimla asked, "What are you looking for?"

"Nothing."

In truth he was looking for evidence that his mother had given some meaning to death. Some written sentence—"What is to happen will happen," "God's will," anything. He found nothing.

On one small piece of paper was Ramsakhi Devi's handwriting: "Balram, there will not be enough pigeon-pea seed for the field behind the drain. Bring two pao."

Reading it, Balram began to cry. His mother was more alive in that ordinary instruction than in all the philosophical sentences.

Vimla sat beside him. "Did understanding the cause make the grief less?"

After a long time Balram said, “No. But I am a little less angry at things that are not true.”

12

The decision was made not to repair the culvert but to rebuild it completely. The new design provided deeper piers, a wider opening for the flow, erosion protection along the sides, and a clearly marked load limit. Once construction began, villagers came repeatedly to watch.

One day Bhola Sah asked Neeraj, “Why wasn’t all this done earlier?”

Neeraj replied, “It was in the rules. Whether rules are followed everywhere is another matter.”

Bhola Sah did not laugh. “Then the cause is not only absence of rules; failure to follow them is also a cause.”

Neeraj said, “Yes. But next time it will not be enough simply to say ‘failure to follow.’ Who will inspect, when, and where it will be recorded—all that has to be explicit.”

Uma Devi started a new register at the panchayat. Roads, culverts, pond ghats, public buildings—wherever any crack, erosion, or hazard was seen, it would be recorded with the date; a photograph would be attached if available; to whom it had been sent and when a reply came would also be written down.

Someone joked, “Now even cracks will enter the Panji!”

Uma Devi said, “Forget a name and a lineage breaks; forget a crack and a culvert does.”

News of the new register reached the school. Sumedha, the science teacher, took her eighth-grade students to see the new culvert. She asked, “Why did the old culvert collapse?”

One student said, “Water cut away the soil.” Another: “The government did not repair it in time.” A third: “The vehicle drove onto it.” A fourth student, Neelima, said, “All of them.”

Sumedha did not laugh. She stood a dry twig in the soil and removed a little earth from beneath it with her thumb. The twig leaned. “What is the main cause here?”

The children again gave different answers. Sumedha said, “In science, ‘main cause’ can be useful. But in complex events we have to look at layers—what condition already existed, what event supplied the immediate push, and what safeguard was absent.”

Neelima asked, “Then what about karmaphala?”

Sumedha paused. “That question cannot be measured with the instruments of science. If someone understands the meaning of life in that language, that can be respected. But when we build a culvert, we must examine soil, water, load, and inspection. Giving both questions one name weakens the investigation.”

On the way back the students read the new load-limit sign. One child asked, “Now that the sign is there, accidents cannot happen?”

Sumedha said, “No sign can guarantee the future. But once causes are understood, we can reduce risk on that basis. That may sound like a small use of knowledge, but it is not small.”

13

One evening Priest Shashikant came to Balram’s house. The shraddha was over. This time he had no ritual to perform. He had come only to ask how the family was.

Balram said, “Did you read the report?”

“Yes.”

“And where has karmaphala gone now?”

Shashikant did not evade the question. “Where it was before—in one tradition through which human beings try to make meaning of suffering. It has no place in an engineering report on a culvert.”

“Then religion does not explain causes?”

“Not every kind of cause. If I ask why a brick broke, I must examine the brick. If you ask what a person should do on witnessing injustice, religion, ethics, philosophy may all speak. If I answer the first question with the second, I create confusion.”

Balram said, “Why did my mother die?”

Shashikant was silent for a long time. “There are two questions inside that question. What physical sequence caused her death—the doctors and the accident investigation can answer that. What it means that your mother is no longer here—that grief does not have a complete answer in my possession.”

For the first time Balram heard him say “I do not have it.” Strangely, the answer felt more respectful.

14

Two months later the new culvert was ready. There was a proposal for ribbon, chairs, and a microphone at the opening, but Balram did not want a celebration. In the end there was only a small meeting. A board stood on the right side of the culvert: year of construction, load limit, date of the next inspection, and a number for registering complaints.

Ramsakhi Devi’s name was not on the board. The family itself did not want it there. Manjula said, “It would not be right to turn Mother into nothing but the culvert accident.”

Even so, Uma Devi recorded the incident on the first page of the panchayat register—the date, damage, death, findings of the inquiry, and corrective work. At the end she added one line: “Unknown or disputed matters shall not be written as certain.”

When Ramudit drove a vehicle onto the new culvert for the first time, his speed dropped of its own accord. A vehicle behind him sounded its horn. He did not panic. After crossing, he stopped a short distance away and got out.

The drain flowed below. The water was low but moving. The layer of stone around the new piers was clearly visible.

He touched the railing. Solid. Yet he understood that solid things too stand within a web of causes: soil, water, brick, iron, inspection, labour, attention.

15

That evening the electricity went out in the panchayat building. Before closing the register Uma Devi lit a lamp. Balram, Ramudit, Bhola Sah, Neeraj, and Shashikant happened to be there—to fix the first inspection date for the new culvert.

The lamp's light fell on the register page. On one side were technical words—"scouring," "foundation," "load," "inspection." On the other were dates and names.

Looking at the page, Shashikant said, "Many causes have been written down."

Neeraj replied, "Only what has been established so far."

Balram asked, "And what has not been established?"

Uma Devi pointed to the empty margin. "There is room there."

Ramudit said softly, "Not every empty space has to be filled."

No one disagreed.

Outside, the drain could be heard flowing in the darkness. Its flow had many causes: rain, gradient, soil, water released from a distant pond. Naming one thing did not explain the whole current. Yet searching for causes was not futile—understanding them could make the next culvert a little better.

The lamp flame moved slightly. The shadows of the written lines moved too, but the letters remained where they were.

The complete meaning of grief was not found. Many causes of the accident were. Neither took the place of the other.

— *End of Story* 32 —

33. Silence

STORY

I

On the day Harinath Jha announced that he would undertake a vow of silence, Malti Devi was setting dal on the stove. To her, the announcement did not seem like a new event in the household, merely the next experiment in Harinath's long life. At times he led kirtan, at times gave discourses, at times mediated village disputes. People called him "Baba," though Malti Devi still called him "Harinath."

"For how many days?" Malti Devi asked.

"Thirty."

"Why?"

Harinath replied, "I have said too much. Now I will listen for a while."

Malti Devi lifted the lid from the dal. Steam rose. "Listening is fine. But what about people who come with questions?"

"I will remain silent."

"Silence is not an answer to a question."

Harinath smiled. In that moment Malti Devi understood that, before the vow had even begun, this was his last answer.

2

Harinath's small ashram stood behind the old peepal tree, half a kos from the house. One room, one veranda, a tulsi platform, two sitting mats. His disciple Sadanand had been living with him for five years. The moment he heard the announcement, he became excited.

"Guruji's thirty-day discipline of silence," Sadanand said, "is no ordinary occasion."

Harinath looked at him.

Sadanand folded his hands. "I understand. There will be no publicity."

Harinath looked at him again.

The next day a notice hung on the ashram gate: "A discipline of silence is in progress. Please ask only necessary questions." Beneath it, in Sadanand's smaller handwriting: "Donation box to the right."

Harinath read the notice. He looked at the donation box. Sadanand interpreted the glance to mean that Guruji was above greed for donations. Harinath was merely thinking that the box had not been there yesterday.

3

For the first three days the silence truly was quiet. Harinath rose at dawn, swept the courtyard, watered the tulsi, and sat on his mat. People came, bowed, sat quietly, and left.

From the fourth day, questions began.

First came Ganesh Sah. His two sons were quarrelling over the division of their shop. "Baba, should the old shop go to the elder son, or to both?"

Harinath remained silent.

Ganesh Sah asked again. Harinath raised his right palm before his forehead to shield his eyes from the sun. Ganesh Sah's face brightened.

"I understand. The elder son is like the right hand."

By evening the village had heard that Baba had signalled his support for the elder son.

When Malti Devi heard, she said, "He was shielding his eyes from the sun."

People replied, "You are family. How would you understand the signs of spiritual practice?"

For the first time Malti Devi felt that the silence no longer belonged only to Harinath; the village was becoming its owner.

4

On the fifth day Nikhil came. He was Harinath's only son and ran a medicine shop in the market. The previous month he had spoken of taking a bank loan, which Harinath had not liked.

Nikhil sat in the ashram. "Babu, I have submitted the papers."

Harinath looked at him.

"The loan papers."

Harinath's face remained still.

"Are you still against it?"

Silence.

Nikhil sat for five minutes, then got up and left. At home he told his mother, "Babu is very angry."

Malti Devi asked, "Did he say anything?"

"No."

"Then how did he become angry?"

"I saw his face."

"Your father's face has looked the same for thirty years."

Nikhil did not laugh. The old distance between father and son seemed larger inside that silence.

For Malti Devi, Harinath's silence was not entirely new. In the early years of their marriage, when questions arose about household expenses, his mother's illness, Nikhil's studies, or selling a field, Harinath often spoke beautifully—of patience, time, faith. But Malti needed the next answer: where would the money come from, who would take the patient to the healer, who would sign the papers?

Once Malti had told him, “You speak a great deal, but in the middle of it you stop listening.” Harinath had laughed then. Thirty years later, the sentence returned to her.

On the seventh day of the silence, Malti deliberately went to the ashram and spent five minutes talking only about the house—dampness in the grain store, Nikhil’s loan, a crack in the roof. Harinath could not interrupt. At first he felt uneasy; by the third minute he realised that before Malti had finished a sentence, he was already composing his reply in his mind. He stopped himself from forming the reply.

Malti finished speaking and rose. “Whether today you truly listened all the way through, or merely kept your vow—I do not know.”

Harinath had an answer, but he also had a vow. He merely folded his hands. Malti did not assign a meaning to the gesture.

5

On the eighth day an elderly woman, Parvati Devi, came to the ashram. Her husband had died two years earlier. The boundary of her field was disputed with a neighbour. She brought no papers, only a tired face.

“Baba,” she said, “everyone tells me to let it go. They say quarrelling is not a woman’s work. What should I do?”

Harinath looked at her for a long time. Before the vow, perhaps he would have advised her: show the papers, go to the panchayat, do not go alone. But now there was the vow.

Whether Parvati Devi took his silence as agreement or disagreement, Harinath could not tell. She rose and bowed.

“All right. I will let it go.”

Harinath’s body leaned slightly forward. But he did not speak. Parvati Devi left.

That night, for the first time, Harinath experienced silence not as his chosen discipline but as an answer that had failed to appear.

6

Meanwhile, for Sadanand the importance of the silence kept growing. At first he explained to people who came with questions, “Guruji’s answer will come through signs. Do not decide in haste.” But soon Sadanand himself began explaining what each sign meant.

If Harinath closed his eyes—“Look within.”

If he looked toward the road outside—“Contemplate leaving the household.”

If he drank water—“Keep the mind cool.”

If he coughed—“Impure speech is leaving the body.”

One day Malti Devi heard the list and asked Sadanand, “And if he sneezes?”

Sadanand remained serious. “The body too gives signs.”

Malti Devi said, “The body also sneezes.”

Sadanand did not answer. Malti thought to herself: the first lesson of silence is learned not by the people who speak the most, but by the people who manufacture meanings.

7

On the twelfth day two village families arrived at the ashram. The dispute concerned the path to an old well. One side wanted to build a wall beside it; the other said the path would become too narrow. Both wanted Harinath's "impartial sign."

Harinath lifted the earthen water-pot kept in a corner of the veranda. Rainwater was dripping from the roof there, so the pot had to be moved.

The two families looked at each other.

"See?" said Hardev from the first side. "Baba is saying: change the old place."

Shyamu from the other side immediately protested, "No. He moved the pot aside and left the passage clear. Keep the path open."

Within five minutes the pot had become philosophical evidence.

Harinath felt, in turn, surprise, helplessness, and a little amusement. Quietly he put the pot back where it had been.

That left both sides even more confused.

When Nikhil heard the story that evening, he laughed for the first time. "Babu hasn't taken a vow. The whole village is playing a riddle competition."

Malti Devi said, "Laugh, but Parvati is thinking of giving up her field."

Nikhil stopped laughing.

On the thirteenth day a seventeen-year-old student named Kumud came with her mother. She wanted to study music; her family wanted her to take ordinary subjects at the nearby college. Kumud asked, "Baba, is it right for me to go away and study music?"

Harinath heard the question and smiled faintly. At that moment a yellow leaf fell from the peepal tree. He glanced at it without thinking.

Kumud's mother said, "Did you see? Let the old leaf go; begin a new life."

Kumud's face lit up. Two days later she sent in her application. When Malti later heard about it, she asked Harinath, "Did you give her a sign to study music?"

Harinath shook his head—no.

"But perhaps the decision will turn out well," Malti said.

Harinath nodded.

Malti said, "A good outcome does not make the meaning we invented true."

This time there was agreement in Harinath's eyes. Malti smiled. "That too is my inference."

8

On the fifteenth day Malti Devi reached the ashram. Harinath sat on his mat. Five people were before him. Sadanand was saying that the veranda

should be extended the following year, a small meditation room built, and that if a portion of the mango grove to the east were donated to the ashram, the centre for spiritual practice could expand.

"Guruji himself will say nothing," Sadanand said, "but yesterday he kept looking east for a long time."

Malti Devi asked directly, "The sun rises in the east. Will you draw up a deed of donation for that too?"

No one laughed.

She turned to Harinath. "Do you want that grove?"

Harinath remained silent.

"These people are calling your silence a yes."

Harinath's eyes rested on Malti.

Malti Devi continued, "You may remain silent. But the person whose land it is has not remained silent."

The eastern grove belonged to Ramvati Devi, whose two sons lived away. Ramvati had never spoken of donating anything. Sadanand had merely asked once whether it might be possible.

Harinath lowered his head. That day he understood that when a person with authority embraces silence, other people can fill the empty space with their own authority.

9

On the seventeenth day Parvati Devi came again. This time she had papers in her hand.

"Baba, I had given up the boundary dispute. But my daughter phoned. She said, 'Ma, if the share is yours, why surrender it merely out of fear of people?' Here are the papers. I am going to the panchayat."

Relief appeared on Harinath's face.

Parvati Devi laughed. "At first I took your silence to mean 'let it go.' Later Malti didi told me you had said nothing at all. Then I understood—I had put my own fear into your mouth."

She gathered her papers. "This time the decision is mine."

Harinath folded his hands.

Parvati Devi said, "I won't ask what this sign means."

They both laughed—one without sound, one with it.

10

On the twenty-first day the ashram was unusually crowded. Sadanand had arranged a small gathering. The topic was "The Glory of Silence." Harinath had not been told about the gathering beforehand.

Sadanand said, "Guruji's silence itself proves that speech is limited. We all wish to make this place a permanent centre for spiritual practice. Auspicious signs have also been received concerning Ramvati Devi's eastern grove."

Ramvati Devi herself stood up in the crowd. "What sign?"

Sadanand faltered. "Guruji..."

Harinath rose to his feet.

Everyone fell silent.

He looked at Sadanand, then at Ramvati Devi.

“No.”

One word.

The vow broke there.

Some people were disappointed, some astonished. Sadanand’s face went pale.

Harinath spoke again. “Ramvati Devi has donated no grove. Nor have I asked for it.”

Sadanand said softly, “But Guruji, you were looking east—”

“The sun was rising.”

This time some people laughed. Harinath did not.

II

After the gathering dispersed, Sadanand remained seated on the veranda. Harinath sat opposite him. For a long time both were silent. This time it was not a vow. It was simply the time two human beings needed to search for an answer.

Sadanand said, “I made a mistake.”

Harinath said, “So did I.”

“You?”

“I thought that if I stopped speaking, only my own voice would stop. I did not understand that people would speak in my name.”

Sadanand’s eyes were lowered. “I supplied the meanings.”

“Meaning cannot be prevented from arising. But to call the meaning one has invented another person’s words—that is a mistake.”

After a long time Sadanand asked, “Then was silence useless?”

Harinath said, “I do not yet have an answer to that question.”

Sadanand looked at him in surprise. Earlier Harinath almost always had some answer to every question. Now that he could speak, he was saying, “I do not know.”

On the night the silence broke, Malti asked after a long while, “What did you hear in these twenty-one days?”

Harinath did not immediately produce a spiritual answer. After a pause he said, “Two kinds of birds come into the courtyard—I had never noticed that. Nikhil presses his lips together before asking a question—that too. Sadanand, before giving an answer, puts his own thought in Guruji’s name—I see that now. And...”

“And?”

“When you speak, I often begin composing my answer halfway through your sentence.”

Malti remained silent for a long time. Harinath did not, as before, invent a meaning for her silence.

At last Malti said, “Then you heard something.”

“Yes.”

“Because of silence?”

Harinath said, “Perhaps stopping my speech created the opportunity. Listening was a separate task.”

12

When he returned home, Nikhil asked, “The vow broke?”

“Yes.”

“Were you angry about my loan?”

Harinath said, “I was worried, not angry. I needed to see the papers.”

Nikhil was quiet for a moment. “I read your face and decided for myself.”

“A face is not a very good book,” Malti Devi called from inside.

This time all three laughed.

That night Malti Devi was heating milk. Harinath sat on the veranda. Suddenly the milk rose toward the rim. Harinath shouted, “Malti, the milk!”

Malti Devi ran to the stove, pulled down the pot, then turned and said, “That use of speech was very useful.”

Harinath smiled.

No disciple extracted a philosophical meaning from the sentence that night.

13

The next morning Harinath reached the ashram. He took down the notice about “silent discipline” from the gate. He did not remove the donation box; instead he stuck a new slip on it: “Donations voluntary. No signs.”

Sadanand read it and looked a little embarrassed, then straightened the slip.

There was an old notebook in the ashram room in which Harinath had made notes before the vow. On the first page he had written, “Thirty days: speak less, listen more.”

He did not cross out “thirty.” Beneath it he wrote, “The vow broke on the twenty-first day.”

Then, after leaving some space, he wrote, “In my silence, people heard their own voices more than I heard anything.”

He paused. The line sounded a little too beautiful. He wondered whether it was turning into another sermon.

On the next line he wrote more plainly: “It was necessary to say a clear ‘no’ in time about Ramvati’s land.”

That line felt truer to him.

14

In the evening a lamp burned beneath the peepal tree. People came as before, though fewer of them. A young man asked for advice about anxiety over his

work. Harinath did not answer at once. He asked the question again in another form: “What are you most afraid of?”

The young man began to think.

Malti Devi watched from a distance. The scene seemed quieter to her than the vow had been. Harinath was speaking, but less. He no longer placed his own meaning into another person’s sentence before it had been completed.

The peepal leaves moved. So did the flame of the lamp. Darkness lay around the flame. People could assign whatever meaning they wished to the darkness—fear, rest, emptiness, night. The flame merely made visible the things within its reach.

Harinath closed the notebook.

Whether silence was sacred or not—he had found no answer. But he understood this much: being quiet and listening are not the same thing; and turning another person’s silence into one’s own sentence is certainly not listening.

The lamp flame was not still. Nor were words. The empty space between them did not speak its own meaning either.

— *End of Story* 33 —

34. Dream

STORY

I

The first time Ishan saw such a dream, he was twelve. He was standing in the courtyard of his own house, but in the middle of the courtyard there was no well. There was a narrow bridge. Beneath the bridge, not water but night was flowing. He crossed the bridge and reached another veranda of his own house, where his mother sat and said, "Why did you take so long?"

When he woke in the morning, he remembered the bridge and his mother's words. The well stood in its proper place in the courtyard. Night was not flowing. He laughed.

Thirteen years later, when Ishan was twenty-seven, the same bridge returned. This time, on the other side, there was not his mother but a closed library. Its narrow door was painted a deep blue-black; three small brass nails shone on the left jamb, and near the bottom ran a mark like the dried ripple of water. In brass letters on the door were the words: "What has been read is not here."

In the dream Ishan pushed the door. Inside were a table, two chairs, and the smell of neem leaves. On the table lay a notebook bearing his name. The date on its first page was tomorrow's.

He tried to open it, but a hand—whose, he could not see—closed the notebook.

When he woke, he spent a long time looking at his palm. There was no notebook. Whether there was still the smell of neem leaves, he could not decide. Outside the window stood the neighbour's neem tree.

From that day Ishan began keeping a notebook. At the top he wrote, "Dreams." Then he stopped and crossed out "Dreams." Beneath it he wrote, "Seen at Night."

2

Ishan worked as a proofreader at a small publishing house in town. All day his task was to see whether one letter had been changed for another, whether a vowel sign had dropped out, whether a page had been reversed. At night, his world was not nearly so careful.

Sometimes in a dream he reached the same office, but every book had blank pages and only the errors were printed in red ink. Sometimes the press ran, but dry leaves came out instead of paper. Sometimes the editor handed

him a page on which there was only one sentence: "Ishan did not come to the office today."

After such a dream, he would reach the office in the morning and look at the attendance register. His name would be entered there as usual.

One day the editor, Mahendra Babu, asked with a laugh, "Do you proofread at night too?"

Ishan started. "Why?"

"The manuscript you took home yesterday—you've written something in the margin in your sleep: 'The door of this page will not open.'"

Ishan looked at the manuscript. In pencil there really was something like that sentence. The handwriting seemed to be his, though the letters were slightly taller. He did not remember opening the manuscript that night.

"You must have written it in your sleep," Mahendra Babu said casually.

Ishan nodded just as casually. But in the notebook he wrote: "If I do not remember something, does merely calling it 'sleep' make the matter complete?"

3

He showed the notebook to his friend Nachiketa. Nachiketa taught science, but Ishan respected him because he did not leap to conclusions.

Nachiketa's first question was, "You write down what you saw in a dream; do you also write down what you already knew before you woke?"

"No."

"Then the two can mix. Something you saw during the day may return at night. Afterwards it can seem as though the night told you first."

Ishan said, "Should I make two sections?"

"Do. But dividing them will not make the boundary certain. It will only make your memory a little clearer."

He made two sections: "Seen at Night" and "Checked After Waking." On the third day he added a third: "Known Beforehand?"

The trouble began when certain things fit properly into none of the sections.

One night he dreamed of an old railway station. The clock on the platform had no hands. A tea seller gave him tea in an earthen cup and said, "Your train came yesterday." Far away, a white kite lay on the railway track.

In the morning, on his way to the office, Ishan really did see a white kite caught in the overhead wires. He opened his notebook and wrote: "Kite: seen at night. Seen in the morning. Known beforehand? No."

Then he stopped and added: "Perhaps I had seen it yesterday evening too?"

That "perhaps" gave him relief and dissatisfaction at the same time.

4

At home his mother, Devaki Devi, spoke very little about dreams. When Ishan told her about the bridge, she only asked, "The night that flowed beneath it—what did it look like?"

Ishan was surprised. "Like water. But not water."

"Were you frightened?"

"No. Astonished."

Devaki Devi strained the tea and said, "Good. Let the astonishment remain astonishment."

"You won't ask what it was a sign of?"

"What would I gain by calling it a sign?"

Ishan laughed. "The aunties in the village would find plenty of meanings."

"The aunties have the right to find meanings. You have no obligation to believe them."

Ishan did not write this sentence of Devaki Devi's in the notebook. Yet later, many times, he felt as though he had written it there.

5

Three weeks later the dream-library opened again. This time there were no words on the door. A young woman sat inside. Ishan could not decide whether he had seen her somewhere before. Her hair was short, there was a bluish shadow like a mark on her forehead, and she held a grey-bound book.

"You are late," she said.

Ishan blurted, "Is there time here?"

She laughed. "If you are looking for a clock, there must be something."

"Who are you?"

"Whatever name you give me."

"That is not an answer."

"Then the question is not complete either."

Ishan was irritated. "Is this my dream?"

The young woman closed the book. "If I say yes, will you consider me less real? If I say no, more?"

Ishan did not answer.

She placed a brass button on the table. "You will find this tomorrow."

"Where?"

"Where you will not look."

When he woke, the first thing Ishan did was search his pillow, his cot, his table, and his pockets. There was no brass button. He laughed at himself.

At noon, while opening an old bound volume in the office, a brass button fell to the floor. Perhaps it had broken from someone's kurta long ago and become trapped inside the binding case.

Ishan picked up the button.

Mahendra Babu said, "Someone's old thing. Throw it away."

Ishan did not throw it away. He pressed the button between the pages of the notebook.

Then he wrote: "Prophecy?"

After a long time he added after the question mark: "Or coincidence? Or memory of a button seen earlier? No proof."

6

After the button, Ishan became more cautious, not less. It was not his excitement that frightened him; he distrusted it. He showed the button to Nachiketa.

Nachiketa said, "This proves only that you saw a button at night and found a button during the day. We do not yet know the relation between the two."

"You are not astonished?"

"Very much. But astonishment and conclusion are different things."

"What if it happens again?"

"Then write it again."

Ishan smiled. "Why is your answer to everything 'write it down'?"

"Because memory tells beautiful stories. Keeping an account spoils the beauty a little."

That night Ishan dreamed of Nachiketa. Nachiketa sat by a river tearing pages from the notebook and making a boat.

Ishan shouted, "That was evidence!"

Nachiketa said, "The boat too is evidence that paper gets wet."

In the morning Ishan laughed so much at the sentence that Devaki Devi asked, "Whom did you meet last night?"

Ishan said, "Nachiketa."

"But he came here yesterday."

Ishan stopped laughing. He had no memory of Nachiketa having come to the house the previous day.

Devaki Devi said matter-of-factly, "You were at the office. He sat for five minutes and left."

The matter was simple. Yet Ishan wrote in the notebook: "Someone's waking event may not be a memory for me; someone's dream-event may be a memory for me. 'Memory' itself is not the boundary."

7

One day a new manuscript arrived at the office—the memoir of an elderly teacher. In the third chapter there was an incident: as a child, the author had crossed a river at night in a boat and met a boatman; in the morning his family told him he had never left the house. The author ended: "Even now I cannot decide whether the river was in the dream or the house was."

Ishan remained over the page for a long time.

Mahendra Babu asked, "An error?"

"No. A sentence."

"Proofread the sentence, not the life," Mahendra Babu said.

Ishan lifted the red pencil. The vowel sign in “river” was correct. “Dream” was correct. “House” was correct. Grammatically the sentence was clean.

That evening it suddenly occurred to Ishan that the daytime world too depended, to a great extent, on other people’s testimony. He did not know his date of birth from memory; he knew it from a certificate. Many childhood events he accepted because his parents had told him about them. Much of what he had done in the office yesterday could be supplied to him by his colleagues.

The thought did not make dreams seem true to him. It merely made waking certainty a little more modest.

8

The young woman appeared in the dream-library for the third time. This time Ishan gave her the name “Neera.”

“Why?” she asked.

“I need a name.”

“You do.”

“You don’t?”

“Would my name solve your question?”

Ishan said, “At least I will be able to write it in the notebook.”

Neera laughed. “Then write it.”

She went toward the room at the back of the library. Its wall held many windows, but every window showed a different time. In one there was dawn, in one afternoon, in one pounding rain, in one a star-filled night.

Ishan went to one window. It showed the courtyard of his own house. Devaki Devi was watering the tulsi.

“Is this now?”

Neera said, “The ‘now’ in the question you are asking belongs to which window?”

Ishan turned, irritated. “You twist everything.”

“You want everything straight.”

Ishan suddenly asked, “Where do you go when I wake?”

For the first time Neera’s face became sad—or so it seemed to Ishan; he could not be certain.

“You wake,” she said. “Where I go—that question is in the language of your waking.”

In the morning Ishan could not remember the whole sentence. Only “You wake” remained.

9

One night Ishan woke inside the dream. Yes, woke—he was completely certain that he was getting out of bed. The same room, the same window, the same notebook on the table. He drank water, went to the veranda, heard his mother cough, opened the gate, and walked out to the road.

The milkman met him. "So early today?"

Ishan asked, "What day is it?"

The milkman laughed. "Have you forgotten the day too?"

Ishan walked as far as the market. Everything was ordinary. Only the clocks had no hands. Shopkeepers, bicycles, dogs, tea, newspapers—everything.

Suddenly he understood that this might be a dream. What was the proof? Only the missing clock hands?

He pinched his hand. There was pain.

He drank tea. There was taste.

He smelled the dust of the road. There was scent.

"None of this proves anything," Nachiketa's voice returned to him.

So Ishan asked a betel-shop keeper for paper and wrote: "If this is a dream, when morning comes I will remember this sentence." He folded the paper and put it in his pocket.

Then he woke.

Really?

He was in bed. Light outside. The notebook on the table. No paper in his pocket.

But the place on his right palm where he had pinched it was slightly red.

He looked at it for a long time. He could have scratched himself with a fingernail in the night. Or during the previous day. Or the memory of pain in the dream might now be assigning meaning to the redness.

In the notebook he wrote: "The body too did not become the final judge."

The next day an old iron cupboard was moved in the office. Behind it, on the wall Ishan had seen for five years only as a grey strip, a narrow door emerged. The paint was peeling, a dark blue-black; three small brass nails stood on the left jamb; along the bottom ran an old wavy stain of damp. Ishan held a dusting cloth in his hand. It stopped in mid-air.

He did not open the notebook at once. First he touched the door. The wood was solid, with fine worm-holes along the edges. Mahendra Babu said, "Old bound volumes, forms, and waste paper are stored in this room. Once the cupboard was put here the door simply stayed shut." Ishan asked, "When I first started working here, was this door visible?" Mahendra Babu pushed his glasses up onto his forehead. "Perhaps for two or four days. How would I remember?"

The door was opened. Inside there was no library—only such a small room that if two people stood together their shoulders would touch. Dust, old cover-board, coils of string, discarded forms. In one corner lay dry neem leaves. Mahendra Babu said, "The old people used to keep them so insects would not get into the paper." At the smell of neem, the table in the library, the grey book, and Neera's face rose together inside Ishan. But neem was hardly an unusual thing in town or village.

He drew the door on paper—the three nails, the stain, the latch, the small crack in the jamb. Then an uncomfortable thought occurred to him: in his earlier notes he had never recorded these details of the dream-door. What now seemed to him "the same" door—was the memory of the night

actually being rewritten by this daytime door? Or had he once seen this door for an instant before it was blocked and the night had given it a new form? He wrote both possibilities in the notebook and added only: "Similarity recorded; sequence uncertain."

That night the library did not return. Only the door appeared, standing alone in mist with no wall around it. Ishan looked at the left jamb. There were four brass nails, not three. He kept counting them. Slowly the fourth nail became a point of light. In the morning he counted the office door again—three. The mismatch did not disappoint him; it brought a strange relief. The dream was not obliged to obey his investigation by producing an exact copy.

Four nights after this, Ishan experienced a morning that unsettled him more than anything else. He woke, brushed his teeth, drank tea made by Devaki Devi, bathed, and went to the office. On the way there were the same vegetable seller, the same yellow bus, the same wet sand at the turn. Nothing was unusual.

At the office Mahendra Babu asked him to look again at two pages. At noon a client came whose manuscript was titled "Between Two Mornings." Ishan laughed at the title, though the author did not ask why. In the evening he received part of his salary. On his way home he bought a new notebook with a blue cover near the station. At home Devaki Devi said, "The salt is finished. Bring some tomorrow."

That night he wrote on the first page of the blue notebook: "Today was a very ordinary day." Then he put out the lamp and went to sleep.

Then he woke.

Morning lay outside the window. The old notebook was on the table; the new blue-covered notebook was not. The clothes he had worn to the office were folded on the chair—from yesterday. The salary money he had put in his pocket was gone. Devaki Devi was making tea in the kitchen.

Ishan first checked the date. It was the same date that had been morning at the beginning of that "whole day." He understood that he had gone to the office, lived through noon, returned from the market in the evening, gone to bed at night—and all of it had happened within one night. Yet even saying "within one night" depended on the clock of waking.

He went to Devaki Devi. "Is there salt in the house?"

Devaki Devi opened the tin and looked. "A little. Bring some today."

Ishan was silent. In the dream-day her words had been, "The salt is finished. Bring some tomorrow." Here the meaning was close, the words different, the time different.

At the office he searched Mahendra Babu's table for a manuscript called "Between Two Mornings." It was not there. Mahendra Babu instead handed him a booklet on agriculture. The salary too was not due that day but the following week.

Ishan felt a strange grief—as if he had lost an entire day. The tea, the client, the salary, the blue notebook—if all of it had been a dream, it nevertheless existed in his memory with more detail than many waking days.

In the notebook he wrote: "If a day was not shared, was it not a day? It leaves no result in the outer accounts, yet inside me there is fatigue,

attachment, and loss.” A little later he added: “Even so, I cannot ask for yesterday’s salary. The shared world keeps a different ledger.”

After writing this, for the first time he understood that giving dreams and waking life equal narrative dignity was not the same as giving them equal external authority. The memory of meeting someone in a dream might be part of his experience; but on that basis he could not impose a debt, promise, or blame on a waking person. The boundary seemed useful to him, though not final.

IO

After this, Ishan stopped writing down dreams for a few days. It was not fear but exhaustion. By testing everything, he was draining the taste from the day. Instead of drinking tea, he would wonder whether he had tasted it in a dream yesterday. Crossing the road, he looked for kites. In the office he searched for objects like the brass button.

One evening Devaki Devi said, “You live more in the accounting of dreams now than in the dreams themselves.”

Ishan asked, “Then should I stop writing them down?”

“Did I say that?”

“No.”

“Then why put a sentence into my mouth?”

Ishan laughed. He realised that in his haste to escape uncertainty, he was completing other people’s words as well.

Devaki Devi said, “What you saw at night, you saw. What work you have in the daytime, do it. Why put both of them in court?”

“Because I want to know which is true.”

“Does two things being true mean they must be true in the same way?”

Ishan did not answer. Devaki Devi did not offer a philosophical explanation either. She got up and went into the kitchen.

II

Two weeks later Nachiketa suggested a small experiment. “If you like, try to find in a dream some information you could not know in the daytime. But whatever the result, do not jump to a conclusion.”

Ishan said, “For example?”

Nachiketa put five slips of paper of different colours in his pocket. “Tonight I will choose one colour and put it in a drawer at home. I won’t tell you. If you see anything in a dream, write it down. We will check in the morning.”

Ishan agreed, but that night he dreamed of no colour. There was only the library, Neera, and a glass bowl filled not with water but with yellow light.

In the morning he wrote, “Yellow?” and then a question mark.

He went to Nachiketa’s house. There was a green slip in the drawer.

Ishan could not decide whether he felt disappointed or relieved.

Nachiketa laughed. "One night's result. That much and no more."

Ishan said, "The yellow answer was wrong."

Nachiketa stopped him at once. "If the question was to guess the colour, then yellow did not match. Say only that. Calling the dream 'false' would again be a much larger conclusion."

Ishan crossed out "wrong" in his notebook and wrote, "Did not match."

That night, in the dream, Neera asked, "Did you find the green paper?"

Ishan woke.

He looked at the clock at once. Three twenty in the morning.

He wanted to phone Nachiketa, but did not. He waited until morning.

In the morning Nachiketa said, "You knew about the green after opening the drawer yesterday. It is not surprising that it appeared in a dream at night."

Ishan asked, "And Neera, who asked the question in the dream?"

"A character in your dream."

"Does naming her that explain so much?"

Nachiketa was quiet for a moment. "No. Giving a name does not finish the description."

12

On a winter night Neera was not in the library. On the table lay only Ishan's notebook—the real notebook? Same binding, same corner, same brass button pressed inside it.

Ishan turned the pages. All the entries he had written after waking were there. But between them were lines he did not remember writing.

One line said: "An event of the day too becomes a story after one wakes from it."

Another: "Waking life issues its own certificate of authenticity."

A third: "Tomorrow Ma will say—do not hang the red towel low."

Ishan stopped at the third line. It was ordinary and testable.

When he woke, he opened the notebook at once. None of the three lines was there. He wrote them on a separate sheet so he would not forget.

At breakfast Devaki Devi was hanging clothes to dry in the courtyard. Ishan deliberately hung a red towel low on the clothesline, close to the ground.

Devaki Devi saw it. "Hang that towel higher. The calf will get its mouth on it down there."

A shiver went through Ishan.

His mother had not literally said "do not hang it low." The meaning was almost the same. But Ishan himself had hung the towel low—he had created the situation that could produce the sentence.

In the notebook he wrote: "Does a prophecy create its own event?"

He did not cross it out. He left the question there.

Then came a night from which Ishan remembered no unusual dream at all. Morning was ordinary. The office was ordinary. Mahendra Babu searched for his spectacles while they were on his head. Nachiketa phoned and asked to meet on the way to the vegetable market. Devaki Devi was sorting dal.

The day felt intensely solid to Ishan. The experience itself was strange—as though he were tasting the firmness of “waking.”

In the evening, returning from the market, he reached the old station. The clock was being repaired; its hands had been removed and laid to one side. A tea seller was serving tea in earthen cups on the platform. Beside the tracks lay a white kite.

Ishan stopped.

He had already seen this scene in a dream—the handless clock, the tea seller, the white kite.

But had coming to the station today been his own choice, or had the dream influenced him? How long had the clock been under repair? White kites were not unusual in this town. The tea seller had been there for years.

The tea seller handed him a cup and said, “After such a long time today?”

Ishan’s heart beat faster. In the dream the sentence had been: “Your train came yesterday.” This was different.

He drank the tea.

The tea seller asked, “What happened? Why are you making that face, as though you had been here before?”

Ishan laughed. “Perhaps.”

In that moment he understood that the word “before” could contain both day and night.

Ishan could not later record the exact date on which the dream-library appeared for the last time. Perhaps it was the beginning of Phagun. When he opened the blue-black door, he counted the nails on the jamb—three. But there was no water-stain below; instead there was a pale line, as though light had rested there for a long time. This time all the windows in the library were closed. Neera sat at the table with the brass button before her.

“Have you come to prove yourself to me?” Ishan asked.

Neera said, “Do you want to prove me?”

“I used to.”

“And now?”

Ishan was silent for a long time. “Now I want to know why what happens with you must be called less true.”

Neera answered, “Because after morning its consequences are different.”

Ishan started. “Then you admit this is a dream?”

“I said only that the consequences are different.”

“Why do you never say anything plainly?”

Neera laughed. “Perhaps you made me that way.”

“And if I did not?”

"Then?"

They both laughed.

The walls of the library slowly filled with light. Ishan remembered the first bridge beneath which night had flowed.

He asked, "After waking, will I remember you?"

Neera said, "What you keep will be memory. It will not be me."

Ishan wanted to ask what the sentence meant, but the light kept growing.

15

In the morning Ishan was in bed. Light outside the window. Devaki Devi sweeping the courtyard. Far away the milkman's bell. Everything ordinary.

He opened the notebook and began writing the night's dream. "Neera said—What you keep will be memory. It will not be me."

His pen stopped. Had Neera really said it in those words? Or was the morning Ishan turning an indistinct sentence into something more beautiful?

Beside the second half of the sentence he wrote: "Wording uncertain."

The brass button was still pressed inside the notebook. He took it out and held it in the window light. It was ordinary—four holes, green corrosion around the rim.

Devaki Devi came inside. "Where did this come from?"

Ishan said, "I found it in the office."

"Will you keep it?"

Ishan thought for a moment. "Yes."

"Why?"

"For memory."

Devaki Devi asked, "Of what?"

Ishan smiled. "Only that once this button seemed very mysterious to me."

Devaki Devi turned the button in her hand and put it back on the table. To her it was only a button.

Ishan liked that.

16

Many months later Ishan's notebook was full. He bought a new one, but did not repeat the old headings. Not "Seen at Night," not "Dream," not "Waking." He wrote only the date.

Nachiketa asked, "Have you stopped marking the distinction?"

"I have not stopped believing in distinctions. I have only stopped naming every page in advance."

"Why?"

Ishan said, "Some events can be checked after waking, some cannot. Some leave an effect on the body, some only in memory. Some things are

seen by other people too, some by one person alone. These distinctions are useful. But ‘useful’ and ‘final’ are not the same.”

Nachiketa laughed. “Now you are beginning to talk like me.”

Ishan said, “Neera could say that to me tonight as well.”

“Then give me the credit.”

They both laughed.

17

Whether Ishan dreamed that night, he could not remember the next morning. He remembered only that at some point in the night he had been standing on a bridge—perhaps in a dream, perhaps in an old image remade by memory. Beneath the bridge this time, not night but a faint light was flowing.

He woke—or rose—and opened the window.

The dawn sky was grey. A white kite was caught on a rooftop in the distance. The brass button lay on the table. In the courtyard Devaki Devi was watering the tulsi.

For a moment Ishan wondered: where had he seen all this before?

Then he felt no need to answer the question at once.

He opened the new notebook and wrote the date. Beneath it only one sentence: “Morning came.”

He paused and thought of adding a question mark. He did not. Nor did he cross it out, because he had never written it.

Light entered through the window. It made the table, the button, the notebook, and his hand visible.

The light did not also declare which world this belonged to.

Even so, what was visible was, in that moment, his experience.

Ishan lifted the pen.

— End of Story 34 —

35. Doubt

STORY

I

Shailesh Master wrote on the school blackboard in white chalk: "To question is not disrespect." Then he stepped aside and looked at the students. In the eighth-standard class, some had opened their notebooks, some were watching the peepal leaves beyond the window, and some were watching chalk dust drift in the air. Shailesh liked a classroom in which a question could remain standing before an answer arrived.

That day the lesson was on eclipses. The previous week the village had seen a lunar eclipse, and half the village had kept food covered, placed tulsi leaves upon it, and counted the proper time for bathing. At school two children said that going outdoors during an eclipse brought a blemish upon the body. Without laughing, Shailesh had asked, "Has anyone seen evidence of that?"

The classroom had grown heated. One child said, "Grandmother says so." Another: "They did not say it on the radio." A third: "I was outside, and nothing happened to me." Shailesh had then explained that an astronomical event and a household fear were not the same thing. The positions of the Moon, Earth, and Sun could be measured; the history of a grandmother's fear was another question.

As the class ended, little Rashmi asked, "Master Sahib, if everyone at home believes something, then what do you do?"

The question was simple, yet Shailesh did not answer at once. The next day was his father's shraddha. For three days his mother had been sorting rice. His wife Anupama was making a list. An invitation had already been sent to Pandit Krishnamohan Kaka.

Shailesh set the chalk down and said, "At home too, I ask questions."

Whether Rashmi was satisfied could not be read from her face. But to Shailesh his own answer felt incomplete.

2

When he returned from school, two low wooden stools had been set in the sun in the courtyard. On one stood a glass bowl of sesame seeds, on the other paddy. Bhubneshwari Devi sat on the veranda picking stones from the rice. Her fingers had grown old, but the sorting was still exact.

“Bathe early tomorrow morning,” his mother said. “Krishnamohan will be here by seven.”

Shailesh took off his bag. “Do I have to sit for the ritual?”

Bhubneshwari Devi looked up. “It is your father’s shraddha. Then who will sit?”

“Sitting and believing are not the same thing, Ma.”

“Have I given you a paper on which you must write what you believe?”

The sentence was a little sharp, but she went back to sorting rice. Shailesh went inside. Anupama was drying spices in the kitchen. Seeing him, she said, “You have started again?”

“I only asked.”

“Your ‘I only asked’ is the biggest declaration in this house.”

Shailesh fell silent. Anupama was not his opponent. On the night of the eclipse, she had been the first person in the house to open the window and look at the Moon. When their child had a fever, she had taken him to the hospital instead of for an exorcism. But on the day of her father-in-law’s shraddha, she did not argue with his mother.

“Do you yourself believe that by offering pinda Father is somehow satisfied somewhere?” Shailesh asked.

Turning the spices, Anupama said, “I do not know. But your mother feels that on this day her son sits beside her. I can see the effect of that before my eyes.”

“Then I should perform a play?”

“There is a difference between acting and giving someone company.”

“Who decides the difference?”

Anupama looked at him. “You do. Only remember this: while protecting your own integrity, do not turn someone else’s grief into a laboratory.”

3

That night Shailesh sat in the reading room. When he opened the desk drawer, he saw an old fountain pen—a black body, a golden nib, scratches on the cap. It had belonged to his father. Raghunandan Babu used to write accounts in the village court. His handwriting was as straight as rows of transplanted paddy.

Shailesh took the pen in his hand. One memory opened immediately: he was ten, had received low marks in mathematics, and his father had struck the pen on the table and said, “If you are going to study, then study properly.” That night Shailesh had cried. Another memory ran in the opposite direction: there had been no money for his trip to Patna for the Class Twelve science exhibition; his father had not bought himself a new dhoti and had given the money to him.

Which Raghunandan was true? The one who scolded, or the one who paid? The man who performed worship, or the man who opened the radio and listened to the news? He would not eat without bathing in the morning, yet if anyone in the house fell ill, he ran to the doctor before he went to a pandit.

Memory always spoiled the neat compartments of Shailesh's arguments. In examples made for school, a human being became simple—"the cause of belief," "absence of evidence," "the pressure of tradition." At home the same human being was tangled like matted hair.

He wondered: if he did not sit for the shraddha tomorrow, what would that prove? That he stood firmly by what he said? And if he did sit, what would that prove? That his public reasoning belonged only to the platform? Both conclusions seemed contrived.

The nib had dried. Shailesh scratched it across paper. No ink came out. Even so, the nib left a fine line on the page—the mark of pressure.

It suddenly occurred to him that some objects stopped writing and still left a mark. Then at once he doubted his own metaphor. It was not right to turn his dead father into a dry pen. He put the pen back in the drawer.

4

The next morning the house woke early. The courtyard was washed. Near the tulsi there was no lamp, only the shine of water. Bhubneshwari Devi had bathed and was wearing a white sari. Anupama was in the kitchen. Their son Anshuman had come home from the city for the holiday; he sat on the veranda, the screen of his phone glowing.

Anshuman came close to his father and asked softly, "Are you really going to sit?"

"It seems so."

"At school you criticize ritual."

Shailesh heard his own younger voice—its edge, its straightness. "I never tell anyone not to remember."

"But the pinda?"

"That is the question."

"Then do not do it."

Shailesh looked at Anshuman. Was it that simple? He remembered being twenty and telling his father, "If there is no evidence for something, I will not believe it." His father had replied, "Do not believe it. But in front of your grandmother, take off your shoes and walk respectfully." At the time, Shailesh had thought it a cowardly compromise. Today the same sentence, in another form, was circling inside him.

"What would you do?" he asked his son.

Anshuman shrugged. "I would not sit."

"And if your grandmother's heart broke?"

"I would explain it to her."

"And if even after understanding, her heart still broke?"

Anshuman was silent.

Shailesh thought: the reasoning of youth is sharp because it has not yet had to bear the weight of every consequence. Then he felt ashamed of his own thought. Was that not merely age's arrogance in reverse? It was possible that Anshuman truly saw more clearly.

5

Krishnamohan Kaka arrived at ten past seven. Dhoti, bag, spectacles. Shailesh had known him since childhood. He was a pandit, but he also farmed; he spoke just as readily about the mood of the weather, varieties of seed, and old songs.

"Master, ready?" he asked with a smile.

Shailesh wanted to say, "No." What came out was, "Please sit."

Krishnamohan Kaka began laying out the materials: sesame, kusha grass, water, two leaves. Shailesh stared at them. Every object was physical—weight, smell, temperature, texture. Yet when his mother looked at those same objects there was another meaning on her face. Meaning could not be weighed on a scale; that did not automatically make meaning an external fact. Shailesh repeated this distinction to himself again and again.

Before the mantras began, Shailesh said softly, "Kaka, one thing."

Krishnamohan pushed his spectacles up.

"I will not be made to say a sentence I do not believe."

Bhubneshwari Devi's fingers stopped. Anshuman stood by the doorway.

Krishnamohan asked, "Which sentence?"

"A definite claim that the dead literally eat this food, or that this rite changes their condition in another world."

For a moment Krishnamohan Kaka looked at Shailesh. Then he said, "I will not force such a sentence into your mouth. I will recite the mantras that belong to the rite. You may offer water and speak your father's name. If even that is more than you wish to do, say so."

Shailesh was surprised. He had prepared himself for a quarrel; the quarrel did not come. One refuge of doubt is the imagined hardness of the opposing side. When that hardness fails to appear, one's own position lies more exposed.

6

The ritual began. Shailesh spoke his father's name. "Raghunandan." The moment he said it, he did not remember his father's face but his heels—cracked in winter, mustard oil rubbed into them at night. Shailesh was startled. Why, at a shraddha, did he remember not the scriptural ancestor but a small fissure in the body?

Krishnamohan continued the mantras. Shailesh kept releasing water. It sank into the earth. Two voices went on inside him: one said, "This act proves no invisible consequence in the external world." The other said, "Mother is not counting these drops; she is hearing her son speak his father's name."

Then a third voice rose: "Does emotional usefulness make every ritual right?" No. Many traditions had carried pain, exclusion, expense, fear, and inequality. To accept everything merely because "Mother wants it" would be an abandonment of reason.

Then a fourth: "And is a harmless method of remembrance to be rejected merely because its language comes from an older belief?"

Shailesh felt as though a panchayat had assembled inside his head. No presiding elder was going to give the final verdict.

Krishnamohan Kaka said, "Now place the food."

Shailesh extended his hand, then stopped. "Kaka, one more thing."

This time Bhubneshwari Devi lost patience. "Is this a shraddha or a classroom?"

The words struck like an arrow. Shailesh realized that he truly was turning the house into a classroom. He placed the food without another word.

7

By the time the meal was being prepared, the main part of the rite was over. Several relatives had arrived. Conversation began, and memories of Raghunandan Babu came out in different forms. Someone said he kept strict accounts of loans. Someone said that in the year of the flood he had given paddy to three families. Someone laughed and said that at weddings he sat in the very front to watch the dancing, then came home and claimed, "I went only because people insisted."

To Shailesh this part felt more alive than the ritual. He wanted to tell everyone: this—this is remembrance. Then he realized that this conversation was taking place because the ritual had brought everyone together on one day, in one place. Without the shraddha, perhaps each of them would have been in his own field, shop, bus, or phone today. But "perhaps" was not evidence. They might have gathered under some other pretext too.

Anupama was laying out leaf plates. Shailesh rose to help, but Bhubneshwari Devi stopped him. "You sit for now. That is the rule."

"Ma, why is that the rule?"

His mother looked at him with tired eyes. "Is it necessary to ask why about everything right now?"

Shailesh sat down again. He had no answer to that sentence. Asking questions was his nature, but choosing the time for a question could itself be an ethical act—something he had never taught his students.

Anshuman was sitting nearby. He whispered, "You agreed."

"To what?" Shailesh asked.

"The rule."

"Is following something once the same as accepting it as true?"

Anshuman did not answer. His face suggested that the question no longer interested him; it inconvenienced him. Shailesh smiled inwardly—today, for the first time, his son was tired of his questions.

8

By afternoon the visitors had thinned. Bhubneshwari Devi sat exhausted on the veranda. Shailesh gave her water. Taking the glass, she asked, "Was it hard for you?"

“A little.”

“Because of me?”

Shailesh almost said “No” at once, but stopped. “Some of it because of you. Some of it because of myself.”

His mother smiled faintly. “If your father were alive, he would have argued with you a great deal.”

“He did argue with me when he was alive.”

“But the pen you were looking at last night—he had thought of giving it to you.”

Shailesh was startled. “How do you know?”

“I lived in the house.”

She continued, “Two months before he died, he said: I will give it to Shailesh; it will keep writing in his hand.”

Something softened inside Shailesh. At the same time doubt arose: was his mother, in this moment, giving an old memory a new meaning? Had Father really intended to give him the pen, or was she creating the connection now? The moment the question arose, he grew angry with himself. Did every sentence of affection require testimony, a date, a document? Then the mind answered: memory can be wrong too. Love does not prove the infallibility of memory.

He did not question his mother. He held her hand and sat beside her for a while.

In that silence Shailesh understood for the first time that not every question born of doubt had to be spoken aloud. Some questions could remain within and still remain honest. Silence was not the same as accepting an answer.

A little later Krishnamohan Kaka returned for his bag. Seeing the veranda empty, he sat beside Shailesh. “I put up with a lot of interruptions today,” he said with a smile.

Shailesh was embarrassed. “Did you mind?”

“Are you the only one allowed to mind?” Krishnamohan laughed. “I have doubts too. I recite the mantras because this is both my tradition and my livelihood. But do I understand every meaning written in the books in exactly the same way? No.”

Shailesh was startled. In the argument inside his own head he had kept Krishnamohan as a clean opposing position. When the opponent himself turned out to be complicated, argument became less convenient.

Krishnamohan continued, “There is one thing I understand differently from you. A rite divides time for human beings. On this day you will do this; at this hour you will remember this name. There is belief in it, yes. But there is discipline too.”

Shailesh asked, “If discipline is necessary, why must it be the old rite?”

“It need not be. Make a new one. But after some days people will make the new rite old as well.”

Shailesh both liked and resisted the answer. He feared that while speaking of “human meaning,” people might stop testing claims about the external world. He said, “The problem begins when fear, expense, caste, or coercion is attached in the name of ritual.”

Krishnamohan nodded. "Then fight that part. But while you fight, do not assume that everyone else is a fool and only you are awake."

The sentence was sharp. Shailesh could have replied that he had never said such a thing. But inwardly he remembered how many public speeches of his had taken on a tone as though reason were his private property. He did not extend the argument. He only said, "I will remember that."

Krishnamohan rose. "Keep some doubt about remembering it too, Master." Both of them laughed.

9

That evening Anshuman walked with his father on the roof. In the distance they could see the school's tin roof. Lamps had begun to appear in a few village houses.

Anshuman said, "I still think you should not have sat."

"That may be so."

His son looked at him in surprise. "You mean I am right?"

"I mean there are reasons on your side."

"And on yours?"

"There are reasons there too."

"Then how do you decide?"

Shailesh placed a hand on the railing. "Not every decision is the answer to a mathematical problem. Sometimes we act while certainty is incomplete, and then we also take responsibility for what we chose."

"That is convenient."

The sentence stung. Shailesh thought: yes, doubt can become a curtain for convenience. A person can call whatever he wants "complicated" and justify it. An objection against oneself was necessary too.

"You are right," he said. "Doubt can also become an excuse. That is why we must look at the consequences of what we do."

"And what is the consequence today?"

Shailesh looked down into the courtyard. His mother was laughing at something Anupama had said. Krishnamohan Kaka had gone home. No one had been frightened, no crushing fee had been taken, no one had been excluded. And Shailesh had not spoken the claims he did not believe.

"That is all I can see today," Shailesh said. "The rest of the meaning may change later."

10

The next day at school Rashmi raised her hand again. "Master Sahib, yesterday there was a shraddha in your house?"

The class suddenly became alert. Private news did not take long to reach school in a village.

For one moment Shailesh could have chosen the old answer—"That is private." Or he could have made a hard declaration—"I sat only for my mother." Both would have been incomplete.

He said, "Yes."

A voice came from the back. "Did you do it?"

"I performed some acts. I did not speak some claims."

The children laughed because the answer sounded strange. Rashmi did not laugh. "Then what is right?"

Shailesh turned toward the board. Yesterday's sentence still survived in faint chalk: "To question is not disrespect." Beneath it he wrote: "Question your own answer too."

He did not give the class a sermon. He simply continued the eclipse lesson—shadow, orbit, the angle of light. Yet as he taught, it seemed to him that the second sentence on the board was not only for the children.

At noon Rashmi came to show him her notebook. As she was leaving she asked, "Master Sahib, if there is no evidence for something, then we should not believe it—is that rule correct?"

Shailesh said, "If someone is making a factual claim about the external world, ask for evidence. But first understand what kind of claim it is. Sometimes a person is not stating a fact; they are expressing grief, memory, or hope."

Rashmi asked, "Then accept everything?"

"No."

"Then?"

Shailesh smiled. "Then ask another question."

II

After returning from school, Shailesh went straight to the reading room. He took the fountain pen from the drawer. This time he cleaned the nib and filled it with a little ink. The pen did not write on the first attempt. On the second, a black drop fell on the paper. On the third, a line emerged.

He wrote: "Raghunandan."

The shape of the name brought his father's handwriting to mind, yet this handwriting was his own. There was an odd peace in the difference. Remembrance was not imitation.

Anupama appeared at the door. "Another experiment today?"

"I have got the old pen working."

"Does it write?"

"A little."

Anupama set on the table a small brass bowl left from yesterday's ritual. "Ma said to put this in your room. She thinks Father's things should remain here."

Shailesh looked at the bowl. "They are going to turn my room into a shrine."

Anupama laughed. "It is a bowl. If you like, keep pens in it."

She left. Shailesh actually put the pen into the bowl. Then at once took it out. He was afraid that somewhere inside himself he might turn the act into a symbol. Then he laughed at his fear. Where could one put an object in order to escape symbolism?

In the end he left the pen on the table and the bowl beside it. Separate.

12

That night the electricity went out. Anupama brought a small lamp from the kitchen and set it on the table. Shailesh opened the window. Darkness outside, a yellow flame within.

The lamplight fell on the pen's golden nib and on the rim of the bowl. Shailesh remembered at once yesterday's water, his mother's hand, his son's question, Rashmi's notebook. Some things could be measured, the effects of some things could be observed, and some things were only felt inwardly. To gather all these differences under one word now seemed improper to him.

He opened his notebook and wrote: "I do not know whether yesterday's rite did anything to the dead. I have no evidence for that claim. I know only that something happened among the living—but whether that something came from the ritual itself, from sitting together, from memory, or merely from making time on one day, even that is not entirely clear."

He paused, then added: "Let uncertainty not become an excuse. Let certainty not become arrogance."

He read the sentence. It had become very beautiful. Shailesh distrusted beautiful sentences too—sometimes beauty covered an error in thought. He did not cross it out; he made a small question mark beside it.

The flame moved. By its light objects became visible; the light itself did not decide what those objects meant.

Shailesh picked up the pen. Beneath the question mark he placed a small dot. Then he closed the notebook.

The next morning the board would be wiped clean again. The children would ask questions again. At home his mother would state some old rule again. Anshuman would object again. Shailesh might agree sometimes, refuse sometimes, sometimes simply sit beside them.

He understood only this much: doubt does not block the road; sometimes it slows the foot, so that a person does not trample someone else with his own argument.

Air came in from outside. The flame bent, then straightened.

For a while Shailesh sat in that light without a conclusion.

— *End of Story 35* —

36. Liberation

STORY

I

For three days Dayakant Babu had wanted the eastern window kept open. The last wind of winter blew straight into the room, yet again and again he signaled toward the window with his eyes. Speaking had become difficult now. Sometimes two words came out clearly; sometimes his breath broke halfway through. His daughter Shubhada would adjust the covering and say, “The wind is strong, Babu.” He would shake his head—no, let the window remain open.

Outside the window stood an old mango tree. One thick branch leaned over the courtyard. Beyond it a small gleam of the pond could be seen. Not the whole pond—only a triangular piece of water that changed color with the day’s light: pale in the morning, white at noon, grey toward evening. Dayakant Babu looked at that triangle often. Everyone in the family thought he liked seeing the water. No one knew whether he was looking at the water or at something beyond it.

In that house, time was now measured less by the clock than by his breathing. Shubhada counted the watches of the night. The elder son, Nachiketa, wrote down the hours for medicine. The younger son, Shashank, had returned from Delhi and kept every phone switched off and face down. Granddaughter Ira had taken leave from university; she sat pressing her grandfather’s feet. Dayakant’s wife, Kamala, had died five years earlier. Her photograph stood beside the household shrine, but Dayakant Babu looked less at the photograph than at the empty cot where Kamala had sat during her last months.

People in the village said, “Now have him remember the Name. It is the final time.” Someone brought tulsi leaves, someone Ganges water, someone an old scripture. Nachiketa placed everything respectfully to one side. Shubhada said, “First understand what Babu wants.” But what Babu wanted had to be inferred from his eyes, his fingers, and unfinished words.

Then, on the third evening, he suddenly said in a clear voice, “Liberation.”

The five people sitting in the room looked at one another. The word had been so clear, as though someone had struck a bell once.

Nachiketa bent close. “What do you want, Babu? A reading for liberation?”

Dayakant Babu closed his eyes. No answer came.

The next morning discussion began near the tulsi platform. The village priest, Radhakant Jha, said that in one's final days listening to the Gita was auspicious. Shubhada asked, "Certainly, if Babu wants to listen. But I do not want to place an interpretation in his mouth."

Radhakant Jha did not take offense. He had also been Dayakant's childhood friend. They had studied in the same pathshala, bathed in the same pond; later one became a priest, the other worked in the revenue office and retired. Radhakant set his bag on the veranda and said, "He himself said the word liberation. That is why I came."

Shashank said with some sharpness, "He said the word, so will you decide its meaning too?"

"No," Radhakant replied calmly. "If I decided the meaning, I would become God. I can only read the text."

Shubhada liked the answer, but anxiety sat on Nachiketa's brow. He could see his father's bodily suffering before him. At night Babu tired even while swallowing water; turning on the bed caused pain. For Nachiketa the first meaning of liberation was release from suffering. In that meaning he felt no philosophy was needed. He wanted Babu to be at ease, not afraid, not forced to endure too much bodily pain.

For Shashank the word was different. Twenty years earlier he had gone to the city against the family's wishes. Babu had not replied to his letters for three years. Later they had begun speaking again, but those intervening years had not been erased by any sentence. Shashank wondered whether Babu, by saying "liberation," wanted release from some old anger or guilt—or whether this was merely Shashank's own desire to hear one word of forgiveness from his father.

For Shubhada, the word liberation immediately summoned her mother. At the end Kamala Devi had said, "Do not move me from here; let me remain in this room." The family had taken her to a city hospital. Whether life had been prolonged by two weeks, no one knew for certain; Kamala had not returned home. Dayakant later said again and again, "I could not honor Kamala's wish." Shubhada wondered whether her father's liberation might be release from that memory.

For Ira the word belonged to books. In philosophy class she had read of release, self, bondage, rebirth, ignorance. But before her grandfather's cracked lips and trembling fingers, the definitions from the book felt light as paper.

Each of them sat outside Dayakant's room holding a different liberation. Inside, the old man slept—or perhaps only lay with his eyes closed.

It would have been easy to say that Dayakant Babu had been very religious all his life, but it would not have been accurate. He bathed every day, fasted on festival days, and lit a lamp in the shrine. At the same time he laughed at horoscopes, scolded people for exorcisms, and before changing a doctor

would reread the test reports. He argued scripture with Radhakant Jha, then invited the same man to conduct worship.

Once, long ago, when Shashank was a teenager, he had asked, “Babu, do you believe in God or not?”

Dayakant had replied, “Why are you in such a hurry to put me in one box?”

Shashank had been irritated then. He wanted yes or no. Dayakant’s answer had seemed evasive. Today, sitting outside the room, Shashank remembered the same sentence. Even before death, was Babu refusing a single box?

At noon Dayakant woke. Shubhada touched a spoonful of water to his lips. He drank a little and stopped. Then his finger indicated the window.

“It is already open,” Shubhada said.

He signaled again—more.

One shutter was jammed. Ira brought oil and loosened the latch. When both shutters opened, air entered. The curtain lifted, the medicine papers on the table shifted slightly, the extinguished wick of the lamp bent. More of the pond was visible now.

Dayakant took a long breath. “This is right,” he said.

“What is right?” Ira leaned closer.

“Open.”

Ira laughed. “The window?”

Dayakant too smiled faintly. “For now, the window.”

A shiver ran through Ira at the words “for now.” Had he meant something? Or was it only a joke? She stopped herself from making meaning too quickly. It would have been easy to turn one word of her grandfather’s into a prophecy.

4

That evening Radhakant Jha went inside carrying the Gita. “Shall I read?” he asked.

Dayakant opened his eyes and recognized his friend. “Do you still read that loudly?”

Radhakant laughed. “Your ears have grown old, not my voice.”

The small laughter between the two old men lightened the room a little. Radhakant opened the book, but before beginning asked, “Which chapter?”

Dayakant said, “Whichever you like.”

“And you?”

“What I liked kept changing.”

Radhakant read a few verses. The words were Sanskrit; from time to time he gave the meaning in Maithili. Dayakant sometimes seemed to listen, sometimes closed his eyes. Shubhada sat near the doorway. She feared the reading might turn the room into an announcement of death. But there was no theatricality in Radhakant’s voice; it was as though an old friend were reading an old poem.

At one point came the teaching that the self is indestructible. Radhakant began explaining. Dayakant opened his eyes and stopped him. "Radha."

"Yes?"

"Do you know for certain?"

Radhakant did not close the book, but he stopped reading. After a while he said, "The book says this."

"And you?"

For the first time hesitation came into Radhakant's eyes. "I believe it."

"Believing and knowing?"

"Are not the same."

Dayakant moved his head slightly. "Good."

Shubhada thought there was satisfaction on her father's face. Then she thought: perhaps it was only exhaustion. She let go of the hunger to interpret.

5

That night Shashank sat alone beside his father. Nachiketa had gone to sleep for a while, Shubhada was in the kitchen, Ira on the veranda. A small lamp burned in the room because Dayakant disliked the harsh electric light.

For a long time Shashank did not speak. The sentence he had carried inside for twenty years seemed even more artificial now that death was near. He wanted to ask, "Babu, have you forgiven me?" But the word "forgiven" assumed that the offense itself was settled. Who would call his decision to go to the city a crime? Or his father's three years of silence? Or his own stubbornness in leaving? Both?

Dayakant opened his eyes. "Why are you sitting with such a fallen face?"

Shashank tried to smile. "Nothing."

"Lie."

A flash of the old voice. Shashank's eyes filled. "Do you remember those three years?"

Dayakant's brow tightened. "Which?"

Shashank was stunned. The three years that had remained a thorn inside his own life might no longer have a clear shape in his father's memory.

"When I went to Delhi and you would not answer my letters."

Dayakant thought for a long time. "Yes... some of it."

"Were you angry with me?"

"I was."

"And now?"

Dayakant closed his eyes again. Shashank leaned closer. The answer came after a delay: "Now I am tired."

Shashank did not know whether to laugh or cry. "Is that an answer?"

Dayakant's lips moved faintly. "Anger grows tired too."

"Then—have you forgiven me?"

"Have you forgiven yourself?"

Shashank was silent.

"Why are you asking me for a certificate?"

Shashank lowered his head. The question of proof stood here not on paper, as it had for the mukhiya in Story 25, but between two human beings—yet Shashank did not give that comparison a name. He understood only that hearing one formal pardon from his father might not automatically untie the knot inside him.

After a while Dayakant extended his hand. Shashank held his fingers. Whether that touch contained forgiveness or merely supported a tired body was a decision no one made that night.

6

On the fourth morning Dayakant tried to rise. Nachiketa stopped him. “Your body will not manage.”

“Veranda.”

“There is air here.”

“Veranda.”

Four people carried him out on the cot. The mango tree was fully visible. Fallen leaves below it, the old well nearby, bamboo in the distance. Dayakant kept his eyes open for a long time.

On that veranda he had spent forty years reading account books, teaching the children, quarrelling with his wife, giving tea to guests, watching floodwater rise. Now the same veranda was going on toward a future without him. The thought suddenly became unbearable to Shubhada.

She asked, “Babu, is there anything you want to say about the house? Land, papers, anything?”

Nachiketa immediately looked at his sister. The question was necessary, but the time was cruel. Shubhada herself felt ashamed.

Dayakant laughed—a dry, short laugh. “When a man is dying, everyone remembers the land.”

“I do not want quarrels,” Shubhada said.

“Land does not quarrel.”

“Then?”

“People.”

Nachiketa said, “The papers are prepared. Everyone understands what you divided.”

Dayakant looked at him. “Does paper kill greed?”

No one answered.

After a while he said to Shubhada, “Did I give your mother her share?”

Shubhada was startled. “Mother is...”

“Name.”

Then she understood. In the back orchard of the house stood guava trees planted in Kamala Devi’s name. In the land record the owner was Dayakant. All her life Kamala had said, “This orchard is mine.” Whether it had been a joke or a claim had never become entirely clear.

“Not on paper,” Shubhada said.

Dayakant closed his eyes. “I kept many things in my own name.”

No one decided whether the sentence was only about land or about life.

In the afternoon Ira opened her grandfather's old trunk to look for clothes. Shubhada had asked her to take out a light dhoti. Beneath the dhotis she found letters, ledgers, a broken pair of spectacles, two pieces of Kamala Devi's glass bangle, and a brass tumbler. Ira did not touch the papers, but on top she saw an envelope bearing her mother Shubhada's name.

"Ma, is this yours?"

Shubhada recognized the envelope at once. A letter written a month after her marriage. Her father had written, "If you feel like coming home, tell me. I will deal with what people say." Shubhada had not returned then. Married life had been difficult, but it had not broken. She could not remember whether she herself had later given the letter to her mother for safekeeping or whether her father had kept a copy.

She opened the envelope. The letter was there. The black ink had faded. The final line read: "A daughter's home is not only her husband's house."

Shubhada began to weep as she read. In life Babu had rarely said such things aloud. He had been strict, careful with accounts, attentive to propriety. Yet on paper there was another voice.

Ira asked, "Dada used to write like this?"

"Sometimes."

"Then why do all of you call him hard?"

Wiping her tears, Shubhada said, "One sentence cannot make a whole person."

Ira wanted to show the letter to her grandfather. Shubhada stopped her. "Not now. He is tired."

But in the evening Dayakant himself asked about the trunk. Perhaps he had seen Ira go there. "Found the letter?"

Shubhada was startled. "You remembered it?"

"Not everything."

"Why did you keep this?"

Dayakant said slowly, "Sometimes what I could not say, I wrote."

Shubhada laughed and cried at once. "And sometimes what you wrote, you did not give?"

A glint came into Dayakant's eyes. "Then how did you get it?"

In the question the old father was present again. Shubhada did not put the letter under his pillow. She tucked it into her sari. She felt that if liberation meant release from memory, she did not want release from this letter.

On the fifth day Dayakant spoke very little. His bodily exhaustion had deepened. Nachiketa called the doctor again. The doctor checked his pulse and medicines, then spoke softly with the family—mainly rest, water, keeping the mouth moist; if the pain increased, they should say so. He gave no certain hour.

People outside kept asking, “How much time?” Nachiketa gave everyone the same answer: “It cannot be said.”

The uncertainty irritated him. Having spent his life working with schedules, banks, tickets, and paperwork, Nachiketa wanted death too to give some sign. Who should come when? Should a granddaughter miss an examination or not? Should distant relatives be informed now or later? Was preparing for the funeral cruel or practical?

That night Shubhada saw Nachiketa crying alone on the veranda.

“Bhaiya?”

Nachiketa wiped his eyes. “I am afraid that when Babu goes, I will feel relief too. For five nights I have been thinking—when will this suffering end? Is it sinful to think that?”

Shubhada sat beside him. “I think it too.”

“Then do we want him to die?”

“I do not know.”

Nachiketa looked at his sister. Shubhada said, “Perhaps we want his suffering to end. And our own exhaustion too. Both are there together. It is harder to admit that.”

Nachiketa held his head. “People say the soul will be liberated. It seems to me that first we want to be liberated from caregiving. I hate myself for thinking it.”

Shubhada said softly, “People who care for someone get tired. Exhaustion is not the opposite of love.”

As she said it she remembered their mother Kamala, who during one of Dayakant’s long illnesses had once said, “Let me sleep for one night.” At the time Shubhada had privately thought: how selfish Ma is. Today she felt ashamed of that memory.

The brother and sister kept sitting on the veranda. From inside came the sound of Dayakant’s breathing. That night one hard meaning of liberation opened within them: the burden of a bond made by love is real too. To acknowledge the burden is not the same as breaking the bond.

9

On the sixth morning Dayakant was very quiet. Sunlight from the eastern window fell directly on the cot. Ira went to draw the curtain halfway, but he stopped her with his hand.

“Let the light remain,” he said.

Ira sat down. “Dada, yesterday you said liberation. What does it mean?”

Shubhada stood at the doorway listening. She wanted to stop Ira, then did not. Perhaps the question now belonged to Dayakant’s own word.

Dayakant opened his eyes. “What do you think?”

Ira laughed. “The question comes back to me again?”

“You have studied.”

“I have studied. I have not understood.”

“Good.”

“Have you understood?”

A long pause. Outside, a crow called from a tree. A heron descended onto the pond and flew away again.

Dayakant said, "I used to think I understood."

Ira leaned closer.

"When I was young, I thought liberation meant not being born again. In middle age I thought it meant having no debt. When Kamala went, I thought it meant having no memory. Now..."

The words broke. Shubhada came forward and gave him water. After a little while Ira asked again, "Now?"

Dayakant looked toward the window. "Now—letting go of so many things I cannot decide."

Ira wondered whether this was a philosophical answer or the wish of an exhausted man. She did not ask.

Dayakant spoke again. "But not letting go of everything either."

"What should remain?"

His eyes moved over Shubhada, Ira, the doorway, the window. "Whatever does not leave by itself."

That answer too was a riddle. Dayakant was perhaps not being deliberately obscure; words were becoming insufficient. For the first time Ira felt that near death language grows small, but experience does not necessarily become clear.

IO

That afternoon an unexpected visitor arrived—Dayakant's younger brother Harikant. The two brothers had spoken little for five years. The reason was a path through the ancestral orchard. On paper it was four cubits wide; in practice, three. A trivial measurement had slowly become insult, old accounts, bitterness between wives, and children taking sides. While Kamala lived she had mediated; after her death the distance hardened.

Harikant stopped on the veranda. "Is Bhaiya awake?"

Nachiketa said, "Sometimes awake, sometimes asleep."

Harikant was afraid to go inside. Perhaps he feared Dayakant would turn his face away, or would be unable to speak—either way, five years of distance would take its final form.

Shubhada took his hand and led him inside.

Dayakant's eyes were closed. Harikant sat by the cot and said only, "Bhaiya."

His eyes opened. Recognition took a little longer than before. Then Dayakant said, "Measured the path?"

Harikant's mouth trembled. "No."

"Three cubits or four?"

Breathing itself seemed heavy in the room. Harikant suddenly began to laugh through tears. "You are still there?"

A smile came to Dayakant's lips. "And you?"

Harikant gripped the bamboo of the cot. "Take the whole path. I want nothing."

Dayakant shook his head. "Do not become generous because you have seen death."

"Then what should I do?"

"What you think is right."

"Bhaiya, was I wrong?"

Dayakant closed his eyes, then opened them. "I was wrong too."

It would be tempting to say that the five-year dispute ended in two sentences, but it would be untrue. The land remained where it was, the path still had to be measured, the wives' bitter words remained in memory. Yet the tightness of one knot had loosened a little.

Outside, Harikant told Nachiketa, "We will look at the papers again. We will not fight."

Nachiketa merely nodded. He knew that decisions taken in grief could change later. Even so, the humanity of this moment was not false. A moment did not become unreal merely because it was temporary.

II

On the seventh night rain began. It was unseasonal, light but continuous. The drops filled the room with sound as they struck the tin awning. Dayakant woke.

"The pond?" he asked.

Ira went to the window. "The drops are making circles on the water."

"When we were children, Radha and I used to cross that pond."

By chance Radhakant Jha had also come that night. He laughed. "You used to cross it? Half the way I dragged you."

"Lie."

"Even while dying you catch lies?"

Dayakant's eyes brightened. "Your lie is so old it will follow me into liberation."

Everyone in the room laughed. Death was present, but laughter was not insulting it. On the contrary, one familiar tone of Dayakant's life had appeared once more.

After a while Radhakant asked, "Shall I repeat the Name?"

Dayakant said, "You repeat it."

"And you?"

"I will listen."

Radhakant began the remembrance of the Name, slowly, without force. Dayakant closed his eyes and listened. Shashank sat by the doorway thinking: does Babu believe, or does he simply want to hear his friend's voice? Is it necessary to separate the two?

The rhythm of the Name mingled with the rain. After a while Dayakant's breathing became steady. Shubhada thought he might have fallen asleep. Radhakant stopped.

Dayakant opened his eyes. "Why did you stop?"

"I thought you were asleep."

"I was listening."

Radhakant began again. This time Shubhada noticed Dayakant's finger moving faintly on the sheet, as though keeping rhythm. Faith, memory, music, habit—she chose no one name.

12

On the eighth day Dayakant's body seemed very light, as though its weight on the cot had diminished. Ira was afraid even to lift his hand lest the bones hurt. Shubhada moistened his lips. Nachiketa gave the medicine. Shashank pressed his feet. Care had become more action than conversation.

At noon Dayakant suddenly said, "Kamala."

Shubhada bent close. "Ma?"

"That day..."

Everyone understood. The final day at the hospital.

"It was not your fault," Shubhada said at once.

Dayakant opened his eyes. "How do you know?"

Shubhada stopped. True—how did she know that her father's sentence had been about blame? Perhaps he had wanted to say something else.

"Say what you want to say," she said softly.

"She wanted to stay at home."

"Yes."

"I took her away."

"Yes."

"I thought I would save her."

"Yes."

"I could not."

Shubhada's eyes filled. "That does not prove the decision was wrong."

Dayakant asked in an exhausted voice, "Does it prove it was right?"

"No."

They were both silent.

"Then?"

Shubhada held her father's hand. "Then we did what we understood at the time. Ma may have suffered. So did you. We cannot change that now."

A tear left Dayakant's eye and ran toward his temple. "Did she forgive me?"

This time Shubhada did not answer quickly. She wanted to say yes so that her father would be at peace. But she had no right to distribute forgiveness on behalf of her dead mother.

"Ma loved you," Shubhada said. "She quarrelled with you too. What she was thinking on her final day, I do not fully know."

Dayakant looked at her for a long time. Shubhada was afraid: had the truth fallen too harshly?

Then Dayakant whispered, "You did right."

"What?"

"You did not speak for her."

Shubhada began to cry. Dayakant's fingers lay still upon her hand.

That night, for the first time, the family spoke openly about preparations for death. Which clothes? Whom to inform? The village cremation ground or the city electric crematorium? Dayakant had once said, "Why spend on wood after death?" On another occasion he had said, "Do not take me away from the village ghat." Two statements from two different years and two different circumstances. Which was the final wish?

Nachiketa said, "Wherever Babu wanted..."

Shashank interrupted, "Ask him himself."

Shubhada hesitated. "Is it right to ask?"

Ira said, "Better than all of us standing outside and guessing."

They all went inside. Dayakant was awake. Nachiketa asked gently, "Babu, one practical thing. Afterwards... where would you want the final rites?"

At first Dayakant did not understand. Then the meaning opened. Something like irritation came over his face. "Already?"

Nachiketa was embarrassed. "So there is no quarrel later."

Dayakant closed his eyes and thought for a few moments. "If I am here, I will quarrel. If I am not, it is your work."

"But your wish?"

"What wish does the body have?"

Radhakant, who had been on the veranda, came inside and said, "There is a tradition for the rites."

Dayakant looked at his friend. "Will you conduct them?"

"If the family asks."

"Then do whatever causes everyone the least trouble."

Shashank asked, "The village ghat?"

Dayakant smiled faintly. "The water will keep flowing. I will not be there to see it."

Everyone fell silent at the sentence. One person understood it as detachment, another as practicality, another as acceptance of death. Dayakant may simply have been tired.

"One thing," he said again. "Move Kamala's photograph from beside the shrine."

Everyone was startled. Shubhada asked, "Why?"

"She was not a deity."

"Where should we put it?"

"Where people can see it and talk. In the sitting room."

Ira laughed. "Give Dadi liberation from the shrine?"

Dayakant laughed too, with great effort. "Yes. Hers first."

On the ninth morning the eastern sky was clear. The leaves were washed by the night's rain. Light fell straight upon the pond. Shubhada opened the window fully.

Dayakant's breathing now took long pauses between breaths. The family sat around the cot, but no one repeated the Name loudly and no one wailed. Radhakant Jha sat a little way off with the book closed.

Once Dayakant opened his eyes. "Everyone here?"

Shubhada named them: "Nachiketa, Shashank, Ira, me. Harikant Kaka is outside. Radhakant Kaka too."

"Kamala?"

The room went still. Shubhada's throat tightened. She did not want to lie. "Ma is not in the photograph, Babu. But her words are here."

Dayakant closed his eyes. "Yes."

After a little while he said again, "Lamp."

Ira brought a small lamp from the shrine. It was full daylight; a lamp was unnecessary. Even so she put oil to the wick and lit it.

Nachiketa perhaps thought: his final religious wish. Shashank thought: Babu liked the smell of a lamp. Shubhada remembered Kamala's evening hands. Ira simply watched the flame. One lamp, four meanings.

Dayakant opened his eyes toward the flame and said, "A lamp looks small in the daytime."

Radhakant laughed. "Shall we see whether it lasts until night?"

Dayakant looked faintly toward his friend. "We shall see."

After that sentence he said nothing for a long time.

By afternoon his breathing had slowed further. The doctor came again, examined him, and advised the family only to remain near. When asked for a time, he shook his head.

Before evening Dayakant opened his eyes once. Outside the window the light on the water was descending. He tried to lift a finger. Ira leaned closer.

"The window?"

A very slight movement of the head—no.

"The lamp?"

No.

"Water?"

Perhaps. Ira was not certain.

Dayakant's lips moved. Shubhada put her ear close. The word did not make sense the first time. On the second attempt: "Leave it."

"Leave what, Babu?"

No answer.

Shubhada did not ask again. Sometimes repeating a question takes away the other person's right not to answer.

15

That evening Nachiketa brought an old ledger. It was not from Dayakant's office but the household account book—seed, labor, loans, wedding expenses, treatment, debts. The paper edges had yellowed. Nachiketa said, "Babu, this ledger still shows five thousand due from Bindeshwar Mahato. It is thirty years old. His son says the money was already paid."

Dayakant opened his eyes. "Bindeshwar?"

“Yes. There is no receipt.”

Concentration came into Dayakant’s face through the exhaustion. “There was a flood that year.”

“The date is written here. But repayment is not.”

Shubhada grew irritated. “Why this now?”

Nachiketa was embarrassed. “So there is no dispute later. Babu may remember.”

Dayakant asked for the ledger. He did not have the strength to hold it, so Nachiketa held the page before him. Dayakant stared at the faded writing for a long time.

“Did Bindeshwar give paddy or money?” he asked.

“It says money here.”

“I remember paddy.”

“Then the ledger is wrong?”

Dayakant laughed. “The ledger is not God.”

Nachiketa asked, “Then what should we do?”

Dayakant said slowly, “Call Bindeshwar’s son. Listen to what he says. Do not sell the peace of the house for five thousand.”

“Five thousand then is not five thousand now,” Nachiketa said. “If interest is added...”

Dayakant glared—the old father returned for a moment. “You are calculating interest at a deathbed?”

Nachiketa was silent.

After a while Dayakant himself said, “Crossing something out on paper does not kill a debt. If it is truly unpaid, that is injustice. If it was paid and we demand again, that is injustice. I do not remember clearly.”

“Then?”

“Then write: I do not know.”

Nachiketa was startled. “In the ledger?”

“Yes. Why be ashamed to write what we do not know?”

With a black pen Nachiketa wrote in the margin: “Memory concerning repayment unclear; Dayakant’s statement: not certain.” He added the date.

Dayakant looked satisfied at the page. “This much liberation is needed in so many places,” he whispered.

“What?” Shubhada asked.

“Writing ‘I do not know.’”

This time no one asked for the meaning.

That night Ira stayed awake beside her grandfather. Everyone else outside had fallen asleep. The rain had stopped; now and then one drop fell from the corner of the roof. The lamp had consumed nearly half its oil.

Ira asked softly, “Dada, are you afraid?”

The moment she asked, she regretted it. Perhaps one asks such questions for one’s own curiosity, not for the patient’s good. But Dayakant opened his eyes.

"I am."

Ira had not been prepared for the direct answer. Elders in the house usually said, "Trust God," "What is there to fear?" "Everyone has to go." Dayakant said only: "I am."

"Of what?"

"Pain. Breath stopping. Not seeing all of you."

Ira paused, then asked, "Of what comes after death?"

Dayakant thought for a long time. "How do you measure fear of what you do not understand?"

"Then no?"

"Sometimes. Sometimes not. Sometimes the mind makes pictures."

"What kind?"

"Kamala sitting somewhere. Father. The pond. Empty darkness. Nothing at all. All pictures made by the mind. What is beyond them, I do not know."

"What if there is nothing?" Ira asked.

A faint smile came to Dayakant's lips. "Will you be sad?"

"Me?"

"Yes. If I understand nothing, the sadness will be yours."

Ira lowered her eyes. "I want you to be somewhere."

"Somewhere?"

"In memory... or... something."

Dayakant said slowly, "If you keep me, does that make my work easier?"

Ira laughed through tears. "You are joking again."

"No. It is true that a human being remains in another person's memory. Whether I will see that—separate question."

"Do you want me to remember you?"

Dayakant gathered his breath before answering. "Keep whatever comes back to you. Do not force it. Do not make a statue of me."

"Like Dadi's photograph?"

"Yes."

Ira placed her palm on her grandfather's hand. "What one thing about you should I never forget?"

Dayakant opened his eyes and looked almost annoyed. "Another examination?"

Ira laughed.

Dayakant added on his own, "Remember one thing: when someone gives you their answer, ask whether that answer belongs to your question or to their fear."

Ira was stunned. "Are you saying that for me, or for yourself?"

Dayakant's eyes closed. "Could be both."

After some time he slept. Ira did not add more oil to the lamp. She knew the lamp might go out before dawn. The possibility frightened her, then she stopped herself. Keeping the lamp alive and keeping Dada alive were not the same thing. Understanding the limit of a symbol did not diminish love.

In the last watch of the night the wick shortened, the flame trembled, then steadied by itself. Watching it, Ira dozed off.

Dayakant's breathing stopped a little before full darkness fell that night. The moment was so ordinary that at first the family was not sure. Nachiketa called him by name. Shubhada touched his hand. Ira watched his chest. Shashank kept a hand on his feet. Radhakant touched his pulse, then folded his hands and stepped slightly back.

No one said, "He attained liberation."

News reached the veranda. Wailing rose, people began to gather, work began—cloth, water, messages, bamboo, a vehicle. The body that for nine days had been the center of the family's time now became the center of the sequence of rites.

For one moment Shubhada moved away from the crowd and went to the eastern window. The pond water could no longer be seen in the darkness. The lamp was still burning. The flame that had seemed small in daylight was now the clearest light in the room.

Nachiketa came behind her. "What did Babu mean by 'leave it'?"

Shubhada did not answer for a long time. "I do not know."

"The medicine? The window? All of us? The body?"

"It could be anything. It could also be nothing."

Nachiketa grew restless. "We should at least understand the meaning of his last word."

Shubhada took his hand. "Why? Babu had a whole life. Why make one last word the key to it?"

Nachiketa fell silent.

The next day the final rites took place at the village ghat—because it was convenient for the family, because Harikant insisted, and because Radhakant could arrange it. Dayakant had left no clear order. As the pyre burned, Shashank noticed how easily the word "liberation" now came to people's mouths. Someone said, "May God grant peace to the soul." Someone, "He is free from great suffering." Someone, "The bonds of the world are broken." Someone simply said, "Poor man," and fell silent.

Shashank corrected none of them. He remembered his father's question: "Why are you asking me for a certificate?" He did not decide to stop searching for a document of forgiveness; he merely understood that forgiveness might not be a document.

On the third day Harikant came to measure the land path. He left four cubits. Some months later his son raised the question again; there was more discussion. Dayakant's death did not miraculously end the dispute. But the five-year silence did not return.

Kamala's photograph was moved from beside the shrine into the sitting room. For the first week everyone found it strange. Gradually people sat near it, children's books were placed beside it, visitors noticed it. Kamala looked less like a deity and more like a member of the house.

Shubhada placed her father's letters in separate envelopes. She read some, not others. She understood that not every memory had to be opened; nor did everything have to remain closed.

Before returning to university, Ira was cleaning her grandfather's room. She asked, "Ma, shall I close the window?"

Shubhada looked outside. The mango leaves were moving. The triangular piece of pond water was shining again.

"Let it remain open in the daytime," she said.

"At night?"

"When the winter grows colder, we will close it."

Ira laughed. No symbol was made; the house began to function like a house again.

In the evening Shubhada lit a lamp in the sitting room. Not merely from habit—Kamala used to light one, Dayakant too. She could stop the sequence if she wished. Today she did not wish to stop it. Tomorrow the lamp might not be lit. That possibility did not make today's flame less true.

She remembered her father's final nine days. Was liberation release from the body? The end of suffering? A loosening of guilt? Giving up the need to own land in one's name? Giving up the temptation to speak on behalf of the dead? Carrying the weight of memory without becoming its servant? Some of these—or none?

Shubhada did not decide. Not deciding did not feel like laziness to her. Leaving some questions unanswered could also be a form of respect—provided one did not use that as an excuse to avoid action.

She went to the window. Darkness was descending over the pond in the distance. The water itself was no longer plainly visible; only the lights of two or three houses trembled upon it. Wind entered and bent the flame slightly.

Shubhada shielded it with her palm, then withdrew her hand. The flame straightened by itself.

She remembered Dayakant's "Leave it." Once again, no meaning came. Even so, the room was not completely dark.

— *End of Story* 36 —

37. Chhath

STORY

I

The first quarrel at the meeting of Pipra's Chhath-ghat committee was over four pieces of bamboo. The bamboo was not thick enough to inspire reverence at the very sight of it, nor thin enough to be tossed into the river without argument. All four lay beside the masonry steps at the middle ghat. The only question was whose way would be blocked with ropes tied to those bamboos during the evening arghya the next day.

"It will not be blocked," Chairman Ramlochan Babu corrected. "An arrangement will be made."

Treasurer Nandu Sah closed the ledger and said, "How many cubits lie between an arrangement and a blockade?"

"This is not a game of words," Secretary Gaurishankar Jha said. "There will be a crowd. Donor families, elderly people, committee members—everyone needs safe access."

Sitting by the river, Sukhdev Sahni laughed. "Will safe access come from the paved steps or from a donation receipt?"

The meeting was on the veranda of the school. In the field before it lay the bamboo, rope, two sacks of lime, three spades, and Badri Kaka's red plastic chair. Badri Kaka was the committee's oldest member. Because of pain in his knees, the chair travelled with him from meeting to meeting. If anyone sat on it, he would call from afar, "The chair may be public property; my knees are not."

This time too, when a child went to touch the chair, Badri Kaka did not scold him. He merely glared and said, "Keep it safe till next year. It is my throne." The child ran away laughing.

Ramlochan Babu opened a sheet of paper. "Two steps at the middle ghat for the committee. Three steps on the north side for the general public. There is open sand on the south as well."

Sukhdev did not laugh this time. "There is no sand on the south, there is mud. Is it written somewhere that our neighbourhood is to go there, or is it merely an order passed by word of mouth?"

A little silence fell over the veranda. The four bamboos suddenly seemed heavy.

2

Pipra was a small town, but it did not like calling itself small. The market had two banks, one private clinic, three coaching centres, seven mobile-phone shops, the old post office, the ruined wall of a cinema hall, and three principal Chhath ghats along the Kamla. The middle ghat was called the oldest, although its masonry steps had been built only eighteen years earlier. Here, calling something old sometimes simply meant that people's memory grew tired before it reached any farther back.

Most of the market households lay north of the middle ghat. To the south were settlements of boatmen, labourers, sanitation workers, potters, and several Musahar families. All year long everyone used the same ghat to wash clothes, launch boats, bathe children, and unload fish. But for the two days of Chhath, the ghat suddenly became an object of measurement.

"This was the old arrangement," Gaurishankar Jha said.

"How old?" Sukhdev asked.

"From my father's time."

"My father was alive then too. Did anyone ask him?"

Nandu Sah intervened. "Come now, no quarrelling. Understand the matter of donations. This year the market association has given thirty-five thousand rupees. Electric lights, generator, cleaning, bamboo—everything costs money."

From the back, Champa Devi, who worked with the municipal council's temporary sanitation crew, spoke at once. "First tell us under whose account the money for cleaning lies. Our team has not yet received gloves."

Nandu Sah's hand moved of its own accord onto the ledger. "That is a municipal-council matter."

"If the ghat is dirty, it is the committee's matter. Ask about wages and it becomes the council's matter. A beautiful arrangement indeed."

Laughter rose. Ramlochan Babu smiled too, though he could feel the meeting slipping little by little from his hands.

3

It was decided that everyone would go to the ghat and measure it. From the school to the river, half a kos away, the committee moved like a procession: Gaurishankar in front carrying the measuring tape, Nandu Sah behind him with the ledger, Sukhdev empty-handed, Champa leaning on her broom, and Badri Kaka having a child carry his red chair.

At the ghat, Gaurishankar opened the tape. The first difficulty was that it jammed at twenty feet, while he needed to measure thirty.

"Measure twice," Ramlochan Babu said.

"What if five inches are lost or gained at the joint?"

Sukhdev said, "The Kamla will not file a lawsuit over five inches."

"Not the Kamla; people will," Nandu Sah said gravely.

In the end they estimated from bamboo joint to bamboo joint. The central masonry steps were eight cubits wide. The northern side, five. The

southern slope had been eroded after the rains; beneath the sand the earth was sticky.

Champa took off her sandals and stepped down there. In two steps her feet sank to the ankles. Looking up, she called, "Will elderly people come down safely here?"

No one answered.

Just then Sunaina Devi, leaving off the work of arranging her daura, came to inspect the ghat. Five women were with her. Sunaina asked, "Why were women not called to the meeting?"

Ramlochan Babu said without thinking, "The meeting was technical."

Sunaina looked at the steps, the bamboo, the mud, and the seven men. "You gentlemen will handle the technology of Chhath, and we shall offer the arghya?"

Badri Kaka coughed from his chair, though there was more laughter than coughing in it.

4

Sunaina Devi's suggestion was very simple: the paved steps should not be reserved in anyone's name; one side should be kept open for elderly people, persons with disabilities, and families with small children; everyone else could come early and place their daura, but no one should block the path.

"The donors?" Nandu Sah asked.

"Was the donation given to the river or to a chair?"

"The committee's prestige also matters."

"Shall we tuck prestige under our ribs and offer arghya with it?"

Again there was laughter. Nandu Sah did not take offence; he had known Sunaina's manner of speaking since childhood. But two representatives of the market association had arrived. One of them said, "We have given money. At the very least, our banner will remain at the middle ghat."

Sukhdev asked, "Will the banner go down into the water and offer arghya?"

"You turn everything into a joke."

"No. I am asking where you will tie the banner so that it does not snag the boats' ropes."

From this point the real problem took another direction. The market association had made a six-foot-wide banner: "Chhath Service Offered Reverently by the Pipra Traders' Association." If it was tied directly above the middle steps, it would shade the open route for elderly people, but it would require two bamboos. The committee had only twelve sturdy bamboos. Four were already trapped in the dispute over reservation, two more would be eaten by the banner, and the rest were needed for the lights and ropes.

Badri Kaka heard the arithmetic and said, "Chhathi Maiya is testing the bamboo this year."

Sunaina corrected him at once. "The test is yours. The bamboo is innocent."

5

By noon the discussion had moved from “arrangement” to “tradition.” In Pipra, whenever an immediate reason for something could not be found, tradition became its temporary cause.

Gaurishankar said, “Earlier every neighbourhood kept to its own ghat. There were fewer quarrels that way.”

Champa asked, “Its own ghat, or separate ghats?”

“Same meaning.”

“No. ‘Own’ sounds affectionate; ‘separate’ sounds like a boundary.”

Ramlochan Babu scratched his head. “What is the use of opening up such old matters?”

Sukhdev’s voice was quiet this time. “Perhaps no use. But where these four bamboos are planted is still being decided by that old matter.”

He told the story of his father. Thirty years earlier there had been no masonry steps. On a Chhath evening, his father had tried to go down the middle slope carrying his mother’s *daura*. No one had stopped him; someone had merely said, “Your side is over there.” The sentence was small. His father had gone that way. No one returned home and quarrelled. Year after year, even the sentence became unnecessary, because people themselves learned whose “side” was where.

Gaurishankar grew uncomfortable. “It is not like that now.”

“Good. Then remove the four bamboos.”

“The crowd?”

“The crowd belongs to everyone.”

Nandu Sah opened the ledger and said, “I am writing a proposal: the reserved strip will be called the ‘assistance path.’ It will not be based on caste, donation, or committee membership. Only those who genuinely need help.”

Champa laughed. “If changing a name changed the work, half of Pipra’s problems would be solved by tomorrow.”

Even so, the proposal was written. On paper the matter was clear. At the ghat the four bamboos still lay on the ground.

6

The day before the first Chhath evening, the cleaning began. Champa’s team had been working since dawn. Plastic, rotting garlands, broken cups, pieces of fishing net, old incense boxes—everything came out. The committee arrived at ten to have photographs taken. By then half the ghat was shining.

Nandu Sah took out his phone. “Champa ji, stand here for a moment with the broom in your hand.”

Champa set the broom on the ground. “Do you need the broom in the photograph, or the cleaning?”

“For public awareness.”

“Then hold it in your own hand.”

The crowd burst into laughter. In the end Nandu Sah too picked up the broom. The photograph was taken. By evening it was circulating through

the market: “Treasurer Himself Cleans the Ghat.” Champa stood in the background with her hands folded behind her. No one recognised her.

Meanwhile the bamboos were planted. A paper strip on the rope of the assistance path read: “For elderly persons/persons with disabilities/families with children.” The market association’s banner hung above. Donors’ names appeared on a smaller board to the side.

The problem returned when a ward member’s man placed two chairs at the entrance to the assistance path. “The Honourable Member will be here for five minutes.”

The moment Sunaina Devi saw them, she had the chairs moved behind the banner.

The man said, “You do not understand. The Honourable Member...”

“Is he elderly?”

“No.”

“Disabled?”

“No.”

“With a small child?”

The man stared at her.

“Then he may stand for five minutes. His merit will increase.”

Badri Kaka applauded from his red chair.

7

On the way home that evening, they discovered that one bamboo from the assistance path was missing. The committee immediately produced three theories. Nandu Sah believed someone had uprooted it in protest. Gaurishankar thought children had taken it to play. Ramlochan Babu believed municipal workers had moved it elsewhere.

Sukhdev’s view was: “First look for it.”

Ten minutes later the bamboo was found fifty yards downstream. The rope had loosened; the bamboo had fallen toward the water and drifted away.

“Someone deliberately cut the rope,” Nandu Sah said.

Champa inspected the knot. “The rope was rotten.”

“It was bought new.”

“The receipt may be new.”

At this Badri Kaka laughed so hard that his chair wobbled. Nandu Sah laughed too, though he hugged the ledger to his chest.

New rope was brought. This time Sukhdev tied the knot. Gaurishankar asked, “How strong?”

“Strong enough for a person to untie, but not for the current.”

“What kind of measurement is that?”

“A ghat’s measurement.”

At night the strings of lamps were tested. The electricity failed three times, the generator coughed twice, and once the microphone made such a sound that dogs throughout the settlement began barking. Ramlochan Babu sat holding his head.

Badri Kaka said, "Do not worry. Chhath did not begin on the electricity department's assurance."

8

On the evening of the first arghya, Pipra poured down toward the ghat. Daura, soop, bananas, coconuts, thekua, sugarcane; burdens on heads, children in arms, songs on lips. People who did not know the road to one another's houses all year were moving in the same direction.

Committee volunteers stood wearing yellow bands. At first the assistance path was empty. Nandu Sah was pleased. "See? Arrangement."

Five minutes later an old woman arrived, her grandson holding her hand. A volunteer opened the rope. Behind her came two pregnant women. Then an old man leaning on a stick. Then one man said his child had a fever. Another said his mother had pain in her knees. The assistance path became more crowded than the ordinary path.

"Who does not need assistance?" Badri Kaka asked.

Ramlochan Babu grew irritated. "Kaka, stop joking."

At that very moment Ramvati Devi from the southern settlement arrived. Her mother-in-law, after paralysis, could no longer move half her body. Four people had brought her on a small bamboo cot. Going through the mud instead of the paved steps was impossible. There was a crowd at the mouth of the assistance path.

Without asking anyone, Sukhdev opened the second central rope.

Gaurishankar started. "That is the general entrance!"

"Right now it is assistance."

"The crowd will break through."

"Then lend a hand."

For a moment Gaurishankar stood still. Then he took hold of the front bamboo of the cot. Ramvati's mother-in-law was carried down the masonry steps. Someone raised a cry of praise, though whether it was for her or for the setting sun was difficult to tell.

Once the rope had been opened, it was never completely closed again. People kept descending in turn. Committee members stretched out their arms to make a passage. The four bamboos had become less a boundary than a support.

9

The microphone stopped working at the precise time of the arghya. The announcer's mouth kept moving, but no sound came. Five minutes earlier he had been saying, "Please maintain discipline, do not push; the committee is at your service." Once the sound stopped, people heard the river itself clearly for the first time—the soft slap of water, the rustle of soop baskets, a child crying, women singing.

Sunaina Devi raised a song. The melody travelled from one side to the other. Champa began singing too. Ramvati, who had set her mother-in-law's cot beside her, joined in.

The market association's banner folded to one side in the wind. In the words "Reverent Chhath Service," the word "Service" turned upside down. Nandu Sah moved to straighten it, but with people already waist-deep in the water, reaching it from behind was difficult. In the end he left it alone.

The sun sank. A red line spread across the water. A thousand hands rose "together," although, to tell the truth, togetherness too was an illusion of distance: someone's soop lifted a little earlier, someone's later; some recited a mantra, some sang, some were silent. From afar, unity; from near, difference.

Standing above the masonry steps, Ramlochan Babu watched everything. Suddenly he understood that what the committee called order was remade by people according to the convenience of their own bodies and the manner of their devotion. Whether this understanding gave him joy or fear, he could not decide.

Badri Kaka sat in his red chair. The child came again to touch the armrest. This time Kaka said nothing. The child sat on the ground beside him and listened to the song.

After the arghya ended and people began climbing back up, the ghat revealed another meaning: the place that had been full of devotion all evening turned back into a market within five minutes. On the outer road, tea, flowers, toys, balloons, hot milk, peanuts, photographs, even mobile-phone covers were being sold. Because of the crowd, the committee did not allow carts on either side of the main entrance.

Tarini Sah's small tea cart had stood at the same bend during Chhath for thirty years. This time he was sent fifty yards back. He said nothing and pulled the cart away. But twenty cartons of "free drinking water" from the traders' association stood right beside the entrance, because the donors' names were printed on them.

The moment Tarini saw Nandu Sah, he asked, "A cart creates a crowd, but cartons meditate?"

Nandu Sah was tired. At first he opened his mouth to answer, then looked at the cartons. Half-empty bottles and plastic cups lay scattered underfoot. "Tomorrow these too will be moved back," he said.

"By tomorrow my tea will be cold."

Nandu Sah laughed. "Bring the cart a little forward now."

Tarini brought it closer but parked to one side, leaving the entrance to the assistance path clear. Within five minutes there was a crowd for tea. Two members of the traders' association too stood holding paper cups. Tarini tried to return their money. "Can I charge the donors for tea?"

One member said, "We donated to the ghat, not to you."

Tarini kept the money. "I like that."

People nearby laughed at the small exchange. From a distance Ramlochan Babu saw that donation, prestige, livelihood, and service did indeed arrive at the same ghat in Pipra, but they did not stand in the same

line. Four bamboos could measure only the passage of bodies; the passage of dignity required another measure.

IO

After the ghat emptied at night, the real quarrel returned: where had the rubbish gone? On the steps that had gleamed before the arghya lay banana leaves, plastic bags, broken lamps, wet cloth, flowers, and mud.

Champa stood with her hands on her hips and looked at Nandu Sah. "Photograph now?"

Nandu Sah put his phone in his pocket. "Cleaning first."

This time the committee members truly picked up brooms. Sukhdev filled baskets with rubbish from the water's edge. Gaurishankar took down the banner. Ramlochan kept broken clay lamps separate.

The ward member's man returned. "The Honourable Member's photograph was missed."

Holding a basket full of rubbish, Ramlochan said, "Call him tomorrow at five in the morning. He will look excellent in a cleaning photograph."

The man did not return.

While cleaning, Champa found an old iron peg half-buried in the soil. Sukhdev said, "This could have been an old boundary peg."

Gaurishankar immediately said, "Do not speculate."

Champa pulled out the peg and dropped it in the basket. "If it was a boundary, now it is rubbish."

Everyone fell silent at the sentence. Then Badri Kaka said, "First see how much the scrap dealer will pay."

Everyone laughed again. The silence lost its weight.

II

The dawn arghya proved more difficult than the first evening because people were half asleep and mist sat over the river. The strings of lights became blurred globes in the fog. The masonry steps were wet, so Champa's team scattered ash over them. The sign on the assistance path had softened in the night dew and now left only half its letters: "elderly/.../children..."

Nandu Sah said, "Write a new one."

Champa said, "People are looking now, not the sign."

Before sunrise the crowd gathered again. But this time the volunteers kept asking, "Who needs a hand?" The answer was sometimes laughter, sometimes "No," sometimes "Yes, give me your hand." The rope remained open half the time.

The president of the traders' association arrived in person. The banner had been taken down during the night. He asked, "Where is our banner?"

Nandu Sah, cleaning the ghat, said, "It has been kept safely."

"Photograph?"

"The sun is rising. Take its photograph."

The association president looked at Nandu Sah. Perhaps in these two days Nandu really had changed a little; perhaps he was simply tired. From outside, the two looked exactly alike.

The sun rose. First a pale yellow line appeared on the water, then a bright one. People offered arghya. Ramvati's mother-in-law did not descend the steps this time; the cot was placed above, and she folded her hands from there. Someone urged her to be carried down, but she shook her head. Assistance being available and assistance being accepted were two different things.

Sukhdev was checking the mooring rope of a boat in the river. Behind him the four bamboos stood upright, but none retained its old meaning that day.

12

On the evening of the second day of Chhath, the committee met again on the school veranda. This time the four bamboos were not lying before the veranda; they had remained at the ghat. On the table lay the ledger, leftover rope, a torn sign, and two plates of thekua.

Nandu Sah read out the accounts: generator, electricity, bamboo, lime, microphone, cleaning, water, first aid. Champa interrupted. "Gloves?"

Nandu Sah looked a little ashamed. "First item next time."

"Write it."

He wrote it.

Gaurishankar read the proposal: "Next year there will be no reserved strip at the middle ghat on the basis of donation or office. The assistance path will remain, but there will be no permanent bamboo barricade; volunteers will make space according to need. At least five representatives from the women's group will attend the planning meeting. The southern slope will be repaired well before Chhath."

Ramlochan Babu asked, "Unanimous?"

Chewing thekua, Badri Kaka said, "What about the reservation of my chair?"

Sunaina Devi said, "Show us a certificate for your knees."

"Is a seventy-year-old body not a certificate?"

Again there was laughter. In the end no one objected. But while signing, Sukhdev said, "The paper is good. Next year we shall see what the bamboo says."

The meeting broke up. When Badri Kaka began to lift his red chair, the child ran up—the same child who had touched the armrest the day before. "Shall I carry it?"

"Carry it. But do not break it. Next year I will sit on it again."

The child hoisted the chair onto his head and walked ahead. Badri Kaka followed.

Darkness was falling toward the river. After the cleaning, a few lamps still burned at the ghat. Whenever the wind touched them, the flames bent

and rose again. Their light did not remain in one place upon the water—it broke, joined, and drifted.

From afar Ramlochan Babu looked at the four bamboos. After two days of dispute, they looked simply like bamboo. But he knew that boundaries were planted less deeply in objects than in memory, and uprooting memory was not a single day's work with broom or spade.

Then Sunaina Devi called from behind, "Chairman ji, from tomorrow the ghat will again be everyone's ordinary ghat."

Ramlochan turned. "And today?"

"Today too. It merely took you gentlemen two days to understand it."

They all laughed. The Kamla flowed on in the darkness. The light wrote no one's name upon its water.

— *End of Story 37* —

38. Raga

STORY

I

On the fifth day after Chhath, Pipra's ghat had become an ordinary ghat again. The four bamboos had been removed, the marks of the ropes remained in the earth, and on the steps lay only as many dried flower stalks as the wind had failed to carry away. The river had receded a little. At evening, on the third step, Harihar Mahato sat with his eyes closed, the first two fingers of his right hand tapping against his knee.

He sounded from a distance as though he were singing. Come closer and there were no words—only a long note, first very thin, then full, then rising with a slight tremor until it stopped abruptly in the middle. After the note ceased, the river could be heard more clearly.

At that moment a young woman came down to the ghat. A bag hung from her shoulder; in her hand was a small sound recorder; a black cable looped at her throat. She stopped on the first step and waited. Harihar did not open his eyes. The note rose again. This time the young woman switched on the device. A small red light came on.

When the note ended, Harihar opened his eyes and looked straight at the red light.

"How much did you save?"

The young woman was startled. "Forgive me. I should have asked first."

"I asked—how much did you save?"

She stopped the recorder. "One minute and eighteen seconds."

Harihar laughed. "And where will you keep the remaining twenty years it took?"

The young woman laughed too, though not at once. "I am Naina. I have come from Patna. I am working on the songs and melodic forms of Pipra."

"Write down the song, catch the tune, and leave the singer out?"

"No. That is why I have come to you."

Harihar looked toward the river. "Then sit. Listen first. The machine later."

2

Harihar Mahato was known in Pipra as "Harihar the Singer," though he described himself less as a singer than as a farmer. Only half his land remained; both sons worked away from home, his grandson went to school,

and an old harmonium lay covered with cloth in the back room. His singing did not belong to a single profession's discipline. He sang at weddings, at collective rituals and festivals, with boatmen on flood nights, sometimes while ploughing, sometimes in the silence after a death.

Naina had found his name in a list made from an old cassette. The person who made the list was dead, and no one knew where the cassette was. On the paper alone was written: "Harihar Mahato, Pipra, Uttarahi Raga, 1994." The words "Uttarahi Raga" had brought Naina there.

She had studied music in the city but had left the direction of the classical stage and begun working on sound archives of folk melodies. She believed that a voice disappeared not only when a singer died; if the next generation did not hear it, the path of the melody itself would break. So she recorded, wrote names, dates, places, contexts, the singer's consent—everything.

At the word "Uttarahi," Harihar remained silent for a while.

"Who said this is a raga?"

"It is written in the old list."

"Did the person who made the list sing?"

"I do not know."

"Then he called it a raga, and you accepted it as a raga."

Naina took a notebook from her bag. "What do you call it?"

"I say it was first an evening movement. When wind came from the north, the note bent like this. People asked for a name; I called it Uttarahi. Tomorrow if the wind blows from the south?"

"Will the name change?"

"The name will remain. The tune will change a little."

Naina stopped writing. "Then what exactly am I to preserve?"

A faint gleam came into Harihar's eyes. "That is why you have come, is it not? You are asking me?"

3

The next morning Naina reached Harihar's house before sunlight had entered the courtyard. His daughter-in-law Sarita was making tea on the hearth. Harihar was opening the cracked case of the old harmonium. The leather had hardened; two reeds were out of tune.

"Do you sing with this?" Naina asked.

"Not much now. It has grown older than I have."

"Why not have it repaired?"

"If it is repaired, will it become a new instrument or will the old one be saved? You answer that question."

Naina understood that the old singer turned everything into an examination. She smiled. "If sound comes out again, the instrument survives. But what if its sound changes?"

"Then a new sound in an old box. Life is no more difficult than that."

Sarita set down the tea. "Babuji, let the girl sing first. Philosophy later."

Harihar laughed. "See? My standing in this house."

Naina first found a clean sa, then held it. Harihar shook his head. "That is a stage sa. In Uttarahi, do not place the first note on the ground. Place it on the wind."

"How does one place a note on the wind?"

"If you sang as many questions as you write, you would already know."

She began again. Harihar stopped her midway. "Not straight. Turn a little backward."

"Backward in the note?"

"Yes. As if you have stepped out through the door and then remembered you left the key inside."

Naina burst out laughing at the comparison. But the third time, the note truly curved a little. Harihar tapped his knee.

"That is it. Now do not clutch it. Let it go again."

"If I do not hold it, how will I learn it?"

"Learning and tying down are not the same thing."

4

For three days Naina's recorder remained in her bag. Harihar first taught her to listen without it: at the ghat, in the mango grove, on the veranda of the empty school, once behind the oil mill after the machine had stopped. The same melodic movement sounded different everywhere.

Naina grew irritated. "You change it every time."

Harihar would say, "You want to hear the same thing every time."

"If there is no foundation, how is this a tradition at all?"

"There is a foundation. A foundation is not a wall."

One day Naina took out her phone and played a passage she had sung from memory the day before. Harihar listened closely.

"You made a mistake here," he said.

"Where?"

"At the third turn. You came down too quickly."

"Then there is a rule!" Naina said almost triumphantly.

"There is a rule, but writing it down will not make a raga."

"You refuse to state the rule, and then you call something a mistake."

Harihar rested a hand on his knee and thought for a while. "Have you watched a river's current? You may say the water will go downhill. That is a rule. But can you measure in advance which drop will turn around which stone?"

"A recording will at least show how you sang."

"How I sang on one day."

"That too is necessary."

"Yes. I do not deny that."

It was the first time Harihar had said anything in favour of Naina's machine. Naina did not switch on the red light. She understood that she had received a sentence of agreement, not yet permission.

5

Word spread through Pipra that Naina had come. People began saying Harihar's music was "going to the city." Manoj, who ran the photo shop in the market, proposed one day, "Didi, make a video. River behind, Baba in front. It will run on YouTube."

Harihar asked, "Run where?"

Manoj showed him the phone. "All over the world."

"If a song sung at the ghat goes all over the world, will the ghat become empty?"

Manoj assumed the old man was joking. "No, Baba. You will become famous."

Naina remained silent. Fame was one of the hardest words in her work. If a voice was saved, it should also be heard; if it was heard, someone might attach it to his own name; if it was kept shut, an archive could become a dead room.

She told Harihar plainly, "Before making any recording public, I will take written permission. If you wish, it may remain only for study. If you wish, some part may be open. If you wish, none of it."

"Who will read the written permission?" Harihar asked.

"You. Your family. The institution."

"And permission from the people whose old lines are in the song?"

"From those who are alive, if possible. For older collective portions, I will identify the source."

"And those whose names no one remembers?"

"Then 'unknown' or 'folk tradition.'"

Harihar said slowly, "Calling someone unknown does not make that person nameless."

Naina had no answer. She closed the notebook.

6

That evening Harihar took Naina up to the loft of his house. An old tin box sat on a bamboo beam. Inside were clothes, wedding invitations, two broken pairs of spectacles, his sons' school certificates, and a black cassette. Half the label had peeled away; in blue ink only "Hari... 9..." remained.

"Could this be the one?" Naina asked, holding her breath.

"Who knows. I have not listened to it in many years."

Finding a machine in the village that could play a cassette became a story in itself. At last an old tape recorder was found with a retired clerk who lived behind the post office. Its belt was loose, the sound wavered. There were no batteries, so wires were connected.

The cassette played. First came static. Then two men talking. After that, a voice—young, sharp, very different from Harihar's present voice. Naina looked at him. He listened with his eyes closed.

In the middle of the song, another woman's voice appeared. It was not very clear. She raised a line and young Harihar followed it.

"Who is that?" Naina asked.

Harihar did not open his eyes. “My elder sister.”

“Her name?”

“Kusuma.”

“She sang too?”

“I learned from her.”

Naina fell silent. The old list had named only “Harihar Mahato.”

The cassette made a sound as though it were about to jam. Harihar immediately had the machine stopped. “Enough.”

“Shall we hear the rest?”

“Tomorrow.”

“May I make a digital copy?”

After a long time Harihar said, “Write Kusuma’s name first.”

Naina opened her notebook. This time Harihar spelled the letters for her himself: Ku-su-ma.

7

Kusuma had died fifteen years earlier. After marriage she had gone to another village and had never sung on a stage. But in Harihar’s account, the first turn of Uttarahi was hers.

“Didiya used to say—release the first note as if the boat’s rope is slipping from your hand.”

Naina laughed. “You say a forgotten key. She said a boat rope.”

“Then see—the raga is one, the metaphors are two.”

“Or are there two ragas?”

Harihar did not answer.

That day the first formal recording was made. The courtyard was swept, the fan switched off; Sarita asked the neighbour to keep dishes quiet. Naina’s recorder sat on the table, its red light on. Sitting before it, Harihar first spoke Kusuma’s name: “I learned this movement from my elder sister Kusuma Devi. Whether she learned it from her mother or from someone else, I do not know for certain.”

Naina did not interrupt.

Harihar began singing. The first take went well. In the second he coughed. In the third, a motorcycle passed outside. In the fourth, his grandson came in looking for a ball. The fifth time Harihar himself stopped. “No. The wind has changed.”

Naina looked at the clock. Two hours had passed. Her professional patience began to fray. “For a recording, I need one clean take.”

Harihar’s face grew serious. “What does clean mean?”

“Less outside noise. No interruptions in the middle.”

“I have never had a day in my life when there was no outside sound.”

“But the listener needs to hear the melody clearly.”

“The listener needs a melody separated from life?”

Naina too grew firm. “If nothing can be heard clearly, how will the next person learn?”

Harihar looked at the machine. "Will the next person learn from this machine, or from someone's mouth?"

This time Naina had an answer. "From both."

Harihar softened a little. "Then make one clean take. And then one in which the house keeps its own voice."

8

The clean take was made. Window shut, grandson outside, Sarita standing guard on the motorcycle road for five minutes. Harihar sang the entire movement. Headphones over Naina's ears. The tone was clear, the turns were clear, even his breathing could be heard. The red light remained steady.

When the recording ended, Naina smiled. "That was very good."

Harihar asked, "Very good singing, or a very good recording?"

"Both."

"Then keep the distinction."

For the second take, the window was opened. Far away came the millstone, Sarita's rolling pin, the grandson's laughter, a crow in the tree, once the village loudspeaker. Harihar sang. Strangely, his voice was more natural this time. In the headphones Naina felt that the background was not covering the raga; instead, it was giving the raga a place.

She named the file `UTARHI_HARIHAR_TAKE2`. Then stopped. She changed it to `UTARHI_KUSUMA_HARIHAR_HOME`.

Harihar could not read the screen. Naina read it aloud to him.

"Kusuma first?"

"You said you learned from her."

"Then her mother?"

Naina laughed. "Now you are making me draw a genealogy."

"A raga's lineage is more difficult than a Panji."

Hearing this, Naina thought for a while. In the file notes she wrote: "Attribution incomplete; tradition depends upon collective memory."

After hearing it read aloud, Harihar said, "That is right. Write incomplete. Making it complete is the greatest lie."

9

A week later, Naina received a call from the city. Her colleague at the institution was excited. "Send a sample. We will put a short clip on the project website. We can let the funder hear it."

Naina told Harihar.

"Who is the funder?"

"The one whose money keeps this work going."

"He will listen to the song?"

"Yes."

"Before giving the money, or after?"

"Both times."

Harihar smiled. "Then he will want the cleanest take."

Naina started. "Are you being sarcastic?"

"No. The one giving money will also want pleasure for his ears. But you will write that to make the clean take we stopped every sound in the house."

Naina agreed to that condition. Then she brought out the consent form and read it aloud in simple Maithili—how much could be made public, how his name would appear, no commercial use, further permission required for reuse.

Before signing, Harihar asked, "If ten years from now someone sings a song over this tune and earns money?"

"This permission form may not prevent that. Ownership of a melody is a separate question."

"Then you used to say 'preserved.'"

Naina folded the paper and set it on the table. "Yes. The word was a little too large."

Harihar laughed. "Now you are learning."

"You too."

"What am I learning?"

"That recording is not only theft."

Instead of answering, Harihar picked up the pen and signed. But only two minutes were approved for public release. The rest would remain restricted in the archive.

10

The following Sunday a cultural stage was erected at Pipra's weekly market. The organisers had heard that someone from the city had come to "save an old raga." They summoned Harihar to the stage. "Baba, five minutes. Let Pipra hear its authentic raga."

Harihar asked, "Will it become authentic in five minutes?"

The organiser laughed. "People will not listen much longer."

A sponsor's cloth banner hung behind the stage. Plastic flowers stood before the microphone. The announcer proclaimed, "Now you will hear Pipra's ancient, pure, endangered Uttarahi Raga."

From behind the crowd Naina heard every word. No one had evidence that it was "ancient"; "pure" was itself contested; and after calling it "endangered," Harihar was sitting on the stage alive and ready to sing. For one moment she thought that an introduction could be more dangerous than a recording.

Taking the microphone, Harihar began with this sentence: "Whether this raga is ancient, I do not know. What 'pure' means, I do not know either. My elder sister Kusuma taught me one movement. Today I will sing what I remember."

From behind the stage the organiser looked at Naina as though the event were slipping out of his hands. Naina said nothing.

Harihar began to sing. A vegetable seller called out from the market, a child laughed, the microphone shrieked once. When five minutes were up,

the organiser signalled. Harihar stopped in the middle of a turn and said, "Time is over."

People burst into laughter. Someone applauded. Someone called, "Go on!"

Harihar looked at the organiser. Helplessly, the organiser waved his hand. The song ran for seven minutes.

After he came down, Naina said, "You did not object to the word 'endangered.'"

"If I correct every long introduction, when will I sing?"

"But people will remember precisely that."

"Then you write. I sing."

Naina did not like this answer. For the first time she understood that the work of a documentarian was not only to capture sound, but also to watch the true and false sentences being built around it. She went to the organiser and asked him to remove "pure" and "endangered" from the next notice. He asked, "Then what attraction will remain?"

Naina answered, "The music."

The organiser looked at her as though the answer were impractical.

II

Naina now wanted to test her own learning. One evening she said to Harihar, "Today I will sing. Do not stop me in the middle."

Harihar agreed. Evening was descending over the ghat. The decorations left from Chhath had been removed. In one corner a round mark from the leg of Badri Kaka's red chair still remained in the earth, though the chair itself was gone. A last thin line of sunlight lay over the river.

Naina raised the first note. Harihar closed his eyes. She tried to push out of mind Kusuma's old recording, Harihar's clean take, the household take, and three days of practice. She tried to place the note on the wind. The first turn was good. In the second her voice returned a little toward the straight line of her city training. In the third she let it loosen by itself.

It was not a whole song, only the movement. After five minutes she stopped.

Harihar opened his eyes.

"Where were the mistakes?" Naina asked.

"In two places."

"And the good parts?"

"In three."

"So altogether five places?"

"A raga is not arithmetic."

"You escaped again."

Harihar laughed. "What you did at the third turn, I do not do."

Naina's face fell. "Then it was a mistake?"

"No. If you do it again, we will see whether it is a mistake or your path."

Naina could not decide whether this was praise or warning. But for the first time she understood that learning did not mean becoming an exact copy. If exact copying were the aim, a machine would be more qualified.

12

The next day Harihar's granddaughter Munni came home from school and began looking at Naina's recorder. She was twelve. She asked Naina, "Will Baba stay inside this?"

"His voice will."

"Not Baba?"

"No."

Munni looked a little disappointed. Then she put on the headphones and listened to the clean take. After half a minute she removed them. "Baba does not sing like this."

Naina was startled. "How does he sing?"

"At home he says 'hmm' in the middle, coughs, scolds me. In this he is too straight."

Harihar had been listening from the veranda. "See?"

Naina played the second take. This time Munni smiled. Her own laughter was caught in the background.

"That is me!"

"Yes."

"Did you write my name?"

Naina stopped. In the file notes she had written "child laughter." She opened the notebook and asked, "Your full name?"

"Mrinalini. But everyone calls me Munni."

Harihar said slowly, "The lineage of a raga is more difficult than a Panji."

This time Naina did not write down the sentence. She simply added Munni's name.

Munni wanted to learn the tune from her grandfather. Harihar said, "First listen."

Munni listened for five seconds and immediately imitated him. Her note climbed too high. Harihar did not stop her. She did it a second time. Then he said, "Turn back a little here."

Munni asked, "Forgot the key?"

Naina burst out laughing. The metaphor had reached the household.

13

Once Naina understood that the Uttarahi in Harihar's account came through Kusuma, she also asked to listen to older women in Pipra. Sarita invited three to the courtyard one evening—Sonvati Kaki, Jagrani Devi, and Phulkumari. All three had known Kusuma; all three remembered differently.

Sonvati said, "Kusuma used to sing this movement at a bride's farewell."

Jagrani corrected her at once. "Not at a farewell—when the rains were coming."

Phulkumari laughed. "Neither of you remembers the time. She slipped it into whatever she felt like singing."

Harihar sat silent on the veranda. Before taking out the recorder, Naina asked permission from all three. Sonvati asked, "My voice is bad. Will it be played in the city?"

Naina said, "If you do not want it to be, it will not. It can remain only in the archive."

"Then what is the use of singing?"

Jagrani said, "Leave aside the use. First let us see who remembers what."

All three began singing. Through the first line they were almost together. At the second turn Sonvati went up, Jagrani stayed low, Phulkumari changed a word in the middle. Naina's ears, which had spent all these days searching for a "foundation," suddenly grew very alert.

"Which version is right?" she asked without thinking.

All three laughed together.

Sonvati said, "If Kusuma were alive we would ask her, and perhaps she too would sing a fourth."

For the first time Harihar spoke from the veranda. "That is why I stopped you earlier over 'one clean take.'"

Naina remembered her old insistence. Yet the clean take no longer seemed useless; it simply was not the sole truth. She kept all three versions in separate files and did not call them merely "variant 1/2/3"; she recorded names, contexts, memories, and disagreements.

When the recording ended, Phulkumari asked, "Will writing so much save the song?"

Naina said, "Not completely. But what we heard will not disappear."

Jagrani smiled. "And what you did not hear?"

Naina answered, "I will leave an empty place for it."

From a distance Harihar nodded. It was praise.

14

At night in her room, Naina also tried to write the Uttarahi melody in notation. Her musical training gave her some device for nearly everything—symbols for notes, curved lines for meend, measures for pauses. She kept adding sa, re, ga, arrows, curves, dots. After half an hour the page was so full of signs that it looked more like a map than a song.

The next morning she placed the paper before Harihar.

"What is this?"

"Your melody."

Harihar put on his glasses and studied it for a long time. "Do I do this much work while I sing?"

"Not work—movement. Look, here the note rises."

"On the paper."

"In the song too."

Harihar put a finger on one curved line. "This?"

"Where you bend the note."

"And this small dot?"

"A pause."

Harihar held the paper farther away. "Good. If someone can read it."

Naina asked, "You think it is useless?"

"No. A map of a field is not the field. Does that mean the map should be torn up?"

Naina fell silent. This time Harihar's metaphor was on her side.

He called Munni. "Look at this. Didi says you can read it and sing the raga."

Munni spent five minutes learning the symbols, then sang the first line. Seeing the arrow, she pushed the note too high. Harihar laughed. Naina corrected her. The second time was better. The third time Munni left the page and watched her grandfather's mouth.

In her notebook Naina wrote: "Notation is a support; not a substitute for living performance." Then she crossed it out. "Not a substitute" sounded too final. She wrote another sentence: "Notation is one path; listening another."

Harihar heard her read it aloud. "And singing?"

Naina added a third: "Singing is a third."

"And changing?" Munni asked.

Naina laughed. "That is the fourth, which arrives by itself."

This time Harihar laughed loudly. "Now you may return to the city."

15

The day of Naina's departure from Pipra drew near. Her bag held a dozen files; her notebook held names, consent forms, a digital copy of Kusuma's cassette, Harihar's two takes, Naina's practice, Munni's first attempt. In the technical sense, much had been "preserved."

But on the morning of her departure, Harihar refused to sing. "Not today."

"Why?"

"I do not feel like it."

At first Naina was concerned—health? voice? Then she understood that sometimes the reason was simply desire. She did not take out the recorder.

Before catching the bus, she went to the ghat. The mist was thin. Tarini the tea seller was opening his cart. Two boats lay at the bank. In the distance Munni came running in her school uniform.

"Didi!"

Breathless, she said, "Baba sent this for you." In her hand was a small piece of paper.

In Harihar's trembling hand were only four lines—no full lyrics, only memory cues: "First note on the wind. Do not hurry the second turn. At the third, find your own path. Listen before naming."

Naina read the note and asked, "Baba did not come?"

"He said farewell is not done by singing."

"Is that his rule?"

Munni shrugged. "Tomorrow he will say something else."

Both laughed.

16

Three months later Harihar went to sing at a wedding in Pipra. Naina was not there. Munni sat beside him. In the middle of the song, when Harihar's breath caught, Munni picked up a line. Her voice was raw, her pronunciation still carried childhood, and at the third turn there was the very new twist Naina had once made on an evening at the ghat. Harihar looked at her for a moment. He did not stop her.

Someone was making a video on a mobile phone. Someone else was simply listening. Someone got up to see the food line. Someone asked, "Which raga is this?"

Harihar answered, "Call it Uttarahi."

"The real name?"

"The name is as real as any of us."

Lamps burned in the wedding courtyard. The flame trembled in the wind and straightened again. A red dot glowed on the mobile-phone screen. Far away in the city, the files on Naina's archive server remained still in their places—with date, name, duration, consent, and notes. In Pipra at that moment the melody was not still. From Harihar's mouth to Munni's, from Munni's to the ear of another child sitting nearby, and from there perhaps onward.

Something had been saved; something was changing. The answer to which of these deserved to be called "preserved" was not written in the file.

As night deepened and they walked home, Harihar said to Munni, "Sing the third turn again."

Munni sang it.

"Like this?"

Harihar listened for a while. "Again."

Munni sang it a second time. This time it was different from the first.

Harihar smiled. "Good. Remember now—every difference is not a mistake. But every difference is not a new path either."

"How will I know?"

Harihar looked up at the sky, then toward the ghat in the darkness, where the light from a small lamp at someone's house trembled upon the water.

"Sing, listen, then sing again."

They kept walking. Behind them the wedding song faded. The road ahead was not fully in light, but there was as much light as they needed to see.

39. The Court

STORY

Testimony 1 — Badri Narayan Jha, President, Pipra Ghat Committee

Question — Since when do you first remember seeing the disputed strip?

Answer — It is difficult to say since when I have been seeing it. For as long as I can remember, people descended to the ghat from that spot. When I was a child, my father would take me by the hand to offer arghya at Chhath. The line of people went down to the right of the peepal tree. The bamboo posts driven there now are new; the path is old.

Question — Are you saying that the land belongs to the committee or to the public ghat?

Answer — I am saying that it is used by the people. You will examine whose name stands in the papers. I am not giving testimony about the papers. But the people of Pipra never treated that strip as anyone's courtyard. Chhath, cremations, boarding boats, unloading relief sacks during floods—all took place there.

Question — Were you president of the committee during the last Chhath?

Answer — I was. If you have already assumed that this means I shall lie, why ask me to testify?

Question — Did the committee drive four bamboo posts into the disputed strip and tie a rope between them?

Answer — To manage the crowd. Not to establish permanent possession. The rope was removed the day after the worship ended.

Question — But an iron post was also driven there.

Answer — The contractor put it in for his own convenience. I had objected. It was removed later.

Question — Ramdev Mandal's family says that their ancestors once grew mustard there.

Answer — Mustard used to be grown at many places along the river. It may once have been grown there too. But the fact that it was a field does not mean the path to the ghat should be closed.

Question — Does your committee place its donation box on that strip?

Answer — For the four days of Chhath. Beside my red chair.

Question — How old is your red chair?

Answer — Will the age of a chair decide who owns the land? Then write this down as well—the chair is three years old, my knees are seventy years old.

Question — Just answer the question.

Answer — I have. But if you try to understand the ghat only by measurement, the river will become the greatest witness of all. If you can summon it, do so.

Testimony 2 — Ramdev Mandal, Plaintiff

Question — What is your claim?

Answer — The six-dhur strip southeast of the peepal was cultivated by my grandfather, Shivilal Mandal. We have old revenue receipts. After Grandfather died it came to Father, and after Father to me. When the river cut the land and when it laid down sand are separate matters. Land does not disappear from a name simply because the river changes.

Question — How old are the receipts?

Answer — One is from 1968, one from 1972, and there was a later receipt in Father's box that was half ruined in a flood.

Question — Is the plot number legible on the receipts?

Answer — On the first one, yes. On the second, the ink has spread.

Question — The plot number on the first receipt does not match the present map.

Answer — The present map was made after the river had changed. Look at the old map.

Question — Have people continued using that strip to reach the ghat?

Answer — They have. I did not stop them. Grandfather did not stop them either. Does allowing someone a path mean donating the land?

Question — Was any fee ever taken?

Answer — Not for unloading goods from boats. But some people putting up temporary stalls would drive bamboo poles there, and Father would take rent from them. Tarini, the tea seller, has paid it.

Question — Tarini has also paid fees to the committee.

Answer — The committee came later. People holding a function on someone else's land can also collect money in the name of cleaning. That does not make them owners.

Question — During the last Chhath, did you cut the rope?

Answer — I untied the rope at one end; I did not cut it. People had driven bamboo into my field.

Question — Was there an argument in the crowd?

Answer — Yes. Badri Kaka called me a 'seller of the ghat.' I called him the 'committee king.' That was all.

Question — What do you seek from this suit?

Answer — First, it should be recorded that the land is mine. I have never said the path to the ghat should be closed. If people have always walked there, let them continue. But it is not right to erase someone's name merely by saying, 'people walk here.'

Testimony 3 — Subhadra Devi, approximately seventy-five years old

Question — Do you remember use of the disputed strip?

Answer — I first went down that way for Chhath after my marriage. My mother-in-law told me, 'Walk slowly on this side; the sand is soft.' That was about fifty-five years ago. The peepal was large then, but the present peepal is not the same tree.

Question — Is the present peepal a different tree?

Answer — Yes. The old tree was half uprooted in a flood. It stood for a few more years, then fell. The present tree was planted near it. I never measured how many cubits this way or that.

Question — Did Shival Mandal cultivate that land?

Answer — I have seen mustard there. But along the river, wherever sand rose up, people sowed it. Women did not discuss exactly where one man's field ended and another began. Our work was to clear the path for worship, carry thekua down, and mind the children. Men discussed ownership in their gatherings.

Question — Were you ever stopped?

Answer — Not on Chhath. Once on an ordinary day Shival's son said, 'Do not walk through the crop.' I went around to the ghat. If I were now to say whether that crop stood on the disputed strip or beside it, I would be lying.

Question — In your memory, was that strip public?

Answer — We did not use the word 'public' then. There was a path. It would also be wrong to say that people of every caste descended by exactly the same way. Some families went down from the lower side. Everyone going down together now is something new. It is difficult to make the past perfectly clear in today's words.

Question — Whose side are you on?

Answer — My knees are on my side; if they let me descend the ghat, I shall descend. You decide whose land it is. But do not turn what I say into anyone's flag. I have told you what I saw.

Testimony 4 — Jagdish Prasad, Retired Amin [Land Surveyor]

Question — Have you examined the old maps?

Answer — By order of the court I examined the three copies available: a photocopy of the survey map, a later copy from the Circle Office, and a hand-drawn demarcation sheet. The reference points of the three are not identical. The main difficulty is the river. In the old survey the channel is shown farther west; it has now shifted east.

Question — Does the disputed six-dhur strip fall in Plot 217 or in the ghat path?

Answer — A one-word answer would be technically wrong. If you take the old peepal as the reference point, you get one result; if you take the present peepal, another. But according to Subhadra Devi's testimony, the two trees are different. The map says 'peepal'; it gives no coordinates.

Question — Does river erosion alter plot boundaries?

Answer — A paper boundary and the physical ground are different matters. A river may cut away land and later deposit sand. The court will decide the legal consequence for ownership; I can speak to the landform.

Question — Are Ramdev Mandal's receipts useful?

Answer — They indicate payment of land revenue. But the area entered on the receipts belongs to a larger holding; they do not independently identify this small disputed strip.

Question — And the old photograph produced by the committee?

Answer — It shows steps and a crowd, not a boundary.

Question — Did you inspect the site?

Answer — Yes, twice. The water was low the first time; the river had risen the second. Between my first measurement and the second, the waterline was seven cubits farther forward. If anyone treated the waterline as the boundary, the owner of seven cubits would change in seven days.

Question — Then you will give no conclusion?

Answer — Giving a conclusion is my work, but stating the limits of that conclusion is also my work. I can say only this: from the maps available, the disputed strip cannot be identified on the present ground with complete certainty. Anyone who says it is 'absolutely clear' is reading his own confidence more than the map.

Testimony 5 — Tarini Sah, Tea Seller

Question — How long have you sold tea at the ghat?

Answer — Seventeen years. First from a basket, then from a cart. During Chhath I hardly sleep for three nights.

Question — Who gave you permission to place your cart?

Answer — The answer changes by year. The first time, Ramdev's father said, 'Do not break the field ridge; keep it there for two days.' I paid him twenty rupees. No receipt. Later the committee was formed and there were cleaning fees, electricity fees, bamboo fees—the names changed, the money kept being paid.

Question — Did you regard Ramdev's family as the owner?

Answer — When I paid twenty rupees, what I thought was that there should be no trouble. Whether I regarded him as owner or simply as the powerful neighbour is difficult to say now. A small shopkeeper first looks at who can overturn his cart.

Question — And when you paid the committee?

Answer — The committee gave a receipt, but it said 'sanitation contribution,' not land rent.

Question — Has your cart stood on the disputed strip?

Answer — During two Chhaths. The third year Badri Kaka said, 'The crowd will turn here,' and moved me ten cubits north. The next year Ramdev said, 'My mustard used to grow here.' I told him, 'If mustard grew here, it could have come to drink tea.' He laughed. There was not so much litigation then.

Question — Whose side are you on?

Answer — My side is wherever I can place my stove. If the court gives it to the committee, I shall pay the committee; if it gives it to Ramdev, I shall pay Ramdev. But if the path is closed, my customers will decrease, so I want the path open. Write down that self-interest. Let no one later say Tarini was an impartial saint.

Testimony 6 — Budhan Sahni, Boatman

Question — What do you know about the disputed land?

Answer — Less about the land, more about the water. I have run a boat for twenty-four years. The ghat has one name; the ground does not stay in one place. The steps that are in the middle now had boats mooring to their right ten years ago. Before that, farther east.

Question — According to Ramdev Mandal's claim, the strip was his field.

Answer — It may have been. When the river retreated, people sowed. When it advanced, boats came in. Have I seen fields cut away? Yes. Which field was Ramdev's and which belonged to his agnates, I never examined the papers.

Question — The committee says this has always been the ghat path.

Answer — A boatman does not say 'always.' The river would laugh at that word. But it is true that people have descended in this direction for many years.

Question — An old stone slab is said to be a boundary marker. Have you seen it?

Answer — I have. But the stone now near the peepal used to be a little lower down.

Question — Who moved it?

Answer — The flood. Or people after the flood. I did not see the stone moving with my own eyes. After the 2019 flood it was found higher up. Four men can lift it; water can too.

Question — Did you see anyone lifting the stone?

Answer — No.

Question — Then saying 'people' is an inference.

Answer — Yes, an inference. Write 'inference.' With a river, calling inference truth is dangerous.

Question — Why do you want the path open?

Answer — To moor boats. Corpses will come, passengers will come, relief sacks will come in floods. If a wall goes up across five cubits, I shall moor somewhere else. The river will not stop me, but old people will have to walk ten cubits farther. Whoever owns the land, the question of use of the path is separate.

Testimony 7 — Champa Paswan, Sanitation Worker

Question — What is your relationship with the ghat committee?

Answer — Before Chhath, my group and I clean the place. Sweeping, removing mud, picking up broken glass, washing the steps. The committee pays wages—sometimes on time, sometimes two weeks later.

Question — Have you worked on the disputed strip as well?

Answer — More there than anywhere. People set up carts, throw leaf plates, flowers rot. Before the bamboo was driven in last Chhath, we levelled the soil there.

Question — Did the committee tell you the land was public?

Answer — Badri Babu used to say, 'This ghat belongs to everyone.' But I did not hear the word 'everyone's' in childhood. My mother observed Chhath, but she was made to use the lower slope. Some people objected to her using the upper steps. The committee now says everyone is equal. That is a good thing. But if I testify about old usage, I must also say that usage was not equal.

Question — Did Ramdev Mandal's family ever stop you?

Answer — Not from cleaning. Once we piled mud on the disputed side and Ramdev said, 'Do not dump it in my part.' The committee said, 'It belongs to everyone.' I asked, 'Then why does everyone not pay our wages?' Both went silent.

Question — In your view, whose land is it?

Answer — If you ask for my view: the name on the land will be decided by the papers. My testimony is that my hands worked there, but my hands did not become owners. People worshipped there, but worship is not a seal of title. Ramdev may have sown mustard, but mustard does not grow carrying a certificate either.

Question — Whose side are you on?

Answer — I am on the side of not letting the court hear the old word 'everyone's' and assume everyone had equal rights in the old days. For the rest, read the papers yourselves.

Testimony 8 — Shivanand Jha, Priest

Question — How old is the religious use?

Answer — Since my guru's time; his guru spoke of it too. Chhath, water for shraddha, bathing after cremation—the use of the ghat is old. People descend through the disputed strip.

Question — Is there any record in the temple registers of land being donated?

Answer — One old ledger says 'donation for repair of the ghat.' There are three donor names. It is a donation of money, not land.

Question — The committee cites this ledger as evidence that the land was public.

Answer — Then the committee is reading too much into it. I will say what the ledger contains, not what it does not.

Question — Is the name of Ramdev's grandfather Shivalal in the ledger?

Answer — Yes. Five rupees one year for repairs to the steps.

Question — Does that mean he accepted it as a public ghat?

Answer — A private landowner may donate to repair a public ghat; and someone who is not a private landowner may donate too. A donation reveals intention, not boundary.

Question — Was the peepal tree treated as a ritual boundary?

Answer — People placed lamps there. But the old peepal fell and a new one was planted. I heard that from my guru; I did not see it myself.

Question — What is your personal wish?

Answer — That the ghat remain open, that temple-goers have access. But wish and testimony are separate. If in the name of religion we take someone else's land, that is not service to religion. And if a private name is used to block an old path, that too seems wrong. Both questions are before the court.

Testimony 9 — Malati Devi, Seller of Flowers and Worship Materials

Question — Do you set up a stall beside the disputed strip?

Answer — On Chhath, on Mondays, sometimes on wedding days. Not permanently. My shop is as wide as the cloth I spread.

Question — Who gives permission?

Answer — I listen to whoever comes first and scolds me. Sometimes the committee, sometimes Ramdev. You may laugh at the answer, but that is how rules at the ghat have operated.

Question — Have you ever paid rent to Ramdev?

Answer — Not directly. Twice I gave flower garlands free to his wife. Whether that was rent or neighbourliness, I cannot say.

Question — To the committee?

Answer — Fifty rupees for cleaning. I have the receipt.

Question — What happened on the day of the dispute?

Answer — Bamboo was being driven in. Ramdev came and said, 'Drive it two cubits inward.' Badri Kaka said, 'Not by a finger.' The contractor stood between them. I kept selling flowers. Customers began watching the spectacle. In the end the bamboo was not uprooted; it was tilted a little and driven again.

Question — On whose instructions?

Answer — That is exactly what I did not understand. Badri Kaka said it was his instruction; Ramdev said his demand had been accepted. The contractor said, 'The ground was firm here, so I put it here.' All three went home believing they had won.

Question — Was the strip used as a path?

Answer — Yes. But to me 'path' and 'ownership' are not the same thing. My neighbour has crossed my courtyard for twenty years to fetch water; that has not made the courtyard hers. But if I suddenly put up a wall, she will say, 'You have blocked my path.' Both things can be true together.

Testimony 10 — Shashikant Thakur, Assistant, Circle Records Room

Question — Describe the condition of the available government records.

Answer — An old copy for Khata 41, Plot 217 is available. The edge of the original register was damaged by floodwater. The names are legible—Shivlal Mandal and two agnates. The area is clear. But the boundary description says, 'North—the old channel of the river.' The present channel is different.

Question — Is there a separate plot for the ghat path?

Answer — The map shows a narrow public path, but its position on the present ground is disputed.

Question — Has Ramdev Mandal obtained mutation?

Answer — An application was filed. It was not fully approved. The note says, 'Boundary verification required.'

Question — Has the committee filed any application calling the land government land?

Answer — There is an application for a ghat beautification scheme. It describes the land status as 'under public use,' not 'government-owned.'

Question — Who wrote those words?

Answer — Whoever prepared the application. The office did not verify ownership.

Question — Then what do the government papers establish?

Answer — They establish that papers too leave questions. The khata points toward private names; the path symbol toward public passage; the old river channel makes the boundary uncertain; mutation is incomplete.

Question — When were the records damaged?

Answer — In a flood year. Some pages were dried; some copies were made later.

Question — Is there a possibility that the copies were altered?

Answer — It is easy to speak of possibility. Evidence is required. Writing in different ink may also date from restoration. I saw records being preserved, not falsified. But the original page is incomplete, so I would not claim complete certainty.

Testimony 11 — Deepak Kumar, Photo-Shop Owner

Question — Is the photograph of the 1998 Chhath produced by the committee from your father's studio?

Answer — Yes. The negative was found in an old box at my shop. Father used to take photographs at the ghat.

Question — Does the photograph show the peepal, the steps, and the disputed strip?

Answer — It does, but from an oblique angle. The print had been cropped to wedding-photo size. The full negative shows more on the right.

Question — Did you digitally enhance it?

Answer — I removed dust and increased contrast between light and dark. I added no object.

Question — The committee says the photograph proves there was no field then.

Answer — The photograph is from Chhath in Kartik. Mustard is small at that time; the picture shows sand and people. No field is visible, but the photograph does not show all six disputed dhurs.

Question — Ramdev says the peepal in the photograph is the old tree and the present peepal is another.

Answer — The trunk in the old photograph is very large. The present tree is smaller. It is difficult to believe they are the same tree.

Question — Can you measure the distance?

Answer — No. The camera lens, angle, and cropped frame all matter. If you try to measure land from the size of someone's head, the result may be entertaining, not useful.

Question — Does your shop receive work from the committee?

Answer — I print posters for them. I also photographed Ramdev's son's wedding. Both are customers. If being a customer makes one a party, I belong to both sides.

Question — What does the photograph say?

Answer — It says that people were there that day; there were lamps, a peepal, and steps. It does not say whose name stood on the land papers. Trust the photograph for what it shows; do not ask it what lay outside the frame.

Testimony 12 — Harinandan Yadav, Construction Mason

Question — What work did the committee give you before the last Chhath?

Answer — Two temporary bamboo railings, a small wooden platform, and filling a broken corner of the steps. A permanent iron post was not in the order.

Question — Then who drove in the iron post?

Answer — I did. The bamboo kept coming loose, so I hammered in an old iron pipe. I thought I would remove it after Chhath.

Question — Did Badri Kaka give permission?

Answer — He said, 'Make it strong.' He did not say the word 'pipe.'

Question — Did Ramdev object?

Answer — He did. He said move it two cubits back. Badri Kaka said, 'The old line is right here.' I asked where the marker for the old line was. One said the peepal, the other the stone. The peepal and the stone are not on one straight line.

Question — What did you finally do?

Answer — I removed the pipe and drove it again one and a half cubits north because the ground was harder there. To tell the truth, reducing the quarrel was also a reason.

Question — Did you later take measurements for the court?

Answer — No. I am a mason, not an amin. But both sides told me, 'You know where the line was.' I know where I drove the pipe. I do not know who owns the land.

Question — Did the committee pay you in full?

Answer — Half remains due.

Question — Then you are angry with the committee?

Answer — My wages are due, so yes, I am angry. That does not move the place where I drove the pipe. You are entitled to think that if Ramdev paid me, I would lie for his side; but keep the account of my stomach separate from the account of my eyes.

Testimony 13 — Rekha Kumari, Teacher at the Local School

Question — Why has the school's old project map come before the court?

Answer — Nineteen years ago, students made a hand-drawn map of the settlement called 'Our Pipra.' I was a new teacher then. The children marked the ghat, temple, post office, old peepal, boat landing, and fields. One copy survived at the school.

Question — The disputed strip is labelled 'ghat ground' on the map.

Answer — The children wrote that. It is not a government survey.

Question — Is it not evidence of local memory?

Answer — It is evidence of memory, not ownership. Children write the names by which they know places. My student Manoj wrote 'Badri Kaka's Square' even though the square was not Badri Kaka's private property.

Question — Where is Ramdev's field on the map?

Answer — A green area marked 'Mandal Field' lies south of the disputed strip. The boundary was drawn with a thick coloured pencil; an error of five cubits would be easy.

Question — Whose accounts did the students listen to while making the map?

Answer — Their families', their neighbours', and their own experience. I corrected some things, such as the direction of the post office. Not land boundaries.

Question — What do you personally remember?

Answer — During the school's pre-Chhath cleaning, children used to paint on the disputed strip. Once Ramdev's father said, 'Do not let the paint spread toward the field.' I moved the children two cubits away. That day I assumed the field was nearby. Whether the field reached into the strip or lay beside it, my memory is blurred now.

Question — Your student Manoj is now a member of the committee?

Answer — Yes. He posted this map on social media calling it 'old evidence.' I wrote beneath his post, 'School project, not revenue map.' That comment later disappeared. I do not know who removed it.

Testimony 14 — Manoj Kumar, Young Member of the Ghat Committee

Question — Did you share the school map online?

Answer — I did, so people could see an old memory.

Question — Did you write, 'Here is the proof that the ghat has always been public'?

Answer — In enthusiasm, the words may have grown larger than they should. I edited the post later.

Question — Did you remove Teacher Rekha's comment?

Answer — It may have disappeared when I changed the post. Not deliberately.

Question — Did you make a video of Ramdev during the dispute at the last Chhath?

Answer — Yes. He was untying the rope.

Question — The video is before the court. The first thirty-two seconds are missing.

Answer — It took me time to start the phone.

Question — A video from another phone shows that committee members had first extended the bamboo toward Ramdev's field.

Answer — There was a crowd. The angle is different.

Question — Did you say, 'This time we shall settle the boundary'?

Answer — I may have. I meant the boundary for crowd management, not the legal boundary.

Question — Does your committee want a grant for beautification of the ghat?

Answer — Yes. Railings, lights, waste bins, toilets.

Question — Would it help the grant application if the land were undisputed?

Answer — Certainly.

Question — Then you have an interest in having the strip treated as public.

Answer — Call it self-interest or Pipra's convenience. I want the ghat developed. But that does not make what I have seen false. I have seen people walk there. I have not read the land papers.

Question — Does Badri Kaka's red chair stand on the disputed strip?

Answer — Sometimes on Chhath.

Question — Where will you place it next Chhath?

Answer — If the court says so, outside it. A chair can be moved; a river cannot.

Testimony 15 — Bhagirathi Devi, approximately eighty-two years old

Question — What do you know about the old peepal?

Answer — I did not see it being planted; by the time I became aware of the world, the tree was large. I played among its roots as a child. The present peepal was planted when my sons were young men. Not after the old tree fell — some time before, because half the old tree had dried out.

Question — Where was the new tree planted?

Answer — To the southeast of the old one.

Question — At what distance?

Answer — Four cubits? Six? Do not rely on the measure of my hands now. Nobody was measuring for a court case then.

Question — Who planted it?

Answer — Shival Mandal, Badri's father, and two or three young men. Together.

Question — Ramdev's grandfather Shival?

Answer — Yes. No one asked caste or faction while planting a tree.

Question — And the stone said to be a boundary marker?

Answer — There was a flat stone on which women rested their water pots. Later people began calling it a 'boundary.' It may have been a boundary too; no one told me so then.

Question — Did Shival cultivate there?

Answer — He did. When the river retreated, mustard and khesari. Badri's father also sowed nearby. The men may have known which line belonged to whom. But for the three days of Chhath, Shival himself cut through the ridge to widen the path.

Question — Was that a donation?

Answer — No one used the word donation. It was a path for worship. The next week he might raise the ridge again. Sometimes he did, sometimes not.

Question — In your view, was the land private or public?

Answer — You have made two boxes—private and public. In the old village some things operated between the two. A name could belong to one person, use to many; responsibility to one, a right to another; fear of the river to everyone. If the law now requires two boxes, you may put it into one of them. My memory will not fit completely inside either.

Question — Is Ramdev related to you through your daughter's family?

Answer — Distantly. Badri is also distantly related. Pipra is small; if relationship ruins testimony, summon a crow from outside the village to testify.

Testimony 16 — Anita Devi, Wife of Ramdev Mandal

Question — Where did you find the old receipts?

Answer — In my mother-in-law's iron box. When the roof of the house was being replaced, I separated the papers. Cloth had rotted, the ledger was wet. Two receipts were stuck between sheets of paper. I dried them slowly and separated them.

Question — Did you know about this land before?

Answer — After I married into the family I used to hear that the 'field by the ghat' belonged to us. But which five cubits and which seven, no. Men discussed land in the household. When floods came, women first saved grain and children. Papers came later.

Question — After finding the receipts, did you advise filing the suit?

Answer — I said, 'Look at the papers first, then quarrel.' Ramdev first wanted a village meeting with the committee. Three meetings were held, with no conclusion. Then came the suit.

Question — The committee says your family used to take money from people setting up shops at the ghat.

Answer — During Chhath my mother-in-law took straw, bamboo, or a rupee or two from two or three families. Whether that was rent or the price of materials, I was not present every time. There was no separate household ledger for it.

Question — Do you want to close the path?

Answer — No. My daughter observes Chhath. If the path is closed, how will she go down? But when the committee put up a board saying 'Pipra Public Ghat Area,' the line of that board reached into our mustard. After seeing it I told Ramdev that if we stayed silent, one day even our name would disappear from the papers.

Question — Is the board still there?

Answer — No. It fell in a storm, and the committee took it away.

Question — Your self-interest is to preserve the land?

Answer — Yes. Why hide it? But having an interest does not make the receipts forged; and the receipts being genuine does not prove that all six dhurs still lie in exactly the same place. That much I understand.

Question — Do you know where the old peepal stood?

Answer — My mother-in-law used to say the new peepal was east of the old one. But when she said it, I did not pay attention. Now that same sentence has acquired value in court. Memory asks no price at the time; later everyone wants to buy it.

Testimony 17 — Rajkishore Yadav, Former Panchayat Secretary

Question — Are there any panchayat records concerning the ghat?

Answer — Two. A 1994 resolution for voluntary labour to repair the steps, and a 2004 approval of expenditure for cleaning and lighting the Chhath ghat.

Question — The first resolution calls the land 'village ghat.'

Answer — Yes. But panchayat resolutions often use the name of the use. Writing 'village ghat' does not automatically make revenue ownership belong to the panchayat.

Question — Was Shival Mandal present at that meeting?

Answer — There is a mark in the attendance sheet resembling his signature. An expert would be required for a definite identification; I am not an expert on his signature.

Question — If he was present and raised no objection, did he not accept public ownership?

Answer — The resolution concerned repair of steps, not determination of ownership. In old meetings many people signed without hearing every line. That was the panchayat's old practice; I am not praising it, merely describing it.

Question — Does the 2004 paper contain a measurement of the disputed strip?

Answer — No. Only, 'cleaning from the peepal to the ghat steps.'

Question — The present committee cites that resolution as the basis of its authority.

Answer — The present committee is not the panchayat. It is a community body. Panchayat cooperation with its Chhath arrangements does not transfer land to it.

Question — Did Ramdev's family ever pay tax to the panchayat?

Answer — Land revenue belongs to the Revenue Department. Panchayat house tax is separate. My records contain no separate tax for the ghat strip.

Question — Your personal relationship with Badri Kaka?

Answer — Twice we were on the same panel in panchayat elections, once on opposing sides. Ramdev's father cultivated my field. If you cut every web of relationship in Pipra, only migrants will remain to testify.

Question — What conclusion would you give?

Answer — Panchayat papers show long public use, but there is no line in any resolution saying that private ownership was extinguished. Any side that reads half a sentence for its own convenience will find its own truth. Read the full page and the question remains.

Testimony 18 — Nagina Khatun, Fish Seller

Question — Since when have you been coming to the ghat?

Answer — Since childhood with my mother. She sold river fish. Even now I come in the morning with my basket. I do not set up a stall in the Chhath crowd; those days are for different work.

Question — Did you use the disputed strip for passage?

Answer — I do now. Earlier, not every day. My mother used to say the upper path was crowded on worship days, so we should use the lower side. Sometimes someone stopped us, sometimes not.

Question — Who stopped you?

Answer — It would not be right to name one family. In the old days the ghat too was divided like society. Some looked at caste, some occupation, some only at their own convenience. Now people say 'the ghat belongs to everyone.' It is good to hear, but if you paste that sentence unchanged onto the past, my mother's experience disappears.

Question — What dealings did you have with Ramdev's father?

Answer — He bought fish. Once in the rains I put my basket on his ridge and he said, 'Save the paddy seedlings.' I moved it. I do not know whether that ridge was within the disputed strip.

Question — And with the committee?

Answer — The committee now calls women from my group too on cleaning days. Earlier only families who performed the worship made decisions. There has been change. That is why I want the path to remain open.

Question — Does an open path mean public land?

Answer — Not to me. On my way to market I pass in front of three houses; that does not make the three houses mine. But if a path used for twenty years is closed one day, my life changes. The name on the land and a right of passage may be two separate questions.

Question — For which side are you testifying?

Answer — The committee summoned me, but I do not know whether it will be pleased by what I say. Ramdev's family knows me too. I sell fish; from

the smell of water I can tell whether fish is fresh or stale. From the smell of land papers I cannot tell the owner. That is your work.

Testimony 19 — Dayakant Mishra, Commissioner Appointed by the Court for Site Inspection

Question — What did you observe on the day of inspection?

Answer — The date was the eighteenth of Paush. I arrived at ten in the morning. Both sides were present. North of the disputed strip stood the present peepal; south, a small mustard field; east, the upper part of the steps; west, an unpaved path. The sides indicated different lines. The committee drew a straight line from the western roots of the peepal to the steps; the plaintiff drew another line beginning about five cubits north of the peepal.

Question — Was there any permanent boundary marker?

Answer — One flat stone, half buried in earth. Each side assigned it a different meaning. There were no letters on the stone. A hole from an old iron pipe was also visible, but according to the mason's testimony the pipe had been temporary.

Question — What was the measurement?

Answer — The maximum distance between the two claimed lines was five cubits and seven fingers. The total dispute is small, but it is important because it concerns entry to the ghat.

Question — What about public use?

Answer — During the two hours of inspection, fourteen people went toward the river through the strip—four women, five men, three children, and two boatmen. Two people, after being told by the plaintiff, did not step onto the mustard side. No one paid an entry fee. This is an observation from one day, not history.

Question — Any structure?

Answer — Wheel marks from a temporary tea cart, two old holes from bamboo poles, a heap of rotting flowers, and a fragment of a small clay lamp.

Question — Did you give an opinion on ownership?

Answer — No. My order was to record the condition of the site. The report also says: 'Conclusion on ownership is a matter for the court.'

Question — Did you inspect a second time?

Answer — Yes, in the evening, because both sides objected to the first report's description of the waterline. Seven days later the river had risen a little. Two steps were wet. The eastern corner of the disputed strip was damp.

Question — Did you see anything else that evening?

Answer — The temple arati had ended. Two women placed lamps at the ghat. One lamp caught at the corner of a step; the other entered the water and began drifting. The shadow of the present peepal did not reach the water; there was no visible sign of the stump of the old tree. Ramdev stood at a distance, and so did Badri Kaka. Neither spoke to the other.

Question — What relevance does that scene have to the suit?

Answer — None directly to ownership. You asked what else I saw, so I am telling you.

Question — Read the final line of your report.

Answer — 'The signs of use at the site are multiple; the boundary markers are not undisputed; the present river, the old map, and oral memory do not sit perfectly upon one and the same line.'

Question — Would you like to add anything?

Answer — Only this: during the first inspection everyone was showing me his own line. On the evening of the second inspection, no one tried to show me a line. Darkness was increasing. Lamplight trembled on the water, and the dispute of five cubits and seven fingers became hard to distinguish with the eye. But because it was hard to see, I am not saying the line ceased to exist. Nor can I say that because the line exists on paper, it is perfectly clear on the earth.

— *End of Story 39* —

40. The Postman

STORY

I

On the day of his retirement, Dinbandhu Paswan reached the post office carrying his satchel empty for the first time. For thirty years it had held money-order forms, registered letters, postcards, court notices, examination results, and sometimes envelopes whose very corner changed the faces of the people in a house. Today it contained only an old handkerchief and a small copper box.

Pipra's sub-post office stood in a one-storey yellow building at the end of the market row, two turns beyond the old peepal tree. A new blue signboard had recently been fixed outside, but the wooden cupboards inside were older than Dinbandhu's service. Dust lay on the cupboards, registers on the dust, and between the registers three decades of Pipra.

The new postmaster, Vivek, said, "Kaka, you are not on duty today. The ceremony is at ten."

Dinbandhu looked at the clock. Half past eight. "What ever arrives punctually at a ceremony? The post arrives first."

Vivek laughed. "There is less post now."

"Less post, or less patience among people?"

"Both."

Dinbandhu went to his old table. Three envelopes lay at one corner, marked in red ink: 'INCOMPLETE ADDRESS.' Without touching them, he read them one by one.

The first—"Mrs Savitri Devi, Pipra, near Kamla Ghat, behind the old neem."

The second—"Nasim Ansari, Pipra, who used to repair watches."

The third—simply—"Chhoti, Pipra."

Vivek said, "I shall return the first two today. The addresses are incomplete."

For the first time Dinbandhu felt the weight of his satchel being empty. "The neem has been cut, Savitri has not. The watch shop has closed, Nasim has not. The address has changed, not the person."

"And the third?" Vivek lifted the envelope addressed to 'Chhoti.'

Dinbandhu could not keep from smiling. "For the third, even Pipra may be too small."

Postcard — 1997

‘Son, your letter arrived. Do not send money just now. First make sure you are eating properly. The paddy is good here. Your mother says that if you do not get leave, do not come for Chhath; travel in the crowd is difficult. But do not tell her that I wrote this. For three days she has washed your old shirt and kept it ready.’

Even if he wanted to, Dinbandhu could not forget the entire text of that postcard. Postcards lie open; a postman’s eyes inevitably fall upon the words. He did not try to read, but some lines made paths into memory by themselves.

The card had gone to Ramlochan Yadav’s son in Delhi. Two months later a reply came—this time in a sealed envelope. Dinbandhu saw only the writing outside: ‘For Babu and Ma.’ Ramlochan’s mother took the letter and immediately went inside. The son did not come for Chhath that year. He came the next. Then not again for five years.

Ramlochan’s house is now a solid three-storey building. Half the old courtyard has become a shop. The mother is no more. The son has returned from Delhi and runs a medicine shop in Pipra. Whenever he sees Dinbandhu he says, “You delivered the appointment letter for my first job.”

Dinbandhu does not remember the appointment letter. He remembers the line about the shirt.

Human memory too keeps things by its own rules. The government paper that changed a life has grown dim. A mother’s anxiety, mixed with a small lie, remains clear.

Dinbandhu’s route book was not an official map. It was a thick black-bound notebook in which, for thirty years, he had pencilled Pipra’s changing places. ‘Madhuban Toli — turn left before Jagdish’s house.’

Beneath it, a later pencil note—‘Jagdish’s house now blue; nameplate says Sudhakar.’

Then—‘Blue paint faded; look for the water tank.’

‘Behind the mosque, Nasim the watchman.’

Later—‘Shop closed; son sells clothes.’

‘Kamla Ghat — path to the right of the peepal.’

Then in red pencil—‘Path shifted after the flood.’

Official addresses demanded numbers. People in Pipra gave addresses through relationships, trees, wells, occupations, nicknames, and old incidents. ‘Where Ramdev’s bull once fell into the pond,’ ‘Master Sahib’s first house,’ ‘the lane where three sisters lived together,’ ‘near the old cinema screen.’

Dinbandhu understood all of them. When he did not, one question at the tea stall was usually enough.

“Who is this ‘Muniya Didi’?”

Four customers would give four answers. A fifth would say, "Show us the envelope; we shall know from the handwriting."

Dinbandhu never showed the handwriting. "Tell me the name. I shall deliver the letter."

Delivering post was not merely finding a place; it was a narrow path between people's privacy and the village's curiosity. He could have known many things, but knowing everything was not his right.

One year the flood rose so high that half the places in his route book became useless. Lanes were under water, mud houses stood empty, people had moved to the high verandas of the school and temple. Letters reached the post office addressed to old homes, while their people lived in relief camps. That was when Dinbandhu first saw clearly the difference between a 'house' and a 'recipient.'

One postcard was addressed: 'Phulkumari Devi, behind the Musahari, Pipra.' At that time there was only water behind the Musahari. Dinbandhu went through the relief camps asking the name. Someone said Phulkumari was at the Dakshin Tola school; someone else said she had gone to her sister's house. At last a child said, "The woman who ties a red gamchha?" The child's identification proved right.

The postcard was from her son, who had gone for labour near the Nepal border. Only three lines: 'Heard the water has risen. I am well. If the house has fallen, do not worry; save yourselves.' Phulkumari could not read. At her request Dinbandhu read it aloud. She asked him to read it a second time. Then a third. On the third reading, Dinbandhu understood that the words were not changing, but their meaning inside the listener was.

When the flood receded, Phulkumari's house truly was half collapsed. The next letter came to a new place: 'Phulkumari Devi, new hut by the high embankment.' Government records still carried the old address. In Dinbandhu's route book a new pencil line appeared.

After that experience he could never read the phrase 'permanent address' casually. In Pipra a place was called permanent while the river quietly kept changing the meaning of permanence.

Once a man wanted to see a neighbour woman's registered letter. "It is a matter of our family."

Dinbandhu said, "If it belongs to the family, ask at home. In the post office, it belongs only to her."

From that day people began saying Dinbandhu knew how to keep his mouth shut. Whether it was praise or complaint, he never knew.

4

Returned Letter — 2004

Recipient: 'Meera Jha, Kashi Tola, Pipra.'

Red stamp: 'LEFT ADDRESS.'

Sender on the reverse: 'Bindeshwar Jha, Surat.'

Dinbandhu carried this envelope to Kashi Tola three times. The first time, the house was locked. The second, a neighbour said the family had

gone to the maternal home. The third time, an old uncle said, "Meera no longer lives here. Send the letter back."

"Where has she gone?"

"Does the one who wrote it not know what he ought to know?"

Dinbandhu did not repeat the question. Under the rules, the envelope went back.

Two years later a woman of the same name came to the post office to collect a bank letter. Her address was in another tola. Whether Dinbandhu recognized her or not, he is no longer certain. That day she merely signed and left.

Sometimes people imagine a postman knows every story. Dinbandhu knew that a postman usually sees a story only in the middle. The beginning remains with the sender, the ending with the recipient. In his hand comes only a piece of paper at one bend in the road.

That was why he was wary of imagination. It is very easy to turn what one does not know into a story.

5

Days with court notices were the hardest. When he delivered a wedding invitation, people served tea. With an appointment letter, sweets. With a money order, blessings. With a notice, a door opened only halfway.

Once he went to Ramdev's house carrying a registered letter connected with the ghat land dispute. A young man in the house said, "Kaka, say you did not find me."

Holding the envelope, Dinbandhu asked, "Did not find whom?"

The young man did not laugh. "Me."

"You are standing in front of me."

"Then write that I have gone out."

"Then go out. After that I shall write it."

For a few moments they stared at each other. At last the young man signed.

A few days later papers for the ghat committee arrived too. That time the committee president came to the post office himself.

Dinbandhu knew the way to the homes of both sides. People asked his opinion on who owned the land. He would say, "I deliver letters, not judgments."

Someone would joke, "You have seen thirty years of post. Whose truth is heavier?"

He would reply, "A scale can tell you the weight of an envelope. Not what is inside."

In fact, he was never summoned to give evidence. That pleased him and stung him a little at the same time. So much of Pipra's life had passed through his hands, yet to the court he remained only a mail carrier. Then he would correct himself: perhaps that was good. Doing only the work entrusted to one was also a kind of dignity.

Incomplete Address — 2011

‘Nasim Ansari, Pipra, who used to repair watches.’

This was not today’s envelope; such an address had come before. The first time, Dinbandhu had laughed. Nasim’s shop stood near the bus stand. In a small glass case were watch straps, screwdrivers, springs. Every clock on the wall showed a different time. Nasim used to say, “I repair watches, not time.”

Then mobile phones came. Wristwatches became fewer. Nasim closed the shop and began selling clothes in front of his house. Old customers still called him ‘the watchman.’

Dinbandhu picked up today’s envelope. The sender was some factory in Ahmedabad. Nasim’s younger son worked there.

“I can deliver this,” Dinbandhu said.

Vivek said, “The address is incomplete.”

“Not for me.”

“From tomorrow you will no longer be in service.”

Dinbandhu placed the envelope back on the table. The sentence was plain, yet inside it thirty years of roads seemed to shut at once.

“Then I shall deliver it today.”

Vivek hesitated. “The ceremony today...”

“At ten. Nasim’s house is five minutes away.”

“The record needs the delivery employee’s signature.”

Dinbandhu lifted his pen to sign his name, then stopped. His date of retirement was today. Whether the speeches were at ten or five, the whole day was his final day of service.

He placed the envelope in his satchel. The empty satchel immediately recovered its old shape.

In the lanes of Pipra people stopped Dinbandhu unusually often that day. The news had spread.

“Kaka, now you can rest.”

“Kaka, the pension will come on time, won’t it?”

“Kaka, when will my son’s Aadhaar card arrive?”

“Kaka, who will bring the post from tomorrow?”

He gave separate answers to all the questions. Only to the last did he say, “The post office will. I will not.”

Some people made a face as though the idea that the post office and Dinbandhu could be separate institutions had just been introduced to them.

On the way, in front of the old school, he met Shanti Devi. She took a folded postcard from her bag.

“Look, you delivered this.”

Half one corner of the card had broken away. The ink had run. The date was nineteen years old. Shanti’s son was in the army. Four lines remained on the card: ‘I am fine. It is snowing. Keep rubbing oil on your knees.’

“Why do you not throw this away?” Dinbandhu asked.

Shanti folded the card and placed it back in her bag. “The paper is torn, not the words.”

“Your son calls you now.”

“Where do I keep the words spoken on the phone?”

Dinbandhu gave no answer. He remembered the old iron trunk at his own house. It too held letters he did not open even once a year, yet never threw away.

Where do I keep the words spoken on the phone? That question was not in his service manual.

Walking on, Dinbandhu also remembered the old days of money orders. Not every household had a bank account; no one had heard of sending money by mobile phone. A son working away from home, a husband labouring in Punjab's fields, a brother washing dishes in a Kolkata hotel—a part of each one's earnings would arrive at the post office as a paper slip.

Money Order — 2001

Sender: Shafiq Ansari, Ludhiana.

Recipient: Zarina Khatun, Pipra.

Amount: one thousand eight hundred rupees.

Message: ‘Ammi, buy clothes for Eid. Do not stop the medicine.’

Every time Zarina put down her thumbprint she would ask, “He must have kept something for himself, no?”

Dinbandhu would say, “It is not written in the message.”

“But you have not seen his face?”

“I have brought the money, not his face.”

At that answer Zarina would laugh, then while counting the notes set one aside and say, “This is for him, when he returns.”

Year after year, whether the number of those saved notes increased or they were spent, Dinbandhu did not know. Shafiq later went to a Gulf country. Money orders stopped and bank transfers began. Zarina received the money now, but she would tell Dinbandhu, “Earlier even two words came on the slip.”

Dinbandhu understood that as convenience grew, absence changed its form. In the slow journey of paper there had been the pain of waiting; in money arriving instantly there could be a shortage of words. Yet he did not believe the old days were better. Money orders too arrived late, sometimes wandered into another branch, sometimes left household expenses waiting. Memory sweetens inconvenience—he remained cautious about that.

8

Nasim's house was not locked. The door stood half open. From inside came the sound of a sewing machine. Nasim's wife Sakina was folding clothes. Seeing Dinbandhu, she said, “Today you are supposed to be off duty.”

“One is still left.”

Nasim came out from inside. His hair was completely white and thick glasses sat over his eyes. Seeing the envelope he said, “Mine?”

“From Ahmedabad.”

Nasim turned the envelope over. "The younger one must have sent it?"
 "The factory's name is on it."

While signing, Nasim asked, "Do you remember my watch shop?"
 "The address still comes by that name."

Nasim laughed. "The shop is gone, the name remains. When the man goes, what remains?"

From inside Sakina said, "First open the letter. Do philosophy afterwards."

The envelope contained papers about company insurance. Nasim could read half of it and asked Dinbandhu about the rest. Dinbandhu read it out but gave no advice on its meaning. "Talk to your son."

Nasim removed his glasses. "You used to read letters aloud too."

"For those who asked. Not everyone's."

"You used to fill out forms during money orders too."

"That was different work."

"Who will fill them now?"

Dinbandhu stood up. "Ask whoever brings the post now. Do not make him old from his first day."

As Dinbandhu stepped out, Nasim called, "Dinbandhu!"

In thirty years, very few people had called him by his name, simply as a name, while he was delivering post. Most said 'Dak Babu,' 'Kaka,' 'Postman Sahib.' He turned.

Nasim said, "The watch shop is gone, but I still keep the tools for repairing watches. If you have an old watch, bring it."

Dinbandhu looked at his wrist. He was not wearing a watch. "If I find the time."

Nasim laughed loudly. "Now you have nothing but time."

Dinbandhu laughed too, but there was a little fear inside the sentence.

9

The ceremony was small. A garland, a gamchha, a box of sweets, a service certificate. In his speech the postmaster said, "Dinbandhuji has been Pipra's walking address book."

People applauded. The word 'has been' sounded strange to Dinbandhu. He sat right in front of them, yet in the sentence he had already become past tense.

He was asked to speak. At first he refused. Then he stood.

"Not much to say. In learning to deliver post, I learned that addresses do not belong only to houses. People keep changing the addresses of their lives too. Some go away, some return, some change while remaining at home. The old address remains on paper. My work was, wherever possible, to get that paper into the right hands. Where it was not possible, to send it back. That is all."

Someone from the back called out, "And you kept everyone's secrets?"

Everyone laughed. Dinbandhu did too. "Who ever gave me their secrets?"

The applause came again.

After the speech people began telling one small memory after another. One said Dinbandhu had once wrapped his examination admit card in plastic during rain; another said he had tracked down a wedding invitation mistakenly sent to another tola. Dinbandhu grew a little uncomfortable listening to all the stories. He remembered some, not others. In people's memory he had become more careful, more present, at times almost a character in a story.

He took the microphone again and added only one thing: "Remember also where I made mistakes. Service is not made only of good stories."

An old man sitting in the back immediately called out, "You once delivered one of my letters three days late!"

Everyone laughed. Dinbandhu folded his hands. "There, the accounting begins."

The old man laughed too. "But it arrived."

"Even so, three days late was a mistake."

Saying that made Dinbandhu feel lighter. Farewell ceremonies often turn a person faultless. He did not want to leave as a faultless man. In thirty years he had sometimes rung the wrong bell, sometimes called a person's name too loudly in a crowd and made a private matter public, sometimes been tired and held a letter for the next day—small mistakes all remained in memory. Respect for work is not built by erasing mistakes, but by accepting responsibility among them.

After the ceremony Vivek asked Dinbandhu for the route book. "We shall keep this in the office. It is very useful."

Dinbandhu opened the notebook. The first pages held the official route list. In the middle were landmarks for houses. The last pages contained comments that touched the boundary of someone's private life—"Old mother lives alone here," "In this house give the letter into the daughter-in-law's hands," "Babuji cannot read—read it aloud if asked," "If a letter comes in this name, first try the new settlement, not the old house."

He did not hand over the notebook immediately.

Vivek asked, "What happened?"

"Not everything belongs to the office."

He could not tear out the blank pages because both sides of the paper were written on. At last he said, "I shall make a clean copy."

"Today?"

"No. Tomorrow."

Vivek smiled. "Your first task after retirement?"

"My task. Not the office's."

Envelope — Address Unclear

'Chhoti, Pipra.'

After the ceremony ended, Dinbandhu returned to the table. The third envelope was still there. In small letters, the sender's name read: 'Aarti,

Pune.' No telephone number on the back. No lane. No father's or husband's name. Only 'Chhoti.'

Vivek said, "This one will have to be returned."

Dinbandhu took the envelope in his hand. Guessing whether the handwriting belonged to a woman or a man had never been his habit. How many 'Chhotis' could there be in Pipra? The youngest daughter of a house, a younger sister, a childhood nickname, an address that survived into old age.

"The sender is Aarti," Dinbandhu said softly.

"Do you know her?"

"There are many people named Aarti."

He turned the pages of his route book. Aarti—three entries. One a schoolteacher, one a girl who had left after marriage, one a woman from the sewing centre. None had 'Chhoti' beside the name.

Suddenly Dinbandhu remembered an old incident. About twenty-five years earlier, a teenage girl arriving from the station had sat crying on the post-office veranda. She had forgotten the full address. She kept saying, "I want to go to Chhoti Mausi. Above the ghat, red door." Pipra had a dozen red doors. At last the tea seller had recognized the place.

Was that the same 'Chhoti'? Deliver today's letter on a twenty-five-year-old memory? No.

He placed the envelope back on the table.

"Return it," he said.

Vivek looked surprised. "You will not search?"

"Searching and guessing are not the same thing. If the address depends on my memory, and the memory is uncertain, putting it into an unknown hand is not delivering post."

Vivek took out the red stamp. Dinbandhu did not stop him.

The stamp fell—'INCOMPLETE ADDRESS.'

Thump.

A small sound. He had heard it thousands of times in thirty years. Today, for the first time, it seemed to him that returning a letter was also part of a postman's work; he had no right to complete every story.

II

That evening Dinbandhu sat on the veranda of his house with the route book open. The box of sweets remained closed before him. The gamchha hung over the back of a chair. His wife Phoolmati had placed the garland beside the tulsi pot.

"Still working on post-office papers?" Phoolmati asked.

"I am making a copy."

"So this thing called retirement happened only on paper?"

"From tomorrow it will become real."

In the copy he wrote only places—tolas, turns, lanes, public buildings, new roads, changes in old paths. He left out private notes. 'Old mother alone' disappeared. 'Give letter to daughter-in-law' disappeared. 'Read it aloud' disappeared.

The copy was cleaner. More official. A little less alive.

Phoolmati set down tea and picked up his old book. "What will you do with this?"

"Keep it."

"Why?"

Dinbandhu thought before answering. "It is less an address book than the road I have walked."

Turning a page, Phoolmati found a dried yellow flower. "Which letter was this from?"

Dinbandhu tried to remember. Perhaps it had come with a wedding invitation, perhaps someone's daughter had given it to him, perhaps he had simply picked it up on the road. "I do not remember."

"So even a postman does not remember everything?"

"That is a good thing."

Closing the book, Phoolmati said, "You remember fewer of the letters from your own house."

Dinbandhu laughed. "Why would I not remember the post from my own house?"

"Kanta's first letter?"

He went silent. When their daughter Kanta went to a hostel in Darbhanga, her first letter was addressed 'For Ma.' While sorting post Dinbandhu had recognized his own home address. A colleague joked, "Open it and read it; it is going to your own house anyway." Dinbandhu did not open the envelope. That evening, following the delivery route, he stood at his own door and handed it to Phoolmati like an ordinary letter, not a registered one.

Phoolmati went inside and read it, then, believing she had Kanta's permission, read it aloud to her father. The letter contained less about college than about the fear of spending a night away from home for the first time. Kanta had written, 'Do not tell Babu; he will worry.'

After hearing it, Dinbandhu had asked only, "Is she eating on time?"

Phoolmati laughed now. "You did not worry?"

"A great deal."

"Then why did you not say so?"

Dinbandhu ran a hand over the old book. "The letter was for you. What was read aloud to me—that much was my share."

Phoolmati looked at him for a while. "In thirty years you brought that habit home as well."

"Must every habit be left behind?"

"No. Keep some."

They both fell silent. A bicycle passed on the road beyond the veranda. Its bell rang once, then grew distant.

Night was settling. The streetlight by the road came on, but one corner of the veranda remained dark. Phoolmati lit a small lamp. Dinbandhu bent over the new copy of the route book. In the lamplight the pencil lines became clear, while some erased letters in the old book appeared only in the light falling at an angle.

For a moment he looked at the two books together—one clean and public; the other blurred, private, incomplete.

Pipra was in both, but complete in neither.

12

The next morning, when Vivek opened the post office, he found a brown envelope pushed under the door. In Dinbandhu's handwriting it said: 'Route List — Pipra Delivery Area.' Inside was the clean copy. On the last page there was only one line:

'If the address has changed, ask the people first; if people's account keeps changing, ask the paper; and if the two say different things, do not guess.'

Vivek read the line and smiled. He placed the envelope in the cupboard.

That day's first post included a postcard. Address: 'Shanti Devi, near the old wall of the school, Pipra.' The old school wall had been demolished the year before. Vivek stepped outside and asked the tea seller.

"Who is Shanti Devi?"

The tea seller first named two women. On the third try he said, "The one whose son is in the army?"

Vivek looked again at the recipient's name on the postcard. "Perhaps."

"Deliver post on 'perhaps?'" the tea seller laughed.

Vivek laughed too. "No. First I shall make sure."

Far down the road Dinbandhu was walking without his satchel. His shoulder looked straight, but his right hand repeatedly rose to the place where the satchel strap had rested for thirty years. Each time he lowered it again.

A light mist was rising from the direction of the ghat. The market was opening. A mobile phone rang in one house, a newspaper fell at another door, and inside the post office the new postman, holding his first postcard, began searching for the correct place.

Dinbandhu did not turn back.

Yet he knew that in Pipra, even today, some things require more than an address in order to arrive.

— *End of Story 40* —

41. Away from Home

STORY

I

I know very well how pointless it seems to write you a letter. You have no postal address. A PIN code can be written after your name, but that PIN code will reach only the Pipra sub-post office, not you. If I write a street name, the street comes to your side and stops. If I write “Kamla Ghat, Pipra,” into whose hand will the new postman put it? The ghat committee? The flower seller? The boatman? Or that red chair which arrives first on Chhath day and is removed last?

Still, I am writing to you.

Night is not yet over in this room. Outside the window, yellow lights planted in the sand burn in a straight line. The air is hot; the air-conditioner’s hum makes more noise than coolness. All five men who live with me are asleep. Someone’s phone glows beneath his pillow; someone’s shoes lie overturned by the door. I have returned from the night shift and bathed, yet the smell of machine oil still clings to my body.

On nights like this, writing to home is difficult. Home will ask—how much did you earn, when will you come, has the roof been cast, did you send the younger girl’s fees? You have nothing to ask. That is why writing to you feels easier.

2

I do not know whether you remember. I do not know whether places remember, or whether human beings lay their memories upon places. But when I was twelve, I fell from your third step. My right knee split open. Instead of lifting me, Mother first scolded me—“Didn’t I tell you not to run near the water?” Father came laughing from a distance and wiped the blood with his gamchha.

The river was not very full that day. My feet sank into mud, and sand stuck to the wound on my knee. It hurt until evening. Yet today, when I descend the iron stairs of this country’s factory, that old scar on my knee keeps pulling. A doctor would say the skin healed and the joint is fine. I remember your third step.

How many times have your steps been built and broken? At some Chhath a bamboo railing, after some monsoon a sunken half, sometimes

bricks laid again. I look at photographs and try to identify the third step. Perhaps it no longer exists. Yet it still exists in my knee.

In this country people identify places by numbers on a map. The company bus takes us from “Housing Block C-7” to “Industrial Zone B-4.” In the first month all the roads looked the same to us—grey road, white lights, iron fencing, sand into the distance. Three years later I know at which turn the bus body will sway a little, which red light will keep us waiting longer, behind which petrol pump the first light of dawn looks best. A place eventually becomes a place if the body passes through it again and again.

But not like you.

3

I did not leave you all at once. When people go away to a foreign land, they say they left the village, left home, left the country. In truth, a person leaves nothing in one single moment. First the bus stand falls behind. Then, in phone calls, the village voices recede a little. Then the weather is left behind—in the month when mist settles over Pipra, afternoons here are still hot. Then the taste of food changes. Then language. Then the body’s own sense of time.

I left fifteen days after Chhath. A few dried flowers were still caught on your steps. The committee men were taking down bamboo. Badri Kaka sat on the red chair, settling accounts. I had gone to your side with friends although I was to catch the bus the next morning. No one said farewell. Neither did I.

At night Mother kept opening my bag and tying it again. Father kept counting the money and putting it back among the clothes. My sister filled my phone with songs. Everything was for the journey. Only that half-hour by your side was not.

I did not understand then. Now I do—a person going far away first stores certain places inside himself so that he can open them later. That half-hour beside you lies folded within me like a sheet of paper.

4

Here water comes through pipes, rises into tanks, is filtered, and is sold in bottles. At first I laughed at the taste of bottled water. “What taste does water have?” Rahim, who worked with me, asked. I said, “My ghat would know.”

He looked at me, then laughed. “Does a ghat drink water?”

I did not answer.

I do not know whether you know the taste of the river. But I know the water by you is not the same every day. In the rains its smell is different. In winter its transparent cold is different. On Chhath evening the smells of flowers, milk, incense, crowds, and mud mingle together. After floods I have seen broken bamboo, leaves, cow dung cakes, bundles of paddy, sometimes an entire thatched roof floating in that water.

Here water tastes almost the same every day. Safe, measured, sealed. The bottle carries a date of manufacture. An expiry date too. Your water had no date.

When the factory heat rises, the supervisor says, “Keep drinking water.” I lift the bottle. Sometimes, the moment I open the cap, your steps appear before my eyes. This is no miracle. Thirst probably sharpens memory—that is all. Yet at that moment one sip of water measures the distance between two places inside me.

5

Money here is a number. Hours worked, overtime, deductions, room rent, food, the sum sent home. On the phone screen the number rises and falls. In Pipra that same number becomes bricks, school fees, medicine, an embankment for the field.

The first year I repaid the debt. The second year the tin roof came off and a concrete roof was cast. The third year went to the younger girl’s studies. Father kept saying, “The fruit of your work is visible at home.”

I used to feel happy. I still do. But sometimes a question comes—where do I see the fruit of my work for myself?

I saw the roof in a photograph on my phone. Gleaming new. Half the old courtyard in shade. Mother said, “Your room has been built upstairs.” I looked at the room on the screen. The door was closed. Nothing of mine was inside. I laughed—“It has been built before I arrived; now send me there too.”

Mother did not laugh. She said, “Don’t say things like that.”

I changed the subject at once.

I can tell you this. A room built in my name was completed without me. Whether that is sorrow or happiness, I cannot decide. Perhaps both. Earning away from home does not merely add to a house; sometimes it changes the house into a form that the returning person must enter as though for the first time.

6

Last Chhath my brother made a video call. He turned the phone toward you. I was in uniform, about to leave for the night shift. Evening had not yet fallen here; in Pipra the sun was going down. Everyone’s faces were tiny on the screen. The song crackled through the phone microphone. Someone said, “Turn the camera toward the ghat.” Someone else said, “The network isn’t working.”

Then I saw you.

On that four-inch screen.

There was a new bamboo enclosure. Yellow cloth on one side. The river seemed to have moved farther away than the year before. The red chair was there again. Whether Badri Kaka had risen from it or someone else was

sitting there, I could not see clearly. The lamps drew long lines on the water, but each time the video shook all those lines broke apart.

My brother asked, "Can you see?"

I said, "Yes."

He asked again, "Properly?"

I said, "Yes."

In truth, I could see only half. But away from home, "yes" is often used in place of a complete picture. People at home ask—have you eaten? Yes. Is your body well? Yes. Is the job good? Yes. When will you come? "Yes" does not work for that question, so we look for fault with the network.

I will not lie to you. That day I saw half and filled the other half from memory. Perhaps every video of home works like that.

7

Here even my name does not remain whole. It is written in English letters on my identity card. The supervisor pronounces only part of it. My companions have shortened it for their convenience. On the phone Mother uses my full name, especially when angry. Father only the first two syllables. My sister says, "Bhaiya."

How many forms does your name have? Kamla Ghat. Old Ghat. Main Ghat. Chhath Ghat. In court papers perhaps a plot number. The town boys simply say "the ghat." Old people sometimes add the name of an old shrine. To the river you have no name—only a cutbank, a bend, a shore.

My days in the factory pass among three or four languages. Orders in English, laughter in someone's Malayalam, abuse in someone's Bengali or Nepali; the moment a phone call goes home, everyone returns to his own mother tongue. In the first year I thought language abroad was only a convenience—whatever was understood was enough. Slowly I understood that convenience can carry life, but not memory. Some things, the moment I say them outside Maithili, change temperature. When Mother says "khali liyau"—eat, please—the meaning can survive in another language, but not Mother's very voice.

That is why, while writing to you, I do not step outside my own speech. For your mud, bamboo, steps, and water I need the same words I heard in childhood. Sometimes a co-worker sees me typing Maithili on my phone and asks, "What language is that?" I tell him the name. He asks, "Different from Hindi?" I say, "Yes." Then something inside me becomes alert. Explaining one's language in a distant country can feel like explaining the boundary of one's home—but a boundary that does not keep another person out; it merely says: inside here, my memory speaks in this sound.

I wonder whether names bind people to places, or places bind names to themselves. My work identity card may change after five years. My passport will expire. The visa will be renewed or not. Even the company's name may change. Yet while writing to you I do not need to write my own name.

You know—after writing that sentence, I stopped.

Do you know? To say that an inanimate place “knows” may be a poetic convenience. Still, in a letter I will not stand guard over logic. If a person can speak in his mind to an absent mother, ask questions of a dead father, say to an old house, “Do you recognize me?”—why not speak to a ghat?

You will not answer. Perhaps that is why writing to you is safe.

My brother says there is a new road in Pipra now, two old market shops are gone, and the pond behind the school has been half filled. In photographs all changes look small because the screen gives every place the same size. But I know that when I return these small changes will spoil my directions. Where the body used to turn right without thinking, perhaps there will be a new wall. The tree that signalled home from a distance may have been cut down. The fear of living away is not only that home has changed; it is also that the body will go on moving according to the old home.

8

The things kept safely accumulate the most.

Shaukat, who shares this room with me, went home three months ago. After seven years. For the first two days he sent videos—the station, the road, his front door, the fields. From the third day he fell silent. When he returned, he said, “I reached home, but home did not reach me.” I laughed. So did he. Then neither of us said anything.

Last night in the canteen he suddenly asked, “There’s a river in your village, isn’t there?”

I said, “Yes.”

“When you return, where will you go first?”

I was going to say home. What came out was, “The ghat.”

He asked, “Not home?”

“Home afterwards.”

We both laughed again. But that answer kept circling inside me all night. Mother would be hurt if she heard it. Father might say, “Home first.” Yet the truth is that if my feet permit when I get off the bus, I would like to go first to you.

Everyone at home will look at me. They will ask questions. Open my bag. Measure gifts, smell, thinness of body, complexion, earnings—everything. You have nothing to measure. I will sit on your steps and stretch my legs, if the steps survive. If the river has withdrawn, I will walk over the sand. I will only see how much the distance has changed in five years.

Sending things from abroad is easy. A watch, clothes, a phone, perfumed oil, toys for children. On a migrant worker’s first leave, his bag is often heavier than his body. I too have made a list—a light shawl for Mother, a watch for Father, a phone for the younger girl. But in which bag can I carry five years of absence? The evening Father’s eyesight weakened and I was not there, the day of the younger girl’s exam result, the night Mother fell ill and a neighbour took her to hospital—no gift can stand in place of these.

People at home do not put this account before me. Instead they say, “This happened because of you, that happened because of you.” Their gratitude gives me happiness and, sometimes, weight. For every thing built from my earnings, another question rises—if I return, who will earn for the next thing? Away-from-home work slowly ceases to be only employment; it becomes a permanent bracket in the family’s calculation of the future. A person wants to step outside that bracket, but the rest of the household account begins adjusting itself again.

9

But it is difficult to write a date for returning.

First I said—when the debt is paid. Then—when the roof is built. Then—when the younger girl’s studies are complete. Now there is Father’s eye treatment. The company is offering a new contract. The wage will rise a little. Home says, “Stay one more year.” One year is a small phrase. Four seasons. Twelve months. Twelve mobile bills. Yet in Pipra, in one year, the river can change course, a tree can be cut, a postman can retire, the red chair can become empty.

You know none of this calculation. A river does not read contracts. A ghat does not look at payslips. So I will not give you excuses.

I do not know when I will return.

Last year I filled out a leave application. I even chose the date—the first week of Kartik. The application sat on the table for three days; then production increased; then two men went on leave; then the supervisor said next month. The next month Father’s treatment expense arrived. I tore up the application myself. At home I said, “The company would not give leave.” It was half true. The company had been delaying, but the last postponement was mine. I am writing that for the first time now.

That day I felt guilty for a long time. Then the bank message came—the money had arrived. Mother said on the phone, “Good. Now the treatment can happen without worry.” The edge of guilt dulled at once. Life away from home is built from many such small compromises—seen separately, each looks reasonable; added together, five years pass.

I do not have the courage to write this sentence home. I have written it to you.

The hardest work for me abroad is not lifting heavy pipes, not the night shift, not the heat. The hardest thing is admitting that the account of time is not fully in my hands. I came to earn. I cannot identify the exact point at which earning became the reason to stay.

10

News about you now comes through a lawsuit as well. My brother said papers are moving again over the land at the ghat. Someone says public, someone private. Old river maps, measurements, testimony. I sat far away listening. I even laughed. I do not know whose name that place, which seemed

everyone's in my childhood, will bear on paper. Perhaps childhood's "everyone's" was not the whole truth either. Entry was easy for some, difficult for others. Some had places in front, some behind. On Chhath all the lamps floated on the same water, but on land everyone's feet did not stand on the same line.

Distance gives perspective; sometimes it scrapes the decoration from memory. I cannot call you only beautiful. There were social lines in your mud as well. I saw some things, did not see some, and saw some without understanding.

Still, I write to you. If love were only for blameless things, human beings could love very little.

Beside the factory here is a small prayer room. People from different countries go there at their own times. Shoes stand in one row outside. Inside there is no sign of whose home lies where, what anyone's caste is, which river belongs to whom. But the moment they come out, everyone goes toward his own bus, language, wage, room. Equality too is sometimes only the size of a room. I understand this by remembering the Chhath crowd at you.

II

Father called today. His eye treatment is next month. I have sent the money. In a very ordinary voice he said, "Don't worry."

People usually say "don't worry" about the things they themselves are worried about.

Mother took the phone. She asked, "Food?"

"I've eaten."

"Sleep?"

"It happens."

"Leave?"

"Not yet."

A few moments of silence. A utensil clinked somewhere behind her. Then Mother said, "Will you come for Chhath?"

I looked out the window. The industrial-zone lights were burning even in daylight.

"I'll see," I said.

This "I'll see" is the longest sentence of life away from home. Hope, helplessness, calculation, shame, love—everything fits inside it.

After the call ended, I began writing to you. Not on paper, on my phone. But now I think I will copy this letter onto paper. I will not post it. I will keep it in my box. When I return, I will bring it with me. Whether I will sit on your steps and read it, I will decide then. Perhaps there will be no need to read it. Perhaps by then all these sentences will seem ridiculous.

Paper does only this much—it gives the unstable things of today a body for a few days.

It is four in the morning. Outside the window the darkness has faded a little. Far away, a row of white factory lights is still steady. My shift begins again in the evening. I have five hours to sleep.

I do not know how to end this letter. If I were writing home, I would write, "Respect to everyone." If I were writing a friend, "We'll meet when I return." What should I write to you?

To write "Stay there" is pointless—I do not know whether you will remain or whether the river will cut you away and carry you elsewhere. To write "Wait for me" would be arrogance—why should a ghat wait for a human being? To write "I will return" would be a promise—a promise without a date that weighs upon me.

So only this.

If next Chhath my brother turns the phone toward you and the screen shakes, you will appear only half. I will fill the other half from within myself. If the river has retreated, I will remember the old waterline. If the third step is gone, the scar on my knee will remain. If someone else sits in the red chair, I will know that time does not leave an empty seat vacant for long.

And if one day I truly return and reach your side, I will not touch the water first. I will first stand a little way off and look. I will see whether I recognize you or the ghat made by my memory. Then I will descend the steps slowly.

Here, in this country of sand, night is falling away. Light is coming, though the sun has not yet risen. The distant lights are reflected in the window glass. There is no river on the other side of the glass, yet for a moment I feel as though the light is trembling on water.

I do not rub my eyes.

I close the letter I have written to you.

— *End of Story 41* —

42. Dom

STORY

I

In Pipra, water first arrives as news, then as sound, then as smell, and only after that inside the house.

For three days in the last week of Sawan there had been news that the Kamla was rising. At the market tea stall people counted the bridge piers, showed one another pictures of the upstream current on their phones, then went home and cleared the drains in their own courtyards. Sumitra listened too, but her work continued in the spaces between the listening. First she lifted the sacks of paddy onto the cot. When her back strained, she paused, then put the spices, oil, matches, and bundle of papers on the mud shelf in the room. She set bricks beneath the utensils. She tied the cow to a peg on the higher ground behind the house.

Her son Neelu received news of water as though it were news of a holiday. Fear of the river had not yet fully entered his nine-year-old body. With the other children of the lane he floated paper boats in the flowing water, then ran ahead to catch them. Sumitra called him inside twice. The third time, without calling, she took off his wet half-pants and spread them on the peg by the door.

By evening water glimmered in the southern corner of the courtyard. Whether it was drain water or river water was difficult to tell. Tiny bubbles rose through the ash of the hearth. Sumitra put rice on the stove, set aside one lota of clean water, and placed Neelu's schoolbag on top of the old iron trunk.

When her husband Raghav returned from the market, half his feet were caked in mud. He came inside, wrung out his wet gamchha, and said only, "We'll have to watch through the night."

Sumitra did not even say "yes." She was draining the starch from the rice.

Neelu opened his exercise book and sat at the table to write something. The electricity went once, returned, then went again. Sumitra took out the lantern and checked the oil. The wick was half gone. She cut a new wick from an old piece of cloth.

By ten at night the courtyard water had reached the ankles. By then neighbours had begun moving goats, children, grain, and bedding toward the high school building. Sumitra first lifted two sacks. Raghav stood one cot upright against the wall. Neelu wanted to walk in front holding the lantern. Sumitra took the lantern from his hand and slung a small bag on his back.

The bag held two sets of clothes, a steel bowl, his mathematics exercise book, and half a packet of flattened rice that Sumitra had stuffed in hurriedly.

By then the flood was no longer merely water. It had reordered the house. Things that always stayed below had been moved upward; the people who owned the house were preparing to leave it as guests.

2

On an ordinary day the way to the school took ten minutes. That night it took more than half an hour.

In the lane the water reached the knees. In some places it was shallower; in others it deepened suddenly. People walked holding bamboo poles. Someone had a sack on his head, someone a child against the chest. An old woman held a basket of hens tight to her stomach. From time to time someone raised a torch, then swept its light down over the water.

Sumitra kept hold of Neelu's arm. In her other hand was a bundle of clothes. Raghav followed carrying rice and a plastic sack of papers.

At one turn the water ran fast. There the cover of a municipal drain that had been dug earlier was missing. People had planted bamboo to mark the path. Sumitra set one foot beside a bamboo pole, then the other. Neelu between them. The boy had never been so quiet.

The school veranda was packed with people. They found space in Class Five. Four families were already on the floor. Sumitra spread a mat near the window. Before laying the bedding she touched the ground with her hand; it was damp. She spread newspaper and placed the mat on top. Neelu took off his bag and put it in a corner.

Sumitra did not sleep for the rest of the night. One moment she wiped Neelu's feet, another she checked the knots of the sacks, another she went to the veranda to see how high the water had risen. Outside in the dark there were only streaks from torches, and whenever lightning flashed the school field turned white for an instant.

By morning the water in the field was chest-deep.

Raghav wanted to go and see the house. Sumitra did not stop him. She only handed him an empty sack and a rope. Neelu held the iron bars of the window and watched outside. Wood, grass, plastic, cow-dung cakes, a broken shoe drifted past on the water.

Raghav returned in the afternoon. Water inside the house stood above the waist. A neighbour had untied the cow and sent it to the high embankment. Two sacks of paddy were soaked.

The moment Sumitra heard about the wet paddy, she pulled an empty sheet of plastic from beneath her mat. "It can be dried," she said.

That was all.

Neelu asked for flattened rice twice that day. The third time he wanted to wash the bowl himself. The school tap had gone under water; tanker water was limited. Sumitra took the bowl from him and wiped it with cloth.

On the second night the wind strengthened. The classroom filled with the mingled smell of bodies, wet clothes, oil, earth, and fear. Sumitra rested Neelu's head in her lap. The child slept. One hand hung outside the blanket. Sumitra gently lifted it and tucked it inside.

3

On the third day the water seemed still, but current keeps moving inside still water.

In the morning a relief boat arrived. Flattened rice, jaggery, candles, medicine. A crowd gathered on the school veranda. Raghav went to help with distribution. Sumitra did not stand in line; they still had flattened rice from the day before. To wash Neelu's clothes, she brought a bucket of relatively clean rainwater that had collected behind the school. The boy's half-pants, vest, towel—three things. She scrubbed carefully, saving soap.

Neelu was with the children at the other end of the veranda. Someone was setting bottle caps afloat and racing them. Someone had cut up a relief carton to make a boat. Sumitra looked up twice. The third time she did not.

At noon people shouted near the wall behind the school. It was not the main river current, but the water in the field had suddenly begun pulling in one direction. Perhaps some part of the earthen embankment behind had broken. People began calling the children inside.

Sumitra was wringing out the half-pants. She spread the cloth over the bucket and looked up.

Neelu was not where he had been five minutes earlier.

At first it did not seem unusual. Children change places. She walked from one end of the veranda to the other. Checked Class Four. Checked the stairs. Checked the way to the roof. Swept her eyes over the groups of boys. She quickened her step at the sight of a yellow shirt, then saw it was another child.

She reached Raghav. The wet vest was still in her hand.

"Where is Neelu?"

Raghav's face first understood the question, then the fear.

They went in different directions.

Someone said the children had gone behind the school. Someone said he had been seen in the crowd near the boat. Someone said he had gone inside the school. No one was certain.

Sumitra went to the back wall. The water there was flowing faster than before. Three children were crying at one corner of the wall, but Neelu was not among them. A young man had gone into the water with a bamboo pole. Another held the rope.

Sumitra took off her slippers. Someone stopped her. She did not stop. Knee, thigh, waist—the water rose. The current began taking her footing away. Raghav caught her arm from behind.

Sumitra tried to free her arm, but the strength of her body was less than the current.

At that moment someone shouted that something red was floating farther ahead. Four men ran. A boat was launched.

The red thing turned out to be a plastic bag.

Sumitra stared at that bag for a very long time.

4

The search began first with the name.

“Neelu.”

People threw the name across the water. The school roof, the fields behind, the embankment, the mango grove, the old road, the temple mound. The boatmen called the name. Sumitra too could call, but after two or three times her voice closed up. After that she kept working with her hands.

She opened Neelu’s bag. The mathematics exercise book was not wet. The bowl, two clothes, the flattened rice. She took everything out and tied it in one cloth. Someone said they needed a photograph. Sumitra took out the small school identity card kept behind the exercise book. The photograph was two years old. Neelu’s front tooth was broken then; a new one had since grown. Sumitra looked at the photograph, then had his present identifying marks written on a sheet—an old cut mark on the right knee, a small mole behind the left ear.

The young man writing asked, “Age?”

Sumitra said nine. Then thought. The school paper said eight. The exact date of birth? She looked at Raghav. Raghav had lowered his head. In the end they wrote “about nine.”

Even the age of a child lost in water became an estimate.

The first time Sumitra climbed into a boat it was growing dark. They seated her in the middle. Four men on the sides with bamboo poles and oars. River water and floodwater had merged; where there had been road and where field could be known only from people’s memory. Electric wires sagged low. Of one roof only the upper edge was visible.

Sumitra kept watching the water’s surface. Her eyes searched for colours—Neelu’s blue shirt, black half-pants, skin, hair. But whatever floated on the water became for an instant something belonging to a child. A cloth. A sack. A box. A dead goat. A bamboo mat.

At the sight of the dead goat the boatman turned his eyes away. Sumitra did not.

When they returned to the school at night, someone gave her food. She took the plate. Broke off one mouthful of rice. Did not bring it to her mouth. Then pushed the plate toward Raghav.

She sat on Neelu’s mat. A child’s sleeping place had been so small; once empty, it seemed enormous.

5

For the next four days Sumitra’s day ran not by the clock, but by the boats.

The first boat at dawn. The second at noon. Walking until evening wherever the water had receded. School at night.

Everywhere she repeated the same work. Showing the photograph. Saying the colour of the clothes. Describing the marks. Having the name written. Looking at hospital lists. Walking among children in relief camps. Turning whenever any name sounded familiar.

On the fifth day news came—a child had been found in a village downstream. Sumitra climbed into a boat. Halfway there rain began. She did not cover her head. When she arrived, the child was seven, not Neelu. His mother too had arrived searching. The two women looked at each other. Neither said anything.

On the way back, Sumitra straightened the wet sheet around that child.

On the sixth day there was news of a body. The age was similar. Raghav wanted to go; Sumitra went too.

What she saw there does not ask to be described. Only this: Sumitra looked at the right knee, looked behind the ear, then shook her head.

Not Neelu.

After returning, she lit a stove for the first time. A temporary hearth behind the school. The wet wood smoked. Sumitra blew on it again and again. Water ran from her eyes. Some thought it was smoke. Some thought another reason. Sumitra corrected no one.

She cooked rice. For Raghav, for herself. She took out a third bowl as well. After a while she put it back into the bag.

On the seventh day the boatman said the current might have carried him very far.

Sumitra did not answer. With her fingernail she kept scraping the mud dried on the boat plank.

6

On the tenth day the water began to recede.

People started returning to see their houses. The school slowly emptied. Families whose houses had collapsed stayed. Those whose walls had survived went to search for their belongings in the mud.

Sumitra and Raghav returned too. Inside the house a grey line ran across the wall above chest height—a straight mark of how high the water had reached. The cot overturned. The trunk shifted. The smell of swollen, rotting paddy. The calendar hanging on the wall half dissolved.

Sumitra did not pick up the broom first. She opened the door of Neelu's room. Mud inside. The trunk had been high enough to survive. She took down his schoolbag. The bag he had carried to the school was another one; this was his everyday schoolbag. The edges of the books had curled from damp. On the first page of one exercise book Neelu had written his name five times, each in a different size.

Sumitra closed the exercise book.

Then the work began.

She shoveled the mud from the courtyard. Scraped silt from the wall. Boiled utensils. Wet clothes separate. Rotten grain separate. Salvageable grain in the sun. She cleaned the stove three times. Changed the ash.

Women from the neighbourhood came to help. One picked up a broom without asking. One took the stove. One the clothes. Sumitra gave Neelu's clothes to no one.

She began washing them one by one. The white school shirt, its collar now grey. Blue trousers. The vest he wore at home. A small gamchha. A red sweater that was not for the season but had been wet at the bottom of the trunk.

She rubbed in soap, wrung them out, then put them in clean water. The muddy water was black at first, then pale. One stain on the white shirt would not come out. She soaped it again. The stain lightened a little. She rubbed it a third time.

A neighbour gently tried to hold her hand. Sumitra did not pull away; neither did she stop scrubbing.

The cloth of the shirt grew thin.

At last she wrung it out and spread it over a bamboo pole.

The sun had come out. Sunlight in Pipra after many days. Clothes lay spread on every roof, wire, bamboo, bush. The whole town seemed to be drying its soaked body.

Neelu's shirt too was taking the air.

7

There was no single date on which the search ended.

The boats gradually shifted to distributing relief. The police lists filled with newer incidents. News of searches in the downstream villages grew sparse. At first people asked Sumitra whenever they saw her, "Any news?" Then the question came less often. In the end people asked only with their eyes.

Sumitra herself did not search less; the form of her search changed.

When she went to the market, she looked into crowds of children. Boys getting off buses at the stand. Temple steps. The school prayer line. Groups of outside labourers who had arrived after the flood. If someone from behind walked like Neelu, she quickened her pace by two steps. As she came nearer, the gait changed.

One day in the market she saw a blue shirt. She left her vegetable basket and followed. The boy turned. Not Neelu. Sumitra came home without buying anything. Only then she remembered the basket was still at the shop. She did not go back. In the evening the shopkeeper's son brought it to her house.

At home Neelu's plate remained in the same place for three weeks. Sumitra washed it, dried it, put it away. She did not take it out at mealtime.

Raghav spoke little at night. Once he began putting Neelu's schoolbag on the upper shelf. Sumitra brought it down and placed it in its old place.

Raghav said nothing.

That night Sumitra stayed awake for a long time. Outside, water remained only in the drains. Frogs. A dog far away. She got up and stirred the ash in the stove. A small ember remained inside. She did not blow it back to life. She simply covered it again with ash.

The next morning the same ember lit the stove.

8

Government papers reached the house after the water had gone down.

A young man came with a list. Damage to the house, grain, livestock, household members. A name beside “missing.” On paper Neelu fit into one box. The young man spoke respectfully, but he had to move on.

Sumitra looked at the paper. Not “dead.” “Missing.”

She took the pen. Earlier she used to make a thumbprint rather than sign, but while helping with Neelu’s school matters she had learned to write her own name. Slowly she wrote “Sumitra Devi.” The “tra” leaned slightly.

The paper went away.

A few weeks later there was talk of compensation. Which category, what proof, after how many days a missing person would be considered dead—people said different things. Raghav went to the block office. Brought papers.

Sumitra kept the papers wrapped separately in cloth, with Neelu’s birth paper, school identity card, and photograph.

That day she cleaned the room for a long time. Bedding in the sun. Books dusted. She opened Neelu’s pencil box. Inside were three short pencils, an eraser, a broken ruler, a glass marble. Holding the marble, she sat in the courtyard. In the sunlight green and blue turned inside the glass.

She put the marble back in the box.

The paper said—missing.

The house said—absent.

Her hands said—dust is settling on this box; clean it.

Sumitra kept working on the third thing.

9

By Kartik the roads of Pipra had dried. Flood silt turned to dust. Shops opened again. The waterline remained on the school wall, but classes resumed.

One day a teacher came to return Neelu’s books. Another set was available at school; these were his own books from home. The teacher had a small bag in his hand. He sat on the veranda. He seemed to have prepared many words, but when Sumitra went inside to make tea, the words perhaps scattered.

He only put down the bag.

Sumitra took out the books. Mathematics, Maithili, environmental studies. One page in the Maithili book had been folded. She straightened it.

The teacher said, “In his studies, he...”

The sentence did not finish.

Sumitra placed the cup of tea in front of him.

After a while the teacher left. Sumitra began washing three cups. She did not remember why she had taken out the third. She washed all three.

That evening two neighbourhood children came asking for Neelu's glass marbles. They used to play together. Both stood silently at the door. Sumitra opened the box. Gave one marble to each. Kept the rest.

The children ran away. In the courtyard the marbles struck—tok. Then another—tok.

Sumitra went on stirring the dal on the stove.

After that sound, whether the house felt a little less empty or more, she could not decide.

IO

As Chhath approached, the ghat began to be cleaned again. After the flood there was much more work this year. Silt on the steps, old bamboo stakes torn out, the edge altered. The committee gathered again. Someone's donation, someone's list, someone's quarrel.

Sumitra used to go help prepare the ghat for Chhath. This time she did not go for three days. On the fourth morning she left carrying a broom.

Raghav did not ask.

At the ghat women were scraping mud. Men were driving bamboo poles. On one side Badri Kaka's red chair lay covered in dust. Sumitra spoke to no one. She took up the work of clearing silt from the fifth step. Broom, basin, water.

After a while a small plastic wheel came out beneath her hand—the wheel of a toy car. Blue.

Sumitra's hand stopped.

She washed the wheel in water. The blue brightened. Neelu's toy? She remembered Neelu had a red car, with black wheels. This was not his.

She threw the wheel onto the rubbish heap.

The work began again.

By noon five steps were clean. When she returned home her palms were cracked. She rubbed in mustard oil. Neelu's shirt was no longer on the bamboo; she had folded it away in the trunk long before.

On the first evening of Chhath she did not go to the ghat. The smell of thekua came from neighbouring houses. Before dawn on the second day she woke suddenly. The courtyard was dark. She filled a lota with water, but not for worship. Set it by the stove. Then opened the door and went out.

She did not go as far as the ghat. She stopped by the peepal tree halfway. From far away came fragments of song, the dholak, people's voices, long trembling lines of lamps upon the river.

Sumitra stood there for a very long time.

Her hands were empty.

II

At the beginning of winter Raghav put a cot in Neelu's room. The old cot had rotted in the flood. A new cot was necessary; guests would come, the room would have to serve some use.

Sumitra pulled the cot ropes with her hand. They were loose. She tightened them again.

She did not spread bedding on it.

A few days later her sister's five-year-old son came. He was put to sleep in that room. The child found Neelu's old box of glass marbles. Sumitra watched for a moment, then did not take the box from his hand.

In the morning three marbles lay in the courtyard. As she swept, Sumitra set them aside and put them on the shelf.

A house slowly rewrites the meanings of things. The cot that belonged to a son becomes a guest's cot. The bowl that belonged to a child begins measuring spices. The bag that went to school can hold paddy seed.

But not everything changes.

Neelu's white school shirt remained in the upper layer of the trunk. From time to time Sumitra took it out to air. The smell of soap had gone long ago. The mud stain remained as a faint yellow shadow. Whenever she saw the stain her hand wanted to look for soap again, then stopped.

One day she did not wash the shirt. She only spread it in the sun.

No one noticed this small change.

12

By Phagua, people in Pipra talked less about the flood. New crop in the fields. Potholes filled. On the old waterline on the school wall, children began drawing with chalk—boats, fish, the sun.

One day Sumitra went to the school because a paper bearing Neelu's name needed the headmaster's signature. She sat on the veranda. The bell rang. Children came out of their classrooms. So many nine-year-old bodies. The same height, different faces.

She lowered her eyes.

The headmaster signed the paper. The word "missing" was still there. The period required by government rules had not yet been completed.

Sumitra did not fold the paper. She placed it straight in the folder.

On the way back she went behind the school, to the place where the water had run fast on the day of the flood. Now the field was dry. Grass was growing again. The bamboo stake people had planted for the rope was gone.

Sumitra bent to the ground. She found a small rusted clip. Whose, from when—no mark. She picked it up, then threw it far away.

She returned home.

That afternoon she opened the window of Neelu's room fully for the first time. It had remained half closed all winter. Air came in, papers moved, dust rose. She swept. Rearranged the books. Put a tin of dal on an empty shelf.

Raghav saw it in the evening. Said nothing.

13

Before the year was complete, Sawan came again.

On the first night of heavy rain Sumitra woke. Water on the roof. The sound of drains filling. Her body rose before memory did. She checked the paddy sacks. Put the matches up high. Documents into plastic. Tested the torch.

Raghav woke too. Without speaking they began moving things upward. This time there was practice. Fear too.

By morning water had not entered the courtyard. Only rain. The river had risen, but there was no danger.

Sumitra brought the sacks down again. One by one. She left the papers on the shelf where they were.

Neelu's folder too had been in the plastic. She took it out, looked at it, then placed it in a separate trunk.

When the day had risen she sat to wash clothes. Raghav's dhoti, her sari, the small trousers a guest child had left the previous week. At last Neelu's white shirt came into her hands.

She looked at it for a while.

Then did not dip it in the water.

She folded the shirt and put it back in the trunk.

The bar of soap remained in her hand. Sumitra used it to scrub her own sari.

14

One morning in Jeth, news came that many things from the flood had been exposed on a sandbar downstream—clothes, boxes, wood, toys, animal bones, pieces of houses. No one knew exactly whose mouth the news had come from. The moment Sumitra heard, she covered the water lota, took the milk off the stove, and left without eating breakfast.

Raghav had gone to the field. Sumitra left the house key with a neighbour. Walked to the bus. Two kos by bus, then sand.

There truly were things on the bar. Dried in the sun, caked with mud, colours bleached. Someone recognized a door panel. Someone an iron trunk. Someone bedding. Many objects had no owner. The river had gathered things together without genealogy.

Sumitra walked slowly. Her eyes searched colours again—blue, black, white. A child's slipper in one place. Small size. She picked it up. Neelu's slipper had a broken heel strap; this strap was intact. She put it down.

An iron box held three coloured pencils. She opened it, then closed it. A torn book cover. A blue button. A plastic whistle. Each object became a possibility for one moment, then the remnant of someone else's life.

At noon the sun grew harsh. People began searching for shade. Sumitra sat beside an overturned boat. With her foot she scraped away sand. Dampness beneath. After a while she rose and walked again.

By evening she had found nothing.

On the bus home her lap was empty. But sand filled the spaces beneath her fingernails. When she reached home she washed her hands first. The sand would not come out all at once. With the back of a needle she cleaned it slowly.

The next morning she kneaded flour with those same hands.

15

Between rain and flood, one other thing changed in Pipra—the way people watched children.

Before, if children in the lane played near the river, someone would shout from a distance, then return to his own work. After Neelu, whenever Sumitra went toward the ghat, her eyes involuntarily counted the children. Five went, did five return? Four climbed into the boat, did four get down? She tried to stop herself, but the counting happened on its own.

One day two small boys were floating paper boats in a pit left by the flood. The water was knee-deep. There seemed no special danger. Sumitra was returning with vegetables. She went some distance past, then turned back. Moved the boys aside. Pressed the bank of the pit with her foot to test it. The earth was hollow underneath.

She planted two pieces of bamboo so the place could be seen from a distance.

The children watched her. One boy had studied with Neelu. For an instant recognition came into his eyes. Sumitra turned her gaze away.

Before reaching home she told the young man who did sanitation work in the ward about the pit. The next day it was filled with earth.

Sumitra did not mention this work at home. But after that, whenever it rained, she began checking not only the courtyard drain but the mouths of the lane drains too. If a sack was blocking one, she removed it. If a child stood beside fast-running water, she gestured him back.

People said—after the flood Sumitra had become very cautious.

The sentence was half true. Caution is a thing whose result can be seen. Much of what moved inside Sumitra had no result. Waking and sitting upright at the sound of heavy rain in the night; hearing Neelu's voice in some child's cough; having her breath catch at a blue shirt in an unknown crowd—none of these made anyone safer.

Yet when morning came she cleaned the drains.

16

On the day a year was completed, the family performed no fixed ritual. The date itself was disputed—the third day of the flood? The day he disappeared? The day he was recorded missing on paper? How does one observe a death anniversary without a date of death?

Raghav's mother came from the village. An old body, hearing weakened. She wept very little while speaking Neelu's name; mostly she sat looking at

his things. Schoolbag, books, cot. Once she lifted the white shirt, rubbed a finger over the stain, then folded it and put it back in the same place.

In the evening she sat to pick stones from rice. Sumitra beside her. The two women on the same low stool. There were very few stones in the rice, yet the old woman examined each grain carefully.

After a long time she said only, "This stain never went?"

Sumitra shook her head.

That was all.

The next day the old woman returned. As she left, whether she touched the threshold of Neelu's room or merely put her hand there for support, Sumitra could not decide.

That week Raghav came back after speaking with a priest. Some rites could be done, some not; opinions differed. Sumitra listened. She neither objected nor insisted. For her the main question was not ritual correctness. She simply did not want anyone to say after some ceremony—now it is finished.

In the end a small lamp was lit at home. No announcement. Raghav sat silently. Sumitra made kheer in the kitchen and distributed it among neighbourhood children. Whether in Neelu's name or without naming him was not clear either.

One child licked the bowl and came back asking for more. Sumitra filled it a second time.

She put the remaining kheer in the refrigerator at night. In the morning she ate the cold kheer herself. After many months she ate something sweet and tasted it. When taste came, she did not feel guilt. She felt surprise.

The body often begins its work before the mind does.

17

In the next flood season the municipal school held a disaster drill. Children were taught lines, ropes, high ground, the order of boarding boats. Parents too were called.

At first Sumitra did not want to go. Still, she went.

The same veranda. The same classroom. The old waterline on the wall now covered with limewash, though parts still showed through. A new teacher demonstrated how to tie a rope. The children laughed and pushed one another. The trainer repeatedly straightened the line.

Sumitra stood at the edge and watched.

A small girl could not open a knot in the rope. Sumitra stepped forward. Took the rope in her hand. Tied the knot again—not loose, not so tight that it would be hard to open. The girl repeated it. Wrong the first time. Right the second.

Sumitra let go of her hand.

At the end of the drill everyone was told: in a disaster, children and old people first. Keep essential household papers separately. Drinking water separately. Beware of rumours.

Sumitra listened. Some of this was exactly what she had done instinctively on the first night of the flood; some were things that, even had she known them then, no one could say whether the outcome would have changed.

On the way back from the school she did not stop at the field behind. Came straight home.

At home she took out a large plastic bag. Documents, matches, a small torch, two bottles, a tin for dry flattened rice. On top, in thick letters, she wrote: "FLOOD."

She did not put Neelu's folder inside. Left it in a separate trunk.

Necessary things and remembered things are not the same. She did not write down this distinction; she made it only in the order of her hands.

18

After the flood Sumitra began making a list at night. Not on paper. In her mind.

Door closed? Stove out? Cow tied? Torch? Matches? Water? Papers?

Earlier the list would have ended there. Then one question began adding itself—are all the people of the house inside?

She listened for Raghav's breathing. If there was a guest, she checked his place. Sometimes a neighbour's child stayed playing until evening; her eyes followed the path until the child reached his mother.

This habit sometimes irritated the family. Once Raghav returned late and Sumitra went as far as the lane turn three times. When he came back, she took his wet shirt, hung it on the peg, served food. Said nothing.

Raghav understood. From the next day onward, if he was late he began making a short phone call.

Because of these short calls, for the first time after the flood a new rule formed between them. They still spoke little about grief, but they began reporting time. "I'm at the field." "I'm in the market." "Half an hour." These sentences were not declarations of love, yet they reduced the empty boxes in the household's night list.

When Sumitra herself went out, she began telling someone first. Market. Ghat. School. Block office. The woman who once felt no need to account for her own errands now left the name of a place behind. It did not feel like restraint to her, but like a marker—knowing where a person is can sometimes be very small and very necessary knowledge.

One evening she herself was late. On the way back from the market she saw an accident; a crowd. When she reached home, Raghav stood at the door. For the first time Sumitra saw in his eyes the same unease she carried within herself day and night.

She came inside. Put down the vegetable bag.

"I'm late," she said, only that.

Raghav nodded.

Then Sumitra went to wash her hands and face.

Very slowly, some of Neelu's clothes began serving other household purposes.

A torn vest became a wiping rag. The small gamchha dried utensils. An old pair of trousers was given to a poor child in the neighbourhood. Before giving them away, Sumitra checked the pockets. Inside were a dry peepal leaf, half a pencil shaving, and a two-rupee coin.

She kept the coin aside. The leaf broke in her hand. The shaving flew away with the dust. She washed the trousers and spread them in the sun, did not iron them. The next day the child's mother took them.

From the window Sumitra saw—the trousers were a little long on the child. His mother folded the cuffs. The child ran. The cloth began moving again with a body.

Sumitra did not cry at the sight. Something inside her tightened, then loosened.

She did not give away the white school shirt. She kept it outside use.

There was no rule for how many things could be given away and how many could not. Sumitra's decisions changed from day to day. One day she thought of giving Neelu's books to the school library; the next she arranged them again on the shelf. She gave one toy to a neighbour's child, wanted to ask for it back that night, but did not.

Perhaps being a mother now lived in these small decisions. The child was absent, but the hands of motherhood did not become absent at once. She still measured—which child would fit this garment, who would read this book, where should this bowl be kept. The direction of the work had changed; the work had not ended.

One day she spread the white shirt in the sun again. The stain was the same. Sumitra watched from a distance. Wind filled the shirt's empty sleeves, then flattened them. For an instant its shape resembled a body; the next instant it was only cloth.

Sumitra did not go forward to straighten the sleeves. The wind continued its own work.

Neelu was not found.

This sentence slowly took different forms inside the family. On paper: "missing." In people's speech: "went in the flood." In Raghav's silence: a place without a name. In Sumitra's work: one fewer bowl, one garment kept apart, one window opened wider, haste to move things upward as soon as rain began.

One day someone asked, "Have you accepted it now?"

Sumitra did not answer. She could not quite understand what "accept" meant in the question. Accept what—that the child would not return? That the body would not be found? That the search was over? That memory was fixed? That life went on? These questions did not have one answer.

That day she had put dal on the stove. It rose to a boil. She skimmed off the foam with the ladle. Lowered the flame. Lifted the lid of the rice. There was a little too much water; she left the lid half open.

The woman who had asked the question sat for a while, then left.

Sumitra served the meal. Two plates.

At night the rain stopped. The electricity was out. She brought out the lantern—the same one she had prepared on the first night of the flood. The wick had grown very old. She cut a new wick from cloth, filled oil, lit it.

The light was small, but it had not been given the task of removing all the darkness from the room. Its work was only to show whatever lay within the reach of its glow—the flood line on the wall, books on the shelf, the cot ropes, the closed trunk, the black smoke marks of the stove, Raghav's tired face.

Sumitra carried the lantern into the courtyard. Rainwater moved slowly through the drain. The river was far away, but in the dampness of the night its smell perhaps reached even here—or perhaps it was only memory.

She set the lantern down, bent, and pulled a leaf caught in the drain. The water began moving again.

Then she came inside, closed the door, and measured out rice for the morning.

— *End of Story 42* —

43. The Ghost

STORY

I

In Pipra, the time of the last night bus was determined less by the clock than by habit. When half the market shutters had come down, the sweet-shop cauldron had been washed, and the tea seller had raked the ashes from his stove for the second time, the rickshaw-puller Jagdish knew that perhaps one or two more fares might appear; otherwise it was time to go home.

That night the mist was not very thick, but the air was damp. Moisture drifting in from the Kamla had begun to settle on the iron handlebar. Three rickshaws remained at the bus stand. Two drivers had already left. Jagdish was sitting backward on his seat, stretching his legs, when a woman approached from the direction of the post-office turn.

Her age was not easy to guess at once. A deep-grey end of her sari covered her head; she wore a plain cotton sari and carried no bundle. Coming up to the rickshaw, she asked, "Will you go to the old temple?"

Jagdish looked up. "At this hour?"

"Yes."

The old temple was not very far from the market, but few passengers took that road at night. By day, the square in front of the temple was filled with little stalls selling flowers, bet leaves, oil, and offerings; after ten at night everything closed. In people's talk, the pond behind the temple and the darkness of the peepal tree made the place seem farther away than it was.

Jagdish did not ask the fare. The woman sat on the rear seat. The rickshaw moved. He had an old habit: once a passenger sat down, his body knew by itself how much weight lay behind him. This woman's weight was ordinary. On the incline he felt the same pull in his thighs that he felt with any other passenger. Later, Jagdish would remember that single fact many times.

2

As soon as they passed the post office, the woman said, "Not to the right. Take the road by the pond."

"That road is muddy."

"Even so."

Without another question, Jagdish turned. The rickshaw's small front lamp cast light only two or three arm-lengths ahead through mud and grass.

Beyond that little pool of brightness, he followed the road by judgment. Sometimes a wheel sank into a hollow, sometimes it crackled over dry leaves.

When the first shadow of the peepal fell across the road, the temple roof emerged in the darkness. The outer iron gate was shut, but beside it an open strip of stone led up to the steps. Jagdish stopped the rickshaw.

The woman got down. "Up to the third step."

Jagdish did not understand. "The rickshaw stops here."

"Yes. I am going up to the third step."

She climbed the first step, then the second. The right corner of the third step had been broken long ago into a triangular edge. She stood there for a moment. Jagdish heard the loose chain of the rickshaw and bent down. It had not slipped; it was merely rubbing against the guard. He put his hand to it and straightened it.

Five or seven moments later he raised his head. The steps were empty.

The gate was shut. To the right stood the peepal, to the left the pond. A narrow path ran behind the temple wall, but dry thorn branches bent across it. Jagdish called out, "Mother?"

No answer came.

He got down from the rickshaw and went up to the third step. The inner courtyard was dark. The chain hung from the gate. The pond water could not be seen; only frogs could be heard.

Jagdish did not remain there long. What he needed that night was his last fare, not a mystery. He turned the rickshaw and started home. Halfway there, he remembered: the woman had not paid him.

3

When he reached home, Tara opened the door. She was Jagdish's wife. First she took the bag hanging from the rickshaw handle, then asked, "Why so late?"

"A passenger to the temple."

"At this hour?"

"Yes."

Jagdish said no more. The words—the woman disappeared—rose to his mouth, but he stopped them. It was not his nature to turn at once into a story something he himself did not fully understand.

In the morning, while taking the rickshaw out, he found a folded twenty-rupee note between the seat and the rear bar. The note was neither wet nor torn. Perhaps it belonged to an earlier passenger. Perhaps to that woman. Jagdish put it in his pocket, but in his little account book, on the final line for the previous night, he wrote: "Old Temple—20."

He had long been in the habit of writing the destination beside each fare. Market—15. Hospital—25. Station Turn—20. During floods there might even be "Relief Camp—0." How much money had come in and how much had not: by day's end this notebook was more trustworthy than his memory.

Once “Old Temple—20” was written down, the incident looked ordinary. Whatever could fit into a line of an account book circled less insistently in the mind through the day.

4

On the sixth night, the same woman appeared again.

This time not at the bus stand. Jagdish had dropped a passenger near the hospital and was returning. It was around half past ten. At the turn toward the nurses’ quarters the woman stood by the roadside. The same grey head-covering. Empty hands.

Jagdish’s feet slowed of their own accord.

“Old temple?” the woman asked.

Before answering, Jagdish wanted to see her face. It was not a face that lodged immediately in memory—neither very old nor young, neither especially beautiful nor ugly. Her eyes were clear, yet it seemed as though the light could not quite hold them.

“Come,” Jagdish said.

This time he deliberately took the main road. The woman did not object. They passed the shuttered shops, the police-station turn, the wall of the oil mill. The rickshaw bell rang once by itself; there was a pothole in the road. Jagdish did not look back.

When they reached the temple, the woman said nothing about the third step. She got down on her own and moved toward the steps. Jagdish did not turn the rickshaw around. He remained seated and watched.

First step. Second. Third.

At that moment a motorcycle came from the pond road. Its bright headlamp struck Jagdish’s eyes. He blinked and raised a hand to shield them. The motorcycle passed.

The steps were empty again.

Jagdish did not immediately run after her. He remained seated, hearing his heart thud in his chest. After a while he got down. He went to the gate. The same chain. The thorn branches beside the path seemed a little more pressed down this time—or perhaps they had always been like that. He could not be certain.

Then he touched the broken corner of the third step. The stone was cold with the night’s dampness.

5

The next morning Jagdish went to Shivanath, the temple attendant. Shivanath was a lean man somewhere between fifty-five and sixty, who by day cleared away flowers, swept the courtyard, checked the oil in the lamps, and opened and closed the gate.

In an ordinary tone Jagdish asked, “Does anyone go inside at night?”

Shivanath stopped sweeping and looked at him. “Why?”

“I dropped a passenger there. Twice.”

“The gate closes at eight.”

“The side path?”

Shivanath looked toward the peepal. “There is a path behind the wall leading to the pond. It can be used, though there are thorns at night. Someone who knows it could get through.”

At that answer Jagdish’s body relaxed a little.

Then Shivanath himself asked, “Was it a woman?”

Jagdish said nothing.

Shivanath resumed sweeping. “Let a night matter remain in the night. By daylight people give it too many names.”

Jagdish had not expected such an answer. He wanted to ask, What do you know? But Shivanath’s back was already turned toward him.

He left. On the road, he felt that he had found a reasonable answer—the side path. Then at once he remembered that on the first night the dry thorn branches had not been bent down. Or had he simply not seen properly? How much can one see correctly in the small beam of a night lamp?

6

Whether the story escaped from Jagdish himself or from one sentence of Shivanath’s, he could never later determine. Within three days it had begun circulating at the tea shop.

“Jagdish carries the temple woman at night.”

“What woman?”

“The one who disappears on the steps.”

Thus, passing from one mouth to another, the sentence became a story. Someone said a newly married woman had drowned in the pond twenty years earlier. Someone else said that tale belonged not to this temple but to a place five kos away. Someone gave her the name “Gauri.” At that, Kaushalya Kaki, who made the tea, scolded them: “Gauri is alive. She is in Biratnagar playing with her grandson.”

Everyone laughed.

Jagdish did not. Nor was he angry. His difficulty was that people were describing with greater confidence than he possessed someone they had never seen.

A young man asked, “What was her face like?”

Jagdish said, “Like a human face.”

“White sari?”

“No.”

“Feet turned backward?”

Jagdish got up and left.

After that he did not speak of the matter at the tea shop.

7

The matter did not remain hidden from Tara. A village story takes little time to reach home. That night, while serving the meal, she asked, "Truly, twice?"

Jagdish said, "Twice a passenger sat in my rickshaw. She got down at the temple. After that I did not see her."

"Disappeared?"

"That word belongs to other people. I only did not see her."

Tara stirred the spoon in the dal for a while. "The fare?"

"The first time I found a note. The second time..." Jagdish stopped.

He took out the account book. On the line for the second night was written: "Old Temple—20."

Jagdish scratched his head. "I don't remember writing it."

Tara turned the notebook over and back. The handwriting was Jagdish's. She made no miracle out of it. She merely said, "You must have been tired."

"Possible."

"If she comes again, take the fare first," Tara said.

Jagdish burst out laughing. It was the first laughter amid the fear. Tara did not laugh. "Then the accounts will stay clear."

That night Jagdish did not put the notebook beneath his pillow; he returned it to its usual place in the box. He did not like making objects extraordinary.

8

The third time, the woman came eleven days later. That night the mist was thick. Jagdish was drinking the last tea in the market. The other rickshaws had already gone home. As he set down the glass, he saw the woman standing across the road.

He glanced at the tea seller. The man was busy washing earthen cups. Jagdish felt like asking, "Do you see that woman?" but did not.

The woman sat in the rickshaw.

Jagdish said, "Twenty rupees in advance."

A faint smile came to the woman's face. From the end of her sari she took out not coins but a folded twenty-rupee note and handed it to him. An ordinary note. Jagdish examined it under the lamp and put it in his pocket.

For the first time, he himself began the conversation on the way. "How do you get inside the temple?"

"Do I go inside?"

"I cannot see you afterward."

"Are not being seen and not being the same thing?"

Jagdish fell silent. He disliked the question because it sounded like an answer while not actually being one.

After some distance he asked, "Your name?"

The woman said, "If I tell you a name, you will begin looking for the name. Watch the road."

"I watch the road every day."

“Then all is well.”

This time Jagdish thought of stopping the rickshaw a hundred yards before the temple, but his feet went on pedalling of their own accord. They reached the third step. The woman got down.

She stood on the third step and looked back once. Jagdish saw clearly—there was no fear on her face, no haste. Then she went upward.

This time Jagdish did not take his eyes away. He watched her through the first five steps. At the sixth, a thick branch of the peepal and a temple pillar hid her for one moment. The next moment the path was empty.

Whether that was enough time to reach the side path, Jagdish could not measure. The hand of his watch had not been made for moments like these.

9

The next day, in daylight, Jagdish examined the whole rear side of the temple.

From the third step to the fifth, from the fifth to the pillar, from the pillar into the narrow side path. A person truly could use the pillar as cover and reach behind the wall in two or three quick strides. Thorns stood in the way, but there was also a narrow trace of footsteps on the ground. Temple attendants, flower sellers, pond cleaners—someone must have used it.

Jagdish walked it himself. From behind the pillar, reaching the back of the wall was not difficult.

He ought to have felt relieved.

But from behind the pillar he noticed something else: the narrow path ended at a wire fence by the pond. One part of the fence was bent; a thin person could squeeze through. Beyond that lay open ground. If someone had gone there in the night mist, she could disappear from sight at once.

That was all.

Jagdish walked the path three times in daylight. By the third time his own activity seemed ridiculous to him. He picked up the rickshaw and went to the market.

In the evening he carried an ordinary passenger to the settlement behind the temple. The man got down near the fifth step and, using the pillar as cover, took that same narrow path. Jagdish watched his back for a few moments.

He went home and told Tara, “There is a path.”

Tara asked, “So?”

Jagdish had no answer to the “so.” Finding the path could have made the woman’s story simpler; whether it actually had, his mind could not decide.

10

The fourth time the woman came, some winter cold remained after Saraswati Puja. The night was chilly, the mist light. Jagdish was returning after dropping an elderly passenger near Station Turn.

The woman stood not in the road but beneath the awning of a closed medicine shop.

"Not tonight," Jagdish said without intending to.

The woman said nothing.

Jagdish pedalled two strokes forward, then stopped. Whether his refusal came from fear or stubbornness, he himself could not tell. Tara would be waiting at home. His earnings for the day were enough. There was no need to take the temple road.

He looked back. The woman was still there.

"How many times do you go?" Jagdish asked.

"As many times as I find the road."

"To whom?"

"To whom do you carry passengers?"

"Wherever they tell me."

"Then come."

Annoyed with himself, Jagdish nevertheless turned the rickshaw around.

This time they were both silent all the way. As they approached the temple, a single bell sounded in the distance. The gate remained closed at night; wind could move a bell. Jagdish deliberately fixed his attention on that explanation.

The woman got down. She placed her foot on the third step.

Jagdish asked, "Do you frighten me?"

The woman turned. "Are you afraid?"

After thinking a little, Jagdish said, "For someone who has to work at night, fear travels alongside him. Otherwise the eyes grow careless."

For the first time the woman smiled openly—or perhaps only the light changed; Jagdish could not be certain. "Then keep it with you."

She went upward. Behind the pillar. Empty steps.

This time Jagdish ran toward the side path. When he reached behind the wall, there was only mist. The bent part of the fence was still. There were no footprints in the open ground. The earth was dry, unlikely to hold marks.

He stood in the darkness for a long time. Then anger rose in him at himself—since when had following a passenger become his work?

II

People's curiosity had grown by then. One night three young men planned to follow Jagdish's rickshaw on a motorcycle. "We'll see where the ghost goes."

Jagdish refused plainly. "I will not make a spectacle."

"Afraid?"

"Following a passenger is not decent work."

The young men laughed. One said, "A ghost's privacy?"

Jagdish lifted the rickshaw and left.

The woman did not come that night. Nor on the next three nights. The young men's laughter faded.

A week later Shivanath, the temple attendant, stopped Jagdish in the market. "People come at night and shake the gate. They take photographs on the steps with their phones. Get this stopped."

"How can I?"

"The story travels under your name."

Regret stirred in Jagdish. He had never called anyone a ghost, yet the story had climbed into his rickshaw and was travelling around the town.

The next day, at the tea shop, he spoke loudly for the first time: "I say only what I saw. A woman sat in my rickshaw as a passenger and got down at the temple. After that I did not see her. Who inserted the word 'ghost' between those facts, I do not know."

Kaushalya Kaki, straining tea, said, "People cannot bear an empty space. They fill it with a name."

No one answered.

A few days later, the nightly spectacle at the temple died down on its own. Another topic came to Pipra. The memory of a market is like its livelihood—one subject does not last very long.

12

The fifth time came many months later, on one of the nights just before the rains began. The air was hot; lightning flickered far away, but no rain had yet fallen.

Jagdish had already turned his rickshaw toward home. The woman was standing in front of the old post office.

This time she held a small object that gleamed like brass. A lamp or a bowl, Jagdish could not make out from a distance. He stopped.

The woman sat down.

No talk of fare, no name.

Halfway there lightning flashed. For one instant the shadow behind the rickshaw stretched huge across the road. Jagdish thought he saw two shadows—or perhaps the wheel and his own body had combined into a shape. The moment passed. He did not look back.

Fifty arm-lengths before the temple, the woman said, "Stop here."

"Not the third step?"

"Today I will walk."

She got down. This time Jagdish did not ask for the fare. The woman extended the small object in her hand toward him.

It was a small brass lamp, unlit. It smelled of oil.

"You keep this," Jagdish said.

"Not keep it. Deliver it."

"Where?"

The woman did not answer. She took the lamp back into her hand and walked toward the steps.

Jagdish remained with the rickshaw stopped. First step, second, third. This time she did not stop on the third. She went straight up. Behind the pillar.

Darkness.

A few moments later a tiny light appeared inside the locked gate. Very small. As though someone had placed a lamp beneath the threshold.

A shiver passed through Jagdish. He did not go as far as the gate. He watched from a distance. The light was not steady; it trembled though there was no wind—or perhaps distance made it seem so.

Then the first drop fell. One, two, and then hard rain. Jagdish pulled plastic over the rickshaw seat. When he looked toward the temple again, the light was gone.

13

In the morning Jagdish went to Shivanath. The night's rain had washed the steps. A little water had collected in the triangular break of the third step. The gate was locked with the same chain.

"Was a lamp burning last night?" Jagdish asked.

Shivanath stopped while taking out the key. "I had put out the evening lamps. There was little oil left."

"Anyone inside?"

"The key was with me."

The gate was opened. Near the inner threshold stood a small brass lamp. Shivanath picked it up.

"This is not mine," he said.

Jagdish's mouth went dry.

Shivanath turned the lamp in his hands. "A dozen lamps like this can be found in the market."

"Last night, a woman..."

Jagdish did not finish the sentence.

Shivanath asked no question either. Very little oil remained inside the lamp. The wick had burned. Rainwater had not entered it.

"Could someone have placed it over the top of the gate?" Jagdish asked.

Shivanath looked at the height of the gate. "Perhaps, if the arm were long enough. Or it may have been left there in the daytime and I did not see it."

Both possibilities were ordinary. Neither was a complete answer.

Shivanath put the lamp in a corner of the temple. "Whoever owns it will take it."

For three months no one did. After that Jagdish stopped asking.

14

The woman never came again.

At least, not in Jagdish's rickshaw.

Sometimes, at night, the sight of a grey-covered head made his feet slow, but when he came closer it would be some other woman—a hospital attendant, a market shopkeeper's wife, an old woman who had just stepped off a bus. Ordinary passengers. Ordinary places.

The story of the old temple never completely ended in Pipra. Where does any people's story end? New children told the old matter with new details. Someone said Jagdish had carried the ghost every night for five years. Someone said the rickshaw travelled to the temple by itself, without a driver. Hearing such things now, Jagdish merely shook his head.

Once a young man from outside came looking for him. Taking out his phone, he asked, "Can you say for certain that she was a ghost?"

Jagdish was pumping air into a rickshaw tyre. He stopped the pump.

"I can say only this for certain: she sat in my rickshaw. She had weight. She spoke. She got down near the temple. After that I did not see her."

"So—a ghost?"

"How can I give a name to what I did not see?"

The young man was disappointed. His video needed a clear answer. He left.

That night, after finishing work, Jagdish took the old-temple road home. It was shorter. The peepal leaves sounded in the wind. The temple was closed. The broken corner of the third step was unchanged.

The rickshaw's front lamp threw light as far as that step. Above it lay darkness. Jagdish did not stop.

He had understood by then: light is not meant to abolish all darkness. Where its brightness falls, what is there becomes visible. What remains beyond it does not need to be named at once.

The rickshaw wheels slowly cut through the night road toward home.

— *End of Story 43* —

44. Master Sahib

STORY

I

When the first bell rang on Master Sahib's final day at Pipra High School, the boy ringing it himself forgot how many strokes there were supposed to be that day.

The first time he struck it five times. Then someone shouted from the veranda, "Seven!"

The boy gave it two more strokes.

From inside his room Master Sahib called out, "Where in the school rules is seven strokes written?"

Laughter rose in the veranda. The boy let go of the bell rope. His face wore the expression of someone caught by Master Sahib even on the very last day.

Master Sahib's name was Jagannath Mishra, but in forty years no one at the school had called him Jagannath Babu. To students he was Master Sahib, to teachers Master Sahib, to the peon Master Sahib, and at home even his wife Shakuntala sometimes called him "Master Sahib" when angry.

Three things on his desk that day were unusual—a flower garland, a shining box containing a pen, and something wrapped in red cloth.

Jagannath Babu looked at the garland, then opened the register.

"Attendance even today?" assistant teacher Nirmal asked.

"Is the school closed?"

"No."

"Then?"

Nirmal laughed. "Today is your last day."

"Service ends. Routine does not."

The moment he said this, two old students standing in the veranda looked at each other. The same old glint of fear shone in both their eyes.

2

Jagannath Babu's class began on time. The ninth-standard students were unusually quiet. On an ordinary day, the first five minutes would have gone into silencing them, but today they were quiet already.

He wrote on the blackboard: "Sentence."

Someone whispered from the back, "Grammar today?"

Master Sahib turned. "Does language become free upon retirement?"

The class burst out laughing.

He said, "If a sentence is not clear, the fault is not the words' but the speaker's. This is more useful in life than in grammar."

Then he stopped himself. He realized the sentence had begun to sound like a speech. He immediately opened the book.

"Page fifty-eight."

Every book opened. A girl raised her hand.

"What?"

"Sir, in our book page fifty-eight has a poem."

Master Sahib looked at his own copy. An old edition. The children had the new one.

The class laughed again.

For the first time, without giving any explanation, Jagannath Babu said, "All right. My mistake."

Manish, sitting at the back, nudged his friend. "Write down this date. Master Sahib admitted a mistake."

"I can hear you," Master Sahib said.

This time the laughter grew louder.

3

After the second bell, old students began arriving at the school gate. Some were shopkeepers, some panchayat employees, some bus drivers, some had returned from elsewhere on leave. Some brought their own children.

Everyone had a story about Master Sahib.

Ramvilas said, "In seventh standard he made me stand for a whole hour."

"Why?"

"I hadn't memorized the poem."

From a distance Master Sahib heard and said, "Not the poem. You had torn another boy's notebook."

Ramvilas stopped. "You remember even after so many years?"

"Tearing a notebook is different from forgetting a poem."

Another student, Harinandan, said, "I was caned twice."

Jagannath Babu looked at him. "You were caned? I don't remember."

"See! The offender forgets; the victim remembers."

Everyone laughed.

Master Sahib too smiled a little. "Then should I apologize today?"

Harinandan had not expected such a quick answer. His laughter stopped for a moment. Then he said, "No, no, I was joking."

Master Sahib said, "Even something said in jest sometimes asks for an accounting."

The laughter in the veranda softened.

4

Whether Jagannath Babu had truly used the cane a great deal, or whether the cane had simply grown large in people's memory, was not clear even to him. A thin old bamboo cane still lay in his desk drawer. He had not struck anyone with it in the last ten years. Perhaps the last fifteen.

He took the cane out and looked at it. The bamboo had dried yellow. Near the handle, the old worn mark of his thumb was still visible.

Nirmal came in. "Will this go to the museum too?"

"To the rubbish bin."

"People will take photographs with it."

"Then throw it away even faster."

Nirmal took the cane in his hand. "You know, the story of this cane will live in the school longer than you."

Jagannath Babu said, "A story is not the same as truth."

"But sometimes it lasts longer than truth."

Hearing this, Jagannath Babu looked at Nirmal. "Is that your sentence?"

"I learned it in your class."

"I never taught such a sentence."

"Not the words. The method."

Jagannath Babu put the cane back in the drawer. The matter never reached the rubbish bin.

5

By noon, according to plan, the farewell meeting was to be held. A stage had been set up in the school courtyard. Plastic chairs stood in front. In the middle was a red chair—for the guest of honour.

Jagannath Babu saw it from a distance and said at once, "Remove that red chair."

The headmaster laughed. "Why?"

"I am not a king."

"You are the chief guest."

"Chief guest at my own farewell?"

"Then what should we call you?"

"A retiring employee."

The headmaster shook his head. "Even on your last day you will correct every word."

The red chair was not removed. In the end Jagannath Babu sat on an ordinary blue chair beside it. The red chair remained empty.

The students kept laughing about it. Someone took a photograph.

By evening, the photograph of the empty red chair in Pipra had reached many phones.

6

When the meeting began, the first speaker was Mohan, the school's oldest peon. He opened a sheet of paper, then began looking for his spectacles. They were on his head. The students laughed. Mohan laughed too.

"I don't know how to give speeches," he said, "but Master Sahib knows time. Nine means nine. If dismissal was five minutes late, I was scolded too."

A voice came from the back: "And five minutes early?"

Mohan said, "Then an even bigger scolding."

Everyone laughed.

The second speaker was Ramvilas. Taking the microphone, he said, "Master Sahib made me stand for an hour because of a poem..."

The courtyard erupted.

Without a microphone Jagannath Babu called out, "You had torn a notebook!"

Another roar of laughter.

Ramvilas folded his hands. "See, he corrected me even today."

Then his voice changed. "I felt deeply humiliated that day. I went home and told my father I would leave school. Father sent me back. Now I think—Master Sahib made me stand, but I never remembered the name of the boy whose notebook I tore. His humiliation was greater than mine. I understood that many years later."

Jagannath Babu lowered his eyes.

7

The third speaker was a woman—Savita. She worked as a nurse at Pipra Primary Health Centre. As a student she had spoken very little. Even now, after coming to the stage, she first stood a little away from the microphone.

"Master Sahib did not teach me mathematics," she said. "He taught language. But the biggest mathematical problem of my life was the one I gave him."

Everyone fell silent.

"After class ten, my family planned to stop my studies. I wrote an application and gave it to Master Sahib: 'Come to my house and speak to my father.'"

Jagannath Babu raised his head. He remembered the incident.

Savita said, "He came to the house. Father served him tea. Master Sahib said, 'A daughter's education is neither charity nor investment; it is her right.' Father became very angry. For three days Master Sahib's name was used in our house as an abuse. On the fourth day, my admission was completed."

The courtyard was silent.

Savita smiled. "But the story is not only this. Later my younger brother left his studies and took up a shop. Then Master Sahib told me, 'Along with a right, ask about desire too. Every child will not walk the same road.' I was angry with him then. To me, leaving studies looked like defeat. Today my brother's shop supports three families."

She lowered the microphone. "I remember two things Master Sahib told me, and they do not fully agree with each other. Perhaps that is precisely why I remember them."

A faint brightness came into Jagannath Babu's eyes.

8

In the middle of the meeting, a boy was found crying behind the stage. Neeraj, in sixth standard. He had been supposed to recite a poem, but had forgotten a line.

Jagannath Babu saw him.

"Why are you crying?"

The boy wiped his nose. "I forgot."

"The poem?"

"Yes."

"Where is the paper?"

"Masterji said it had to be memorized."

Jagannath Babu looked at him for a moment. He felt both amusement and embarrassment at how many of his old sentences still lived in other teachers' mouths.

He said, "Take the paper and read."

Neeraj looked surprised. "But..."

"A poem being written on paper is not a crime."

The boy ran off.

Standing behind the stage, Jagannath Babu remembered his own student days. Once his Sanskrit teacher had twisted his ear so hard for forgetting an entire shloka that it hurt for two days. The incident was still clear to him. The teacher's face was blurred; the pain in the ear was clear.

Suddenly he understood: a student sometimes remembers a teacher's unnecessary wound more vividly than the teacher's teaching.

9

Neeraj returned with the paper and read the poem. He stumbled twice. One word was wrong—Jagannath Babu's mind rose at once to correct it. He opened his lips, then closed them.

The poem ended. Applause came.

Neeraj stepped down from the stage and came straight to him. "I got one word wrong, didn't I?"

Master Sahib asked, "Did you realize it?"

"Yes."

"Then correct it next time."

The boy went away.

The farewell programme also included a short performance by the students. Jagannath Babu had not been told about it. Five children came onto the stage. One boy wore a false moustache, held a thin bamboo stick, and tilted his head slightly. The moment he entered he said, "Open your notebooks. Page fifty-eight."

The whole courtyard filled with laughter. Jagannath Babu understood at once—they were imitating him.

The fake master asked the first boy, "Homework?" The boy folded his hands. "Not done." The fake master raised the cane, then read a slip posted on the stage: "Beating prohibited." He lowered the cane and said, "Then write five times: I will improve from tomorrow."

The second boy stood up and said, "Sir, tomorrow was a holiday."

The fake master froze for a moment, then said, "Then improve from today."

The children bent over laughing. So did the teachers. Jagannath Babu sat upright at first. He saw his own gait, his way of knitting his brows, the way he held chalk—all appearing in another body. The imitation was exaggerated, but not entirely unfamiliar.

At the end of the skit, the fake master scolded all the children together: "School is not a place for laughing!" and the children laughed loudly on stage.

Applause broke out. Jagannath Babu laughed too.

But beneath the laughter he felt a small unease. What had seemed to him merely discipline had become, in the children's memory, a particular voice, gait, and posture of fear. He could not decide whether there was more affection or revenge in the imitation. Possibly both.

After the skit the boy with the false moustache ran to him. "Sir, you didn't mind, did you?"

"No."

"Did I speak properly like you?"

Jagannath Babu straightened the crooked corner of the boy's moustache. "Do I speak so much through my nose?"

The boy laughed. "A little."

"Then you need more practice."

This time Jagannath Babu laughed first.

11

After the skit, a thin old man came near the stage. His name was Ramcharit Yadav. He had been among the school's very early students, from one of the first batches of Jagannath Babu's service.

"Master Sahib, I remember you sent me out of the class because I had not drawn a map."

Jagannath Babu frowned. "A map? I taught language."

"In seventh you taught geography too."

"For one year?"

"Yes. The map of the Kamla river."

In Jagannath Babu's memory an old classroom suddenly opened—Bihar's map on the wall, a rainy day, chalk breaking. But whether Ramcharit had stood outside or some other boy—he could not clearly tell.

Ramcharit continued, "I had drawn the river backward. You said, 'A river is not a line in a book. Understand the slope of the land.'"

Jagannath Babu said slowly, "That sentence could have been mine."

"And sending me outside?"

"That I don't remember."

Ramcharit laughed. "I remember it very well."

His contemporary Shyamnarayan, standing nearby, immediately said, "Oh, it wasn't Jagannath Master who sent you out; it was Ganesh Master! Jagannath Babu was on leave that day."

Ramcharit's face changed. "No, it was Master Sahib."

Shyamnarayan insisted, "I sat beside you. Ganesh Master's left eye used to twitch. I remember clearly."

Three old men—two students and one teacher—stood holding different memories of one rainy day. People around them were laughing, but Jagannath Babu found the matter interesting.

"Was the map backward?" he asked.

Ramcharit said at once, "That much is certain."

Shyamnarayan too: "Certain."

Jagannath Babu said, "Then at least the river's direction survived."

Everyone laughed. As he left, Ramcharit said, "Whoever did the scolding, your name has attached itself to it. What can I do now?"

Jagannath Babu answered, "Write only that memory sometimes marks attendance for the wrong teacher."

Nirmal whispered from the side, "You are changing."

"Evidence from the final day is not admissible proof of change."

"Why?"

"The sample is too small."

Nirmal laughed.

12

Near the end of the meeting, the headmaster unwrapped the object covered in red cloth. Inside was a wall clock. Golden rim, white face, large numerals. On a small plaque below was written: "Jagannath Mishra, Forty Years of Dedicated Service."

The courtyard filled with applause.

Jagannath Babu took the clock in his hands. The second hand was moving.

"A clock?" he said softly.

The headmaster laughed. "You are so exact about time, we thought a clock would be appropriate."

"What will I do with time after retirement?"

A student called from the back, "Measure it!"

Another: "Scold it!"

A third: "Ring the bell!"

Laughter rose again.

Jagannath Babu kept looking at the clock hands. It seemed to him that for forty years school time had been divided into bells, periods, examinations, attendance, dismissal, results, admission, and the date of retirement. For the first time the question felt real: at what hour would the time of home begin?

13

It was his turn to speak. Everyone expected Master Sahib to give a long speech. The students readied their phones.

Jagannath Babu went to the microphone. He carried no paper.

"I have been asked to say something," he began. "I taught for forty years. In that much time I said many things. Many may have been right; many may also have been wrong. I do not remember them all."

The courtyard fell silent.

"Many of you tell stories about me. Some incidents I remember, some I do not. I cannot say that what I do not remember did not happen."

The faces of the old students changed.

"A teacher has one advantage—every day he sees the faces of many children. A child does not have that advantage; one teacher may remain in his memory for a very long time. I understood this imbalance very late."

He paused.

"If I gave anyone an unnecessary wound, humiliated someone, or failed to listen when I should have listened, that account cannot be closed simply with the word 'discipline.'"

A breeze came. Papers on the stage fluttered.

"And if I managed to teach anything useful, that is not mine alone. Books, colleagues, homes, students—all have a share in it."

Then he lowered the microphone.

The headmaster gestured. "That's all?"

"That's all."

For a moment the students seemed uncertain. Then applause began.

14

After the farewell there was a meal. Jagannath Babu took a plate and stood in the queue. The organizers called him to the front.

"No. The queue."

"Not today."

"If the queue changes today, when will a rule do its work?"

An old student standing behind him whispered, "This is why it will be difficult for Master Sahib to survive at home."

Shakuntala, seated a little distance away with the women teachers, heard him. She said, "At home, I make the rules."

Everyone burst out laughing. Jagannath Babu did too.

After the meal the students began taking photographs. One group said, "Sir, smile a little."

He smiled.

"More."

"This much is sufficient."

"Sir, your hand like this." One young man wanted him to make a victory sign.

"Have I won an election?"

In the final photograph everyone was laughing, with Master Sahib in the middle wearing half a smile.

15

Before evening, the school began to empty. Decoration paper was being taken down. The microphone man coiled his wires. The red chair was loaded onto a truck.

Jagannath Babu entered his room. The desk was clear. He opened the drawer. The old cane, two pieces of chalk, one stamp, three pins, a worn eraser, and five old student applications that had never been placed in any file.

He opened the applications. One requested a fee waiver. One asked leave for a sports competition. One requested postponement of an examination because the student's father was ill. On one sheet were only four lines: "Master Sahib, I do not want to leave my studies. At home they say I should work in the field. Please speak to my father."

Name—Budhan Paswan.

Jagannath Babu looked at the paper for a long time.

Budhan's face did not come to him immediately. Then, slowly, the outline of a thin adolescent appeared. He had left school after class eight. Had Jagannath Babu gone to his house or not? He could not be certain.

Why had he never put the application in a file? How had the paper survived in the drawer?

Five papers amid forty years. One name among five papers. How many lives behind one name.

For the first time the school records seemed painfully small to him. An attendance register tells who came. It does not tell why someone did not.

16

Mohan came in. "Master Sahib, shall we go? I have to close the gate."

Jagannath Babu showed him Budhan's paper. "Do you remember this boy?"

Mohan narrowed his eyes. "Budhan? Yes. Later he went to Punjab. I hear he has returned to Pipra and does small machine work now. Across the river."

"Did I go to his house?"

Mohan shrugged. "So many years ago. Perhaps you did. You used to visit many homes."

"I don't remember."

"Can anyone remember everything?"

Jagannath Babu did not answer.

He put the paper into his bag. The other four as well.

Mohan asked, "The cane?"

Jagannath Babu looked toward the drawer. "Let it stay there."

"The new master will see it."

"Let him."

"Shall I throw it away?"

Jagannath Babu thought for a moment. "No. But don't hang it on the wall."

Mohan laughed. "If you give this many instructions, how will retirement happen?"

Jagannath Babu closed the drawer. "You are right."

17

As he walked out of the school, the gate seemed unusually large. For forty years he had entered through it—sometimes on a bicycle, sometimes on foot, and in recent years on a motorcycle. Today, for the first time, walking out felt like an event.

Three children stood by the gate. They had not been at the farewell; they had been playing near the market. One boy asked, "Master Sahib, now you won't come to school?"

"My work is finished."

"Never?"

"Sometimes."

"Then will you still be Master Sahib or not?"

At the question Jagannath Babu stopped.

One can retire from the post of teacher. How does one retire from an address?

He said, "Whatever you call me."

The boy immediately said, "Master Sahib."

All three ran away.

18

When he reached home, Shakuntala was looking for a place on the wall for the clock.

"In the sitting room?"

Jagannath Babu said, "Put it opposite the kitchen. You can see the time."

"I am used to asking you the time."

"Now my clock will not ring the school."

Shakuntala looked at him. "We shall see."

A nail was hammered into the wall. The clock was hung. Five eighteen. At home that time had no special meaning. No period, no bell, no attendance. Only evening.

Jagannath Babu sat in the veranda. From the direction of the school came the sound of crows. A little later, voices of people going toward the ghat. Pipra was returning to its ordinary evening.

Shakuntala brought tea. "Where will you go tomorrow morning?"

The word almost left Jagannath Babu's mouth—"School."

He stopped.

"We'll see," he said.

19

The next morning Jagannath Babu woke on his own at five. No alarm had rung. Forty years of clockwork lived inside his body.

He rose, bathed, put on a dhoti, picked up his bag, and reached the door.

From inside Shakuntala asked, "Where?"

He stopped.

In his bag were yesterday's five applications. Budhan's paper was on top.

"Across the river," he said.

"Why?"

"An old student's house."

"This early?"

Jagannath Babu looked at the clock. Five twenty. Then he laughed.

"You're right. I'll go a little later."

He put the bag down and sat in the veranda.

The sun had not yet risen. A pale light was beginning in the east. The new wall clock inside ticked, but its sound was not clear in the veranda.

For the first time, Jagannath Babu watched the light increase without checking the time.

He felt that the dismissal bell had rung, but it was still too early to say whether the lesson was over.

— End of Story 44 —

45. The Painter

STORY

I

On the outer wall of Urmila Devi's house in Pipra's southern quarter were fish, lotuses, bamboo, birds, and two bicycles. Between the bicycles stood a mobile-phone tower, with three black birds perched on top. Some people in the village laughed when they saw the tower: "Has this entered Madhubani painting too?"

Urmila would say, "If it exists in the village, why should it not exist in the painting?"

Her place for painting was the rear veranda of the house. On one side the smoke from the stove rose upward; on the other, sheets of paper dried. There were small bowls of pigment, old cotton cloth, two bamboo pens, fine brushes bought from the market, a tin of gum, and a bag hanging on the wall with unfinished sheets of work inside.

Urmila knew colors less by their names than by their behavior: which red demanded more water, which black line cracked after drying, which green sank into the paper. Her hands knew all this.

That day she was finishing a painting of the Chhath ghat. On the ghat were bamboo baskets, thekua, the setting sun in the water, children, loudspeaker wires, and a red plastic chair. No one sat on the chair.

Her daughter Rupa asked, "Why the red chair?"

Without lifting her head, Urmila said, "It was there on the ghat."

"Empty?"

"In the painting, for now, it is empty."

2

Two weeks later a young woman named Ira Mehta came to Pipra from Delhi. She had travelled as far as Darbhanga for work connected with an exhibition and, at an acquaintance's suggestion, had come on to see Pipra. She carried a phone in one hand, a black shoulder bag, and a notebook. She did not go from house to house hunting for paintings; first she walked through the market, then the ghat, then the road by the temple.

Urmila's painted wall stopped her.

"Who made this painting?" she asked.

Rupa said, "Mother."

Ira came inside. Urmila was drawing a line on a sheet of paper at the time. The arrival of a visitor did not excite her particularly. Outsiders often came to Pipra to look at paintings—some took photographs, some asked the price, some said “very beautiful” and went away.

Before picking up each sheet, Ira asked permission. Urmila liked that.

She looked at the Chhath-ghat painting.

“This red chair?”

Urmila gave the same answer again: “It was there on the ghat.”

Ira looked at the painting for a while. “And the mobile tower?”

“That too is in the village.”

Ira did not laugh. She wrote something in her notebook. Then she set six paintings aside: the Chhath ghat; the waterline left high on a house wall after a flood; children waving toward a train; women planting paddy; birds sitting beneath a mobile tower; and a painting of an old woman listening to the radio.

“I have a gallery in Delhi,” Ira said. “Will you give me these six?”

Urmila named the price.

Ira did not ask her to reduce it.

That was where the story changed. But at the time all Urmila understood was that six paintings were being sold.

3

The paintings went to Delhi. A month later a message from Ira came on Rupa’s phone: four of the six had sold. Urmila received three times what an ordinary buyer in Pipra would have paid. The gallery had deducted its share, and even so this was the largest sum she had ever received at one time.

The western side of the roof, which leaked in the rains, was repaired. Two months of Rupa’s college fees were paid. Pigments, paper, and gum were bought in larger quantities at once.

Urmila was happy while counting the money. She felt no shame about that happiness. Art does not live outside the stomach—she had known this long before she ever needed a theory for it.

Ira sent another message: “I am considering proposing a solo exhibition.”

Rupa explained the English words one by one. “Solo means only your paintings.”

Urmila asked, “Will my name be there?”

“It will.”

“The price?”

“Ira-di says that will be discussed once you reach Delhi.”

Urmila took the phone in her own hand. In a voice message she said, “The price must be decided first. And I will name the paintings.”

Rupa burst out laughing. “Mother, you haven’t even reached Delhi and the bargaining has started.”

Urmila said, “The paper is in Pipra, and the hand is mine. Delhi will only provide the wall.”

4

When the first list arrived, it turned out to be larger than the wall. Twenty paintings were wanted. All the same size. Handmade paper. A uniform black line around the border. "Traditional color scheme." Five principal subjects—marriage, nature, goddess, sun, women's everyday life.

Rupa stopped midway through reading. "It says here—use fewer modern objects. Viewers prefer a 'timeless' look."

Urmila got stuck on the word "timeless."

"Meaning?"

"One in which the time is not obvious."

Urmila looked toward the Chhath-ghat painting, whose photograph Ira had especially liked. "Then shall I remove the red chair?"

Rupa said nothing.

"The mobile tower?"

"Probably they want less of all that."

Urmila listened to the list again. Marriage—she had painted it. Goddess—she had painted that. Sun too. But four versions each of five subjects, to make twenty paintings? The arithmetic of work began moving inside her head.

"If the size is the same, cutting the paper will be easy," she said.

"Then shall we agree?"

Urmila did not answer at once. "I can agree to the size. We will see about the subjects."

That was the first small decision.

5

The uniform size really did have advantages. The paper measurement was fixed; there was less trouble with the framer; quantities of pigment could be estimated. Urmila's hand began to move faster. She even enjoyed the first four paintings. There was a challenge in making different worlds within the same dimensions.

But by the seventh painting something strange happened. Her hand made a pair of fish before she had thought about it. In the eighth, the lotus grew in exactly the place it had occupied in the seventh. In the ninth, the woman's eyes tilted down as they had in the first painting.

She stopped the brush.

Rupa asked, "What happened?"

"My hand has learned ahead of me."

"That's a good thing, isn't it?"

"Not always."

She wet half of the ninth painting with water. The color spread. Rupa started.

"That would have sold!"

"It was not being sold yet. It was being made."

Urmila turned the spreading color into floodwater. Water rose beneath the marriage kohbar. Fish came up to the bride's feet.

A photograph went to Delhi. Ira replied, "Very interesting, but a little heavy for the main exhibition series. We can keep the flood theme for a separate project."

Urmila heard the message and turned the sheet over.

"What is heavy?"

Rupa shrugged.

"The water, or the painting?"

6

The next dispute was about color.

A biographical note was being written for the gallery website. The draft said: "Paintings made with local natural pigments."

Rupa read it aloud.

Urmila said at once, "That is not correct."

"Why? You make green from leaves, black from kaja—"

"Sometimes. Not every color. Look at this." She lifted the bowl of yellow. "From the market." Red? "From the market." Blue? "From the market."

In the old days her mother-in-law had made some colors at home. Urmila had learned to do so too. But once the number of paintings increased, it was not possible to make every color at home. Some natural pigments faded quickly; some depended on the season. Market colors gave her stability and speed.

"Why should I have a lie written?"

Rupa wrote to Ira.

The reply came: "The publicity team used a generic description. We will change it."

Two days later the website read: "Mixed natural and commercially available pigments on handmade paper."

Urmila was satisfied.

Her trust in Ira increased a little, because Ira could admit a mistake.

But that same week another message arrived: "If possible, include more work using natural pigments in the exhibition; viewers like that story."

Urmila laughed.

The lie had been removed. The desire had not.

7

The exhibition was titled "Memory of Earth."

Urmila said, "I have not made all my paintings on earth."

Rupa said, "The title is a metaphor."

"Does metaphor live in Delhi?"

Rupa laughed so hard she put down the phone.

Urmila wrote the names of her twenty paintings on a separate sheet: "Kohbar under Rising Water," "Three Towers and Five Birds," "Ghat with Red Chair," "Night Train," "Mother Listening to the Radio," "Grass Growing on Dust."

On the phone Ira said, “Some of the titles are very beautiful, but we may have to shorten them in English translation.”

“Shorten them, but do not cut away the meaning.”

“I will send them.”

The translations arrived. “Ghat with Red Chair” had become “River Ritual.”

Urmila said, “Where did the chair go?”

Rupa wrote to Ira.

A new translation arrived: “Ghat with Red Chair.”

Urmila could not read English, but Rupa explained the meaning. She said, “Now it is right.”

She was slowly beginning to understand that when a painting reached Delhi, it was not only the sheet of paper that changed; another frame of words formed around it. Title, biography, certificate, photograph, price—all together made a second body for the work. How much authority did she have over that body? The question was still open.

8

On her first journey to Delhi, Urmila did not sleep the whole night on the train. Rupa was with her. Outside the window darkness kept running past, split now and then by the light of stations.

Urmila asked, “Do my paintings run like this too?”

“Which way?”

“Made in one place, seen in another. Who sees the road between?”

Rupa kept looking at the ticket on her phone. “You have become a philosopher again.”

“I am a painter. I fill empty spaces.”

The gallery in Delhi was bright. The walls were so clean that Urmila remembered the smoke-darkened veranda of her own house. The paintings hung with wide spaces between them. Beneath each was a small label—title, artist, medium, dimensions, year.

Seeing her own name clearly written, she stood silent for a while.

“Urmila Devi, Pipra, Mithila.”

Ira asked, “All right?”

“The village name is there. All right.”

Then Urmila’s eyes went to “Ghat with Red Chair.” On the right side of the painting, where the red chair stood, the white mount inside the frame had overlapped a little too far. One leg of the chair was hidden.

Urmila immediately called Ira.

“Open this.”

The framer was called. The mount was cut back. All four legs of the chair became visible again.

It was a small matter. Not to Urmila.

On the evening of the opening, people came. Some stood for a long time in front of paintings; some took photographs and moved on; some asked about the pigments; some spoke in long sentences about caste, tradition, “women’s art,” and “folk sensibility.”

Looking at “Ghat with Red Chair,” one man said to Ira, “The chair is a little disruptive. In a traditional composition, the plastic feels very sharp.”

Before Ira could answer, Urmila said, “It looks sharp on the ghat too.”

The man turned toward her. “Oh, you are the artist?”

Rupa translated.

Urmila said, “Yes.”

The man smiled. He wanted to offer some explanation—

Urmila did not attempt to answer in Hindi. In Maithili she told Rupa, “Tell him people put plastic chairs there. The painting contains people’s life. Not only the things viewers recognize as tradition.”

Rupa translated.

The man looked at the painting again, this time for a little longer.

He did not buy it.

That same evening a journalist asked Urmila, “How has life changed after being discovered in Delhi?” Rupa repeated the question in Maithili.

Urmila first understood the question, then got stuck on the phrase “being discovered.”

“Where had I been lost?” she asked.

The journalist laughed, then realized that Urmila was not merely joking. He changed the question: “After becoming associated with the gallery?”

“That is a different matter,” Urmila said. “The gallery brought me to people in Delhi. But I was making paintings before that. People in Pipra were seeing them before that. The day you see an artist for the first time is not the day the artist is born.”

Ira stood beside her and did not interrupt. Later she said, “We will use the word ‘discovery’ less in the publicity material.”

Urmila said, “Say you met me. If you say you discovered me, it sounds as though I had been lying in a bush.”

The next day one line in the publicity really was changed: “The gallery became acquainted with Urmila Devi during a visit to Pipra.”

Urmila asked Rupa to save a photograph of that small change. She was beginning to understand that words, too, were like the edge of a painting: if they intruded a little too far, they could hide one leg of the meaning.

After that, for certification material, the gallery asked for photographs of her home and work space. When the photographer came, he asked her to pose mixing colors beside the stove. Urmila said, “I mix colors on the veranda now. Why should I go beside the stove for the photograph?”

The photographer became slightly awkward. Ira immediately said, “Photograph her where the work is actually done.”

In the photograph one could see plastic pigment bottles, a steel tumbler, an old mobile phone, bamboo pens, and stacks of paper. The publicity team

first thought of removing two bottles, but at Urmila's insistence the image was left as it was.

At the end of the evening Ira said, "That was a good answer."

Urmila asked, "Do good answers sell paintings?"

Ira laughed. "Not always."

"Then it is all right."

IO

On the fifth day of the exhibition, "Grass Growing on Dust" sold. On the seventh, "Mother Listening to the Radio." On the ninth, "Night Train."

"Ghat with Red Chair" remained.

Ira told her that one buyer liked the painting but had asked, "Could another version be made without this chair?"

Urmila fell silent.

"That would be a different painting," she said at last.

"Yes. It could be made as a separate work."

"But then the ghat would not be the same ghat."

Ira said nothing.

Urmila herself thought: what crime would there be in making a ghat without the chair? Artists paint the same subject again and again. She herself had painted the Chhath ghat many times. The problem was not removing a chair. The problem was that someone sitting far away wanted her to remove one thing from her present so that the present would resemble that person's imagined past.

She said, "I will paint another ghat. But I will paint what I see."

The buyer did not wait.

The painting with the red chair returned to Pipra.

II

After she returned from Delhi, people's behavior in Pipra changed. Those who had once bargained over the price of a painting now asked, "What is the Delhi price?" Some called her a "national artist," others "the gallery woman."

Urmila accepted neither expression.

Her work did change, certainly. Large bundles of paper began arriving at once. She kept brushes in three sizes. Rupa began keeping sales accounts on a computer. On the back of each painting they started writing the date, medium, and title.

Urmila found all these changes useful.

But commissions increased too. "Marriage series—six." "Fish-tree—four." "Goddess—three." "Blue-background version—five."

One day she noticed that she had spent the whole week merely repeating forms that sold. Her hand moved easily; her mind was tired.

She could not stop taking all commissions. The household income now depended on them: Rupa's education, the tool shop of her younger son Amit, medicine for the house, pigments, travel—all of it.

So she made a rule for herself: after five commissioned paintings, one painting without a commission.

Rupa asked, "What if that one does not sell?"

"Then it will stay at home."

"Paper is expensive."

"The hand is expensive too."

12

In the first uncommissioned painting, Urmila painted Pipra's market: plastic awnings over vegetable stalls, motorcycles, milk cans, schoolchildren, a mobile-repair signboard, and two kites in the sky above. There was no traditional creeper-pattern around the border; electrical wires wound their way around it instead.

Rupa looked at the painting and said nothing.

"What?" Urmila asked.

"Shall we send it to Ira-di?"

"First I will look at it."

The painting remained on the wall for three days. Every time Urmila came onto the veranda, she changed something: added a dog, removed a rickshaw, deepened the shadow beneath the milk can.

Then a photograph was sent.

Ira's reply came late. "This is very strong, but it may be difficult for our current client base. We can place it in the experimental section."

Urmila asked, "What does experimental mean?"

Rupa searched for the word. "Where you are doing something new."

Urmila laughed. "It has been ten years since I painted the tower. In Delhi it has only now become experimental?"

Even so, the painting went to Delhi.

It did not sell for three months.

In the fourth month, a schoolteacher bought it.

Ira called and said, "See? It took time, but it found its viewer."

Urmila answered, "A painting too has to find its own person."

13

In the second year the gallery asked for ten paintings for a large fair. This time Ira wrote clearly: "Buyers prefer medium sizes, open color, and compositions with less crowding."

Urmila read the list and fell silent.

Open color—fine. Medium size—fine. Less crowding—difficult. How could a view of Pipra contain less crowding? The ghat, market, wedding, fields—everywhere there were people, animals, goods, sounds, wires, water, dust.

In one painting she made only a tree and two birds. It came out very beautiful.

Rupa looked at it and said, "This will sell immediately."

Urmila looked at the painting for a day. On the second day she added an electric pole behind the tree. On the third, a child's football below. On the fourth, a small train in the distance.

Rupa clutched her head. "Mother!"

"What?"

"Less crowding!"

"It is still very empty."

The painting went to the fair. It did in fact sell. The buyer's comment came back: "I liked the tension between tradition and contemporary life."

Rupa translated.

Urmila said, "I did not make any tension. The pole was there."

14

A few months later, one of Urmila's paintings appeared on the cover of the gallery's publicity booklet. The photograph was very beautiful, but her signature at the bottom of the painting had been cropped out. The gallery's name appeared in large letters on the cover; the artist's name was on an inside page.

Rupa brought the booklet home.

At first Urmila was pleased. Then, as she kept looking at the photograph, her eyes moved downward.

"Where is my name?"

"Inside."

"The painting is outside."

She called Ira.

Ira said, "The painting was cropped in the cover design. It was not deliberate."

"Next time do not crop away the name."

"All right. I will tell the design team."

"And in photographs posted online, let the name remain with the painting too."

Ira was silent for a moment. "The same arrangement is not possible on every platform, but we can do it on the website and in gallery publications."

Urmila was not looking for total victory. She wanted clarity: where her right extended, and where another system governed. She wanted to know the boundary.

After that, in most of the gallery's online publications, her name appeared clearly. Sometimes another mistake happened. Rupa would send an image of it. It would be corrected.

In the meantime another matter arose. The buyer of "Mother Listening to the Radio" wrote to the gallery asking for another copy "exactly the same"—but with a blue background. Ira asked Urmila politely.

Urmila looked at the photograph. In the old painting, the old woman's hand was not on top of the radio but beside it. While making it, she had remembered her mother-in-law's hand. Now it seemed impossible to reproduce that hand exactly.

"If I make a replica, it will be a print," she said. "I can paint the same subject again, but not the same painting."

The buyer agreed. In the new painting the radio stood beside a window, the woman was spinning thread, and rain fell outside. The background really was blue.

After seeing the new work, the buyer wrote that she liked it more than the first painting.

Rupa laughed. "So refusing to make an exact copy turned out to be useful."

Urmila said, "Useful for the buyer. My work was simply to make it again."

From that day the gallery stopped sending orders using the word "copy" and began saying "new version." The word changed only slightly, but within it Urmila found a little more room for her own hand.

The work now extended beyond color and line.

15

A new problem arose in Pipra. Two local shopkeepers began printing Urmila's popular "Fish-Tree" design on cheap cloth and selling it. No one had taken permission.

Rupa was furious. "We'll go to the police."

Urmila looked at the cloth. The lines were crooked, the colors gaudy, and the fish in the middle was upside down.

"This is not my painting."

"It is a copy."

"Yes."

"Then?"

Urmila did not decide at once. In the village, who owned the fish, the creeper, the sun, the motifs themselves? She had learned many forms from her mother, mother-in-law, and older women. But reproducing her particular composition, her particular sequence, her particular image without permission was another matter.

She went to the shopkeeper. She did not quarrel. She asked, "Did you take this design from a photograph of mine?"

At first the shopkeeper denied it. Then he admitted it.

"Next time do not lift a photograph. If you want to make cloth, tell me. I will make a separate design. We will decide the price."

The shopkeeper was startled. He had expected the police or abuse.

Two months later he really did commission five designs from her.

Rupa asked, "You turned the man who copied you into a customer?"

Urmila said, "No one owns line itself. But do not steal the page I have made. The two things are different."

Ira came to Pipra again in the third year. This time she was not alone; the gallery owner, Vinay Sahu, was with her. Vinay looked carefully at all the work and spoke little.

In Urmila's new series were things left after the flood—a waterline on a wall, an overturned cot, a schoolbag half sunk in mud, a sari drying, and an empty red chair.

Vinay stopped before the painting with the chair. "The same red chair?"

Ira had probably told him the story before.

Urmila said, "Whether the chair is the same or another one, in the painting now it is empty."

Vinay asked, "This series may be difficult to sell. Very sad."

Urmila said, "If it is difficult to sell, then do not sell it."

Ira spoke in between: "It may suit an institutional exhibition."

Urmila looked at her. "The paintings will be made first. We can look for the place afterward."

Ira smiled. "All right."

Vinay did not disagree from a business point of view; he merely said, "Then we should keep the saleable series separate."

Urmila agreed to that too.

That evening all three went to the ghat. Badri Kaka's old red chair lay overturned to one side. A new rope had been tied around one leg.

Ira said softly, "Now I understand."

Urmila asked, "What?"

"Why the chair remains."

Urmila did not answer. Understanding, too, can sometimes become a new frame.

Market pressure did not come only from the gallery. The household too asked, "Will this painting sell?"

Talks about Rupa's marriage had begun. Amit was thinking of expanding his shop. The house needed a new water pump. Urmila's knees hurt.

The rule of one uncommissioned painting after five orders stretched to seven orders. Then sometimes to ten.

Once an invitation came from a fair in Delhi for a "live painting" demonstration. The program letter said she was to complete a small painting before the audience in twenty minutes. Urmila looked at the paper and asked, "Why twenty minutes?"

Ira said, "The program time is fixed. People want to see the process."

"Will they see the process, or speed?"

Ira was silent. Then she said, "I can ask them to increase the time."

Urmila went, but she did not promise to complete a painting. On stage she demonstrated making the bamboo pen, the pressure used to draw a line, the absorbency of paper, and the intervals needed for color to dry. When

twenty minutes had passed, the sheet was only half finished. The host asked, "Is the painting complete?"

Urmila said, "Not yet. The color must dry, then the next layer will go on."

Some viewers were disappointed; some moved closer. At the end of the program, the half-finished painting remained on display. The next day she sat in the gallery and completed it.

The experience taught her that the market did not merely ask for subject and color; sometimes it wanted even the time in which art was made shortened for its convenience. From that day she had a rule for such demonstrations: "The work will take as much time as it takes."

One day Urmila realized that for three months she had not made a single painting simply because she wanted to.

That night she sat on the veranda. The power was out. A small lamp burned. The sheets hanging on the wall looked yellow in its light. Colors that were distinct in daylight now seemed a little alike.

She took out a small sheet. It was not cut to the size of any order. She dipped the bamboo pen. She drew the first line—not the flame of the lamp, but its shadow.

Around it she did not fully draw tower, fish, train, woman, paddy, chair, water—only incomplete signs.

Rupa woke in the night and saw it. "What is this?"

Urmila said, "I don't know yet."

"Shall we send it?"

"To whom?"

Rupa laughed. "All right."

The painting stayed at home for a long time.

18

Some time later a museum in Delhi contacted the gallery. It wanted to hold an exhibition of contemporary Mithila painting. Ira sent Urmila's name. The selection committee wanted to see five works—three older, two new.

Urmila also sent the small painting of lamp-shadow and incomplete signs.

Rupa objected. "This does not even look complete."

"It feels complete to me."

"Title?"

Urmila thought for a long time. "Light in the Middle."

"But no light is painted in it."

"Even so."

Of the five, that was the painting selected.

The museum's note said: "The work presents fragments of traditional visual vocabulary as incomplete signs."

Rupa read it aloud.

Urmila said, "They understood it in their own language."

"Do you agree?"

“I made it. They saw it. The two acts are different.”

For the first time Rupa saw her mother so calm while an outside interpretation placed a new meaning over her painting. Perhaps because this time the painting felt sufficiently complete within her. Words from outside could not make it smaller.

19

After that, the change in Urmila's paintings became obvious. She did not abandon traditional forms. On the contrary, she went back to older women to relearn some old lines. One creeper-turn would not come like her mother-in-law's hand; she practiced it again and again.

At the same time new objects began entering without fear—ATM slips, train windows, plastic water tanks, school identity cards, flood marks, hospital beds, masks drying on wires, and a bridge being built far above the river.

Ira would sometimes say, “This series is very contemporary.”

Urmila would answer, “And the others belong to ancient times?”

Both would laugh.

Market demands did not disappear. Nor did requests for uniform sizes or popular subjects. Urmila did not reject everything either. Some orders she took gladly, some for money, some she refused.

To say that her art became “free” would not be quite right. Freedom too moved through negotiation among household, price, time, body, customer, and paper.

But the negotiation no longer happened only to her. She too set terms.

20

One evening four children from Pipra's school came to her house. Master Sahib had retired; the new art teacher had sent the children to see the work of a local artist.

The children looked at the paintings and rained questions on her.

“Why is the fish so large?”

“Why are the eyes looking both ways?”

“Why is the train crooked in this painting?”

“Why does the red chair come again and again?”

Urmila did not answer every question. For some she said, “What do you think?”

One girl stopped before an old painting of the Chhath ghat. “This chair is empty, but it feels as if someone is about to come and sit.”

Another child said, “No, someone has just got up and gone.”

Urmila listened to both.

“Which one is right?” a third asked.

Urmila said, “A painting is not a police statement. You can see both.”

The girl asked again, “What do people in Delhi see?”

Urmila laughed. “They too see with their own eyes.”

"What do you see?"

At that question she paused.

"While making it I see one thing. After it is made, sometimes another."

21

That night, after the children had gone, Urmila took out the old red-chair painting. Since returning from Delhi it had lain wrapped in cloth inside the house. The colors were still clear. The chair really did shine differently from the rest of the painting.

Once she had had to fight to preserve that difference. Now she saw that the painting itself also lived apart from her argument. Perhaps the chair really was too sharp. Perhaps that was its work.

She thought of placing a drop of black paint on the chair. Her hand rose. Then stopped.

There was no need to correct the old painting again.

She took a new sheet.

This time the ghat was at night. No Chhath. No crowd. The river black-blue. At the bank stood three seats—one red chair, one green, and an unpainted bamboo stool. Far away, the red light of a mobile tower. A faint reflection in the water.

No goddess, no sun, no explicit ritual. Only night, river, three things on which one could sit, and a distant light.

Rupa saw it late at night. "Who is this for?"

Urmila said, "For no one yet."

"Title?"

"Not yet."

Rupa wanted to say something, then remained silent.

22

In the morning there was no electricity. A small lamp burned on the veranda. Urmila propped the new painting against the wall and looked at it from a distance. The lamp's light did not fall directly on the paper; Rupa's hanging clothes, a bamboo branch, and a pigment bottle cut shadows across the way. Even so, the red dot of the tower in the painted water seemed to glimmer slightly.

Urmila picked up the brush. The place for a title in the corner of the painting was empty.

A message from Ira arrived on the phone—a proposal for a new series for the coming season. Theme: "Changing Images of Time." Free size. Free subject. Only ten paintings.

Rupa read it aloud.

Urmila smiled. "Now they want time?"

"It seems so."

"All right. But this painting will not be among those ten."

"Why?"

“Because this one was already being made before that.”

In the lower right corner of the paper she wrote her name—small, clear, without ornament.

Then she folded the cloth back over the old red-chair painting, left the new painting to dry, and stepped outside the veranda. Morning market was opening in Pipra. A milk bicycle passed, two schoolchildren ran by, a train whistle sounded far away, birds sat on the mobile tower.

Some things were old, some new. Some could be sold, some could not. Some lines had come from her mother-in-law's hand, some from her own life, some had not yet even taken a name.

Inside, the flame of the lamp was small, but it had not gone out.

— *End of Story 45* —

46. The Return

STORY

I

Phoolmati Kaki recognized Renuka first by the suitcase.

The evening bus had gone down Pipra's main road raising dust. From the bus stop, the face of the woman walking toward the house was not clear to Kaki at a distance, but the sound made by the wheels of the blue suitcase dragging behind her over the broken brick path seemed slightly out of place. In Pipra, such wheels generally worked properly only as far as the market; after that one had to lift the case by hand. The woman lifted it twice and dragged it again three times.

Kaki rose from the cot on the veranda and narrowed her eyes.

"Renuka?"

The woman stopped.

Across twenty years of distance, gait is recognized before voice. Phoolmati Kaki suddenly remembered the walk of the girl who, three years after her marriage, had returned one afternoon to her parents' house without music, lights, or guests, two bags hanging from her hands. For three days afterward, people in Pipra had invented six answers to the same question. Some said her husband beat her; some said Renuka had become too educated; some said she could not get along with her mother-in-law; some said she was tempted by employment; some said she had no child; some said she did not want one either.

At the time Phoolmati Kaki had said, "In household life one has to endure a couple of things."

Now that sentence sounded somewhat bitter in her own ears.

Renuka came up and bowed. Kaki placed a hand on her head. There were a few white strands in her hair. The face was thinner than in Kaki's memory, but the eyes were the same—half inward, half outward when listening to what people said.

"You arrived in time?" Kaki asked.

Renuka said, "Is the body still at home?"

"Yes. Arun has held it back. He said, let Didi arrive, then we will go to the ghat."

Phoolmati Kaki liked that and found it slightly strange too. Whether bodies were held back for daughters in her time or not, she could not clearly remember. Many rules were now retold as "old," but Kaki felt that even in the old days they differed from house to house.

Renuka moved toward the gate. Kaki called from behind, "Leave the suitcase here; we'll send a child with it."

Renuka turned. "No, Kaki, I'll take it."

Kaki thought to herself—the girl's habit has not gone. Her own burden, carried by herself.

There was a crowd in the house. A white sheet on the veranda, women in the courtyard, the smell of incense inside. Devkant Babu lay on a bamboo bier. His face had grown small. Phoolmati Kaki arrived a little behind Renuka and saw that she did not sit by the body; first she touched the doorframe.

Kaki's mind immediately made a story: see, the threshold first.

But just as quickly it made another: perhaps her foot had faltered.

In village life, meanings are made very quickly out of people's actions. It takes no time to make a meaning; it can take years to erase one.

Kaki sat among the women. Someone whispered, "Twenty years."

Someone asked, "Was she speaking with her father?"

Someone answered, "There were phone calls."

"Will she stay through the shraddha?"

"Who knows?"

Phoolmati Kaki said in between, "The body is still in the house. The rest later."

She herself was surprised that those words had come from her mouth. Twenty years earlier she would not have let such an occasion pass.

Renuka sat by her father's head. She did not cry. She kept looking only at the nail of his right hand. Phoolmati Kaki found even that strange. Crying at death was natural; when someone did not cry, people went looking for meaning. Kaki thought—city life dries people out. Then she saw that Renuka was gripping the edge of her anchal so tightly in her fist that the joints of her thumb had turned white.

At that, Kaki loosened her judgment a little.

When it was time to go to the ghat, a question arose among the women. Would Renuka go or not? Two elderly women of the house said daughters did not go to the ghat. Meena—Arun's wife—said nothing. Arun looked toward his sister.

Renuka only asked, "Had Babu said so?"

Phoolmati Kaki was startled at the question. It was not necessary that the dead man had laid down a rule; living people often fashioned his wishes according to their convenience.

Arun said, "He never said any such thing."

Renuka stood up. "Then I will go."

Kaki wanted to say, "What will people say?" But now the weight of that sentence felt like an old iron trunk on her own head. She remained silent.

When people returned from the ghat at night, darkness had fallen into the courtyard. There was no electricity. Meena had lit two lanterns. Renuka sat in one corner bringing together her father's old pair of slippers—one had been under the bed, the other by the door.

Phoolmati Kaki said, "Leave all that for now."

Renuka did not smile. "Babu was always losing one slipper."

Kaki remembered Devkant Babu's voice: "Phoolmati, have you seen my right slipper?"

For the first time all day she laughed. Renuka laughed a little too.

In that small laughter Kaki did not find the story of twenty years. She found only two slippers together.

As the night deepened, the first crowd of women thinned. Phoolmati Kaki rose to go home, but at the doorway two old women again began discussing Renuka. "Does she live alone in the city?" one asked. The other answered, "There must be someone." There was less curiosity inside the question than anxiety to place a life in a familiar compartment.

Phoolmati Kaki used to enjoy such talk. This time she said, "Giving a name to something you do not understand does not make it understood." Both women looked at her as though Kaki had suddenly returned from reading some book.

On the way home, Kaki remembered her younger sister. Widowed, the sister had wanted to return to her maternal home, but Kaki herself had told her then, "Stay in your husband's house; what will people say?" The sister stayed. Five years later she died of illness. The line between cause and result in that memory was not clear, but the sentence was still lodged inside Kaki.

Kaki thought: in what Panji is the account written of lives saved by fear of people's talk? And where is the account of lives broken by obeying people's talk? Renuka was not the answer to this question. But her return was certainly unsettling Kaki's old answers.

2

Shyama could not call Renuka a culprit, because half the guilt seemed to her to lie with herself too.

They had gone to school together. Written poems in the same notebook, bathed secretly in the same river, been scolded by the same Master Sahib. When Renuka married, Shyama cried so much at the farewell that people laughed. Three years later, when Renuka returned, Shyama had let her sleep for two nights in the back room of her own house—something few people knew.

After that Devkant Babu kept Renuka at home, but the atmosphere itself was like a condition: "There will be a compromise."

A compromise between whom? Over what? Even now Shyama did not fully know. At the time Renuka said very little. Only once at night she had said, "I cannot live there."

Shyama had asked, "Does he beat you?"

After a long time Renuka had replied, "Does only beating make a house bad?"

Shyama had spent twenty years trying to understand that sentence.

Later there was something like a panchayat meeting. The husband came, his maternal uncle came, Devkant Babu, two agnates, one teacher. From the far veranda Shyama listened to voices. "Job," "family honor," "living

separately,” “child,” “city,” “pride”—the words rose again and again. The dispute did not fit inside any single one of them.

Three months later Renuka went to Patna. Then Delhi. For the first two years letters came to Shyama. In the third year they became fewer. When mobile phones arrived, there were occasional calls.

Whether Renuka’s relationship with Devkant Babu had broken or survived, Shyama was never certain. Once Babu had said in the market, “My daughter is well.” That was all. Another time Renuka had said on the phone, “Babu does not talk; he hangs up.” Then five years later she said, “Now we speak.”

Human relationships are not government registers in which one can simply write “broken” or “continuing” in a box.

Three letters from Renuka were still preserved in Shyama’s trunk. The first, from Patna—four pages about the exhaustion of job-hunting and the heat in the hostel. The second, from Delhi—brief, only the news that she had found a temporary appointment at a school. In the third there was almost no mention of home, only one line at the end: “Tell Kaki I am well; tell Babu if you think it proper.”

Shyama had never understood the meaning of that line. “If you think it proper”—was she making a messenger of a friend, or protecting herself from her father’s anger? Shyama went to Devkant Babu. She did not have the courage to give him the letter; she merely said, “Renuka is well.” Babu folded the newspaper and asked, “She is teaching?” Shyama said yes. Babu asked no other question.

A year later Babu himself stopped Shyama and asked, “Did that school post become permanent?” Then Shyama understood that silence was not ignorance. Some people did not openly ask for news, but kept gathering it inside.

One letter Shyama sent to Renuka came back—the address had changed. There was a red postal stamp on the envelope. Shyama kept it for a long time like evidence of a crime. Later, when phones became common, the distance lessened, but the long reply that a letter could contain never returned. On a short phone call, everything becomes short.

On the second morning after the funeral, Shyama reached Renuka’s house early. Renuka was sweeping the courtyard.

“You?” Shyama called.

Renuka stopped the broom. For the first time in twenty years they heard the intimate “you” from one another.

“At this age should I bow to you?” Renuka said.

Shyama embraced her. For a while both were silent. Neither cried loudly.

“Why didn’t you come earlier?” Shyama asked. The moment the question came out, she regretted it.

Renuka leaned the broom against the wall. “How much earlier?”

“When Kaka was ill.”

“There was talk of coming.”

“Then?”

“He said—not now.”

“Kaka?”

"Yes."

Shyama both believed it and did not. Devkant Babu was proud, but she could not believe that in his last years he had not wanted to see his daughter.

Renuka went inside and brought out an old mobile phone. "Want to hear his voice?"

The recording was short. Devkant Babu's rough, coughing voice: "Don't buy the ticket yet. The flood roads are bad. We'll see after Dussehra."

The date was two years old.

Shyama asked, "And after that?"

"At Dussehra my school had exams. Then his winter illness. Then my..." Renuka stopped. "That was it. Days kept joining one another."

There was no large reason in that answer. That hurt Shyama even more. Twenty years are often not made by one enormous decision, but by small postponed days.

In the afternoon the two went into the old room. The wall color had changed, but the iron bars of the window were the same. Renuka touched one corner. "We wrote poems here."

"On the wall?"

"Yes."

"Kaka had it plastered over."

"He did right."

Shyama laughed. "At the time you said—it is violence against art."

"At the time I was very learned."

Both laughed.

Then Shyama became serious. "People still talk."

Renuka kept looking out through the window. "That is people's work."

"Doesn't it hurt?"

"It does. But life has become too short to answer every remark."

Shyama wanted to ask why the marriage had really broken. With whom had she lived in the city? Why had she not married again? What were the last words she spoke with her father? But she understood that friendship does not grant the right to ask every question; sometimes trust means leaving a question unasked.

Even so, one question Shyama could not hold back. "Were you ever angry with Babu?"

Renuka did not answer at once. Outside the window two mango leaves struck against each other in the wind. "Very," she said at last.

"And now?"

"Now the man to be angry with is no longer here."

At first the sentence sounded harsh to Shyama. Then she understood—death does not command anger to turn into sacred memory. Love and resentment can live together in a relationship while people are alive; death only removes the other person's ability to answer.

Renuka continued, "I blamed Babu for not accepting me immediately. Later I understood that he himself was trapped in his society, his fears, his reputation. Understanding that did not erase my pain; it only changed its shape."

Shyama did not take that answer as forgiveness. Perhaps it was more difficult than forgiveness—to understand the cause and yet not erase the wound.

As Shyama was leaving, she said, “You’ll go after the shraddha?”

“I have a ticket.”

“Will you come again?”

Renuka did not answer.

Shyama did not take the silence as a promise, nor as a refusal. For the first time in twenty years she felt that more important than trying to understand Renuka was to give her a place to be here—whether for thirteen days, or until the next time.

3

Meena’s first fear about Renuka’s return was land.

She did not want to say this to anyone, because in a house of mourning thoughts of property look petty. But when something that looks petty is tied to food, children, debt, and the future, how petty is it really?

Meena had been in Devkant Babu’s household for fifteen years. For the last five, his medicines, meals, doctor, night cough, eye drops, bank pension, electricity bill—the entire routine—had passed through Meena’s hands. Arun was away for contract work ten days at a stretch each month. Devkant Babu used to say, “My daughter-in-law is like a daughter to me.”

Meena was pleased to hear the sentence, but somewhere inside she understood that between “like a daughter” and “a daughter” lay large differences of law, memory, and blood.

On the first night after Renuka arrived, Meena prepared a room for her suitcase. The old room now held the children’s books, so she spread bedding in the small front room. Renuka said, “I’ll stay in the old room.”

Meena replied at once, “Anshu’s books are there.”

“All right. Here, then.”

That was all. But Meena heard harshness in her own voice.

The next day there was talk of taking out the bank passbook, death certificate, pension papers, and land records. Arun opened the cupboard. Renuka stood at the door.

Meena watched her eyes—which document would they rest on?

Renuka picked up only one old paper—Devkant Babu’s handwritten medicine list. “Was Babu’s handwriting like this till the end?”

Arun said, “Toward the end it trembled.”

Renuka put the paper back.

Meena’s fear did not lessen. To demand a right one did not need to keep one’s eyes fixed on papers.

In the afternoon a neighboring woman drew Meena aside. “Didi will have a share, won’t she?”

Meena said, “How would I know?”

“Did Kaka make papers?”

“I don’t know.”

In fact Meena did know that Devkant Babu had once gone to the registry office. What he had done there, even Arun had never clearly said. The fact remained stuck in Meena's mind like a thorn.

After dinner that night Renuka began washing plates in the kitchen. Meena stopped her. "Leave them, you're a guest."

Renuka stopped her hands and looked at her. "A guest?"

Meena immediately knew the word had slipped. "I meant..."

"It's all right," Renuka said. "After twenty years, some words choose themselves."

To Meena it sounded like a taunt. She stopped the next words inside herself. Perhaps, she thought—perhaps it was not a taunt.

Renuka kept washing the plates. No glass bangles sounded in the soap foam; she was not wearing any. Meena noticed it for the first time. In the village people look for signs of a woman's marital history on her body. Renuka's body had become an old textbook for people here to read.

On the thirtieth day, Devkant Babu's lawyer came. There was no crowd, only Arun, Meena, Renuka. A simple will was taken out. The main part of the house was in Arun's name, the back plot equally in the names of brother and sister, and half of the old mango orchard in Renuka's name.

Meena's stomach tightened from within.

Renuka read the entire document. "When was this made?"

"Three years ago," the lawyer said.

Arun was silent.

Renuka asked, "Babu never told me?"

No one answered.

Meena suddenly said, "We look after the orchard. Fertilizer, labor, taxes—everything..."

Arun wanted to stop her, but the words were already out.

Renuka did not fold the document. She laid it slowly on the table. "I'm not saying anything right now."

That was the sentence Meena found most frightening—right now.

At night Meena said to Arun, "Did you see?"

Arun was tired. "What?"

"She won't say anything? Later?"

"It is her share."

"Who has my share?"

"You and the children have this house."

"On paper the house is yours."

Arun fell silent.

Meena understood—the fear of property was not only fear of Renuka. When a woman puts her life into a household, little paperwork records her labor. Renuka had lived away and returned carrying a right of blood; Meena had remained inside and served, but her right came through her husband. The system could make the two women see each other as threats because it placed them directly opposite one another.

That night Meena took out Devkant Babu's old medicine notebook. Dates, tablets, blood-sugar checks, doctor's fees—and between them her own handwriting: "Cough at 2 a.m." "No food." "Arun away." "Renuka

called 8:40.” Meena was startled. The last note was not Devkant Babu’s; it was in her own hand. And she had written “Renuka called.”

At the time it had seemed merely routine. Now she understood—while doing the work of care, she had also been writing the memory of the household. This notebook contained a paper record of five years of her labor, even though it was no registry.

The next morning Renuka saw the notebook. “You wrote all this?”

After the familiar “yes” slipped naturally out of her mouth instead of formal address, Meena relaxed for the first time. “For the doctor. Then it became a habit.”

Renuka turned the pages for a long time. “Babu even wrote down the time of my calls.”

Meena said, “I wrote it. That night your call came after his medicine.”

Renuka closed the notebook. “You took great care of Babu.”

Renuka opened it again and stopped at one page. In Meena’s handwriting: “11:30 p.m.—spoke with daughter, ate a little better.”

“I remember this day,” Renuka said. “Babu said there wasn’t enough salt in the vegetables you made.”

Meena laughed despite herself. “The salt was fine that day. The doctor had reduced his salt.”

Both laughed together. In Devkant Babu’s absence, his complaint came and sat between them like a small living thing.

For the first time Meena asked Renuka, “Did you send Babu money?” As soon as the question came out, she disliked it; it sounded like accounts again.

Without taking offense Renuka said, “Sometimes. He often sent it back. Later I began paying the medicine bills directly.”

Meena remembered some bills Arun had said, “Didi paid this.” At the time she had paid little attention. Care and money had come from different places, yet a household story often tries to give one person all the credit or all the blame.

Before answering, Meena felt something soften inside her. Not because of praise, but because for the first time someone had looked at care not as the natural duty of a daughter-in-law, but as work. “Whatever could be done,” she said.

The day before the shraddha, Renuka met Meena in the courtyard. “Shall we talk about the orchard?”

Meena stiffened slightly. “Say it.”

“I don’t want to sell.”

“Then?”

“Anshu studies environmental work, doesn’t he?”

Meena was surprised.

“Babu used to say two old varieties of mango are still alive in the orchard. If it seems right to you, let the care continue as it does. Arun can keep the accounts of the income. My share can remain on paper. Later, if Anshu and his brother want...”

“You’ll give it up?”

“I’m not talking about giving it up.”

Meena became alert again.

Renuka smiled a little. "Look, I have not come here to become noble by surrendering my rights. But having a right does not mean everything must be divided today."

For the first time Meena laughed openly. "I had thought you came and..."

She stopped.

"Everyone thought so," Renuka said.

"Are you angry with me?"

"Why?"

"I called you a 'guest.'"

After a little while Renuka said, "That day it hurt. Now I understand—you too have to protect the house."

Meena wanted to say—the house must not only be protected, it must be kept running. Then she thought, I'll say it next time.

She herself was surprised at that "next time." Somewhere inside, she had accepted that Renuka might come again.

4

For Badri Kaka, the first problem about Renuka was whether a woman would go to the ghat.

A bigger problem than that was that they were short of bamboo.

Four bamboo poles were needed to make Devkant Babu's bier; only three available ones were sound. The fourth had a split at a joint. Badri Kaka was an old member of the ghat committee; during Chhath his famous authority consisted in sitting on a red plastic chair and giving everyone instructions. At a death he did not take the chair. Here the work had to be done by hand.

Arun said, "Didi will go to the ghat."

Badri Kaka paused for a moment. "If she goes, she goes."

Someone behind them said, "Such a custom..."

Badri Kaka snapped, "Will custom give us a bamboo? Look at this bamboo first."

People laughed. Half the dispute ended there.

At the ghat Renuka came walking at the very back. No pot on her head, no special ritual act; she was simply present. Badri Kaka looked at her from time to time. People's eyes were on her more than on the river.

The pyre was arranged. Arun lit it. Renuka stood at a distance. Once the wind carried smoke toward her and she did not move back; her eyes watered, but whether from smoke or grief, Badri Kaka did not try to guess.

He had grown slightly weary of guessing. While giving testimony in the land case of Story 39, he had seen how people mix desire even into what their own eyes have seen.

When the pyre was half burned, Badri Kaka remembered Devkant Babu. Five years earlier the two had quarreled in a dispute over the Chhath ghat. Devkant Babu had said, "The ghat is not your ancestral property." Badri Kaka did not speak to him for three days. Then at a feast the two ate pickle from the same plate.

Human enmity too often does not end formally; the next task simply passes over it.

The Kamla had cut the bank again that year. New sand had accumulated seven hands east of the old cremation place. Badri Kaka kept telling people, “Not there; the ground is soft.” Death too obeys the geography of the river; the wish that the son’s pyre burn where the ancestors’ pyres burned may prove smaller than the movement of water.

While alive, Devkant Babu used to argue on this changing ghat. “Why make permanent claims on a river’s path?” Badri Kaka would say, “There must be order.” Between those two truths a committee would be formed, bamboo would be planted, and in the next flood the bamboo would wash away.

With Renuka standing before the pyre, Badri Kaka heard a strange echo of that argument. The village too wants to make a permanent ghat for people—this is your place, this is not; this is daughter, this is daughter-in-law; this belongs to the house, this is outside. But life keeps cutting the bank. On new sand, footprints are made again.

He told this thought to no one. Badri Kaka did not like being publicly so philosophical. He merely checked the bamboo joint and told Arun, “Hold it from this side.”

When the ashes were being gathered, Renuka came forward. No one stopped her. She picked up a piece of bamboo that had half burned black. Badri Kaka said, “Don’t touch it; it may still be hot.”

Renuka let go at once.

At that simple obedience Badri Kaka smiled inwardly. The village imagined this woman as a symbol of breaking rules; here, over a hot bamboo, she withdrew her hand without argument.

The next day Badri Kaka went to Devkant Babu’s house. On the veranda stood an old chair of the same color as his red chair—actually a different chair. Renuka was not sitting on it; she was on the floor looking at papers.

“Kaka,” she said, bowing.

“You live in Delhi?”

“Now in a school in Ghaziabad.”

“You teach?”

“Yes.”

“What?”

“Hindi and social science.”

Badri Kaka frowned. “Not Maithili?”

Renuka laughed. “At home.”

“Where is home?” The question escaped him.

Renuka paused. “That is a difficult question, Kaka.”

Badri Kaka changed the subject at once. He felt people must have asked her that question many times.

“Your Babu came to the ghat less in his last year. But one day he said—Badri, if my daughter comes, don’t say anything to her.”

Renuka went still. “Me?”

“I asked—which daughter? He scolded me.”

Renuka laughed, then her eyes grew wet. “Babu said that?”

“Why would I lie?”

Badri Kaka said it, but immediately remembered the courtroom in Story 39. In testimony, “Why would I lie?” had been one of the weakest kinds of sentence. He corrected himself: “That is how I remember it. The words may not have been exact.”

Renuka nodded.

On the day of the shraddha, Badri Kaka sat among the crowd. Food, leaf plates, water, offerings, the priest's instructions. Renuka kept busy—sometimes water, sometimes plates, sometimes a seat for an old woman. No one made her the center of the ritual; no one kept her outside either.

Badri Kaka thought—the village changes less through declarations than through scenes like this.

On the day she was to leave, Renuka went alone toward the ghat. Badri Kaka watched from a distance. She sat on the steps for five minutes, touched the water, then rose. She floated no flowers, recited no mantra.

Badri Kaka could have made meaning here too. This time he did not.

There are many footprints at a ghat. The river does not ask for an interpretation of each one.

5

Rahman the tailor had stitched the red blouse for Renuka's wedding.

Now his shop had become half tailoring shop, half mobile-recharge counter. His son ran the machine, his grandson checked payments on a phone. Rahman Mian's eyesight had weakened, but his old pride in remembering measurements remained.

When Renuka came to the market for shraddha supplies, she stopped in front of the shop.

“Do you recognize me?”

Rahman Mian pushed up his glasses. “The voice is Renuka's, the face is her mother's.”

Renuka came inside.

“Do you still remember my red blouse?”

“I remember the measurements too.”

“Lie.”

“If a tailor forgets measurements, he should leave the profession.”

Both laughed.

Rahman Mian remembered that wedding clearly—Devkant Babu bargaining over the price, Renuka's mother wanting the neckline a little lower, Devkant Babu saying “no,” Renuka interrupting, “Who is going to wear it, Babu or me?” The whole shop had laughed.

After the marriage broke, Rahman Mian's shop had become an information center for the village. People came to give cloth and, under that pretext, asked, “What happened?” Someone said Renuka had gone away with a man in the city. Once Rahman Mian had said, “I stitch clothes, not character.” The sentence made him very popular, although he had said it only in irritation.

But he remembered one incident he had never discussed with anyone. Two days before Renuka went to Patna, she had come to the shop. Not with the red wedding sari, but to have an ordinary blue suit stitched. While taking her measurements, he had seen an old blue mark on her arm. Rahman Mian saw it but did not ask. Whether it was from a blow or from striking a door, he did not know.

To make that one bruise the proof of the entire collapse of the marriage seemed wrong to him. To act as if he had not seen it might also have been wrong. Even after twenty years he was not certain.

"How many days will you stay?" he asked.

"Until the shraddha. My ticket is for the day after."

"Will you sell the house?"

Renuka laughed. "Kaka, you too?"

"I'm a shopkeeper. I ask market questions."

"The house is Arun's."

"Nothing is yours?"

"I have a share in the orchard."

"Then we'll eat mangoes."

"I'll send them."

Rahman Mian shook his head. "No. Mangoes do not come by post. They come with a person."

Renuka was silent for a moment. "Then I'll have to come."

Rahman Mian did not seize the sentence as a promise. Old people place burdens on the young by holding on to promises. He merely said, "The shop will still be here, if a mall hasn't swallowed it."

After Renuka left the market, his son asked, "This is the same Didi whose husband left her, isn't it?"

Rahman Mian stopped the machine. "I don't know who left whom."

"But in the village they say..."

"The village says many things."

"What do you know?"

Rahman Mian thought—should he mention the bruise? No.

"I know only this much: she wanted her clothes stitched to her own measurements."

Rahman Mian's son started the machine again, but the sentence remained in the shop. For a tailor, "measurement" is not only the measure of the body. Some like a loose fit, some close; some do not want the cut of an old garment changed, some open it entirely and make a new pattern. The same cloth does not sit the same way on every body.

He remembered the blue suit he had stitched when Renuka was leaving for Patna. The neckline was plain, the sleeves full-length, the two pockets large. Renuka had specifically said, "Make the pockets strong." Rahman Mian had joked, "What will you keep in so much pocket?" She had said, "Keys, money, pen."

Now he thought: when a woman changes her life, does she need pockets first or courage? The question was pointless. Very often she needs both.

Outside the shop two customers passed discussing Renuka. One said, "Returning after so many years—it must be for the orchard." The other said,

"No, man, her father died." Rahman Mian heard them and did not intervene. Not every rumor can be repaired with stitching; some are unpicked by the friction of time itself.

His son laughed. "What kind of answer was that?"

"A tailor's."

On the day of the shraddha, Rahman Mian went to Devkant Babu's house to eat. From a distance he saw Renuka distributing leaf plates. An elderly woman stopped her and said, "Daughter, let the daughter-in-law do this work." Renuka immediately handed the plates to Meena and picked up the bucket of water.

Rahman Mian smiled. A person may want to change roles; society moves slowly in giving a new role. Sometimes she resists, sometimes she lifts the bucket. Both can be true.

Before leaving, Renuka left a bag at the shop. Inside were two of Devkant Babu's old kurtas.

"What is this?"

"The cloth is good. Can you make something for Anshu?"

Rahman Mian opened the kurtas. One corner was worn; the sleeve of the other was sound.

"Something can be made."

"What?"

"We'll see. First the cloth will tell us."

Renuka laughed. "Cloth speaks?"

"All old things speak. A tailor simply has to add less."

Renuka left. Rahman Mian folded the kurtas and put them away. In truth he did not remember the measurements of the red blouse. But he felt no need to say so. Memory too works like tailoring—it cuts some things, adds some things, hides some stitching inside.

Two days later Anshu came to be measured. Rahman Mian opened Devkant Babu's kurta and spread it before him. "This will make a shoulder bag for you, and the leftover cloth will make book covers."

Anshu was disappointed. "Not clothes?"

"The body of the kurta is worn. If I force it into another garment, it will tear after two washes."

Anshu asked, "Did Bua say what to make?"

"No. She said—let the cloth decide."

Rahman Mian thought perhaps one could find a metaphor for Renuka's return in that. But he did not impose such a decorative thought on his customer. The old cloth would take a new form. That was enough.

6

For Anshu, Bua had first been a photograph on a mobile phone.

There were two photographs of Renuka in the house—one from the wedding, in which she wore heavy jewelry; another from some school program in Delhi, with an identity card around her neck. Anshu knew both

were the same person, but the twenty years between the photographs were for him like a chapter of history—read, not lived.

His mother spoke little about Renuka Bua. His father sometimes said “Didi” on the phone. Sometimes late at night Dada would hold the mobile to his ear and speak softly in Maithili; when Anshu asked, he would say, “Your Bua.”

Once Anshu had asked for the phone. “I want to talk.”

Dada had said, “Later.”

Later never came.

Now Bua was in the house. On the first day Anshu kept watching her. Would she tell stories of the city? Delhi? School? Why the marriage had broken? His friends had already supplied the question: “Did your Bua run away?”

Anshu had fought with them then. But he himself did not know the answer.

During the thirteen days he saw Bua doing many small things in the house. Sometimes dusting Dada’s books, sometimes cutting vegetables with Mother, sometimes alone on the roof. She did not give many sermons. This disappointed Anshu too—why was the city Bua so ordinary?

One night the electricity went out. A small lamp burned in the courtyard. Mother was in the kitchen, Father outside with visitors. Anshu and Bua sat on the veranda.

Anshu asked, “Bua, did you run away?”

Renuka did not start. “Who said so?”

“People at school.”

“What do you think?”

“I don’t know.”

“Then for now that is the correct answer.”

Anshu was dissatisfied. “But what happened?”

Renuka looked at the lamp flame. “I left the house I married into. Later I left this house too. People make the two into one story.”

“Why did you leave?”

“The life I needed was not being made in the first house. When I returned here, everyone wanted me to go back there. I did not. Then it became difficult to live here too.”

“Did Dada throw you out?”

Renuka was silent a long time. “No. It would not be right to say that.”

“Then?”

“Sometimes a house does not say ‘go.’ It simply becomes such that staying grows harder and harder. And sometimes the person herself makes it harder too.”

“You?”

“Me too.”

For the first time Anshu heard an adult accept her own part. The answer felt less like a story than a doorway—open, but not showing the entire inside.

“Why didn’t you marry again?”

Renuka laughed. “You asked that like a very old man.”

"Answer?"

"I did not feel like it. That's all."

To Anshu, "that's all" seemed a very small answer. But he did not ask again.

The next day he accidentally heard the discussion about the orchard papers. Mother was saying, "Bua won't sell her share." Father said, "All right."

Anshu went to Bua. "Is the orchard yours?"

"Half of it, on paper."

"Can I do a project there?"

"Whose permission do you need?"

"Yours."

Renuka smiled. "And your mother and father's, who look after it."

Anshu learned something from that answer that was not in the chapter on "property rights" in his textbook. A right on paper and a right created by work can cut across each other, and can also sustain each other.

The following day Bua took him to the orchard. After telling Meena, the two walked. On the way Anshu walked a little faster past his friends' houses; he did not want someone to joke again about "the Bua who ran away." Whether Renuka understood the sudden speed or not, Anshu could not tell.

The orchard lay behind the village. Many trees were new; two old mango trees had thick trunks. Renuka placed a hand on the rough bark of one. "This is still here?"

"You know it?"

"I used to climb it as a child."

Anshu looked up. He could not believe that Bua, who now wore schoolteacher spectacles, had once climbed so high. "Didn't you fall?"

"I fell too."

"Did Dada scold you?"

"A lot."

There was a rusted lock on the back shed in the orchard. From her ring of keys Renuka took out a small brass key. At first the lock would not open. She turned it twice, brushed away dust, and then it opened with a creak. Inside were an old hoe, a bamboo basket, dry rope, a broken lantern, and a long bamboo pole for plucking mangoes.

"Who owns all this?" Anshu asked.

Renuka said, "First, whoever can use it. Paper may say something else."

Anshu wanted to lift the broken lantern. Renuka stopped him. "There is still glass in it; you'll cut your hand." Then together they left the shed door open for a while so the dampness inside could escape.

On the way back Renuka put the key in her pocket. Anshu did not yet know that on the day she left, the same key would come into his fist.

On the day of the shraddha, Anshu kept seeing Bua through different people's eyes. Phoolmati Kaki touched her head; Shyama Mausi laughed with her; Mother silently counted leaf plates beside her; Badri Kaka laughed over some old story; Rahman the tailor raised a hand from far away. Anshu understood that a person does not return to a house in a single form, but in many.

That night Anshu sat to write a school essay in his notebook: “My Family.” His first line was: “In my family there was Dada, there are Father and Mother, one brother, and a Bua in Delhi.”

Then he crossed out “in Delhi.”

He wrote: “I have a Bua who lives in Delhi.”

It was slightly different. The place did not come before the person.

On the morning she was to leave, Renuka’s suitcase was again on the veranda. One wheel was slightly bent. Arun had gone to call a rickshaw. Meena was tying up a food box. Phoolmati Kaki had come to the door. Shyama too. In Pipra, farewells are rarely private.

Anshu asked, “When will you come again?”

Renuka kept hold of the suitcase handle. “I won’t give a date yet.”

Phoolmati Kaki immediately said, “Not a date—make up your mind and come.”

Everyone laughed.

Renuka gave Anshu a small key.

“What is this?”

“The back shed in the orchard. Dada gave it to me once. I took it with me. Now you keep it.”

Meena watched from a distance. For a moment her face tightened, then relaxed. “Anshu, don’t lose it.”

Anshu closed the key in his fist. “Is it mine now?”

Renuka said, “The key is with you. The shed is for everyone’s use. Learn the difference.”

The rickshaw came. The suitcase was loaded. Renuka bowed to everyone. As she passed through the gate, she turned once and looked back toward the house—not for long.

Anshu thought that in films this was where a person cried or waved a hand. Bua only looked, then sat in the rickshaw.

At the bend in the road the rickshaw disappeared.

People in the house turned back toward one another. Leaf plates had to be gathered, utensils washed, leftover grain distributed, guests seen off. After both death and farewell, work remains.

Anshu stood alone on the veranda for a while. The brass key had grown warm in his fist. Inside, in Dada’s room, the small lamp was still burning; daylight had grown strong, yet the flame could still be seen clearly.

When he went to school in the afternoon, his friends asked questions again. “Bua went back?” Anshu said yes. “Did she take the orchard?” someone asked. Anshu did not quarrel as before. He only said, “She has a share on paper; we will do the work.” His friends did not find the answer entertaining; gossip needs a clear quarrel.

After reading his essay on the family, the teacher asked Anshu, “Why did you cross out ‘Bua in Delhi’ and write ‘Bua who lives in Delhi?’” Anshu searched for an answer.

“Because... Delhi is her place, not her name.”

The teacher smiled slightly. “All right.”

Anshu was not completely sure the answer was correct. But it seemed to him that it was a mistake to shut a person entirely inside the name of a place.

Pipra was one of Bua's places; the city another. The road between them was also part of her life.

He put the key in his pocket.

He still did not know whether Bua was brave, guilty, proud, wounded, a stranger, or simply Renuka. Perhaps all those words were doors belonging to different people.

For the first time, Anshu felt that a person herself was like a house—in which not every room opens for everyone at the same time.

And some keys, even when found, do not give only the right to open; they also give the responsibility of entering.

— *End of Story 46* —

47. The Boat

STORY

I

To both Gopi and Jhunki, the sand on the far side of the river looked like another country.

Seen from Pipra Ghat, the far bank was not very far away. In winter, when the water fell, a bar of sand appeared in the middle. People could even cross through knee-deep water. But after the rains the current of the Kamala was still well filled. The water looked calm on the surface and ran fast beneath. Bamboo poles stood at the ghat, and the elders kept telling the children the same thing: "Look from the bank; do not go into the current."

Gopi had grown tired of hearing that every day.

"Do not go into the current" sounded to him just like "Do not touch the utensils," "Do not climb onto the roof," and "Do not stay outside after dusk." The world of grown-ups seemed fenced with the thorns of prohibition.

Jhunki did not count prohibitions. She asked for reasons.

"Why not?"

The answer was usually the same: "Because it is a river."

Jhunki would say, "So what if it is a river?"

Then her mother would answer, "Because a river is a river."

Jhunki did not like that answer, but she understood that for now there would be no better one.

That day, on their way back from school, the two stopped at the ghat. Two dry leaves spun in circles on the water and suddenly caught the central current and went sailing away. Three egrets stood on the sand across the river. An old yellow kite was caught in the scrub.

Gopi said, "If that kite were mine, I'd go and bring it back."

Jhunki said, "If it were yours, it would have torn by tomorrow."

"I'll make a boat."

Jhunki looked at him. "Out of paper?"

"A real one."

"You?"

"Me."

"Come on, then. First find some rope."

Gopi had not expected agreement so quickly. Some of the heroism went out of his face.

The first material for the boat was banana trunk.

After the floodwater had fallen, two banana plants in the back garden of Jhunki's maternal grandfather had broken halfway. The trunks were thick and light inside. Jhunki cut off a piece and pushed it into the edge of the pond. It floated.

"See?"

Gopi added thin split lengths of bamboo. "One won't make a boat."

"Four."

"Six."

"Six will be heavy."

"You know?"

"More than you do."

The first rule of boat-building became this: the two would contradict each other about everything, but take turns doing the work.

It took three days. After school, each told the family, "I'm going to play." It was not wholly a lie. Building a boat was play; only grown-ups would not have called that game a game.

Four banana-trunk sections were cut to equal length. Two bamboos were laid crosswise over them. Jhunki had taken old hemp rope from her grandfather, saying it was "for tying a doll." Gopi secretly brought cord from a torn mosquito net at home. An old fertilizer sack was spread across the middle to make a place to sit.

Gopi named the boat "Lightning."

Jhunki said, "Is it a boat or a light bulb?"

"You name it."

After much thought Jhunki said, "Come-Back."

"What kind of name is that?"

"Whoever goes in this boat should come back. Then it is a boat."

Gopi laughed. "And if they don't come back?"

Jhunki was silent for a moment. Then she said, "Then other people will name the boat."

Having said that, she went back to tightening the knot.

The trial was held in the pond. First they loaded stones. Then one brick after another. Then Gopi put one foot on it and the raft tilted to one side. Jhunki shouted, "Sit! Don't stand!"

Gopi sat down. The water came only to his knees, yet his heart began hammering.

They both understood: no standing on the raft.

That became Rule Two.

Gopi made Rule Three: "No jumping into the river."

Jhunki said, "The grown-ups already made that rule."

"I'll put it in our rules."

"Where's the paper?"

"In my head."

"The paper in your head gets wet."

They went home laughing.

They chose Sunday for the crossing.

At dawn everyone at home had work of their own. Gopi's father had gone to the market. His mother was drying paddy on the roof. Jhunki's mother had gone to help with a neighbour's childbirth. Her maternal grandfather had gone towards the temple.

Each of them carried a small bag. Gopi tied up two portions of jaggery and flattened rice. Jhunki packed a bottle of water, a gamchha, and matches.

"Why matches?" Gopi asked.

"What if it becomes night on the other side?"

Gopi first wanted to say that it would not become night. But having matches made the voyage feel more real, so he said nothing.

The raft was hidden in the bushes. They dragged it through the mud. Once it faced the river, it suddenly looked small. What had been a boat in the pond became, at the edge of the current, only four trunks and two bamboos.

Jhunki's feet stopped.

Gopi said, "Are you scared?"

"Yes."

Gopi was scared too. But when another person admits their fear, one's own fear becomes a little easier to hide.

"Me too."

Jhunki looked at him. "Then?"

"Then slowly."

They pushed the raft halfway into the water. Gopi climbed on first, Jhunki behind him. Each held a long bamboo. The bottom could still be reached. They braced the poles against it and pushed the raft forward.

For the first ten handspans, everything was easy.

Gopi said, "See? What happened?"

Before answering, Jhunki planted her bamboo again. This time it found no bottom. The pole went all the way under and pulled her hand a little forward.

"Sit!" Gopi said.

Both dropped low.

Now the raft was moving by itself.

The bank began slowly sliding behind them. The far side no longer appeared straight ahead but at an angle. The water changed from muddy near shore to green-brown in the middle. Small round whirlpools formed beside the raft and broke apart.

Jhunki whispered, "This isn't the pond."

Gopi said, "It's the river."

This time the sentence sounded like an answer.

The children had heard folktales saying that a water-deity lived in the middle of the river. Some said whirlpools were his eyes. Some said a white

horse ran over the water at night. Some said the river asked the name of any child who disobeyed mother and father.

Gopi decided that if the river asked his name, he would give a false one.

Jhunki must have been thinking the same thing, for she suddenly asked, "If someone asks our names, what will we say?"

"Lightning."

"That was the boat's old name."

"Then Come-Back."

"Our names?"

Gopi said nothing.

Both wanted to laugh, but the laughter came only halfway and stopped.

The current was fast. The yellow kite on the far bank no longer lay straight ahead; it was far to the left. The raft was drifting downstream.

Gopi tried to use the bamboo as a paddle. The raft swung around. Jhunki shouted, "Not from only one side!"

They began alternately cutting the water from either side. The raft straightened a little, but did not move much closer to the bank.

"We're being carried away," Jhunki said.

"We're going across too."

"Less."

That was true.

In the distance they saw a boat—a real boat. A dark hull, one man standing in it. Gopi started to rise. Jhunki grabbed his shirt and pulled him down.

"Rule Two!"

Gopi sat again. Both waved their arms and shouted. The wind was against them. They could not tell whether the boatman heard. The boat vanished around a bend.

For the first time Gopi wanted to go home. But the home bank was now behind them, far away and upstream. Going back was no longer merely a matter of wanting to.

5

A thick branch came floating down the current. Jhunki saw it. "Move!"

They braced their poles and turned the raft slightly. The branch struck the rear. One rope gave a sharp creak and loosened. The banana trunk on the right began to pull away.

"Hold it!"

Gopi seized the rope. Jhunki pulled out the gamchha and wound it around the knot. Water was rising around their hands. The raft listed.

"The sand!" Jhunki said.

Now a tongue of sand downstream was nearer than the far bank—a narrow strip rising from mid-river. They both began pushing their poles in the same direction. Sometimes they touched bottom; sometimes they did not.

Gopi's palm was scraped raw. Jhunki's bottle rolled off and fell into the water. She reached for it, but Gopi shouted, "Rule Three!"

The bottle drifted away.

Jhunki watched it go. "Mother will beat me."

"If we return alive, she can."

They laughed again. This time the laughter came out whole, perhaps because the fear had grown too large.

The sandbar came nearer. Gopi planted his pole—bottom. Then Jhunki's pole caught too. Slowly they pushed the raft forward. When it finally lodged in the sand, they sat still for a while.

"Get down?"

"How deep?"

Jhunki tested with the bamboo. "Less than knee-deep."

They climbed off. Their feet sank into the sand. Gopi had never before been so glad to stand on ground.

The sandbar was not the other side. It was a temporary island in the middle. Water lay all around it.

Gopi said, "Did we cross?"

Jhunki looked around. "Half."

6

They dragged the raft onto the sand. They tightened the gamchha knot again. The jaggery and flattened rice were eaten. The water bottle was gone, so Jhunki tried to scoop river water in her palm. Gopi stopped her.

"Don't drink it."

"I'm thirsty."

"People in the village say not to drink river water straight."

"People in the village also say not to go into the river."

Both fell silent.

Jhunki did not drink the water.

There were small tracks on the sandbar. Bird, dog, or jackal—they could not decide. In one place they found a broken piece of a red bangle. Jhunki picked it up.

"The river-queen's?" Gopi said.

"Someone's hand."

"Doesn't a queen have hands?"

"She does. But why would every queen wear red bangles?"

Folklore always lost before Jhunki, but never died altogether.

A voice came from far away. At first indistinct. Then clear: "Gopiiii!"

Gopi's body stiffened.

Another voice: "Jhunkiiii!"

Not their mothers' voices—men's. Perhaps from the ghat.

They looked at one another.

"They found us," Gopi said.

Relief did not come onto Jhunki's face; fear did. "Now we'll be beaten."

The call came again. This time a boat also appeared in the distance. Two men were poling it towards them.

Jhunki waved. Gopi did too.

When the boat came close, one man was Jabbar, Rahman Kaka's younger brother; the other was Bisun the fisherman. Their faces looked as if laughter and anger had become stuck there at the same time.

"Have you two filled your heads with straw?" Jabbar shouted from a distance.

Gopi murmured, "The paper in my head got wet."

Jhunki jabbed him with her elbow.

The boat touched the sand. Bisun first examined the raft, then the knots, then the children's scraped hands.

"Who made this?"

"We did."

Bisun tugged the rope. "The knot isn't bad."

Jabbar glared at him. "Praise them later."

Bisun said, "Saying that what is right inside a bad thing is right does not make the bad thing right."

That sentence lodged in Gopi's head.

7

The two children were seated in the boat. The raft was tied behind with a rope.

On the way back Gopi touched the bottom of the real boat. Heavy wood, high sides, a small tin in the middle for bailing water. His four banana trunks suddenly looked like a toy.

Bisun said, "A raft may float. But a river-crossing boat is not made merely by floating. You have to understand direction, current, load, wind, where to land—everything."

Jhunki asked, "Then isn't ours a boat?"

Bisun looked at the raft tied behind them. "The name you gave it can remain. How much work it can do is another matter."

"Come-Back," Jhunki said.

Bisun laughed. "A good name. Today it did its work too."

As they neared the ghat, they saw the crowd. Gopi's mother and father, Jhunki's mother and grandfather, neighbours, several children. Gopi wished the boat would turn back into the river.

The moment they touched shore, his mother seized him. First she pressed him to her chest, then slapped him twice, then hugged him again. Gopi could not decide which of the three actions was the real one.

Jhunki's mother sniffed the top of her head as though checking whether this was her own child or whether the river had changed her and sent back someone else. Then she twisted her ear.

Her grandfather kept staring at the raft.

"Those banana trunks were mine."

Jhunki, head lowered, said, "Yes."

“The rope?”

“Yours.”

“The mosquito net?” Gopi’s mother asked.

Gopi was silent.

Someone in the crowd laughed. Then, slowly, others did too. The knot of fear loosened a little.

But Gopi’s father did not laugh. He only dragged the raft higher onto the ghat and tied it to a tree.

“It stays here.”

Gopi wondered: as punishment or as memory?

He did not dare ask.

8

That night, in their separate homes, both children heard long scoldings. The river’s depth, last year’s drowning, the speed of the current, the lightness of a child’s body—every example was brought out. Gopi had once heard all of it as the same old prohibition. Now, inside some of those sentences, he could see the colour of the water.

But that did not erase the journey.

The yellow kite was still caught in the scrub on the far side. They had not reached it. The next day on the way to school, Jhunki said, “Forget the kite.”

Gopi said, “I didn’t go for the kite.”

“Then?”

Gopi did not answer. He did not know himself. Perhaps the far side was simply the far side, and that alone had been reason enough.

Their school friends heard the story, half believed it, and enlarged the other half. By evening the news had become that Gopi and Jhunki had fought a seven-hand crocodile in the middle of the Kamala. The next day the crocodile was nine hands long. On the third day people said Jhunki had struck the crocodile on the head with a bamboo.

Jhunki protested, “There wasn’t any crocodile at all.”

A friend said, “Then what kind of story is it?”

Jhunki said, “There was water.”

Everyone laughed.

Jhunki did not. She learned that sometimes a real thing seems less wondrous to a story because people cannot measure its fear.

Two days later Bisun called both of them to the ghat—with their parents’ permission.

He seated them in a real boat without leaving the bank. He showed them how to plant the bamboo, how to hold a paddle, how to cut across the current, and why the weight in a boat must not all be kept on one side.

“If you want to learn the river, don’t do it by stealing away,” he said. “Watch. Ask. Stay with people who know.”

Gopi asked, “When can we cross?”

Bisun said, “When you understand the river, the boat, and your own body a little better—all three.”

"How many days?"

"That isn't measured in days."

Again the answer sounded like something grown-ups said, but this time Gopi did not feel angry.

9

A week later preparations began to clean the Chhath ghat. The raft was still tied to the same tree. The banana trunks had dried and shrunk a little. Mud had crusted on the rope.

Several smaller children came to touch it.

"Is this that boat?"

Gopi puffed out his chest, then looked at Jhunki.

Jhunki said, "A raft."

"What's its name?"

"Come-Back."

One small child asked, "Did it cross?"

Gopi was about to say, "Yes."

Jhunki answered first, "Halfway."

Gopi thought for a moment, then added, "And it came all the way back."

Evening light lay on the water. Bamboos were being planted at the ghat. Far away, the yellow kite was no longer visible on the opposite bank—the wind may have carried it off, it may have torn, or someone may have taken it.

For a moment Gopi felt sad, and then he did not. The far bank was still there. So was the river.

Together they tightened the rope around the raft. For one instant both wanted to untie it and put it back into the river. Neither said anything.

Jhunki ran her hand over the knot and said, "Its name was right."

"Why?"

"Because it came back."

Gopi looked at the river. "We came back."

Jhunki nodded.

The water kept flowing. The bank stood still. And between the two, the little raft tied to the tree caught just enough evening light that, seen from a distance, someone might have mistaken it for a real boat.

— End of Story 47 —

48. Chhath Again

STORY

I

At Pipra's first Chhath-ghat committee meeting this year, no quarrel broke out over four lengths of bamboo. All four were stored neatly behind the school veranda. The southern slope had already been repaired the previous winter, no one proposed tying a permanent rope to create a separate assistance lane, and the five representatives of the women's group had taken their seats before the meeting began.

The quarrel was over the red chair.

The same old red plastic chair, with a small crack in the right arm and "B.K." written on the back in black ink. Badri Kaka had died in Phagun. His grandson had brought the chair in the morning and left it on the school veranda. "Grandfather told me to keep it safe until the next Chhath."

Ramlochan Babu kept looking at the chair. Nandu Sah opened the ledger and closed it again. Gaurishankar Jha asked, "Will we leave it sitting here empty?"

Sunaina Devi said, "If someone needs to sit, they'll sit. Why should the chair observe mourning?"

Sukhdev Sahni laughed. "If Kaka were here, he would say it himself—the chair may be public; my knees are not."

Laughter rose, but only halfway. The other half remained beside the empty chair.

2

The committee had written down many things after the previous Chhath. At this year's first meeting Nandu Sah opened those old pages. "Gloves—the first item."

Champa Devi opened the box on the table. Inside were twenty pairs of blue gloves. She pulled one onto her hand; her fingers stuck halfway out.

"Whose hand is this size?"

Nandu Sah looked at the paper. "Standard size."

"Where does the standard human being live?"

The veranda filled with laughter again. In the end they decided to buy half in a smaller size and half larger. Champa said, "See? Written rules change a little as soon as they touch the mud of the ghat."

This year the market association had already made its banner smaller. Instead of last year's strip six hands wide, it was only two hands. The president himself had said, "It is enough if the name appears in photographs."

Sukhdev asked, "Will the river appear?"

The president laughed. "This year we won't cover the river."

These small changes arrived without the triumph of resolutions. No one said Pipra had changed. It was only that some sentences did not need to be spoken this time.

3

On the day the ghat was cleaned, Champa's group reached before dawn. This year committee members came at seven instead of arriving at ten merely to be photographed. Nandu Sah himself wore gloves—his pair was far too large. Every time he gripped the spade, the glove twisted around.

Champa said, "The standard hand."

Nandu Sah replied, "Next year we'll write down the measurements."

The new soil on the southern slope had settled. A bamboo railing had been built beside the concrete steps, not to divide the path but to give people something to hold on the slippery descent. Sukhdev checked the knots and said, "This year let the bamboo be support, not a boundary."

Under a tree above the ghat lay dried banana trunks and a length of old rope. Two children stood looking at them and whispering. Champa asked, "Trash?"

One child immediately said, "No—a boat."

Champa looked at it for a moment, then turned her broom another way.

The red chair was brought down to the ghat as well. It was placed above the concrete steps against the wall. No nameplate was attached. No flowers or garland. Just the chair.

4

Before the first evening offering, a new quarrel broke out over the loudspeaker. The temple group wanted the bhajans louder; the shopkeepers wanted announcements to be audible; three families living near the ghat said their children had not slept the previous night.

Testing the microphone, Gaurishankar Jha said, "If the sound carries far, the arrangements will work better."

Sunaina Devi asked, "Does the information need to travel far, or the noise?"

This time Nandu Sah did not open the ledger. He simply told the boy at the microphone, "Half."

The boy turned it down by half. Five minutes later he raised it a little again. Champa pointed a finger from a distance. He lowered it once more.

Ramlochan Babu smiled. Last year a meeting had spent half a day over four bamboos. This year the argument over sound ended in ten minutes. The

problems had not disappeared; some of them had merely stopped becoming large.

5

At dusk the crowd began descending. There was no separate rope for an assistance lane. Volunteers stood wearing yellow sashes. Whoever needed support was given a hand; whoever did not was given the way.

An elderly man came to the red chair and stopped. His breathing was fast. A volunteer immediately pulled the chair forward. The man was about to sit when someone whispered, "That is Badri Kaka's..."

The volunteer's hand stopped.

Sunaina Devi was standing nearby. She gripped the chair by the back and slid it under the old man. "Kaka said to save the chair, not to keep people standing."

The old man sat. Five minutes later he rose and thanked them. The chair was empty again. Then a pregnant woman sat. Then a mother carrying a nursing child. Then Champa herself sat for two minutes and drank tea.

All evening the chair belonged privately to no one, yet it was not empty of anyone's memory either.

6

Clouds gathered just before the offering. In Pipra, the sight of clouds on Chhath day immediately produces five kinds of forecast. One person said it would drizzle; another said the river wind would drive the clouds away; someone else recalled that an earlier year had begun just like this.

At the first drop, two members of the market association ran to protect their small banner. Sukhdev ran to check the boat ropes. Champa placed a sack of ash beside the concrete steps. Volunteers guided the elderly towards the railing.

No one spoke the word "arrangement." Everyone simply did their work.

The drizzle lasted five minutes, then stopped. The steps shone. Champa scattered ash. Nandu Sah lifted the sack too. This time there was no one taking photographs.

The microphone crackled once more and went dead, just as it had the previous year. But this time, instead of inspecting the wire, the announcer signalled with his hand: descend slowly. People descended slowly. The sound of the river could be heard again. A song rose from one side and travelled to the other.

7

There was no mist at the dawn offering. The sky was clear. The yellow bulb above the concrete steps was still burning, but as eastern light grew, its colour began to fade.

Ramvati Devi came without her mother-in-law. The old woman who had sat on the cot the previous year had died in the summer. This time Ramvati carried the daura on her own head. A hand reached out to assist her. She said, "Take the daura; I can go down myself."

The volunteer took the daura. She held the railing and descended.

On the other side of the ghat, Badri Kaka's grandson was wiping the red chair. Nandu Sah asked, "Why don't you sit?"

The boy said, "My knees are fine."

Nandu Sah burst out laughing.

The sun rose. A white line appeared on the water. The offerings were lifted. This year four bamboos were still present at the ghat, but two were in the railing and two were holding the electric wire. No bamboo was being used to divide anyone's path.

8

After Chhath ended, the committee met again on the school veranda. On the table lay leftover thekua, the account book, two useless pairs of oversized gloves, and a small sheet listing three things for the next year: a limit for the loudspeaker, a first-aid box, and one additional volunteer at the lower bend of the river.

Gaurishankar Jha said, "Fewer resolutions this year."

Champa replied, "More of the work had already been done."

Nandu Sah read the accounts. No one interrupted to ask about a reserved passage for donors. No one counted the number of women representatives. No one called the southern slope "that side."

As Ramlochan Babu signed, he suddenly looked towards the empty space. The red chair stood near the edge of the veranda. No one had sat in it during the meeting. At the ghat it had borne many people's fatigue all day, but here at the meeting it remained empty.

Sukhdev saw it too. "In the end Kaka's reservation survived only at the meeting."

This time the laughter rose whole. The chair remained empty.

9

When the meeting ended, Badri Kaka's grandson came to take the chair away. The previous year this same child had carried it on his head while walking in front. Now he had grown a little taller and carried it in one hand.

Ramlochan Babu asked, "Will you bring it again next year?"

The boy thought for a moment. "If it's needed."

"Who will need it?"

The boy looked at the chair, then towards the ghat. "Whoever gets tired."

He walked away with the chair. No one had any further answer to give.

10

On the third day after Chhath, the bamboo railing of the assistance path acquired a new use. Boatmen began spreading wet nets over it to dry. Women who came in the morning to wash clothes complained that the hooks in the nets caught their garments. Schoolchildren held the railing and swung from it. The bamboo that had been support on Chhath day became, on ordinary days, an object of dispute again.

Gaurishankar Jha said, "The railing was built only for safety."

Sukhdev asked, "Safety only for Chhath, or for the whole year?"

"The whole year."

"Then the net-men are at the ghat all year too."

Champa said, "Dry the nets on one side; leave the middle handhold free. That's all."

No meeting was held for this small decision. It was not entered in any book of resolutions. Four people standing there talked it through; the nets moved to one side, and the way opened.

When Ramlochan Babu later heard, his first thought was: a decision without asking the committee? Then he remembered two days from the previous year. He said nothing.

In Pipra, arrangements sometimes began on paper and sometimes in people's hands. Neither could completely replace the other.

11

The red chair returned to Badri Kaka's house and was placed again in the courtyard. His grandson washed it with water. A hot nail was used to make a small hole beside the crack in the right arm, and wire was tied through it. The "B.K." written on the back had half faded; the grandson did not darken it again.

A neighbour said, "Give it to the committee. It can remain at the ghat in Badri Kaka's memory."

The old Kaki of the household said, "If memory is kept at the ghat, does that make the house empty?"

The man fell silent.

Kaki sat in the chair and began cutting vegetables. Her knees hurt too. The grandson laughed. "Grandfather used to say, the chair may be public..."

Kaki stopped him halfway. "I know the rest of the sentence."

The chair became a household object again—sometimes Kaki used it, sometimes a guest, sometimes the grandson. For two days of Chhath it had gone to the ghat, and then returned home.

Badri Kaka's absence did not grow smaller; but slowly there was less need to keep the chair empty in order to prove his presence.

12

A week later Ramlochan Babu went to the school to close the committee ledger. The previous year's resolutions, this year's accounts, Champa's receipt

for the gloves, the application for repair of the southern slope—all went into one file.

Turning the pages, he found Badri Kaka's name nowhere. It had not appeared in the previous year's resolutions either. He had existed only in the meetings, in sentences, in laughter, in the red chair.

For a moment Ramlochan thought of writing "Late Badri..." Then he stopped his pen. A committee ledger was not a memorial to the dead. Not everything left unwritten on paper was therefore erased.

He closed the file. The veranda was empty. Last year four bamboos had lain here; this year, the red chair. Now there was nothing.

The river could be heard outside. Ramlochan locked the school gate and walked towards the ghat.

The ghat was becoming an ordinary ghat again. The market people were taking down the banner. Champa's group was collecting rubbish. Sukhdev was loosening the knots on a boat. Two children under a tree were tightening the rope of a dried raft. The river did not flow according to anyone's calculation of whether the festival had ended.

The first evening light fell on the water. Unlike the previous year, the flame did not seem to break repeatedly into separate pieces; this time the water was calm, and for a few moments the light ran like one long line. Then the current broke it at the bend.

Ramlochan Babu looked at that line, then towards the veranda where even the red chair was no longer present. An empty space remained, but the meaning of the empty space was not the same as it had been the previous year.

The Kamala kept flowing. No one at the ghat announced that Pipra had changed. Before the next Chhath, many things would change again, and many would not. It was enough that this year old arguments did not require quite as much force to be repeated.

— End of Story 48 —

49. Videha

STORY

I

On the day the old iron trunk was opened in Jagdamba Devi's house, there was no electricity. Rain fell outside; water dripped through the roof in two places inside, and the courtyard drain had filled. Naina first set down a bucket, then switched on the light on her phone. Jagdamba Devi immediately said, "That light will spoil the colour of the papers. Bring the lamp."

Naina laughed. "Can paper tell the difference between a phone's light and a lamp's?"

The paper may not. The eyes can.

Anupama, who had been wringing out wet clothes on the veranda, came inside and brought out a small brass lamp. It was not the lamp from Jagdamba Devi's wedding, as she sometimes claimed; it had come much later. But there was an old scratch along its rim whose story three different members of the family told in three different ways. Naina had never decided where the lamp had truly come from. She liked that an object could hold a fact while stories changed around it.

The trunk had been locked for years. The key used to stay inside Jagdamba Devi's pillowcase, but the pillow had been changed, and no one remembered whether the key had been moved into the new cover. In the end Anupama found it in an old spice tin. "Why here?" Naina asked. Anupama said, "Perhaps Mother put it there." Jagdamba Devi answered at once, "I did not."

When the lock opened, what rose from inside was not the smell of metal but a mingled smell of old paper, cloth, and damp. On top lay a white dhoti, beneath it a sari with a red border, and under that a tied bundle of papers. Two words were written on the bundle: "House Papers."

Naina wondered—which part of a house lives in its papers? Land? Birth? Marriage? Debt? Letters? Recipes? A woman's grief written in her own hand? She did not ask the question then. First the window was shut, another bucket was placed beneath the drip, and the lamp was moved to the right side of the trunk.

The first bundle was a copy of the Panji. The family did not possess the original volume; these were pages copied at some point from a Panjekar, with later additions in newer hands. Men's names ran in sequence—father, son, grandson. Women appeared in marriage notes: “daughter of so-and-so,” “married at such-and-such place,” “two children.” Sometimes a name was written in full, sometimes only its first letter.

Jagdamba Devi asked for her spectacles. “Where is my name here?”

Anupama turned the page. “Here—‘Devnath married in the Madhubani pargana...’ and then...”

“Am I a pargana?” Jagdamba Devi laughed.

Naina reached for her phone to take a photograph. Jagdamba Devi stopped her hand. “Read first.”

In the middle of the page one branch was incomplete. After two names, the record jumped directly to the next generation. The ink there had not faded; the paper was not torn. There were simply no names. Naina immediately began to infer—had someone been removed? Jagdamba Devi read her face. “Do not make a story the moment you see a blank. I do not know either.”

Then she took a thin notebook from the bottom of the trunk. Its cover was blue, its corners worn. On the first page, in Jagdamba Devi's hand, were the words: “Names on Mother's Side.” Then came a succession of women—mother, grandmother, grandmother's mother, aunt, sister, daughter, daughter's daughter—alongside not illnesses but songs and skills: “knew how to dry makhana,” “rowed a boat during the flood,” “told the stories of Saurath beautifully,” “first to send her daughter to school,” “kept the household going by sewing.”

Anupama looked at the page for a long time. “When did you write this?”

“When I understood that half the house was not in the book.”

“Did you ever show it to anyone?”

“I did not write it to show anyone. I wrote it so I would remember.”

Naina did not photograph the Panji just then. She first read every page of the blue notebook under changing light. She began to understand that lineage was not only what had been written down; it was also what some woman in the household had quietly taken into her own hands to record.

The second bundle contained letters: postcards, inland letters, blue airmail envelopes, some without stamps, some without addresses. The moment Anupama opened one she recognized it. “Mama sent this from Kuwait.”

Jagdamba Devi corrected her. “The first time, from Doha. Kuwait came later.”

The letters spoke less about money than about weather. “The air here is hot.” “At night we go up to the roof.” “I miss the smell of the village pond.” “Mother, do not send pickle; it gets held up at customs.” One line would be in Maithili, the next in Hindi, followed by a broken-English address.

Migration bundles language too, Naina thought, like belongings tied for a journey.

Some letters were Anupama's from Delhi, from her first year at college. "Mother, here people hear my speech and then ask—say that again." In one letter she had written, "Sometimes I speak my language softly so no one will hear." In a letter from the following year the sentence had changed: "Now if someone laughs, I say it again, louder."

Anupama took the letter from Naina's hand. "This will not be published."

Naina looked startled. "When did I say I was going to publish it?"

"Your eyes are saying it."

Jagdamba Devi laughed, but Anupama did not. "Finding a paper does not give everyone a right to it. Some things were written because they were meant to be sent. Some things were written because they could not be said to anyone. Those are not the same."

In that bundle there was also an unsent letter. Only "Didi" was written at the top. Inside were words about a broken marriage, returning home, other people's questions, and being unable to tell one's mother anything. No names appeared. The last line said: "I want someone to let me tell my story in my own mouth."

Naina put the letter back into its envelope. Anupama watched her. "That too?"

"Not unless the writer gives permission."

Jagdamba Devi straightened the lamp wick. "Good. Write down that rule."

4

The rules really were written down—at first not on paper but in an empty file on Naina's computer. She titled it: "House Papers: Rules of Work."

1. If the writer is alive, no private paper without the writer's permission.
2. If the writer is dead, whether a paper should be published will not be decided merely in the name of "history"; its effect on living family members must also be considered.
3. Do not fill blank spaces with conjecture.
4. If a person cannot write, transcribe their speech, then read it back or play it back and obtain approval.
5. While "cleaning" language, do not erase the voice.
6. Do not leave a woman's name reduced to "so-and-so's daughter/wife."

On hearing the sixth rule, Jagdamba Devi said, "And do not reduce a man's name to someone's husband or father either. Everyone has a name of their own."

A seventh rule was added.

Naina had thought of the work as a digital archive of the family. Anupama stopped her. "First decide what we are preserving. Papers? Stories? Evidence? Or our own feelings?"

Naina did not answer. The question had never seemed difficult to her before. To a scanner, every page becomes an image of one size; not so to a life.

That night the three of them scanned only ten pages. The incomplete branch of the Panji was left exactly as it was. In the file note Naina wrote: "Gap in the original; reason unknown." The first page of the blue notebook was scanned, but pages containing private remarks went into a "family-restricted" folder. Anupama's old letter was scanned, but not placed in the public folder.

The work was slow. Jagdamba Devi was pleased. "Truth does not ask for hurried work."

5

A week later the water rose again. It was not a flood, only the monsoon spread of the Kamala and the smaller channels, but water climbed into the low ground behind the house. It was no longer safe to keep the trunk in the inner courtyard. All three bundles were carried to the upstairs room.

Devnath Babu's old wooden box was there too. Jagdamba Devi said, "Leave it. Termites have already eaten it."

Anupama opened it anyway. Inside were two cassettes, a small diary, a lump of earth tied in red cloth, and newspaper clippings. The diary was not Devnath Babu's. It belonged to his younger sister Vimala.

In the family Vimala had been known as "very quiet." In the diary, that silence appeared in another form. She had written down women's songs from the household, market prices, how far floodwater had risen, which child had gone to school, which woman had spoken for the first time in the panchayat hall—things of that kind. Between them were her own sentences: "Where will my name remain on paper?"

Jagdamba Devi took the diary in her hands. For a long while she said nothing. "She never showed me this."

"Shall we publish it?" Naina asked.

Jagdamba Devi did not answer at once. "Ask her daughter first."

Vimala's daughter Seema lived near Janakpur in Nepal. On the phone Naina told her everything. Seema was silent at first, then said, "I knew Mother wrote. But there may be private things in the diary."

"There are."

"Do not print everything. Read the songs and the village notes and send them to me. I will give permission for whatever seems right."

After ending the call, Naina placed a slip over the diary: "Permission pending."

Outside, the water touched the first brick at the doorway and receded. Anupama watched from the window. "Water does not read paper, but it does select—the one kept lower gets wet."

Naina said, "That is why copies must be made."

Jagdamba Devi added, "And that is why you must not imagine that the copy has taken the place of the original."

The work might have remained inside the family had Shashank's voice message not arrived. Shashank was Anupama's cousin and had worked in the Gulf for twenty years. Naina had sent him a photograph of an old letter—not one containing anything private, but a postcard in which Shashank had written that from his first earnings he would send “red slippers for Mother.”

Shashank sent a voice message: “I do not remember writing anything like that. Did Mother ever wear the red slippers?”

Jagdamba Devi remembered. “She wore them for two years. They were washed away in the flood.”

Naina sent back the answer. In his next message Shashank spent five minutes telling the story of his first night abroad: eight men in one room, one fan, everyone speaking a different language, no mobile phones, a queue to call home. At the end he said, “If you want to write this, write it. But when you make my speech better, do not erase my fear.”

That sentence changed the direction of the work. Naina no longer wanted only to scan old papers; she wanted to preserve living voices too.

Naina transcribed Shashank's speech. She did not turn “I could not cry the first night” into “I was deeply distressed.” She did not turn “earning money” into “economic opportunity.” She kept the Maithili in Shashank's mixed speech, and left the Arabic words that had entered his everyday work without explanatory notes.

Anupama read the transcript. “This is moving beyond family history.”

Naina said, “Perhaps family history was already beyond the family. Only the papers had been kept inside.”

Jagdamba Devi listened to Shashank's voice again. “He told his own story himself. That is good.”

The next day Seema gave permission to publish five pages from Vimala's diary—the songs, flood notes, the account of a daughter going to school, and that line: “Where will my name remain on paper?” The pages about the private marital dispute remained closed.

Now Naina had two voices—one of a dead woman, with the family's permission; one of a living migrant, with his own permission. For the first time she understood that building a platform was harder than building a museum.

Anupama did not like the idea of a platform. “The moment you say platform, people think performance. Are we going to turn people's suffering into an exhibition?”

“Then what?”

“A booklet.”

Jagdamba Devi said, “The word booklet makes me think of a pharmaceutical company's leaflet.”

All three laughed.

They began searching for a name. “House Papers” was too narrow. “Our Voice” sounded too much like a proclamation. At “Soil,” Anupama asked, “Where did the water go?” At “Water and Soil,” Naina said, “Where did the people go?”

Jagdamba Devi got up in the middle of the discussion. It was time for her evening medicine. When she returned, she brought an old envelope. On it, in Devnath Babu’s hand, there was only one word: “Videha.” Nothing was inside.

“What is this?”

“Your grandfather used to talk about bringing out a journal. He never did. He had made the envelope.”

Anupama smiled. “Then are we completing his unfinished work?”

Jagdamba Devi shook her head. “No. His work was his. Your work is yours. If you like the name, keep it. Do not make it a burden by calling it ‘Grandfather’s dream.’”

Naina turned the envelope in her hand. Inside the word “Videha” lay a region, an echo of old philosophy, and also the sense of being beyond the body; but the meaning that seemed most useful to her now was that no single body, family, or lineage could contain the whole story.

Anupama said, “We can keep the name, but on the first page we must state clearly—this is not a lineage register, not a certificate of proof.”

Jagdamba Devi added, “And not the mouthpiece of a single household either.”

That was how the name “Videha” was settled. There was no vote. Agreement formed slowly, the way silt settles in a pond after rain.

8

For the first issue, more material came from outside the family than from within it. Anupama told people she knew from her old school not “Send us a story,” but “Send whatever you yourself wish to say.” The difference between those two sentences became clear very quickly.

From Pipra, Champa sent a short piece: an account of the women’s group cleaning the Chhath ghat—gloves, rubbish, and the way the women made rules for their own work amid the men’s committee meetings. She mentioned the red chair in one sentence, without naming anyone.

Munni, the disciple of an elderly folk singer, sent a voice message. “I do not know the full name of the raga, but at this turn my grandmother used to lower the note.” She sang the song and sent it. Naina wanted to make a written version, but Munni said, “Half of it will remain if only the notes are written. Keep an audio link too.”

After retirement, a postal worker gave two pages from his route book—names removed, only addresses in which houses were identified by a tree, a ghat, a temple bend, and “the house with the red door.”

A woman wrote about returning home after a failed marriage, but on the condition that the village name be changed. Anupama asked, “If we

change the name, will the story become false?" The woman replied, "No. My body will remain safe." The name was changed.

A student in Delhi wrote one page: at home the household language is spoken on the phone, not in the hostel. Seema in Janakpur wrote a note beside Vimala's song: "I do not know from whom Mother learned this song; therefore I will not call it 'our family's song.'"

Some material was rejected too. One man sent a claim that he would expose another family's "secret lineage." There was no evidence, no permission, and many accusations. Naina wrote back: "It cannot be published in this form." The man telephoned. "Are you afraid of the truth?"

Anupama took the phone. "We are afraid of claiming power over another person's life in the name of truth."

The man became angry. Before the first issue had even appeared, "Videha" had acquired its first opponent. Jagdamba Devi was not pleased by this; she simply remained steady. "Good. If there are rules, they will be tested."

9

The first difficulty of editing was language. One person wrote one form of Maithili, another a different form; someone sent an entire Maithili piece in Roman letters. One migrant woman shifted among three languages in a voice message. At first Naina wanted to make everything uniform.

Jagdamba Devi stopped one transcript midway through listening. "That woman did not speak like this."

"The meaning is the same."

"Meaning alone is not voice."

Anupama agreed, but she did not want to abandon editing either. "If the spelling stays this scattered, the reader will tire. But if we erase the voice, we erase the writer. Work somewhere between the two."

A rule was made: spelling would be regularized according to the house style; the local rhythm of the sentence would be kept as far as possible; unusual words would not be removed if their meaning was clear; translation would be made only if the writer asked for it. Editorial notes would be brief.

Naina sent Shashank his transcript. He sent back three corrections. First, not "I lived with eight men," but "All eight of us lived in one room." Second, one companion was from Nepal, not Bihar. Third, instead of "I was afraid," he wanted "I felt fear." Naina accepted all three.

In her piece, Champa struck out the line "We were allowed to speak in the meeting" and wrote, "We sat down in the meeting." On the phone she laughed: "Allowed by whom?"

Those small corrections became lessons in editing for Naina. Voice was not only grammar; language also concealed who acted and who was imagined to possess permission.

IO

The family's greatest dispute was over whether to include the incomplete branch of the Panji in the first issue. Devnath Babu's younger brother Raghubir said plainly on the phone, "It is not right to make an ancestral Panji public. Who knows what people will cut out of it and what they will make?"

Naina said, "Not the whole Panji. Only one page, where women's names are missing and where there is a gap. Along with an excerpt from Grandmother's maternal-line notebook."

"Then people will think there was something wrong in our family."

Jagdamba Devi took the phone. "Can I say there was nothing wrong in our family?"

Raghubir was silent.

"A gap is a gap. Why be ashamed of it?"

"But your notebook about your mother's side is hardly a Panji."

"When did I call it a Panji? I wrote names."

The argument lasted two days. In the end it was decided that the identifying details of the family would be removed from the original Panji and only a structural excerpt printed; beside the incomplete branch would be the note: "Reason unknown; no conjecture." Alongside it would appear five women's names from Jagdamba Devi's notebook, with her own consent. The title: "Two Kinds of Lineage Memory."

Naina wanted to write a short essay called "The Silences of History." Anupama stopped her. "Let the reader first look at the papers. The editor does not have to explain the meaning of everything."

Naina removed the essay. A blank space remained. To her surprise, the page felt stronger.

II

By the time the first issue was being assembled, "Videha" had moved out of a family meeting and become a small public undertaking in the town. There was no money for a large press. A photocopy shop in Pipra bazaar agreed to print a small number of eighty-page booklets. The shopkeeper said, "A colour cover will cost more."

Naina gave up colour. The cover became a black-and-white line drawing—a lamp reflected on water. Jagdamba Devi looked at it. "Whose lamp?"

"No one's."

"Then it is fine."

The money came through contributions—some from Shashank abroad, some from Anupama's salary, some from Seema in Janakpur; Champa's group said they would buy five copies rather than take them free. Jagdamba Devi wanted to give some of her old savings. Anupama stopped her. "You gave the name, you gave the rules, and now money too?"

Jagdamba Devi said, "I did not give the name. I gave the envelope."

In the end her contribution was treated as advance payment for five copies.

On printing day the machine produced the first four pages in reverse order. The shopkeeper held his head. Naina laughed. “The region will write its own story, the machine its own sequence.”

Anupama said at once, “Do not put that line in the editorial.”

“Why?”

“Too contrived.”

The three of them laughed. The wrongly ordered pages were set aside. New ones were printed. The staples were put in by hand. No launch platform was arranged. The first copy was placed in Jagdamba Devi’s hands. She did not look at the cover but at the contents. She read the names. “Vimala—good. Seema—good. Champa—good. Shashank—good. Why does this say ‘Anonymous?’”

“That is all the writer wants.”

“Then good.”

12

The first copy of “Videha” left the house on a Jeth afternoon. Naina had thought she would place it in the school, but on the way she met the retired postman near the post office. He found the excerpt from his route pages, cleaned his spectacles, read it, and then said, “My name isn’t here.”

“You had said you did not want your name.”

“Yes, right. I was checking whether the editor remembered.”

The second copy reached a tea stall in Pipra. By evening there were tea stains on its pages. The third went to the school library. The fourth to Champa’s group. The fifth went by post to Janakpur. The sixth travelled abroad to Shashank as a scanned file.

Responses came at once. Someone said, “There is too much sorrow.” Someone else, “Why so little poetry here?” Another asked, “Where is our neighbourhood?” Someone said, “Printing the Panji was not right.” An elderly man complained, “Too much about women.” Champa replied, “You write next time. Then there will be less.”

The hardest response came from an old acquaintance of Vimala’s. She said, “The flood date printed in the diary is off by a year.” Seema said, “Mother wrote it.” The acquaintance replied, “Then Mother wrote it wrong.”

Naina first wanted to defend the diary. Then she remembered the rules. For the next issue they prepared a note titled “Correction / Difference in Memory”: “The diary date was published as in the original; local memory gives another year; no decisive record is available.”

Jagdamba Devi heard the note. “Good. Do not turn memory into a courtroom.”

Thus, with its very first issue, the journal learned its first correction. If a region writes its own story, the region will also disagree with itself—this proved more useful than any manifesto.

13

Three months later a small pile of material had accumulated with Naina. A boatman wanted to write about a raft made by children, but did not want to give the children's names. A schoolmaster sent an account of students imitating him on the day of his retirement, adding, "What I remember, the students may remember differently." A painter agreed to let words about market pressure on colour be printed on the condition that no photograph be used.

One woman sent five pages—her experience of returning home twenty years after her father's death. As she read, Naina thought: this is a story no single voice can complete. She telephoned the woman. The woman said, "Then ask my neighbour too, but do not make her account final over mine."

The journal's work grew. Anupama feared Naina would once again take everything onto herself. "Editing is not a hereditary office," she said plainly.

So a small editorial group was formed—Naina, Anupama, Champa, Seema from afar, a school student, and Munni, disciple of the elderly folk singer. Jagdamba Devi refused to accept a formal place on it. "I will advise. I will not take a post."

At the meeting, the first question was not money but permission. The second was language. Third—written material only, or audio too? Fourth—children's material would require consent from both the child and the guardian. Fifth—material containing accusations would require evidence.

Naina laughed. "The journal is becoming more rules than stories."

Champa replied, "Without rules, the voices of people with less power will once again be taken over by people with more power."

Munni added, "And not so many rules that a voice cannot enter at all."

Between those two sentences the next work of "Videha" began.

14

Jagdamba Devi gradually began to hear less. Voice messages had to be played twice for her. One day Naina asked, "Would you like to write your own story?"

"I have already written what I had to write."

"The names on your mother's side?"

"That is not a story. It is a list."

"A list can be a story too."

"You have caught the disease of turning everything into a story."

Naina laughed. "Then you tell it and I will write."

Jagdamba Devi agreed, but on one condition—few questions. She spoke of the flood of her childhood, of her mother rowing a boat, her first school, marriage, the first night in her husband's home, people's reactions after a daughter was born, and her husband Devnath Babu's unfinished plan to bring out a journal. At many points she said, "Do not write this." Naina did not write those parts.

At the end Naina asked, "What was the biggest thing in your life?"

Jagdamba Devi grew annoyed. “What sort of question is that? Is life an examination with one answer?”

Naina struck out the question.

After a while Jagdamba Devi herself said, “Write one thing. Keep account of what I did not do as well. There were many times I remained silent where I should have spoken. Do not turn silence into a virtue.”

Naina wrote it down and read it back. Jagdamba Devi changed one word — “many times” to “some times.” “To say many would also be unjust to myself.”

In that small correction Naina saw an entire philosophy of editing—neither glorification nor self-punishment; whatever was said should be measured no larger and no smaller than it was.

15

While preparing the second issue, the old trunk was opened again. The papers were now arranged in envelopes: Panji, maternal-line notebook, diary pages for which permission had been obtained, private sealed letters, a list of scans. Naina saw that the disorder of the first day had become order, but order itself held a new danger: once categories were made, people could be shut inside them.

She changed the folder called “Women’s Voices” to “Voice/Writing,” because women did not write only about women’s subjects. In the “Migration” folder she placed a woman’s migration story alongside Shashank’s. Under “Lineage,” “rejected lineage” and “maternal memory” were not kept separate; they were cross-linked in the same place.

Anupama looked at it. “A Panji can be made on a computer too.”

“Yes. And someone can be left outside here too.”

Jagdamba Devi said, “Then do not make a god of the list.”

That evening a teenage girl arrived. Her name was Saloni. She carried four pages. Her father worked as a labourer in Punjab; her mother sewed in the village. Saloni had not written about her father’s absence but about the sound of her mother’s sewing machine—the machine running late into the night, electricity cutting out, the wheel turning by foot, studying for examinations, taking clothing measurements, household expenses.

Naina read the pages and asked, “Did you write this yourself?”

Saloni frowned. “Why?”

Naina immediately felt the weight of her own question. “I’m sorry. I only meant to ask whether you are giving permission for us to edit it.”

“Yes. But do not write ‘daughter of a poor family.’”

“I will not.”

“And let my mother read it first.”

“Of course.”

After Saloni left, Anupama said, “See? If the region is to write its own story, the editor must learn language too.”

After the second issue another question arose—the boundary between lineage memory and legal proof. An elderly woman named Kaushalya Devi wrote down seven generations of names on her mother's side. At the top of the page she wrote, "These are my mothers." Beside some names she gave villages; beside others only notes such as "sang sweetly," "grew betel vine," "educated two daughters."

Naina was delighted. "This is just like Grandmother's notebook."

Kaushalya Devi said at once, "But write one thing clearly—this is not a claim to land."

Naina was surprised. Once the reason was explained, it was simple. There was an ongoing dispute over land belonging to the old house on Kaushalya Devi's maternal side. She wanted the names preserved in memory, but did not want any lawyer or agnate to turn this page into proof of inheritance.

The editorial group met. Champa said, "What if we state clearly that this is oral/family memory, not a legal record?"

Anupama said, "And nowhere use the words 'verified genealogy.'"

Naina changed the title of the page to "Kaushalya Devi's Memory List." Beneath it she added: "Published solely for preservation of memory; no claim is made as evidence of property, caste, inheritance, or legal right."

Kaushalya Devi read it again. "Now print it."

Jagdamba Devi heard about it and said, "See? Preserving a name and creating a claim are not the same thing."

Naina remembered her first excitement, when the blank in the Panji had instantly made her mind invent a story. Now she understood that sometimes editing was not the work of adding words, but of reducing the claims words made.

For the third issue of "Videha," Naina went to see a woman whose child had disappeared in an old flood. People kept saying that if her life story were written, it would become a great work. Naina felt uneasy the moment she heard this; the woman's suffering had already begun to be called "material."

The woman's name was Kamli. Naina first gave her the journal, explained the rules, then asked, "If there is anything you want to say, I will listen. If you do not want to, that is all right too."

Kamli turned the pages of the journal for a long time. "People told you about my son?"

"Yes."

"You want to write it?"

Naina paused before answering. "I want to listen. Whether it is written or not will be your decision."

Kamli looked out of the window. "I do not want it."

That was all.

As Naina rose to leave, Kamli spoke again. “People will think I cannot speak. That is not right. I can speak. I simply do not want this matter printed.”

Naina asked, “May I print that sentence—that you can speak, but do not wish it published?”

Kamli thought for a moment. “Without my name.”

In the next issue a small box appeared: “A writer also has the right to decide that some stories will not be published. Do not mistake silence for incapacity.” No name, no incident, no description of grief.

One reader wrote, “What is the use of this empty note?” Naina did not reply. Jagdamba Devi read it and said, “It is not empty. It is a boundary.”

Naina then understood that the journal bore responsibility not only for the stories it printed, but also for the stories it did not print. If the region was to write its own story, the right “not to write” had to live inside that sentence as well.

18

The question of language returned in another form. A young man of Mithila, born in Saudi Arabia, sent his grandmother’s story in Roman letters. He spoke Maithili but could not read Devanagari well. He wrote, “Preserve the pronunciation of my words; you may change the script.”

Naina first transcribed the whole text into Devanagari. Problems appeared at once—where did Roman “ai” mean “ai,” where “āi,” and where only a drawn-out spoken sound? Where did “chhai” mean one form of “is,” and where was an honorific form intended? The levels of respect in the grandmother’s quoted speech were unclear in Roman script.

Naina asked the young man for an audio recording. He also sent old fragments of his grandmother’s voice. Anupama, Seema, and Jagdamba Devi listened. Sentence by sentence, the text was transcribed again.

The young man saw the final text and wrote, “Now this sounds like my grandmother’s voice.”

The editorial group decided: when material arrived in Roman script, the original file would be preserved; the published Devanagari version would be made with the writer’s approval; a brief note would be added if necessary. Change the script, not the voice.

Munni asked, “And if someone sends something in Tirhuta script?”

Everyone fell silent. No one could read it well enough.

Anupama said, “Then we find someone who can. We cannot proceed by pretending to know what we do not know.”

Jagdamba Devi laughed. “Write that rule into all your work.”

Naina actually wrote in her notebook: “Do not hide ignorance.”

Preserving a language no longer seemed to her merely a matter of choosing pure words; whose pronunciation, whose script, whose ease of reading, whose consent—all of these together were what kept a language alive.

At a public discussion, the first hard question about “Videha” came. A college student asked, “You say the region should write its own story. But you are the ones who print. You are the ones who choose. You have the power to decide who remains outside and who comes in. So where is the ‘own’ in ‘its own story’?”

Before answering, Naina looked towards Anupama. The question was fair.

Naina said, “We are not the region. The journal is not the region either. We make selections, so the responsibility is ours as well. ‘Its own’ means only that, as far as possible, people are given space in their own voices rather than turned into objects. But the power of selection does not disappear.”

The student asked again, “Then editorial bias?”

Champa answered, “It will exist. That is why the rules must be public, corrections open, and the editorial group must keep changing.”

Seema sent an added voice message from afar: “Print letters from people who disagree too—provided they are not abusive or making false accusations.”

In the next issue a page titled “How We Choose” was added. It listed subject, permission, evidence, privacy, language, balance of place, and active invitations to less-heard voices such as women, Dalits, migrants, and children; it also acknowledged that editorial selection was not infallible.

Jagdamba Devi read the page. “Now your journal publishes its limits too. Good.”

Naina said, “Printing a limit does not erase the limit.”

“Erasing it is not the work. Keeping it visible is.”

Naina wanted to make that sentence an editorial title, then stopped herself. Not every good sentence has to become a title. Some remain in the house and do their work there.

By the end of a year, three small issues of “Videha” had appeared. Not one had appeared on time. Sometimes money was short, sometimes material arrived late, sometimes permission was held up, sometimes the printer’s machine failed. Yet the journal continued. Even “continued” did not mean a grand success—only continuity.

One copy went to Delhi, one to the Gulf, one to Janakpur, some to Pipra, some to nearby villages. Someone read the whole issue, someone only their own name, someone looked only at the cover, someone sent a correction. Some copies got wet, some survived in libraries, some lost pages in tea stalls.

Jagdamba Devi’s hearing weakened further, but she always read the contents page. In the third issue she saw Saloni’s “Sewing Machine.” “Was this name anywhere before?”

“Not in our Panji,” Naina said with a laugh.

“Then now it is.”

One night the electricity failed again. There was no rain. The courtyard was dry. Naina shut down the computer and lit the brass lamp. On the table lay an empty folder for the next issue. A new voice message had arrived on her phone—an elderly woman from a distant village wanted to tell her story of the river. Naina did not begin writing immediately. First she sent a reply: “I will transcribe your story and play it back to you. Any part you do not want will be removed. You will decide whether your name is printed.”

The reply came: “Good. Play it back to me first.”

From inside Anupama asked, “New material?”

“Yes.”

“Whose?”

Naina looked at the phone. “She will tell it herself.”

From the cot Jagdamba Devi called, “Lower the lamp wick. It is smoking.”

Naina lowered the wick a little. The flame grew smaller but steadier. On the table before her lay the scan of the Panji, the permission page from Vimala’s diary, Shashank’s corrected transcript, Saloni’s essay, Champa’s ghat account, and the blank page for the next issue.

She wrote no editorial sentence on the blank page. Not “our region,” not “our truth,” not “all our voices.” The page remained empty—for the next writer.

Outside, beside the doorway, a little water from the day remained in a shallow hollow. The lamp’s light did not form one line on it; whenever the wind moved, it broke into many small pieces, joined again, then broke again. Naina watched for a few moments.

Inside the house, three generations breathed in different rhythms. The trunk was closed, but the key was no longer hidden in the spice tin—it was in the table drawer, and everyone knew where it was.

The next issue of “Videha” had not yet been written. Even so, its first blank page was ready.

— *End of Story 49* —

Forty-nine stories. Many lifetimes. One flame.

If you look at paper from the front, you see the letters; give it light from the side, and you see the body of the paper.

FROM "THE THIEF OF THE PANJI"

A line scraped from a genealogical register. A house seen again after generations. A diary whose pages must be weighed against a family's silence. In *Light*, Gajendra Thakur gathers forty-nine stories from the Mithila country, tales of lineage and lapse, of proof and doubt, of ghats, courts and post offices, and of a small lamp lit every evening, and follows them across lifetimes.

From the puzzle of a missing name to questions of Maya, Rasa and liberation, and closing on a blank page kept ready for the next writer, this collection asks who is remembered, who decides, and what light we owe the past.

Translated from the original Maithili by the author himself.



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